zero-sum game

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zero-sum game

by roadtripwithlucifer

Summary

It’s been four years since Deku dropped off the face of the earth. Katsuki knows he’s going to find him. He’s so close to him, he can almost touch him.

(Unknowingly, he does.)

Chapter 1

Chapter Notes

> Playlist here , as is tradition.
>
> This is quite a bit different from what I've written for BNHA before. Fifteen months ago, everyday life was filled with so much tragedy that I just wanted to bring something a little brighter into the world as a semblance of relief.
>
> But, now, I feel ready to tackle darker themes. Please mind the tags and stay safe.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Katsuki's steps stutter. As laughing bodies push past him on the sidewalk, he sees it all unfold, a horrible caricature drawn sharply in the corners of his eyes. Shadows dragging their claws, spreading along the concrete, *drip drip drip* of copper hitting pavement, smoke and sweat and fear, so pungent it burns Katsuki's nostrils. A darkness so thick you could drown in it, ghosts with tortured faces, mouth fixed in silent screams, disappearing into nothingness.

His fingers flex, tendons arching to ignite the instantaneous sweat coating his palms, feet angling to dart, to spring like a hunter to its prey. Animalistic adrenaline thrums through his veins, making his senses sharper, the pain temporarily duller. He breathes through it, because he knows how, because *fear* gets people killed, and Katsuki is never afraid. Never.

Katsuki blinks, head swiveling to take on the whole scene before him, only to watch the alley transform back into a scene of utter banality. No blue flames threatening to char every inch of this god-forsaken city. No terrified children pressing tiny hands to blood-filled ears, no place to run from explosions rattling the foundations of their homes. No screams of *Save us!* snuffed out by the smoke. No trembling hands, no throat-choking sob that never makes it out to see the light of day, no soot or dirt or blood or blood or blood. Nothing at all.

Just an alley, the biggest threat in which are the rats scampering under the dumpsters.

Boarded up storefronts now lit up, music filtering from closed doorways. Taped off apartment buildings, exposed rebar and crumbling cement now dotted with well-tended flowers. Katsuki blinks a few more times, swallowing against the knot that's found a home in his throat. His skin prickles as he catches a few concerned glances from passerby's, sparks of recognition and hushed whispers. *Is that…? Why is he…?*

Katsuki exhales slowly, counting each frantic beat of his hummingbird heart, watching his warm breath fog the chilled winter air as he starts to walk again. He fists his hands in the pockets of his jacket, willing himself to relax his fingers. They protest, familiar pain spreading through his joints. The dull, constant ache creeps down his wrists, radiating into each of his fingertips.

The needle-like pinprick of numbness starts to set in despite Katsuki's best attempt to keep his circulation flowing and he sighs, relief washing over at the sight of the familiar poorly-lit house in the corner of the street.

Katsuki ducks inside, bell above the door announcing his arrival. The heat is instant and gratifying, sweet aroma of chocolate and cinnamon and coffee wafting through the air. Katsuki takes his numb hands out of his pockets, massaging at his wrist as he instinctually takes stock of the other patrons, body angled so his vision can easily patrol out the window while scrutinizing the others in the shop.

The screenwriting asshole, Spectacles, always in the corner with his laptop. The college students, Dumb and Dumber, taking up too many tables, perpetually stuck on the same subject. Granny, drinking tea and watching the world pass by the window, knitting resting in her purse. Just the regulars, people he knows, neighborhood faces he's been seeing for years, and his shoulders briefly relax before his eyes land on someone unfamiliar. Red flags instantly pop up all over Katsuki's psyche and Katsuki's shoulders stiffen, feet turning towards the stranger.

Anyone else wouldn't have noticed, but anyone else isn't Katsuki Bakugou. The other man *knows* he has his eyes on him, sees it in the ways his fingers hesitate as they reach for the steaming cup in front of him, a swallow that is too delayed to accomplish the look of indifference the stranger is attempting to feign. He doesn't look up at Katsuki, put Katsuki watches his eyes trace along the same line in his well-worn book.

"Oh, Dynamight! Welcome back! The usual?" Katsuki's spurred out of his thoughts by the starry eyed, pink cheeked barista. Katsuki isn't fucked to remember his name and he glances down at his uniform – right, Aoto – and grunts in response, eyes darting away from the stranger for a brief second.

"Yeah, yeah. Keep it down," Katsuki sighs as the college kids glance up at him at the sound of his hero name, followed by a flurry of poorly hidden giggles. He digs his face further into his scarf, rolling his eyes.

As the kid rushes off to the homey old kitchen to make Katsuki's order, Katsuki crosses his arms, leans back against the counter as if impatiently waiting, eyes making his way back to scrutinize the stranger.

He's fairly large – it's the first thing that gives him away. Even sitting down, it's clear with the way he dwarves the café seat that he's well over six feet. His hair is buzzed short, bleached blonde – a pretty good dye job, eyebrows and all, but the answer lies in the man's dark, unrealistically long eyelashes. His eyes are fairly large (maybe mixed, perhaps American?) - eyes dart down, book's in English, *definitely* American – irises a deep, pensive black behind a pair of oval glasses.

He tries to hide his form under a loose black sweatshirt and joggers, but the tense chords of muscle in his neck, the fold of the sweatshirt and the hiking of his pants against his thighs betray his muscular build. But it's his hands, specifically, that make Katsuki's stomach flip so hard he has to grip against the counter for balance.

He's wearing a singular glove on his right hand, the left hand large enough to encompass the entire book he's holding. *His hands are different sizes,* Katsuki thinks absently. Lots of reasons for that. Maybe he's a heteromorph. Maybe it's a birth defect. Maybe it's a part of his quirk. Its none of his business, but it catches Katsuki attention all the same.

If it wasn't for that obvious asymmetry, Katsuki would think he's some kind of model, or actor or something. No, on second thought. The width of his chest and abdomen tell that the muscles aren't just for show. A hero, maybe?

Katsuki's mind flashes back to that god-forsaken cheesy-ass star-spangled-fuck flexing like an asshole in front of their 3rd year classroom, handing out applications for his shitty-ass Vegas agency. The slide-shows of destroyed buildings, rampant crime, a country up in smoke seemed like a point of

pride to the guy. *Come to America!* He said. *This entire fucking country is falling apart!* Like its some kind of brag or something.

Won over enough of his classmates to call that little ambassadorship a rip-roaring success. That said, they've got U.A. alumni over in America now. Why wouldn't they just send one of their own?

[KATSUKI] 6:48pm – hey old man, you got any American guests coming to U.A?

"Chili Mocha for D – " Katsuki spins around so quick the world stands still, eyes flaying the poor barista alive as he tosses his phone back in his pocket. He clears his throat, muttering out "Mr. D," under his breath, before disappearing somewhere in the back. Katsuki grabs the drink, eyebrows twitching involuntarily at the asshole kid, giving away his identity in front of a potential *threat.* What the fuck is that kid even thinking? He have a fucking death wish or something?

Even so, the warmth seeping through the cup instantly spreads through his joints, soothing some of the throbbing pain in his tendons, and he decides to forgive the kid. For now.

Behind the kid, an elderly woman emerges, walking straight towards Katsuki. Katsuki sees her *immediately,* and takes that as his queue to leave. The stranger might be tall, muscular and foreign, but even *he* might have difficulty battling the true threat in this coffee shop – the owner.

Katsuki's not entirely convinced that the woman doesn't have a teleportation quirk, because how she caught up to him on those stubs she calls legs he'll never know, but her cane is tapping against his shoulder, and although he has the option of ignoring her, he actually *enjoys* this coffee spot, so he turns around.

"Hey, Granny," he acknowledges as politely as he can through clenched teeth, bowing low enough for her to take his cheeks between her talons and squeeze harshly.

"Katsuki, you punk! I know you weren't even going to say hello to me! Don't act all polite now!"

He responds with his characteristic grimace towards the elderly woman doing her best to look stern and failing miserably, what with the fluffy slippers and giant robe adorned with pictures of kittens.

"I'm fucking here now, ain't I?"

"You never visit anymore! Why do I have to have Aoto -"

"Who?"

"My nephew! Don't interrupt!" she smacks Katsuki's ankle with her cane, earning a snicker from the *other* granny sitting by the window. Malicious bitter old hags –

"Why do I have to bribe my nephew to get me when you stop by? You're purposely coming after my bedtime!"

"Not my fuckin' fault your bedtime is at fucking *six,* you geriatric old – "

"Watch!" *Smack.* "Your!" *Smack.* "Mouth!" *Smack.* "…Young man!" She smacks him a few more times on the ankles, and towards the last smack Katsuki's not sure whether the old lady's being playful or deliberately trying to cripple him. What a way to go down – immobilized by an old bat in a cat robe. Not necessarily the way he thought his hero career would end, but probably not the *most* humiliating way that he can think of.

A tiny, low chuckle gets Katsuki's attention instantly, and his eyes shoot to the blonde stranger, poorly hiding a smile behind his gloved hand. Katsuki's teeth clench, muscles contracting. He can feel his hands start to sweat again, corroding into the coffee cup he's cradling close to his body. Katsuki absolutely refuses to address the fact that his cheeks heat up, and he looks back down at the old woman.

"What's with the American?" Katsuki whispers, nudging his head towards the large blonde still pretending to read in the corner. Granny Honoka tilts her head in the direction of Katsuki's jutting chin, then looks back at Katsuki, fuzzy eyebrows furrowed in concern.

"Who?" she asks, and Katsuki scoffs, straightening his spine, casting another furtive glance towards the large blonde. Blind old bat. He's no longer hiding his mouth behind his hand, back to pretending to read his book. The smile, though, hasn't disappeared. That crooked smirk on his lips; something about it makes Katsuki stomach flip and his insides go all *gooey,* like a fried egg with a broken yolk.

Weird. Maybe he ate something bad at lunch.

"Go back to bed. You're going senile," Katsuki murmurs, patting the woman on her shoulder gently. The woman shoots him an entirely toothless grin and wordlessly starts to make her way back to the stairs in the corner. When he hears the tell-tale creak that he can't quite distinguish between the wood of the old house or her Cretaceous-era aged bones, Katsuki exhales sharply and turns back towards the door.

He fights desperately with the impulse to glance at the American one more time, entirely unsure why the desire to look at him, watch him, *analyze* him is so damn strong. Katsuki shakes his head at himself. He doesn't know when he's started to assume that men in *good physical shape* are threats, when the people that make his blood curdle and make him wake in a cold sweat are anything but.

Everyone's a threat, Katsuki reminds himself.

Katsuki drops a few yen in the tip jar, making his way back out into the frigid evening. He looks to the sky – fluffy, large flakes of snow have started falling since he's entered the coffee shop, and stick to his scarf and coat. He takes a sip of his overly indulgent coffee, relieved at the spice on his tongue. He feels his insides warm up with each sip, the pit of ice that had formed in his stomach slowly dissolved by the sweetness. He's being paranoid, Katsuki decides. Just a tourist. Just another face, passing by. No one to worry about.

He quickens his pace, nods sharply to the doorman in front of his apartment building and makes his way up the stairs.

He feels his phone vibrate in his pocket and pulls it out, scowling at the response.

[AIZAWA] 7:02pm – *we've got kirishima and ashido on the books for next month*

Surprised they haven't told you that already

What's this about, problem child?

Katsuki grumbles silently to himself. Much to his displeasure, he was probably the *first* person they told. And the fact that Pinkie's intolerable roommate is tagging along means he certainly will know no peace for the two weeks those three fuckers are in his orbit.

[KATSUKI] 7:08pm – more than two fucking agencies in the States. No one else?

[AIZAWA] 7:09pm –*not that I know of*

why

[KATSUKI] 7:09pm – nothing. Don't worry about it

[AIZAWA] 7:10pm – *you wouldn't text me if it was 'nothing'*

Everything alright with you?

Goddamnit, he *knew* it was a mistake to contact his old homeroom teacher. Not this shit again.

[AIZAWA] 7:13pm – *have you been sleeping?*

Katsuki pauses, standing like a honest fool in front of his own front door, grimacing down at this phone, own fingers turning numb with how hard he's gripping the offending piece of plastic.

[KATSUKI] 7:15pm – like a fucking baby

As soon as his phone starts to vibrate and he sees Aizawa's name pop up on the screen, Katsuki presses DECLINE instantly and shuts his phone off.

Well, that wasn't the answer he was looking for. Somehow, he's not surprised. American heroes are all showmanship and gaudiness. Seeing one outside of uniform in a tucked-away coffee shop is damn near impossible.

He unravels his scarf and shucks his coat, placing both of them carefully in his closet, peeling off his snow-covered boots in the genkan. He turns on the lights, walking the wooden floors to his bedroom. He sits on the bed, staring at the empty wall in front of him. His eyes drift slowly to the duffel bag he left in the corner of his room, half-zipped, sitting there expectedly. Something uncomfortable blooms in his chest at the sight of it, but Katsuki's not going to address that, so he refocuses back on the trusty blank wall in front of him.

He shakes his head at it, as if losing an argument with some unknown entity, before he starts the routine. He removes his street clothes and folds them carefully, like he always does. Throws on his sweats, like he always does. He opens the drawer of his bedside table, one hand inside while the second searches the bottom, muscle memory locating the switch that allows him to remove the false bottom. He grabs the key laying underneath, carefully replacing the piece of wood in its prior location. Gripping the key a bit too tightly, he shuffles across his apartment to the second bedroom. He stalls in front of the door, like he always does.

He unlocks it, pocketing the key and stepping inside.

He flicks the light on.

The wall has grown to be almost unmanageable, a tapestry of coherent shapes and carefully painted lines transforming into something unhinged, abstract.

To Katsuki, it's an organized disaster - littered with photos, aerial shots, multiple maps marred with holes from pins moved and removed, colored string charting out paths that seem random, disconnected, fractured.

Scattered articles with circled words, newspaper clippings, photocopied notes he left for others (some obtained with consent, some without), copies of the nerd's notebook pages from the last few days before his disappearance, phone logs, missing persons reports, police records from minor crimes around the world that may or may not have been illegal to obtain. At a certain point, it became more driven by intuition than logic. Some things don't seem to fit at all – but Katsuki knows that they do. Knows that he just has to connect it all in the right way.

The centerpiece, ground-zero of this monstrous wall, sits adjacent to his desk. A copy of the note – the one he left, same as everyone else, under Katsuki's door as he slept. The words themselves have long since lost their meaning. All that mattered was the message spelled out, vertically, line by line. A message given to Katsuki and Katsuki alone.

I a m h e r e

Signed simply, with no additional flourish, no flowery *Take care!* Or *Stay Safe!* or *I'll miss you!* (the last of which boiled Katsuki's blood so badly that he could hardly think straight) – just D3KU.

He turns his attention to his desktop, letting his eyes linger over a picture of freckled cheeks and dimples alight in a blinding smile – a picture that wasn't his to see, but landed in his hands anyway (through methods he'd rather not disclose) – and briefly scans the security camera feed.

He watches the split screens absently – the one outside his apartment, the one at building entrance, the one he has in this very room. His body looks small, shoulders hunched, face a pallid white. His clothes look like they're fitting more loosely; a fact that he refuses to acknowledge, despite mounting evidence to the contrary. He puts on his headphones, dialing in to the local police report on the scanner. The thing is bulky and an eyesore, but unlike computers, untraceable. Yeah, the VPN he uses routinely changes his IP address from city to city, country to country, so theoretically it's all *untraceable*, but Katsuki's hasn't survived this long without a certain degree of neuroticism.

He turns on the laptop, logs in to the server, and starts, as always, in the normal places. The traffic cameras around Deku's mother's apartment. The ones surrounding U.A. The pier on Dagobah Beach. Cookie-cutter faces on cookie-cutter bodies, one indistinguishable from the other. Not the one he wants to see. Never the one he wants to see.

He's not surprised. Maybe it's because Deku's been so used to being invisible his whole life, so used to blending in with the background, that his disappearance has been so *flawless*. Katsuki would almost admire it, if it didn't piss him the fuck *off.*

He searches for hours – any police report, any social media post, anything at *all* that can be related to Deku or the League – but today yields nothing. The last few *months* have yielded nothing. The cold terror that something happened, that Deku and Shigaraki had some kind of blowout without him knowing, that Izuku Midoriya is dead, faceless, alone and forgotten, somewhere where no one will ever find him knocks the breath out of Katsuki.

No. He can't think like that. Instead of ruminating on that image (*verdant eyes, looking at nothing. Scarred, young body limp and pale. Lips open, cracked, breathless, never to speak another word again. Never to mutter his name again.)* feeling that tell-tale panic creeping up his throat, he switches topics.

The blonde in the coffee shop.

This isn't paranoia, Katsuki reassures himself. He's got files on everyone that lives in the neighborhood. He needs to know if there are criminals hidden in plain sight. There always are. But they're not going to trick Katsuki. Not again. He's just being thorough.

A few rudimentary searches of 'American hero' and 'twenties' and 'heteromorph?' OR '?body modification quirk' yields absolutely nothing. Katsuki swallows hard, trying to deny the thoughts that have been pulsing in the back of his brain.

The League. The League found out where he lives, they're watching him, waiting, Granny Honoka dripping blood in the basement as Himiko Toga steals her face, shadows following him to his apartment, finding this room, finding Deku because of him -

Making Katsuki watch as Deku gets torn limb from limb, only leaving eyes full of betrayal, mouthing his name before choking on his own blood. Responsible for ending the Symbol of Peace, always Katsuki's fault Katsuki's fault Katsuki's fault -

Katsuki breathes deeply, feeling his heart hammer wildly against his ribcage, blinking away the shadows creeping in the corners of his eyes. With shaking hands, he replays the surveillance video inside the room. Outside his apartment. Outside the building. No one. He's alone. He's safe. He's *safe.*

Besides, Katsuki thinks to himself flippantly, *If they thought they could lure out shitty Deku with me, they would have done it years ago. Better chance to take his old lady or All Might. Someone that can't fight back.* Katsuki's stomach twists again, head pounding.

This isn't getting him anywhere. Casting an annoyed glance at the clock, Katsuki gets up and approaches the wall. His fingertips trace the green string – frayed and pale compared to some of the others; crossing oceans and zigzagging through countries, more and more time and distance spent between pins until the most recent one sits, untied and empty. It ends in Norway, just like the black string, while the red, yellow and blue strings progress past Europe and coalesce on Bangkok, Thailand.

Katsuki's safe, for now, but Deku probably *isn't.* But at least – at least he knows that he's *alive.* When he'd find these reports – a body burned to a crisp, doubles with a penchant for murder, something disintegrated to dust that isn't supposed to be – there would always be a ripple effect of some nameless, faceless *hero* saving kittens, feeding the homeless, apprehending villains. He had no way to prove it was Deku – hell, each description of this vigilante is completely different, some even claiming it was a woman – but he knows. Don't ask him how - He just *knows.*

Vaguely, Katsuki remembers that he hasn't eaten dinner. He casts one last look at the wall for the night, eyes lingering longer than they should on the smile in that old photograph before angling himself on his tiptoes to eye the glowing compressible device hidden in the door jamb. One light blinks back at him and Katsuki presses down for two seconds before it goes completely black. He locks the door behind him, breathing out the stale air of his 'study.'

He makes his way to his kitchen, briefly debating with himself whether cooking a whole meal is worth the effort before grabbing a protein bar, shoving the whole thing in this mouth as he walks back

to his bedroom. He places the key back in the secret compartment and stares ahead at the wall.

He plugs in his phone, enough time passing that it feels safe to turn back on. He swipes on the icon informing him of the *5 missed calls* and opens Kirishima's text. His stomach drops as he sees the attached picture. Bright and grinning, Kaminari, Kirishima and Sero are all in matching floral T-shirts and sunglasses, throwing peace signs at the camera as Ashido and Utsushimi wave from beach towels in the background.

[KIRISHIMA] 01:03am – *wish you were here, buddy!*

Katsuki tucks himself under his blankets, still not able to ward off the chill he feels throughout his whole body. It looks *nice*. Warming his frigid bones, dunking Electro-Dolt underwater and drinking so much that he can actually sleep through the night sounds amazing. The beach-shorts in his duffel bag pathetically give away how much he wanted to go. It's not like he has to ask someone for a day off, not like Tokyo would collapse without him if he just left for a few days.

But as he thought of that goddamn messiah-complex asshole, dying alone and forgotten in a ditch somewhere as Katsuki frolics in the damn ocean like a child, and he just *couldn't.*

Bangkok is a six hour flight to Tokyo. At any moment, he could be six hours away from being face to face with the League again. It might be in one hour. They could be touching down right now. Hell, if Kurogiri's rejoined them, then they could be showing up his front door any second - Katsuki shudders through the impulse to return to his study, to cycle through the cameras again, just to make sure that he's *safe safe safe.* Please, just let him be *safe.*

Katsuki's eyes stay wide open as he stares at the ceiling, his heart pumping ardently despite his brain's tired plea for *sleep. Sleep, goddamnit. Fucking sleep.*

It takes several more run-throughs – obsessive scenarios, move sets, how he'd handle the four of them – three of them? - If there were to suddenly show up on his doorstep. Katsuki makes sure he feels a couple of grenades under his pillow, smoke and flash that he can use without thinking in case they neutralize his quirk. The cold metal hidden in his secret compartment might be difficult to grab in a scuffle if he got hit in close range, but he can buy some time with the explosives prior to getting the gun.

Is it still there? He swears he saw it when he was grabbing the key, but, *but*. Katsuki groans at himself, fully aware of how unreasonable he's being, but he won't be able to rest until he checks. He opens his bedside table, digging under the drawer for his secret compartment and feels for the heavy metal of the weapon before pulling it out.

It rests in his hands. He imagines a dead bird, something he doesn't want to be holding, fragile and broken and bleeding all over him, but he can't put it down, someone *has to* hold it and it should be *him.* Forget that the bird has green feathers. Forget that it doesn't sing anymore. Forget that he's the one that killed it~~. All his fault.~~

His hand finds the handle naturally, turning the weapon over in his palms, letting his muscles remember so that they might save him when the time comes. His throat goes dry as he looks down the barrel of his own gun. Vivid images of him sticking the cool metal on his own tongue, of blowing his own brains out, of ending it all, flash across his eyes and he shakes them off without a second thought. Those intrusive thoughts used to scare the shit out of him.

Now they comfort him.

Everything is fine. He’s fine. Katsuki exhales, placing the gun back in the secret compartment. He lays back down, brain pleasantly empty, a buzz of *nothing.* Short lived, Katsuki knows, but he chooses to enjoy it as his eyes start to drift down.

As he falls asleep, he can practically feel the black tendrils pierce his gut, taste the iron flooding his mouth as he sees the last glimpse of green disintegrate in front of his eyes.

Chapter End Notes

Katsuki, seeing nothing wrong with this:



(Also! Re: Playlists - I generally make them using Spotify suggested/discover for each new fic based on the vibe I'm 'going for', so most of these songs I never listened to prior to writing. Anna, you might say. Some of these songs are weird/bad/???. Well that's the vibe of the fic lmao.)

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Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Katsuki's staring at the ceiling, eyes bleary, faint taste of copper on his tongue as his alarm comes to life. He grabs his phone, shutting the alarm off and sighs in exasperation. He doesn't even know why he sets the thing anymore. He watches Deku's blood-covered yellow cape rotate in time with his ceiling fan with an astounding level of detachment.

He's take it over screaming faces and rotting corpses that keep appearing out of the corners of his eyes. Katsuki pinches himself to confirm that he's awake. He blinks several times, and the scarf disappears.

His spine tingles unpleasantly as the solution knocks on the backdoor of his brain.

You know how to fix this, it tells him. Albeit temporarily. Katsuki just hates… relying on it. It feels pathetic, but on top of that, disgusting. Katsuki knows it's not normal, knows their relationship is anything *but,* and the fact that he's grown so reliant, so comforted by their nights together, makes it hard to meet his own eyes in the mirror.

And yet, as the days blend into nights blend into days, as his own body starts to wither as the monsters in his periphery scramble closer and closer to him, threatening to drag him from the world of the living to where-ever the fuck they crawl out of, he knows that this isn't sustainable.

Katsuki knows the dangers of sleeplessness, of these hallucinations, of not being able to differentiate what's real and what's imagined. His bloodied hands don't let him forget it. So he does what he has to do. Everything else has failed him – the meds, the fucking hypnotists, the quirk doctors. This, for some goddamn reason? Works without fail.

Katsuki goes to his outgoing messages, sending off the request before he has a chance to back out.

[KATSUKI] 05:03am –*can I stop by this weekend?*

Shutting off his phone again, unable to stomach receiving the response that won't come for hours, Katsuki slowly sits himself up in bed.

He rubs his eyes, resting his head in the palms of his hand. The room is still bathed in darkness, and he just sits there, in relative quiet for a few seconds. He shuts his eyes tight, pressing hard before letting go, flashes of color erupting behind his closed eyelids and, slowly and arduously, forces his aching body out of bed.

Katsuki rotates his left shoulder, keeping his right hand anchored to stabilize the joint. Slowly, he rolls it, counting under his breath with each rotation. In front, behind, above and to the side. As the *cracking* sensation eases, he moves on to his wrists, gently massaging the tender ligaments straining under his skin before moving to the tendons in the palm of his hand. He rolls his head, neck popping

loudly as he adjusts his jaw, leaving a tingling sensation instead of the constant, thrumming *hurt* that seems so follow him wherever he goes.

Good enough. He stumbles to the bathroom, avoiding eye contact with the pale, exhausted looking figure in the mirror, scrubbing ritualistically against his teeth. He grabs his water bottle, a towel, and walks straight to the treadmill in front of his television. He taps in his password for access to the channel prior to lacing up his sneakers.

His feet are hitting the track, rhythmically and steady as the connection finally patches through, the droning voices of the familiar newscasters echoing around the room.

"…Weekly arrest records – 50 arrests in past seven days in Tokyo. Pro Hero Endeavor, Endeavor Agency. 13 arrests. Pro Hero Fusion, Endeavor Agency. 12 arrests. Pro Hero Best Jeanist, Genius Agency. 10 arrests. Pro Hero Dynamight. Independent. 9 arrests…"

Katsuki jams his finger to increase the speed, muscles burning as his jaw clenches at the news.

"Pro Hero Creati, Endeavor Agency. 7 arrests. Hero Team The Lurkers. 5 arrests. Pro Hero Chargebolt, Genius Agency. 3 arrests. Zero crime-related fatalities. One domestic homicide. Last week arrests 37. Increase in crime in 1 week by 26%. One month increase by 33%. #1 Pro Hero Endeavor to hold press conference regarding spiking crime rate – "

Drops of sweat fly off his forehead, landing on the screen counting the kilometers he's run. He dabs the towel against his forehead, equations flying around in his head. He knew he was making more arrests over the last few weeks, but hearing his own independent numbers compared to the accrued statistics of the Tokyo-based agencies makes his blood boil.

Even worse that fucking *Endeavor's* team is responsible for well over 50% of the arrests the past week. Not to mention that Half-and-Half *bastard,* independently making more arrests than Katsuki, without even fucking *trying.*

He stops at the end of the report, taking heaving breaths, lungs burning and chest aching from more than just the exertion. He ignores the irritation burrowing into his chest and climbing into his shower. He soaks in the high pressure, letting the heat knead his muscles, trying to wash away that which cannot be – those images every time he closes his eyes, the fact he hasn't slept in days, the scent of blood, Shouto goddamn Todoroki -

Wrapping a towel around his waist, he sits on the edge of his bed, thumb scrolling through his work email. Immediately dismissing all the international offers, with an extra annoyed glare at *Sin City Agency,* which courtesy of Kirishima tries to send him contractor work every goddamn week, he turns his attention to the Japanese offers. He skims over most of the small time shit – not worth the commute or time – before pausing on Mirko's characteristic icon. Fucking bunny ears. Theoretically cute, if only the woman's thighs couldn't crush a fully grown Nomu's head.

He opens it, scanning the first few lines. She's offering a higher signing bonus this time. Even includes a paid-for apartment in this offer, close to the city center, big kitchen, near a couple of parks -

Katsuki chews at the inside of his cheek before he swipes left, deleting the email along with the rest.

If only Hiroshima wasn't 10 hours away.

Nothing keeping you here, his brain offers, and Katsuki ignores it.

By some sense of serendipity, he gets a text notification in that exact moment. It flashes above the email, just short enough for Katsuki to read it. His shoulders relax instantly, the tension from the news report dissipating.

[I] – 7:12am – *you're always welcome*

Katsuki checks the time again. He dresses in his winter uniform, avoiding his bulky gauntlets. Using the fire escape on his balcony, he climbs up onto the roof, and lets off a gentle explosion, propelling himself into the sky. He presses the button on the side of his neck, activating the gliding apparatus he's had installed, and watches the city below him. It's quiet up here. Almost peaceful, if such a thing existed.

He makes a quiet landing, quieting his footsteps through the snow as he makes his way to their designated meeting spot.

There, hidden in the shadow is the characteristic purple hair of his former classmate, ear jacks plugged into the concrete wall. Her headphones are outfitted with fur to insulate her ears, thick gloves on her hands, her earphone-jacks diving into her jacket and emerging from hoodie strings. She turns slightly at his arrival, tip of her nose a bright pink. Katsuki keeps his face carefully flat as her mouth quirks up in a half-smile before she waves him forward, finger on her mouth.

"You're late," she signs, giving Katsuki an annoyed glare. Katsuki rubs his fist around his chest, the best 'sorry' that he can express, before returning back to watching Earphone Jack work.

Katsuki waits, barely breathing for what must be nearly thirty more minutes before Jirou finally opens her eyes, pointing to Katsuki, then the number three, then putting her palm in front of her face, closing it as she gets to her chin.

Katsuki nods sharply. He grips at the door, heat from his hand instantly melting the lock. He sticks to the shadows, skirting through the open door. He observes silently. The warehouse is well lit, a makeshift lab set up in the corner. Microscopes, computers and vials of dark red liquid, passed between the three unassuming looking kids. Just like the others.

They're young, maybe in their twenties, all wearing protective lab coats, headphones in their ears. The sterile, stainless-steel hidden room is littered with papers and stacked with boxes, stinking vaguely of formaldehyde and cobwebs. The new equipment looks out of place in this library of rotting patient records.

Katsuki holds his breath, ducking down low behind a stack of boxes, pinpointing the strips of bare flesh that will render his targets immobile. *Neck. Ankle. Hand.*

Katsuki will be the last to admit that he took a fucking page out of *Mina Ashido's book*, for fucks sake, but increasing the strength and viscosity of his nitroglycerin has made him a verified triple threat. Where else are you going to find a pro hero that specializes in long range, short range *and* stealth work?

He catches the 2D flattened version of Edgeshot in the corner and notes his marks with miniscule movements of his hands. Quick. Quiet. Unnoticed. That's what Edgeshot hired him for, and he's sure as fuck not going to disappoint.

He's so fast the kids hardly have enough time to process that something is happening at all; one trying to take out their headphones, one trying to swat away at the phantom bug that touched their ankle, one turning around sharply, probably having spotted him.

It takes less than thirty seconds. Nitroglycerin is a potent vasodilator. Quick on, quick off, rarely dangerous except in large doses. A perfect weapon to render someone immobile for a few minutes without all the hassle of 'rearranging organs' or 'making them stop screaming,' like some of the other Lurkers are prone to do.

Edgeshot makes quick work of unlocking the storage door, allowing Kamui Woods to walk through. Using Lacquered Chain Prison, the incapacitates the three kids, giving Katsuki a sharp nod before disappearing.

In the silence of the room, Katsuki looks around, frown painted on his face. The vials of blood look back at him expectedly, microscope still lit over a pressed slide. He looks through the lenses, avoiding the settings lest he contaminate the crime scene. All he sees are tiny red blobs punctuated by a tiny blue blob every now and again. Cells, yeah. But *why.*

He knows it's not his fucking job to know anything about this mission – the commission has given them a task, and they're doing it, that's all there is to it, but – he doesn't like this. Call it paranoia, or intuition, or a horrific amalgamation of the two, but there's something *off* about all of this.

Katsuki runs his eyes over the vials, committing the details to memory. They're set in pairs, numbered well into the low hundreds. Just six pairs in this makeshift lab – not unlike the last two they infiltrated. Katsuki walks to the notebook the kid looking through the microscope was doodling in. Each pair held the words 'mono' or 'di' next to them, as well as several more columns filled out in total, paused on the last duo of samples. Katsuki walks past the final station, zeroing in on the multicolored liquid in a 96-well plate and the Southern blot gel sitting right next to it, victims-to-be of a never completed experiment.

"Dynamight – you coming?" Katsuki snaps out of his thought process, head shooting up before responding to Earphone Jack's concerned look with an indifferent grunt. He casts a final look at the lab, memorizing each detail best he can, before he makes his way out the same backdoor through which he entered.

The car ride is silent. Katsuki looks out the window, fingers tapping out against his thigh. Ninety-six wells. For two samples, that forty-eight wells each. Southern blots are used to compare DNA. Assuming eight wells in each Southern blot gel, that makes - a sequence of eight genes, compared between two blood samples. Eight genes relating to… what, exactly?

"Third one this week," Earphone Jack absently, playing with her earphones, staring out the window. Katsuki glances at her. Her body is stiff, and she's pretending to look out the window of the car, but her eyes seem to dart from object to object, teeth digging firmly into her lip.

"Fuckin' know, Ears. I was there," Katsuki says flippantly. The car stops, and Katsuki pulls at the handle before hearing a response, walking directly towards the agency. He doesn't slow down as Jirou practically jogs up behind him, saying something else that Katsuki can barely fucking hear.

"…ot doing anything illegal, so all the kids go within 24 hours, is what I've heard. None of them know anything, either. But I've heard the previous twelve people that they correlated the samples to are fine. Just blackouts – "

Katsuki pauses despite himself. This is new information. The victims who had their blood collected. "…Know anything about them? Ages? Relation? Anything that would connect them?"

Earphone Jack's ears twitch, as if surprised that Katsuki took the time to reply to her, before sheepishly looking back down at the ground. She opens the door to The Lurkers Agency for Katsuki, and he walks in without a second glance.

"They aren't telling us much. Just that they're alive and okay," she repeats. Katsuki exhales. That should be a good enough answer – he's done his job as a hero. He doesn't need to *know.*

Earphone Jack leads Katsuki to their makeshift office, bright eyed interns gaping up at them as they make their way to the back of the room, separated from the rest with a simple cubicle wall.

Katsuki sits down, rolling his shoulder once again, the sharp *crack* of his bone making him wince.

"…We should grab lunch," Jirou offers, watching Katsuki pull up the police report documents on his temporary laptop, face a mask of indifference.

"Not hungry," Katsuki responds after a few seconds, ignoring the furrowing of Jirou's eyebrows and her pull closer into his space. She lowers her voice and Katsuki's fingers stay rigit on the keys, working hard not to crush the electronic below him as he clenches his jaw.

"Is it… is it your stomach again? You've just – it looks like you – well –"

"Don't finish that sentence." Katsuki enunciates slowly through gritted teach, the growl underneath shooting all the warning he has patience for today. Jirou pulls back, not even trying to hide the frank pity in her eyes.

"I know its harder – I mean – with how All Might – "

"Ears. I'm fucking *warning* you."

Jirou sighs, loud enough to catch a concerned glance from one of her interns, and puts her palms up, like Katsuki's some kind of wild animal. He keeps his eyes locked on the police report, words blurring in front of him.

"I just – we all just – we're *worried* about you, Bakugou. All of us. And – since everyone's heard you've been working with my team – people just keeps asking about you, about how you are, and I don't know what to *say.*"

Katsuki feels his body start to shake as Jirou's voice starts to waver, thick emotion in her whispers.

"I'm not going to ignore you *hurting.* How am I supposed to tell our friends that you look like you're not sleeping? Not eating? That you're so quiet it scares me sometimes? This isn't *you* - "

"Not *me?*" Katsuki's voice comes out almost frantic, and his body moves on his own, standing up. He towers over Jirou, whose wide eyes stay fixed on him with an unwavering intensity Katsuki could almost respect. Almost.

"You don't know anything about me! So stay the *fuck* out of my business." Katsuki's chest heaves with the effort to not scream, but even so, his presence and the thick scent of burned sugar wafting off his body, just begging to be ignited, earns the attention of every set of scared eyes in that tiny room.

“This contract, this fucking mission, is the *only* thing that binds me to you. That’s *it.* I don’t owe you *shit.*”

Katsuki grabs the folder detailing the case and turns away, making a beeline for the door.

“I’m entering this report later. Go fuck yourself.”

He ignores the insistent flip of his stomach at the devastated look Jirou is sending his way. He doesn’t know why he expected something different from *her.* She always minded her own fucking business, so Katsuki didn’t think too much of joining her team for these off-jobs. But he supposes it doesn’t matter who the fuck he works with, it always ends the same. The worried looks, the whispers, the insistent texts and phone calls that he has to block – its been easier since half his so called ‘friends’ high-tailed to the states, but not *easy,* by any means.

It’s a risk he knew he was taking as an independent. The number one, three and four agencies are all based in Tokyo, and all three of them have his former classmates on their payroll. Its unavoidable that he’d have to collaborate with them – but man, for *once* he’d love to work with a classmate that does not give a single *shit* (or pretend to, at least) about his well being.

You could leave, the tiny voice in the back of his head reminds him, and he swats it away for the millionth time this week.

Still in uniform and not wanting to brave the streets as Dynamight, Katsuki lights up his sweaty palms, easily propelling himself into the sky. It doesn’t take long until he’s landing hard on the rooftop of his apartment complex. He climbs down the fire escape, opening the latch to the window with his magnetic key and clambers in, throwing his boots off as to not drag dirt across his floor.

By the time Katsuki’s finished scrubbing his skin, he’s bright red, scratched to shit and feels like he can *breathe* again.

He sits down on his bed, staring at the wall in front of him, placated by the utter silence of his apartment. He glances at the file sitting on his bedside table. The impulse to start searching, to dig, to *understand* nips at Katsuki’s heels and he sighs in exasperation. He knows he won’t be able to stop thinking about it until he starts to look into it.

Could be nothing. Everything could be nothing, unless it’s something.

Then it’s *definitely* something.

He’ll need to grab some coffee. He’ll just go back to the shop. This has nothing to do with Granny, his paranoid fantasies, and *absolutely* nothing to do with the suspicious-ass large blonde he saw there last night.

Just a tourist. No reason for him to be there again today. Just a nobody.

(Or a somebody. Granny Honoka clawing against the large blonde man, unable to fight him, as the monster arm underneath his gloves chokes off her air supply, and with her last breaths, she says, yes, yes, I know Katsuki, he lives – And why wouldn’t she, why wouldn’t she give him up, he’s the one that’s killed her, he’s a murderer, murderers never change, he -)

Katsuki ruffles through his still-wet hair, throwing on a beanie and the jeans that he assumes are the freshest from his ever-escalating pile of laundry. He reaches the coffee shop faster than usual, elbowing into the warmth. The tiny bell rings overhead, and Katsuki turns his body on instrinct,

angling himself to easily see out the window, and with a single turn of his heel to take in the rest of the patrons. It's well past eight, nearing their closing time. One of the baristas is stacking chairs, sweeping underneath the table, casting annoyed glances towards the counter. At the counter is a very blushy, stuttering Whats-His-Face (Toto? Whatever.) looking up at a behemoth of a man that Katsuki can tell from that horrible dye-job and the way his massive back stretches that sweatshirt, that its the fucking American.

Katsuki feels his pulse quicken instantly – not adrenaline, but something else *entirely* as his eyes scan down the whole giant. He's well over six foot something, having at least a solid five or six inches on Katsuki. Katsuki's eyes follow down, definitely not taking a beat to admire the curve of his ass in that compromising position, oh-so-beautifully outlined by the fabric of his joggers.

He's ordering a drink or *something,* speaking in a hushed, raspy caramel voice that sends a shiver down Katsuki's spine. He's speaking Japanese, remarkably well with nary an accent to be found, which strikes Katsuki as unusual for an American. Katsuki glares at the back of the man's head, trying to place his accent or lack thereof, when Otto's (?) eyes light up as he glances past the American to look at Katsuki.

"Oh! Dynamight! Welcome back!"

The American turns around instantly at the call of his hero name, face evenly flat, but the second their eyes meet Katsuki feels electricity erupts between them. The American doesn't shy away, wide black eyes narrowed in at him, portraying an emotion Katsuki certainly can't put his finger on, before he circles around him to sit down on the floral couch.

What *was* that? The tension in Katsuki's chest feels catastrophic, like he's taken a fist to his sternum, some lingering warmth left on his face from where the other's dark eyes landed.

"*-----usal?"*

Katsuki's attention flits back to Tiesto – glancing down, right, fuck, Aoto - before speaking.

"What?" Katsuki's voice comes out oddly choked, eyes flitting back to the American. He seems to be browsing through his phone, but his lip is up in that fucking *smirk* again, and – and there's that feeling. The heavy, pressing feeling right over his breastbone.

"I said, the usual, sir?"

"Yeah, whatever." Katsuki pauses, leaning in so no one else can hear his voice. "That guy come here often?"

Aoto's eyes widen and he furrows his eyebrows. "…What guy?"

Katsuki sucks at his lip. "…The guy you were *just* talking to. You high or something?"

Aoto looks around, eyes finally landing on the American, flushing slightly before looking back to Katsuki sheepishly.

"Oh. Guess I never noticed him before. Um – be right out with your drink."

Katsuki leans against the counter, refusing to take the only other available seat in the café – the couch, right next to the American. What the *fuck*. Katsuki runs his eyes over the man's face, the sharp angle of his jaw, zeroing in on his hands that grip an old-school looking smartphone. How could the kid *not* notice him?

As if he could *feel* Katsuki's watching him, black eyes dart past his phone to lock with Katsuki's, and he's on *fire.*

Something is up with this guy. Something is *off.* Maybe something to do with this dude's quirk, because Katsuki is fucking *sweltering.* He takes his scarf off absentmindedly, not noticing the way those black eyes roam down the exposed valleys of his throat.

There's something in those eyes – *detached* yet hungry, likely they're trying to memorize each detail on Katsuki's face in their second-long exchange of glances – and it's that fucking look, loaded like a goddamn pistol that is ready to go off, that makes Katsuki make up his mind.

Something is wrong with that fucker, and Katsuki is not going to let *anyone* else get hurt.

It feels like a million goddamn years before Aoto comes back with his drink, Katsuki tapping impatiently against the floor as his plan crystallizes. Katsuki spends a few seconds longer than he's like next to the counter, making absolutely sure the American sees him fidget before he hightails out of the store.

He makes sure to leave deep, pseudo-hurried footprints in the snow.

The sprint slows down as soon as he's out of view of the café. He stops, backing himself slowly, inconspicuously, into the darkened alley.

It couldn't be more perfect. The streets are nearly empty, the café is closing, the guy is going to have to leave *soon*. And Katsuki will be waiting.

He shudders under the evening chill, wrapping his previously discarded scarf tight around his neck.

He doesn't have to wait long.

Katsuki almost misses him. He's silent, nearly soundless, the snow not even crunching at his carefully placed steps. Katsuki watches curiously through the shadows as the man steps *in* his footprints, something almost *giddy* dancing against his pinkened cheeks as he keeps his eyes fixed on his own feet, ignoring the empty sidewalk in front of him.

The guy seems distracted enough, each step into Katsuki's footprint devolving into something like a hop, almost *childlike* in its frivolity. It nearly causes Katsuki to hesitate, to wipe his nitroglycerin against his jeans and walk away.

But he doesn't. He doesn't hesitate – not anymore. Katsuki springs forward, hands covering the American's mouth, slathering his nitroglycerin on his lips. He has maybe a minute, maybe more with how large he is, before the man is out – a minute to pull him into the alley, to make him speak, to disappear into the night before the fucker wakes up.

Katsuki forces the hulking man into the darkness with almost no struggle.

That's weird, Katsuki thinks instantly. *What the fuck.* A civilian would definitely freak out. A villain would fucking fight. It shouldn't be this easy.

He can't think too much about it. He slams the other against the brick wall, the two of them blending into the shadows, hidden from the eyes any curious passerby's. Katsuki keeps his face flat, eyes focused on the other man's black irises, hand pressed firmly against his mouth as his forearm pins his chest and one thigh pins his legs.

“Don’t scream. Don’t even fucking *move,* got that?”

His eyebrows arch up, almost like he’s challenging him, and Katsuki shakes his head. This isn’t making *sense.* He’s just trying to throw him off, confuse him, and its fucking *working.*

“I’m going to lift up my hand so you can talk. If you so much as *twitch* wrong, I’m gonna set your whole fucking face on fire.”

Katsuki nearly doubles over at the scoff that erupts out of the lips of the taller man.

“Not a good look to kidnap civilians and threaten them with bodily harm,” he states, voice a low whisper, so goddamn deep and familiar that Katsuki wants to lean in, just to hear him a bit better, to *place* that spark of *knowing* to a face or a name. He resists the urge, pressing his forearm harder against the man, earning nothing but an amused smirk in return.

“I know damn fucking *well* you ain’t a civilian. Now who are you? *Talk*. You’ve got a minute before you’re out.”

The American’s eyes darken, smirk falling off his face. Katsuki wants to pat himself on the back, *not so fucking paranoid after all, am I, fuckers?!* Before cold reality slaps him in the face. Katsuki takes a deep breath, controlling himself so fear, or excitement, or both don’t make themselves too apparent on his face.

“…I probably have more than a minute. My body isn’t very sensitive to nitroglycerin.”

Katsuki’s chest tightens instantly. *What the fuck.* It wasn’t spoken as a threat, but it fucking *sounds* like one. Katsuki ignores the impending panic, thrusting the man against wall with more force, satisfied with the way the other man’s head thuds against the concrete.

“Who sent you?” Katsuki hisses, pulling his face in closer so the other can see the sharp angles of his canines. “The League?”

His face changes somehow, transforms into something dangerous, some deep, unbridled furry erupting behind those eyes.

The scent of burning sugar, ready-to-ignite nitroglycerin wafts all around them, and Katsuki must be losing his goddamn mind, because he swears he can *see* the American inhale deeply and close his eyes, body shuddering under his grip.

“You have the wrong idea,” he finally says, clipped, as if trying to restrain himself, but from what, Katsuki’s not sure.

“Yeah?” Katsuki’s voice comes out strangled, knowing full well he’s not putting his full weight on the limbs that bind the American to the wall. But he stays there, pliant. His minute is nearly up, but that large body shows no sign of collapsing under him. Katsuki eyes the open skin that could be his next target – his lips, the tight muscles of his neck, behind his neck, just under his ear – Katsuki bites the inside of his mouth hard enough to draw blood.

He doesn’t touch his skin. He ignores now bad he *wants to.*

“And what’s the right idea?!”

The American leans his face in, enough that his breath, oddly smelling like lavender, flutters against his cheek.

“You should let go of me.”

Katsuki’s not sure why his own voice has dropped to a whisper. “Is that a threat?”

The bleached-blonde’s eyelashes, dark as hell in contrast to his stupid eyebrows, flutter.

“It can be.” There’s no fucking malice in his voice. Katsuki’s eyes trail down those eyelashes, down his pinkened cheeks, his almost artificially-smooth skin, the sharp angle of his jaw where dark stubble is starting to grow in.

“Fucking try me.” Katsuki smirks, an old fire flaring in his abdomen. “Like I can be intimidated by an American with a shitty-ass dye job.”

It happens in half a second flat. The guy grabs his arm, seamlessly twisting it and pushing Katsuki up against the opposite wall, pulling it behind his back in a wild show of strength. The American isn’t so gentle, pressing hard into Katsuki’s spine, the arm pinning him hard and metallic. *So it’s a prosthetic,* Katsuki thinks.

“Not American,” the man rasps in a breathy whisper next to his ear. Katsuki suppresses the urge to shudder, his heart stuttering stupidly in his chest. God, what the fuck is *happening* to him? As if on afterthought, he leans in even closer, until Katsuki can feel the very tips of his lips against the shell of his ear. “Just like the way blonde *looks*.”

Katsuki thrusts back with his hips, trying to get an angle on the guy, flexing his hands and letting out some weak explosions – enough to get this guy *off him* but not to alert a crowd – the guy responding with pushing his body flush to his, pressing Katsuki flat against the wall.

“Don’t fight me. I don’t want to hurt you,” he’s closer still, soft skin pressing up against the back of Katsuki’s neck, and Katsuki *refuses* to acknowledge that his pants are starting to feel a little tight. Is he really so touch starved that being pinned by a stranger in a dirty ass alley doing it for him…?!

“Like you could,” he grits out with as much aggression as he can muster, cheek scratching against the brick wall. He’s got to get out of this guy’s hold. He’s got to get his head on straight. Stun grenade to the face from the wrist he’s holding down. As he’s momentarily blinded, he’ll flip around, grab his shoulders and kick him in the gut. Two explosions to the ears should give him vertigo – if he tries shit, he’ll get a Howitzer to that pretty mouth of his. Just a few moves, and he can have this American on his way to the police station – It would work.

“I know what you’re thinking. Don’t.”

“You don’t fucking know me,” Katsuki spits out, bucking against the harsh touch of the stranger, the fire in his abdomen spreading into his chest, his fingers, down to his feet. He realizes, with some delirious sense of humor, that for the first time in a while, his entire body feels warm to the core despite the cold winter air surrounding them.

Katsuki doesn’t expect those man’s fingers to card through the short hairs on the nape of his neck, a touch so gentle and reverent that it makes Katsuki stop in his tracks.

“I do,” the voice says, and it’s just on the wrong side of honest. “I know you, Ka-tsu-ki…” The way the man rolls his name off his tongue is like he wants to taste every syllable as it drips from his mouth. *No honorific,* Katsuki thinks with some unhinged sense of humor, before the universe comes crashing right back down.

“What the fuc –“ Katsuki lets off a stun grenade, twisting around with hands sparking, ready to take this fucker down for real – but he’s gone.

Just – gone. Like he was never there in the first place. Katsuki spins around, eyes wide, before dragging his fingers through his hair. Is he losing it? What the fuck is *happening?*

Trembling hands touch the back of his neck, still tingling from the other blonde’s touch. It was real. He was *real.*

Wasn’t he?

He runs out the alley, looking down the street to see the usual mostly-empty sidewalks. He swivels around frantically, the few people still walking down the street giving him a wide berth.

He shoves his hands back in his pocket, walking back home, his mind miraculously, startlingly *clear.*

Chapter End Notes

Katsuki, a bad bitch with long range, short range AND stealth attacks:



Also nitroglycerin is 10000% a vasodilator lmao i dont know why i haven't seen anyone else use his quirk like this.... the implications....

WHO IS [I]? WHO IS THE SEXY COFFEE SHOP STRANGER (lol...i mean really) AND WHY CAN'T ANYONE SEEM TO REMEMBER HIM? WHY IS THERE SO MUCH EXPOSITION?! WHEN DO WE GET THE SEXUAL FLASHFIRE ANNA?! YOU PROMISED DICKS ON DICKS ON DICKS (and intend to keep that, hand over heart/dick)

FInd out on the next episode of Dragon Ball Z

Also me: *posts like 6 chapters in two weeks, hasn't replied to a single comment or message, refreshes AO3 like 800 times per day* haha i'm doing great

Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

HAPPY MONDAY SLUTS LETS GET THIS BRED (haha. get it.....)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Katsuki stares up at the ceiling, fingers digging into the sides of his scalp. He glares at his clock. 0300am. Ridiculous. Instead of laying in his bed like a fucking corpse, he could be doing shit. He turns, eyes landing on the file from the case yesterday.

Katsuki's bones groan as he rolls himself out of bed, grabbing his secret compartment key, and pads to the opposite end of his apartment. In his 'study,' he feels the tension release from his shoulders. His eyes linger on the strings on his wall, on the letter, on *I a m h e r e* and the 3 in Deku's signature. Fingertips graze the photocopied note, some wild part of him insisting that he *burn it all down. rip it all apart.* He doesn't – but lets the elation of destroying his whole world pass briefly through him, not lingering too long on the thought of life outside of…*this.*

He checks all his cameras, then turns to the file. Sitting down in front of his computer, Katsuki types in the IP address he's got memorized, desktop's screen changing to that of a computer located inside the Tokyo Police Department.

Two months. Three pop-up labs. Ten different college students, from different universities, with biology backgrounds. All answered an untraceable ad on their university websites that were taken down almost immediately. Locations have varied – one in a storage room of a clinic, one in the university basement, one in a mostly-abandoned mall. Always six samples of blood between them – with the promise of more once they sent their information to a secure email. Katsuki pulls up the pictures of the crime scene. He focuses, digging those same images out of his own memory. Nothing's been intentionally removed or altered, best he can remember. He zooms in on the notebook left lying on the table. Sample numbers, each having the words 'Di' or 'Mono' scribbled next to them.

Huh. Katsuki quickly looks up the terms to confirm. Just as he thought – these samples must be from twins.

So, at least eighteen pairs of twins have had samples taken from them in the last several weeks, and are being tested by villains for… something genetic. Something that matches.

Katsuki bites at his pen, typing in 'twins,' and 'quirk theory' into the academic search bar. The data is lacking – but there's plenty of data *about* the fact that the data is lacking. Twins are extremely rare in their superhuman society – have become progressively rarer since Quirks became commonplace. There's plenty of theories to *why,* apparently. Katsuki frowns, downloading several of the articles directly to his phone.

No leads there. No suspects identified. Even the names of the victims haven't been uploaded yet. Katsuki's hand twitches in irritation – the police is always inefficient and slow as hell. People could be getting kidnapped left and right and the police would *still* be submitting an application to a warrant

so they can scratch their own asses. Well. Whatever. Katsuki closes out of the file. He'll give them more time. He's got his own shit going on, anyway.

His fingers find themselves brushing against the nape of his neck again for what must have been the hundredth time since last night.

'Vigilante,' 'arm prosthetic' Katsuki pauses, 'America.' The man claims that he's not *American,* yet he didn't use a honorific when saying Katsuki's name. His friends don't even call him *Katsuki*. And the English book and the way he dresses still point to America, despite his perfect Japanese.

His heart nearly stops as an old post on a sub-Reqqit dedicated to 'highlighting' non-famous heroes and praising every day acts of vigilantism directs him to a shaky Chirper picture taken by a civilian. *Just another day commuting in NY! Smh*

Dated two years ago. A near collision, one car wrapped around a pole in the middle of the intersection, the second *physically* stopped by someone in a black uniform. The person is turned away from the hapless photographer, but the right arm, glaringly obvious by the way it reflected sunlight, is a metallic prosthetic.

Katsuki stands up, muttering under his breath. Why does New York two years ago sound so damn familiar? He walks over to the map, following the strings and dates written under them. The Blue string passed through New York around that same time. Katsuki swallows. *Reports of arson in Brooklyn. Four dead. Three gravely injured.*

He digs further into the post, hoping to find a name, or more identifiers, but comes up short. He needs to get a look at that arm. He needs more things to help identify him. He needs – Katsuki touches the back of his neck once more, feeling his chest grow heavy. He needs to know why he called him by his first name, why he said he knows him. Why being close to him, having those eyes on him, feeling those hands against his body made him feel so…

Katsuki shakes his head.

After (another) cursory check of all his cameras, Katsuki glances at the time again. His stomach twists, alerting him that he should probably eat something before his workout. Personal experience has taught Katsuki that no sleep, no food and extreme physical exertion generally don't go great together.

He checks his refrigerator, cabinets and pantry, absently surprised at the fact that its mostly empty. Just rice and protein powder. Its unlike him, but so is hallucinating, so Katsuki lets it slide. It's been a rough few weeks. Months. Years. Whatever.

Katsuki walks back over to the bathroom, accidentally meeting the glazed gaze of the tired man in the mirror. He lifts his shirt, eyes instantly focusing on the scar on his abdomen. He swallows down his disgust as he watches his ribs protrude with each breath. What Ears said shouldn't fucking bother him so much, but it *does.*

It's not that he's not eating. The thing All Might didn't warn him about was how much his appetite was going to suffer. Or how often and how much he needs to eat to maintain his mass. It's easy to slip up, especially when hours lose all their meanings and days start to blend together.

Fuck that. If he's getting weak enough that some fucking muscle-head American can take him down, then he's *really* slipping. Katsuki walks back to his kitchen, cataloguing everything he'll need to buy, digging up his old meal plan and training schedule somewhere in the back of his closet. Katsuki

nearly balks at the sheer degree of weight his sixteen-year-old-self could lift, and then instantly gets annoyed with himself for balking at it. He's twenty years old. He should be lifting *more* than he did then.

He should be *more* than he was then. But then there was the war, and the injury, and *Deku* and the villains and the blood on his hands and the screaming and the screaming and the screaming –

He sees the man out of the corner of his eye, just out of reach, top-hat and all, skull visible as his flesh bubbles, and Katsuki can't breathe, can't fucking *breathe* and he sits down, and blinks, and the man is gone, but he's never really gone, is he?

He rests his head in his hands, shame pouring out in droves as his body comes down from the sudden spike in adrenaline.

How are you supposed to help anyone when you're like this? Pathetic. Look at you. Oh, boo hoo, I'm sad. Get your shit together, you fucking useless loser. Deku's been running for his life for four fucking years and you can't eat a meal more than once a day? You gonna make more excuses, or are you gonna stand up and be a goddamn man?

The chastising voice in his head sounds an awful lot like him in middle school, the sneering of a child who had never had to face a single real challenge in his shitty, overconfident, needlessly cruel life. He'd be so ashamed of what Katsuki has become; but in this case, it goes both ways.

But, the voice is right. He can't help anyone like this. Weak and tired and fucked in the head. Can't do much about the fucked in the head part, but he can at least work out and eat actual food.

He makes the trip to the supermarket quickly and discreetly, and, without any new missions popping up in his email to distract him, he gets to work.

This part he forgets about, sometimes. How calming it is to rhythmically chop vegetables. How the scents of spices cooking dissolve the headache always looming in the background. How doing *something* makes him feel like not ripping all his hair out. How eating an actual meal is so much better than fucking granola bars and protein shakes. How things can still taste nice. How he can still experience things that are nice.

Feeling unusually chipper, Katsuki grabs his duffel, throws in some workout gear and old, crumpled up workout routine and starts his walk to the gym. He definitely doesn't walk past the coffee shop, which was definitely on the way and not about two blocks east of the direct path from his apartment to said gym, definitely not glancing inside, and definitely not noticing the blonde sitting in the corner, like he didn't shake down a pro hero just the previous night, nonchalant as ever.

Katsuki's blood boils and before he processes why he's doing what he's doing, he's storming through the door. The bell ringing above said door alerts him to his idiocy and he stands there, deer in the headlights, absolutely not knowing what his next more should be. He stands in front of the counter, glaring at the menu, neck heating up as he feels the eyes of the blonde find him.

As soon as the barista kid tries to make a whimper of a sound, Katsuki interrupts. "When did the blonde guy get here?"

Morimoto (?) looks around, eyes finally locking on the Dye Job sitting in the corner. The kid has the audacity to look surprised. "Oh. I didn't see him come in."

Katsuki grinds his teeth, clenching his fists in an effort to not reach over the counter and throttle the kid.

Once or twice might have been a coincidence, but, three times? Maybe it's the fucker's quirk. But that doesn't explain why Katsuki remembers him. Can't *stop* remembering him.

In a split second decision, he waltzes straight over to Dye Job's table, puffing up his chest in an effort to hide the very misplaced jitteriness he feels in the other's vicinity. Something about yesterday's encounter has rendered him… well, Katsuki doesn't want to say nervous, but some kind of switch flipped, and now… he can feel his own cheeks heating up at the approach. He grabs the opposite chair, spinning it around before straddling it, slamming his hands down on the table.

Pretending like he hasn't been watching him like a hawk since Katsuki came in, the other jumps slightly, the offended look on his face striking Katsuki as almost… cute.

"What are you doing," Dye-Job asks, voice monotone, holding none of the playful dangerous lilt it had as his lips grazed the shell of his ear just the prior night. Katsuki shudders at the memory, pushing it away to instead focus on the dark eyes fixed on him.

"Sitting. Wondering why some American asshole didn't turn tail and run after assaulting a pro hero in a back alley." Katsuki says it all as casually as possible, as if he has the upper hand, even though Katsuki has a sneaking suspicion that he does not.

"…. I didn't assaul – You remember that?" The look of sheer, unadulterated surprise nearly floors Katsuki.

"… Yeah, shithead. What the fuck you take me for – a goddamn goldfish?"

"I – " Dye Job pauses, setting his book down. He takes his teacup into his hand and stares at the thing like it owes him money. He takes a large sip and eyes Katsuki curiously. "You remember… all of it?"

"I remember the part where you fucking pinned me to the wall – " Katsuki whispers harshly, leaning in closer than he thinks he needed to. An instant flush coats the other's face, eyebrows raised. His mind goes back to the night, the bulk of the man's body pressed against his, the just-on-edge brush of his lips against his neck, thick fingers carding through his hair – and finds himself growing way too hot in return. Katsuki drops his voice lower, and they're inches apart, and his heart is threatening to jump out of his chest, " – and whispered my *first name* in my ear."

"I –" his dark pupils shift to the window, lip disappearing between his teeth. "Is that what this is about?"

"…What?" Katsuki leans back, crossing his arms, scrutinizing the other man. He's surprised to hear a little laugh punch out of Dye Job's mouth, eyebrows quirking.

"…You're upset that I *pinned you.* You just hate to lose, huh?"

"Wha-" he stutters, Katsuki's neck getting uncomfortably warm as he leans forward, "I didn't *lose* – "

"You *did.* To me. It's killing you, isn't it? That some nobody got the jump on you." The obnoxious smirk on the guy's face does nothing to dissipate the sheer *heat* coming off Katsuki in waves. He knows for a fact he's cherry red, with rage or frustration or a whole new thing entirely, and sputters through an array of responses, most of which would probably get him kicked out of the café at best and maybe arrested for disturbing the peace at worst.

“It was a goddamn *fluke!* And – you fucking caught me off guard! And – it was dark!” Katsuki insists, leaning even closer. The guy rests his chin on his hand, so fucking *condescending,* before he takes another sip of his tea.

Katsuki watches closely as the guy goes back to pretending to read. He’s still holding the book in just his left hand, thumb fumbling to turn the page. His still right hand, gloved, nudges against the page to help it flip. His shoulders are tensed, back straighter than it was when Katsuki came in, eyebrows furrowed. He’s vehemently trying to ignore Katsuki, and Katsuki’s not sure why it irks him so fucking *much.* He taps his fingers impatiently against the table, jaw clenching harder with each passing second and -

“You really don’t like being ignored, do you?” he finally says as his eyes finish scanning the page. Katsuki is almost offended. He’s spent his life with people *trying* to get close to him, and this dude is trying to get him to fuck off. This is… unexpected. Makes Katsuki bristle all over with annoyance.

“Fuck you! You couldn’t fucking do it again!” Katsuki barks out, his thought making it out his mouth before he could reign it in. That was a fluke. There’s no way. There’s just *no* -

“I could pin you again. In broad daylight. With you expecting it. *Easy*.” Dye Job assures Katsuki, and for the life of him, Katsuki can tell he isn’t *lying.* This *fucker* actually has the audacity – actually *believes?!?!* That he can take Katsuki Bakugou, Great Explosion Murder God Dynamight, on in a fair fight?

He fucking *wishes.*

Katsuki can feel that old spark of competition licking at his heals and he stands straight up out of his chair, using one finger to jam against the other’s unreasonably hard chest.

“Then fucking *do it!”*

The guy actually lifts his head in confusion, doing nothing about Katsuki’s finger digging a new hole into his chest.

“…What?”

“You fucking heard me!” Katsuki spits, prodding the guy again, so hard that the other flinches just slightly. “Let’s spar.”

At that, Dye Job rolls his eyes, smacking his hand away before crossing his arms, stretching that goddamn distracting shirt tight over his chest.

“You’re incorrigible. Are you gonna let me say no?”

Katsuki grits his teeth. Him? Incorrigible? Fuck this guy actually. “No.”

At that, Dye Job sighs, resigned, muttering something that sounds suspiciously like *stubborn pig-headed ass*- before he speaks out louder. “What do I get out of it? What happens when I win?”

“*If* you win, I’ll leave you the fuck alone or whatever so you can go on doing whatever sketchy shit you do.” Katsuki waves his hand off with an air of indifference. At that, Dye Job’s eyebrows raise and he tilts his head, as if thinking about it. He glances at his tea again, and then back to Katsuki, and then back to his tea, as if debating the merits of not drinking his shitty little drink in lieu of fighting Katsuki.

Which is straight up *offensive*. There are *hordes* of U.A. students and other pros who would sell their first-born child for a chance to dance on the mat with the legendary Dynamight, so what was this fucker thinking about?

"… and what do *you* get if, by some miracle, you win?"

"… You tell me your name."

Something complicated flashes behind those black eyes. They hold each other gazes, for perhaps a little bit too long, Katsuki still on his feet, still pointing to the other as the bleached blonde watches him closely. Almost analytically. Almost like he can see straight *through* Katsuki. Its fucking unnerving.

"I – "

The two of their heated conversation is cut off by a sharp smack of a cane against the legs of the table where Dye Job's book and tea sit unattended. They've got the attention of the two other people in the shop, trying to pretend they aren't listening but definitely keeping their eyes on him. Katsuki bristles. Maybe not the best for his PR as a pro to be loudly challenging strangers in coffee shops to fights, but, well.

Something about this fucker just *gets under his skin*. He can't seem to put his finger on *what.*

"Young man, are you starting fights in my home?!" Granny Honoka says in that croaky old voice of hers, wearing a robe and slippers like she just got out of the shower rather than *went to visit the café that is on the first floor of her home? Where there are customers? Was she even dressed under there?* Katsuki shudders at the thought and turns his attention to her, baring his canines.

"No, hag! Mind your own business!"

"You – little – " *Smack* "Come to my *home," smack,* "Harass my customers,*" smack*, "Don't even say hi to my nephew, who adores you," the barista flushes a bright red as the woman delivers another smack to Katsuki's shin, "You better buy something or stop loitering in my store!"

"You fuc –"

"We were just headed out." The smile that Dye Job flashes her is so wide and bright that Katsuki feels like he's stepped into an alternate dimension. The same guy threatening him and rolling his eyes has the sweetest, most polite smile in the world, teeth a gleaming white and lips just on the right side of crooked to be *cute*. He bows deeply to the elderly woman, placing his hand on Katsuki's lower back as a way to lead him out of the café, saluting the blushing boy at the counter who is staring at the two of them with an open mouth with a cheeky, 'See ya Otao!'

The second they're outside, Dye Job's hand leaves Katsuki's lower back and gets thrust into his pockets. Katsuki refuses to linger on that touch, and the residual heat from that man's hand that seems to have left a persistent imprint on his skin. Katsuki rolls his eyes, *Tch*-ing loudly and flipping the middle finger to the elderly woman in the window, who returns his gesture with two of her own.

Dye Job actually *laughs* at that, making that similar annoyance (which is what this *must* be) bubble up in Katsuki's stomach.

"You always get your shit handed to you cute elderly coffee shop owners?"

“Fuck *you*.” Katsuki walks ahead, unable to stomach this dude being in front of him, despite the fact that his instincts *scream* at him to walk behind, to watch him, to watch his own back.

“So. Where are we doing this? Middle of the street? So everyone can see a *civilian* floor their amazing hero?”

“Fuck you. I know you’re not a fucking civilian.” Katsuki responds, more serious than he intends. That shuts Dye Job right up. He just keeps following him, up until they’re in front of the Hero Gym.

Dye Job actually hesitates outside the discreet matte-black building, staring at the door with a look of trepidation.

“Scared?” Katsuki teases, and Dye Job’s face hardens.

“Let’s get this over with.”

Katsuki scoffs, pushing inside. He flashes his hero ID, scanning it in, introducing ‘fuckface’ as his guest. He scans the room quickly, ensuring that no *annoyances with dual-colored hair and stupid faces* are in the room, before making his way to the back to the private sparring rooms.

This pro-only gym has state of the art equipment, Olympic-grade pool and sauna and quirk-proof sparring rooms – an ideal place for a pro hero like Katsuki to train. Theoretically. If only he didn’t have to share it with, well, other pros.

Katsuki finds one of the rooms that remains unlocked and walks straight in, expecting Dye Job to follow. He throws off his jacket into the corner, tossing his sweater and leaving just a thin tank top. He unbuckles his belt, glaring down at the too-tight jeans. He certainly didn’t dress for this, and the jeans are going to limit his mobility. He could change, of course, but the idea of letting Dye Job out of his eyesight for even a minute doesn’t sit right with Katsuki.

He hops up and down, not facing Dye Job, mind racing as he tries to get his circulation up and his muscles warmed up. He’s not really sure where his head is at. On the one hand, yeah, Katsuki’s been *itching* for a good fight, and *yeah,* he’s curious how this stranger was able to pin *him*, Katsuki Bakugou, and *yeah,* he also wanted to know how this fucker seemed to be resistant to his nitro.

But Katsuki doesn’t go around picking fights. This isn’t normal for him. And neither is that warm, giddy feeling that flares in his chest every time he’s near the other man. That makes no goddamn *sense.* Katsuki glances up at Dye Job’s silhouette and swallows, a thrill shooting down his spine.

The other is removing his sweatshirt, looking way more comfortable than Katsuki in his joggers, thin strip of a dark happy trail revealing itself down finely sculpted abs. In just the remaining T-shirt, Katsuki finds his eyes fixed on his right arm.

The prosthetic looks like something straight out of a cyberpunk wet dream, the piston attaching to the connecting rod connected to a hydraulic press moving smoothly as he flexed his elbow. The fingers move slowly, stiffly, but somehow beautifully, each knuckle carefully crafted, bending at 90 degree angles. The metal disappears under the sleeve of his t-shirt, and Katsuki can’t explain why he desperately wants to see how its attached. And what other scars mar the other’s body.

It’s definitely the arm from that New York picture. *Vigilante or undercover hero,* Katsuki thinks to himself. At least he was two years ago. He could have still definitely turned to the villains, it’s not like its unheard of, but -

“Not nice to stare,” Dye Job chastises, and Katsuki is spurred out of his thought process, looking up sharply to those dark, knowing eyes. He scoffs and rolls his eyes, looking at the wall somewhere behind Dye Job as he stretches out his own arms, not noticing how the other man’s eyes linger on the star-shaped scar visible on his left shoulder.

They stretch in silence for a couple of minutes. Katsuki makes the first move, starting to circle the other, hands held out in front of him. He lets a few tiny fireworks *pop!* Off his palms.

“No quirks.” Dye Job says instantly as he moves opposite of Katsuki, circling him all the same, metallic arm and left arm held as a mirror to Katsuki’s own.

“Why?” Katsuki hisses.

Something dark flashes past Dye Job’s eyes.

“Can’t beat me without your little light show?”

Katsuki can tell by that self-satisfied smirk, Dye Jobs thinks he *got him.*

“Fuck you. I can beat you with both hands tied behind my back,” Katsuki snaps back, absolutely had.

“Maybe later.” Dye Job instantly responds, arching his eyebrows suggestively before lowering himself into a half-squat.

Katsuki does a double-take. “What did you – “

Dye Job makes the first move. He leaps forward, using the momentary confusion of his enemy, obviously, to throw the first punch, favoring his left arm, the right seeming to be heavy and throwing off his equilibrium.

Stick to his right, Katsuki thinks, dodging exactly to there, narrowly avoiding his fist. He takes the opportunity to try to swipe at the guy’s feet – but he’s quick, unusually so for how *bulky* he is – and his leg comes up in a beautiful angled kick. Katsuki barely has the time to defend himself with his arm, blocking a direct kick to his jaw but making his arms ache instantly.

But - the way he pivoted, the feel of that leg against his arm… it felt just like when. When. And suddenly, all Katsuki can see are images of green lightning, destroyed buildings, screaming voices. Images of wild glowing eyes, of explosions, of *him* under his hands.

Shit. What the fuck.

Katsuki throws a hurried punch, anything to make those thoughts go away. Side cut to the right side of his chest – he’s unsteady there. Katsuki’s right – Dye Job flinches, trying to protect his ribs, leaving his jaw open to a rapid uppercut. The hit isn’t clean, and the guy barely moves back, but the glint in his eyes and the grin he sports despite the new busted lip betray the fact that Dye Job is enjoying this just as much as Katsuki is.

Kinda hot, Katsuki thinks and instantly wants to scoop his brains out. The sweat running down the front of his neck, the way his white t-shirt sticks to the outline of his finely toned chest and his rock-hard abdomen, mouth open in a breathless pant – Katsuki wishes he wasn’t wearing skin-tight jeans right now.

Especially when Dye Job grabs him by the shoulders, knocks his legs out from under him and tackles him to the ground. He tries to keep Katsuki down, wrapping his thick thighs around Katsuki’s head as

he presses down on his arm, and Katsuki *really* wishes he wasn't wearing skin-tight jeans right now. Fuck Best Jeanist and the fucking denim-hell he crawled out of.

Katsuki flips them with a knee to the other man's abdomen, muscles straining against the bulk of his shoulders, defending against his right arm as the crushing strength of metal tries pin Katsuki's chest to the ground.

Katsuki briefly wonders why the guy doesn't target his injuries. Instead, he seems to be working hard to *not* grab at Katsuki's scarred left shoulder, or kick him on the left side of his abdomen. Any trained fighter would use that to their advantage.

He doesn't know how long they go for. It might have been minutes, it might have been hours. The fucker is meeting him blow for blow, sharp and responsive and strong as hell. Dye Job's smiling back at him, all playful furry, muscles bulging under Katsuki's hold.

He sees his opening when the fucker starts relying too much on thrusting and kicks. He's favoring his legs again, which means his arms are bothering him. Katsuki does it quickly, just like he's been trained – left hand pulled tight against Dye Job's chest, wrist pushing down the right shoulder, legs across his thighs to keep him pinned in place.

The slight wince of pain and the fact that he's not making aborted efforts to get Katsuki off him tells him all he needs to know.

"You fight dirty," Dye Job nearly spits in his face, eyes ablaze in something almost disgusted. Katsuki presses down harder on his right shoulder, exactly where the prosthetic meets the other's mangled flesh, earning a wince from the other.

"I fight to *win.*" Katsuki corrects, and the other man's face changes – minutely, almost imperceptibly. His sneer relaxes into an even pout, his eyebrows stop furrowing, his right shoulder which has been tense against Katsuki's fingertips now rests, flesh soft and malleable. There's something undeniably *gorgeous* about making a man like this lose. Katsuki leans in, a force grander than gravity pulling him forward, closer to his face, closer to the *something* that's been undulating between them since they first met eyes.

Dye Job's dark eyelashes flutter at his approach, eyes half-lidded as they follow him, and although Katsuki's the one who's pinning the other, he gets the unmistakable impression that he's not the one that's in control here.

"Guess I'm not leaving you alone," Katsuki whispers, leaning in further still, until he can feel the ragged breaths the other man is taking along his face.

"Good," Dye Job replies. He smiles, teeth covered in blood, and Katsuki stomach does a somersault in his abdomen.

Katsuki keeps his red eyes fixed on the dark black of Dye Jobs. He can see a little outline around his pupils and realizes, absently, that he's wearing contacts. Dye Job's eyes search his face, lazily tracing from one eye to the next, finally landing on Katsuki's mouth. He closes them, slowly, almost teasingly and Katsuki can feel his breath hitch.

"Zero. I go by Zero." He finally says, voice raw with an emotion Katsuki doesn't have a name for.

"Zero. " Katsuki whispers out.

He doesn't know what comes over him next – one moment he's gloating in the glory of his win, *Still got it assholes!* And the next he's darting forward, licking into the strangers mouth like he wants to eat him whole.

He tastes like salt, blood, raw energy, and Katsuki moans as the man grabs his hips, grinding him down into his dick as they messily meet lips, over and over again. For all Katsuki's adrenaline and excitement, Zero seems to slip his nonchalant façade, drinks him in like a starving man, biting into his bruised lip till copper floods both of their mouths, licking at his teeth, stroking at his tongue, gasping against him as Katsuki ruts back, hot air flowing back and forth through their mouths like they're not strangers – like they've mapped each other's mouths out many times before, like their bodies meeting was simply them coming home.

When they finally part, mouths slick and lips swollen, Katsuki is *burning* from the inside out, his jeans are so tight its painful and the press of Zero's cock against him is making his mouth water. He's so turned on he can't think straight, hands already finding their way under the wet t-shirt, nails digging into the others skin as he moves his hips up and down, humping into the stranger below him like he's a professional. God, he's gonna ride this annoying fucker until neither one of them can stand and –

Something in those half-lidded eyes connects, and his hands are on Katsuki's waist instantly, pushing him off. Zero scrambles away, body shaky as his back meets the wall. Using the wall as his brace, he somehow stands up, exhaling sharply.

Katsuki, recovering from whatever the fuck that was, looks up at him where he was tossed on the mat, clipping a "What the *fuck*?" His annoyance falters when he sees the sheer look of panic in the guy's eyes, the way he's pressed up so tightly against the wall, like he's trying to merge with the damn thing. His flush is so deep it spreads down his neck and into his chest, beads of sweat pouring from his forehead and catching into the neck of his already-soaked t-shirt.

"I should go. I – I didn't mean - "

"What's the fucking problem? You're into this. *I'm* clearly fucking in to this," Katsuki emphasizes the 'I'm' as he standing up and starts to saunter over, making sure to cup the very obvious outline of his straining erection against his jeans, nearly grinning as Zero's eyes follow his motion hungrily, eyes fixed on his cock.

He swallows visibly as Katsuki stands in front of him. Katsuki licks his lips, fingers plotting a trail up the other man's thigh. He doesn't miss the way Zero's whole body shivers under his touch. Katsuki's high off it – the win, the massive man in front of him trembling at the mercy of his hands, the prospect of having a heavy cock down his throat – it's been so long. Why the fuck *not.*

Katsuki drops to his knees instantly, nuzzling against the side of the erection. He looks up at Zero for permission, who seems to be watching him so closely he might be committing him to memory. The nod is almost imperceptibly small, and Katsuki's not 100% sure he actually saw it or just *wanted* to see it, but his hands are on the man's joggers in an instant, pulling down his pants and boxers with absolutely no pre-amble.

Katsuki's dick twitches at the sight of it. He's large all over, thigh curly dark hairs on the base of a thick, veiny cock, just glistening with pre-cum. Katsuki takes one of his hands and wraps it around the base, appreciating the way it looks almost *painful* for the other man, before he slowly, slowly starts to jerk him off.

The whimper that escapes the man is so fucking *cute* Katsuki wonders for a moment if it didn't accidentally leave his own mouth instead. He looks up at Zero, only to catch dark eyes staring right down at him, hand clenched so hard the fingers are blanching, and a deep, deep red blush that doesn't belong on a man who is nearly six and a half-feet tall and is roughly the size of a small barge.

"You always throw fights, or am I special, Zero?" Katsuki croons, drinking in every rough expression and bit-off whimpers the other man is offering him.

"You always – " keening whine, a strangled moan, a voice so wrecked you'd think they've been fucking for hours rather than half a minute of hand-play, "Blow strangers at the gym, or am *I* special?"

Katsuki glances up, showing Zero just how much spit has accumulated on his tongue before he licks a thick stripe down the underneath of his dick, before letting the shiny cockhead rest on the tip of his tongue. The other is utterly *lost,* face fixed in this desperate, hopeless look – a look that's asking Katsuki to reassure him. To tell him he's special.

Katsuki will do no such thing.

"Jealous?"

Something indescribable flashes across those black eyes, an expression that sends fire straight into Katsuki's bloodstream. He flashes teeth, canines unexpectedly sharp that send lightning down his spine. And suddenly, the man in front of him isn't soft and scared, he's *dangerous* and Katsuki doesn't understand how he could possibly *want* this much, how anyone can survive with such a viscous force living in their body. His face must say as such, because Zero angles himself, heavy cock hitting him lightly in the face, smearing pre-cum on his cheek, before he answers Katsuki's question.

"Yes." He growls more than he says it, large hand gripping the base of Katsuki's hair, and forces the head of his cock down Katsuki's throat.

Katsuki's eyes flash open at the intrusion, thick head hitting the back the back of his throat, and suppresses the urge to gag and sputter at the sudden pressure. But his mouth catches up much faster than his brain, and he relaxes his jaw as bleached blonde's hips surge forward, burying Katsuki's nose in the scent of gym heavy cock.

The buzzing in his head amounts to the ache in his jaw to the tingles down his spine. Katsuki realizes, somewhere in the back of his head, that he's reaching down to put some pressure against his own painfully hard erection. He relaxes his throat, letting the spit dribble down his face as the man above him uses him, fucking his mouth ruthlessly. All Katsuki can do is put his free hand on the other man's thighs, digging his fingernails into the hard muscular flesh, and lets it happen.

The second his eyes start to water with the pressure, that he closes them in order to keep himself from crying, Zero starts to slow down, and its all Katsuki can do to dig his nails harder into the other's, drawing blood and nodding, giving him silent permission to use him.

Katsuki hasn't felt this clear headed in who the fuck knows how long. His body vibrating with pleasure, his mouth keeps flooding with more saliva every time he tastes just a drop of beautifully bitter pre-cum, and he might actually *get off* at this rate.

Fuck that. He's not giving this asshole the satisfaction. He's not going to cum first.

So he gets with the program, his tongue swirling around the other man's cockhead, stroking the underside of his cock with the muscle as his fingers find the other man's taint, rubbing with a persistent pressure that makes the man above him moan, nearly buckling his knees. It takes almost no time at all, one second he's a dominant monster ready to fuck Katsuki's throat raw, the next he's trembling under Katsuki's hands, trying to pull his head off his cock as Katsuki stubbornly deep throats him, aware what comes next as the mans' balls contract and the pulsing in his cock hits all his senses with thick, bitter drops.

He wipes the spit off with the back of his arm, makes a show of swallowing the cum in his mouth and licks his lips as he pops off loudly from the other man's spent cock. Chest heaving, Zero watches him, wide eyes, lips open, just *panting* and it's so goddamn beautiful to see a man as powerful as him just fall apart for Katsuki's mouth.

"I win." Katsuki states simply, getting off his knees.

Casting one last smirk to Zero, Katsuki grabs his jacket and scarf, putting them on and making sure his still-hard dick is in the waistband of his jeans. Zero is still trembling up against the wall, eyes wide and disbelieving as he watches Katsuki walk across the room, barely functioning enough to catch his sweatshirt when thrown at him.

He flashes his tongue, flicking up his eyebrows and disappears out the door. This time, he's going to leave *him* confused and alone.

Fuck this guy.

Chapter End Notes

Katsuki: 

Katsuki: sucks his dick immediately

(forgive me I literally don't know how to do art or edits lmao I did my best FOR THIS MEME EXCLUSIVELY - SO HERE HAVE ZERO, an amalgamation of Mirio's body, Chisaki's hair, Katsuki's hair color, Izuku's eyes, nose and mouth (...no way... unless?!🤫) and Edward Elric's arm.)

Chapter 4

Chapter Notes

a.) This is my favorite sex scene I've ever written. Maybe my favorite chapter I've ever written.
b.) This will 100% lose me readers. I'm sorry and no I'm not and lmao.

Also, guys. Guys. Suspend your disbelief for one second. Dramatic irony = you, as the reader, know something that the character does not. That's the plot lol. Give it a few more chapters.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Katsuki puts his headphones on, letting the movement of the train soothe him into near-sleep. This early in the morning, leaving Tokyo, the train is mostly empty, and Katsuki appreciates the reprieve. He still wouldn't catch himself falling asleep in such a public place, but at least he can relax.

His fingers grip at the box in his hands a little tighter as the walks the familiar neighborhood, each foot forward feeling leaden. The pressure builds with each familiar sidewalk, street corner, flowerbed. By the time he reaches the front door, an insurmountable pressure is on his shoulders makes it impossible to breathe, to think, much less to lift his hand to knock.

But, just like every other time, he does.

The door swings open instantly, like she's been waiting for him, and for all Katsuki knows, she has been. Familiar and duller greens look up at Katsuki in gentle joy, and Katsuki feels the nausea hit him full-force. He averts his eyes, clearing his throat and thrusting the box towards Inko Midoriya, careful not to brush her fingers, as she lets him inside.

"Pardon the intrusion," Katsuki mumbles, removing his shoes in the genkan and making quick work to take off his jacket, hat and scarf, putting them on the empty rack next to the door. He leaves his duffel bag on the floor and makes his way into the Midoriya's living room as Inko disappears into the kitchen. Katsuki can hear the tale-tell click of the kettle and the familiar rattle of Inko pulling out the reliable can of tea.

Katsuki watches her out of the corner of his eye. Inko's aged a lot in the past four years. Fine wrinkles rest under her eyes and her forehead, constantly creased from her years of worrying. Her movements are slowed, too, like she's walking underwater. Silver strands intermingle in the green on her head, shining brightly under the fluorescence. Her clothes actually fit, which is unusual. Katsuki analyzes them as the woman moves around the kitchen, until a certain bend reveals the label. Ah. That makes sense. His mother's been here recently. The strange thought that *Inko dressed up for him* flits in and out of his brain, but it makes him too sick to even pretend to entertain it.

Things are weird enough already. He doesn't need to start noticing shit that he has no business noticing.

When she finally sets the tea and sweets down between them, Katsuki's looking at his own fingers, the discomfort starting to seep in. Inko sits down next to him, too close for Katsuki's taste, and places

a nearly translucent hand on his shoulder.

“I’m so happy to see you, Katsuki. It’s been too long.”

It hasn’t been very long at all, but Katsuki doesn’t correct her. Swallowing down whatever response he might have had, he opens his arms. As if she was waiting for permission, she dives into his hold, wrapping around him tightly, squeezing the breath out of him. His shirt starts to feel slightly damp and he rubs along her back, chin resting on the top of her head.

After a long moment, she pulls back, grabbing a nearby tissue and dabbing her eyes. She gives Katsuki that wobbly smile that makes his stomach twist and zeroes in on a piece of strawberry shortcake.

“How have you been, sweetheart?” Inko starts again, sitting a little further from Katsuki so she can look at his face.

Katsuki sighs out, the weariness pouring out of him in droves.

“I’ve been better.” Katsuki leans back against the couch, looking up at the same ceiling that Deku himself must have looked up a million times before. “Worked on some weird-ass cases that make no sense. Been shit getting my stats up as an independent in Tokyo. I -“ Katsuki hesitates. He’s made a point to be as honest with Inko with possible, but telling her about Zero feels… *wrong,* somehow, so he doesn’t say anything about their illicit encounter, though it’s been on his mind. A lot.

“… I haven’t found any more leads on De – Izuku’s – location. Two months and nothing.” Inko’s face falls, just slightly, but enough for Katsuki to catch it, and guilt floods his chest. He sighs, taking a bite of his own strawberry shortcake, hating the sweetness in his mouth. Hating that it used to be Deku’s favorite. Hating that he knows it, and still buys it, and still comes here, and is still like… *this*. Some pathetic paranoid insomniac with a too- familiar relationship with the mother of the person he can’t let go.

“…I feel like I’m going crazy. Something’s wrong with me.”

Inko nods, the light disappearing almost imperceptibly from her eyes. She sets down her teacup, hands resting on his forearm. Always touching him. They’re soft and small. Not broken and scarred like his. Not rough like his. Not his. Not enough *him* to make it better, but Katsuki can pretend. Has been pretending for the past four years. An actor in a play to an audience of ghosts.

“Katsuki… My Izuku has been gone for four years. I’m starting to think – “ Katsuki grits his teeth, holding on harder to the cup, playing the ceramic doesn’t splinter, but wishing that it does all the same. Wishes the liquid burns them both. Wishes the cuts from the ceramic never heal. Wishes that Deku drinks from this same cup ~~if~~ when he returns. Tastes the iron of his blood on his sullied tongue. *Don’t’ say it* he begs internally.

“If he is still… well,” *Alive,* Katsuki fills in for her, because it’s always what they say, “Maybe he doesn’t… want to be found. This – this isn’t healthy. We can’t – you can’t live like this.”

“And how do you think *he’s* living?” Katsuki snaps back, hearing the cup groan under his fingertips.

“He wouldn’t want you dying for him!” Inko exclaims, and Katsuki freezes. He really must look a wreck for Inko Midoriya to try to convince him, the only person still fucking *looking for her son*, that maybe he shouldn’t.

“He shoulda thought of that shit before – “ Katsuki doesn’t know how to end that sentence. The past twenty years of his life flash before his eyes. He’s had this conversation with himself half a million times, and no matter how many times he wants to bitterly blame Deku, he just *can’t*.

He should have trusted me? Really? Why? What in your history would make him trust you? The bullying, the ignoring, the undermining? The rooting for him to fucking fail? He should have relied on me? Why. Why would he do that? Especially when you’re so weak that you nearly fucking died but still couldn’t slow Shigaraki for a single minute? He should have – What? What should he have done?

~~Stayed with me.~~

Katsuki’s heart lurches at that thought. Fuck. He’s really getting delirious.

“I never cared about what he wanted before. I’m not about to start now.”

Inko doesn’t look happy with his response, her usually kind face fixed in an annoyed twitch. It almost makes him want to smile. He’s put that same irritated look on Deku’s face countless times – he never thought he’d be so desperate to see it again. He watches the way her hair tumbles over her ear, so straight and flat, and he wonders for the millionth time about Hisashi Midoriya, and where the fuck that asshole is, and if he’s covered with curls and freckles like his son.

They don’t talk about the fact that, in the corner of the room, a photo of Izuku Midoriya is framed, surrounded by fresh flowers, candles and always-burning incense.

As they finish their tea, Inko busies herself in the kitchen with making dinner. Katsuki grabs his duffle, shuffling to the room like he belongs there. He still pauses at the ‘Izuku’ on the door, pushing past with only a passing spark of shame.

The fact that it’s a shrine to the old man should bother him way more than it does. He can see those empty, deep blue eyes watching him from the figurines, the posters, the fucking *bedspread.*

He goes to the closet first, taking out the well-worn binders. He digs gloves out of his duffel and leaves through the pages of the *Hero Analysis for the Future!* Volumes. He’s made copies of most of the relevant stuff already, but there’s something about seeing his writing, about the jokes and doodles in the margins uncoils some disgusting knot in his chest. He skips right past notebook 13, guilt gnawing at his ankles like a persistent little rat.

He doesn’t give a shit what thirteen year old Deku thought of him or the world. Doesn’t care about the shitty notes he jotted down after he tossed his notebook in the koi pond. Doesn’t care that that same day, All Might gave him this fucking cursed power, after watching a thirteen year old boy nearly kill himself for someone who probably deserved to die that day. Katsuki doesn’t care, and he doesn’t look, because it doesn’t matter.

He, instead, pulls out one of the more recent volumes. He’s read through these notes enough times to recite them from memory, but it never hurts to look. Deku might have been leaving hints even *he* wasn’t aware of. And the numerical ‘3’ Deku used in the English spelling of his hero name still stumps Katsuki.

Because the top three heroes in the industry, plus All Might, helped him disappear? Because One for All holder #3 was the answer, somehow?

Katsuki still has a lot of questions. Why didn’t Shigaraki just *kill* Deku if he couldn’t take One for All by force? Why not just kidnap his mom or hold U.A. hostage to lure him out? Why chase the kid all

over the world? Why has the man who leveled cities just four years ago degraded down to committing petty crimes and misdemeanors?

None of it fit, which can only mean one thing.

Deku figured something out.

He had to have.

After sharing a quick, entirely silent dinner with Inko and helping her with the dishes, Katsuki brushes his teeth, changes into his pajamas and climbs into Deku's childhood bed.

It's a tight fit, the twin hardly wide enough for his shoulders completely when he's on his back, and he turns on his side, inhaling deeply into the covers. After all this time, none of it smells like him anymore. It's something Katsuki prefers not to think about, hallucinating the scent of mint and pine that he inhaled greedily the first few days he invaded Deku's space after he disappeared. Inko clearly doesn't use the same detergent she did when Deku was around. He could ask her to – but doesn't think he'd be able to live with the shame.

Katsuki sighs, knowing full well that sleep was hours away. Instead, his eyes find themselves focused on the dork's ceiling. Its filled with those gross glue on glow in the dark stars, and Katsuki can't help but think of the boy – sweet and innocent, eyes as starry as his ceiling, so excited to be a hero. Bet he never thought this is how it would end.

Hasn't ended yet, his brain addends stubbornly, and Katsuki agrees, despite the fucking memorial alter in the Midoroya living room.

She might just be humoring me, Katsuki considers, knowing he sounds paranoid even to his own brain. *She thinks he's dead too, just like everybody else. They're all laughing behind my back and –*

Katsuki exhales quickly, trying to get his heart rate back to normal. It doesn't matter. Doesn't matter who believes him. Deku's alive and Katsuki's going to find him. It's an indisputable fact.

He knows what comes next. He doesn't know why he always tries to put it off, like one day he's going to wake up and not have this disgusting compulsion. But today isn't that day, and Katsuki can feel the tell-tale tingling in his limbs, telling him its *time.*

Absently, Katsuki starts to trail fingertips down his exposed neck. His mind is blank as he pets himself, cock filling out in his sleep pants. Katsuki doesn't do this here for fun or for relief. He doesn't really even know why he does it. He reaches into his own shorts, running his hand up and down his cock. When he's here, he doesn't try to enjoy it or drag it out. He brings himself to orgasm quickly and quietly, so that he has the rest of the evening to stew in utter self-disgust.

He doesn't know what compels him to do it when he's in the nerd's room. Maybe he'll never really know. Will never process the fact that he breathed his scent and rutted against his pillows the first few days he was gone like a bitch in heat. Why? The hope that he comes back and finds Katsuki like that, debasing his space? The desire to take *more more more,* because he feels like he deserves more, deserves more than that generic ass note after everything they went through? The desire to ruin him, the same way that he's ruined Katsuki?

Katsuki's heart skips a beat as he thinks of him, wherever he is. Has Deku taken on a lover? Is he somewhere, with a different name and a different face, happy and ~~forgotten all about him~~?

Katsuki's still awake, as he always is, when the door creaks open, and the room is filled with soft foot-steps. Katsuki moves closer to the wall, discretely, to give her more room. Inko crawls into bed next to him, sighing softly as she buries her face into his back, thinning arms wrapping lightly around his abdomen.

Katsuki has no idea if she knows that he's always awake when this happens.

He feels her trembling, hears the tiny aborted sobs and the tell-tale wetness of tears soaking into the back of his shirt. He keeps himself still. He doesn't make so much as a sound, even though his own eyes start to burn as the woman's body trembles, trying hard to stay quiet as grief wrecks her body. She always cries, he always pretends he doesn't notice, and when they sleep next to each other, two warm bodies in the bed of her son and his former childhood friend, they pretend its normal.

But when he's here, he sleeps through the night. He never pretends that Inko is Deku, holding him. He never pretends that it's his hands wrapped around his abdomen, grounding him, helping him, saving him.

He leaves as soon as its morning. Katsuki never lingers. Its better this way.

It's interesting the way this works. He leaves feeling well rested, but wound up in a different way. He wants a giant villain to attack so he can go all out, or someone to beat the shit out of him, or – Huh.

Now that he thinks about it, for the first time in a long time, he might actually have a way to work off some of this excess… energy.

He changes quickly, locking up, before walking to the spot. He vaguely remembers hearing about it – hadn't used it before, had no reason to, but… He enters through the back, pressing a few buttons on the machine. The place it nearly dark, and there's almost no people mulling around, but Katsuki keeps his head ducked under the hood, face mask and sunglasses hiding his more recognizable features.

Card in hand, he stomps over back towards his apartment. Back towards the coffee shop.

He rushes in with an unknown urgency, completely ignoring Moto-moto (?) grinning at him from behind the counter as he walks straight towards the giant blonde, already sitting at his regular table, reading that same fucking *English* book like he doesn't have a care in the world.

Katsuki shoves his hand in his pocket and slides the jet-black electronic card across the table.

Katsuki's too frazzled to notice the light blush painting the taller blonde's cheeks at his sudden intrusion.

"…What is this?"

"Meet me at 7 tonight." Katsuki orders. He doesn't take the time to observe the other's reaction, hastily making his way out of the coffee shop.

Katsuki comes through the discreet back door, swiping his card in the elevator to get to his floor. The lighting is essentially non-existent, only illuminating the room numbers in a faint, maroon glow. He doesn't see anybody else as he goes there, but adjusts his baseball cap and sunglasses all the same.

The room's not bad. Pretty modern and stylish. Not any different than a regular hotel, except for the amenities.

Katsuki glances at bedside alarm clock. 6:30. He's a bit early, and the sun's just now setting. He walks over to the curtains, shutting them tight, so only a sliver of orange sunlight shadows across the made bed. Sitting anywhere feels off. So he stands. And paces. And debates the merits of pulling his hair out.

And waits.

And waits.

…And waits.

Goddamn. Its 8:03, but fuck this. Katsuki's paid for this room, and he's using it. He's definitely not going to spend time wallowing over the fact that he got stood up by a complete fucking stranger.

He's watching something shitty on the TV, splayed out on the bedspread in his shoes, sipping on the open bottle of soju he got from the mini fridge and crunching spicy chips, not giving a shit as he wipes his red-stained hands on his t-shirt, when he hears the lock mechanism activate on the door.

He jumps, body turning towards the door, sweat pooling in his palms. He flexes the tendons in his wrists, ready to fire off the first hit, high or low, depends on the height of the guy -.

A large body and head of bleached blonde hair makes it past the threshold, looking around suspiciously, and suddenly Katsuki remembers exactly what he's doing there. At the sight of Katsuki, Zero's shoulders seem to loosen, and he lets out a breath, whole chest heaving in something that looks vaguely like relief. Katsuki hides the opened soju bottle behind him, heart hammering as he approaches the other man. He showed up, which means… does it…?

"…You're late." Katsuki states simply. Zero's face doesn't change – in this darkness, barely illuminated by the television, he almost looks… upset.

"Thought this might be a trap. Observed for a bit before I… figured out what kind of place this is." Zero states, pointing pointedly to the array of condoms and lube on the bedside table. Katsuki frowns in response.

"What did you *think* I wanted from you?"

"Don't know. You did assault me in an alley the day after we met."

"I also sucked your dick two days after we met. So." Katsuki crosses his arms, feeling vaguely that that might not have been as good of a comeback as he thought it was.

"…What was that about?" Zero finally says, voice rough. Katsuki tilts his head, watching the glow of those dark eyes. Something looks.. twitchy about him, almost insecure. It's kind of weird. The dude fucked his throat like a monster, so Katsuki doesn't understand why he's being so coy now.

Katsuki pauses, really thinking about it, turning over the statement in his head. Why. Why did everything have to have an answer? "Don't know. You made me mad. I wanted to put my mouth on you."

"That how you normally deal with people that make you mad?"

"You'd be surprised."

Mouth, fist, cock, what did it matter. His body was a killing machine, through and through, hands still dripping with blood that no one else can seem to see, and his words don't mean shit, but skin on skin, bone on bone, blood and sweat and cum, that? That's a language he understands.

It's all pain anyway. Just different flavors.

"…You know, most heroes probably wouldn't face-fuck a stranger like that." Katsuki smirks, mouth watering at the memory.

Zero's eyes flash with something complicated. "Never said I was a hero."

Katsuki bridges the distance between them. The heat seems to escalate into an inferno, magnetic force trying to bring them together. Try as Katsuki might, he's never felt like this, this raw energy between himself and another person. Its intoxicating. He takes his hand, placing it upon the other man's left shoulder, and slowly drags it down, over his loose sweatshirt, until he can feel the steady thrum of his heart pumping under his fingertips.

"What are you, then?"

Zero's eyes flash and his arm darts up, grabbing Katsuki by the wrist, just on the right side of too roughly. There's something tumultuous, dark and stormy behind those black eyes, and Katsuki finds the way the TV's light hits his angled face intoxicating. Almost frightening.

"Does it matter…?" Zero nearly whispers, but he's not asking. There's a different question in the glint of his eyes, the press of his hand against Katsuki's wrist, and he sighs with satisfaction.

"No." Katsuki barely has time to bite out before Zero is grabbing his chin, squeezing his cheeks and slamming a kiss on him – something hungry and almost violent, ravenous in a way that Katsuki's never encountered. He barely remembers when to breathe before he can reciprocate, before he can take a moment to taste the other man's hot tongue searching his mouth, before he can feel the slightly rough skin on his own lips, before he tastes the tangy metallic taste of blood and isn't sure whether its his own or Zero's.

Katsuki's desperate for it, hands under the man's jacket, tossing it off his body as he trails wet kisses down his jaw, briefly breaking apart as he quickly tugs his shirt off his abdomen. He pulls back, taking in the other man's body. Fuck, he looks good.

Dexterity seems to be an issue for Zero, so he helps him out, throwing his own shirt off, hands messing with the button on his pants before he feels the other man's hand stop him.

"What," dark eyes search Katsuki's, though hazy with lust, some panic behind them that Katsuki can't really discern. He furrows his eyebrows, urging the other man to continue. Zero, licks his lips, then start again. "What do you want? From me?"

Katsuki grins, grabbing at the other man's waistband and pulling him towards him roughly, so their naked chests are flush. He feels like rock, all warm and hard and goddamn sexy, and Katsuki's mouth finds his clavicles, trailing down to the muscle of his pec as another hand, slightly more devious, cups the half-hard member in his crotch. He hears Zero's breath hitch and smiles to himself. *Sensitive.*

Katsuki stands on the tips of his toes, licking his lips before breathing out raggedly in the other man's ear, nipping gently at his earlobes and eliciting a gasp too small and too sweet for such a large man, before whispering "Want you to fuck me."

Katsuki nearly gasps at the sudden flourish of pain in his abdomen where Zero's grabbing him, fingers tightening hard at the whisper.

The movement is sudden, one second he's standing in front of the taller blonde, whispering dirty shit in his ear, the next second his arms are lifting him up, practically tossing him onto the bed, bounding afterwards on four knees, trapping him beneath his heft.

"You want *me* to *fuck you*." He repeats, breathless, but his eyes betray some degree of excitement. Katsuki shrugs beneath him, watching his eyes trail along his shoulders, down his generous pectorals, landing on the scar on his abdomen.

"If you can't deliver, I have other options," Katsuki lies, keeping his voice evenly flat. If this jackass was paying any attention, he'd see that Katsuki's rock hard, that he's starving for him, specifically *him,* that his whole body responds to his rough kisses in a way that he doesn't have a name for.

He leans down, baring his starkly white teeth, arms trapping his head. Katsuki doesn't notice himself lifting his chin, trying to narrow this distance between them, trying to catch those snarling lips back into his own, eyes locked in challenge but roaming hands (*the muscles of his thighs, jesus, his ass, feels good, want him want him want him)* betraying how he really feels.

"No." He states, like he's ordering Katsuki around, and he shudders under it, biting into his lip before Zero's mouth is on him, nipping at his lips, almost violent in their constant need for contact, for tongue against tongue, slotted so close they hit each other's teeth, and Katsuki doesn't fucking *care,* because Zero drops the bullshit, lets his body angle down and *moans* into his mouth as he thrusts his hips forward, his cock rubbing against Katsuki's clothed thigh.

His hand is… shaking, which is fucking weird, and he rests his sweaty forehead against Katsuki's shoulder, breathing deeply, just for a second too long, like he's debating the merits of *fucking Katsuki*, which is insulting, actually, because Katsuki's *a god* and anyone should be so *lucky –*

"Lights have to be off," Zero finally says, up on his knees, towering over Katsuki as he stares up at him incredulously on the bed.

"What the fuck? You think I'm fucking ugly or somethin'?" Katsuki has never, ever, *ever* heard anyone so much as imply that he wasn't god's gift to mankind, and honestly, shit kind of hurts. What the hell?

When Zero doesn't respond, Katsuki's jaw drops further. "Are you *fucking* jok-"

"Its not that," Zero replies, eyebrows furrowed, hands still trailing down his chest, taking a beat too long to outline the scar on his abdomen, matching in size and shape to the one on his shoulder. His fingertips are featherlight, gentle against it, and Katsuki searches his face.

"What, *scars* gross you out?"

"I promise it's not that," Zero assures, softer this time. He leans down, his lips gently tracing the outlines on the scar on his abdomen, making whatever thrill that had worn off with the insult return in droves. His lips are so soft, so *gentle,* and Katsuki doesn't fucking know why he's getting *emotional,* like there's a baseball stuck in the middle of his throat as too-gentle hands rest on his hips, hot tongue lapping at the V-cut of his abdomen, just short of reaching his straining cock.

His left hand fumbles awkwardly with the button of his jeans, frustration painted clear on his face as he struggles with his mechanical arm to take his pants off. Katsuki's hands are quick to help him,

jeans sliding off along with his boxers to reveal his ruddy pink cock, rock hard and bouncing against his abdomen. Katsuki splays himself out on the bed, stark naked, flushed from the previous touch, aroused and *ready.*

He hears Zero inhale sharply, face drawn carefully neutral, but his exhale sounds strained.

“Lights have to be off, or I’m not doing this.”

Really not what a guy wants to hear when he’s completely naked, cock leaking all over his own torso in a love hotel, but what-the-fuck-ever. Katsuki grimaces and reaches for the bedside lamp lit behind him, quickly turning it off.

Without the persistent source of light, the only thing left to illuminate the room is whatever barely-there flickers of moonlight are present behind the curtains. Katsuki feels utterly blind for a second, before his eyes adjust. He glares, or at least whatever a glare might be in this sheer darkness, back up at the man towering over him. He hears the man exhale again, this time more evenly, before he feels his left hand feeling up his thigh, rubbing against his hip bone before, so fucking *gingerly,* grabbing at the base of his cock. Katsuki hisses at the contact, too worked up and hypersensitive.

“*Fuck,”* Katsuki hears from above him, and he doesn’t take a second to ask as the other man starts to stroke, on the wrong side of too slow, grip gentle and intimate. “*Fuck, fuck, fuck,”* he hears the other man whisper under his breath as his strokes pick up, sounding utterly bewildered, like he’s never fucking seen a cock before, Jesus, and whimpers escape unintentionally from behind Katsuki’s parted lips.

The larger man leans down, bulk spreading back out on the bed and suddenly hot puffs on air are caressing his dick, and Katsuki groans, cock twitching with need. He nearly bites his lip in half as the other man licks up the entire underside of his cock in one fell swoop, sucking briefly at the sensitive head, tonguing at his slit. Katsuki straight up moans as the other man takes him into his mouth, tip of his cock hitting the roof as he tries to find some semblance of rhythm.

It's not… *good* necessarily. He’s slobbering all over him, spit pooling on his abdomen and running down the clefts of his ass, and he’s sloppy, teeth grazing the sensitive skin a touch too often, so that every time the tell-tale warmth of orgasm starts to teeter on the edge, Katsuki loses it completely, only for the other man to bring him there again.

It's driving him *crazy.*

“Stop *edging* me, asshole, and fucking *fuck me!*” Katsuki demands. Zero seems to remember what the fuck he’s doing, and his left hand leaves its spot pressing down on the base of his cock, running down the clefts of his ass and resting pretty against his hole.

“Ask me again,” Zero whispers with his lips against the head of his cock, before he gives down again, one crooked finger dabbing into the saliva that been pooling all around his ass before simultaneously pushing past his rim. Katsuki nearly hops off the bed, the lightning sensation in his spine almost sending him over the edge.

“Goddamnit, would you fuck me already!” Katsuki nearly yells, and the rhythmic feeling of fingers (two now? Not that he’s paying attention.) Katsuki waits a solid five seconds before he scoffs, and through clenched teeth, whispers, “*Please.*”

“Ask me *again*,” Zero repeats a second time. Katsuki can hear something in the background, something that sounds an awful lot like a cap of lube open and then the wetness between his legs

becomes much more, well, wet and slippery, and those fingers are massaging his walls like they were fucking built for it, and in the darkness Katsuki's not too ashamed to let tears collect in the corners of his eyes, frustration and arousal mixing in his under stimulated body.

It's been so long, and the last person – urgh. He can't think about him right now, he wants to enjoy this, he wants this, he wants *Zero.* That's all that matters, this moment, the man hovering over him. This new pain to replace the old pain to replace the older pain, tumbling dominos that are infinite, but god forbid that they reach the very end and see what's at risk of tipping over.

"Please. *Please* fuck me. Want you. Want you inside me. Please." Katsuki babbles out, vision whiting out as Zero hits the bundle of nerves inside him that make him nearly prematurely ejaculate all inside the stranger's mouth. He comes off him with a pop, breathing heavy, chest heaving, and Katsuki just lays there, staring up at him, vision clouded with unshed tears.

"Get on your knees." Zero demands, and Katsuki shudders, arousal pooling hard in his gut before he complies, sticking his ass nice and high in the air. He moans lightly as lips, wet with spit, kiss tenderly along his ass, almost reverently as more lube and the same fingers find his hole. At this angle, its all the more intense, and Katsuki's too on-edge not to moan, openly, sluttily, rutting back into those fingers like he's got rent to pay.

"Fuck me, hurt me, break me, *please* –" Katsuki groans out into the pillow, stretch harsher and slightly painful as a third finger meets the other two. Katsuki's brain is buzzing pleasantly, all static and nothingness, so blissed out he doesn't notice the pause in those fingers at his words.

Katsuki can hear the telltale sound of a condom being ripped open. He can't help himself - he moves his neck, desperate to see – but Zero's metallic hand, presses in the back of his neck, harsh, just shy of cutting out his air supply.

"Don't look." Zero whispers harshly, and Katsuki bites at his tongue, desire to argue way outweighed by his desire to get railed. Zero doesn't want to see his face, his body, doesn't want to hear his voice, doesn't want to be looked at – doesn't seem to *want* this, but he's pressing his rock-hard cock against his hole with his left hand and… Wait. What? His hand is shaking so hard Katsuki can feel the vibration through his ass, and if a heavy metallic weight wasn't pressing his neck down, he'd try to turn around again, concern overwhelming his annoyance, flitting off his tongue before he can stop it.

"Don't fucking *force* yourself, jackass, I – "

"Please. Please stop talking." Zero's voice takes on a different cadence, one of desperation and misery. Katsuki doesn't know what to do with it, feels his own cock softening at the anxiety of his partner. But he keeps himself still, not sure what to do.

"I *want* this."

Zero's voice is tragically soft, the ache in it spreading through Katsuki's bones and making his heart skip a beat.

"I *want you*. So much." He takes a beat, voice sounding wrecked. "*Too* much. Just – just give me a moment."

Katsuki doesn't know what the fuck to do with that. But it's not like he's got a ton of options right now, so he, well, gives him a moment.

He hears the man behind him exhale again, metallic arm pressing harder against his neck and slowly, *slowly* his hips move forward, his cockhead teasingly pushing past the thick rim. Katsuki groans loudly, dick filling back out as snippets of pain and pleasure shoot through his abdomen. Zero's breathing so hard its all he can fucking hear in the room, but Katsuki can't fucking complain as inch by inch, so slow its killing him, Zero sheaths his cock inside of him. He stays absolutely still as Katsuki tries to relax around it.

"How… how does it feel?" Zero rasps out, the hands previously around his cock now on Katsuki's waist, gripping as hard as they can though they're sweaty and shaking.

"Full. S'big. Feels fucking *good.*" Katsuki grunts into the pillow. He feels a cold sweat erupt along the base of his neck, not sure whether in desire or pain. The guy's got a thick cock, and its been a long time, and Katsuki can't really explain why he jumped into this with a complete stranger, except he needed it, and he needed him. That's it.

The exhale that Zero lets out after the word *good* could make the whole room vibrate. The room itself feels hot, stuffy, almost humid, like a rainstorm might start at any second.

"Move." Katsuki orders, but Zero doesn't at all. Katsuki bites at his tongue. "*Please.*"

"Don't order me around," Zero's voice, previously so scared and vulnerable, sounds like all sex and grit, and before Katsuki has time to process that whole transformation, he feels him slide out nearly to the tip, and *slam* back into him. His own moan is *beautiful,* music to Katsuki's ears, really, and he grinds his ass back on his cock.

For someone who seemed nervous as hell to start, Zero's merciless, pumping his cock into Katsuki's ass like he's trying to punish him. Over and over again until Katsuki can't think, can't breathe, until his body feels like its floating through space, until he can feel himself drooling all over himself, tears leaking openly from his eyes, so blissed out that things like *shame* don't exist. This is going to hurt like a motherfucker in the morning, but Katsuki can't bring himself to care as each thrust of the other man's hips brings him one step closer to ecstasy.

The slide of that thick cock spreading his walls is *perfect.* The hands digging into his hip, his neck are *perfect.* The desperate moans above him, a man in the throes of passion, murmuring something that Katsuki can't make out under his breath, is fucking *perfect.*

"Close – close – " he says, suddenly, louder as his grip against Katsuki's neck tightens. Katsuki can feel it – the stuttering movement of his hips, the moans that almost sound *pained,* and he puts a hand on his own cock, stroking himself in time as the man above him thrusts a few more desperate, hard, harsh times before his body convulses, sweaty chest meeting Katsuki's back. Lips press fervently at the nape of his neck, teeth scraping the muscle, whispers of "Holy shit, oh my god– *"* before Katsuki's catching his own orgasm in his fist, drops falling onto the covers of the bed.

Katsuki can't see a goddamn thing, all with the darkness, the fact that his vision just blacked out completely, and he heaves as Zero seems to regain consciousness, shakily getting himself back up and gingerly pulling out of his ass.

Katsuki can hear shuffling, shifting on the bed, something wet hitting a trashcan, heavy footsteps walking away and coming back, towel and water in hand. Wordlessly and meticulously, he cleans Katsuki and then himself, before tossing the rag away and immediately climbing under the covers with Katsuki, not bothering to put his clothes back on.

Katsuki scoots towards him, reveling in the other man's warmth, not at all put off by his sweat. He can feel the instinct to pull away, to get dressed, to get *out* but something pulls him back to Zero.

"Good?" Katsuki asks, kissing at the man's shoulder. Not that he fucking cares. He *doesn't.* And he would never, not on his life, admit the fact that he was looking for some kind of reassurance, because this thread of disgusting self-doubt is weaving itself into his chest.

A delirious-sounding laugh punches out of him, and he rubs at his eyes with his hand, a smile that Katsuki can hardly make out flashing across his face that makes Katsuki's stomach twist uncomfortably. Must be his guts re-rearranging themselves.

"Yeah… *yeah.*" There's a pregnant pause, before a much more hesitant whispered, "You?" Leaves his lips.

"Had worse," Katsuki says, because it's true, because he's a jackass, and refuses to let Zero know just how good for him that really was. He feels Zero's arm stiffen, but he doesn't say anything else, and exhaustion gets the better of him. He doesn't mean to, not really, but he drifts off to a dreamless, boneless sleep.

Katsuki's eyes open to the sound of someone shuffling next to him, twisting the covers, breathing picking up. He's briefly tense, not remembering where the fuck he is, before he recounts the events of the last night, both in his mind and in his sore ass. *Nice.* He turns sharply to the alarm, *4am*. Holy shit, did he fall asleep.. and at a love hotel?

He looks next to himself, fully expecting the other to be gone. But he's not – Zero's asleep too, chest heaving, eyes scrunched, gnawing his jaw so loudly Katsuki can hear it, whimpers escaping from behind his teeth.

Katsuki props himself onto his elbows, looking at the man's tortured face. Some sadistic part of him is *fascinated* with this. What is Zero having nightmares about? The whimpers leaving his lips sound almost *pathetic* coming from a body so large, and in the darkness, Katsuki can make out the light sheen of sweat collecting on his forehead.

Shirtless, he can see where the metal arm attaches, and the short nub of his arm. The shoulder itself is heavily scarred, discolored, but the site of the stump itself looks surgical. Something in it makes Katsuki's stomach churn. Katsuki's fingers, at their own accord, reach out to touch that marred shoulder, the scars singing a song of familiarity, and he almost feels like something clicks when the body below him bolts upright, voice booming.

"DON'T TOUCH ME!"

Katsuki pulls back instantly own heart stopping completely, eyes wide, face pale as a ghost, his voice loudly still ringing in the hotel room. His horrified eyes dart towards Katsuki, and he's scrambling out of bed before Katsuki can even raise his voice. He trips over the covers, naked body wrapped in sweaty sheets, and he ends up ass down on the floor, trying and failing horribly to unwrap himself with the one dexterous hand.

For the first time since Katsuki's met this enigmatic Zero, he seems frazzled. Scared. And Katsuki feels at fault.

He hates this. He hates those wide eyes looking up at him, fear pouring off the other in waterfalls. He hates that he's looking at Katsuki like a threat. And the fact that this feels so *familiar,* like he's been here before, like he's had those horrified eyes look up at him before, makes Katsuki's head spin.

“What are you doing? Its four in the fucking morning. You had a nightmare. Come back to bed.”

Katsuki’s not fucking sure why he says those words. The spot that Zero just occupied radiates warmth, and the sight of the six-foot-something giant looking like a lost child pulls at a heartstring that Katsuki didn’t even know he still had.

“I – I shouldn’t be here.” Katsuki couldn’t ignore the waver in his voice, how much deeper it got, how resolute. But despite that, there’s some doubt in there. “This. This was a mistake.” Zero says, voice dark. Katsuki can hear him absently tapping on the floor, trying to locate his clothes with touch alone, ignoring pointedly the way his heart absolutely drops in his chest at those words.

“*Why.*” He grits out, not exactly angry, but confused. They had a good time last night, didn’t they?’

“You wouldn’t *want* this if you knew who I was.” Zero’s words are harsh whispers, eyes panicked as they meet with Katsuki, and Katsuki can *feel* that he’s telling the truth.

“I told you,” Katsuki shrugs, “It doesn’t matter to me.”

“*Why?*’ He looks horrified, and Katsuki shrugs, his chest feeling heavy and horrible.

“Not a whole lot of shit matters to me anymore.” Katsuki responds, and it’s the most honest he’s been in years.

Zero’s face softens then, to something imperceptibly gentle. Katsuki doesn’t see it in the darkness, but he can feel it, and he lays back down, looking at the ceiling. His chest feels like shit, and tears are pushing at the corners of his eyes, and he doesn’t know why he’s telling a goddamn one-night-stand any of this, but he can’t seem to stop himself, the post-sleep delirium getting the better of him.

“I get them too. The nightmares. This shit,” Zero follows Katsuki’s hand as it travels to hold on to his own scarred abdomen, “Just plays on repeat. Over and over and over again. I get nightmares when I’m awake too. I’m starting to think my whole fucking life is a nightmare.”

Its silent. Katsuki closes his eyes again, steeling himself at the stupid devastation he’s going to feel when Zero walks out the door. This is what he gets for being vulnerable with anyone. This is what he gets when -

“Why…? Why did you sleep with me?” The questions sound rhetorical, almost delirious, and Katsuki doesn’t know why he… worded it like that. They fucked. They just *fucked.* It was transactional, mutually beneficial, and now its over, but the man sitting on the floor is treating it like it was… Something else. A figment of the real personality under the façade, something *soft* and *young* hiding underneath that scarred, hard body.

Katsuki get up on his knees, shuffling past the covers, taking the man’s face into his hands. He forces him to look up, conflicted black irises meeting his own, before Katsuki leans in for a kiss. Morning breath, fucking *nasty,* but somehow he doesn’t care, lips so soft and pliable for him. Zero sighs into it, shoulders relaxing as hands wraps around Katsuki’s waist, pulling him close, closer still until he’s flush with the other man’s chest. Its not exactly *comfortable,* not for kissing, and Katsuki realizes somewhat late that Zero is… *hugging* him.

“Does it matter?” Katsuki finally asks, similar to what Zero asked him before they fucked.

“Yeah. Yeah, it does.” Katsuki recoils, not having expected that answer, but Zero only hugs him closer, laughing humorlessly against his shoulder. “It would be kinder just to kill me.”

He’s trembling again, shaking like a goddamn leaf, just like before he was about to fuck him last night, and Katsuki has no idea why he agrees, because he’s being cruel, but *how*. All that he knows is that there’s a man who bears scars comparable to his own, who has nightmares and no name, whose eyes and hair and laugh is fake.

And he wants to hold him.

“I made a mistake.” Zero finally whispers, lips brushing against Katsuki’s neck with the words, sending shivers down his spine. He runs his hands up the man’s muscular neck, playing with the short strands of hair on his nape, eyes not meeting his face but looking at him, through him, past him.

Katsuki doesn’t ask him what the mistake was. Katsuki doesn’t say a single thing.

Zero unhooks from him, finds all his clothes, and Katsuki stares at the ceiling as the mechanical whirring of the door signals that its closed.

Kinder just to kill me.

There it is again. That familiarity, that burning in his throat, this horrible feeling of intimacy and connection to Zero, a complete stranger that doesn’t treat him like a stranger.

Everything that Katsuki feels – hurt, betrayal, loneliness, desire – he packages away. Gingerly, like these raging emotions, like this fire in his abdomen is going to annihilate him from the inside out, he shuts it away.

And he feels nothing.

Chapter End Notes

Me: 

Lol idk why I always fuck with Inko's character, I promise I love her.

I was so, so SO tempted to write them actually having sex because of how interesting it would be to write Izuku's devastation and fallout and PAIN and Katsuki's self-hatred... BUT while I could write it away for Katsuki I couldn't give any excuse for Inko (Katsuki at his lowest point, just wanting to see and feel Izuku in whatever way he can, in his heart believing he's never coming back... URGH the cinnamon-tography. PLEASE.) But doing that to Inko would be COMPLETE character assassination. She misses her son, and might be a tad touch-starved, but its KATSUKI. She watched him grow up. Knew that Izuku adored him. I just couldn't do it.

Chapter 5

Chapter Notes

Plot? In my depressing porn? It's more likely than you think.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Katsuki tips the cup back, the last of his protein shake pouring thickly down his throat. He chews on the remaining ice, mouth going numb as he crosses his arms. He stares at the clear push-pin – Zero's – and the blue matching one, a marker of Dabi's location. *Arson. Brooklyn. Blue flame.*

He doesn't know what compels him to do it. Call it a hunch, an instinct, a feeling that has burrowed into his bones like a cancer since their encounter last night. A man who insists that he's no one is generally someone. A man that has something to hide often has something worth finding.

He follows the red, yellow, black and blue strings past New York.

It's been two years. The papers tacked under new information are yellowing with age, slightly crumpled but easily readable. The article hangs right above a pin with yellow string. *Husband accused of triple homicide. Insists 'Double' committed murders.* Cases like this generally don't catch Katsuki's eyes – but this time, the sheer quantity of stab wounds and the amount of blood reported missing from the scene piqued his interest. "Amsterdam."

He sits back down in front of his computer. "Vigilante." "Prosthetic" "Amsterdam," Katsuki hedges his bets, "August, 20XX."

The hit comes up instantly. Family outside of a crumbling building. Masked person in gloves, holding up collapsing concrete. There's a tear in his jet-black suit, revealing the machinery of his artificial right arm.

"… Huh."

Two places in the past two years. Two places that link Zero to the League.

The four split there; different cities and different countries; at least, Katsuki believes. Photos that have surfaced of the four generally disappear within hours. All mention of the League on search engines from Japan are carefully curated – words like *cold case* and *defeated* and *disbanded* floating around, blatant lies to pacify the public.

He supposes its fair. After all, which problems don't get better when they're ignored?

All Might made that mistake in the past – assuming All for One was gone just because of a few years of radio silence. Katsuki isn't that foolish.

"Vigilante," "Prosthetic," "Moscow" or "Istanbul" or "Dublin" or "Reykjavik."

No hits.

Katsuki sighs. The gnawing disappointment is almost *surprising.* It's an unfamiliar feeling, snuffed out after years of flimsy leads going cold the second Katsuki set his sights on them, after the utter betrayal of his 'friends' and 'colleagues,' after every hero he was naïve enough to believe in let him down. But now, yeah. He's disappointed.

He wants Zero to be involved. He wants Zero to be the answer.

There's something *off* about the man, something dark and rotten, and all Katsuki wants is to stick his fingers in the corpse and squeeze, watch the entrails squirt through his fingers. He wants the darkness of the other to stick under his nails, to scrape it out with his teeth, to taste the secret vitriol ingrained in the man's body. He wants to dig and dig and dig, dig until he's dug a grave for himself or Zero or both. He doesn't know.

Its way past the point of curiosity, more dense than simple lust, a violent *need* presses on Katsuki's sternum, and he tries his best to ignore it.

Katsuki returns to the triple homicide report. The *modus operandi* matches Toga Himiko, down to the surgical precision, the sheer tenderness in the dissection of the two little girls. Like she carved them to look like little dolls, drained of blood and pale and *perfect.* The mother wasn't given the same treatment – a vision of garish beauty, splatters of blood bursting out of her, painting the floors, the ceilings, the walls in maroons and reds. Over a hundred distinct stab wounds. A crime of *passion,* they said. They're right.

All of Toga's crimes are passionate. That's what makes her so dangerous.

Katsuki stares at the crime scene photos, feeling nothing. And, suddenly, the most blatant thing in the universe hits him straight in the face as he processes the two eight year olds, laid out side by side. Identical size, shape, age. Clothes. Faces.

Twins.

Katsuki's breath hitches.

Twins? Has to be a coincidence. Has to be has to be has to be.

He darts back to New York, to those burnt corpses, mouth dry at the pictures of the victims. Arson. Four victims. *Who are they.*

The universe tilts on its axis as he sees the pictures. Two pairs of nearly identical people. Unrelated twins, who somehow ended up in the same apartment building, who somehow ended up victims in the same 'incident.'

Three pairs of twins. Killed by the League.

Katsuki jots down their names; he'll have a hell of a fucking time accessing quirk registries in two different countries, but it's not impossible. If the League is connected, then this is quirk related. Katsuki's mind drifts back to those Southern blots – the DNA comparisons.

Eighteen pairs – eighteen pairs of twins that were being evaluated for *something.* Katsuki's stomach drops. He shouldn't be making assumptions. Shouldn't immediately be linking the murders.

Because that would imply that the League is already back in Japan. Has been, for weeks, if not months. Hiding right under his nose.

Not possible, Katsuki shudders, tell-tale prickles of panic making his peripheral vision dim. He's taken *every* precaution. If the League was local, he would *know.* If they were doing something as conspicuous as setting up experimental stations, Katsuki would *know.*

It's still possible that they are managing these pop-ups labs remotely. There could be similar cases in other countries. If so, it hasn't made national news or gotten the attention of the World Hero Association, or he would have heard something.

He's spurred out of his thoughts by his cell phone vibrating next to him. Katsuki frowns, checking his watch. Who could be calling him at this – oh. *Nearly six am.* Despite the fact that he didn't go to bed, he feels energy pulsing under his skin.

He checks his caller ID and grabs his phone instantly, smashing it to his ear.

"You never call. What's happening?"

"A hello would be nice. A good morning. Your ability to collaborate and cooperate is *exactly* the reason you - " The gruff voice sounds a bit exacerbated and Katsuki rolls his eyes at the old man's lecture.

"You gonna lecture me about playing nice like I'm still in high school, or you gonna tell me what the fucking mission is?"

"…" Katsuki can hear murmuring on the other line that sounds quite suspiciously like *insolent fucking brat why did I –*

"Right. Well, there were two children kidnapped yesterday; we've been watching them closely as they are two of the individuals whose blood samples were identified in the Arakawa Lab. We were just able to locate their whereabouts. Considering your involvement in the case and the fact that The Lurkers are on a stakeout in Yamagata and are unavailable, I decided to contact you. If you're not working other jobs, of course - "

Katsuki feels the hairs on the back of his neck rise, excitement flaring in his gut. He doesn't even care that he was the second choice.

"No, I'm free. I'll be there." He assures, almost too quickly, urging Gang Orca to continue. "Do we know anything about the people behind this?" Katsuki taps the sensor on the inside hinge of his door, locks his study, quickly walking to his bedroom to deposit the key and grab his hero uniform. He throws Gang Orca on speaker as he starts to pull on his suit, clicking the bracers against his forearms.

"No idea. Tracked them to an abandoned warehouse outside Kanagawa. Doesn't appear to have guards. Unclear what's happening with the twins."

"…Their quirks?" Katsuki's heart rate picks up, feeling like he's about to stumble on something that will change everything. Orca scoffs over the phone, like he expected this question.

"Same quirk. Flashlight. Light can pour out of their eyes, mouth or other orifices."

Katsuki puts his mask on, brain mulling over the information, unsure whether Gang Orca is still speaking. There were multiple pairs of twins killed, many more sampled, one pair kidnapped – ones with the same quirk.

Now Katsuki doesn't know how often the same *quirk* occurs in twins, but considering quirks are random genetic mutations, it has to be rare. Can't be a coincidence.

“Send me the coordinates. I’m on my way.”

He climbs out his fire escape, his explosions lighting up the awakening sky, no louder than store-bought fireworks. His hands are just pouring nitroglycerin despite the morning chill – his heart is thrashing wildly in his ribcage and, for some damn reason, he just can’t stop smiling.

The small group of heroes gathered in the alley a few blocks from the presumed target signal to Katsuki while he’s still in the air, difficult to miss with Gang Orca’s giant body standing conspicuously in the middle of an industrial district. He tries not to be too obvious with how he positions himself in the group, landing as far away from Shoji as possible. Despite the fucker’s multitude of ears and eyes, Shoji generally minded his own business back at U.A. Even so, Katsuki is suddenly is too aware of the looseness of his uniform and how bloodshot his eyes look under his mask.

TentaCole simply nods his direction, and Katsuki chooses to not acknowledge him as Gang Orca steps towards the center of the small group.

“Now that our team’s complete – thank you for coming on such short notice, Dynamight – we’ll review the mission objectives.”

One of Gang Orca’s sidekicks steps up, tapping something on the side of her head; her goggles project a 3D version of a building that Katsuki can only assume is the target warehouse.

“Thank you, Carto. Through several hours of reconnaissance with the assistance of TentaCole, Carto was able to reconstruct this map of the warehouse where our targets are being held hostage.” Two glowing red dots appear as the woman taps the side of her head once more.

“The victims appear to be in the center of the warehouse. Per our intelligence, no evidence of enemies in the building itself and heat sensors don’t demonstrate any movement in the surrounding buildings. We have alerted all employees to evacuate the area during the raid. The position in the middle of the warehouse is optimal for our team’s visibility, although the same can be said for the enemy. There are numerous escape routes if the enemy decides to retrieve the targets and escape. Our best bet is to stage a hero in each alley leading out of the district. TentaCole, Carto, Krillex and Dolfinnick, you four will be stationed here, here, here and here.” Gang Orca points towards four alleyways surrounding the warehouse. “Myself, Dynamight and Man O’ War will make up the rescue team.“

Katsuki side-eyes the weird gelatinous creature in military fatigues. Katsuki can understand the strategy – the three of them have both offensive as well as immobilizing techniques at their disposal, ready to incapacitate any threat they might encounter. But when it comes to stealth, a giant man-orca and big-ass jellyfish aren’t exactly… low profile. Their enemies, whoever they might be, could probably see them approaching from miles away.

If the League captured these twins, if they are on the other side of this rescue, they might be in real trouble. Four years ago, Shigaraki nearly killed dozens of pro heroes, leveled cities, murdered thousands. Katsuki has no way of knowing how his power has grown or changed over the past four years. How *he’s* changed. He was enough of a threat as an unstable, petulant teenager throwing a temper tantrum. If he’s, god forbid, matured and started using that brain of his, they might actually be fucked. Just ants scurrying around their little colony, trying to fight a bored child with a magnifying glass, unaware how pointless and powerless their struggle is.

They might all be walking straight into their graves. Katsuki nibbles at his lip. He should probably tell them. Warn them. Give them the opportunity to save themselves, run just like those same cowards who gave up being a hero because they were being criticized instead of praised. Instead, Katsuki says

nothing, following Gang Orca and Man O' War towards the target, the four other sidekicks dispersing to their respective stations.

Katsuki and the other two circle the perimeter of the warehouse. Confident that there isn't any immediate threat around them, Katsuki flushes himself to the concrete wall, sticking to the shadows as he glances briefly through the grimy window.

The old industrial building is littered with rusted construction equipment, cargo boxes and cobwebs. In the very center, as promised, are two metallic chairs, positioned back to back. There sit two girls; from here, he can see that they have blindfolds and gags in their mouths, their hands tied behind them, feet tied to the chairs, thick leather binding their thighs together.

A quirk like Flashlight would surely be useful to alert people of their presence, if they were able to use it. The kidnappers aren't complete idiots, which is a point against the perpetrators being the League.

"The two are just sitting in the middle of the room. Bound and gagged. No one else appears to be in the building," Katsuki confirms. He hears the electrical hum of the gelatinous creature next to him, voice a warbling, wet sound that sets Katsuki's teeth on edge.

"Seems like a trap," Man o' War states, despite not having a mouth or eyes, his jelly vibrating with the statement.

"For their sake, I hope not," Orca responds, eyes fixed on Katsuki.

Katsuki isn't listening. If there's a risk that the League is involved, he needs to be the first in that building. If this is a trap, *he* needs to be the one that gets captured.

Suddenly, the fact that these *nobodies* stumbled onto a case that could lead them towards Tomura Shigaraki and, in turn, *Deku*, fills Katsuki with inexplicable rage. He clenches his fists, feeling the viscous sweat pool into his gloves, the excess flowing to the reserve tank in his gauntlets. They're in the way.

"What are your orders, Commander?" Man O' War warbles after a few minutes of silence. Gang Orca continues to gaze at Katsuki, appearing to be deep in thought, before he nods to himself.

"We need to get rid of their visibility. Dynamight… I'm leaving it to you." Gang Orca's voice is almost resigned, and Katsuki nods at him sharply.

Katsuki unhooks several grenades from his garter, handing them off to his temporary teammates.

"We create a distraction from three points of access. That way they won't know where we're coming from. I'll enter here – you two follow exactly two minutes apart. I'll draw whatever enemies there may be towards myself while Orca will enter through the front and Man O' War slides in through the windows to the west. Got it?"

If Man O' War had eyes, Katsuki would swear that he just saw Gang Orca and the giant jellyfish exchange a concerned glance. Despite that, neither argue, departing without word to their stations.

Katsuki takes a few deep lungful of air, massaging his hands, fingers trembling with something between fear and excitement. As if responding to the increase in blood flow, or Katsuki's perceived enemy, his shoulder and stomach start to ache – that insistent stinging reminding him of his previous

failure. He clenches his hands into fists, lifting his chin. He's not failing again. He's never going to be that helpless, useless, hopelessly *mortal* heap of blood and bones again. He'll win, or die trying.

He crouches, glancing through the window one last time, before sending a spark into the sky. They move fast – first it's the sound of glass breaking, ear splitting in the empty silence of the early morning – then it's the sound of explosions, grey smoke, coughing, obscured windows. Katsuki punches several more times through the panes, allowing enough space for him to jump inside, and hops over the glass certainly digging itself into his skin.

Katsuki looks around, pleasantly surprised by the potency of his smoke grenades. Despite the large size of the warehouse, the smoke is thick and heavy, obscuring everything that isn't a foot in front of him. Oddly enough, the scent of nitroglycerin is weak, but Katsuki doesn't have time to dwell on that – he crouches low, piquing his ears for any signs of movement.

High pitched scraping of metal against concrete and muffled screams. The girls. Somewhere behind him. Katsuki counts down internally, allowing for those 120 seconds, stomach sinking further and further as he hears their obvious distress. He's not a rescue hero, he reminds himself. He's here to draw out enemy fire. He's here to fight. Even though he knows, more than anyone, what it's like. The horror that they must be experiencing right now. He knows what it's like to be bound like a wild animal, to be at the mercy of some deranged fucker, to be so fucking *weak* – Katsuki nearly retches at the intrusive memory of that thick grey liquid pouring out his mouth, and with some sadistic relief is glad that the girls are gagged.

Its eerily quiet, outside of the movement of the victims. One hundred and ten. One hundred and eleven. One hundred and twelve -

From nowhere, a leg slashes through the smoke, aiming right at Katsuki's chest, but Katsuki's fast enough to block with his arms, blasting the other with a shot to the abdomen, the slightly startled explosion with more power behind it than Katsuki truly intended, exerting enough force to fling the body to the other end of the warehouse. Katsuki hears the metallic crashing echoing throughout the room, sound of tumbling, and then… silence again. Katsuki glances around, frantic, not entirely sure which direction he threw the enemy. How did they sneak up on him? Katsuki swivels his head, only the groaning of machinery settling to answer him. He tenses all his muscles, intuition telling him that this isn't over.

The next hit is just as fast, just as hard, landing directly against Katsuki's shins. Sharp pain ascends up his legs and he loses his footing, falling backwards – but he thrusts his arms behind himself, explosions lifting his body up and propelling him forward. He lands what must be several feet away from where he was, the force of his explosions dispelling some of the smoke around him.

He sees the next one coming. The figure is dressed in a skin-tight black body suit, blending into the background smoke seamlessly, limbs moving with a practiced elegance. Katsuki's almost distracted enough with odd admiration to make his move – but the fucker doesn't anticipate Katsuki's next move, and he grips the other by the shoulder, one hand pressing hard against their neck, making sure to compress the carotids before putting all his weight into his back and slamming the oversized body into the dusty ground.

The other coughs at the impact, but rolls out from Katsuki's grip with a kick to his boney hip, jumping to their feet. The other doesn't disappear into the smoke this time – in full view, they decide to attack, and Katsuki can't explain the smile tugging at his lips.

The person in the black body suit is unexpectedly fast, punches and kicks generating a weak air current, clearing the smoke around them, giving the illusion of fighting in some kind of rink. Katsuki

dodges a fist meant for his jaw, jumps over a swipe, leans just far enough to avoid the elbow to his ribcage, grinning to himself at his obvious superiority when he feels a knee connects with his stomach – on the *left,* exactly at the site of his previous injury like the fucker *knew,* and Katsuki doubles over, holding tightly onto the spot, vision blacking out at the sudden explosion of pain.

Katsuki grinds his teeth hard, seeing only red. His brain loses each coherent thought, adrenaline and rage spurring him forward, and he launches himself forward, straight towards the other like he's got a homing device, swinging his fist at the unexpecting enemy, knuckles meeting jaw, satisfy crack of bones under his hands. He doesn't know if he's knocked the other out – their body is limp momentarily after the hit, and most normal people would probably be unconscious at this point. But Katsuki's got no sympathy for this asshole, so he wraps one leg around their arm, pinning it between his calf and thigh, lifting their heavy torso and slamming it on the concrete, straight on their ribcage. He hears a strangled groan of pain, body stiffening under Katsuki's hands, and a part of him feels relieved that the other is still conscious.

"Dynamight?" Gang Orca's voice rings out somewhere in the building and adrenaline rushes out of Katsuki's body, reminding him of his situation. Katsuki swallows past the lump in his throat, controlling his voice best he can so none of the others can't hear the horrific pain pulsing in waves through his whole body.

"Engaged with unidentified party!"

"Need backup?"

"Nah, I can take this asshole! Find the hostages!"

The other squirms under his grip, and Katsuki *swears* that the room is filling with more smoke, despite there being no evidence of additional smoke grenades going off. Out of nowhere, something wraps around Katsuki's leg, pulling him off the other, thrusting him on the ground, his skull resounding against the concrete with a resolute *crack!* He jumps back up, head swiveling to identify the second enemy that pulled him off the one in the black bodysuit, nearly missing the way the other struggles to stand, hands gripping onto their ribs, knees clearly shaking at the effort of keeping themselves upright.

Katsuki races towards him once more, putting his whole body weight on the other as he wraps his hands round their throat, heels digging into the man's injured ribs as he keeps him in a chokehold, hoping that the pressure through on his carotids is enough to get the fucker to *pass out.* Katsuki directs a blast toward his face as the man moves his neck, disappointed to see the mask is flame retardant.

The large body collapses under him, wheezing but still awake somehow, and Katsuki grins, flipping the person over.

"Okay, jackass, which one of those League fuckers are – "Katsuki grips at the mask at the neck, ripping it off the other's face. Katsuki's voice falls, "You." He ends weakly.

A very annoyed man with black eyes and blonde hair, mouth filled with blood, bruising already blooming against his jaw, chest heaving, glares up at him. *Zero.* He turns his head, spitting the blood onto the ground, grimacing as Katsuki's knee presses harder against the spot where he's *confident* he broke the fucker's ribs.

Katsuki can't explain the sick elation he feels on top of Zero, body blooming with pain, the ache in his back and ass reminding him that this same jackass fucked him senseless just *hours* ago.

“What are you doing here?” Katsuki asks breathlessly, in awe at how damn *pretty* the other looks with a mouthful of blood.

“I should be asking *you* the same thing! *Why are you in Kanagawa?*” Zero arches his neck, bones cracking loudly as he grimaces, tongue darting out to lick at his busted lip. Katsuki watches the man’s tongue with fascination, utterly unfamiliar with the softness budding in his chest.

“You think you can fucking ask questions right now? *Hah?* What, you fucking *lied* to me when you said you weren’t with the League?” Katsuki thrusts his knees against the broken ribs again, enraptured by the widening of the other’s eyes, the hopeless twitching of his fingers, the way he seems to grind his teeth together as to not cry out in pain.

“I’m *not!* I didn’t lie! I was trying to lure them out! You fucking everything up!”

Katsuki leans back, difficulty hiding the shock in his face.

“…You did this? You kidnapped them? You bound and gagged two *little girls?*”

Zero carefully flattens his face, staying silent, and its answer enough. Katsuki’s one free hand digs into his belt, pulling out handcuffs, not missing the flaring of the other’s nostrils at the sight of them.

“I didn’t *hurt* them! He wasn’t going to hurt them *either.* He needs them – I’m not your *enemy!* You have to believe me!” His eyes are dark and desperate and Katsuki feels his grip on the other loosen. He lowers the handcuffs, opening his mouth to ask more questions when -

“Dynamight! Targets are secure – approaching your location!” The smoke is still thick, but Katsuki can make out the sound of rapid footsteps nearing his direction. He looks back down at Zero – eyes wide, pleading, desperation painting his face with a sincerity Katsuki hasn’t seen in who known how many years, and –

Shit.

“Goddamn it. Fuck.” Katsuki climbs off of him, offering him his hand. Zero looks incredulous before taking it, standing with a wince. His eyes don’t leave Zero’s.

“They escaped! Out the Northwest exit – go, go, GO!” Katsuki yells, tilting his head sharply towards one of the broken windows. The footsteps don’t stop, and Katsuki scoffs, hands creating small explosions, smoke becoming thicker and thicker around them, swirling around the two bodies, delicate and elegant like silk.

“…Why?” Zero whispers, eyes wide and disbelieving as Katsuki gives him a sharp look, the other man’s features disappearing in the smokescreen.

“Fucking *go,* Zero!” Katsuki bites out, turning away from him, throwing a grenade in the opposite direction, the sound of it exploding seeming to pause the footsteps approaching them for just a fraction of a second.

Something deep and turbulent glows within those dark eyes, but he nods sharply, putting his mask back on, dissolving soundlessly into the smoke.

Katsuki stands starkly still, letting his heart rate slow down before he moving towards the footsteps, painting his face into a careful look of anger and concern. It, surprisingly, doesn’t take that much effort.

The smoke starts to clear by the time he meets the other two, Man O' War's tentacles extended all around them, seemingly feeling out the landscape. Gang Orca's disturbing red eyes meet Katsuki's. "Well?"

"Lost them. Out the window. I – fuck, we should search the periphery. Maybe they've hidden somewhere. It would be difficult to disappear without being seen with this many heroes on the premises." Katsuki says it more to himself than the others, something akin to concern surfacing to the front of his mind. He's being insane. Why should he fucking care if Zero gets captured? He's a criminal. He captured children. He –

You let him go. What kind of hero are you?

The group carefully searches each corner of the warehouse, no trace of anyone else ever being there to be found.

"Looks like whoever it was got away," Krillex states, the remaining sidekicks congregating with hung heads, disappointment palpable in the air. They made the rescue but didn't catch the villain, and Katsuki's sure people feel that it's a *loss* on their end. He's familiar with that feeling – and guilt gnaws at him. He doesn't meet anyone's eyes as the disappointed chatter continues.

"Any identifying characteristics? You were engaged with them directly, correct, Dynamight?" Gang Orca asks, and all eyes are expectedly on Katsuki.

"Didn't get a good look at them," Katsuki lies, not able to meet Gang Orca's eyes. "Wearing some kind of black camo suit."

"…That's unfortunate." Orca sighs, and claps him on the shoulder. "Well, the girls are safe. That's the most important part. Good work, Dynamight."

"Yeah…" Katsuki trails off.

Katsuki doesn't notice TentaCole's eyes fixed on him, keeping his berth as the team walks slowly back towards the wrong end of the building.

The place has become utter commotion in the few minutes that it took to rescued the girls – flashing lights of reds and blues, multiple ambulances, the police milling around like they have nothing else to do. There's aspects of this that are unavoidable – the statement, the official report, the inevitable press. His stomach churns.

Did he make the right choice? Of course he did. Its too late to doubt himself now. He's looking at the bigger picture. He protected Zero because he knows something about the League, about the twins, things that Katsuki can use. That's the *only* reason.

Unknowingly, Katsuki wandered over to the ambulance, some component of his training on autopilot, compelled to check on the victims despite the pure shitshow that his brain is in this moment. How is he supposed to look them in the eyes when he let their captor get away? When he protected him over them? What kind of hero –

"Okay, let's take you two to the hospital…" the EMT directs, and Katsuki's head pops out of his gnawing thoughts. The two twin girls sit on the edge of the red truck, wrapped in shock blankets, looking anything but shocked. They look utterly unharmed, not a single scratch or bruise. It takes just a second for them to notice him staring at them, and the two girls exchange a quick look, both blushing lightly and giggling at each other.

“I’ll ride with them. To make sure they’re protected.” Katsuki tells the EMT in a split second decision.

The EMT looks him up and down, face falling. “…Dynamight, sir, you… you’re clearly in need to medical attention.”

Is he? Katsuki surveys his own body. The only hit Zero got on him was the knee to his stomach, which is hidden under his uniform. He frowns as he remembers crawling over the freshly broken glass, the hits against his legs, the bruising of his own knuckles as they met bone.

“…Then I’ll fucking get medical attention at the hospital. That’s where it is, isn’t it?” Katsuki sneers back, crossing his arms, the movement unexpectedly painful.

The ENT furrows his eyebrows before his shoulders sag and he shakes his head.

“Whatever. Get in the back, *sir*.” The older man’s voice is laced with sarcasm, and Katsuki rolls his eyes as he clambers into the back of the truck, the twin girls following suit. They sit opposite of each other, Katsuki sitting with his spine straight to relieve the pressure on his stomach as the EMT slams the doors of the truck closed.

The truck is moving when Katsuki finally speaks.

“You two okay?”

“Yes, of course, Dynamight, sir.” One of the girls answers, while the other nods ardently.

“Are *you*?” the one that’s been nodding asks, and their faces furrow in concern for him. Katsuki frowns. Seriously, does he look that shitty? Why are kidnapping victims asking him if *he’s* okay? He wants to snap at them, but breathes in deeply, trying to control his annoyance.

“I’m fine. What are your names?”

The two girls exchange glances, nearly bouncing up and down at the question. Katsuki suppresses the urge to smile, their excitement reminding him of shitty annoying middle school Deku. That kid would have shat himself with joy if a pro hero asked his name.

“I’m Shiryoku Hikari!”

“And I’m Shiryoku Senko!”

“We’re huge fans, Mr. Dynamight!” The girls say simultaneously, in perfect tandem, and it would be kinda creepy if it wasn’t just a little bit cute.

“Can you tell me what happened?” Katsuki leans in, voice hushed so the shitty EMT doesn’t eavesdrop on their conversation, eyes scanning the two girls. They are nearly identical in every way, black bobs and dark eyes and pink lips. They can’t be much older than fifteen, looking a hell of a lot like Jirou did their first year of high school. Guilt flares out of fuckin’ nowhere. He clears his throat, hoping the emotion didn’t show on his face.

The girls don’t seem to mind, both smiling.

“Well, last thing we remember, we were going to sleep, and then the next day, we were in the warehouse!”

“We sat for a long time, and couldn’t move our arms or legs or talk or see… It was really scary.”

“The man that did it fed us, and took us to the bathroom, but otherwise we were alone. He didn’t talk. But he didn’t hurt us.”

“But at least we could still talk to each other through our quirk, so we knew we were okay! And then you heroes showed up! Thank you for rescuing us!” Both girls bow, grinning widely.

Katsuki stills. “What do you mean? I thought your Quirk was Flashlight.”

“Oh, we mean, inside our heads! There’s this… this space, kind of like a dream, that we can go into, even when we’re awake! It’s hard to describe, but it’s some kind of a different *world,* where our quirk lives."

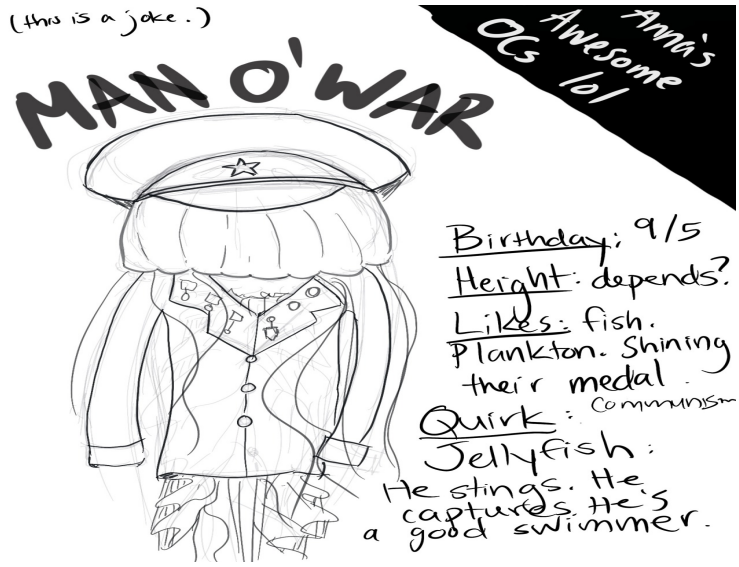
A different world.

And it’s like he’s thrown back in time, to that shitty couch in All Might’s office. To the discovery of that cursed Quirk the old man bestowed to Deku. To the reports of a dark world that Deku could sometimes access in his dreams, or states of lowered consciousness, somewhere between his psyche and his subconscious. A place where he could communicate with the vestiges - other users of One for All.

“You said *your quirk.* Singular.” Katsuki repeats, and the two girls smile again, nodding their heads.

“Yeah!” The girls sit closer, clasping hands. “It’s just one quirk! We share it!”

Chapter End Notes



Me, inventing OC's: Genius. Stupendous. Horikoshi tell me how this ass taste.

Chapter 6

Chapter Notes

I'm sorry I've been gone - but look, I made you some content!
Daddy made you your favorite, open wide -

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Sharing a quirk.

It should be impossible. Quirks don't work like that – they can't be *shared*. You either have one or you don't. It either is or isn't.

Except that… Katsuki's learned in his short life that there's no such thing as absolutes. Reality has knocked him on his ass enough times that he simply can't just discard something that doesn't fit with his worldview. Its not an option. Experience is a bitch, but it's the best teacher, and Katsuki's nothing if not an assiduous student.

Why *shouldn't* a quirk be shared? Especially between individuals that share a genetic code? It can't be more fantastic than quirks existing in the first place.

Katsuki's eyes scan the computer screen, darting between each article opened in front of him. In front of him sits the sum-total of published evidence behind quirk theory in twins – just a few dirtied, scanned in articles dated nearly fifty years, hidden behind paywalls or deep in university digital libraries, nearly impossible to find. It's like all interest died off soon after quirks started becoming more commonplace.

Case reports of one twin being born with a quirk, one without. Case reports of both twins having different quirks. Case reports of twins having seemingly the same quirk. The last article, from University of Tokyo, is the only one that mentions a theory similar to the Shiryoku twin's assertion – that maybe, the same quirk isn't district in each individual, but belongs to them both.

Professor Isao Sugai. Katsuki puts the man's name into the search engine, eyebrows furrowing at the first result. An obituary. Katsuki clicks on it tentatively, a newspaper article lamenting about the 'untimely passing' of the controversial professor.

Maybe people just lost interest in this twin theory. Or, maybe, just maybe, someone tried to bury this secret long before it made its way to the surface.

Katsuki stands from his computer, walking to the mostly bare wall opposite of his obsessive monstrosity. The printed article from Professor Sugai, the three pairs of murdered twins, the Shiryoku girl's school pictures – the five pieces of paper circle the singular window in the room like some kind of blood-stained halo. The bodies are stacking up – the thought of those twin girls covered in blood, entrails spilling onto the ground flashes through Katsuki's brain – and he digs his nails into his own hand, hoping the pain distract him from the invasive visions.

He's drawn blood by the time his brain catches up. He wipes the droplets against his thigh, shaking his hand from sticking to his sweats. The throb clears his mind, and he refocuses on the evidence in

front of him.

What's so special about twins? Katsuki leans in, getting a better look at photo of one of the labs he busted – specifically, zeroing in on the notebook to the side of the microscope. Each sample simply written *'Mono'* or *'di.'*

The Southern blots were being used to identify specific DNA arrangements.

Katsuki remembers the eerie way the Shiryoku twins finished each other's sentences, their mirrored motions, their perfect symmetry, and the realization hits him all at once.

They were trying to distinguish between monozygotic and dizygotic twins.

Why? If the theory of evolution, of random genetic imprinting, holds true, quirk inheritance would be subject to the same mutations in dizygotic twins as it would in any pair of siblings. But in monozygotic twins… Well.

One egg, one sperm, one face. One *quirk.*

And this quirk… what, can ebb and flow between people like a wave of energy, belonging to neither body, but transitioning itself from container to container as the hosts see fit? That concept is, at best, science fiction. At worst, blasphemy.

Because it implies, unlike every schoolbook that Katsuki's ever read, that Quirks aren't simple genetic mutations inherent to the individual. That they're entities of their own.

Maybe One for All isn't an exception, like Katsuki always believed. Maybe One for All follows the same rules that other quirks do, and someone, somewhere along the way, realized it.

It's the lack of being unique – an answer within twins that share a quirk – that the League must be looking for. If One for All works the same way as these 'shared' quirks, then perhaps they're looking for a way to sever or alter the connection. To sever Deku from the predecessors, from the other quirks, from his borrowed power. Peel them one by one, layer by layer, until Deku's bound to nothing and no one, helpless and quirkless ~~just like he was always meant to be.~~

Katsuki's ears are deaf to the sound of his own footsteps against the wood, back and forth, back and forth, the mumbling under his own breath just white noise. If he was in their position – if he thought that One for All works the same way that the twin-connection quirks do – then he would experiment on the twins. That's the only possible next move. Mutilate them, hurt them, make them quirkless, make them take quirk-enhancing drugs, kill one, kill them both. Dissect them down until they're nothing but blood and sinew and shrapnel.

Katsuki stops suddenly, heart falling straight into his feet, cold realization digging its claws into his lungs, making each breath feel painful and jagged.

No. They're way past that. They know the answer. The answer was within those girls drained of their blood, the two pairs of twins in that apartment fire, other cases that Katsuki's certainly missed. The experimenting phase is over. If they were still looking, there would be more bodies. No, they *know.*

Zero said so himself. *'I didn't hurt them! He wasn't going to hurt them either. He needs them – I'm not your enemy!'*

Shigaraki needs them. Needs a pair of monozygotic twins – alive- for… something. Katsuki's train of thought hits a wall, familiar rage and blame bubbling up naturally.

That fucker. Zero knows something. Knows about the twins, about All for One, about Shigaraki, knows and is willing to hurt those children to get his answers. And Katsuki let him go. Katsuki let that two-faced arrogant bitch-ass vigilante *go*.

Katsuki can feel his own breathing still instantly as the sound of footsteps reverberates above his head. They appear suddenly, heavy and intentional, like a person was dropped straight out of the sky and onto Katsuki's roof.

No one has access to Katsuki's roof. He pays a good premium for that.

Katsuki's eyes flash to his cameras, and his mind goes blank. He doesn't think, doesn't grab his suit, doesn't do anything he'd smart enough to normally do – instead, Katsuki opens his window and climbs out to the fire escape in his T-shirt and sweats and bare feet, barely feeling the winter chill driving needles into his skin.

Katsuki hauls himself onto the roof, feeling his joints ache in protest at the cold.

Its him. Katsuki would recognize that silhouette anywhere, the misshapen right shoulder, the large, muscular body, that horrible bleached blonde hair. Rage eclipses any other emotion and Katsuki's nostrils flare as he crouches, palms itching with thick sheen of sweat, ignoring the slight twinge of *elation* he felt the second he saw the other.

Standing there, mask less, appearing ghost-like in the silvery cloak of moonlight, he's stunning, and Katsuki hates himself for thinking so.

"We need to talk," Zero says without turning towards Katsuki, voice even and deep, and Katsuki scoffs, flexing his hands, letting the tendons pop loudly as thin, steady smoke emanates from his fingertips.

"Yeah? What could you fucking have to say to *me?*"

"Katsuki. Stand down. I'm not here to fight – "

"Well, I sure fucking am!" Katsuki darts forward, Zero dodging his right hook. His mistake, because Katsuki grabs the other by his good shoulder, and the scent of burning fabric and singed skin permeating the pure winter air. Zero hisses, jerking his shoulder away, but he doesn't try to escape Katsuki's space – instead, he grabs Katsuki by the wrist, jerking him into his own body so they're chest to chest.

"That *hurt,* you jackass! " Zero's voice is dark, threatening, black eyes staring Katsuki down like he wants to, no, is *going to* hurt him and Katsuki flashes his canines, his trademark arrogant smirk poorly hiding the rapidity of his pulse or the sudden flash of pink on his cheeks.

"Let go." Katsuki spits, sharp pain shooting through his damaged shoulder as he pulls hard against Zero's grasp – but the other only holds him closer, fingertips grasping tight enough to bruise.

"No. Not until we talk." Zero responds, looking Katsuki straight in the eyes. Something about Zero's eyes is magnetic – they're wide and vulnerable, don't look like they belong to a liar and a traitor and a vigilante – and for some unknown reason, Katsuki feels the fight leach out of him. He sighs, wrapping his free hand around his own waist as he shakes the other hand out of Zero's grasp.

"You must have a fucking death wish." Katsuki mumbles under his breath. The chuckle that bursts out of the other is unexpected, and Katsuki tempers down the sudden burst of satisfaction as he sees the

other grimace, leaning away from his right side as his chest contracts into the aborted laugh.

“What’s so goddamn funny?”

“I sometimes wonder… If I do. I must.” Zero muses, eyes glued to the gentle glow of the waxing moon. Under this light, his cheekbones, hollow, look all the more pronounced, the cupid-bow of his lip full and downturned. He almost looks tragic with his head of wrongfully acquired golden hair, a picture of a fallen angel desperate to return to the heavens. The lilt in Zero’s voice sounds wistful, and Katsuki softens despite himself.

It’s this brief moment of what Katsuki can only call sympathy that causes him to take down his guard, to walk over to the edge of his roof and sit down, letting his bare feet dangle over the side of the building. Up here, weightless and free, Katsuki wonders about the fall – about the speed of his explosions, about his ability to cushion himself, and what would win out – the instinct to survive or his desperation to finally rest? And at which point will it stop being the former, and trend towards the latter?

It doesn’t take long for Zero to sit down next to him, leaving about a foot of space between their thighs.

“…How the fuck do you know where I live?” Katsuki bites, glaring at the dark sky in front of him.

“I’ve been watching you.” Zero answers in monotone, and Katsuki bristles with something that’s not annoyance or fear or flattery, but something else entirely.

“Why.”

“…I don’t know how to answer that in any way that won’t make you mad.”

“Answer it anyway,” Katsuki insists, glaring at the other, watching his face try to morph into any form that might give away what the stranger is thinking.

“…You’re a threat.” Zero shrugs, metal arm grinding against the concrete with the movement, making Katsuki’s teeth ache. Its somehow both the wrong and right answer, and Katsuki waits for the other to continue, but he doesn’t. The wind whistles past them, and Katsuki shudders, all too aware of the deep winter night and his own threadbare outfit.

“Because I remember you?”

Zero’s body goes starkly still.

If Zero thought Katsuki was an idiot, he fucked with the wrong pro-hero. Katsuki’s not the kind of man that ignores things that are right in front of him.

And the fact is this. Katsuki remembers Zero. Everyone else seems to – not.

Sure, Katsuki’s been hallucinating here and there, and sure, Katsuki’s been so desperate for a lead that maybe, in some context, in some universe, *maybe,* some version of himself would have made up a magical pretty-boy vigilante to save him from this endless, hopeless monotony. But a made up lead doesn’t kidnap children, or bruise Katsuki’s abdomen, or fuck Katsuki’s ass until he can’t stand.

…Right?

“Yeah.” Zero states simply, like he’s utterly unaware of the turmoil within Katsuki’s head.

Zero's real, isn't he? He can't touch someone who isn't real. Can't feel their heat if they aren't – Katsuki scoots closer. The heat comes in waves from the other, radiating through his thin t-shirt, soothing his prickling skin.

He's real. He has to be real. He *has* to be.

"Why. Why can't others remember you?" Katsuki asks breathlessly. Not so convinced that his brain hasn't played its final and most impressive trick. It would be a whole new rock bottom, but Katsuki's always surprised how deep his personal hell can go.

"… A quirk."

Katsuki pauses. "…*Your* quirk?"

The wind rushes past them once more, and Katsuki finds himself drawn closer to the other, a moth to the glow of an electric lamp. Katsuki can almost feel the static, the faint zapping of electricity, the inevitability of his own end in the humidity that Zero gives off, but he can't stop himself. The heat is real. He's real. This is real. This isn't a dream. This isn't a figment of his imagination. Katsuki peers over the edge of his building to the ground below. Not a dream. Don't jump. Don't jump don't jump *jump jump jump wake up! Wake up! Wake up!*

Katsuki's trembling, the back of his eyes aching, hands digging into the ledge, afraid that some traitorous muscle will twitch just right and end his miserable existence right here and now.

"Why doesn't it work on me?"

" It… it does work on you." Katsuki furrows his brows, glancing up at the other. Zero's face is contorted into something ugly, disgust blatant on his weirdly cherubic face. "The way it affects people is… dependent on a certain variable."

The sidewalk below him looks warm. Inviting. So much better than this cold. So much better than being alone. So much better.

"And what variable is that?"

Zero turns harshly towards Katsuki, eyebrows raised in some kind of childish surprise.

"Why would I tell you that? You ever consider that its *important* that people don't remember me? That I stay invisible?" Zero doesn't sound so sure, and Katsuki shrugs his shoulders.

"You're doing a shitty fucking job. I remember you."

"Yeah. Yeah you do." Zero agrees, and Katsuki nearly misses the pinkening of the other's cheeks. Zero clears his throat, fingertips twitching against the ledge. Its moments like these – the few seconds of quiet, the not-so-subtle twitch of the eyebrow, the incessant tapping of his fingers, the unintentional stumbling of his words, the trembling as he touched Katsuki - that gives away more about who Zero truly is than Katsuki thinks the other is willing to share.

He's too obvious with it – a persona of aloofness, apathy, detachment thrown hastily over some *person,* a man who acts as if he's been a poltergeist until Katsuki first saw him.

Like he's forgotten how to act human, because he's been invisible for so long.

“What would have happened? If I turned you in at that warehouse?” Katsuki asks himself more than the other.

Zero shrugs, looking somewhere past the buildings, voice sounded defeated. “They would have forgotten me. I would have gotten away.”

“But I remember you.” Katsuki doesn’t know why he keeps saying it. Maybe the way it makes the other flinch. Or that, for some reason, it makes the heat radiating off the other brighter, hotter, like he’s Katsuki’s own personal sun. Maybe because Katsuki needs him to know that his weakness is sitting right next to him – that he’s got the upper hand.

Zero’s lip twitches. “Yeah.”

“I can stop you.”

“You can interfere,” Zero corrects. “I’m asking you not to.”

“If you tell me *what* I can’t interfere with, I might just fucking consider it.”

Zero’s eyebrows shoot to the top of the head. “You – you what? You’d work… with me? A vigilante?”

Katsuki shudders, feeling like the spotlight is shining straight on him, like the Hero Commission can hear his every words on this rooftop, but he says them anyway.

“Listen, fucker. I’m not some delusional, bright-eyed kid who doesn’t understand how the world works. If you’re after the League, it doesn’t fucking matter who I have to hurt, or maim, or fuck to get to him.”

Zero’s eyes widen further in surprise. “Katsuki.”

“… But I draw the line at hurting kids. If I catch you laying a single finger on those twins again, I’ll kill you.”

The gentle smile that flashes across Zero’s face makes Katsuki sick.

“I won’t. I promise.”

Katsuki swallows against the lump in his throat. “… So – are you?”

“Am I – “

“After the League.”

Zero sighs, almost like he’s annoyed. “I am.”

Katsuki suppresses the urge to laugh, to jump with joy, to let off an explosion despite the fact that his hands are dripping with sweat. Holy shit. Holy *shit,* he was right!!!

“You’re suicidal.” Katsuki chuckes, and Zero nods.

‘I’m telling you the truth.”

“Fuck. I know. Shit.” Katsuki laughs, delirious, unsure when his fingers started to grace Zeroes’ on the ledge. Maybe he’s grateful, or elated, or going crazy, but he wants to hug this bastard. He truly

does. “He’s in Japan. Fuck.” And Katsuki doesn’t know who he’s talking about, whether its Deku or Shigaraki, but if one is here then the other is sure to follow.

“I – I don’t know if he is. In Japan. But what he’s looking for is here. He’ll come eventually.”

“And what is that?”

Zero seems to bite his tongue. “I can’t tell you that. That’s part of not interfering.”

“Whatever. All I need to know is that he’s coming. I’ll be ready.” Katsuki grins to himself, clenching his fist. Like a child grasping a butterfly, Katsuki isn’t quite sure if he’s trying to destroy something or protect something precious – either way, the motion is the same. A wisp of energy runs through Katsuki – Zero has given him everything. Some semblance of hope. A light at the end of this endlessly monotonous tunnel. Katsuki doesn’t even know what he’ll do when he gets there. What his life will be like. If he’ll even have a life to go back to.

He’s sabotaging everything. Working with Zero will surely cost him his hero license. Pursuing Shigaraki might just get him arrested. Maybe even killed. Everything might be over for him before he sees Deku again. Everything might be over for him, period.

But for now, this blinding light that Zero emits is the only thing he wants to move towards. Fuck everything else.

Katsuki’s pinky caresses at the warmth of the other’s hand, the nauseating feeling of gratitude flooding his abdomen until he’s pink cheeked, desperate to talk but incapable of producing the words. Are there words that can truly portray how much Katsuki feels? How can he express that the stupid fucker next to him has just given him a reason to keep living?

When he looks at Zero again, the feeling in his chest is foreign and overwhelming. His face looks pensive, pale skin almost glowing under the moonlight, lips fixed in a straight line. The bruises flowering over his jaw look enchanting, reds and purples swirling on a flawless jaw, swollen lip jutting out in a painful pout. He’s distant, gaze drawn away from Katsuki, and Katsuki desperately wants it on *him*.

Katsuki’s eyes stay fixed on the other. His jaw doesn’t so much as tremble.

“You’re the only one that remembers me like this. If – if this fails. If he wins, and I can’t stop it, and if I can’t do it myself, I need you to kill me.”

A chill that has nothing to do with the weather shoots down Katsuki’s spine.

“Why.”

“Can you?” Zero’s hand is skirting up his thigh, his fingertips causing tingles of pleasure to shoot into Katsuki’s abdomen despite the numbness throughout his extremities.

“…Yes. Yes, I can. I can kill you.” Katsuki’s eyes glisten in the moonlight, and he feels his own hands, numb as they are, traveling up the other’s thigh in return. Small, gentle movements, and Katsuki almost feels an indescribable mirth as the other shudders, eyelashes fluttering as he exhales.

“You need to tell me why. I can do it, but tell me why. I don’t kill people for no fucking reason.” Katsuki’s hand brushes against something hard in the other’s groin, heart doing unspeakable things at the gentle whimper that leaves the other man’s lips.

“Shigaraki. He – he needs me. To use his power. He – if I’m gone he can’t. He can’t use it.”

Katsuki’s eyes flash, grabbing Zero’s thigh hard. The other’s dark eyes glance at him, glazed and blown.

“Why shouldn’t I kill you now?”

Just throw him off this building. End this. End all of this.

“You should.” Zero whispers, and the air leaving his lips is intoxicating. So much so that Katsuki leans forward, examining them, bloody and cracked and ugly and everything Katsuki ever wanted.

He doesn’t know which one of them closes the distance, doesn’t know and doesn’t care as their mouths meet in an explosion of fire, gentle meeting of the lips turning heated without any preamble. Katsuki licks against the other’s mouth, biting into the same lip he spilt, fingers digging exactly where he knows he broke the other’s ribs, drinking each pained gasp and throaty whimper.

Feeling starts to come back into his body as the other’s hands roam his body, the metallic one still on his thigh but the left pulling him closer by the nape of the neck until each meeting of their mouths is bruising, gripping his left shoulder, digging into the scar.

Its hurts, and its horrible, and its beautiful, and Katsuki’s tingling all over, aroused and angry and nearly overwhelmed by sheer degree of emotion, feeling too much and too foreign in his damaged body.

When they part, foreheads meeting, Katsuki’s heady and delirious and high off the thought of *close, close, close, this might finally be ending, I’ll kill them or I’ll die, but its almost over* – his thumb finds the split lip, reveling in slide of tongue against the tip of the grimy finger, Zero just as lost in it as he is. He digs his fingernail into the tear in the other man’s skin, watching with a morbid fascination as a drop of blood pools there, around his digit, and as the others tongue desperately laps at the iron droplet and the same digit that caused it.

“Fuck. When was the last time someone touched you?” Katsuki wonders out loud. He’d be lying if he said the desperation emanating off the larger man, how his lips try desperately to stay on his own, how hard he is under Katsuki’s hand with minimal touch doesn’t turn him on, but *fuck.*

“Should ask you the same thing,” Zero whispers out, mouth downturned into what looks like a poorly hidden frown. Katsuki tries to hide his smile – there he goes again, acting jealous, and Katsuki wishes that it didn’t make him happy, but it does.

“Come inside. Let’s fuck.” Katsuki doesn’t ask, he demands, and the glazed look in Zero’s eyes is enough of an answer.

It might have been a mistake, and Zero might have hated it, and he might have been too disgusted by Katsuki to look at him, but he wanted it, he liked it, and there’s no misreading the desperate grip of the other’s fingertips, his hot breaths, his wandering lips. Zero wants it as much as he does. Maybe because Katsuki is the only one that remembers him. Maybe because he’s a criminal, and can’t trust anyone, except the one dirty hero who set him free.

Maybe because touching anyone makes him feel less like a specter, more real, more tangible.

The fact that Katsuki’s the only one that can remember him is sad. Tragic, even. He would never wish that on anybody.

“Yeah,” Zero finally responds, and Katsuki leads him through the fire escape into his window, silently padding over to his bedroom.

“Strip.” Katsuki orders, and Zero does. In the darkness of his bedroom, the skintight vigilante universe peals off, corded tense muscles, bruised abdomen, scars and blood all Katsuki’s for the taking. He struggles with his shirt, the ache in his ribs clearly a problem, and Katsuki nudges the other back onto the bed, looming over him as he removes the garment.

“You broke my ribs,” Zero states, as if Katsuki didn’t already know.

“Consider this an apology,” Katsuki says. He gets on his knees, removing the man’s boxers almost tenderly, keeping his gaze fixed on the half-hard cock sitting heavy between the other’s legs.

“Lay back,” Katsuki demands, and Zero follows, no questions asked.

Leaning back against his headboard, stark naked, dark skin glowing in the moonlight, Katsuki feels his heart skip a beat, warmth pooling in his stomach. This doesn’t feel transactional – it feels like something *more,* and maybe he should stop this, because his eyes can’t stop raking the other’s body, wanting to drink it in, remember it, watch that face moan with pleasure, shake under him, *cry.*

With the desperation of a wild man, Katsuki realizes, he wants to make this giant, scarred, fucked up man beg. For *him.*

He strips slowly. Puts on a show. Zero never takes his eyes off of him, the same heat coming from his gaze that it did that first day in the coffee shop, drinking him in, memorizing. Likely exploiting his weaknesses for when he’ll have to hurt Katsuki next. His stomach and his shoulder were both targets in this last fight. He fights dirty, and Katsuki *likes* it.

Katsuki approaches the bed, hand sliding up and down the head of his pink cock, thumbing at the pre before shoving that same thumb into the other’s mouth. Zero laps it up like a dog, sucking the sticky liquid from his hands like he’s desperate for it. Katsuki feels himself nearly moan as the other’s tongue extends past his thumb, licking at the palm of his hand. With some horror, Katsuki realizes he’s licking his *sweat,* the nitroglycerin – can’t seem to get enough. He wants to pull back, tell the man that his hands are dangerous, he shouldn’t *touch* – but maybe, maybe, thinking back to that request on the rooftop, the reason he *wants* them is because they’re dangerous.

The reason he *wants* this is because he knows that Katsuki can kill him. Will kill him. He doesn’t know why that turns him on so much.

Not thinking, Katsuki shoves more of his fingers in the other’s mouth, tantalized by the thick saliva, the way his tongue works in between his digits, the way he sucks each bead of sweat desperately from his fingertips, the way he doesn’t stop looking into Katsuki’s eyes, something like a challenge behind those dark irises.

He pulls his fingers out, dripping with the other’s saliva. Katsuki’s tempted to put them in his own mouth, make the other watch as he drinks his spit, but he’s got better things to do with it. He crawls over Zero, flanking him between his thighs, ass up in the air. He spreads his fingers, the string of saliva connecting his wet digits, a droplet landing on Zero’s taught abdomen, before those fingers disappear behind Katsuki and into his ass. The saliva makes it a little easier, but its still dry, painful, and he’s still swollen from the night before, and his knuckles still ache from the bruises of punching the man he’s about to fuck in the jaw, and Katsuki revels in it, mouth opening in a silent moan, penetrating to the first knuckle, fucking into himself briefly before forcefully shoving in the second, not taking his eyes off Zero, and Zero not taking his eyes off him.

“You going to fucking throw up if we do this face to face?”

Zero laughs, but doesn’t sound like he finds it funny. “No.” He seems to hesitate, something flashing across his face, something nearing *honesty,* before he steels his expression again. “But I’m going to close my eyes. Can’t look at you.”

This shit again? Katsuki’s somewhere between rage and embarrassment, but even so, the insult makes his own cock harder. He doesn’t know what the fuck is wrong with him, which wires were crossed that make him want Zero *more* the more he pushes him away.

“I can make you open them,” Katsuki taunts, and a flash of competitiveness passes through Zero’s face.

“You can try.”

Katsuki grins, pointed teeth feral as he grabs the lube from his bedside table, tired of the theatrics, pouring a generous amount on his own hand. He rolls the condom on Zero’s hard cock expertly, working his shaft for just a few seconds with his lubed up hand for good measure, preening at the cock twitches, fully erect, in his grasp.

“When are you going to close your eyes?” Katsuki teases, moaning more as he scissors two fingers into his hole, impatient to have the other’s heat inside of him.

He watches the other swallow thickly, breathing picking up.

“Soon,” Zero’s voice sounds raspy, wrecked, and Katsuki would laugh if it didn’t make him want to cum.

It’s a challenge if Katsuki’s ever heard one. He grabs Zero’s dick, holding it still as he holds his own dick and balls taught, slowly, ever so slowly impaling himself on that monster cock. Katsuki moans, loud, wanton as the head of his cock makes it all the way past the tight rim of muscle, the fullness and pressure sending waves of pain through his abdomen. But Katsuki watches the other slowly close his eyes, metallic arm covering his face, as if an additional curtain to shield himself from what Katsuki’s doing.

That won’t do. Katsuki slowly, slowly sits down on the other man’s cock. When their pelvises are flushed, he gives a self-satisfied chuckle, hand traveling up the other navel, tweaking a nipple in his quest to grab the other’s chin.

“Look at me,” Katsuki orders, jerking the chin forward. The man shakes his head, slightly, almost imperceptibly, and Katsuki must be imagining the tiny wobble of his lip at the request.

“You don’t want that.” He sounds like he wants to cry. Katsuki flexes his thighs, cock sliding deliciously out, before he rams himself back down.

“*Fuck* – don’t tell me what I want.” But Zero refuses, keeping his left arm limp next to him, prosthetic covering his eyes, the mild puckering of his lips beautiful, the whimpers escaping him music to Katsuki’s ears. The slap of skin on skin, the whispers of pain and pleasure escaping Zero and himself, the humidity picking up in the room – the same thunderstorm forming over the ceiling that was in the love hotel – makes Katsuki’s hair stand on end.

Katsuki focuses on the sensation, not daring to touch his own cock as he grinds up and down on the other, over and over and over again until his legs are numb, and he leans forward, overcome with

something, lips searching under the man's metallic arm to find lips.

The kissing is breathless, desperate, and with Katsuki's mouth on him, Zero's whimpers and moans are all the more obvious, body trembling like a fucking *first timer,* chest shaking at the exertion of each breath, and Katsuki grins against his mouth, biting into the lip, knowing each shuddering breath is painful.

"You said it would be kinder to kill you," Katsuki whispers against his lips, smiling at the statement.

"You said you would," Zero murmurs back, eyes opening. As soon as their eyes meet, Katsuki goes down *hard,* and the blush painting the man's face, how splotchy his cheeks are, how bitten his lip is, how watery his eyes are, only affirm the horrible fact that the other man is *fucking gorgeous.*

"You trust me?" Katsuki wants to laugh. Mistake #1.

"I know you don't make promises you don't intend to keep." And there he goes again. Pretending that he knows Katsuki. Acting for all the world like he can see inside Katsuki's heart, and he can tell that Zero can read the way his expression changes. But it doesn't matter, because it gets Zero's eyes on him, scanning his body as Katsuki continues to ride him, drinking in the attention like he's been stranded in the desert his whole life.

"You're thin," Zero states, eyes focused on Katsuki as he rides him, hands nearly wrapping around his waist. All the way around his waist. Holy *shit.*

"The – the injury," Katsuki pants, fucking himself silly, unsure what the hell is coming out of his mouth because he's too busy feeling *everything,* each of his nerves alight. He moves the man's hand onto his stomach, the same scar he kicked just a few hours prior, blooming with fresh bruises surrounding the puckered starburst tissue.

"Pierced my stomach. Hard to gain weight." Katsuki states, and something darkens in the other's expression, hips pistonning up to hit him deep, deep in his colon, and Katsuki doubles over with a moan, his own cock leaking down on Zero's stomach in response.

"Like All Might," Zero whispers, and fuck, that should be an erection killer, but it isn't. It makes Zero change – instead of a passive watcher, for some reason, that makes him more an active participant, pistoning his hips and groaning, fucking *loud* and *hot as hell*, eyelashes fluttering, sweat gathering on his forehead, cooling on his clavicles. It clearly hurts him, Katsuki can tell, each thrust painting his face with both moans on pain and grunts of pleasure, and its intoxicating.

With Zero participating, Katsuki feels himself near the edge quickly. Faces locked, eyes on eyes, both drowning in pleasure, Katsuki puts his hands on his cock, trying to stroke in time, feeling himself get closer as the other man watches him touch himself.

It doesn't take long – one second he's trembling, thigh muscles screaming as he impales himself one more time on Zero's cock, and the next he's shooting thick white cum across the other's stomach.

With the way he moans and shakes under him, he's sure that the other has finished too. Katsuki leans over, breathing hard, catching his bearings before he gets off, pealing the condom off the other man, tempted to lick the beads still stuck on his cock. He doesn't – instead, he disappears into his bathroom, grabbing a rag to wipe his own seed off the other's stomach. To his surprise, he hasn't left, still starkly naked in his bed. It's a beautiful sight, that man illuminated by moonlight, head back, eyes closed, breathing like he's run a marathon.

He could get used to this.

Katsuki swats that stupid thought away, walking forward, and swipes at the cum on his stomach, wiping down his dick before tossing it into he laundry basket. He climbs under the sheets, waiting for the other to follow suit. Zero doesn't, keeps his eyes closed, and Katsuki holds back from touching him, although his hands itch to be back on his skin.

"…I've hurt people." Zero's voice is pained, soft in the early morning atmosphere, and Katsuki feels his heart rate speed up. That should shock him, disgust him, make him feel *something.* But he doesn't. Other than something warm and tender, pooling in his stomach.

"Yeah. Well, sometimes you gotta hurt people."

This time, Zero looks at him, surprised.

"I… never thought I'd hear a pro hero say that."

They stay silent.

"…Have you?" Zero whispers, implication clear in his voice.

Katsuki scoffs, stomach tightening at the question. "Yeah. I killed someone. In high school. Hurt a lot of people since. I'm always hurting people. It's like a can't stop."

Zero's entire body seems to lock up, shocked eyes on him. "… You… you killed someone?"

Katsuki shrugs, nausea climbing up his stomach. He doesn't like to think about it. He doesn't need to explain himself to anybody. He didn't expect someone to die at his hands when he was sixteen. But that's what happened.

"He was… " Katsuki has no idea why he's saying this out loud. He's never so much as told his own parents, or Aizawa, any of this.

"He was with the League. It… was an accident, but if I didn't lose control like that, it wouldn't have happened." Katsuki swallows, tongue loose, "He – he told me… he told me he was *dead* and I just – I couldn't stop."

Katsuki puts his hand in front of his face, hating his fingers, the very sweat that pools in his palms.

"All I wanted to find him. That's all I wanted. But he was just… outside my reach. The one person I *had* to save, and I just… I couldn't."

Zero doesn't ask who *he* is. He doesn't say anything at all.

Katsuki doesn't know how long he's closed his eyes for. All he knows is that he's warm, and its quiet, and his curtails are waving in the wind. A part of him thinks, maybe, there was a ghost of a touch against his lips, but he can't be so sure that wasn't a dream.

Katsuki must be dreaming, because the voice he hears reminds him of home.

"I've – I've been alone for a really long time. And it didn't matter, not really. I had a goal. A purpose. A mission. It didn't matter if no one remembered me."

Katsuki pretends to be a sleep, evening out his breathing as Zero pets through his hair, rhythmic and affectionate in a way that flips Katsuki's stomach upside down.

"I was fine with being invisible. And then you – *you.* Made me *want* things again." The laughter that bubbles out of the taller blonde is almost bitter, heart-wrenching in its self-deprecation.

The sob that escapes him jars Katsuki to his very bone. "*I want to live,*" Zero whispers.

Katsuki stays starkly still as the weight on his bed disappears. As footsteps ring across his bedroom. As the window leading to the fire escape opens. A gust of wind, and then, suddenly, quiet.

Chapter End Notes



(those of you who are reading the manga.... IZUKU?!?!??!?:!!?!??!?!??!??!? !?!? !?!??!/ ! 1jljajdfklajsdklas flkasdjfkajdfa sdfaksdj fnice i have a reason to live like 3 more years until this is animated lmao)

Chapter 7

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Katsuki is woken up with a start as someone raps against his door. Adrenaline surges under his skin, fingers already twitching, palms coated with a thin sheen of sweat. He swivels his head, half-expecting someone – *him* – to still be in his bedroom. Katsuki instantly extinguishes the spark of disappointment when he discovers he's alone.

Katsuki stays absolutely still, piquing his ears for another knock. Shoulders drooping with relief at the resounding silence, he takes a moment to mentally check through his body. The normal aches and pains of every morning are *gone,* which he certainly can't explain. The only discomfort he feels are phantom memories of the night before. The flowering bruising on his abdomen, the throb of his ass, the swollen numbness of his bitten lips. He runs his fingertips against them, reveling in the tingle, swiping his tongue at the nitroglycerin he leaves in his wake.

The night before – rather, the other man's words – spread through Katsuki's mind like a thick, ominous fog. Zero's request to die at Katsuki's hand and the confession that he wants to live make Katsuki's chest constrict in a vice. Its unfamiliar. Its nagging. Its insistent. It's something he hasn't felt in years.

Protect him. Shield him. ***Save him***.

As it stands, the instinct to protect is still foreign to him. Katsuki simply wasn't born with it. Though he was always slotted to be a hero, the weepy ideals of trying to do it to 'save' others made no sense to him. That worldview was too narrow.

No one asks the goddamn sun to focus its' rays on a single withered sunflower; doesn't matter how much it might need the warmth. To save a single flower ignores the billions of others waiting for his light. It's as simple as that. The sun doesn't worry about how it's used – whether it burns or salves. Whether it destroys or builds. The sun simply blazes.

And that's what Katsuki does. He blazes.

Why should he waste his time, his energy, his *life* trying to protect one when there's millions of others? Katsuki understood the 'greater good' before his classmates could tie their shoes. If stands to reason – if saving one person is good, isn't defeating an evil that would hurt many *better?*

Katsuki certainly thought so.

One person put a divot in that ideology. Useless, quirkless, selfless Deku.

Just like with all other things, he saw it before everyone else. Before Deku himself did. He's not so sure the other's figured it out, even now.

If Katsuki was the sun, Izuku Midoriya was a swirling mass of dust and rocks that condensed, using Katsuki's gravity, his light to shape into something *more.* Something *purposeful.* Something *beautiful.*

There's stories about how the moon worships the sun. How it reflects the sun's light, basks in its' warmth, how it flies across the sky in tandem, a half of a whole. But the moon is infinitesimally tiny,

and the sun is overwhelmingly grand. They can only be normalized, equated to any degree in the zenith of the earth.

It's the Earth, in the end, that gives the sun purpose. That gives the moon purpose. That's responsible for the concept of *purpose*. Without creatures to perceive it, all the sun and moon would be would just be hot gas and a gray rock.

Does the sun ever feel jealous of the Earth, simply because it fosters life? Does it ever remind the earth that it can't exist without it; that in millions of years, when all is said is done, when the earth is scorched and barren, the sun will still be shining?

Katsuki reminded Deku. Frequently. He seared those lessons into his brittle skin.

Because Deku made Katsuki feel like he was broken.

If Deku could do it, could create, could nurture, could care, could *save,* why couldn't Katsuki? What was he lacking? What's *wrong* with him? Was he simply assembled wrong? Should he slap a defective sticker on his forehead and ship himself to the nearest manufacturer for reprogramming?

But Deku – he infected him somehow. Katsuki nearly didn't notice it. Didn't notice the poisonous spores gnawing at his stomach, didn't notice the vines twisting through his ribcage, didn't notice until it was too late, until Katsuki was flying through the air, eyes fixed on the boy he's known and despised and envied his whole life, with a singular goal. Singular desire.

Save him.

But he didn't. He didn't, and he's gone, and Katsuki's saved no one. He can barely save himself.

So that tremble in Zero's voice, those secret words, this pressure in Katsuki's chest, it all makes him want to do something foolish. Like risk his life just one more time for someone else.

He shakes his head at the stupid train of thought, rubbing sleep out of his eyes. A cursory look at his alarm alerts Katsuki to the flashing *10:00am* in bright, red numbers. Katsuki furrows his brows. Not taking his eyes off the contraption, he reaches to his cell-phone on the nightstand, ignoring the dozen messages to look at the time. The phone taunts back with a very clear 12:00pm. Noon.

Huh.

He wraps his bedsheet around his torso, standing up gingerly, mind on high alert. He puts his back to his bedroom door, peering into the empty living room, then kitchen. Cautiously putting his weight on the pads of his toes in an effort to be silent, he ambles forward. His microwave and stove both flash *10:00am. 10:00am. 10:00am.*

Not possible.

Katsuki nearly jumps out of his skin as the knocking, louder and more insistent this time, erupts against his door. That fist is harsh, not the tentative knock of his landlord or some delivery asshole that got lost on his way up. Flashes of cracked lips and curdled red eyes erupt before Katsuki, and he's about to dash to his bedroom to grab his gun when -

"Hey, Bakugou! Let us in, man! Did you forget you were gonna pick us up from the airport?"

Katsuki's blood goes cold and he stops in his tracks, jaw falling open. He stands frozen in place, half-naked in his living room, some lizard-brain part of him begging him to stay still, not to move, not to

make a sound. Maybe they won't know he's here. Maybe they'll leave.

Why is he even here? They're not supposed to be back in Japan until – until.

"…Maybe he's not home, Ei –" a woman's voice whines, and Katsuki prays to whatever deity is out there that he fucking *listens* to her, for once.

There's some mumbling behind the door and Katsuki stalks towards it, back against the wall, trying to quiet his own rapid breathing to hear whatever conversation is happening on the other side. It's all deep rumble and muffled words and Katsuki's heart somersaults with something foreign at the familiar cacophony of voices.

"…Yeah, I guess." Kirishima audibly sighs outside the door, and Katsuki doesn't feel guilty. He doesn't.

"C'mon, Ei! We're gonna be late!" the second woman's voice adds, and Katsuki rolls his eyes despite himself.

As soon as Katsuki hears their footsteps retreating, he exhales slowly. He doesn't know what compels him to unlock his door, if only to catch a peak at the retreating forms of his former friends. He can only to gaze on in horror as Camie Utsushimi's fake glamour of the three of them walking away dissolves down the hallway. He turns sharply, hands already clawed and popping with poorly suppressed explosions, accusatory eyes on the three of them pressed against his side wall, Utsushimi hysterically laughing into her own hand as she continues to stomp her feet up and down.

"You motherfuc-" Katsuki starts, before a blur of pink is tackling him through his own front door.

"BLASTYYYYY!" Mina Ashido screams into Katsuki's unsuspecting ears, nuzzling her cheek into his, as if they touch all the time, as if he's talked to her in months, as if things aren't different. As if *he* isn't different.

The other two waltz in after her without Katsuki's permission. Like this is just a normal morning for them, and not the first time Katsuki's seen any of them in person in nearly two years.

Katsuki doesn't know what the fuck to do with his hands or have any idea what to say, but his cheeks flare pink against his consent when Ashido peals back, scanning his semi-nude body up and down, face falling.

"Baku – " she starts, eyes landing indiscreetly to the deep-purple and vomit-green bruising on his abdomen, but Kirishima thankfully cuts her off before she has the opportunity to end that thought. Katsuki crosses his arms across his chest, not-so-discretely hiding his stomach, glaring up at Kirishima.

Or, at least the man that Kirishima's grown to be.

He's seen pictures of the guy over the past few years, and occasionally opened up the annoying-ass articles he would text to Katsuki regarding his 'accomplishments' in Vegas, but seeing him in person makes Katsuki feel…. He doesn't know. *Small,* he supposes, but not physically. He adjusts his bedsheet tighter against his hips.

He let his bright-red hair grow long, losing its characteristic spike, keeping it up in a high ponytail. His skin is finely tanned, muscles bursting out of a tank-top, which is certainly not the outfit of choice

in the middle of the winter in Tokyo, but he doesn't seem bothered, directing his sharp-toothed 1000-watt smile at Katsuki, just as joyous and unbothered as when Katsuki and him first met.

Despite the sparkle in his eyes, something behind them looks tentative, uncomfortable. *Hurt,* Katsuki's brain supplies, and the word tastes correct on his tongue despite its bitter flavor.

"I thought you were gonna meet us at the airport, man! And you weren't answering your phone, so we just – well." Kirishima grins, rubbing the back of his neck sheepishly, awkwardness rolling off him in waves.

"He was clearly preoccupied!" Ashido shouts from what definitely sounds like Katsuki's bedroom, and she pops out, eyebrows wiggling as she hold up the empty condom wrapper, flapping it like the most damning evidence in the world.

Katsuki's pretty sure his face has never been so red. "I – what the *fuck,* don't touch my shit – "

"Oh, dude, awesome! I didn't know you were seeing someone." Kirishima's smile doesn't reach his eyes.

"I'm *not* – " Katsuki insists, grabbing the wrapper out of Ashido's hand with a fiery glare. He takes the second of reprieve in his bedroom to throw on a T-shirt and boxers, not spending more than two seconds out of eyesight of his very unwelcome guests.

"Anyway, we just wanted to stop by on our way to U.A. to make sure everything was okay and remind you about tonight! Six sharp." Kirishima adds, pointing towards the door.

"Tonight?"

Kirishima's face falls, but he does a good job of putting it back into a carefree smile.

"We're doing the reunion thing. It's been planned for months. You really don't – " Kirishima cuts himself off, disappointment blatant in his tone. The tension seems to roll off the other, shoulders drooped, and Katsuki feels the gnawing guilt (re)surface in his stomach.

Its Kirishima's own fault, for still expecting something from Katsuki. You'd think the fucker would get the hint by now.

"…When was the last time you saw any of our friends?" the way Kirishima says it sounds almost sympathetic, and Katsuki wants to snap him in half.

"*Your* friends," Katsuki grunts. "You're one to fucking talk. I'm not the one who moved overseas the second shit got just a little too hard here," Katsuki spits with an unexpected vitriol, and that carefully crafted careless smile that Kirishima's been wearing clatters loudly to the floor.

It's silent as hell. Katsuki can feel the boring eyes of Ashido and Utsushimi on the back of his neck, but he doesn't back down, letting them stew in the discomfort. Eijirou Kirishima's mouth opens slightly, but he snaps it shut instantly, hands loosely forming weak fists.

That's what I fucking thought, Katsuki gloats, although it doesn't even remotely feel like a victory.

Its Camie, unfortunately, who breaks the silence.

"What's in here?" she asks, her hand twisting the knob, and Katsuki's on her so quickly he doesn't even remember consciously moving. Her tiny wrist looks fragile in his harsh grip, and he bends it

back at an acute angle, making the woman in front of him gasp in pain, trying in vain to pull away.

“What the *fuck* do you think you’re doing?” he hisses at her, baring his teeth, too aware of how far she was able to twist the doorknob. It shouldn’t have budged. The door is locked. Its *locked.* He locked it.

“Ow – let go Baku!” Utsushimi looks pathetic, trying to struggle out of his grasp. “That seriously *hurts!”*

“Bakugou. Let go of her.”

Kirishima’s voice is darker, authoritative, and Katsuki gets the distinct impression that his former friend isn’t afraid of hurting him. Not anymore, at least. Katsuki fights the animalistic impulse begging him to lunge, to punch the fucker in the face, to crack the bird-like bones so fragile under his burning fingertips, but then – but then. The logical part of him reminds him what’s behind that door.

To compromise his study, his information, four years of his work, is to compromise his very life. No one and nothing is worth that. Certainly not Utsushimi.

Katsuki weakens his grip and Utsushimi pulls out from his hold, cradling her bruised wrist softly to her chest. Ashido runs towards her, wrapping her hands around her shoulders, glaring in Katsuki’s direction as a sniffle escapes the long-haired blonde. Kirishima stands in front of the girls as if acting like a human wall, face just as hard and uncompromising as his quirk.

The three of them look at him like he’s a monster.

He’s not so sure they’re wrong.

“What is *wrong* with you?” Ashido asks him breathlessly, guiding the tearful Utsushimi towards his door, and Katsuki’s defenses drop. *I don’t know,* he wants to answer. *I don’t fucking know.*

“I - .” Kirishima runs a hand through his long hair, exhaling sharply, red eyes skewering Katsuki to his spot.

“Maybe you shouldn’t come tonight, man. It was… Glad you’re doing…” Kirishima can’t seem to find his words, unusually tongue tied, and Katsuki can virtually see the chasm between them, opening wider, wider, gnashing its teeth, the last bridge, the only thing left from his past life collapsing right in front of his eyes.

“…Okay.” Kirishima finishes, and leads the other two girls out of Katsuki’s apartment, the door slamming behind them.

And he stands there. Alone.

He blinks a few times, a part of him desperately grasping on to the idea that maybe, maybe that was all a shitty dream. A hallucination. Maybe it wasn’t real, and he’ll wake up, and that didn’t just happen.

But the crescent moons of his nails digging into his arm tell him the answer – all of this is reality, and he’s the harbinger of his own misery, and why didn’t he just fucking *die* that day when Shigaraki impaled him, why didn’t that Half-n-Half fucker just let him break his goddamn spine on that battlefield as he fell, why did that motherfucker curse him to this half-a-life?

Katsuki fights the burning in the back of his eyes, taking a few raged breaths to steel himself.

None of that matters. They don't matter.

What matters is – Katsuki places his hand on the doorknob, the ravine ready to swallow him alive, and twists.

The door creaks open. Katsuki stands there, dumbstruck, watching it.

He mechanically moves towards the door-jamb, eyes fixed on the accusatory red flashing at him. The pressure sensor signaling two openings of the door without a reset.

Katsuki might have forgotten to reset it. He might have just forgotten to lock the door. This could be all him, his mistake, his carelessness, his own stupidity. He might have just forgotten. He's been forgetting so much lately. He's been distracted. He's let the stranger distract him.

He searches his brain for the last time he was in this room, landing on right before Zero appeared on his rooftop the night before. He didn't lock up, didn't reset anything, because he went up to the rooftop, and then they… had sex…. And then Katsuki fell asleep. He fell asleep, and slept, for the third time this week, and he forgot.

Because of that asshole. Because of Zero. Resentment, that old familiar friend, floods in as Katsuki flares his nostrils, desperately trying to stave off the impending self-deprecation.

This is what happens. This is happens when Katsuki relies on anyone, trusts anyone, lets anyone in. You'd think he'd learn his lesson by now. You'd think he wouldn't be this fucking *stupid* anymore.

He sits down in his chair, throat parched, and rewinds the feed to his in-room surveillance camera, knowing exactly what he's going to see.

Zero. Zero walking in here. Zero knows something already – more than he's told Katsuki. And he uses it, uses it to find Deku, uses it to lure out Shigaraki (he's not above that. He's not above hurting people for his own benefit. Katsuki knew that, and let him into his bed anyway.) Green eyes on him, mouth fixed in a scream, All your fault, all your fault, all your fault -

Katsuki frantically laughs, forwarding the video, trying to dissipate that thought with anything else, but it plays out on repeat, so clear and potent that it might as well be a memory. Maybe it is.

The grainy feed plays on fast-forward. Katsuki observes himself over the computer, observes himself placing those new pieces of evidence around his window, watches himself hear the noise above, his own hurried exit, the empty room, and all is normal until it isn't.

Until the feed goes black.

Katsuki grinds his teeth so hard he hearts his jaw pop, fingers straining against his mouse, turning white at the tips. No. He rewinds and plays again. Just black.

Rewind, and again.

Black.

Nothing from 5am-7am. Two hour period of darkness.

He feels nostrils flare and his mouth open in an attempt to deliver air to his body, not enough oxygen making its way into his lungs as he heaves, muscles straining for some relief, but he can't fucking *breathe* and he wants to scream – to scream and destroy and punch and gouge his own eyes out.

His apartment lost power last night. For two fucking hours.

And he's willing to bet that it wasn't a fucking coincidence. Not with that fucking vigilante in his bed.

No. No no no. Katsuki stands up sharply, knocking his chair over in the process, fingers trembling as they rake his wall, chewed fingernails catching on frayed articles and old pictures, trusting touch to tell him if something is amiss more than his lying eyes.

Nothing seems to be missing. Everything is still there. Still the D3KU. Still the I a m h e r e (*but you aren't. you aren't here. Where are you. Where are you.)* Still the pictures, the notes, the scrap of his old uniforms, the photocopied journal entries, the pictures and pictures and pictures and pictures. School photos and aerial battle shots and too many others. Smiling eating ice-cream. Cheeks pinkened as he's jotting something in his notebook. Shy biting of his lip.

Not Katsuki's to see. But Katsuki's, none-the-less. Fucking Todoroki didn't need them. Uraraka didn't need them.

Katsuki did. Katsuki does.

Somewhere, deep in the recesses of Katsuki's burrowed sanity, he understands. He knows, in his heart of hearts, how absolutely batshit insane this wall – his collection - must look.

He's fine with Zero having seen his research regarding Shigaraki and the League. Hell, if he asked, Katsuki would happily show him everything he's found over the past four years. He'd happily hand it all over - no matter how ill-gotten, no matter how damning the information was - if it got him closer to ripping that fucker's tongue out of his throat.

But Zero didn't ask. He turned off Katsuki's power grid, and he went into this room, and he took more than Katsuki was ever willing to offer.

If Zero didn't know about Deku, about his connection to Shigaraki, he certainly does now.

Knows everything about him. His favorite color, his favorite snacks, the way he curls his letters when trying to write in English, the people he loves (*Not Katsuki. Never Katsuki,)* where his mother lives, the nature of his fucking power, every dug-up piece of information regarding the previous holders of One for All, their quirks, their strengths, their weaknesses. The way he smiles. He's seen *everything.*

He collapses in front of the wall, banging his head gently against the papers, fingertips grazing the information, digging at it, like something about the motion will help him scrape at Deku's skin, like he can sink his hands into something tangible, real, something that could *touch him back –*

It's all there. The amalgamation of who Izuku Midoriya was – *is, is, is*, - there, on his wall, like a prized carcass of some game animal. And if he could sew these things, these pieces of Izuku Midoriya, his thoughts, his words, his passions, all into some kind of scarecrow, into a straw body with button eyes and seaweed hair and an empty cross-stitched smile, he just might. He just might, so he can touch it, so he can beat it, so he can punch through its chest and grasp at its heart and tell it *this is what you made of me! This is what you did!*

If Katsuki could craft Izuku's heart of straw, could he have it? Could he fall asleep with it under his pillow, hear it beating against his ear, let it exist as he exists, hollow and pointless but *there?* If it was made of blood and muscle, could he chew through it? Could he gnaw through the tendons, could he crack his bones and suck the marrow, could he kill him without killing himself?

And that's the funniest thing about it. About the notebooks filled with notes on Katsuki. About the hero worship, about the analyses, about the obsession.

Katsuki started the search trying to understand Deku, see into his mind, only to find out that he already knew. He already knew so much of it. All this time, as Deku was watching him, Katsuki was watching back.

The glass was a two-way, and neither one of them had known it. The glass was a two-way, and they spent their lifetimes watching each other, never listening, never talking. The glass was a two way and when Katsuki was finally, *finally* ready to punch through that fucking barrier, Deku disappeared.

It took him a week. A week to break into his dorm bedroom, a week to trash his belongings, a week to start sleeping in his bed, to wrap himself in *Deku,* another week to be found by Inko drowning in the other's sheets as she tried to clear it out, a week to act embarrassed even though none of his shit was Inko's to touch.

Everything that was Deku's was Katsuki's. Everything that is Katsuki's is Deku's. Always was and always will be.

That's what they never understood, that's what no one else can see, that's what his useless classmates and teachers lacked that Katsuki had. They gave up too early on him because they only knew him as superficial, sweet, smiling Deku – and didn't *know* him.

But any of them would search endlessly if they lost their limb, their heart, their mind. They'd look if they lost a part of themselves. And Katsuki did. The parts of himself that he hated are still him. The rot is still a part of the floorboards. The mold is still a part of the ceiling. This house is falling apart, filled with holes *(and the termites, they're part of this too)* but it's still him.

They didn't look because they didn't know him. Their limited perception of him hindered them, restricted them, all that '*he wouldn't want this!'* Bullshit. They say that, without a single ounce of irony, as they watch a boy splinter his bones, flay his skin, ruin himself over and over again for nothing but an *ideal.*

They don't fucking know what Izuku Midoriya wants.

And they never will. No one else is allowed to know Deku.

No one else is allowed to see his blood and guts up here like garlands, in Katsuki's private room.

This isn't for anyone else to know. This could put him in danger.

This could kill him. *(Responsible for ending the Symbol. Katsuki's fault. His fault.)*

Katsuki feels his hands fall to his sides, heartbeat steadied, mind clear. The thought wraps him up in its arms, calms him, cradles him close.

He's got no choice. To protect Deku, to protect One for All, he's got to kill Zero.

He walks out his study, resetting the pressure sensor, locking the door, just like he always does. He gets dressed, unhurried, in his bedroom. He walks out the front door, just like any other day, cold metal tucked carefully into his waistband.

He walks to the coffee shop. He nods to the blushing barista (Otoa? That doesn't look like the right name.) and orders his coffee. He sees the bleached blonde out of the corner of his eye, sitting, reading

his shitty book, drinking his shitty tea like nothing's different. Katsuki does what he always does, standing with his back to the counter, pretending to watch the outside world, but he doesn't see anything at all.

He takes his drink, sits across from Zero and sips on it, tasting nothing. He's aware of the way the other freezes, aware of the irises trained on him, aware of the tapping of his legs under the table.

"Bathroom." Katsuki says simply to the other, and walks to the other end of the shop, to the single-person bathroom flanking the staircase. He stands there, waiting, until Zero makes his appearance, closing the door behind him. Katsuki's body moves fast – he spins the other around, shoving the stand holding a vase underneath the door jamb, before pushing Zero hard against the mirror, but not hard enough to crack it. Katsuki can see the corner of his own eye behind the other in his reflection. He looks away.

"What the – "

Katsuki crowds him, shoving his hips against the other, hand on his neck, squeezing without sympathy, reveling in the way the other's eyes nearly pop out of his head.

"You. Fucking. Traitor." Katsuki grits out, ignoring the minute shake of the other's head, like he's trying to deny shit.

"I know you went in there. I know you saw it. I know about the power outage. Everything." Zero's metal arm moves to counter Katsuki, gripping around his wrist, trying to pull back, but Katsuki's quicker, pure adrenaline giving him superhuman strength, and he pushes on, squeezes harder against the other's neck, thumb against the carotid, letting his fingertips smoke against the other's skin, until the bathroom is filled with the sweet caramel of nitroglycerin and the distinct smell of burning flesh.

In the mirror, Katsuki can see a man in a top hat, and he's juggling two marbles between his singed knuckles.

Katsuki pulls the metal piece from his belt, jamming it against the other's skull, staring him deep in the eyes, challenging to something he doesn't have a name for. The surprise from Zero's eyes morphs into something else, and the hand that was trying to fight against Katsuki's grip around his neck relaxes.

"Do it." Zero's mouths, throat too constricted to talk. His eyes show no hesitation.

Katsuki wants to. He does.

Katsuki's hand starts to shake. His whole body is shaking too, a tremor so great that he can hardly stand upright, and he couldn't pull the trigger if he tried, fingers slippery with his own viscous sweat. Tears are forming in his eyes, and the room is suffocating him, he needs to get out, its that *smell,* and he's going to die, he just knows it, he's going to fucking die, he wants, no, *needs to* -

Katsuki takes the gun from Zero's head and, with shaking hands, rests it against his own skull, feeling the burning sensation of tears running his cheeks.

They hurt. They hurt the way rain hitting the cracked desert ground hurts. They hurt the way dabbing a cut with alcohol hurts. They hurt because they're wrong, and they're foreign, and because all this pain in his chest, his stomach, his shuddering heart is trying to pour out of his eyes, and it's too much, too heady and thick, he can't, he just -

Zero's cold acceptance explodes into something else when Katsuki puts the gun against his own temple – panic, fear, something too honest and raw for Katsuki to comprehend – and that metal arm is squeezing his wrist, making the gun clatter to the ground, useless.

Pathetic. Useless. You couldn't even get that right. Katsuki sobs, letting the voice dig its claws into his psyche. *No wonder everyone leaves you. No wonder.*

Warmth. Katsuki's barely aware as a hand maneuvers his head into a crook of a warm shoulder, until he can feel a hand running through his hair, until he can hear the distinct hummingbird thumping of a heart that's not his own. Zero holds Katsuki hard, unapologetically, like he's afraid he'll disintegrate if he lets go. Hell, Katsuki might be apt to agree. He's falling apart. *He's falling apart.*

"Please. Please. Please. God, please." Katsuki can vaguely hear through an ocean of nothing, Zero's voice. And its desperate, shaking, emotional, and it doesn't sound like his, and Katsuki's surely hallucinating, because it sounds like someone *else,* and Katsuki's tired of seeing him everywhere he goes, tired of not seeing him anywhere, Katsuki's just *tired* –

So he lets himself dissolve into the other's arms. And he weeps.

Zero's whispering something to him. Zero's sitting them down on the toilet seat, adjusting Katsuki in his arms, cradling him like a newborn baby, and Katsuki feels a distinct wetness against his scalp, and he doesn't know what to do, so he lets it happen. He just lets is happen, like he let the past four years happen, like he let everything just… happen.

"Please don't do this. Please don't. I need you. Stay with me, Katsuki. Please. Please. I need you. I need you."

Zero's words are frantic, and he rocks Katsuki in his arms, and Katsuki feels that crushing darkness choking him up rescind, just a little, just enough. Despite everything, he believes him. He actually believes him.

Katsuki wants to argue with that thought. Wants to ask. *How can you need someone you hardly know? How can your words sound so sincere when we're strangers? How can you betray me but still need me? How?*

Instead, he tries to wrestle out of the other's arms, pathetically too weak and drained to thrash against Zero's tense grip.

"Stay the fuck away from him. Stay away. He's not a part of this. You can get Shigaraki without him. I'll –" Katsuki's voice cuts off in an aborted sob, and he leans forward, trying to control the shaking of his voice, "I'll help. I'll do anything. Just don't touch him. Don't – "

"I can't. I can't promise that." Zero's voice is distant, quivering with resignation.

"I'll kill you." It doesn't even sound like a threat to Katsuki's ears as he gasps it out. How could it, when his hands are shaking too hard to push himself away from the other, much less hold a gun or blow up this entire god-forsaken coffee shop, Zero and himself along with it?

"You won't." Its assured. Almost relieved. It doesn't make sense – Zero asked Katsuki to do it, asked him yesterday and today, he asked for Katsuki to end it, so why does he sound –

"You're not a murderer. You're a good person. A hero."

“I’m n-not,” Katsuki whispers, and the other pulls him closer, so Katsuki can feel the sweat accumulating on his collarbone against his cheek. He doesn’t try to pull away.

“You are. You are,” Zero coos softly against Katsuki ear, hand brushing through his hair. “You’re good. You shouldn’t get mixed up in this. Walk away. Walk away and live your life. Please.”

Katsuki laughs, high pitched and delirious. “This *is* my life. He – He *is* –“

Katsuki doesn’t know how to finish that sentence.

Maybe it was always like that. Maybe Katsuki always existed between states of being – an electron hurtling recklessly without direction, without aim – only reaching a physical state when Deku’s eyes are on him. He only exists when he’s being watched. Neither here nor there, neither dead or alive, neither a hero or a villain – not until Deku’s eyes tell him which one he’s supposed to be.

The sun was just like any other ball of hydrogen and helium, like the millions of other stars in the known universe, until the Earth was created. It was one of millions until the Earth gave him a name, a legend, reverence and worship. It was the Earth that made the sun special. Nothing more.

It was Deku that made Katsuki special. Nothing more.

Katsuki would kill for Deku, die for Deku, burn down this entire fucking planet for Deku. And he’d never say it to his face, never admit his weakness, never thank him or apologize to him or touch him *(but oh how his fingers itch to)* but all of this – his soul, his heart, this bleak, colorless world around him – none of it means anything without him.

The truth is, Katsuki’s life has belonged to Izuku Midoriya from the very beginning.

“I *need* him,” Katsuki’s voice breaks, that of a child that’s broken their favorite toy, and his fingers are shaking against Zero’s collar, and Zero’s hands are on his face, dark eyes looking desperately between tear-stricken reds before he pulls his face towards his own and kisses him.

There’s something different in this kiss, something too soft and reverent, something magic between the taste of salt and lavender, between sniffling noses and swollen lips. It feels good, and it shouldn’t, because things don’t *feel* good, but it does - Katsuki’s eyes flutter closed, the tension in his chest dissolving with each breathless meeting.

He gasps into it, putting his pain into each frantic kiss, into his tongue, his mouth, in to his very saliva. He wonders if it tastes just as poisonous to Zero as it does to him.

The other isn’t acting like it does. He reciprocates readily, moving his body on the toilet seat so Katsuki could straddle him, so he can feel more of him, all of him, everything. Katsuki vaguely realizes that this is the first time the other ever initiated anything between them, and his fingers are so, so gentle against his abdomen, and his biologic hand is traveling up and down his back, gently, almost affectionately, and its breaking Katsuki’s heart because – because –

Katsuki’s heart is somersaulting in his chest when he pulls back, slowly, the tingling across his lips dancing like electricity. He doesn’t understand that look on Zero’s face – a ferocity that he almost recognizes, something akin to wildfire, beautiful but deadly, destructive, corrosive.

He doesn’t know what the fuck he’s doing. He doesn’t know why putting his lips on his feels like salvation. He doesn’t know why touching him is the only thing that makes sense. But maybe, in this

moment, he understands why the Gods came down from the heavens to consort with the mortals below.

“I’ll go.” Zero sighs against their salted lips. Horror, immediate and hostile, spreads through Katsuki’s psyche, and he holds on to the other.

“Don’t.” It's less an order and more a prayer, Katsuki locking eyes with the other, not knowing what to do with the collection of tears in the corners of his eyes. They glitter under the shitty lights of this coffee shop bathroom like stardust. Zero’s left hand comes up, the back brushing against Katsuki’s cheek, lips cracking open slightly before they clamp shut. Zero shakes his head, brushing Katsuki’s hair from his forehead before landing a languid kiss there. He hesitates, just a beat too long, before pulling back.

“… I have to. I had to.”

“No – “ Katsuki tries to hold on, pride discarded as soon as his first tears fell, but Zero has no trouble maneuvering his body off himself, settling him on the closed toilet seat.

Zero pauses. His biologic hand makes a harsh fist, and with his back to Katsuki, he exhales slowly. But he doesn’t look back. He moves the table blocking the door, opening the door. He moves past Granny Honoka and her nephew without them so much as blinking at him.

Katsuki stares after him, each step Zero takes away from him feeling like a band stretching, ready to snap.

“What have you been doing in here?!” The old woman asks, her eyes displaying some semblance of concern. Katsuki slams the door back in her face, turning on the faucet, dabbing his swollen eyes with cool water. He ignores the tears that flow openly as he presses his palms against his eyes, the thought constant, insistent. *Everyone leaves you. Everyone leaves you. Everyone’s left you.*

It’s six sharp.

Katsuki stands outside the busy *izakaya,* letting his frosted breath mingle with the cigarette smoke outside. Heat seems to pour out of the building, noise erupting every time the door is opens. He catches flashes of familiar faces – Kirishima and Kaminari and Sero, holding their beers, laughing over something Katsuki is sure is idiotic. Ashido, Yaoyorozu and Jirou, holding each other’s hands in apt conversation. He hesitates, a part of him wanting desperately to walk through those doors. For the past four years to not have happened. To be wrapped up in the warm embrace of his friends, to laugh with them, to feel at home again.

That feeling evaporates just like his breath as another group walks past the window. There, the perfect scene of Uraraka, Iida and Todoroki, sitting down to plates of food, peaceful smiles across all three faces. Like they don’t have a care in the world.

The others, Katsuki could understand. He forgave them, as far as he’s able to forgive. But never Todoroki. Never him. He was the one who was supposed to understand how Katsuki felt. He was the one that stuck with him the longest. He was the one who spent endless nights, sleepless patrols, weekends without rest, looking alongside him. He was the only one Katsuki trusted with this, and even he -

Katsuki exhales again, the old wound aching to be picked at again, like a non-healing scab, if only to fill that ever-expanding emptiness in his chest.

Katsuki shoves his hands deeper into his pockets and starts to walk away. He doesn't notice Jirou seeing him out the window, doesn't see her run out the door, doesn't hear her weakly call out his name. Doesn't see Kirishima follow her out, eyes downturned in surrender. He drapes a jacket across her shoulders, hand nudging to lead her back inside.

"Come inside. We have to let him go."

So it comes back to this. To this empty apartment, to this monstrous wall, to the crushing loneliness and to a mystery that seems too far from being solved.

With the vigilante knowing about Deku, about his power, Katsuki's time is limited. He has to find him, and he has to find him now. He has to save him.

He sits down. Opens his computer, turns on his police radio, starts playing back his cameras. Gets back to work.

He's been missing things. Been sloppy. Didn't know that Shigaraki had been setting up these labs – that he's been trying to find the 'right' pair of twins for nearly two months now. Didn't realize that his old friends were flying in today. Didn't realize he didn't lock his door. Didn't realize that his cameras would stop recording after a power outage – it would have been an easy way for the villains to get him. He can't believe he hadn't thought of that.

They need a backup source. Some kind of battery or generator. Something separate from the larger grid.

He – he needs me. To use his power. He – if I'm gone he can't. He can't use it.

Wait.

Zero said the last statement off the cuff, and Katsuki didn't think about it, not really. He was too thrilled at the prospect of hunting down Shigaraki to process it, but now, now those words stand out starkly in the forefront of his mind.

He wasn't going to hurt them either. He needs them –

Wait.

Why would he need the twins? Why would he need Zero? Why would Shigaraki need anything at all, with his all-encompassing power?

If quirks are really separate from DNA, if they can ebb and flow and be shared just like electricity within a circuit or any power within a closed system, why would it matter to Shigaraki? Sure, maybe if he took a quirk from one twin, he'd have to keep the other alive – keep the circuit flowing, so to speak. But why would that matter for All for One?

After all, that quirk is an enclosed system. It shouldn't be affected by external factors.

Unless it's *not* an enclosed system. Unless Shigaraki's working off a battery or a generator. Because he's been separated from the larger grid.

Katsuki's entire world crashes around him.

Holy shit. He laughs, hands digging into his grimy hair, skin soaked with nitroglycerin, feeling like the last of his sanity is evaporating with the sticky substance on his fingertips.

That’s the reason that Shigaraki didn’t kill Deku. Why he followed him all over the world. Why Deku leaving seemed to be the solution – and Deku had to have known, because with his departure came peace. He never killed Deku because he *couldn’t.*

Isn’t it a lot like All for One?

He said it himself, sitting next to the nerd in that tiny office, All Might’s notebook of ill-gotten quirks sitting in front of it. He said it from the very beginning.

Deku’s power is a lot like All for One.

Because it *is* All for One.

The original holders of All for One and One for All were *twins.*

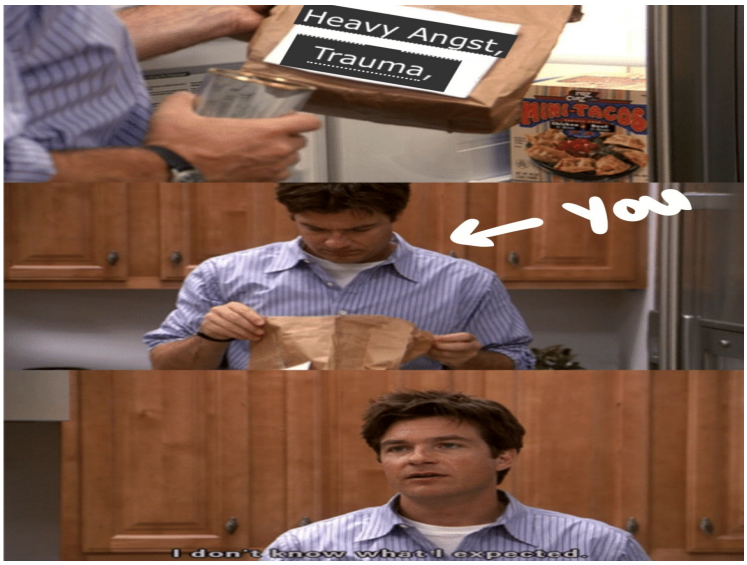
They shared a singular quirk.

Izuku Midoriya and Tomura Shigaraki share their quirk.

Chapter End Notes

anyone else think that Izuku being able to see into Shiggy's mindscape was a little.... hmm suspicious?!
horikoshi hit me up if you need a big reveal, man. i'm free whenever

two memes, because this made me sad lmao





(you know the funny thing is, i went into a really vulnerable place mentally to write this chapter, and it put me into a super weird headspace for a few days and, despite that, it still doesn't.... hit in the way i was hoping. i'm trying to find a way to balance prose with plot and make something more... i don't know, impactful, I guess? but I'm just... not there yet. but i'll keep trying.)

ANYWAY. I'm psyched for chapter 8!!! Get ready for me to pathetically try to bring us back to high school chemistry and physics as I try to explain this convoluted-ass plot lmao

Chapter 8

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Deku knew.

He had to have. Somewhere along the way, the little nerd figured it out.

That gullible sucker must have finally seen the light (*or, rather the maggots and flesh rotting underneath*,) when that crusty asshole put his hands on him amidst the destruction in Daika City. While Katsuki was attempting not to hemorrhage to death, blood-wise and emotional-development-wise, that stupid asshole was *realizing things*.

Tomura Shigaraki tried to take Izuku Midoriya's Quirk and found that he could not. You can't take something you already have.

All this time, was Tomura Shigaraki making Deku colder, sharper, less forgiving? All this time, was Deku making Tomura softer, kinder, more loving?

And if *their* connection holds true… then, at some point, bright-eyed fifteen year old Izuku Midoriya was one half of the demon king. Linked directly to AFO himself.

Maybe, unknowingly, the person that gave away the location of their training camp, gave away so much of what U.A. was trying to keep hidden was… was him. Katsuki's hands clamp into fists, the sensation of fingers around his neck and taste of smoke asphyxiating him. He pushes through, exhaling evenly through his nose, unclenching each tense muscle in his jaw and neck.

Katsuki stares at the pink-cheeked monster in question, grinning without a care in the world on his wall, feeling something wound-up tight inside him unfurl at that happy-go-lucky face.

Light versus dark, good versus evil, justice versus injustice – in the end, they're both drawn from the same source. Its nearly poetic.

…If it wasn't so horribly fucking trite. Katsuki could laugh, if he wasn't so personally deeply entrenched in this cosmic bullshit.

But here they are. All for One and One for All are the same Quirk, Deku figured it out somehow, and he made choices so that Shigaraki had… less access to it? Proximity must be a factor – would at least explain why he left. But that can't be the only thing.

"Come on, fucker, you're smarter than this!" Katsuki growls to himself, pulling lightly at his hair.

This changes things. He wasn't thinking about this right. With this context, every insane obsessive thing Deku wrote down about his *own* Quirk probably applies to All for One, too.

Katsuki exhales slowly, disgust climbing up his throat as he grabs his phone, ignoring the texts from this morning and the pang of discomfort at the sight of Kirishima's name on his phone.

[KATSUKI] 7:15pm – I need to stop by tomorrow

[I] 7:17pm – *in the middle of the week?*

[I] 7:18pm – *I work until five, but how about dinner?*

Katsuki's eyes feel hot again, and he looks around the room, swallowing against the lump in his throat.

[KATSUKI] 7:20pm – can't do dinner. Just need to look at some of Izuku's things

[I] 7:21pm – *oh.*

[I] 7:21pm – *you can always spend the night. We could have breakfast. I can take off work.*

STOP! Katsuki wants to scream, the uncomfortable pressure building in his chest.

[KATSUKI] 7:23pm – I have something to do tomorrow night.

It's not even a lie. He hates it so much he'd almost rather spend the evening with Inko, although both tasks fill him with an indescribable dread. It's funny, how being both loved and hated is stifling in their own ways. Katsuki sometimes wonders what it's like to be nothing to no one. It's a peaceful thought.

Not one he can dwell on today.

[KATSUKI] 7:23pm – another time?

Katsuki stares at his phone. He's already burned every other bridge in his life – detached himself from every person that might have ever given a shit about him. But to lose the connection to Inko is to lose the connection to his – *to Izuku's* – things. That's not something he can afford. Even if it takes… Katsuki's stomach churns with nausea. Katsuki's reading into things too much. He has to be.

[I] 7:30pm – *of course. :) Another time.*

[I] 7:31pm – *I'll leave the key in the plant by the door. My home is yours.*

Our, Katsuki thinks. *Our home is yours. Stop – stop talking like he's not here.* Still, he exhales the breath he didn't realize he was holding, sharp relief washing over him. To be around those things, his bed, without her around? He's not entirely sure why he hadn't thought about it before.

Doesn't matter. He'll go first thing in the morning, stay just before Inko gets back, and he'll be in perfect proximity to… Katsuki chews on the inside of his mouth. There's really no one else he can talk to about this, even though he's a cheap substitution to the real thing.

If Katsuki could somehow fuse the image of him with Inko, they would maybe make half… no, *less*, a fourth, of who Deku was. *Is. Is, jackass. IS.*

The train rattles, empty cars oddly loud in their early morning emptiness. The few other commuters glance at Katsuki, recognition fueling their indiscrete whispers, but Katsuki doesn't notice them. Bleary eyes stare straight ahead, unseeing of the landscape passing by. Spring is rapidly approaching, sidewalks still frosty in the morning, browned trees shiny with ice as tiny buds start to peak through the deadened wood. Although the mornings are cold, the sun beats down, warming the old bones of Musutafu, rebirth more natural in the cracks of the concrete *(inhospitable and harsh as it is)* than in Katsuki's bones. Katsuki shoves his hands further into his jacket at the sound of school-children rushing past, laughter ringing out between each other.

Katsuki recognizes the black uniforms, the golden buttons, the too-tight collars, the feeling of choking against invisible bile. Out of the corner of his eye, he swears one of the boys running past has curly green hair and freckles. This one he's sure is a hallucination – Deku never laughed like that. And he certainly didn't have friends.

He had made sure of that.

Doesn't stop him from turning around and watching after that silhouette until it disappears into the horizon.

He stands in front of the familiar apartment, hypnotized by the prospect of just.. using a key. Opening the door. Walking in. It feels like something much grander than what it is, and Katsuki can't shake the odd elation as he steps inside the empty home.

He listens for a second, just to make sure Inko hadn't played a trick on him and decided to skip work. Certain that the place is deserted, his voice tries a shaky, "I'm home." His heart hammers against his ribcage, and even though there's not a resounding 'Kacchan! Welcome home!,' the satisfaction of saying it *out loud* sticks to his skin.

He shucks his shoes, leaving his coat on the hook as he walks straight to Deku's room, not pausing elsewhere. Certainly not at the plate of what appears to be cookies on the kitchen counter, covered with plastic wrap, a sticky note tacked on top.

Katsuki can pretend it isn't for him if he doesn't look at it. Katsuki can pretend the thought of that woman, flour on her chipmunk-cheeks, hurriedly trying to bake a treat for his ungrateful ass, doesn't flood him with a too familiar mixture of shame and revulsion.

"Hey, nerd." Katsuki says to no one as he walks inside. He sits down on his bed, bouncing slightly on the creaky springs. He looks around the room, almost expecting it to look different. He's mostly here in the evenings – today, the sunlight filters through the curtains, illuminating the room in a cacophony of yellows and blues, All Might's colors reflected tackily along the white walls.

“I figured it out, you know.” Katsuki tells the empty room. “It being the same Quirk. I fuckin’ told you it was a cursed power.” Silence answers.

“’All about how you use it, Kacchan.’ That’s what you’d tell me. Asshole.” Katsuki laughs, voice catching at the nickname. Flustered at nothing, Katsuki clears his throat, running his hands against the comforter before getting up.

“Guess if you found a way to make sure Shigaraki had less of the power, I gotta figure out how you got *more* of it the first place, huh? His body had to go through some freaky augmentation Nomu-ass-bullshit, but your scrawny body could handle getting the Quirk, with, what – “ Katsuki puts his gloves on, grabbing the crate at the bottom of the closet. He digs in until he finds notebook with just touch, instinctually. - #13. Still burned and distorted, pages wrinkled and fat from dried water.

“- The power of fucking… believing in yourself or some other anime protagonist bullshit?”

Katsuki makes his way back to the bed, resting his back against the wall as he gingerly flips through the pages. They’re unexpectedly fragile, thinned out and blurry from being water-logged, but still miraculously legible.

You wanna be a hero so bad? I’ve got a time-saving idea for you.

Katsuki’s body stiffens at the sound of his own middle school voice, jeering as always, in the back of his mind.

If you think you’ll have a Quirk in your next life… go take a swan dive off the roof!

“Not that easy,” Katsuki says to himself, ignoring the fresh gush of shame pooling deep within his gut.

“If you could just kill yourself and get rid of All for One, you would have already done it. You’d never value your own life over anyone else’s. So that can’t be it.”

Through the haze of being choked out by that disgusting slime monster, he could still remember useless, Quirkless Deku, jumping into danger when no one else would, all to try to save the same guy that told him to kill himself just an hour before. Deku’s had a death wish from the moment he set foot on this god-forsaken earth; Katsuki spent most of his life trying to make it come true.

I never asked you to save me!

He turns the page. In large, English letters, Katsuki recognizes All Might’s signature, spanning two pages. He blows air out his nose, small smile playing at the corners of his lips. He can just imagine fourteen year old Izuku Midoriya, fanboy extraordinaire, probably seconds away from pissing his pants with excitement at the meeting of their idol.

As if you could!! Huh?! Well?! I could’ve beaten him myself. How dare a Quirkless failure like you pity me?

That was the day, wasn’t it? The day everything changed between them. Him at twenty and him at fourteen don’t see eye-to-fucking-eye for a lot of fucking excellent reasons, but they both… *saw* it. You’d be fucking stupid to look at Izuku Midoriya and not be blinded.

Carefully crafted hero notes became something else. He flips through the pages, frantic writing outlining a harsh schedule, just a few hours dedicated for sleep, instead focused on weights, reps, runs, back-breaking work on a ten month timeline. Just prior to the U.A. entrance exam.

He needed to get stronger to receive the Quirk. He didn't get it right away.

"Why?" Katsuki asks the empty room, fingers running against the divots Deku's pen made against the paper. "Because the sudden influx of power would, what, wreck your body?" Like when you plug in a device meant to work on a 110V input into a 220V, and it instantly destroys the battery – too much power in too short of a time?

Kind of like Kaminari's Quirk.

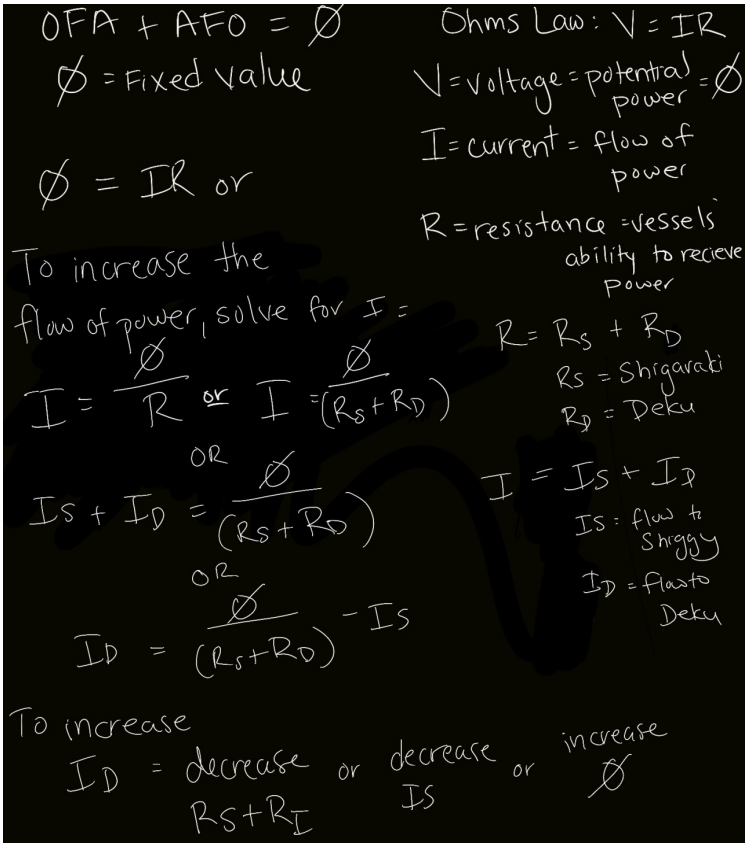
So. Deku had to change his body to be able to receive the power. Makes sense. Just like how Shigaraki had to change *his.* So does that mean… he had to further alter himself, further change himself as a vessel to be able to draw more of the power, giving Shigaraki less?

Katsuki turns to the back of the notebook, hesitating slightly before ripping the empty page out, grabbing one of the untouched All-Might themed pencils from the meticulously arranged and dust-less All-Might themed pencil case on the desk and flipping the notebook around to give himself a surface to write.

He starts to scribble, talking himself through each movement of pencil against paper.

Let's assume that this Quirk – all Quirks, maybe - really *do* work like electricity. If that's the case, then Ohms Law holds true, where Voltage (V) is equal to current (I) multiplied by resistance (R.) To simply it in Quirk-oriented terms, voltage is equivalent to the total pool of potential power that Deku and Shigaraki can both draw from – a combination of OFA and AFO. Let's say (I), or current, is equivalent to the flow of power to either Shigaraki or Deku. Finally, resistance is equivalent to the ability of the vessels, Shigaraki's body and Deku's body, to receive said power.

Rearranging the equation to increase the 'flow' of power, I=(AFO+OFA)/R. Rather, if broken down further to the two people sharing the Quirk, the I_S (flow to Shigaraki) + I_D (flow to Deku) = (AFO+OFA)/(R_S (resistance of Shigaraki's body) + R_D (resistance of Deku's body.)

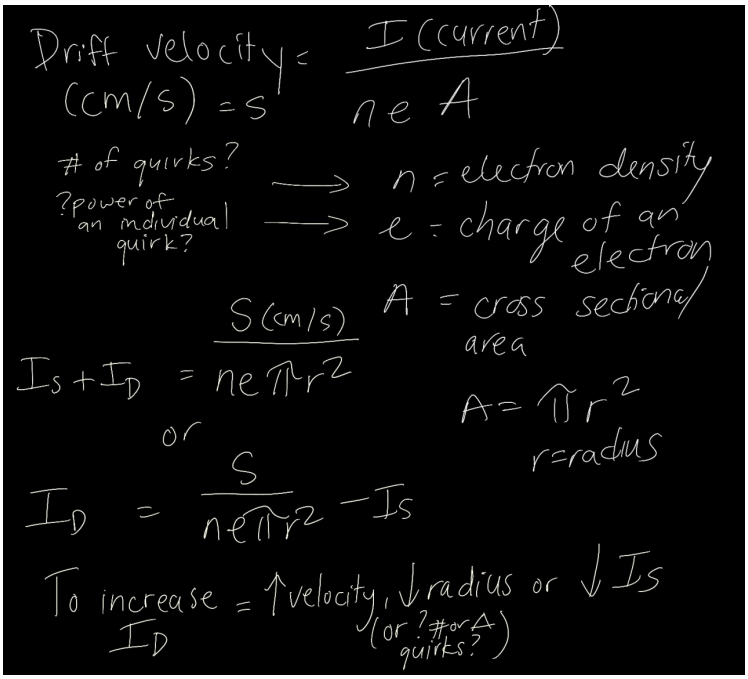


In the end, $I_D = (AFO+OFA)/(R_s+R_D) – I_s$. To increase Izuku's share - or flow - of power, one of three things has to happen: decrease the resistance, decrease the flow of power to Shigaraki, or increase the total power available that composes AFO+OFA.

Okay. Simple enough. Decreasing the resistance must mean physical augmentation. Without the good doctor at his disposal, Katsuki can only assume that means more of the same 'physical fitness' shit. No way would Deku let his physical body degenerate if it meant he had less control of the Quirk.

The next logical step would be to decrease the flow of power to Shigaraki.

So, what is flow? Flow is measured as a unit of power divided by period of time. Simply, drift velocity is equal to I (current, or flow of power) divided by n(electon density) x e(charge of electron) x A(cross sectional area, also known as πr^2). If Katsuki was to rearrange the equation again to solve for the flow of power to Izuku specifically, one of three things need to happen – the velocity, or speed, of the flow of power has to increase, the radius has to *decrease,* or the flow of power to Shigaraki has to decrease.



Putting it all together, Deku had several options in front of him. In order to increase his own share of the power, he'd have to decrease his resistance, increase the total power available to them, increase the speed of flow of power or decrease the radius of the flow of power.

That's just what he did. He increased the radius the power had to travel by leaving the country – by constantly staying as distant as possible from Shigaraki. Then, he probably decreased his own resistance. Altered or changed his body in some way that made him a better vessel. Whatever the fuck that might entail.

This also means, the closer they are to one another physically, the stronger they both become. That certainly explains that insane show of power in Daika City. It was almost mesmerizing – the way a neutrino star about to blow might be. Unhinged, limitless, neither of them human; just vessels for something too infinitesimal and untouchable to comprehend.

Katsuki taps the pencil against the piece of paper.

It… sort of makes sense. If the human body is used as some kind of conductor and capacitor to the power, it also explains why there are… shadows of the power left in the predecessor after the Quirk is passed on.

Just like a battery, the former user can exert what they've stored up. All Might had it for so *long* – it's no surprise he was able to use it for such a prolonged period of time.

"You're a goddamn fucking nerd," Katsuki tells the room, something sweet and sickening filling his chest.

"So, you're connected. How do we get you unconnected?"

He could pass the power on, but knowing that it links the owner to AFO, Deku never would. That's out of the question.

The power will likely disappear if one of them dies, just like a short circuit. So if Deku dies, the power dies with him. Including Shigaraki's share. There's something off with that theory, though.

It would be risky. Maybe Shigaraki's already stored some of his own DNA to pass off AFO if Deku does anything stupid. Or maybe *he* has a sample of Deku's DNA and is just waiting for the fucker to off himself so he can somehow give OFA to one of his minions, and control 100% of it?

...Swan dive off the roof...

Katsuki shakes his head against the memory, tapping the pencil harder on the paper, puncturing small holes through his writing.

What else? What else?

What is he missing?

Katsuki sighs. He digs in his pocket, taking out his phone. There's new texts, but he doesn't register them. Settings -> Phone -> Blocked. He sucks his teeth at the sheer quantity of numbers, not having to pretend to not know which one he needs to press.

Closing his eyes, he brings the phone up to his ear, anxiety climbing with each passing ring.

Katsuki's about to hang up when he hears the hurried click, heavy breaths followed by a flurry of high-pitched background voices. Katsuki clicks his tongue.

"Young Bakugou?"

"You shouldn't answer your phone in the middle of lecture, old man."

"I – well. You haven't called for years. I was concerned that something may have…" Toshinori Yagi trails off, coughing to just the side of the speaker so Katsuki isn't prime to the disgusting rattle of his lungs.

What's the opposite of when Narcissus looked into the lake and nearly drowned from self-admiration? Katsuki hears his reflection and wants to release a few explosions straight against his eardrums, maim his body in every way that makes him and the other *less* similar despite the growing evidence to the contrary.

Fuck fate and inevitability and symbolism or whatever the fuck this is supposed to be. Katsuki wants no part of it.

He grits his teeth, ignoring the sweat pooling in his hands.

"…How are you? How's your stomach? " Toshinori starts after his coughing fit.

"I'm not calling to trade fucked up stomach stories. I need to talk to you about something. Can't be on the phone. Can you meet?"

Yagi is silent for too long, the voices in the background dimming after a short *slam!* of a heavy door.

"… Of course. When and where?"

"…When does lecture end today?"

"Hm. Around three pm."

"How about Dagobah, at four?"

"… Absolutely. I'll be there, Young Bakugou."

Katsuki tosses his phone away as if its corroding through his hand, unsure why he feels all his hairs rise up on the back of his neck.

He leaves the Midoriya household without touching the plate of cookies or casting a single look at that shrine (*middle school picture of him. Why? Look at the way his smile doesn't reach his eyes. Look at the way he doesn't even look at the camera. Did you even know him? Did you even love him? Did you?*) He walks the familiar streets, slowly, deliberately. Like each step holds some kind of significance – thought it doesn't. It's a shitty street, filled with shitty people, making him think of shitty things. The corner-shop where him and Deku bought those hero trading cards. *(They both got All Might. Of course they did.)* The park where Deku defended that shitty extra kid. The clearing where him and Deku would chase bugs. The pond where they'd skip stones (*well, Katsuki would skip them. Deku would just throw them in the river and cry about it. Big baby.*)

He finds the spot where his cameras will capture their meeting and sits in the sand. The beach is mostly empty, still too cold for tourists, and the howling wind chills Katsuki down to his bones. He briefly covers his ears against the chills with sweaty hands, re-adjusting his scarf as he burrows his head inside, hiding under his coat, hands and feet housed inside the lining,

There's something calming about the repetitive motion of the waves, about their constant ebb and flow, their rhythmic cycle. About the way they break, a snapshot of their power and simultaneously their weakness. About the way that's what's so loved about them – not simply the potential to break, but explicitly their ability to do so.

Nearly dozing off, hypnotized by the monotony of the waves, he barely notices the pair of large shoes supporting a larger-than-life presence find their way to his side. Katsuki's entire body goes tense as he looks to his left.

He hasn't changed at all, save for the cane sinking slightly into the sand.

"Yagi." He looks away, keeping his gaze firm on the ocean.

"… It's been a long time."

More than two years. But who's counting.

Katsuki still very much remembers the cracking of ~~All Might's~~ Yagi's gaunt jaw against his knuckles when the man confessed that he helped get Deku out of the country. About how he, a sixteen year old child, disappeared completely from Yagi's radar mere *weeks* after those pro assholes finagled the system to get him housing with 'contacts' in Los Angeles.

It almost looked like Yagi was asking for help – so Katsuki helped him by putting a new fracture in that old man's skull. Katsuki knew what the man wanted – to be punished. To pay a retribution of some sort what he's done.

"Yeah." Katsuki states. The scar in his abdomen hurts like a motherfucker. He readjusts, trying to hide the flinch of pain with a grimace of annoyance.

"Look, I'm not here for a social visit. This is about One for All and All for One."

"Ah." Toshinori Yagi awkwardly maneuvers his body so that he can sit next to Katsuki. On the sand, crispy with frost, the gaunt man barely makes a dent. Katsuki bristles at the proximity, but says

nothing.

"…You're still looking for him," Yagi says, and it comes out soft, nearly overwhelmed by the sound of the water crashing. He doesn't clarify which 'him,' and Katsuki doesn't bother pressing it. At this point, they're indistinguishable. He just didn't realize how much.

"I am." Katsuki assures. "And…I think I'm fucking *on to something.* Worse, I think he fucking *knew* this shit before he left."

Why didn't he trust you? Katsuki's brain asks, mocking. Katsuki scoffs at the intruding thought, pressing forward.

"…Did Deku ever mention anything to you about… feeling connected, somehow, to Shigaraki? Being able to speak to him or something through the vestige world?"

Yagi's eyes widen almost comically and excitement dances under Katsuki's sternum. He doesn't let it show on his face, but he can almost feel the answer in the air between them. Yagi's face is too damn easy to read – that's been the old man's downfall from the beginning.

"…He. In the hospital, he did mention that when Shigaraki touched him, he… saw inside of his mind. Similar to what he sees when he interacts with the Vestiges. He even mentioned…" Yagi's voice picks up, almost eager, but then trails off.

"What?" Katsuki urges him forward.

"…Well, that one of the vestiges, my old master. Was able to… *interact* with Shigaraki."

"Shit." Katsuki laughs, punching against the frosty sand, and Yagi startles at the movement.

"…Listen, old man, I think… All for One and One for All are the *same Quirk."* Katsuki pauses, letting the full impact of his words hit Toshinori like the brick shithouse that they are, before he continues, *"*There's…other people like them that communicate through this vestige world. They're not the only ones. Just… two halves of the same whole. Maybe of the world's biggest goddamn coin, but… " Katsuki finishes, placing his hands together in an effort to show Yagi what he means. The other looks unconvinced, eyebrows furrowed.

Katsuki's not a fan of the skeptical look on the other's face, or that twitch of pity he can see crawling onto his eyebrow like a judgey-ass caterpillar.

"Twins. He's been looking for twins. Identical twins share the same Quirk. It's – Shigaraki's been researching them. Trying to find them. I don't know why yet, maybe he found out about the twin shit too, and is trying to find a way to separate himself from Deku without losing the Quirk. Shit, I'm getting ahead of myself… Were the original holders twins?"

Yagi rubs his chin, deep in thought.

"The story that was passed on to me is that the two were an older brother and a younger brother."

Katsuki's face falls slightly.

"That said, this was a time before Quirks were commonplace. It was rare enough for one person to be born with a Quirk, much less twins. It wouldn't be outside the realm of possibility that One for All and All for One were born as twins, and once One for All realized that connection exists, he tried to

hide it. It would be a huge point of vulnerability – if the most superpowered man on the planet could be taken out by simply killing his much weaker brother."

Katsuki's breath hitches, and he stares at Yagi next to him, a contemplative look on his face. An old spark of admiration flares in Katsuki's gut, and a part of him is so happy that the other is humoring him that he almost, *almost*, doesn't hate him with a burning fury in this moment.

"That's – that's also what I wanted to talk to you about. Hear me out." Katsuki bends over, knees in the sand as he starts to draw through the smooth surface. The same equations he's worked through now make their way onto the sand. He mumbles through them, attempting to be much clearer than he was in his own head. Yagi nods along, at least feigning understanding, so Katsuki continues, leaving him exactly where he left of.

For Deku to increase his own share of this 'power,' he'd have to decrease his resistance, increase the total power available to them, increase the speed of flow of power or decrease the radius in the flow of power.

"…That's very… interesting, Young Bakugou. But… well, you're thinking of One for All and All for One as a singular power." Yagi points to the velocity equation, circling the n and e (electron density and charge) with his cane. "But the degree of that 'power' lies within the hundreds - maybe thousands - of Quirks that are stockpiled inside. You're treating the function as a wave – but if this is like electricity, then it can behave as both a wave and as a particle."

Katsuki swallows. "So… what you're saying is..."

"I'm saying, if you're correct, and Young Midoriya has somehow altered his body to augment the flow of the Quirk towards himself, he likely acquired some of All for One's Quirks. It's quite likely Young Midoriya has different powers than when we last saw him."

...It's a Quirk.

Your Quirk?

Katsuki's heart jolts. What the hell? That's… that's an insane thought. There's… no. No. He needs to focus.

"Like…A disguise Quirk?" Katsuki asks anyway, his throat suddenly so dry he's not sure how his voice worked.

"Hm. I suppose that's possible. All for One had taken so many over the years, I'm certain he himself isn't aware of which ones are available to him."

Katsuki exhales shakily. He's being paranoid. Insane. There's just no possible way… *Except he knows about the twins. Knows about you. Knows about Shigaraki. Who else? Who else could he be?*

No.

You really believed a complete stranger would touch you like that?

No, no, *no.*

Katsuki digs his nails into the sand, trying to steady his body as his head spins. He's dizzy, certain that the palpitations aren't helping him perfuse his overworked brain, but he can't show that weakness to Yagi.

“But… why the twins?” Katsuki says in the most even voice he can manage.

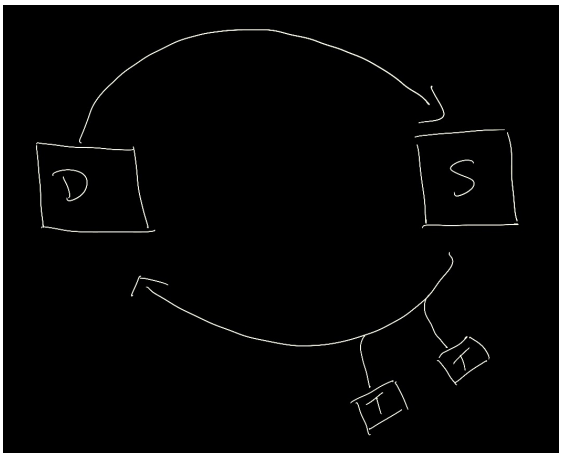
Yagi ponders, looking off into the distance.

“You said all identical twins have this connection, right? Perhaps…”

Yagi stands, suddenly using his cane to draw into the sand next to Katsuki’s equations. He draws two boxes, an arrow going from one to the other.

“The power they share is, perhaps, finite. And if Young Midoriya has access to the same Quirks Shigaraki does, the latter might want… well, a way to store Quirks away from Young Midoriya.”

Off one of the arrows, Yagi draws a two smaller side boxes.



“If what you said holds true, then for Shigaraki to reduce Young Midoriya’s power, he must also maintain distance, reduce his own resistance and reduce the total power available. Assuming the first two are maximized, in their own way, the only way to weaken Young Midoriya is to store some of that power away from his reach.”

“Oh.” Katsuki’s eyes brighten. “So he’s using the twins like capacitors! He takes the Quirk of one of them, maintains the connection with the second, and can give or take Quirks from them at any point without Deku knowing about it! Like his own private storage tanks! And since there are many of them, Deku has no way of knowing who has them or which Quirk he’s hidden where!”

He needs them!

He can’t use it without me!

Another jolt shakes Katsuki’s sternum.

“Which sounds quite smart, but it can certainly backfire. They can push and pull and alter the energy all they want, but the overall energy of the universe must increase. Their struggle might actually be reducing the total stockpile that they both have access to.”

Katsuki furrows his brows. “Huh?”

“You know. The laws of thermodynamics.” Yagi says, like it’s the most obvious thing in the world.

“It’s not a perfect system. Some energy is dissipated in an electrical system, and I assume the same holds for Quirks. So the more they move the Quirks around, the more they flow, the more they’re likely to lose them, right? They’re firmly stuck in the conservation of energy state, forgetting completely about the entropy of the universe.”

Yagi grins to himself, throwing his fingers up, the glint in his eyes a tell-tale sign he’s transitioned into teacher-mode.

“One: conservation of energy. Energy cannot be created or destroyed. Only altered.”

A second finger goes up.

“Two: Energies can flow and equilibrate, but the total energy of the universe must increase. The law of entropy.”

The third finger goes up.

“Three: Entropy at absolute zero is exactly equal to zero.”

Katsuki forgets how to breathe.

“Repeat the last one,” he demands through some force of superhuman willpower as the universe starts to swim before his eyes.

“…The third law of thermodynamics. Entropy at absolute zero is exactly equal to zero.” Yagi repeats, giving Katsuki a curious look.

Here is what Katsuki knows.

Izuku Midoriya likely changed his body to be able to handle more Quirks. He likely has new and different Quirks. He knows the power itself ebbs and flows like electrons, like energy, and thus has to follow the basic laws of physics. Including the laws of thermodynamics.

D3KU.

Three.

Entropy at absolute zero is exactly equal to zero.

Zero.

“Fuck. I have to go. Shit. All Might – Yagi, I’m – “ Katsuki scrambles off the beach, running faster than he’s ever run. Two seconds into the sprint, he simply lets off explosives, launching himself into the air, completely unaware of the civilians pointing up at him from the ground, of the cold air whipping his face, of Yagi staring at him incredulously from the beach.

It can’t be possible.

It can’t. It wouldn’t. *He* wouldn’t.

This whole time…

Katsuki has just enough time scramble through his window before he’s running to the bathroom to empty his guts into the toilet.

Chapter End Notes

Katsuki this chapter:



when ur emotional breakdown is over and u have to do physics

You this chapter:



ho ho ho YES. the amount of pieces of paper i have lying around my apartment in the attempt to make the physics of this work is, frankly, embarrassing. doesn't help that circuits was literally my worst subject. if you're actually smart and these equations look wrong.,.,.,.,., no they dont

KATSUKI KNOWS. OH SHIT HE KNOWS. NEXT CHAPTER IS GONNA HURT LIKE A MOTHERFUCKER! How is he going to handle THAT confrontation I wonder.... 👀 and what does this mean for the twins, and for Zero's plan, and for Katsuki's mental state? find out on next episode of 'Anna's coping mechanisms keep getting weirder and weirder is this bitch okay?? Is this insane-ass bitch okay?!'

Chapter 9

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Katsuki rests his forehead against the cool porcelain, bile fresh and acidic on his tongue. He puts shaking hands under the running faucet, rinsing out his mouth before spitting the vile mixture back into the sink.

Splatters of bright red blood hit the surface, reminiscent of flicked-off paint on an ivory canvas. Katsuki watches with a profound indifference as the droplets disappear down the drain.

After all, it's not the first time he's bled for Deku.

Deku is Zero.

Zero is Deku.

His stomach rolls and Katsuki bites into the back of his hand in a desperate attempt to prevent himself from vomiting again.

Its Deku that's using kids as part of his plan, Deku that's 'hurt people,' Deku that's acting as a vigilante, Deku that's been hiding directly under his nose for fuck knows how long, laughing at him behind his back, fucking *taunting* him…

Can't be. A laugh bursts out of Katsuki's chest, loud and unexpected. Can't be Deku. Deku would never fucking *act* like this. He wouldn't do *any* of this. Especially not…

Katsuki's skin burns along the paths the other had outlined with his hands. Each trace of fingertips now feels corrosive, leaving a trail of rotting skin and bubbling fat. His skin suddenly feels too constrictive, too tight against Katsuki's body, and the invasive thought of filleting it all off runs through his mind before he dismisses it, but not before his nails find his forearm and gouge into his own flesh. Objectively, it should hurt. Katsuki doesn't feel a goddamn thing.

It was Deku? This whole time? Deku who touched him, who kissed him, who -

Katsuki feels the nausea crest against the back of his throat and he digs his elbows into the counter, gasping as sour spittle runs down his chin.

Why? What could his motivation possibly be? Was he simply testing him with this persona, this fake name and fake face? Trying to see if Katsuki figured it out, if he was worthy of being trusted, and made the conclusion that he was not? But fuck, he *saw* Katsuki's wall, he *knew* Katsuki was still looking, and said *nothing.*

Why? Why toy with him like this? Why engage him, talk to him, sleep in his bed, be where Katsuki can always find him? Why kiss him, why hold him, Jesus, why *fuck* him?!

You're the only one that remembers him'.

Katsuki feels all the air leave his lungs as the thought comes to him, crystal-clear, like it's been there all along.

He said so himself. He's been alone for a long time. No one to talk to. No one to touch.

And Katsuki just… showed up. Offered himself up like a goddamn whore. Pushed himself onto him.

He tried to stop Katsuki. He couldn't even stomach looking at him.

'*You're disgusting. You disgust him. You're so pathetic even Deku had to throw you a pity fuck.'*

Katsuki stares up at the ceiling, mouth open in soundless hysterics.

He wouldn't.

There's patronizing, and then there's just *cruel.* And Deku is a lot of things, but he's not cruel.

'You don't think so?' The voice makes Katsuki's eyes open wide, and he looks around frantically, aware the sound would have to leave a corpse's lips but unable to ignore the way he feels the tepid air leaving the other's mouth.

'Wasn't it cruel to leave you? To disappear for years and tell you nothing? After everything you did for him? After everything you two have been through? He took your dream, left you with this broken body and this broken mind, and you don't think he's capable of cruelty?'

Out of the corner of his eyes, Katsuki can see two blue marbles being juggled between charred knuckles.

'He's got you fooled. Just like the rest of them.'

"SHUT UP!"

The sound of the mirror crashing brings Katsuki back to full consciousness. He watches the shards clatter to the floor, his bloodied knuckles leaving a linear smear of blood from where they embed half-way between the glass and the wall. He blinks a few times, swallowing, not remembering making a fist or taking a swing. This isn't a hallucination or a dream – the pain cements him firmly in this reality.

The top-hat asshole is gone, the voices are gone, and now it's just him. Him, alone with himself. He'd rather be dancing in hell with Mr. Compress himself.

He stares at what's left of his reflection, just a red-rimmed eye, pupils pinpoint, mouth open and heaving.

He looks down at his knuckles and tentatively moves them, wincing slightly at the feeling of glass scraping between his bones. Nothing broken.

The question still stands.

Can Izuku Midoriya be capable of something *this* sadistic?

Who is worse, the dog-owner who leaves their dog at the pound, or the pound that euthanizes the unwanted animal? Deku abandoned him, sure, perhaps with the naïve idea that Katsuki might have a better, safer life without him. But Zero? Zero touched his skin, brushed through his hair, looked at him with such profound affection that Katsuki nearly believed there's something more to his life than constant agony – all before injecting him with this lethal poison.

This. This is the killing blow.

Four years spent trying desperately to save Deku. Four years of destroying his heart, his soul, his sanity, his pride. He's given up everything – only to find out he's lost him. He's truly lost him.

Katsuki surprises himself as a soft gasp of air leaves his lips, the fresh tears prickling in the corners of his eyes unrelated to the blood in his mouth or pooling on his knuckles.

He's never mourned Deku, because there was nothing to mourn. But now?

There's no worse fate than this. This isn't the person he knew.

And that hurts worse than any physical pain Katsuki could inflict on himself.

The Deku he knew is gone.

No more constant trailing footsteps. No more declarations of rivalry or murmurs of admiration. No more chipmunk cheeks, awkward blushes, gangly limbs. No more laughter like windchimes. No more warm smiles, always in his direction, always expecting nothing in return. No more crooked fingers pulling back before they touch him, no more averted meeting of the eyes, no more excuses to get the other pinned under him.

It's all gone. That too-white smile, the scattered curls, the vibrant greens of his eyes, those irritating incandescent freckles. Even his grotesquely scarred right arm, a testament to his drive to save above all else, is gone. Just… gone.

Sixteen years ago, a chubby right hand reached out to him after he fell into a river, and Katsuki did not take it. He did not take it then, and now he never will.

If he had just tried harder. If he just found him earlier. If he solved his fucking puzzle. If he had *known,* would the outcome be the same?

Is that really all Deku left for him? A half-hearted explanation of why he left? No way to follow him? No way to help? Just a shitty fucking *reason,* like that makes it any better?!

All for One might have taken Izuku Midoriya away from U.A., from his mother, from all those that loved him, but *Zero* took Izuku away from Katsuki. Decayed each sun-soaked memory with his cancerous touch.

He's not going to get away with this. Not with this.

Katsuki takes steady, even breaths, mind beautifully clear as the plan solidifies in his head. He reaches under the sink, pulling out the first aid kit, dressing his knuckles mechanically. He quickly sweeps the broken glass, tossing it in the trash before padding back over to his study. He sits in his chair, swiveling around the room until the pictures blur into an odd cacophony of reds and greens.

Katsuki has two choices. He can just lay down and die like a bitch. Or he can gnash his teeth, growl and bite and fight until his last fucking breath.

Katsuki knows Izuku Midoriya.

Knows how to confirm it's him.

Knows where to hit him where it hurts.

He dials into the Pro Hero Emergency station, holding his mouth against the microphone. A logical part of his brain knows this isn't a good idea. Using this channel and reporting a false crime is a felony offense. If he gets found out, it's not just his license – he could be facing jail time. If not for this, then certainly for all the illegal shit in his apartment, or the fact that he's allowed a vigilante to run free.

"Come in. This is Pro Hero Dynamight. Requesting backup in Keiyo Industrial Zone. Engaged with unknown hostile. Over."

Katsuki holds his breath at the silence that follows. After an eternity, the radio crackles back to life, familiar voice shooting razorblades under Katsuki's skin.

"Pro Hero Dynamight, Team Idaten Pro Heroes Ingenium and Uravity have been dispatched to your location. Please send coordinates."

The class rep is as reliable as ever.

Katsuki smiles to himself as he quickly dons his hero gear. He leaves his apartment through the roof, explosions lighting up the night sky as he glides through the air.

He lands on the roof of what looks like an abandoned factory, letting his heartrate come down as he breathes deeply. After a few more seconds, he pins his location on the map and sends out his coordinates. He puts his phone away, flexes his fingers and lifts up both arms, palms flat as if reaching out to hold the stars.

The scream erupts out of his chest, deep and guttural as his palms blaze, a tower of fire and smoke forming a giant homing beacon. Its nearly euphoric – the sheer power from his hands, the heat from the explosion, the haunting way his flames make the shadows dance against the abandoned buildings, his own voice, explosive in its own way, mingling with the popping and crackling of his Quirk.

It takes seconds for the second set of feet to land on the roof. Katsuki stops the combustion process, turning to the other, sick sense of satisfaction at the sight of that black body suit.

"You're so goddamn predictable." Katsuki states as the approaches the other.

"…Where's the villain?" Zero asks, like an idiot. Katsuki grins.

"Right fucking *here.*"

Katsuki propels himself forward with a slurry of forceful explosions, body slamming into the other before he has a chance to react. They both tumble to the ground, Katsuki rolling a few feet before springing back to his feet and darting forward. Zero's – Deku's – instincts must have kicked in, finally, because he stands back up with an astounding speed, taking on a defensive position.

Katsuki throws his fist at the other's face, and Zero dodges his right hook like he's done it a million times before.

Because he had.

"WHAT ARE YOU DOING?!" Zero yells, but Katsuki doesn't answer, instead kicking the other man's abdomen hard, distracting him long enough to let off a large explosion to the face.

The mask might be flame retardant, but it certainly still conducts heat.

Katsuki is proven right as Zero hurriedly strips the mask off, a large red welt already forming on his cheek. He sees something furious flash behind those placid eyes.

“FIGHT ME!” Katsuki screams, unleashing another explosion to his chest, knocking the other to the ground.

“STOP! STOP THIS! WHY ARE YOU DOING THIS?!” Zero looks up at him, body still limp like he has no intention of fighting back. That betrayed look in his eyes makes Katsuki’s stomach churn uncomfortably, and he ignores it. He uses the steel toe of his boot to kick the other’s chest, forcing his torso to meet concrete.

“DEFEND YOURSELF!”

He kicks hard, against the place where he broke the other’s ribs just a few days ago, surprised to find the other barely flinching. He kicks again, kicks until he’s breathless, kicks until his leg hurts, boot against stomach, against thigh, against arm, and the fucker does *nothing,* just lays there and takes it.

“FIGHT ME YOU GODDAMN FUCKING COWARD!”

Katsuki angles his leg up and stomps down on the other’s chest with all his weight.

Or, at least, he tries to.

He’s stopped by a long, sharp while spear-shaped bone bursting out of Zero’s organic arm, ripping straight through his suit.

Katsuki holds his breath.

Spearlike Bones.

He remembers this quirk quite well. Can still picture the gore as it manifested on All for One’s monstrous arm in Kamino.

The welt on the other's cheek starts to disappear before Katsuki’s very eyes.

Katsuki was right. Deku has new quirks. Not just that, he *took them* from Shigaraki.

“Stop your dastardly deeds, villain!” the voice rings out from behind Katsuki, and he can’t help the sick satisfied smile that spreads across his face as Zero’s eyes widen, mouth slackening, true *fear* marring his features.

“’Bout time!” Katsuki yells, hopping back to join Ingenium and Uravity, giving Zero just enough time to stand back up. Zero crouches, backing away slowly, eyes wild and mouth grimacing.

“We made it here as soon as we could!” Ingenium insists, clapping Katsuki hard on the back, making him lurch forward.

Uravity says nothing. Her eyes stay fixed to Zero, eyebrows lifted, and for a brief second Katsuki thinks that she might have *recognized* him, saw through whatever Quirk he’s using, but he’s instantly proven wrong as she rushes towards him, using her body to stand in front of the door marked *Exit* that Zero was trying to inch towards.

“This is the fucker that kidnapped the Shiryoku twins.” Katsuki states to Ingenium who nods behind his full armor in response.

“Understood! We will alert Gang Orca as soon as he’s in custody!” Ingenium reassures Katsuki before crouching down in his classic battle stance.

Katsuki rolls his eyes and scoffs, but joins him.

Zero takes a tiny step back, closer to the edge of the roof, hands up.

“Please. Stay back. Don’t – “

They rush him simultaneously. Dynamight, Uravity and Ingenium come from three different angles, leaving the edge of the roof the only place he can go.

Surrounded, Zero does exactly what Katsuki thought he’d do.

He activates Float.

Fucker’s lucky that flying quirks are a dime a dozen, because if it was anything else, he would have given himself away.

“NOT TODAY!”

In perfect synchrony and without so much as a signal, Uravity taps Katsuki, and using his explosions, he rushes through the air towards Zero, grabbing onto his metallic arm and spinning him, slamming his body back down to the roof with as much force as he could generate.

The roof cracks as Zero’s spine meets concrete, and the earth-shaking sound of a dozen windows shattering echoes into the empty alleys.

“AND RELEASE!” Uravity yells as Katsuki nears the ground, Ingenium on Zero instantly, knee to his back, keeping the other pinned to the ground.

Katsuki approaches the body slowly, Uravity at his side, Ingenium digging handcuffs out of his utility belt.

How does it feel? How does it feel to have your best friends look at you like you’re a monster? How does it feel to mean nothing to them now?

How does it feel?

Zero’s eyes dart wildly, back and forth across the three of them, and Katsuki can see those gears turning in his head. Like a cornered animal, Zero’s going to do something drastic.

Katsuki wants to see it.

But not today.

“Enough of this.”

They don’t see it coming. Uravity’s wrist, the nape of Ingenium’s neck. Both bodies drop to the ground instantly, Katsuki’s thick nitroglycerin glistening on their skin.

Zero stares up at him, mouth agape.

“What the hell are you doing?!” Zero looks frenzied, glancing to the two heroes on the ground. Katsuki hit them with a small dose – it should be a few seconds before the both of them are conscious.

“Are you insane? You have to get out of here! This – they’re going to arrest you for this! You have to go!”

“Don’t worry about me! I just beat the shit out of you, and you’re worried about *me?*” Katsuki laughs in Zero’s face, vitriol burning in the back of his throat. He fights to prevent his voice from cracking, tears threatening to give away his true feelings.

Maybe Izuku Midoriya isn’t as gone as he thought.

“PLEASE!”

“FUCK YOU!”

Katsuki can swear he sees a flicker of electric green behind the other’s eyes before he’s floating through the air, fire-man carried in the other’s arms. He tries to squirm, letting out explosions into the other’s chest, but he doesn’t let go, doesn’t even flinch.

Katsuki recognizes the place Zero is taking him before they even get there.

Katsuki had grown intimately familiar with the riot shelters civilians hid in while him and his classmates were above ground, trying to stop the world from burning down.

Zero darts past the conveniently placed bushes hiding the underground walkway. At the end, a large metallic door stands between them and the bunker. Effortlessly, Zero slams it open with one arm like it weighs nothing, and brings Katsuki inside. It shuts behind him with a deafening *SLAM!* Katsuki looks around, oddly comfortable with his position in the other’s arms. Zero brings him into a room containing multiple rows of bunk beds, dusty and abandoned, one with unmade sheets. A singular lamp remains on next to said bed, a stack of books the only things on the dirty floor.

This is where he’s been living.

Zero sits Katsuki down gingerly on one of the bottom bunks, wordlessly disappearing into another room. In this moment, Katsuki vaguely realizes there’s a small pool of blood forming at the base of his feet.

He lifts his leg up, surprised to find a gash still weeping blood from his calf.

His stupid Spearlike Bones punctured through his boots, pants and straight through his skin. Katsuki was so goddamn hopped up on adrenaline he didn’t even notice. Here, in the quiet, his heart rate settling down, fresh burning pain blooms at the site of the injury.

“…You’re hurt.” Zero states, showing him the box filled with medical supplies.

“Fuckin’ obviously,” Katsuki rolls his eyes. Zero gives him a harsh look before dropping to his knees in front of Katsuki.

The sight of Zero on his knees makes his heart skip a beat.

He watches the other meticulously work with his left hand, rinsing out the cut with saline, dabbing gently against the uneven edges of sheared skin. The cut is relatively deep and uneven. The guilty look on Zero’s face is delicious – Katsuki decides to rub it in. Just a bit.

“This needs stitches,” Katsuki says absently. Zero gives him a semi-annoyed look, bringing out the medical grade needle and thread from the First Aid kit. Zero must have raided the hospital – Katsuki

spies surgical tools in the same compartment.

The welt on his cheek is entirely gone – Deku must have stolen *Regeneration*, so it's not like he *needs* medical supplies. Although, all things considered, Shigaraki might steal it back. Deku is nothing if not obnoxiously overprepared.

One handed, the vigilante clips the forceps on the needle. He tries to pull on Katsuki's skin with his metallic hand – but its flimsy, and the needle is too small, and Zero can't control his wrist. Katsuki says nothing, watching the other struggle, frustration growing more and more obvious on his face.

"Damn it!" Zero finally exhales, hitting his metallic arm on the concrete below them, making a resounding *thunk* throughout the room. He bends over, chest trembling, looking like he's working incredibly hard to maintain his composure.

"Here," Katsuki says, gingerly taking the forceps and needle out of the other's hand. Their fingers brush, skin on skin too electric to be imagined, and Zero's incredulous look, red-rimmed and glossy eyes make Katsuki almost not want to murder the man in front of him. Almost.

He takes off his gloves, shoving one of them between his teeth as he curls his wrist, needle through the skin. Ties it off. Directs Zero to cut; which he does, like an over eager student, rapt attention on the deftness of his hands. It barely hurts, if Katsuki's honest. Four superficial stitches approximate the skin enough, and Katsuki hands the needle back to Zero, only to be met with some kind of sparkling wonderment that is so distinctly *Deku* that Katsuki nearly forgets where the fuck he is and what the fuck he's doing. But sitting here on this horrible bunk bed, in this shelter used to house civilians while he lost his childhood and heart above ground nearly four years ago, Zero on his knees in front of him, a giant of a man with the saddest goddamn eyes he's ever seen, Katsuki feels… well. A certain sense of correctness in all of this.

"Why the hell did you do that?" Zero's eyes are fixed on Katsuki's, and Katsuki suppresses the urge to laugh in his face.

To hurt you.

"I'm helping," Katsuki lies, shrugging his shoulders.

"…How was that *helping?*" Zero clips back, irritation obvious in his tone. Katsuki tries to keep himself from laughing.

"If you can't take on a couple of rookie proes, how are you supposed to take on Shigaraki? I had to help you train. Gotta make sure I'm backing the right player, right?"

Zero's lip twitches up in a grimace, and he looks away, huffing something under his breath.

"So. You've got multiple quirks." Katsuki says evenly, casually, like they're just talking about the weather. He tries not to smirk when the other's eyes shoot open, obvious panic across his face.

"Uh."

"What, you one of All for One's goons or somethin'?"

Katsuki mentally pats himself on the back as fast relief flashes across Zero's face. He clearly hadn't thought this part through.

"…Something like that, yeah." Zero says, rubbing the back of his neck.

They sit in utter silence. Katsuki can imagine the chaos outside their doors right now. Ingenium and Uravity waking up on a destroyed roof, remembering fighting *someone* with him, and then Katsuki suddenly disappearing. Katsuki frowns. If he's 'missing,' that means his mother will be contacted, and his apartment will certainly be raided.

Better get them off his trail.

Katsuki picks up his phone, not missing the way Zero bristles at the sight of it. He quickly dials into the Pro Hero Network. When the dial-tone devolves into the crackling sound of radio, Katsuki speaks.

"Come in. This is Pro Hero Dynamight – lost target in pursuit. Currently safe. Team Idaten dismissed."

Zero's eyes flash with something complicated at the name, and Katsuki can audibly hear the other hold his breath as a woman's voice comes over the line.

"Pro Hero Dynamight, would appreciate heads up next time before you put us out. We expect a full report faxed to the agency by morning. Uravity and Ingenium, out."

Katsuki looks back up at Zero, staring at his phone with rapt attention, and instant rage erupts in Katsuki's chest for absolutely no goddamn reason.

He swallows it down and tosses his phone to the end of the bed, forcing Zero's eyes to go right back to where they belong – on Katsuki's face.

"What happened to your arm?" Katsuki asks, voice softer to his ears than he's ever heard it before.

"…W-what?" Zero chokes out, eyebrows furrowing. He shifts his knees so he can move back slightly from his spot kneeling in front of Katsuki.

"Your arm. How did you lose your arm?"

"…I don't. I don't understand. Why are you asking me that?" Zero's eyes open wider and he laughs wildly. "Why? What does it matter?"

"…Does it hurt?"

Zero's spine shoots straight up, like the man's been electrocuted, such utter bewilderment in his eyes that Katsuki thinks the other has never been asked that question before. He maintains quiet, keeps watching the way Zero reacts, first with utter indignation, then, some kind of resolute defeat.

"…Constantly." Zero admits, left hand traveling to his right shoulder. "The… arm doesn't fit well. I have a hard time controlling it. But it's the only prototype that could handle – " Zero cuts himself off, biting his tongue, and with a certain satisfaction Katsuki can finish that sentence for him. 'The only prototype that wouldn't instantly get wrecked by your shitty Quirk, huh?'

"Why not fix it? I know good engineers."

"I…" Zero pauses, eyes darting away. "Its… I don't really mind the pain, I guess. I don't really remember what anything other than pain feels like."

"…That sounds like a shit life," Katsuki replies, chest aching. Pain was a cornerstone of the things that Deku felt, even when they were classmates – but there was more, at some point. Not that Katsuki really ever knew. He must have been happy, sometimes. Sad, sometimes. Nervous, excited,

embarrassed. He always showed each emotion so easily on his face; but they never talked. He didn't really know. This is probably the most direct and honest Deku's ever been with him, which Katsuki would find hilarious if it wasn't twisting his entire heart into a pretzel.

"It's the one I have," Zero shrugs. He grabs the First Aid kit, as if trying to find something to do, and walks to the other room. He hears a sink turn on – the bathroom, Katsuki concludes – and Zero exits after a moment, wiping his hands on a grubby-looking towel. He sits on the bunk across from Katsuki, sigh escaping his lips as he stares down at the floor.

What a miserable creature.

"Why haven't you done it?" Katsuki wonders aloud.

"Done what?"

"Killed yourself. You keep begging me to do it, but why not do it yourself? Seems like you're perfectly capable of ending lives."

A sardonic smile spreads across Zero's face.

"…Not that easy. It's not that I haven't… *tried.* My decisions aren't," Zero face scrunches into something odd, like he wants to confess to something before he decides otherwise, "…Entirely… always my own. Besides, they're right – I don't even know if it will work, if it will fix the problem. It just feels, sometimes… like it would be so much… *easier*. And if it's you…"

"They?" Katsuki cuts him off, the sheer implication that Deku would do anything to shorten his own life making his hands ignite with pools of sweat. The irony of that isn't lost on Katsuki.

Zero shuts his mouth so tight Katsuki can nearly hear it snap. Does Zero have colleagues, other people he's working with? He said that no one remembers him, that he's been alone for a long time, so why…

"Anyway. I have a plan. But if I die, I die. It… really doesn't make a difference."

Zero looks far away, and Katsuki frowns in response.

"You really think your life doesn't matter?"

A surprised laugh punches out of the other's chest, and Katsuki stares at him with fascination. Marrying endlessly optimistic, driven, almost foolhardy Deku with this nihilistic broken man in front of him… It makes something tender unfurl inside Katsuki's empty chest cavity, and Katsuki shifts on the bed at the feeling.

"… Not really. I'm – " Zero huffs out, looking up at the ceiling before shaking his head in amused resignation.

"I've had… a long time to think about my purpose. My place in this universe. In the grand scheme of things, I'm really – I'm nobody. I'm just an actor in this endless play, and the second I can't perform, I will be replaced. There's thousands, maybe millions waiting to pick up the mantle. The show goes on. The universe doesn't stop for anybody, and it certainly won't for me."

The sunken appearance of Zero's eyes and the monotony of his voice make it clear that he's thought about this extensively. But there's a certain peace in those resigned words. Like he's not that sixteen year old kid with the world on his shoulders anymore – just a man that has accepted his fate.

“On a smaller scale.. Well. People move on. The world changes. *I’ve* changed. I’ve been dead for a long time to anyone that matters. And I’m satisfied with the person that lives on in their memory. He was a person I was proud of. It would be cruel to ruin that for the people I love.”

The shrine with the constant fresh flowers and incense flash through Katsuki’s mind. The picture of Izuku Midoriya in middle school, ageless and unchanging, always the sweet, caring, doting son. Certainly Inko would want her son *alive,* rather than some sugar-soaked inaccurate memory; not this caricature of the true man her son was growing to become. Has grown to be. Mangled and scarred and *different.*

“… So what’s going to happen to you after we get Shigaraki?” Katsuki asks, narrowing his eyes.

Zero only shrugs. “I don’t know. If I survive, I guess I’ll just… disappear.”

Katsuki’s stomach flips. This motherfucker. Deku has no intention of actually coming back to his life. No intention of coming back to Inko, or his nerd-friends, or Katsuki himself.

“I’ll come with you.”

Zero nods softly before his head shoots up, eyes comically wide as his jaw drops in wordless protest. Katsuki keeps his face carefully even – serious.

“…What?” Zero chokes out, barely able to get the word past his lips.

“Yeah. I’ll come with you. It’s better than being alone, isn’t it? I’ve got nothing for me here. Disappearing doesn’t sound half bad.”

“…You. You can’t.”

Katsuki shrugs, catching the concerned glint in the other’s eye.

“Why not? If this vigilante shit is good enough for you, it’s good enough for me. Plus these digs are pretty dope. Rents probably cheap as fuck.”

Zero laughs, actually laughs, hiding his smile behind his hand, and Katsuki can’t help but smirk in response. There he is. The look Zero levels at him is so fucking soft Katsuki can feel his cheeks heat up instantly.

“That doesn’t sound too bad, actually. Traveling the world, hopping from underground bunker to underground bunker with you..” Zero says, affection saturating his words.

And if he meant it, if Deku would have been honest for one goddamn second, that could have been the end of it. Katsuki tells himself he would have confronted him, talked shit out, worked together. Things didn’t have to be like this.

But if Katsuki knows anything, he knows Izuku Midoriya.

And this fucker is lying through his teeth.

Katsuki stands up, brain empty except for narrowing the distance between them. Zero briefly looks panicked before he’s holding his arms out, trying to prevent Katsuki from getting too close.

“I come with perks. Lots of ‘em.”

“Katsuki. You need to – we shouldn’t – this isn’t a good idea.” He’s starting to sound like a broken record, and Katsuki’s eyebrow twitches, just an inkling of irritation marring his carefully crafted expression.

He doesn’t sound like he’s sure of what he’s saying, so tentative and sad, but Katsuki pushes past his blockade easily, towering over the other. Zero watches him like he’s mesmerized, body stiff under Katsuki’s persistent glare.

“Zero – “ Katsuki’s hand cups the other man’s face, fingers tracing along his cheek.

He massages behind the other’s ear and Zero’s eyelashes flutter, tiny sigh escaping from his lips.

“Katsuki…” he starts his half-hearted protest, body not congruent with his words as his left hand finds itself on Katsuki’s hip, thumb gracing along the hem of his shift. Katsuki leans forward further – in this proximity, the scent of the other is potent – simple soap, lavender, something pungent like grease or gasoline – Katsuki’s not quite sure; no matter what it is, it leaves him feeling heady and delirious.

His hands are on him, and he doesn’t know when they got there.

Deku touching him. Deku’s hands, Deku’s body, Deku’s tongue –

It should be a dealbreaker. Katsuki knows that it should be. But like all foolish beasts are lured to dangerous things, Katsuki feels his control slipping by the second at the hot press of fingertips against his hip and at that desperate, hungry look in the other’s eyes.

“Fuck. Goddamn it.”

Katsuki leans down, heart jumping around wildly in his ribcage, fingers trembling uncharacteristically as he gently, ever so gently, slots their lips together. All fire, spit and force in the past, this kiss is…. Gentle.

This isn’t the way they normally kiss – he’s aware of it. He’s not sure he’s ever kissed anyone like this – not sure he’s ever felt like this when he’s kissed someone. He feels the other’s tongue press lightly against his lips and he opens up to the other, opens all of himself (*it’s all that he can do and how can someone belong to someone so completely without losing a part of themselves?)*

Katsuki feels it fully as his tongue skirts the other’s swollen lips, as they deepen their hold on each other, as fingertips start to hold tighter, anchoring them to each other, two pieces of wreckage in a tumultuous sea.

He feels like he’s losing himself in the other, and he really doesn’t mind.

He’s the same man. The same. Why does it being Deku change things?

Katsuki knows. Maybe, in some way, Katsuki’s always known. It’s not something he has a name for, not something he’s ever really acknowledged, but now its staring him dead in the face and he’d be a fool to ignore it any longer. This gravitational pull, this desire to be closer, the constant strive to be within the other’s orbit, to be the center of the other’s attention – in whichever form it came, fear or admiration or – or whatever the hell this is… this has always been there.

Katsuki places a hand over the other’s heart – he’s unsure why, but feels that pulse hammering away, and with some sick satisfaction knows, in some way, some primordial, basic way that he will never truly understand, they are the same. Maybe they always have been.

Katsuki's mouth travels down his jaw, peppering kisses along the angle, sucking marks against the other's neck. Zero gasps as Katsuki bites down before sucking the sensitive skin between his lips, leaving fresh bruises that will certainly heal by morning before moving on to a fresh spot to mark.

"We. We can't keep doing this. I don't like doing this. I don't want this - "

Katsuki huffs in annoyance, climbing onto the other's lap, feeling the other man's erection against his thighs. Deku's body, aroused by him. Wanting him. Fuck, it makes him feel delirious. His mouth floods with saliva and he can't explain the sudden urgency brewing in his loins.

"If you don't like this, why do you get so turned on just from a little kissing, huh?" Katsuki smirks to himself, something daring overcoming him as he pins the other to the bed, hand skirting up his legs to outline the his obvious erection. Katsuki almost wants to laugh at the light blush painting the other's cheeks under what Katsuki can only assume is some kind of makeup. He imagines a field of freckles in their wake and sharp, hopeless arousal pierces his gut.

"Stop!" Zero flips them over, instantly, effortlessly, leaving Katsuki staring up at the other's conflicted face above him. He looks devastated, arm shaking again, body hovering above his own but not touching.

"*S-stop*…." Zero actually stutters, hanging his head down and Katsuki's heart follows suit.

"I can't. I *can't.* Not when – Is this… is this what you do? You give yourself to anyone that looks at you?! It doesn't matter to you, but for me - You're getting in my head, and it almost makes me – I just - " Zero shakes his head, and Katsuki swears he can see fresh tears glazing the other's eyes before he blinks sharply, eyebrows furrowing. His frown turns into a scowl, and he leans in deeper, something much more threatening clouding his gaze.

"It's not fair. You give this part of yourself, your mouth and your body and your time, to a complete stranger. To me - someone whose name you don't even know. How many, huh? How many people have you let fuck you when you never even – when I was –" Between furious tears and flashing canines, Katsuki doesn't know whether the other is going to weep or bite. For some reason, he feels himself grow harder under the intense stare.

"Do you even understand? Even try? Do you know how insane you make me feel?" Frantic eyes meet Katsuki's, and the heat in them is scorching. "Do you know how much I want to add more scars to your body, hurt you, tie you up and leave you in this room, never let you leave my sight – "

Katsuki shudders, whole body warm and syrupy at the frantic words. His hands finds his way to his own cock, and he starts to stroke to Zero's words, soft puffs of air leaving his mouth as he arches his back, just slightly, at his own touch.

"I want to choke you, bruise you, make you bleed, fuck you so hard you never look at another man again – "

"*K...keep talking…*" Katsuki rasps out, orgasm building which such rapidity with barely any stimulation that its making his head spin. Zero's – Deku's – voice, furious, threatening, *possessive* makes goosebumps erupt from the base of his neck down to his very feet, each nerve feeling alive under those words.

"Don't you DARE get off on this!" Zero's arm is on his, forcefully grabbing his hand from his cock and thrusting it above his head

Zero's voice breaks and Katsuki watches him. "You're giving me *everything* except for what I really want! Why? Why do this to me? Do you think it's funny?"

He bends down, the curve of his hard dick pressing against Katsuki's thigh, and Katsuki gasps at the contact, his own hips curving up to meet him, for more friction, the delicious pain in his wrists barely taking the attention away from the frantic beating of his heart.

"How could I want that? How could I want to take everything from you? How could I want to make you hurt like that? Am I some kind of monster…?" Zero thrusts his hips forward, cockhead rubbing against Katsuki's thighs, more insistent, demanding, and Katsuki moans at it, reveling in the fluttering of the other's dark eyelashes at the sound of his voice.

It's a valid question. Katsuki's wondered it himself. To consume and to be consumed. Ouroboros, devouring his own tail, his own sustenance and destruction, to die and to be reborn again. Him and Deku are both the head and the tail. Desiring an end, a beginning, a wholeness that is forever unreachable to them in these separate bodies. They share what they can, with spit and blood and cum, but it's never enough. It's never going to be enough.

For some insane reason, Katsuki's mind drifts to Tomura Shigaraki – the person who holds 50% of Izuku's very soul – and hates him with such an intensity he's nearly breathless with it.

"What's wrong with being a monster…?" Katsuki asks, and those hazy eyes shoot to him, teeth between his lip. His hand squeezes tighter against Katsuki's wrist.

What's wrong with hiding away the thing that's precious, protecting it, even if it's with fangs and claws? Why blame the dragon in the castle?

Why not fight for what is *yours?*

Zero's thumb rubs against his wrist in such a tender manner Katsuki wants to weep. The expression on the other's face is unreadable, somewhere between aroused and furious and utterly devastated. Katsuki finds that he likes it.

"What's wrong with taking what you want?" Katsuki goads further, licking his lips with intention, reveling in the way the man above him seems to be entranced, dark irises following each movement. It reminds Katsuki of a snake – quiet, seemingly placid until the right moment strikes, until he flashes his fangs and takes Katsuki into his maw.

And if that's all Katsuki is? A meal, something to tide him over, something to nourish him briefly, that's fine. If the only time Katsuki will be held by him is when he's ensnared by the serpents powerful body, waiting for his own demise, then so be it. Sometimes you matter in any way you can, even if it's not the way you want.

"You can't give me what I want," Zero responds, somber, eyes darting away from him for a second. Katsuki's heart actually clenches at that – a clear reminder of being *not enough* to the only person worth being something to.

"Then let me give you what I have," Katsuki says, and he means it. The words feel grand leaving his lips, a confession of something undying and pious. Zero doesn't seem to interpret it as such, consummate pain flashing at those words before, as always, he carefully reapplies the mask, gives him a short nod, and unhinges his jaw.

Zero leans in until Katsuki can feel his lavender-scented breath against his own.

His lips taste like absolution.

It was Deku, defenseless, Quirkless, timid, sweet Deku who fucked his mouth, who choked him out, fucked his ass so hard he could hardly walk. It was fucking *Deku*, this entire fucking time, dominating him, hurting him, making him orgasm over and over again. Of fucking course it was, because who could take care of him, know him, like Deku does? Katsuki exhales hard, putting some pressure on his straining cock. Somewhere in the weird mix of devastation, anger, arousal and affection, he's… finding that he's more turned on knowing it was Deku.

Knowing what he's about to do to Deku.

Katsuki feels like he's going insane – his head is foggy, his chest hurts, his heart is beating so fast that there just can't be enough oxygen going to his brain. Katsuki nips at the lips, hands digging hard into Zero's – Deku's - shoulders, moving his head so he can deepen the kiss, consume him fully, taste every single inch of him.

When he pulls back, they are both gasping for breath, pink blush painting Zero's face under his makeup. His long eyelashes flutter up, and Katsuki is punched in the stomach with something affectionate and heart stopping that Katsuki refuses to put a name to.

From on top of him, Zero grabs the back of his uniform, pulling it over his head seamlessly, tossing it away, revealing his hard torso and the symphony of scars adorning his body. Katsuki's eyes roam him, every inch of him, drinking in the sight before him as sweet saliva floods his mouth.

He must have acquired the *Regeneration* quirk more recently, because his skin is an absolute wreck. Katsuki's eyes trail along the hypertrophic scars at the point of attachment of the prosthetic arm, the smooth scar abutting shining metal.

Zero's eyes are hazy, and he dashes forward, capturing Katsuki's lips in his own as he rolls his hips, dick rubbing insistently at Katsuki's thigh. Katsuki's hands are on his torso, feeling everything he hasn't allowed himself to feel. It feels like he's committing a crime of some sort – like he's entered a museum and put his hands on the cold, ageless marble, a piece of art too precious for his nitroglycerin soaked hands.

Zero's lips move along his jaw before tongue and lips and teeth start to work their way into the tender muscles along his neck. Katsuki groans, goosebumps erupting along his chest, pebbling his nipples. Zero sucks hard into the skin, soothing with his tongue, teeth grazing the lobe of his ear. This close, he can hear the nearly frantic breathing, feel every aborted exhale, every overwhelmed whine. Katsuki's hands travel lower, desperate to hear the man on top of him moan into his ear.

Hands trail down the other's body, rubbing against the nubs of his nipples, along the toned V-shape of his abdomen, past the troublesome waistband. Katsuki touches hard, pulsating skin, the heat and musk built in the other's pants overwhelmingly appetizing to Katsuki's delirious mind.

Katsuki swallows, something in his chest constricting at the invasive thought of *this is Deku. Deku, this hard for me. Deku, this desperate for me. Deku knows it me, can't say no to me, wants me.* He rubs his fingertips against the other's straining cockhead, rewarded by the sharp exhale against his ear, followed by a poorly suppressed, guttural moan. He feels the other's forearms shake, bringing their bodies slightly closer.

Katsuki's hummingbird heart betrays what his desperate mind is trying to protect him from.

There's a wrongness in this – Katsuki knows. Katsuki *knows,* because Deku did it to *him.* There's a difference between Katsuki thinking he's fucking a stranger, and Katsuki fucking Deku. There's a difference between Deku fucking a Katsuki who doesn't know it's him, and surely there would be one if he knew that Katsuki knows.

Katsuki licks his lips as he gets his member completely out of the other's pants, using his own nitroglycerin to slick his way down the other's cock. Katsuki's had a magical time in his early teens finding out that nitroglycerin being a vasodilator meant that it was a vasodilator in the vessels of your dick as well. Many a fainting episodes with dick in his hands later, Katsuki's become an expert.

Zero's already impossibly hard cock somehow gets harder, angry red and throbbing as Katsuki continued to jerk him, hips lifting off the bed in a hopeless attempt to get his own erection some relief. He's so drunk off the sounds coming from the other's mouth that's he's pretty sure if he heard that voice, licking against his earlobe and leaving bruises on his nape moan out *Kacchan* he's pretty sure he'd cum without being touched. That very thought is insane enough that Katsuki wants to laugh, wondering what he'd have to do to the other, how much he'd have to fry the other's brain with lust to get him to slip up like that. To take four years of careful secrecy, only to give it all away as Katsuki rides his cock.

"Ah – I - please – " Zero's voice whispers, and he jerks out of Katsuki's grip, on his knees, cheeks flushed, lips slick with spit and eyes completely hazy. Katsuki exhales shakily as the other takes his hand, circling the base of his cock with his fingers, the head of that pretty dick dribbling pre-cum looking nearly purple. Zero looks absolutely dazed, searching Katsuki's face for some kind of answer to an unspoken question.

Katsuki's chest heaves as he opens his mouth, fire in his stomach burning brighter as he watches the other's eyes devour his chest. As if finally realizing that Katsuki's still fully dressed, Zero leaves his weeping cock alone, hands on Katsuki's shirt. Katsuki complies without argument, back arching off the bed so the shirt can be pulled over his head. Metallic hand pushes him back onto the mattress as Zero readjusts him body, knees now at Katsuki's calves.

He bends down again, licking the sweat between Katsuki's pecs before taking a pebbled pink nipple between his teeth and biting down. Katsuki gasps, hits rutting up for contact, and thankfully the man on top of him doesn't leave him hanging, because his biologic hand unbuckles his pants, hurriedly pulling down the zipper and reaching an overeager hand into his pants. He keeps his mouth slathering on his nipples, hand using Katsuki's precum to wet the head. It's nowhere near enough, and the touch is dry, nearly painful, and Katsuki has to bite his lip hard because he's embarrassingly close to finishing, and he refuses to acknowledge *why.*

Zero switches to the other nipple, tongue leaving a wet stripe from one pec to the other, teeth gently grazing before tongue travels over and over again the sensitive spots, and Katsuki's brain feels like its buzzing, desperately trying to hold on to anything that will keep him from cumming before the other.

Katsuki runs his fingers through short blonde strands, desperate for them to be longer, messy and curly. He can almost hallucinate them, tumbling past his neck, that messy dark head of hair he could pick out at any crowd. He was right to shave and dye it. It was too recognizable. Katsuki would have found him immediately.

Katsuki's fingers pull at the other's hair, earning him a beautiful gasp and a harder pull at his own cockhead. Katsuki feels his body start to shake with pleasure. Thankfully, Zero pulls away, eyes wild. He pulls Katsuki's pants down with an urgency that nearly rips the fabric before lining up their cocks. Katsuki watches through cloudy eyes, not processing the universe around them as Zero's – *Deku's* – larger cock rubs against his.

The other jerks his hip, their slick cocks rubbing, and Katsuki's entire body convulses, too close to that promised pleasure. Staving off his orgasm puts tears in Katsuki's eyes, and he tries to blink them away. This is too much. This is too much.

Zero doesn't seem to be paying attention, enraptured by the sight of their cocks sliding against each other. It's a beautiful sight from Katsuki's perspective on his back – muscular torso connecting to perfect hips, pretty fuckin' face fixed in dazed pleasure, cock rubbing against him in movements that are rapidly devolving into something erratic and desperate.

Zero throws Katsuki's calf over his shoulder, kissing the muscle before refocusing. He slides his cock just lateral to Katsuki's, between his thigh and his hole. Delirious, Zero keeps going, faster and faster until Zero's dick catches on the rim of Katsuki's swollen hole – and Katsuki cries out.

Zero's eyes shoot up to him, glazed, chest heaving. His hand finds his cock, and not leaving Katsuki's gaze, takes his cock and rubs it against Katsuki's puckered hole. Katsuki feels himself twitch, cock bouncing on his abdomen, untouched. Mesmerized, Zero puts a little bit of pressure into his hips, cockhead trying desperately to penetrate past the muscular rim. And just as pain starts to shoot through Katsuki, as soon as he thinks this jackass might *actually* try to fuck him dry, Zero pulls back. And then leans in. Rubs his cock, smearing precum on Katsuki's hole. Katsuki grabs the bedsheets, lust rendering him speechless.

"I – I don't have any – " Zero seems to come into some semblance of sanity, despite the fact that he's still moving his hips, still rubbing against his hole, still pressing, over and over again, leaving Katsuki nearly melting into the mattress.

"Don't care. The – first aid kit. Lube. Don't need condoms."

Zero scrambles off the bed so fast Katsuki barely sees him, clattering sound ringing out from the bathroom behind them. Katsuki laughs to himself, relieved for the second to stave off his impending orgasm. Medical grade lubricant isn't exactly *for* this, but compared to having his asshole torn in two, Katsuki figures it's better.

Zero comes back with a hand-sized silver packets, eyebrows furrowed. He takes his space between Katsuki's knees, looking a lot more cognizant and less lust-crazed than he did just a minute ago.

"Are you – I mean – "

"Tch. You won't catch shit from me. Last person I fucked was two years ago, and he was clean."

Zero's eyes turn into something completely different, hands stilling at the silvery tear-away packet, jaw set tight. Katsuki's cock twitches at the look on Zero's – *Deku's* – face.

"You were in high school two years ago." The voice is dark, foreboding, and Katsuki can't help the shudder of excitement that travels all the way up his spine.

"Yeah." Katsuki confirms. He doesn't want to talk about this, but something about the way the other is reacting, this possessive jealousy, is making him hot all over.

Zero tears the packet nearly in half, squeezing most of the contents onto shaking fingers, rubbing his own still-hard dick before meeting Katsuki's eyes again, pupils narrowed, eyebrows fixed, nostrils flared.

"A classmate…?" he asks, clipped and threatening. Katsuki has to stop himself from grinning.

“Yeah.”

Sharp pain shoots all the way through Katsuki’s abdomen as two fingers forcibly penetrate his rim. Katsuki can’t help himself – he writhes on the bed, gripping harder against the covers, abandoned cock leaking against his own abdomen. He darts his eyes to meet Zero’s, and he swears he sees a flash of electric green behind those dark irises. Thrusting two fingers into his hungry hole, over and over again, looking like he wants to hurt him and failing terribly, Katsuki shakes.

“You like this, huh?” Zero’s voice is dark, emotional, cracking, and Katsuki groans, pushing his hips onto the other’s fingers, wanting more, deeper, *harder*.

“Whore. You fucking whore.” Zero might be trying to insult Katsuki, but Katsuki can see the tears pooling in his eyes, can hear the way his voice hitches, can feel the shaking of his finger as he pulls out and rams back in. Katsuki does nothing but moan in response, delirious from the thought of Deku, trembling Deku, the boy he knocked around, the boy he terrified, the boy he called *useless,* is about to fuck him raw, degrade him, wreck him. It makes something giddy explode in his chest. Feels like fate. Feels like it was always supposed to end this way.

Its serendipity.

Three fingers scissor into him, and the other is shaking hard, but despite those tears in his eyes, his dick is still hard. Katsuki made sure of that. God bless nitroglycerin.

“You… you let him do this to you? Without a condom?” His voice is so full of emotion that Katsuki doesn’t know what to do with it. Wrong place, wrong time, wrong situation, but he meets Zero’s teary eyes, not ignorant to the fact that the other has pulled his fingers out of his ass, now rubbing his cock down with what’s left of the lube.

“Never. Just you,” Katsuki confesses, and those seem to be the magic words. Zero seems to exhale, shoulders losing some of their strain, and he lines up his dick to Katsuki’s hole. Swallowing slowly, Zero inches his cock past the ring, hand with an iron grip on his own dick so he could advance himself slowly. The expression on Zero’s face looks like he’s on the very edge of self-control, that he would fuck into Katsuki even if it broke him, and Katsuki almost wishes that he would.

The second he passes the rim, Zero doubles over, and tears hit Katsuki’s abdomen. Katsuki grabs the base of his dick, trying desperately to not cum at the fact that Deku’s fucking crying.

When Zero is sheathed at the base and their faces are inches away, he opens his red-rimmed eyes, tears still threatening to spill. Katsuki fixes his gaze on the clear line circling his irises, feeling almost insane enough to ask the other to remove those shitty black contacts. He wants those greens devouring him. He wants to cum on Deku’s cock. He wants the fucker to mumble, to praise him, to cry the whole time, to fuck him stupid, to fuck all this hate and pain and loneliness out of him.

“You’re looking at me,” he says instead. The last two times they’ve had sex, Zero refused to look at him, but now? He’s on top, they’re face to face, he’s not using a condom. He can’t separate himself from this. He can’t ignore that the pleasure he’s feeling is from Katsuki. He can’t ignore that his desire is towards Katsuki.

Katsuki briefly wonders if that’s just as confusing to Deku as it is to him.

After all, the little nerd should hate him.

But here he is. Dick in his ass, still hard, still on top, still looking straight into his eyes like they're lovers.

Except he's crying, which Katsuki doesn't fully understand. Perhaps this is a self-punishment. Perhaps he wants to face his mistakes. It doesn't really matter. The worse Deku feels about this, the better.

"Never stopped," Zero says, and the warmth in Katsuki's guts suddenly overflows as the other rolls his hips out and, so perfectly, fucks back in. He closes his eyes, the blinding orgasm ripping through him, cum painting his own stomach, feeling absolutely everything around him as Zero pumps into him.

Being fucked through the orgasm feels utterly insane and he moans, wanton and shameless as the pleasure runs in waves across his skin to the point it's nearly painful. When he opens his eyes, the other looks absolutely dazed, hips pistoning automatically as he stares at his softening cock bouncing on his abdomen and the white pearls of cum pooling in the crevasses of his abs.

"Look at you. Cumming from having a dick in your ass. Big, mean pro hero *Dynamight* – " Zero mocks, face attempting to snarl despite the clear pleasure painting his features, "Getting off from getting fucked. Huh? You like that? You like being fucked by my cock? Huh?"

Katsuki doesn't think the other is hearing himself, fully lost in it, hips rolling with each rough, accentuated thrust, the sound of skin slapping against skin barely louder than their shared gasps. Katsuki can't take his eyes off him. Flushed, sweat accumulating on his forehead from the exertion, mouth propped open, hard cock pumping into him, over and over and –

"Fucking answer me!" Zero roars, absolutely wild, hand grabbing against his waist, pressing hard into his scar on his stomach. Pain feels like *nothing,* each touch rolling out against his skin like waves of pinprick electric pleasure, and Katsuki bites into his lip. He takes his softened cock into his hands, jerking slowly, already feeling blood coming back to his spent member.

"I – I like it – " Katsuki moans, words pushed out with every frantic thrust, "I want MORE," and that fucker puts his endless stamina to the test, fucking into him faster, harder, stretching his walls to their limit, thighs smacking against Katsuki's ass as he pounds into him, and Katsuki's mind is going to implode, it's too good and it doesn't hurt and he needs it to, he needs to hurt so much that he doesn't have to think about fucking Deku, because he'd die for him, but fucking him was never on the table, but now he is, and it feels incredible, and its fucking *Deku*, and "Fuck! Fuck me like you hate me, asshole! Fuck me! Stop being a bitch!"

"SHUT UP!"

Katsuki's tongue nearly lolls out of his mouth as the other jerks his hips forward, angling just so that that cockhead hits directly into his poor prostate as the other hand presses down into his neck. It's a jarring, electric pain that spreads through his abdomen, up his spine and into his chest, mixing with the breathlessness and pressure against his windpipe. Katsuki feels the tears start to form in his eyes, and he doesn't give a shit as a few stray drops pour down his cheeks, elation and pleasure magnified tenfold by the utter absurdity of the situation.

Deku's fucking him ruthlessly, choking him out, degrading him and Katsuki's pretty sure he's seconds away from reaching nirvana.

Zero readjusts them, grabbing Katsuki's hips to lift his ass, in to the base so he can lean over, bending Katsuki in half, forcing Katsuki's cum to slowly start to ooze onto his own chest. Face to face,

Katsuki opens his lips into a breathless moan.

“My whore. *Mine.* Fucking say it, Katsuki! SAY IT.”

“YOURS!” Katsuki rasps out, and something dark shoots across Zero’s expression as he opens his own mouth, thick gob of saliva leaving his mouth and dripping down to Katsuki’s own open lips. Katsuki makes a show of swallowing the thick gob of spit, and that seems to be the end of it – Zero smashes their mouths together as his hips lose their rhythm, and half-thrusts become thick and warm as the other empties himself inside Katsuki’s ass. Katsuki swallows the other’s moan just like his spit, would swallow anything the other gave him in that moment, chest tingling with pleasure as the other comes down from his high.

Katsuki’s whole body convulses, nerve endings catching up to the rough treatment, pain creeping in. Zero’s mouth is still on him, wet lips in half a kiss. He pulls back, Katsuki’s head trying to follow against his permission. The sensation of the other’s still-hard cock pulling out of his ass feels awful – he doesn’t want them separated. He doesn’t want to be out. He’s barely cognizant that his own full cock is standing at attention on his abdomen.

“You’re bleeding,” Zero says somewhere distantly. Katsuki shudders, the other’s voice sounding muffled.

“Mmmm.”

“There’s cum leaking out of your hole,” Zero narrates, sounding absolutely fascinated. Katsuki’s body seizes up as he feels a finger penetrate the puffy rim. He opens his eyes, watching Zero, wet squelching sounds of him fingering his own cum into Katsuki’s ass filling the room.

Deku, crooked fingers inside him, fingering his cum into his ass. Katsuki gasps, grabbing into the bedsheets.

Why can’t he stop thinking about it? Why can’t he stop thinking of that little nerd, with his obsessive eyes, lapping up Katsuki’s naked body? Why do images of them in high school, himself layered on those disgusting All Might sheets, writhing under Deku’s touch, keep appearing in Katsuki’s head?!

“You made a mess on yourself.” He adds, fingers still pumping into Katsuki. He angles them, pressing against his abused prostate like he knew exactly where it was, and Katsuki wails, cock bouncing on his abdomen.

Zero leans over, tongue gliding over his abdomen, and it takes one manic second to realize the other is licking Katsuki’s cum off his stomach. He doesn’t stop the ministrations with his fingers, and Katsuki’s cock starts to ache. This isn’t enough. He needs more. He need *more.*

He wants more. More. Fuck the world outside, fuck Shigaraki, fuck the universe. Katsuki wants to stay in here with this Deku, fuck until neither one of them can stand, until neither one of them remembers the other’s name, fuck until they can’t tell whose body is whose, fuck until Katsuki can forgive himself and Deku can shed this fucking *mask.* Fuck until the last four years disappear completely.

More.

“And you’re ready to go again. Such a slut. You don’t even care who does this to you, huh? You don’t even care who I am. What I’ve done. You just need to have your greedy hole filled.”

More.

He's talking too much, and through the haze of arousal Katsuki nearly chuckles, because Zero's so obviously Deku that he's surprised he ever thought otherwise. He never shuts the fuck up, even during sex, especially this disinhibited, and Katsuki wishes he could say that he found it irritating, but his voice, his words, all of that means that Deku's *alive,* alive and with him, letting down his carefully crafted guard because of him.

That introspective, selfless, 'no place in this universe' asshole. Katsuki can't explain the relief he feels when he knows that Deku – the selfish one, the obsessive one, the jealous one – is still there. There's things he still wants. Things he still wants to fight for. Things that he still takes.

Zero's fingers don't stop, and he moans from the overstimulation.

Zero's lips find their way to his painful abandoned cock, and Katsuki keens, fingers threading through Zero's hair. The other pecks painfully slow kisses against his cock, and Katsuki holds his breath, trying not to cum all over his face. Deku's face, cherubic and freckled, covered with cum. Deku's pretty pink lips on his cock. Fucking Deku's throat so hard the other boy cries. Big green eyes staring up at him, lips spread out on his member. Katsuki's body shakes with a whole different *want*, something that he doesn't even have a name for.

Zero takes his cock into the wet heat of his mouth, tongue lathering the underside and moans around it, and Katsuki nearly loses it. Holding Zero's hair, he starts to shallowly move his hips, cockhead pumping in and out through pursed lips. The sight of it is beautiful, and Zero doesn't move, instead grabbing his ass to help with the angle. Katsuki fucks shallowly before his rapidly approaching orgasm makes his stutter, hips bucking forward, and he moans as he spills at the feeling of hitting the back of Zero's throat.

"You taste so good, Katsuki," Zero rasps. And suddenly, he flips them so Katsuki's straddling him, ass empty as Zero's back hits the wall, so they're face to face. Fucked out, hair all over the place, face flushed, Katsuki can't help but lean in for a stolen kiss. He lets the other handle him, lifting his hips effortlessly as he sits Katsuki down on his fully erect dick.

Katsuki cries out, and it starts all over again.

More.

Thick cock down Katsuki's throat, fisting his own dick.

More.

Tongue grazing his swollen hole, still dripping with cum and maybe blood, he doesn't know, brings Katsuki to orgasm #4 with an almost comical rapidity.

More.

They're both too exhausted, Katsuki aching all over, on top of the covers, grinding against each other, cocks still hard despite the bone deep tiredness. Katsuki slicks up his hands, rubbing their overstimulated cockheads together, slow flicks of the wrist bringing them both to a climax that's more painful than pleasurable.

Katsuki has no idea how many times they've had sex. How many hours have passed. What the hell is going on in the outside world.

He doesn't know and he doesn't give a shit.

Zero sleeps, utterly exhausted, completely naked and covered in cum next to Katsuki, and Katsuki looks at him, really examines him. Deku's doing more than some kind of memory quirk – no matter what Katsuki does, the lines of his body, the angles of his face don't look quite correct, though objectively Katsuki knows one is the same as the other, his mind protests against the recognition.

"You're an idiot," Katsuki whispers, brushing the short strands of the other's hair off his face. His lips exhale, sighing something sweet before wrapping his arms around Katsuki. The twin bed isn't exactly an easy spot to maneuver out of, but Katsuki makes due. His legs shake like crazy under the strain, and he feels fluids trickle down his leg. He's way past disgust at that feeling, having a job to do. If he's right, and this asshole is going to do what he thinks he's going to do, Katsuki has a very important goal.

He's not getting away from him. Never again.

Having accomplished said goal, Katsuki's heart clenches at the thought of worming his way back into Zero's arms. The marathon fuck session is one thing, but to be held, to fall asleep in the other's arms – *Deku's* arms – makes Katsuki's stomach flip with trepidation.

He marches to the other bunk bed across the way, lays on top of the covers, and instantly falls asleep.

When he wakes up, the bunker is empty.

Unsurprising.

Katsuki groans, all his muscles on fire as he moves to the bathroom. First-aid kit gone. The other clothes in here, gone. The books, gone. Its nearly spotless, like there was never a person living here. Katsuki grits his teeth.

He abandoned him again.

Jokes on him, though.

Katsuki cleans himself up best he can in the cold shower, feeling his dick twitch at the sight of new bruises blooming all over his milky skin. As discreetly as possible, using backways and alleys, Katsuki makes it back to his apartment.

He locks the door behind him, walks into his bedroom and turns on his computer screen.

The map lights up with the single green flashing point moving east. Katsuki grins.

"Got ya, asshole."

Chapter End Notes

Katsuki, someone who is mentally sound:



Also Katsuki, who mayhaps should have marinated on the feelings of still wanting to fuck Zero when he found out he was Deku:



At last. Katsuki Bakugou, a quadruple threat. Long range, short range, stealth AND a honeypot. It's what he deserves.

Everyone knows a healthy relationship is built on lies, stalking, jealousy, emotional manipulation, physical altercations and constant violent sex. They really were made for each other (insult.)

Also THANK YOU FOR HUMORING ME LAST CHAPTER WITH THE MATH lmao. hopefully i made it so convoluted that people will ignore all the plot holes from here on out 👀

Chapter 10

Chapter Notes

> Oh yeah baby now we're in all plot territory.
> Just plot. Plot as far as the eye can see.
> ..... Because that's why we're all here right?
> .....Right?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Some time ago, somewhere across the ocean, a young researcher pointed a radio telescope into the night sky and discovered a never-before-seen phenomenon; radio waves that would suddenly appear, then just as quickly, disappear.

The signal appeared reliably, oscillating every 1.33 seconds. First thought to be interference, then signs of extraterrestrial life, these dense neutron stars spinning rapidly along their axis, emitting waves of radiation from their poles, were affectionately labeled as ‘pulsars.’ When these powerful magnetic poles faced the earth, the waves would travel to the keen observer on the surface of this little planet, whispering in a language so ancient and fundamental even simple creatures like humans, heads pointed to the stars, could understand.

‘I am here. I am here.’

The green dot flashes. Disappears. Flashes again.

Incomprehensibly distant and unreachable.

But real.

Not a figment of his imagination. Not a delirious fever-dream.

Izuku Midoriya, in the flesh, alive and breathing and *real,* flashing there on his computer screen.

Katsuki watches it, forcing his eyes to stay on that dot despite the light burning holes into his retinas. Blinds shut and blackout curtains pulled, with only the dull electric blues of the computer screen to illuminate the room, the green dot is the brightest thing in Katsuki’s world. His beacon. His homing signal.

Tangible proof that Deku is alive, Deku is *here,* and Katsuki has found him.

Katsuki bites the inside of his cheek to hide his self-satisfied grin as he reaches for his pen, jotting down the address in the notebook that’s been digging ridges in his wrist over the past 72 hours.

Reassured that the other won’t make any more moves for the next hour, he turns to the stack of papers sitting next to him. He stands, bones cracking in protest at the motion, and walks across the room to the last empty wall available to him. He outlines the space with his eyes before taking the papers, one by one, and tacking them up on the wall.

When he's done, the giant jigsaw-puzzle version of Tokyo stares back at him.

Day to day, there doesn't seem to be any rhyme or reason to the other's movements. Zero frequently travels district to district without consideration for proximity or weather, never staying in one place for longer than an hour - often less - before rushing to the next destination.

Nothing on the police radio, local reports, or social media seem to mention crimes, large or small, that correlate with the other's location, so vigilante justice doesn't seem to be his primary motivator.

But there seems to be a pattern. Schools and universities and office districts between 9am and 3pm. Coffee shops, bars, libraries and gyms between 3pm-8pm. Residential areas between 8pm to 9am.

He seems to be everywhere, but Katsuki zeroes in to where he *isn't* with a much stronger intensity than he cares to admit.

Zero doesn't go *anywhere* that a sentimental Deku might. Doesn't go anywhere that Katsuki expected when he set up his cameras years ago. He gives an incredibly wide berth to U.A., bypasses Musutafu completely, and the blocks surrounding Endeavor Agency, Genius Agency, The Lurkers Agency and Team Idaten remain free of his shitty glowing green dot.

He never lingers inside Granny Honoka's coffee shop anymore. Not long enough or consistently enough for Katsuki to race out the door and catch him, anyway.

He also never comes too close to Katsuki's apartment or the bunker where they spent their last night together.

Zero's intentionally avoiding Katsuki.

Katsuki pretends the thought doesn't strangle his insides in a vice-grip.

Katsuki couldn't imagine a Deku in the past that would actively evade him. A younger Katsuki would surely think it's too good to be true – no matter what he did back then, no matter how much of an asshole he was, he couldn't shake the little nerd.

But then… how much of Deku is left inside Zero?

Which also leads to the question, how much of Zero was lying in wait inside of Deku?

Zero didn't come out of nowhere. No one's that good of a liar - certainly not Izuku 'Borrowed Quirk' Midoriya. He might have fooled everyone else around him with that innocent act, but Katsuki always knew. How no one else saw it – in his inhuman eyes when he was raging against Shigaraki, his impassive face and even jaw even when his bones cracked and his skin split, in those quiet moments when they were alone, when Katsuki would accidentally catch the other's gaze on him and feel like prey in sights of some ruthless beast.

Izuku Midoriya always had a monster inside of him, and this is what he looks like with his chains broken.

This narcissistic, self-destructive, selfish, mangled man.

Maybe Zero is the true manifestation of Izuku Midoriya. Maybe he's more real than Deku ever was.

But if that's true, does that mean the words that Zero frantically threw at him their last night together hold true for Deku, too? Did Deku, with his sweet smiles and pink cheeks, dream about possessing

him, flood with violent jealousy when he was around anybody else, hold himself back in their fights because the impulse to hurt him was too much*?*

He wants it to be true. He wants it to be true so badly it makes him dizzy, and he can't even pretend to logic through the *why.*

This unrestrained Deku, the one that hadn't had to face consequences for his action in years holds nothing back. Not in his punches, not in his words, and certainly not in his fucking.

He can still chase the feeling with the memory of his fingertips brushing through the sensitive hairs on the back of his neck. His body heat, the blazing of his eyes, desperation and desire rolling off him in waves. It felt pure, somehow. Honest.

If he wasn't always holding back, if he wasn't trying to hide these dark parts of himself from Katsuki, if he was just fucking *genuine* for one goddamn second*,* would that have changed things between them in high school?

In middle school?

Would he be able to feel the other against him without performing his own private ritual of rage and violence?

Katsuki releases a shaky exhale, eyes creaking open to stare at the comforting glow of that green dot. Each flash feels like a steady pulse, like he's holding his fingertips to the other's carotid. With this tracker, the power is in his hands. At any moment, Katsuki can hunt him down, kidnap him and collar him and gag him, leave him in this room as the perfect final centerpiece for his blood-soaked shrine.

He wants to. He wants to. God, how he wants to. He wants to make Deku's – Zero's? – promise true. Them, in that bunker, shut out from the rest of the world. Fucking and fighting and bleeding until they both die.

But he can't. Deku would never give up on the world, and Katsuki would never give up on Deku.

So here they are.

The impulse to *see* him is suffocating. Four years of looking for the other, and now he knows exactly where he is, and he can't go to him. This must be some kind of karmic punishment.

But saving him isn't just finding him. Saving him also means stopping whatever insane self-destructive ass shit the other is planning to do.

Whatever he's up to, Katsuki can't let him do it alone.

He's doing this for Deku's own good, even if the other would vehemently disagree.

Katsuki grabs his notebook from the desk and walks back over to the map of Tokyo, fingertip tracing along streets to find his first destination.

A house, a high school, an afterschool club in Kanagawa. Crappy apartment complex, business district, bar in Chuo. A high rise condo, luxurious bank, a love hotel in Nakano. Katsuki ignores the jolt in his chest as he marks the last location.

It's unlikely that Zero himself is indulging in these locations. The much more likely answer is that he's trailing someone. Multiple someones.

Katsuki bites the cap off the black marker, chewing on it as he connects the dots between the school, after-school club and house in Kanawaga. Their radius is as narrow as one would expect – after all, high-school students, particularly those that have recently been kidnapped (*not that Katsuki knows from personal experience*) often have a short leash on them. Katsuki removes the school picture of the Shiryoku twins lateral to the window and places them within the triangle.

Katsuki reaches his arm up, connecting the dots in Nakano, then steps laterally to Chuo. He marks several more locations without clear relation to one another and steps back, willing his eyes to recognize a more complete pattern.

There's seventeen names on that list, seventeen pairs of blood samples still being processed by the Tokyo Police Department, seventeen addresses and painfully researched Quirk registrations. Save for the Shiryoku twins, only six of them are identical.

Within those six are two additional pairs, marked by Zero as important.

Three cities, three locations, three sets of twins that, just by the sheer uncontrollable coincidence of being formed from the same ovum and sperm, got caught up in this royal shit-show.

Katsuki's eyes flick back to the dot. It moves North at almost inhuman speeds, approaching Nakano. Katsuki glances at his watch and grimaces. It's Love Hotel O'Clock for the depraved fucker Zero's following now; nearly on the opposite end of the city, far enough away and time-consuming enough to allow for Katsuki to make his own move a little more South.

Katsuki swallows against the wad of mucus lodged in his throat, sighing out in annoyance at his feet's insistence of staying locked in place.

He knows that he should have at least *visited* those girls since he found them in that warehouse. Asked if they were okay. Checked up on them. That's what a *good* hero would do.

Can Katsuki even be called a hero, considering he let their kidnapper go? That he's letting said kidnapper stalk them? Guilt gnaws at Katsuki's ankles like a yappy little dog, and Katsuki kicks out against air, forcing his stubborn legs to move back to his bedroom.

He doesn't have to talk to them, he tells himself. He can just observe. Just *look.* He throws on a sweatshirt, beanie, non-descript black pants and sneakers, putting on a face-mask. He grimaces at himself in the mirror. The loose closing hides his musculature, and with his hair and mouth hidden, he doesn't look too much different than a regular high school kid.

On his way to the after school club, no one casts him a second glance, and Katsuki wonders briefly if this is the way that Zero feels each day.

The way that *Deku* felt. Invisible. Unimportant. Overlooked.

The pebble under my shoe.

When he finally makes it to the track, the sun is starting to fall behind the horizon, bathing the spring air in a cacophony of oranges and pinks. He climbs up the metallic stands, making sure to keep an ample radius away from the scattered bodies on the stands. There's few people there, some schoolgirls, a small huddle of teenage boys laughing so loud it makes Katsuki's jaw ache, and a few over enthusiastic parents.

The whistle catches Katsuki's attention. Past the chatter of those on the stands, Katsuki can make out the sound of feet hitting the soft ground.

Katsuki watches the first girl round the track with the baton. Three others are squatting, hands outstretched behind them, heads pointed ahead, focusing on their goals rather than watching their teammate approach.

There, second to last, is the characteristic black bob of one of the Shiryoku twins. Her bangs are pulled back with a sweatband and her face is pinched in concentration. Katsuki expects the other to be somewhere around – maybe in the group of girls in uniform watching this practice relay, maybe in the stands, but he can't seem to find her.

"Come on Hikari-chan! You can do it!" one of the girls yells from the sidelines, and he can see the Shiryoku girl's mouth quirk up into a smile, despite her concentrated gaze and her unmoving stance.

As the girl behind her hands off the baton, panting, Hikari breaks into a sprint. Her arms swing rhythmically, thigh muscles pumping, face reddening with exertion. Katsuki raises his eyebrows at the speed – for a girl with a quirk like 'Flashlight,' she's not half bad.

Katsuki watches it happen as if in slow motion. Hikari misses a step, her right knee buckles, and just as she hands the baton to the final runner, she lands hard on her knee, rolling onto the grass.

"Shiryoku-kun!"

"Hikari-chan!"

"Hikari!"

Several of the girls run forward, including the final sprinter. Katsuki watches with fascination as three girls help her up, letting her hold on to their shoulders as she babies the right knee, putting all her weight on the left. From here, Katsuki can see the tell-tale red of blood already dripping down her leg.

"Can you walk?"

"Are you okay?"

"Here, let's take you to the nurse!"

The group fusses around Hikari, and Katsuki rolls his eyes. This is definitely no U.A. They've been told to walk off broken bones and cuts down to the muscle, so a scraped knee is nothing.

Hikari looks bashful, ducking her head as she places the knee back down onto the ground. She hobbles on it, but the incapacitating injury seems much more mild now that she can bear weight on it. Katsuki pretends that it doesn't make relief flood through his body.

"Come on guys, its better already! Don't worry! I'm so sorry that I messed that up – " she starts, only to be cut off by slurry of girls talking over one another, lavishing her with reassurances.

As she goes to sit down on the grass to watch the next relay, Katsuki can hardly believe his eyes. He rubs them a few times, just to make sure.

The wound is *gone.* Its just *gone.*

How?

The bell sounds again, and the next race starts immediately. Another girl hands Hikari a water bottle and she smiles in return, watching the race as if nothing's happened. As if she didn't manifest a completely new Quirk right in front of Katsuki's eyes.

The baton is passed to the second girl. She runs.

He saw this same quirk just a few days ago.

Hand to hand. Baton is passed.

Katsuki's stomach rolls.

Somewhere between a bit over a week ago when Katsuki broke the other's ribs, and four days ago when they fucked each other's brains out in that bunker, Zero acquired Regeneration from Shigaraki.

And somewhere within the past four days, he passed the Quirk on to Hikari Shiryoku.

On these old metal bleachers, Katsuki feels the ground underneath him give. He might as well be free-falling. Hands meet cold metal, trying to steady himself. He doesn't notice as the metal starts to give under the direct heat of his sweating palms.

He's thought about this all wrong. Hell, he never even considered the possibility.

Him and Yagi just *assumed* Shigaraki was the one hiding Quirks away from Deku.

Not that it might be the other way around.

It makes so much more sense this way. No one remembers Zero – he can just as soon interact with these twins, hand one of them a new Quirk in the most fucked up game of flesh hide-and-seek on the planet, and the twin would be none-the-wiser.

Why the *fuck* would this idiot give Regeneration away?! Regeneration is OP in every way. It could be the fight-winning Quirk in that jambalaya of Quirk bullshit sloshing around in Zero's body. Hell, if Deku kept it –

If Deku kept it. If he still had it, Shigaraki could always take it back. In some way, some shape, he could steal it, and it would be Daika City all over again.

Deku's stored away Regenerate because he wants to even the playing field.

Katsuki doesn't watch the rest of the practice race. He walks down the bleachers, rapidly exiting the club grounds before someone can ask him questions about the deformed stair he left in his wake. His phone shakes in his hands as he accesses the Tracker app, watching the glowing green dot outside that Love Hotel.

He's watching his investments.

He's ensuring his stockpile of hidden powers are safe.

If the Shiryoku twins have Regeneration, what do the twins in Chuo or Nakano hold?

What kind of danger has Zero put them in?

As Katsuki's feet make their own decisions regarding their destination, Katsuki's brain works on overdrive. He tries to catalogue every power All for One had, at least that he's aware of. What other powers are there that could turn the tide of a battle?

It would have to be a non-physical Quirk. Something that can't be triggered accidentally. Something that someone can possess without ever knowing they have it.

Which means that Katsuki won't be able to find out from watching from a distance. If he reveals himself, if he interacts with these twins, then surely Zero will catch on, and this game of cat and mouse might become quite a bit more dangerous, if not for Katsuki himself, then for the unsuspecting twins involved in it.

Despite the desire to spend the night staking out Chuo and Nakano, Katsuki finds himself standing in front of his own apartment, despite not remembering taking the train or most of the walk there. As soon as he steps through the door, he sheds all his clothes on his living room floor until he's in a t-shirt and boxers. He wanders back over to his study, sitting down on the chair.

He wants to feel angry. Disappointed. *Something.* But it's all empty, just a flat buzzing in his head. Katsuki pushes off the ground with his foot, letting his chair swivel around, the walls blurring into a giant green smear in front of his eyes.

Zero's movements are intentional, carefully researched, and restless.

He barely sleeps. He doesn't seem to indulge in anything, not food, or a warm bed, not a forgotten conversation with his mother or All Might or any of his nerdy little friends.

So why did he spend all that time just *sitting* in Granny Honoka's café? Why did he sleep in the same place every night? Why did he keep coming there, even though Katsuki remembered him, even though Katsuki could compromise his whole mission?

Unless.

A part of Katsuki believed that, maybe, Zero stayed where Katsuki could always find him so Katsuki *could* find him. That he was there *for* him.

Katsuki's breath stutters in his chest as he stands back up, marker in hand. Granny Honoka's coffee shop. The bunker. Katsuki's apartment.

He connects the dots, eyes skirting his list of twins, before landing on an address within the triangle. He swears his eyes are playing tricks on him as he reads the names. He blinks a few times, begging for it to be an illusion, some kind of hallucination, the universe's final practical joke, but there they are. In plain writing. Staring Katsuki in the face like the utter fool he is.

Minutes must have passed, or hours, he doesn't know. Somewhere in this he must have slept, because birds are starting to sing on the thawing treetops, dew glistening along branches.

Dawn flirts with the horizon, brightening the sheer blackness just slightly, a hint of the sunrise to come. The streets are empty, and Katsuki uses the silence to release an explosion, landing on the doorstep in under a minute. Hands shaking, lips trembling with the effort to catch his breath, Katsuki forms a first and bangs as hard as he can against the door.

"LET ME IN!"

Katsuki hears nothing inside, and irritation mixed with fear spike somewhere in the back of his head. He starts again, fist bruising from his intensity of the knock, the old wooden door shaking with each meeting with his fists.

“GET THE FUCK UP AND LET ME IN!”

“Do you know what *time it is?!* I’m calling the polic – e. “

Granny Honoka’s eyes glance up at Katsuki, and the fury on her face instantly melts into concern. He grabs him by the hem of his shirt, pulling him inside before shutting the door behind him.

“Did something happen? Are you in trouble?”

The warmth of the old woman’s hands, the tender concern in her eyes, the way the corners of them wrinkle as she squints up at him, clearly missing her ever-present glasses make the back of Katsuki’s eyes burn.

“I – “ Katsuki starts, and then shakes his head minutely, taking the elderly woman’s hands off his shirt. He walks over to the corner of the darkened coffee shop, the same spot that Zero always occupied, and sits down with a flourish.

Good vantage point to see both up the stairs to Granny Honoka’s apartment, out the window, and keep an eye on everyone in the coffee shop.

“Son, I’m going to need you to tell me if you’re in trouble with the law. So I can get my nunchucks from my craft room.” Granny Honoka says quite seriously, and Katsuki is surprised at the barking laugh that leaves his mouth. The mood between them lightens instantly, and he can bring himself to look back up at the woman. She watches him patiently, and he finds himself choking on an emotion he can’t put a name to. He simply shakes his head, and the woman nods in turn.

She doesn’t ask any follow-up questions. Instead, she disappears into the kitchen, the tell-tale sound of a kettle on a stovetop and porcelain cups leaving a cupboard. She doesn’t reappear for what feels like hours, and Katsuki takes the time to gather his thoughts.

He never paid any attention to them. Why would he? They were just nameless, faceless background characters in his life. But they were *right here.* Right in front of Katsuki’s nose, this entire time, and he didn’t notice.

When Granny Honoka sits down next to Katsuki, a cup of tea placed gingerly in front of him, Katsuki lets the heat from the cup soak into his hands before he starts to speak.

“…Your nephews. Aoto and Otoa. They’re identical twins, right?

Granny Honoka’s open expression shuts down instantly, and her wrinkled mouth transforms into a tight frown.

“…Yes. They are. What is this about?”

Katsuki evens his face, leaning down so he’s at eye-level with the elderly woman.

“They might be in danger. I need to know where they are.”

Granny Honoka’s eyes dart to the front door, before coming back to Katsuki. She clears her throat and stands, much more spry in her kitten-themed slippers than Katsuki ever remembers seeing her before.

Fingers turn the three locks on the door, as well as the slip chain on top, before she comes back to sit next to him.

“They went to school early. They’re safe there.”

“At U.A.” Katsuki says, and knows with no evidence that he’s right.

Granny Honoka nods. She takes her cup of tea, nursing it in her tiny hands, before taking a long sip.

“You’re not acting surprised,” Katsuki observes, and Granny Honoka places her teacup down, sighs, and stands back up.

“Follow me,” she says. Katsuki stands himself, following the slow-moving elderly woman up the creaky stairs of her apartment. The hallway is incredibly narrow, the house smelling like mothballs and burnt sugar, like the scent of cookies has permeated the outdated wallpaper and soaked into the very walls.

“Twins are genetic, you know. They run in families.”

Katsuki nods, even though the other cannot see him.

She pauses outside a shut door, hand on the handle before she turns back to Katsuki.

“How can I know that I can trust you, young man?” Granny Honoka asks, but there’s no trepidation in her voice, and Katsuki levels his eyes at her, feigning annoyance, although the nerves under his skin prickle.

After all, life keeps proving to him, time and time again, that he doesn’t *really* know anyone.

That he can’t *really* trust anyone.

Hopefully she doesn’t have the same degree of paranoia.

“It’s *me,* Granny.”

Somehow, that seems to be enough. She gives him a gummy smile before she twists the knob, leading them both into a colorful workshop. The place is strewn about with scraps of fabric, yarn, a sewing machine, pieces of paper, and shelves and shelves of books, both self-made and purchased.

Granny Honoka walks with purpose to the other end of the room, stopping in front of a short bookshelf adorned with framed photos.

“Although we were twins, we were incredibly different. Back then, it was common not to have quirks. Neither one of us a ‘meta ability’, but we had each other. We had a special connection. I felt it in my heart when my sister decided to leave Japan. She was always much more adventurous than me.”

Granny Honoka picks up a framed photo of two young girls at what appears to be some sort of graduation. The photo itself has faded with age, cracking along the edges. Even so, Katsuki recognizes Granny’s characteristic nose on both women.

“My sister traveled the world, got married, settled down in the States. She had a daughter. Despite all the love in the world, she fell in with the wrong crowd. She would disappear for weeks, months at a time. She thought bringing her here, back to Japan to live with me, would change things. But it didn’t. I always bailed her out when she’d land into prison or have money problems. And then, we didn’t

hear from her for years. When she returned the final time, after my sister's husband passed, it was with my boys. Aoto and Otao. Of course, it was before they had those names."

Granny Honoka's smile upturns as she pulls a photo album out from the bottom shelf. Despite it's clear age, no dust covers the well-worn pages. Granny Honoka turns to the page without hesitation, like she's flipped the album to this exact photo hundreds of times.

"They were the most lovely boys. They slept through the night, almost never cried. They never really knew their mother. Despite everything, Keiko didn't change. She kept disappearing. She showed up sporadically, almost never sober, and never for too long. There were times when she brought this man with her – Hisaki. He never told us his family name. He was handsome, charming, rich. He showered the boys with gifts and money. Doted on them more than Keiko ever did. He had their hair. He must have been their father, although Keiko never told us as such."

She turns the page in the album. The photo is slightly blurry, but the sense of familiarity at the sight of the man has Katsuki swallowing back bile. He couldn't have been much older than Katsuki, dressed in a suit too smart for a man in his early twenties, curly white hair and startling yellow eyes squinted affectionately at the toddlers playing with matching firetrucks next to him.

"Then one day, he came to the house without Keiko, and – " Granny Honoka pauses, voice trembling. Katsuki reaches out to her, and she takes his hand, squeezing it gently before she continues.

"He said that we need to hide them away. That we need to protect them. Because they're in danger. That his father is a powerful man, and he's targeting twins. That his father doesn't know about his sons, but it's only a matter of time. Only a matter of time before he finds his brother's and his own boys. He said – he said he'd erase them from the records. Give them new names, new birthdays, new lives. As long as we made sure to never tell them about him. As long as they never looked for him. He promised he'd never see them again. So me and my sister and the boys moved here, bought this house, opened this coffee shop. Gave them new names. New lives."

"I didn't see Keiko again. Or Hisaki. Then one day, Hisaki walked through the door of this coffee shop and I just about had a heart attack. But… he didn't recognize us at all. Introduced himself as Hisashi. This was back when the boys were young. I wondered whether he had his memory erased, whether it was some kind of new meta ability, but, well. He disappeared after some time, too. But I haven't forgotten what he said."

Katsuki stares at the picture of Hisaki, body leaden. He can't so much as twitch a muscle, can hardly breathe, his tongue a useless lump in his throat.

Because Hisaki has curly hair and freckles.

There's a reason Zero spent so much time here. There's a reason he's been watching them this whole time.

Because the answer is here. They were here. All along. Of course Deku knew about them, watched them, followed them. Of course he did – because they're family.

They're Deku's cousins.

Katsuki's brain chooses to barrel right past the horrifying information that *All for One is Deku's fucking grandfather?!* And straight to a plan, because he doesn't have time to for a mental breakdown. Not today.

Doesn't have time to imagine how much Deku must have fucking *hated* every cell in his body when he found out he shared the other's DNA.

Doesn't have time to think that maybe, just maybe, he hid his hair and his eyes for more reasons than a simple disguise.

"What are their quirks?" Katsuki finds his mouth wording. He knows what the Quirk registry says, but certainly that can't be true. If their identities have been faked, their quirks must have been as well. They have to have been, because they're listed as fraternal twins with two separate quirks.

Granny Honoka locks her lips, eyebrows furrowing.

"Oato's quirk is called 'Mirror.' He can reflect any attack and use it against the other with equal strength. Aoto's quirk is called 'Opposite.' He can transform anything into its' exact opposite."

Katsuki can taste the lie in the air. They share the same quirk, so they much have chosen to display different aspects of it to make themselves less suspicious.

A quirk that returns something equal, a quirk that returns something opposite.

Now doesn't *that* sound familiar.

Toshinori Yagi, that old asshole, was really on to something.

"Okay," Katsuki pretends to be placated. The old lady might still be protecting her nephews, but Toshinori Yagi's still on Katsuki's side. So is Aizawa. Despite everything, he can depend on them. They're safe with them. U.A. is safe.

"… When are they coming back?" Katsuki finally asks, and Granny Honoka furrows her brows.

"After school. Around four to pick up the afternoon shift in the café."

"…And there's been no one here to protect them. Not for the past few days." Katsuki processes out loud.

"*I'm* protecting them." Granny Honoka insists. And as threatening she is with curlers in her hair and a cane in her hands, Katsuki has the vague impression that Zero, the six-foot-something all-powerful vigilante sitting in the corner of said coffee shop maybe offered up more protection. Maybe.

"I… I need to keep an eye on them. I'm staying here."

Granny Honoka pauses for a second, eyes scanning the room, then hums low.

"What." Katsuki tries to hold himself back from snapping at the woman, but his voice still trembles at the poorly executed restraint.

"That might not be that helpful, considering they won't be here this weekend."

Katsuki bites his continue. "… And where the f – hell are they going to be?"

"Training camp." Granny Honoka levels serious eyes at Katsuki, a flicker of something like fear behind those opacified irises.

“Training camp.” Katsuki repeats, trying not to let the instant panic show on his face. Those very words still send his sweat glands into overdrive, but now, the thought of those twins being anywhere outside of U.A. walls fills Katsuki with a cold, overwhelming dread that has nothing to do with his own painful memories.

“Yes. Their bus leaves Friday morning, I believe.”

Forty-eight hours from now. Unbe-fucking-lievable.

“… You’re joking.”

“They’ve been looking forward to it for weeks,” she quickly adds, almost as if defending the decision to let them embark on something so dangerous. “It’s going to be some sort of island-survival challenge, run by those overseas heroes – “

Katsuki stops listening. He’s certain that at some point Kirishima told him about this training camp in his many unanswered texts, but Katsuki could hardly give a shit at the time.

Now he’s burned a bridge that would have connected him directly to those boys.

God*damn* it.

Maybe it will be okay without Katsuki there.

… Yeah fucking right.

Its not that he doesn’t trust Red Riot, or Pinky, or Mirage. Its not that he doesn’t trust his former teachers.

But maybe its exactly that.

How can people that failed to protect *him,* failed to protect Deku just four years prior, protect something so vital *now?*

“I – okay. I’ll – I’ll figure something out. Don’t worry.” Katsuki swallows hard, nodding to himself before bolting right out the front door, straight into early morning joggers clogging up the sidewalk.

A quirk like ‘equal and opposite’ isn’t something to scoff at. It’s too *useful.*

Its a quirk worth taking.

The thought makes goosebumps erupt along Katsuki’s neck. It’s one thing to use other people’s quirks, hell, even give them to other people, but to take them?

Does Deku even possesses that power?

And has he lost enough of himself to use it?

When Katsuki makes it back through his front door, he marches straight to his bedroom and grabs his abandoned phone off the bedside table. Three messages flash across his screen and Katsuki plays them on speaker as he paces his room, chewing on the edge of his nail.

The woman’s robotic voice shills:

You have three new messages. New message, 8:30pm.

Young Bakugou. I've been thinking a lot about our conversation last night. I've been doing a bit of digging into the subject of twins and quirk theory. Twins births are a recessive gene, much like rare qualities like green eyes or blonde hair. Early into the evolution of quirks, twins and other 'mutants' were much more likely to obtain them. Qualities that were once glorified were seen as dangerous, and many twins were killed. Anyone seen as 'different' suffered the consequences. There was one particular person that took great interest in twins. You might have guessed, his name is All for One. But here's the kicker – "

The voicemail cuts off. Katsuki shakes his head, activating the next.

You have two new messages. New message, 8:55pm.

Your voicemail duration is much too shortl, Young Bakugou. As I was saying, here's the kicker. All for One, was listed as a parent of twin boys. That certainly adds to your theory that All for One and the 1st user of One for All were twins. Ah, I'm getting off topic. So he had twin boys, but both of them appear to have survived. Hisaki and Hisashi Shigaraki. Records of them disappear over the next few years; but – Well, Young Bakugou, as I'm sure you remember, Hisashi is the name of Young Midoriya's absent father. And while I'm not a believer in fate, it does seem serendipitous that Young Midoriya was able to manifest the full power of One for All when the eight previous users could not – do you suppose it's in his genetics? I suppose it would be important to find out whether Hisaki had any children, or if Hisashi fathered anyone after -

The voicemail cuts off once more, and Katsuki feels his impatience spike.

He doesn't bother listening to the third voicemail, instantly dialing Yagi's number, tapping his foot against his floor, heart beating so loudly he can hardly hear the ringing.

"Young Baku-?" a panicked voice answers after less than a full ring.

"You alone?" Katsuki cuts off before the other can ask anything more.

"I'm in my office."

"Lock the door."

There's silence as he hears the other's chair squeak, and then the tell-tale click of a lock.

"You've got to get me into the camp."

"… The camp?"

Katsuki rubs the bridge of his nose, scrunching up his nose before he starts again.

"There's a training camp that your 3A and 3B brats are going to this weekend, yeah? Make me one of the fucking chaperones."

"… Young Bakugou, I don't understand."

"The fucking *twins,* All M - Yagi! Aoto and Otoa! *They* are Hisaki's sons! And I think they're the – fuck, the secret weapon! The ace in the hole! The fucking crux of Shigaraki's plan!"

Or of Zero's plan.

Katsuki bites his tongue. He wants to tell All Might. He wants so desperately to tell Toshinori Yagi *I found him! He's alive! He's fucked in the head and wears a prosthetic and he's doing some shit that he would never, ever want you to find out about, but he's back. He's back. He's finally fucking back.* It would be the right thing to do. It would be the *kind* thing to do.

He can't. He just can't, no matter how many times he clears his throat, no matter how many times he practices forming the words with his cracked lips, no matter how much he knows he *should.*

"… Hm."

Katsuki's tapping gets louder as he holds the phone against his ears, line startlingly quiet.

" Young Bakugou… have you heard of a concept called electron-positron annihilation?"

Toshinori Yagi follows that with dead-fucking-silence.

"…What the actual *fuck* are you talking about?" Katsuki snaps.

Katsuki cringes as the other starts to cough sharply over the line. It takes him a second to clear his throat, all the while Katsuki's nerves are starting to fray end-to-end.

"Its. Well. Aoto and Otoa… their quirks reverse things, yes? So if Young Shigaraki was able to obtain this quirk and use it against Young Midoriya, and All for One and One for All work like electrons in a circuit, it would be like… imagine if an electron meets its exact opposite, a positron. They would simply cancel each other out."

Katsuki's foot stills.

"What are you saying."

"If one of them was to use it against the other, it would cause them to cancel each other out. At least in theory. Total annihilation. Both people would lose the Quirk."

Deku would do that.

Deku would absolutely, one hundred percent, in every fucking reality, do *exactly* that.

Sacrifice his own quirk to end Shigaraki's.

"That's a good thing, then." Katsuki states, the weight off his chest lifting just slightly, allowing him to take a deep breath.

Yagi doesn't sound so relieved. "… I don't think you fully understand what I'm trying to say, Young Bakugou. It's called electron-positron *annihilation* for a reason. The amount of energy this releases – I couldn't even predict it. It would be on the level of multiple atomic bombs. The cross-fire could kill *millions.*"

Katsuki feels his knees buckle as he falls back onto his still-made bed. He stares at the ceiling, the fan above him, spinning lazily sans yellow cape.

He hates the words that thoughtlessly leave his mouth.

"Unless there's a way to limit casualties. Like making it happen on a deserted island with no inhabitants. Just a few nearly-graduated visiting hero students who might be able to defend

themselves."

"…Young Bakugou. You don't know what you're saying. Young Midoriya would never – there are going to be forty innocent *children* on the island, and – "

"Wouldn't he?" The fan rotates, round and round. Katsuki's head spins with it.

Four years ago, he would say with certainly that Izuku Midoriya would never do this.

Now, he's not so fucking sure.

What's the difference between this and the war? They were all first years, barely sixteen years old when this same school thrust them onto the battlefield with some of the greatest threats the world has ever known. The same school that sent them out for cleanup after the massive prison outbreaks while society crumbled around them and civilians cowered in the shelters underground, letting *children* bleed and fight and *die* for them.

How is this any worse?

"… Perhaps we should just… cancel the whole thing."

Katsuki's grinds his teeth.

"Hold on."

"…" Toshinori Yagi inhales sharply across the line, almost like he wants to protest, but Katsuki doesn't give him the opportunity.

"This might be the only way we can get Shigaraki to an isolated place, get rid of his Quirk without some prolonged battle and minimize the fatalities. We can plan this out. We can prepare for this. We can *help* Deku, All Might. He's been fighting all this fucking time for us. You don't want to fight for *him*?"

He can hear the way the other's breath hitches on the other end. He's hit a nerve, a direct punch to the most tender part of Toshinori Yagi's heart.

Just the right part of emotional to make him illogical. Its exactly what Katsuki needs. Its exactly what is necessary to pull this insane stunt off.

If they play this right – by Monday, the world would be free of the greatest threat humanity has ever known, Deku will be eating an awkward meal with his mother like nothing's changed, and Katsuki can sleep for a year straight.

"… I can do that." Yagi finally answers, and Katsuki feels himself sink further into his mattress, whole body melting into jelly.

"On one condition." Yagi quickly adds, and Katsuki has to physically restrain himself from letting out a groan.

"We have to tell Aizawa about this. All of this. Your theory, Aoto and Otoa, everything."

Damn it.

It didn't take much to convince Toshinori Yagi, but that old coot is a sentimental fool.

Aizawa might not be so easy.

Katsuki forms a fist, banging it lightly against his bedsheets before relenting.

“Fine. Tomorrow. After school. Bunker below U.A. You still now how to get there, old man?”

Yagi chuckles humorlessly across the line.

“I’ll find my way.”

Chapter End Notes

WHO NOTICED THE MIXED UP NAMES OF THE BARISTA BOYS THE FIRST FEW CHAPTERS?! SHIT WAS INTENTIONAL YO
WHAT ARE THE TWO HIDDEN QUIRKS ZERO LEFT IN THE CHUO AND NAKANO TWINS
WAS PASSING THE BATON AS A METAPHOR A LITTLE TOO ON-THE-NOSE
DOES ZERO/DEKU REALLY INTEND TO STEAL A QUIRK FROM HIS COUSINS AND KILL EVERYONE ON THE ISLAND
WHY DOES ALL MIGHT KNOW A BUNCH OF RANDOM PHYSICS SHIT THAT SEEMS OVERLY CONVENIENT TO DRIVE THE PLOT FORWARD
find out on next episode of 'wait. wait really? mostly plot for a while? no sex? okay i guess i'll dip PEACE BITCH'

Memes, now Seasonally AppropriateTM



Me, writing the most ridiculous daytime soap-opera-ass-shit:



(man I'm crazy nervous about posting this one. zero-sum is my heart and a ridiculously vulnerable point for me because its my first attempt at writing something more serious in a long long LONG time. its like when a comedian you really like does a dramatic role, and you either think its awesome or you think 'hm maybe they should stick to the jokes.' if you're thinking the latter please don't tell me just let me flop lmao. Sometimes you gotta be cringe in order to grow and stop being paralyzed by your fear of not being good enough... if i sat on this chapter any longer i'd rewrite it one hundred more times, so i hope its okay. thank you for reading as always. i dont have words for how much it means to me.)

Chapter 11

Chapter Notes

Me, looking at the insecure ass authors note from last week: ..... Anyway

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The sound of the bell echoes around campus for what seems like eternity. Students, bundled up in scarves and heavy coats over their uniform jackets, exit the front of the building in groups, huddled together for warmth. Laughter rings out amidst excited conversation as the groups start on the familiar path to Heights Alliance.

Katsuki's eyes follow the bodies disappearing down the trail as he stands behind the gate, hidden from any wandering eyes of students or the overly curious passerby.

An eerie feeling of deja vu settles over Katsuki's shoulders, and all he can do is wait for it to fade, breathing through the mounting adrenaline, the frantic beating of his heart, the sweating in his palms. Everything in him tells him to run, to save himself.

Since walking out after graduation, Katsuki swore he'd never set foot on these god-forsaken grounds again.

This place – the school that he structured his entire life around entering, the place where his dreams were supposed to be realized, the place where he was supposed to grow into the number one hero – is nothing but a cemetery to Katsuki now.

Ghosts are swarming around him – familiar voices, sounds, laughter that he swears he's heard before. He can nearly feel the weight of Shitty Hair's arm around his shoulder, corralling him to the dorms, talking his ear off about something-or-other. Soon enough, they'll be sitting in the common room table, attempting to study. Maybe, Katsuki will find his eyes drifting to the couch, where Deku would be sitting, surrounded by his group of nerds. Maybe Deku would glance up, catching his eye, and grace him with that too-bright smile.

Maybe there's no Shigaraki, no League, no Liberation Front. Maybe they go on to be normal high school students, studying for tests, running mock drills, keeping their distance. Maybe Katsuki would push away that funny feeling, maybe they'd graduate, maybe they'd never see each other except on random missions, maybe they could politely exchange pleasantries and become strangers, maybe Katsuki could move on, *maybe maybe maybe* –

It's not worth thinking about that world. It's not worth thinking about what could have been. This is his reality. He could never have those simple days back.

It's funny. You live the best days of your life and think they're insignificant.

What Katsuki would give to have that eye-sore head of green hair in his eyeline, just one more time. What Katsuki would give just to have *any* of it back.

As the last of the stragglers disappear down the road to the dorms, Katsuki checks that the coast is clear and scans his school-badge against the flickering red light on the electronic gate. With a mechanical click, the door disengages and Katsuki quickly enters the campus. He doesn't take time to acknowledge the significance of this – *first time in two years that he's walked through this gate, the place that Deku disappeared, the place civilians took over, refusing his classmates entry unless they spent their days fighting the escaped villains from the prison riots* – and keeps his feet moving.

The path hasn't changed, and Katsuki knows it like it's been trampled into his psyche. He turns to the left in the fountain, straight into the forested area. The tree has a small carving of a circle along the base, and Katsuki taps down the ground, hearing the metal give under his foot. He clears branches and wilting grass and opens the hatch. Dust plumes out and Katsuki covers his nose, suppressing the urge to cough.

He looks around, ensuring the coast is clear before jumping into the black pit.

He uses a soft explosion to soften his fall; both a signal of his arrival, a warning, and a way to see. None of the lights along the tunnel are on, and the place looks like hell warmed over, more spiderwebs, dirt and dust than anything. Not that the place was ever inviting, but the near-absolute darkness and deafening silence is making Katsuki's hair stand on end.

Katsuki keeps his palms ignited with a tiny fireworks, popping and sizzling and casting alternating shadows along the darkened path, making them seem nearly alive. Katsuki's stride speeds up.

When he finally gets to the door, he pauses. His brain can't help but make the comparison; after all, each of these bunkers were made were nearly identical in their layout, all supposedly connected under the city. A part of Katsuki feels like he'll see Zero, sitting there on a bunk bed, holding a shitty English book with his organic hand. That he'll look up at him, give him that annoying-ass smirk, and Katsuki would shut the door behind him with no intention of opening it again.

Zero is not there. Instead, the skeletal form of Toshinori Yagi sits on one of the beds, cane resting on his lap. Aizawa, has chosen to stand, arms crossed and face fixed in a permanent scowl as he leans against a dust-covered dresser. His entrance causes the two men to look up, and Katsuki gets the delirious impression that he's about to get scolded for getting into a fight; like the two will give him one of those old lectures about his 'behavior' and call his mother.

"What are you waiting for, problem child? Get in here." Aizawa orders more than asks, and Katsuki gives him a short nod before closing the door behind him. A single, swinging lightbulb is the only source of light in the room; it flickers intermittently. Katsuki frowns at the sight of a condom wrapper and some empty bottles of alcohol on the floor, kicking them out of the way as he sits on the bunk-bed across from Yagi.

"The kids found this place about a year ago. It's a popular spot to…" Aizawa starts to explain, even though Katsuki didn't ask, and has never given less of a shit.

"Disappoint their parents," Yagi finishes for him. His voice sounds haggard and hoarse, eyes sunken, and Katsuki ignores the instant flare of concern.

Despite that, the tension in the room seems to ease, if only for a moment, and Katsuki turns his attention back to Aizawa. His single good eye watches him, brow furrowed.

"… have you been eating? Or sleeping? You look like a corpse."

Katsuki's heart skips a beat and his cheeks flush with something between embarrassment and unadulterated rage.

"What are you, my fucking mom?"

"Someone has to be. Do your parents know you're like this?"

"I haven't seen them in…. a while." Katsuki answers truthfully. The thought of his parents seeing him like… like *this* sends a cold chill down his spine. He can't. He just can't. Not until he's better. Not until everything is better. Not until this is *over*.

Uncomfortable silence extends between them, Aizawa's eye boring into Katsuki's very soul.

"… Shota, Young Bakugou discovered something regarding his search for Young Midoriya that I think may be quite relevant to us." Toshinori Yagi's voice is tentative, soft, like trying to calm a wild animal, and Katsuki is surprised to see the other's shoulders relax just a bit at the placation.

"… You're still looking for him."

Katsuki refuses to acknowledge the pity in his tone. Every single inch of him wants to rub it into his former homeroom teacher's face – *Fuck you, you're wrong, he wasn't dead, he's here, he's alive, I can still save him, I can still –*

Instead, Katsuki grits his teeth and ignores him.

"You remember the letters he left for everyone? The ones Yagi dropped off at everyone's door the night he disappeared?"

Aizawa glances in Yagi's direction, reading the guilt on his face instantly before looking back to Katsuki.

"Yes. I also recall you made a show out of ripping the note up in front of the whole class. To make some kind of point."

"Can you fucking – just. Look, Deku left me hints on the way his quirk works, and..."

"… And you chose to keep that information private." Aizawa's tone is straight up accusatory, and Katsuki has to clench his fists, soaked with sweat, to prevent himself from igniting.

"The note was addressed to me. It was mine. You ain't entitled to any of the shit he told me."

"So you chose to shoulder the burden of finding him alone."

He hadn't. There's one other person he showed the note to. One other person who, when everyone else stopped looking, spent his nights holed up in Katsuki's dorm room, searched with him with an equal fervor. He was the person he chose to share this secret with, and all he got for putting his trust and faith in someone else is betrayal.

So here he is.

"Does any of that fucking matter now? I figured it out. So fucking listen, because all of 3A and 3B are about to potentially die in the crossfires of Deku's and Shigaraki's final battle."

That shuts Aizawa up. He straightens up, approaching Katsuki. Standing over him, the man that once seemed so imposing seems almost small. Too human.

“That’s not something to joke about.”

“Do I fucking look like I’m joking?” Katsuki stares Aizawa down, and the man finally breaks, stepping away to join Yagi on the bed. He rests his elbows on his knees, running his hands through his hair before looking back up at Katsuki.

“Okay. I’m listening.”

Katsuki takes a deep breath, and then does his goddamn best to explain it. The discovery that identical twins share the same quirk and can access a ‘vestige world’ where they are able to communicate. The fact that One for All and All for One were twins, and the two separate quirks they had been thinking as opposing forces are actually the same Quirk. That a Quirk shared between twins ebbs and flows between the two depending on the owner’s strength, and that Deku has slowly been stealing Shigaraki’s quirks over the years. That the recent cases of twins being kidnapped and the blood analysis has to do with finding identical twins, because they can maintain the connection with them and store Quirks that they don’t want the other to have easy access to, but can call upon if needed.

Aizawa keeps his face even during the whole story, not so much as raising an eyebrow. Yagi sitting next to him, however, seems to be brimming with a newfound energy, foot tapping impatiently against the dirty floor.

“… And what does that have to do with my class?”

“This is where it gets a little complicated,” Katsuki starts, not noticing the incredulous look Yagi and Aizawa exchange between one another.

“Well, okay, see. Aoto and Otoa, they’re actually identical twins, and All for One is their grandfather, and they have a Quirk that could potentially… annihilate All of One? Shigaraki must have found that out, somehow, and had been looking for them with those blood samples. Despite them being registered as fraternal, they’re identical, which is probably why he set up these labs…”

“…So you’re saying Tomura Shigaraki *might* come to the Training Camp to *maybe* steal a Quirk from two of my students.”

“No… It’s more likely that he’ll kill them. Shigaraki can’t take the quirk, because Deku can potentially steal it. If… If he takes it, then he could use it to - ”

“…Midoriya hasn’t been seen in four years. Neither has Shigaraki. You are making a presumption that for some reason, one or both of them is going to show up to the training camp to either kill my students or steal their quirk, and, what…?”

“Have their final fight. With their Quirk, Deku could probably take on Shigaraki and erase One for All and All for One from existence without killing Shigaraki.”

Theoretically. If they were able to escape the explosion that the electron-proton annihilation would cause.

Aizawa seems to ponder.

“And why has Shigaraki not already killed the boys?”

Katsuki sharply closes his mouth. He knows why he hadn't killed Deku, but the twins themselves…?

Zero had implied that the Shiryoku twins were still necessary for Shigaraki to use his Quirk. In this situation, since they hold Regenerate, Shigaraki wouldn't kill them, because that's an incredibly useful Quirk.

Why wouldn't he just… steal it back?

The same reason that he can't steal the Quirks from Deku? That once the connection is opened, it's the *same* Quirk, and thus cannot be stolen?

Fine. If the twins act as miniature Dekus 'sharing' the same Quirk, then can't Shigaraki just… distribute his Quirks to thousands of twins and establish enough of a connection to just… get rid of Deku? If there's enough flow?

Except the twins are connected to Shigaraki, but not to one another. The power can flow from them to Shigaraki and back, but not between each other, and that limits the amount of power any of the twins are able to hold.

What he needs is another Deku. A twin that can hold multiple Quirks, someone that Shigaraki can establish a new 'circuit' with, so he can get rid of Izuku. He might be losing the Quirks Izuku already holds, but can likely retain significant power if he just… expands his circuit. Adds in a new capacitor.

Katsuki's mouth drops open at the realization.

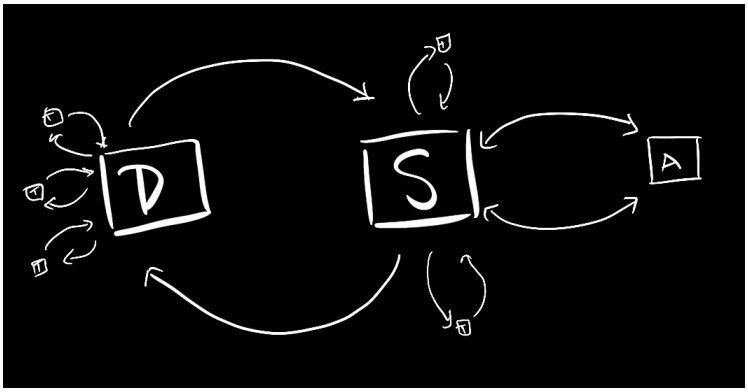
"Oh."

Aizawa leans forward, watching Katsuki as Katsuki's brain tries to process the realization, running equations in his head. It's… a long shot, but it might be Shigaraki's *only* shot.

"…Care to share with the class?"

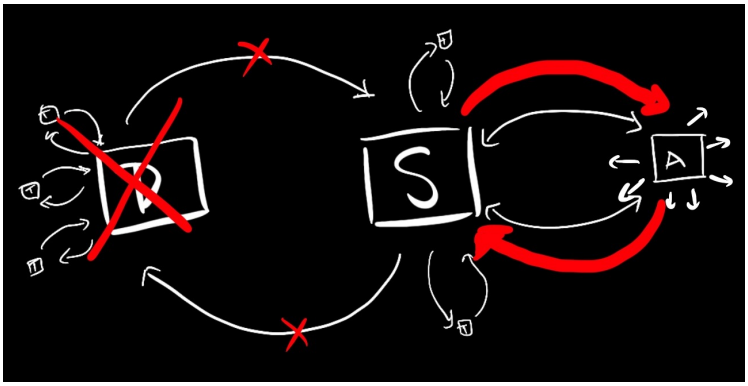
Katsuki gets on his knees with no hesitation, using a finger to sketch out his thoughts before they leave his sleep-deprived brain, not caring about how fucking disgusting it that he can draw in the grime.

The final result shows something similar to what Yagi drew on the beach – Shigaraki and Deku as two large 'squares,' the capacitors in the circuit, with the twins that siphoned off quirks branching off the original grid. Then, he adds a smaller box, titled [A.]



“Shigaraki knows that if he kills Deku, the circuit for the Quirk will be broken, and he wouldn’t be able to All for One and One for All anymore. His goal is to preserve his power, and Deku is making that impossible. He’s his only obstacle to reaching his goal. But he knows that twins can act as little… extensions of the circuit. So if he forms a connection with all the twins, the Quirks can continue to flow. Except all the twins can only handle the one additional quirk, and aren’t connected to one another, so they act more like resistors; they redirect the power, but don’t allow for the flow. What he needs is a capacitor – another source of power that he can attach to his circuit, that allows for All for One and One for All to still function. That way, he can get rid of Deku, but still maintain at least *some* of his power.”

Katsuki draws an X through Deku’s square, then makes the arrows extending to [A] larger.



“It has to be Aoto and Otoa. There’s no one else that could withstand the amount of power that Shigaraki needs to conduct. They’re direct descendants of the creator, like Deku. They’re U.A. students, like Deku. It has to be them. There’s no one else in the world that would give Shigaraki a fighting chance to win.”

“…Do you hear how insane you sound?” Aizawa finally says, although his eyes don’t leave the dirty drawing on the floor.

Katsuki stares at the ground, at his grimy fingertips, at the [D] with the large X through it.

Yeah, he might sound insane. He might be wrong. Hell, he probably is. This theory works on the assumption that Aoto and Otoa, once the connection is made, wouldn’t be able to overpower Shigaraki, wouldn’t be able to take their Quirk back from him, and wouldn’t be able to use it against him.

…That said, Deku, a boy with eight Quirks, trained for four years, completely altering his body and siphoning off the more powerful and useful Quirks to random twins prior to even *hoping* to compete with Shagaraki. Two bright eyed, pink-cheeked part-time baristas? Katsuki doesn’t like their odds.

“… I believe Young Bakugou is right. It works in both Young Midoriya’s and Tomura Shigaraki’s favor for the boys to be isolated, and for the boys to act as bait to lure the other out. These are all presumptions, of course, but…”

“We have no proof. No proof that either one of them will even show up. We have no evidence that either one of them is even *alive.*”

“They are,” Yagi interrupts before Katsuki has the opportunity to open his mouth. “I know they are. I can…” Yagi stares at his boney hands, furrowing his eyebrows. “I can… *feel* it. The power is still flowing, somewhere. And if one is alive, so is the other.”

Aizawa seems to be stunned into silence. Finally he nods slowly.

"… So, you want me to cancel the training camp."

"No." Katsuki stands up, dusting his knees off with equally dirty hands. "I want to help Deku defeat Shigaraki. I want to help protect those kids. I want to fucking *end* this, once and for all."

"We're working off a half-baked theory about something may or may not happen." Aizawa says again, and Katsuki hears his jaw pop.

"What, and you'd rather take the chance and put all your students' lives at risk? What, does putting kids in danger make your dick hard or something?"

Aizawa's eyebrows shoot up and his single eye glows a violent red, hair starting to stand on end.

"Shota. Please. If he's right, we need to prepare. If he's wrong, it will be a nice quiet training camp for our third years with an extra chaperone. If he's right, we can finally defeat All for One, save Young Midoriya *and* keep the children safe."

They both stare at Aizawa, and finally, he shakes his head and relents.

"You're going to a pain in my ass until I die, aren't ya?"

"If it wasn't for me, that would be just two days from now, so stop being a jackass and listen. I have a fucking plan."

Aizawa rolls his one eye, which would almost be comical if it wasn't so goddamn sad, and leans in. Yagi does as well, and Katsuki lowers his voice as if he's sharing a secret, despite their very obvious underground isolation.

"How do you keep 40 teenagers calm *and* have them prepare for a fucking apocalypse?"

Katsuki doesn't wait for an answer as Yagi and Aizawa exchange another cryptic look.

"You make it part of the game. Listen – "

Two hours later, everything's in motion.

Saturday morning, Katsuki stares at his spotless apartment, duffel bag over his shoulder. He lets the moment settle in the pit of his stomach, the finality of it all still raw and undigested. This might be the last time he sees the place. If he's going to die, his mother will be in this apartment, digging through his things. He tried to keep that in mind as he tore down most of his Deku-related content from his wall, leaving the tracking information about the League and the research on the twins up. After all, if he doesn't make it, all this data might be useful to somebody.

His police radio, his router, and his hard-drive sit under piles of garbage in the storage closet on his roof. Hopefully not to be found for years.

He chews his lip before wandering back inside. He left his study unlocked. Inside, he grabs a blank sheet of paper. He pauses for a minute, thinking of what to say, how to explain any of this, but he comes up short. There's no way to say goodbye that would make any goddamn sense, not to them and not to him.

The message he decides on is simple.

Hey Mom and Dad,

I'm sorry. I love you both.

Katsuki

He folds it once, leaving it on his work desk before he makes his way back to the front door.

"Well," he says to the apartment, feeling silly for talking to a couple of walls. "See you Monday," he fibs to no one, and locks his door.

Only one more thing to take care of.

Katsuki presses his phone to his ear.

"Bakugou!?"

Jirou Kyoka answers the phone immediately.

"No one's heard from you in days! Are you okay?"

"… I'm fine," Katsuki lies through gritted teeth. Last time they saw each other, he was a complete dickbag to her. He doesn't deserve her concern. He doesn't deserve to have anyone worry about him, really.

It's easier that way. When he disappears, it won't be like with Deku. People won't be looking. People won't miss him. Tears won't be shed. He'll just be gone.

It's a comforting thought.

"I need something. There's – I can't really tell you the details, but it's the twins case."

"..Oh! Oh. Are you still working that? Have there been more labs? I thought the police took it over…"

"Yeah, they did." Katsuki cuts off, rubbing the bridge of his nose. "Look, there are three pairs that I think are going to be targets."

"I'm going to need more to go on than that."

"Kyoka."

The silence on the other end of the line is deafening.

"I've – recently, they've been followed. I can't say by who, or why, but I need you to trust me. If you don't, I don't care, just... I need someone to keep an eye out for them. I'll hire your team. I'll pay."

"…Bakugou, hey. Just send me the names and addresses. We'll take care of it."

"Thanks for – " Katsuki bites his tongue. For what? For caring? For playing in that band with him? For being his friend?

Katsuki says none of that.

"Just. Thanks, Ears. I'll, uh. I'll talk to you later."

One train ride and short walk later, Katsuki is right back to the front gates of U.A. The large gaggle of students is impossible to ignore, all talking loudly in their designated groups. Three ‘adults,’ all in brightly dressed uniforms, escalate the volume from ‘annoying’ to ‘eardrum shattering’ with their shouting and breaking-sound-barrier laughter.

Katsuki doesn’t let his steps stutter, even though his brain is screaming at him to *Abort! Abort! Abort!*

Kirishima, of course, is the first to see him. Katsuki watches in real time as the smile drops off his face, as he elbows Ashido and the other’s eyes widen at his approach.

“…Um. Bakugou. I didn’t know you were – “

“Yes, well, there’s been a recent change in the plans, and we needed a fourth chaperone! The old gang back together again, huh?” Yagi adds extremely unhelpfully as he appears from literally nowhere, putting a bony hand on both Katsuki’s and Kirishima’s shoulder, the latter of which looks like he’d rather be anywhere else.

“…. Wow. This just, uh. Doesn’t seem like your scene. I asked you, like, multiple times – “

“Yeah, well, I changed my mind,” Katsuki clips back, and Kirishima shuts his mouth tight, shoulders tensing.

“Oh, did he say that they changed stuff? It's not gonna be a scavenger hunt any- mmmhhm!”

A pink hand slaps over Utsushimi’s big mouth, pink head of curls shaking wildly.

“Don’t! It's supposed to be a surprise for the kids!” Ashido’s hand falls from the other’s mouth.

“Actually, yeah, did they change it?”

“Aizawa-sensei –“

“We’ll talk about it later. Alright, everyone. On the bus. Don’t – “

Katsuki can’t ignore the dozens of stares, including Otoa and Aoto, standing towards the back. He looks to them, glaring, and the both the boy’s eyes widen in synchrony. As Katsuki turns away with a scowl, they playfully punch each other’s shoulders, grinning wide, blushes painting both of their cheeks.

Katsuki’s the first on the bus. He sits by the window in the first seat, resting his legs against the outcropping for the wheel. He tries his best to avoid eye contact with the 40 hero wannabes all gawking at him as they board the bus, and doesn’t expect anyone to talk to him until a voice brings him out of his not-brooding.

“…Mind if I sit here?”

Katsuki grunts at Kirishima, shrugging his shoulders. “Do whatever you want.”

“Thanks, man.” Kirishima sits down next to Katsuki, not saying anything. The bus starts, and the sound of the road and chatter fades into the background. To their right, Utsushimi and Ashido giggle privately, staring at Ashido’s phone with rapt attention. He closes his eyes, pretending to sleep.

He doesn’t acknowledge the way Kirishima fidgets next to him or the multiple clearings of his throat.

In the end, Katsuki actually dozes off, and before he knows it, Kirishima is politely nudging him awake so they can make their transfer to the ferry.

Kirishima, Ashido and Utsushimi mingle with the students, playing cards and watching videos while Katsuki exits the common room and heads to the empty bow. The wind whips around his hair, and the scent of salt is nearly overwhelming.

Katsuki watches the land disappear.

It might be the last time he's ever setting foot on mainland Japan.

He's coming back with Deku or he's not coming back at all. That's a promise he intends to keep.

By the time they make it to Minami-Ioto Island, it's late afternoon. During their time on the boat, Katsuki made his way back from the bow, grabbing the three others and informing them of the change of plans. No one uttered their suspicion or disagreement aloud, but Katsuki wasn't blind to the panicked exchange of glances, particularly when Katsuki gave them the details of how this little scavenger hunt is going to have… Well.

More incentive to succeed. Higher stakes, if you will.

He doesn't tell them exactly how high the stakes might be.

The kids all make it off the ferry, forty teenagers standing in the sand like an assembly of bright-eyed dumbasses. They're too busy swiveling their heads around, pure excitement painted on their faces, to notice how morose Yagi looks, the very picture of a skeleton himself.

Katsuki hopes these idiots did their research, because their lives literally depend on it.

"Okay, little shits, listen up – "

Yagi and Aizawa give Katsuki a look, but they stand in the back of the crowd, letting him talk.

"The game is Nuclear Fallout. You've been stranded on a deserted island during the end of the world. Your job is to find resources, shelter, water and food. At random intervals, one of us will release a signal meaning 'Air Strike.' If any are found outside or in non-suitable shelters, they are 'dead.' The team with the most 'alive' at the end is the winner. You cannot exchange team members and you cannot abandon the 'dead' team members or you will be disqualified."

Smiles start to disappear off faces one by one.

"Resources can be found scattered throughout the island and can be obtained on a first come, first serve basis. Each team has four cards; red, orange, pink and yellow. These represent your four chaperones. At any time, you can use your card for a hint or to use one of our Quirks."

"These – " Katsuki pulls box from his bag with a bunch of green pins. "Are your trackers and your team designations. If someone is hurt or would like to be ejected from the game, press the pin, which will alert us of your location. Now, everyone, come and grab a pin."

The kids swarm around him, some trying to discern differences in the pins, as if it's going to help them in the long run. He recognizes the ambition, the analytics, the overbearing confidence and flippancy in the students like he never left high school in the first place. It sets his teeth on edge.

It takes longer than it should, but finally, forty seventeen- and eighteen-year-olds are standing at attention in front of Katsuki like little soldiers, ready to do anything they're told. Just like U.A. intended.

"Okay. The color of your badge will determine your team. These are completely random."

Except for the twins, Katsuki thinks. Those two are staying on the same team. Much easier to track that way.

The badges suddenly all flicker in a rainbow of colors, taking a few seconds to land on the final color. The kids look around, glancing at the pins on their friends, some crying out in joy while some protest half-heartedly.

After a few more minutes, eight groups of five siphon off based on their colors.

"Okay. Any questions."

"Yeah! How – how do we know when there's going to be an 'air strike?'"

"One of the four of us will release a signal with this flare gun. It's your job to be paying attention. "

"What do the winners get?"

Katsuki's voice catches in his throat.

Fuck.

He hadn't thought of that.

"The winners get an all-expense paid three month guaranteed internship with me in Las Vegas!" Kirishima boasts, and the kids look between each other, excitement palpable. Many of them have likely never been on an airplane, and the opportunity to practice hero work in a foreign country, particularly where heroes were still publicly ranked, allowed to maintain celebrity status and not regulated by a commission is like every reckless eighteen year old's wet dream.

"Happy now? We're wasting daylight. Chop chop."

The kids look at each other.

"GO! It's a fucking Nuclear Fallout out here! You never know when the next bomb is gonna drop!"

Literally, but they don't need to know that.

The kids scramble off in different directions until Katsuki is left alone with the three additional chaperones, Aizawa and Yagi.

"Uh…. Aizawa-sensei, I don't mean to complain, but why did you guys change the training camp? They're just kids!"

"Kids that are about to enter the world as pro heroes in just a few months. All of you went through much worse."

Mouths snap shut. What sits unspoken between them could probably fill a couple of therapists notebooks, and everyone there knows it.

“So… uh. What do *we* do?” Utsushimi asks, putting a finger to her lips.

“The four of you will be following the kids. Making sure they’re safe. I’d split the island into fourths and take your own section. I’ll be sending out the alert for when the next strike is at random intervals.” Aizawa nods to his own phone. “The two of us will stay here as home base. Any problems, find us here.”

The island is small enough, just a few miles across in length and width, with a single ‘mountain’ standing just over two miles in elevation. They’ll never be too far from each other, and never too distant to swipe in and save the kids, if needed.

“…Okay. Well, I guess – “

“Final thing,” Katsuki cuts Kirishima off as he adjusts his duffel over his shoulder.

“If I send off two shots. Hide. Hide immediately. Do not look for me, do not try to investigate, just *hide.* If any of you see anything to alert the rest of us, send off two shots.”

“…Bakugou. Are you expecting something to happen?” Kirishima, as always, sees right through Katsuki, and Katsuki clears his throat as he exchanges knowing looks with his former teachers.

They all decided, unanimously, not to tell the other three.

Katsuki can pretend that he doesn’t feel guilty about this. At least for the next 48 hours.

“Everything is going to be fine. Two shots. Don’t forget.”

Kirishima looks like he wants to say something else, but Katsuki doesn’t let him.

“I’ll take North. Kirishima can take South, Ashido should take West and Utsushimi takes East.”

With that, Katsuki starts to walk, not waiting for a response.

It’s a beautiful day. The air is just on the wrong side of frigid, waves high and dangerous.

Katsuki doesn’t see the pair of black eyes narrow at him from midway up the mountain.

He’s not even close to making it to his destination when the first text comes in.

He lifts his flare gun, shooting it off into the sky. Birds squawk and fly out of the trees, and the sound echoes throughout the island.

Katsuki gives exactly 60 seconds before he blasts off, looking around at the groups of kids within his quadrant.

One kid under a pile of leaves. *Dead.*

One kid fused with a tree… good idea, but fucking *dead.*

Aoto’s team, though, Katsuki couldn’t help but admire. One mole-looking kid dug into the sand just by the beach, and with a quick flick of his hands, Aoto turned a well-placed wave of water into a deep cascade of rock.

Alive.

“Let’s fucking keep it that way,” Katsuki thinks out loud. Once he’s finished marking the kids that ‘died’ on his own map, he continues to survey the area to set up his tent. In the end, he goes to the beach, situating himself between two trees, foliage and tall grass hiding his tent from any prying eyes.

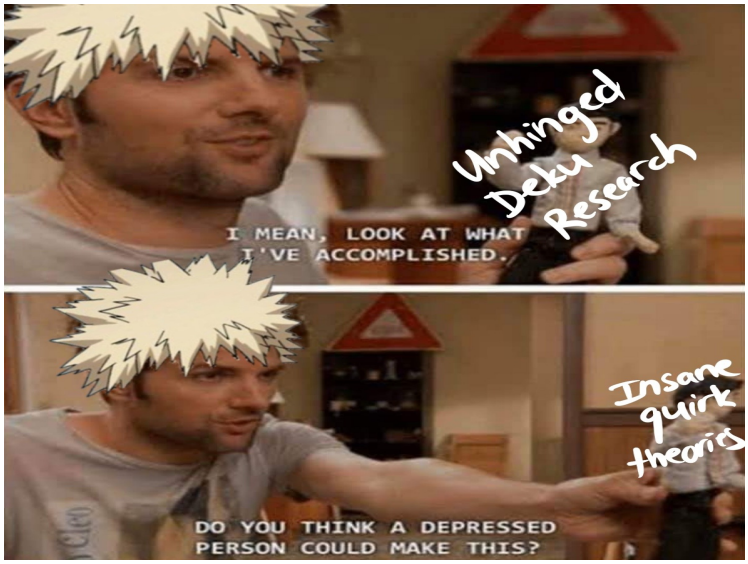
Katsuki lays down inside the tent despite the fact that night hasn’t set yet and pulls out his phone. The green dot flashes somewhere in the middle of the island – probably up on the mountain for the best vantage point. Waiting for the Honoka twins. Waiting for Shigaraki. Certainly not waiting for Katsuki, who he has to know is here.

Katsuki grins to himself, just imagining the look on the other's face. He's underestimated him for the last time, perhaps literally.

If Deku thinks he can get rid of him that easy, he’s got another thing coming.

Chapter End Notes

Katsuki to Aizawa in the bunker:



Katsuki, coming up with his plan of how to trick a bunch of kids into saving themselves without informing them of the danger they're in, like the optimal role model he is:



alfdjasdfjasdf if you see plotholes... no you dont

also not to honk my own clown-nose, but next chapter is going to be LIT. i nearly cried writing it, which... i dont do because i'm the one writing it lmao. (don't worry, like... we're probably about halfway through the story right now, no Izukus or Katsukis were murdered in the making of this story.)

Chapter 12

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

BANG!

Katsuki wakes up with a start, shirt soaked through with sweat despite the chill in the air, early morning sunlight peeking through the leaves he's used to hide his campsite.

"Fuck!" Katsuki groans, hitting his fist against the lumpy ground as his sleep-addled mind recognizes the flare for what it is. It's come from the East – likely from Utsushimi. His chest heaves as he tries to catch his breath, heart trying to worm it's way out of his ribcage and crawl straight into the ocean.

It's just a flare. It's not Shigaraki. He didn't miss the other's arrival. He didn't miss Deku's insane ass kamikaze suicide mission. This isn't over. The kids are safe. He's safe. Deku's – Deku's -

Katsuki's hands are shaking so hard he has trouble grasping at his phone from inside his sleeping bag. When he finally gets his slippery grip around it, he switches to the tracking app without hesitation.

He feels the tightness in his chest unfurl as he sees the green light, blinking, static in its spot on top of the mountain.

It must have been freezing up there in the middle of the night. For some reason, the image of Zero huddled up alone against the cold makes nausea rise to the back of his throat, and Katsuki sits upright, suddenly annoyed with himself.

He climbs out of his tent to a world just waking up. The sun is still rising, the sky a soft peach against a violet backdrop. This far south from the mainland, the temperature is much more forgiving, but the early morning remains cuddled in its own frosty blanket, blissfully unaware of the impending Spring. Katsuki rubs his hands along his arms, nitroglycerin evaporating rapidly into the atmosphere, leaving his skin ice-cold.

He steps onto the sand, feeling himself sink ever-so-slightly. He turns his head. The shoreline is remarkably empty; it should be so soon after a flare is released. Despite what he knows must be forty high school students scurrying inland, the whole world is quiet - save for the crashing of the ocean.

The waves crest, then break. Katsuki's alone. They rescind, wet sand and bubbles left in their wake. Katsuki's been alone for a long time. They rise once more, the water nearly translucent as the tide turns, reflecting sunlight before succumbing to inky blackness. Katsuki might have been alone his whole life.

The salt must be irritating his eyes, and he blinks a few times, clearing his throat for no one before taking a deep breath of briny air.

When this is all over, Katsuki needs a vacation.

He rolls his shoulders, back cracking before he aims his hands to the ground, sand crystallizing as he releases a concentrated explosion, launching himself into the sky.

It takes nearly two minutes of being airborne to see movement out of the corner of his eye – beating the last record by nearly thirty seconds. Katsuki still finds himself bristling with annoyance. If it was

him, he would have got it right on the first try. Hell, he hates to admit it, but his entire shitty class wouldn't *still* be fucking up.

He directs a blast behind himself, launching his body into the foliage.

"YEEP!"

Katsuki steps over the broken branches and burned leaves from his landing towards the sound and *smell* - one that's nearly appetizing enough to make his own stomach growl –

The girl stands in front of the makeshift campfire, skewer of fish roasting over the open flame, eyes wide and fixed on him. Her teammate, standing right next to her, seems to have been mid-way through a bite, and as her jaw slackens, the whole fish falls out of her mouth and onto the ground. Katsuki darts his eyes to follow the back of a third teammate, who decided to bolt out of sight the second Katsuki landed.

At least they had the goddamn instinct to run when they were in danger.

"Uh…" the girl still holding the skewer over the fire starts, body entirely stiff, like Katsuki's some kind of cold-blooded reptile that won't notice her presence if she simply doesn't move.

"What the fuck are you doing?"

The girl furrows her eyebrows, face transforming from concerned to defiant in less than a second.

"We're having breakfast."

"… You didn't hear the flare go off?" Katsuki's jaw twitches. Wouldn't Aizawa be so fuckin' proud of him, watching him give someone *the benefit of the doubt* and a *chance to explain themselves* -

The other girl, the one with the floppy-ass mouth who lets food dribble out like some kind of savage wakes up from her stupor, suddenly stepping in front of the girl *still* grilling her fish over the open flame, fanning her hands in front of Katsuki in a manner that he's sure is supposed to be placating, like a hiker might respond to an approaching mountain lion.

"We did! But we just started cooking – and if we hid, everything would get cold – and it took us so long to catch all these fish, and – "

"Are you FUCKING kidding me?" Katsuki releases a harsh explosion from one hand, and the girl yelps once more, ducking down and closing her eyes. "You're not even gonna *pretend* like you tried*?!* You call yourselves heroes and can't follow simple goddamn *directions* from your superior? This is fucking pathetic! I thought you were *U.A.* students!"

The girl in front has huge, watering eyes, and something about the way she's looking up at him, eyebrows furrowed, poorly hiding her emotion behind bravado makes Katsuki's stomach flip. He glances away, breaking their staring contest to feign a cough.

They look so fucking *young.* Were him and his classmates really two years younger than *these* kids when they fought in the war?

"You're being such a jerk, Dynamight! It's just a *game!"* the girl *still* grilling her fish, which has now turned into a charred, shriveled thing, insists, placing a comforting hand on the shoulder of the girl in front of her.

Wrong fucking answer.

“A *game?!* What, all of school has been a goddamn game to you?! All these battle drills, all these skirmishes, all these rescue scenarios, the three years you’ve spent building up your bodies and Quirks and it’s all a goddamn game?! The reason you do this shit is to be ready for the real deal! When the real thing happens and you fucking *die,* who the fuck are you gonna have to blame, huh? Because it won’t be me!”

The two stare at him, eyes wide. Katsuki clenches his fists, eyeing the badges on the two girl’s chests. He doesn’t have time for this. Lost causes. He starts to walk away when one of the girls calls out to him, stopping him.

“What happened to you isn’t going to happen to us!”

Her friend audibly holds her breath, turning and shaking her head slightly in some silent communication.

Even she looks taken aback, slapping her hand over her own mouth as her eyes beg for forgiveness.

When Katsuki just stares at her, not moving, she opens her stupid mouth again, voice a bit softer.

“What happened to you and your classmates was awful! We learned about it in school, and it’s horrible, and no one deserved to go through that, but things are different now! The Hero Commission changed things, and now there’s safeguards against – “

“You really think things are different?” Katsuki cuts her off, voice dark, gaze falling somewhere behind her, because he truly doesn’t think he can stomach looking at her naive face.

“You really think you’re not in danger just because some political bullshit changed? You think just because heroes aren’t on billboards or have public rankings means that people don’t still fucking *hate* us? That people aren’t still *afraid* of us? You think some handshakes and smiling for the camera changed *human fucking nature?!* What you ‘learn about in school’ happened *three years ago.* You were in *middle school.* How the fuck did you already *forget* that shit?”

Because Katsuki thinks about it each and every single fucking day of his life.

“You saved us! That’s what made me want to become – “

“It was scary, but you guys stepped up –“

Katsuki snaps. “Maybe we shouldn’t have had to! Maybe a bunch of fucking *children* shouldn’t have had to answer for the mistakes of adults!”

“We – “

Katsuki scoffs, turning away, refusing to listen to more. Katsuki presses his phone to his ear, evening his voice out as soon as the line connects.

“Yeah. Number 4 and Number 15 are out. I’ll send them your way. If they’re not there within the hour, come get them.”

Katsuki hangs up as the two girls stare at him, slack jawed.

“What did you –“

“Why would you –“

“We can do bett-“

“Too fucking late.” Katsuki puts up a thumb and finger, mimicking a gun. “Dead,” he points to #4. “Dead,” he points again to #15.

What a fucking waste of time.

Katsuki directs his blasts to the ground, not looking back at the tearful girls staring up at him as he disappears into the horizon.

It all leaves a rotten taste in his mouth. On the one hand, he’s indirectly rewarding this kind of behavior. He’s saving the kids that don’t want to save themselves. But that’s his job as a hero, isn’t it? No matter how they feel about him. No matter if they ‘deserve’ it or not. No matter whether they’re thankful to him or not.

No matter is they *want* to be saved.

That’s what a true hero would do.

Maybe Katsuki started to understand that when he saw that thirteen year old boy, notebook gripped tight to his chest, running towards a blazing inferno as Katsuki choked on sewage, reaching out his hands to clasp the same palms that have burned him, hurt him, alienated him.

He nearly gave his own life to try to save someone who didn’t deserve – didn’t *want* - to be saved. Who wouldn’t be grateful. Who would keep hurting him, for reasons Katsuki still doesn’t understand.

It’s a very real possibility that Deku’s going to hate him after this. That he won’t thank him, won’t forgive him, won’t ever speak to him again. There’s a real possibility Katsuki could save his life, and still lose him forever.

But its never been about that. Just to know that he’s alive. Just to know that he’s *okay.* That he’s out there, and he’s happy, and he’s safe. That’s *enough.* It has to be.

One shot to the South. Kirishima.

They barely had a relationship before any of this. They were classmates, reluctant teammates, childhood friends, but nothing more. Katsuki doesn’t expect that to change. With Zero, the vigilante? Maybe. With Deku, the hero? Impossible. Even his very name is painted with their history. There’s no starting over. Their relationship is so fucking termite-ridden and rotten to the core from the second it was built that the only real choice is to knock that motherfucker down.

Never mind that no matter how damaged and destitute, no matter how flawed and rickety, no matter how much the floorboards creak and the ceiling leaks, their broken relationship was still Katsuki’s *home.*

Maybe that’s why they call it moving on.

The obsidian enclosure hides most of the teammates, and Katsuki watches in real time as the last of them trip over a vine, falling down, abandoned by their team. The boy sits up, looking around wildly, expression resigned as soon as he notices Katsuki make his landing.

Katsuki scoffs at the boy before turning to the enclosure the others disappeared behind.

“Get the FUCK out here!” Katsuki screams, pounding his fist against the rock-like structure, the boy still on the ground staring up at him, foot still caught in the vine.

“…Are you hurt?” Katsuki turns around, kneeling next to the boy. His face flushes instantly as he tries to jerk his twisted foot out from under the foliage, poorly hiding a wince.

The four others exit from the enclosure, surrounding Katsuki, wordlessly watching Katsuki apply bandaging to the sprained ankle. As soon as Katsuki’s done, he stands, making a finger gun.

“Dead,” he points to the boy with the sprained ankle. “Dead, dead, dead, dead. Never fuckin’ leave a teammate behind. Go back to Aizawa and Yagi. Get the fuck out of my sight.”

Katsuki starts to walk away, and yet another snot-nosed brat decides to grow a pair and yell back at him.

“It was only one person! You can’t disqualify us for that! Our shelter is - ”

Katsuki doesn’t know what expression he’s making. All he knows is that his blood is boiling, knows that the kid in front of him is shaking in his (literal) boots, and knows that his mind is astoundingly clear.

“One person? You fuckin’ kidding me? A real hero expects nothing but absolute victory. No losses. No deaths. That’s what a *real* fucking team is.” Katsuki spins around, making eye contact with every slack-jawed teenager staring at him in a circle, muddied and tired. Katsuki refuses to see himself or his former classmates in these bright eyed, frustrated kids. He’s not going to fail them the same way every adult in his own life failed him. Failed *them.*

“Not a single *fucking* person dies on this island.”

No one has any clue how much Katsuki means it.

By the time he finally had a goddamn moment to himself, the sun is already setting, and the day flew by without incident. On the one hand, everyone’s safe. They’ve made it through another day without an apocalypse, which is always something to celebrate.

On the other hand, with the onslaught of night comes the unknown. Katsuki’s skin prickles at the memory, burning wood still stagnant in his nostrils, fingertips still wrapping around his own throat. It’s been years, but each creak of wood, each rustle in the leaves makes it seem fresh.

Something about the night outdoors still makes him feel like he’s fifteen. Fifteen, angry and at the top of the world, inadvertently putting dozens of lives in danger and ending the Symbol of Peace, all because some crusty asshole really thought that Katsuki had the makings of a villain.

How long has Katsuki spent thinking that Shigaraki might have been right?

After all, not everyone gets the good fortune to be considered an important playing piece in a villains’ plot. Aoto and Otoa are likely going to be pretty fucked up about this – through no fault of their own, through their birthright and the chance of being born with a Quirk that’s a little *too* useful, they might be indirectly responsible for the end of the world.

That’s the price to pay for being ‘special,’ Katsuki supposes.

In the quiet, he hoists his bag over his shoulders, starting his hike towards where the green dot remains stationary on the mountain. His phone battery is progressively showing him signs of decline,

now on the lower end of yellow, but Katsuki can't focus on that right now. The next text, the next flare, the next bomb, the end could come at any moment. In a minute, in hours, never and somewhere in between.

And between now and the end, Katsuki needs to find Deku.

The hours have passed without Katsuki so much as blinking. He knows his stomach should be growling but it doesn't. He knows his joints, his muscles, his entire body should be aching, but it doesn't. He's numb, head to toe and everywhere in between, nothing but his constant steps to differentiate between reality and a dream.

When Katsuki's close enough to the green signal to be within throwing distance, he ducks down, peering through the trees. There's a small part of him that expected nothing in its place. That somehow the other's found the tracker within the metal casing of his own nerveless arm, that just like every bad spy movie Katsuki would come along to a dummy glowing green.

Instead, a large body sits propped on a rock, short blonde hairs not moving despite the wind. He's hunched over, as if deep in thought, and Katsuki takes a second to admire the silhouette. All muscle, rippling underneath that stealth suit. Katsuki suddenly feels self-conscious in his own thinning body, hand reaching out to grip at his own too-protruding ribs.

There was a point where a strong gust of wind would just blow Deku away. There was a simplicity in him, back then. Big, green eyes, bright smile, pink cheeks, black uniform nearly falling over his skinny body, notebooks always in hand –

Katsuki would have been lying if his change didn't catch his eye, even in middle school.

Looking at him now, Katsuki gets the insane thought that maybe, just maybe, him noticing the other hadn't always been about some odd sense of competition. Maybe there was something else to it all along.

Katsuki walks past the foliage, intentionally letting his hips rustle the leaves. The other's back straightens instantly, but he doesn't turn.

It's almost curious. What would the other use against him? Spear-like limbs to skewer him where he stands? Black whip to immobilize him? What other Quirks, what other monstrosities, what other genetic mutations lie in wait inside that finely-tuned instrument?

How many types of bullets are loaded into that gun? And does it matter, when they all lead to the same outcome?

"You've been avoiding me."

Zero's shoulders rise further, but he doesn't make a sign that he's heard Katsuki. Instead, he puts his hand to his mouth. Katsuki can see a wrapper from the side – some kind of protein bar – and Katsuki pretends that there's not a degree of relief in him that Deku's eating.

Probably for nothing good, like health or enjoyment. Probably trying to maintain that monster body so he can continue to pull their quirk towards the path of least resistance, aka Himself from Shigaraki.

"…You weren't supposed to be here."

His voice sounds serious. Dark. No playful lilt, no games, no familiarity. Just accusation.

“Why not.”

He turns around so fast that Katsuki nearly takes a step back. That furious look on the other’s face is nearly hilarious enough to overshadow the palpitations in Katsuki’s chest at having the other’s eyes on him.

“You weren’t *scheduled* to be here.” Zero addends, voice spitfire. Katsuki walks closer. A foot away, the view is stunning. A cliff of bright green trees, a blue horizon, the ocean. The beach that Aizawa and Yagi are holed up at. There’s a boat there, parked quite obviously on the shore.

“So.. what? It’s because of Red Riot, isn’t it?”

Katsuki furrows his eyebrows.

“Huh?”

Zero doesn’t even look at him.

“I should have figured.”

“What does Eijirou have anything to do with this?”

Whatever that was inside Zero still interpretable as amicable disappears instantly. Katsuki can feel anger roll off the other in waves. If Katsuki didn’t intend to elicit it, it might have been intimidating.

He hasn’t called Kirishima by his first name, Eijirou, *ever.* Not once. Not to his face.

But wouldn’t Izuku Midoriya find him calling their former classmate his first name so casually in conversation goddamn hilarious?

Clearly he does not.

When Zero actually laughs out loud, sarcastic and deep, Katsuki wants to reconsider.

“… I can’t believe this bothers me. How ? Why should it matter to me who you – “ Zero cuts himself off, gaze falling back to the forest, something inflamed within his irises now back to a dull and lifeless black.

Katsuki ignores wherever the hell that was going, folding his arms across his chest.

“This doesn’t have shit to do with him. What, a man can’t enjoy the great outdoors while bonding with some snot-nosed brats?”

“Those snot-nosed brats are only two years younger than you.” Zero points out, and Katsuki feels his smile fall off his face. If Deku is trying to convince himself the shit he’s about to do to these high-schoolers is okay because they’re ‘nearly adults,’ he’s gonna punch him right in his stupid face.

“Why are *you* here, Zero? I’m guessing it’s not for camping.”

There’s not a whole lot of ways fucking shitty-ass-liar Deku is going to worm his way out of this one. There’s only so many excuses one can make about being on a deserted island, during a training camp, along with a bunch of high schoolers, two of whom just happen to be baristas AND twins in the same coffee shop that Zero’s been sitting his muscular ass at for god knows how long.

Katsuki doesn't know how much he needs to push for Zero to confess. There's no way that Deku is so willfully ignorant that he would think Katsuki didn't figure things out.

Zero says nothing.

"I'm guessing, and fuckin' correct me if I'm wrong, but it might have something to do with those twins from the coffee shop. You told me you had a plan. This is it, isn't it?"

Katsuki expects Zero to act more surprised. Maybe Zero has more faith in Katsuki's ability to recognize faces and remember names than Katsuki does himself.

Zero says nothing for way too long. The air between them somehow grows stagnant, but Katsuki doesn't move and Zero does not either.

"You weren't… supposed to be here." Zero repeats for the third time, voice slightly lower. He turns back to the horizon, shoulders drooping and he tilts his head.

"*They're* what Shigaraki was looking for, aren't they? The reason you've been in that coffee shop, the reason you've been hanging around *me.*"

Katsuki watches the other's hands grasp the sides of his own head, leaning forward further. From behind, his back heaves, like he's trying to take a steadying breath.

"You were never supposed to – you were never supposed to get involved. It's not – I didn't mean – "

Katsuki walks closer, until they're less than a foot apart. He reaches out, something in him desperately wanting to place a hand on his shoulder, to comfort him. But Katsuki makes no such move, instead lowering his voice.

"I said I'm in this with you. I said I'd help you. I said I'd kill you, if that's what you needed. But you still left me behind, didn't you?"

"Katsuki – "

"You're trying to win this on your own, and look where the fuck we are! There's forty kids on this island, completely unaware that they might *die,* and you're still refusing to let me – "

Zero stands up so quickly it makes Katsuki's head spin. He clearly didn't expect Katsuki to be so close, because suddenly they're chest to chest, and the furious expression on Zero's face quickly morphs into something softer, more confused, and his eyes oscillate between Katsuki's, searching his face for something as his mouth remains open, choking on his own words.

Katsuki's heart actually skips a beat, warmth crawling up his neck.

"You're making a mistake. Coming here was a mistake. If Red Riot finds you with me – if the kids find us – then it's all over."

Katsuki doesn't hesitate, raising his flare gun to the sky and shooting. The red projectile whizzes above their heads before it bursts into an array of sparkles. Even from the distance, Katsuki can hear trees falling, rock blasting, orders raining down from team to team.

"No one will come looking for us."

Zero gives him an incredulous look, like he doesn't even know how to respond to the situation, before he shakes his head, something nearly fond tugging at the corners of his lips.

"I've been watching your game." Zero bites his lip, but doesn't move out of Katsuki's space, and Katsuki can't help the way his eyes dart to the flesh abused by the row of too-white teeth.

"It's clever. Splitting everyone up. Sending the others to Aizawa and Yagi as a guise of losing, sending them back to the mainland. You've already cut their numbers in half without raising any suspicion. You knew what I was going to do, and you still…"

Zero's eyes flash back to Katsuki, something vulnerable and tender in them. Katsuki's throat closes up.

"I didn't do it for you." It's a lie, and Zero can see it. He smiles gently, and steps away, allowing Katsuki to actually breathe.

"… No. Of course not." Zero agrees. "You did it because you're a hero."

Katsuki scowls, rounding around Zero's body, and sits down in the space Zero was previously occupying. Being that close is messing with his brain, so Katsuki makes some space between them, no matter how much his body protests.

The ship at the other end of the island pulls back from the shore.

Katsuki inhales deeply.

"Stop saying that. You keep using that word, but do you have any idea what means anymore, huh? That what ya want me to be? That make all of this okay? What happened to you wanting me to kill you, huh? What happened to - "

"It was a selfish thing to ask. This isn't your responsibility. *I'm* not your responsibility."

The stars are starting to peak out in the night sky – so much clearer than they are in the city. But then, it's not like Katsuki ever really turns his head upward. Katsuki's been staring down at the ground, at his own grave, for who knows how long.

Looking up feels a little too much like hope.

"Then what is my responsibility?"

"To live." Zero responds without hesitation. "To keep living, to save people, to keep making this world better with your presence."

"You're such a jackass."

Zero shoots Katsuki a sad smirk, and Katsuki smiles back with as much sincerity he can muster. He can't shake the feeling that this is Deku saying goodbye, in his own way, but Katsuki can't think about that. Can't think about the what ifs. He needs to look forward. He will save him.

All these words will be wasted. He'll see.

Katsuki stiffens as he feels the other sit down next to him, leaving too little space between their bodies.

Katsuki swallows the sudden nerves.

“So… You still think he’ll show.”

Zero sighs with his whole body, large shoulder bumping against Katsuki’s. “I’m certain of it.”

Zero looks at his hands. That oppressive, nearly tangible wall that takes Katsuki’s breath away – it wasn’t in Katsuki’s head. It’s power, pure energy, so thick it’s nearly palpable.

Proximity. Proximity makes them stronger.

“Hm,” Katsuki hums. “But you don’t know exactly when or where.”

Zero’s eyes flash with something complex. “I used to. I always used to know where he was. But that couldn’t last forever.” Zero glances at Katsuki, sad smile painting his face. “Nothing really can.”

The moon, already corporeal as dusk starts to fall, shines brightly. Just on the other side, away from the naked eye, is its ‘dark side’, a face always turned away from the Earth in its perfectly synchronized rotation. Looking at Zero now, Katsuki feels like he can understand how a whole can simultaneously consist of something bright and superficial, and something dark and hidden, both important, essential, *beautiful.*

“… Are you afraid?” The words leave Katsuki’s mouth, and he doesn’t know if he’s asking Zero or himself.

“…Am I afraid.” Zero repeats the words slowly, leaning back on his hands. His face points straight to the night sky, and Katsuki takes a second to admire his silhouette. He looks like some kind of painting, growing faintly, lips dipping into a sharp chin as focused eyes gaze off somewhere that only he can see. Katsuki can feel the other’s mind race despite his quiet, sees the slight twitches in the muscles of his face, like he wants to say something but changes his mind a dozen times.

Katsuki is mapping out the other’s face, now focused on the shell of his ear and how badly he wants to kiss it, when the other finally speaks.

“Though my soul may set in darkness, it will rise in perfect light;

I have loved the stars too fondly to be fearful of the night.”

Katsuki stops his careful cataloguing, looking back to the other’s eyes. The night is changing, his eyes are changing, the world is changing, and Katsuki is changing too. He can feel the puzzle pieces sliding just under his skin.

“…What?” Katsuki’s voice sounds broken even to his own ears, croaking out the word like he doesn’t know the meaning of it. An unspoken emotion fills his chest – something deep, foreboding, almost like *grief,* which makes no sense because there’s nothing *to* grieve. Deku is alive, right here, right next to him. Within touching distance.

They have this moment. Katsuki could talk to him. Tell him the truth. They could finally fucking *talk,* like they have never been able to for the past 20 years. If this is the end, what does Katsuki have to lose?

If he so much as asked for Katsuki to come with him, Katsuki would drop everything. His hero career, his family, his friends, his life. It’s true now, and it was true *then,* too.

But Deku never asked, and Katsuki never followed.

Katsuki doesn't so much as twitch.

"It's a poem," Zero continues, unaware of the turmoil in Katsuki's heart. "*The Old Astronomer to His Pupil.* When I lived in America…I started reading a lot of English literature. To pass the time. I liked that one a lot."

"… It's about… well, how I understand it, it's about working towards something, investing in a future you may never see. And for me… I'm here, I have the *ability* to be here, even with a small chance of ending this, because I'm standing on the shoulders of giants. This is… what this power is for. What *I'm* for."

Katsuki swallows. *No.* He's not just a weapon. He's a person. Deku's a fucking human being, and Katsuki's getting the impression that no one has reminded him of this fact for the past four years.

"I've been blessed with my life. Blessed with what I've been given. I already died in every way that matters, so this ending… it feels right, somehow. Like I was always supposed to end up here. And this ending for me is a beginning for everyone else. True hope for the future. I'm happy that… I get to be a part of that."

This stupid, self-sacrificing, martyr *asshole.* Doesn't he know the world is better with him in it? Doesn't he know how he's changed lives by simply being him, by his kindness, by his patience? Doesn't he know that Katsuki needs him?

"But… over the past two weeks, I… the way I felt…" Zero looks conflicted, pursing his lips before continuing. "I'm not afraid of it all ending. And I haven't changed my mind about this. But. I… I just… I wish…"

Zero pauses, eyes shifting to Katsuki's face.

"I wish I could have known you better."

Katsuki's heart drops, the vast hole in his chest stealing his breath away.

"You can know me now," the words are whispered, gentle and reverent like a prayer. Zero's eyes leave his, and he looks back out onto the horizon, at the ocean, at the world that he's ready to give everything for.

Katsuki wants to hate him. He wants not to understand him. He wants.

"No. Not in this lifetime. Not in the way I want. Not in the way you deserve." He pauses.

"You've given me more joy in these two weeks than I've felt in… I just. Even though it's selfish, I'm glad the Quirk didn't work on you. I'm grateful that some things never change."

Katsuki swallows hard. This is honest. This is too honest. He's telling him too much, like he's desperate for Katsuki to confront him, like he knows that Katsuki knows, but he says nothing.

"How does it work? That Quirk."

The quiet is expected. Katsuki sighs, staring off into the distance. The Deku he knew would babble non-stop about the inner workings of the Quirk, every underlying detail, the pros and cons, potential battle strategies. He wouldn't be able to *make* the other shut up, but now -

“By intention.”

“What?” Katsuki turns to him. He didn’t expect an answer, and certainly not the resigned look on the other’s face. Shoulders drooped, lips downturned, eyes somewhere distant and unfocused, Zero looks ashamed.

Katsuki raises his eyebrows, licking his lips. Something in the air tastes like truth, and Katsuki’s hungry, truly hungry, for the first time in years. Zero’s hesitation, the way he shuts his eyes tight, swallowing, before opening them up again, blood-shot and utterly exhausted, is pretty in a way that suffering rarely is.

Katsuki finds himself holding his breath as the other starts to speak again.

“… It’s a passive quirk. It draws on my desire to be remembered.”

Katsuki’s heart thumps painfully against his chest.

“… What the hell does that mean?”

Zero shakes his head, miserable smile tight across his face.

“I knew that you frequent the coffee shop. I knew that you lived nearby. But I was so *sure* that I didn’t want you to remember me. I doubted my resolution with some of the others, so I stayed away, but with you – “ Zero turns to look at Katsuki, eyes pleading, like he’s asking for forgiveness, and Katsuki can do nothing but stare back.

“Each time, I *swore.* I swore you wouldn’t remember the last meeting. Each time we spoke, each time we touched, each time I – every terrible thing I did to you, you still remembered, and that’s because of *me.* Because that means, somewhere in my heart, I wanted you to remember.”

Katsuki feels his jaw slacken.

Everything that Deku had done with him, to him, every touch of lips, every affectionate brush of hands, each confession, each passionate connection of their bodies was all done with the belief that Katsuki would *forget?*

The universe around Katsuki starts to buzz, ears ringing. Immobilized, Katsuki keeps staring into Zero’s eyes, into those fake black irises. He only sees his own horrified face reflected back, and the sickness brewing in his stomach threatens to bowl him over.

“…I’m. Katsuki, I’m so *sorry.* Everything that happened between us, is because *I’m* weak-willed. Because I – I.”

The tears threaten to overflow the other’s eyes.

“The entire universe can be crumbling inside my hands, but I still can’t… Despite everything… despite the person I’ve become, I still want… I still want you to remember me. This version of me. *Any* version of me. Even if you hate me. I can’t – I can’t stop myself from wanting to be a part of your life.”

Katsuki wants to scream. This fucking *idiot.* This fucker, sitting there, bleary eyed and pathetic, going on and on about being a part of Katsuki’s life even as this fucked-up stranger, when in reality, he’s been *all* of Katsuki’s life. Deku’s been alive in every decision, every sacrifice, every waking moment, every dream –

"… All I've ever done is make your life worse. But after this, I promise. I promise I'll be gone. You'll never see me again."

Them, walking through the forest, capturing bugs. Them, walking past one another in the hallway, Deku's sunken eyes and thin body holding on to his shitty little notebook; burned, floating in a koi pond. Them sitting side by side at the U.A. entrance exam. Burned up Deku, broken arm, scorched and wide eyed, building falling around them. That Nomu, coming for him at USJ. The sports festival; watching the other break his fingers, that wild look in his eyes, the pressurized explosion, a supernova of power. The final exam against All Might. The training camp. *Stay back, Deku.* Ground Beta, electricity dancing, wild grin on his lips, sharing each other's air, that feeling in Katsuki's chest. Training sessions, Black Whip, All Might, that shitty notebook, the carefree smile despite being cursed. The war.

A moment of absolute panic – like his life was ending – as he saw those tendrils extending towards Deku.

All of it, all of this, and this *bastard* has the audacity of saying he ruined *Katsuki's* life?

After everything they've been through. After Katsuki's bled for him, died for him, grew and changed *because* of him, this fucker has the audacity –

"I'm not leaving you. I don't fuckin' care what you say. You're not doing this alone. I'm going to be here." Katsuki clenches his jaw to keep the tears back, fists clenched next to him. It feels electric when the other's fingertips reach his tense hand, coaxing it open before intertwining their fingers.

His hands squeezes hard against Katsuki's, enough to hurt, and yet not hard enough.

"I won't let you do that. If something happens to you, then there's no point to any of this."

Katsuki grinds his teeth. He doesn't think he can overpower Zero right now, and his words don't seem to be doing shit.

Only one thing left, Katsuki figures.

"Spend the night with me."

Zero's eyes widen, tips of his ears burning red, starkly obvious even in the darkness.

"I – we – "

"Not for – not that. I just." Katsuki swallows. "It might be our last night on Earth. Don't you – don't you want to – " *Be together? Spend each second we don't have wrapped up in each other's arms? Not waste any precious moment? We've wasted so much time, so much time, and now – now -*

"…Okay."

Katsuki is thrown off by how easy it is to get to the other to agree.

They silently stand. Katsuki walks on autopilot back to his own campsite, trusting the other to follow him. Despite the fact that the two of them can fly there, they both walk – an unspoken agreement of stretching their time together, even if it's like this.

Katsuki pulls back the shrubbery, revealing his small campsite. Katsuki unzips the tent, climbing in first, heart racing as the tiny space is filled with a second body. He zips the tent back up, laying down

completely flat. In the pitch darkness, he can feel the larger body next to him maneuver around. Its hard to avoid touching in the space, so he doesn't. Completely flat, shoulder to shoulder, their entire sides are flush.

Fully dressed, Katsuki's never felt more naked, more vulnerable. Everything is silent, save their own breathing and the rustle of leaves in the wind around them. The waves crest and crash; a sound that might have lulled Katsuki to sleep if only adrenaline wasn't pumping through his veins, like his mid-fight.

He doesn't know what to say. If they are truly his final words to the other, if this is truly the end, if he never sees Deku again after this – no. He can't think like that. He can't allow himself to think that. To believe that even for a second is to admit defeat, and Katsuki would rather die.

And yet – right now, in this darkness, smothered by the other person's warmth, dying is exactly what this feels like. It feels just like the time Izuku was about to be skewered by Shigaraki, but slower and more gnawing, like he's watching the other be tortured, sliced up by fate in real time.

In the pitch blackness, he hears the other's voice. In the pure darkness, without seeing the other's face, his massive body or his metal arm, the voice sounds young, innocent, sweet. Like they're two kids at a slumber party, brave in the cover of night, whispering secrets where no one else can hear them.

"…Have you ever been in love?"

Katsuki's entire chest bursts into flame. Every point of contact – their shoulders, their hips, their shins – feel too hot, burning through his skin.

Katsuki stutters. "…I. N-No. Never."

He doesn't want to ask back, doesn't want to continue this line of questions, but his head feels foggy and he doesn't know what to do. He doesn't know what to do.

"…You?"

"…I don't know." Katsuki wishes that relieved him, but it doesn't. Katsuki doesn't know how an answer can be both exactly what he wanted to hear and just the opposite.

He doesn't expect the other to continue, but he does.

"There's – there's someone that… There's someone that means a great deal to me. Someone I think about all the time. Someone who I worry about. Someone who I would do anything to make happy. Someone who makes me dream about a future, when there's – when I don't have – " Zero's voice breaks, and Katsuki reaches a hand out to the sound, knuckle gentle meeting face. His skin is soft, so soft, and the heat of it makes Katsuki feel at home. He moves closer, nudging himself up on his elbows, until he's hovering over the other, until he can feel his lavender-scented breath.

"Do you – do you think that's what love feels like?" the other whispers, childlike, each word felt against Katsuki's skin like a caress. He leans in, until he feels the other's heart beat against his chest, until their lips are barely brushing.

"Fuck if I know," Katsuki whispers against the other, before he leans in and captures his lips in his own.

The way Deku whimpers into his mouth makes Katsuki want to cry, but he doesn't, not right now, not tonight. Sweet and slow, he moves his lips against the other, letting his brain believe its Deku under

him, it's just the two of them, back in their dorm rooms, hiding under the covers, young and stupid and shy in their inexperience.

In this world, things are different. Katsuki got his head out of his ass. He reached back when Izuku Midoriya reached out to him in that creek. He held that little hand and never let go. They came to U.A. together. They fought together. They took every new challenge, every fear, every experience as one. They had each other. No matter what the world threw at them, they always had each other.

Is that what love is?

If so, Katsuki might well and truly be fucked.

Katsuki feels his own eyes water, tasting the salt between hot breaths, brushes of tongue, the trembling body underneath him, fingers gripping desperately into his shoulders like they're trying to find their anchor to this world, this reality. Here, in this darkness, there's no room for shame, for insecurity, for his own bullshit.

Here he can be honest. He can be honest with Izuku Midoriya for the first fucking time in his life. He can form the words between soft, painful kisses.

"Don't say goodbye to me like this. Not like this. We were supposed to have time. We were- there isn't enough *time* –"

"I'll give you all the time I have left. I'll give you everything. I'm – please – " the ragged, tearful words fly out of Zero like he's begging, and Katsuki doesn't know what to do. He doesn't know what to do. Everything is falling apart in front of him, and it's so beautiful, and his heart is breaking, and he never knew he had a heart that can be broken like this.

"Everything I have is yours. It always has been. Tell me what to do. Just tell me. I don't know - " he sounds so lost, so desperate, and Katsuki doesn't know how to placate him, how to make things better, because he can hardly keep it together himself, and all he wants right now is to be close to him, to talk to him, to know him, to be *together*.

"Talk to me. I just. Talk to me. Leave me something to remember. Don't leave me with nothing. *Please." Izuku. Deku. Please.*

Katsuki needs to know the person he is now. Needs to know the horrors he lived through. Needs to know everything, because if it's over, if its truly over, and he survives, then he will carry the memory. The real memory. The real Izuku Midoriya, not the caricature, not the lie, but him, the broken boy, *and he's still just a boy, isn't he, laying here, trembling under Katsuki's fingers*, the man he became.

Katsuki will do anything to keep him alive. Even if it's like this. Even if it's just in his heart.

"Tell me about America. Tell me about those books you read. Tell me about your life. I need to know."

Zero snorts, rubbing a hand across his eyes.

And then he talks. Katsuki's not sure he processes everything. He's clearly leaving things out, not alluding to things that might reveal his real identity, and Katsuki finds it deliriously hilarious that even in these final moments, Izuku Midoriya would rather die than reveal that he's Zero.

Somewhere between kisses, between roaming hands, between holding one another, between laughter and pain, they must have fallen asleep.

Katsuki refuses to move as he feels shuffling next to him. Light comes through the foliage, barely discernible. He feels the body next to him pause, a gentle finger tracing against his arm, before he signs. He leans in, lips gentle against his ear.

“I hope you have a good life. A happy life. Thank you for letting me play a tiny part. I –

Katsuki can feel tears form in the corners of his eyes.

The sob is quiet, muffled by the other’s mouth.

“M-maybe in the next life, we could…”

He doesn’t finish the sentence.

With that, he leaves the tent.

Chapter End Notes

Katsuki, Realizing Things:



This chapter has it ALL for me lmao, world-building post-war, Katsuki teaching shitty kids from his own mistakes a'la Remedial Course Arc, Katsuki thinking about Izuku non-stop WITH PROSE, crappy metaphors, me making you read more poetry, the reveal of the forgetting quirk!!!! (and the degree of how absolutely AWFUL it is consent wise, which certainly hasn't been WRECKING Izuku this whole time) love-confessions-without-using-the-word, TEARJERKING GOODBYES. We're nearly at the end of arc#2, so two more arcs to go! Two for hurt, two for comfort. Balanced, as all things should be lmao. (...just kidding there's still gonna be plenty of hurt next arc ¯_(ツ)_/¯)

(I just got off 14 days hell-stretch of work, so sorry for the delay! I have to apologize again for how shitty i've been in responding to comments... I get so behind because i work absolutely batshit hours (anna is it legal to work 90-100 hours a week!? apparently!!!!!!! modern medicine

at it's finest!!!!), and literally have no time, and when I do its been like a month, and I figure you guys would rather have a new chapter rather than my embarrassing keysmash responses... especially other authors who are excited about comments on their OWN work and don't want me clogging up their inbox....adjfadsjf; anyway i'm sorry and thank you for reading and i won't take it personally if y'all stop commenting/interacting because i'm MIA constantly,.....)

Chapter 13

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Katsuki stares up at the thin plastic that makes up the roof of his tent. The flimsy structure warps with each gust of wind, bowing inward before puffing out, like the whole thing is some sleeping monster dreaming of its next meal while Katsuki takes shelter within it's ribcage.

Katsuki turns his whole body to the spot Zero occupied next to him just hours before. He can still smell the other in this tent, on his sleeping bag, on his clothes, on his goddamn skin – that persistent floral aftertaste of lavender.

He never smelled like flowers before – and Katsuki can't explain why that makes him so goddamn unsettled. Since he first met him, Deku always reeked of that shitty over-scented discount brand pine detergent. As he got older, that scent mixed with the mint-shampoo that some greedy advertisement company claimed would 'Give Your Hair the All-Might Glow!' Of course the shitty nerd used it exclusively ever since.

When Katsuki found it, not long after Deku disappeared, he nearly blew up the entire goddamn shower; that stupid shampoo made his scalp feel like it was both on fire and freezing fucking cold.

That kid must have been the most masochistic fuck in the world – who chooses to suffer even when showering?!

But, like the stubborn asshole that he is, because he's not going to be beaten by *shampoo, goddamnit,* Katsuki kept using it - for that reason, and for that reason only. After just a few days, the pain and burning stopped.

That's how it goes. Even the most caustic substance, with repeated exposure, no longer hurts you.

Izuku seemed to be an expert in that department.

And he always hated that about him. Hated his willingness to hurt himself, put himself in danger, break himself over and over and over again. He simply couldn't understand how someone could expose themselves to something that hurts – to Katsuki's nitroglycerin, to the effects of One for All, to that mint shampoo – so willingly.

Yet, here he is, in this tent, alone, in goddamn fucking agony because he just can't *stop* running after Zero. Can't stop asking him into his bed, can't stop kissing him, can't stop touching him, can't stop wanting him to *stay* even though every time they're together, Katsuki feels himself tearing apart.

It's funny. Katsuki had no fucking idea what Zero was going on about when he said '*It would be kinder just to kill me*' the first time they slept together, but it makes perfect sense now.

He wasn't designed to feel whatever the hell this is.

It takes more effort than Katsuki can spare, but he chooses not to scrub that feeling away. He dwells on it, lets it tattoo itself into his skin – a thousand tiny needles, jabbing into each nerve, artery and vein. Let's this memory become so ingrained into himself that no shitty forgetting Quirk could touch him.

After all, this hurt might be the last thing Deku leaves him with.

That, and all that pointless shit he kept prattling on about last night.

Their last night on Earth, and the fucker droned on and on, making shapes with his hands as he described how endless the corn fields are in the Midwest, or how bright the stars are in the middle of the desert, or how the physics of mountain goats just don't make sense! And like the absolute fool Katsuki is, he didn't push. He just watched the other's face, that familiar sparkle in his sunken eyes, that crooked smile, just watched him, because he didn't know what else to do.

He didn't dare confront him. Didn't dare ask questions. Didn't dare do anything at all that might make the night end sooner. That might make him leave.

But the night ended, and Deku left him like he always does, with a parting gift of loaded words and fuck-all else.

In the next life.

The same words. He had to have known they were the same words.

Like he doesn't remember. Like he doesn't think about those careless words every goddamn day of his miserable life.

If you think you'll have a Quirk in your next life… go take a swan dive off the roof!

That's just like Deku. To take each awful thing that Katsuki has done to him and turn it into something palatable. Deku, the name of a hero. The next life, a place worth dreaming about. Zero, a person who is simultaneously nothing and everything.

He never even gave Katsuki the chance to apologize.

Katsuki sighs.

After this fight, after Zero is Izuku again, he will. He's got so much he wants to say to him. So much he *needs* to say. Although….

Deku said that the forgetting Quirk *does* work on him. He said that despite knowing that Katsuki remembered each of their prior encounters.

Unless Katsuki *doesn't* remember one of their encounters – he counts the dates back, mentally cataloguing each hour that he can. Are there missing snippets of time? Were there conversations they have repeated? Are there words that he's said that Deku's own volition made Katsuki forget? Are there things that Deku might have said – admitted to, confessed, fuck, anything – that Katsuki's forgotten? Have they had the same conversation a dozen times, Katsuki none-the-wiser?

Has a version of him, one that he doesn't remember, finally had enough? Finally confronted Deku? Finally ask him why the fuck he left, why he didn't tell him anything, why he keeps kissing him like that, why he keeps fucking him even though Katsuki disgusts him, why he tells him almost enough to mean something but never enough to explain, why he won't just let Katsuki in, why he still insists on doing things on his own, why why fucking *why?*

Is there a version of him that told the other everything? About his last four years, about the intervention his last year of high school, about sleeping in his bed or using his shampoo or wearing his clothes or jacking off in his childhood room or the fact that he's fairly sure his mother wants to

fuck him, the fact that he's made searching for him his life mission, the fact that he killed a man because for the first time he couldn't control his emotions when the fucker told him that he was dead? Has he confessed that in the past four years, the only times he didn't feel like he was free falling was when he was in Zero's arms?

Did Katsuki, in one of these forgotten memories, throw his dignity aside and beg Deku to stay?

Doesn't matter. No matter the answer, no matter if these things happened, Deku didn't want them to.

Deku sure as fuck wouldn't want Katsuki to be tracking him.

But… here they are.

Katsuki digs his phone out from his sleeping bag, pressing repeatedly on the power button.

Nothing. Just a blank screen.

Katsuki narrows his eyes. Pressing longer, the red battery signal lights up briefly before going back to black.

Fuck. Katsuki shuffles to his duffel, grabbing the portable charger and cable from the side compartment, hurriedly plugging in his phone. He stares at it expectedly as the brand symbol lights up, an uncomfortable feeling surfacing in his stomach.

He hasn't spent this much time not knowing Zero's exact location since the night in the bunker. The green dot is always there – but fuck, now that he can't check on it, he feels like he's going to disappear. Vanish off the face of the Earth again. Go somewhere where Katsuki can't find him.

The loading bar inches forward at snail-speeds, like it can sense Katsuki's impatience, and it takes every ounce of self-control not to crush the device under his fingers.

Instead, Katsuki takes a steadying breath and unzips his tent, crawling out of his self-imposed prison.

It's cloudy this morning, a grey sheen blanketing the entire island. There's that distinct smell of rain, a tangible friction in the air, like the clouds themselves are emitting a static charge. The waves are rolling higher today, too, disturbed by the atmospheric change. Too high for a common ferry to safely navigate, at least.

If Shigaraki comes, those left on the island will be the same that face him. If his former friends did their jobs, hopefully that means most of the students are off the island by now.

If he comes, he'll have to trust the adults on the island to do the right thing. Protect the kids. Hide.

It's probably too much to hope for.

Utsushimi and Ashido would probably stick to the script – protect the kids and stay out of the fight unless absolutely necessary. But if Katsuki knows Kirishima - and despite their years apart, he really *does* – then he's going to rush straight for the danger. It's one of the things that cemented their friendship and established some degree of mutual respect.

Fucker's gonna get himself killed.

But it's not like Katsuki can do anything about it. He has no way of knowing when or where Shigaraki's gonna land. Especially since even Zero doesn't fucking know where he is… anymore,

apparently.

That couldn't last forever. Nothing really can.

Huh.

What did that mean? Katsuki furrows his eyebrows, tapping against his forehead. Did that mean that he *had* a way to track Shigaraki before?

Had to have been a Quirk that he doesn't have access to anymore. Maybe stored away in one of the three pairs of twins Deku had been trailing.

A Quirk that allows someone to always know your location… sounds familiar. *Extremely* familiar.

Katsuki is spurred from his thoughts at the loud growling sound coming from, surprisingly, his own stomach. It must have been two days now since he's last eaten anything, and just the thought of eating makes him nauseated.

But the sudden intrusive vision of his weakened body collapsing mid-battle because he can't be fucked to eat wins that internal debate by a landslide.

Katsuki approaches the water, placing his palms until they're just above where the sand meets the sea. As the water hits his fingertips, he puts all his power into a blast – the resounding wave sends several fish, slightly charred, straight onto shore. Katsuki smirks to himself, scooping each one up by their tails quickly before the next wave can render them an easy snack for whatever lives under the surf.

He sits down on the shore, staring at the waves. Katsuki digs in the sand, forming a quick sand-pit. With the addition of several stones, dry foliage from closer to his tent and several large leaves to wrap his fish in, Katsuki makes a make-shift sand-pit to cook his breakfast. He sits by the fire, trying to insulate it from the wind as the stones heat.

After another check in on the status of his phone (only 80% booted, what a serious piece of shit) Katsuki stomps back out, grabbing an unfinished fish and biting straight into the flesh.

He lets his mind wander during the meal, mechanical after the first few bites.

He almost doesn't process it right away, mid bite, when he hears it.

A flare.

Katsuki spine straightens. This might be his last chance to make sure the remaining kids have found an adequate shelter. But this late, with no ferry, sending kids to Aizawa and Yagi might be more dangerous than not. They have their own shelter – but there's only so many people they can protect on their own.

He sighs to himself, standing up. He's just about to go back to his tent and try his phone again before he hears something that makes his blood go cold.

A second flare.

Absolute silence.

South of him. Its Kirishima.

Katsuki doesn't think. His hands aim for the ground, and he's airborne in less than a second, body lurching towards the thin trail of red sparks and smoke lingering in the atmosphere.

Katsuki isn't sure how he's able to maneuver this fast – his explosions feel fluid, body slicing through the air like through a vacuum, every movement precise as his heart pounds in his ears. In this moment, nothing else matters. He braces himself for the landing, kneeling down as his feet dig into the sand.

Katsuki looks around – a petrified looking Kirishima stands on the beach, still holding his flare above his head, eyes wide. Behind him, Aizawa and Toshinori are trying to rush several children, including bug-eyed twins into their own underground bunker.

"What's going on?" Katsuki asks, straightening his back. There's no one else on the beach. No obvious threat. Katsuki approaches Kirishima, tilting his head with the question, but Kirishima does nothing except extend his finger out to the ocean.

Katsuki follows his finger to find an impeccably calm strip of ocean. Artificially calm. To the right and to the left of the linear strip, the ocean continues its wild waves, breaking and hissing, but directly in front of them, as if held back by some kind of forcefield, the ocean remains entirely placid, the only things breaking the surface are intermittent bubbles and steam. The world has gone quiet, sky a hazy grey. Not a single bug, not a bird, not a shuddering leaf makes a sound. Absolute silence.

Katsuki stares at the patch of bubbling, steaming water as it slowly approaches the shore. His joints crack as he squats down into launching position, hands thrust behind him, palms heating.

Who else can keep Shigaraki off the ground?!

He's not going to be useless like he was then. He's going to keep Shigaraki off the ground. He's going to protect them.

As a head of white hair starts to ascent from the depth, plastered to sickening grey skin, the scars on his stomach and shoulder flare in pain, as if reacting to their creator.

Katsuki was right.

Fuck, for the first time in Katsuki's goddamn life, he wishes he wasn't.

"HIDE!" Katsuki shouts, not glancing back, too aware of the lack of footsteps behind him. He feels his palms start to smolder, thick scent of nitroglycerin wafting around them. He needs more heat. More power. Cluster should be fast enough to keep him from reaching the beach. He just needs to be out far enough that Katsuki can put his hands on him without touching the water.

Long, drenched white hair sticks to his sickly grey face, plastering to scar-ridden shoulders. His eyes are hidden, but he still sports a wild grin, seawater pouring out from purple lips. He looks like he's died long ago, like his corpse has been re-animated with the unnatural way his arms and legs move, with the way his face doesn't so much as twitch, stuck in that perpetual grin as he ascends from the water.

As soon as his arms are above the surf, Katsuki launches. The booming of explosions ring out behind him as his body is thrown violently towards the open water; he grasps below Shigaraki's armpits, redirecting the blast onto the water surface, launching them straight into the sky. Shigaraki's long white hair whips wildly around them as he has the audacity to start laughing, palms pressing over and over to Katsuki's back.

“Eraserhead’s just as sharp as ever huh? Erasing my Quirks even this far away! Better be careful, Bakugou! He’s getting old you know – his eyesight might not be what it used to be!”

Even Shigaraki’s voice sounds artificial, high pitched and garbled, like someone stuck a tape-recorder into his sternum.

He sounds like a Nomu.

Katsuki’s eyes widen – shit, fuck, is Shigaraki still human?

Katsuki works on instinct – no time to think, no time to wonder which Quirks he still has, no time to wonder whether his body is about to turn into a rainstorm of ashes – slathering Shigaraki’s dry lips with the most potent nitroglycerin he can, shooting of a blast to the face; while momentarily blinded, Katsuki grabs the fucker’s arms, using the inertia to twist him around and throw him hard into the ground below.

Shigaraki’s not moving, likely unconscious for the short duration his nitroglycerin stole blood flow from his brain, body forming a small crater on the beach. Katsuki uses his explosions to slow his descent, breaking into a sprint as soon as he hits the ground towards the monster that has Tomura Shigaraki’s face.

He feels his steps falter as Shigaraki shoots straight up, spine cracking loudly as his body moves like a marionette out of the sand-crater, eyes pointed in the opposite direction of Katsuki.

Exactly in the direction of his former classmates, teachers, and the twins.

Shigaraki opens his mouth in his persistent grin, blood pouring past his lips and dripping down his chin. He speaks, blood flying like spittle onto the sand.

“Where are they, huh? All Might? Eraserhead? Where are my nephews? I need to see them! I know they’re here. I can feel them. They’re so close! Give them to me give them to me GIVE THEM TO ME – “

Katsuki glances towards Aizawa, teeth clenched, one good eye visibly tearing as he tries to keep himself from blinking.

Tomura Shigaraki takes another off-kilter step.

Katsuki kneels, body gearing up for Cluster once more. Shigaraki won’t use Decay before he has his hands on the twins – they’re his only chance for beating Deku. Seeing the sorry state his physical body is in, it makes perfect sense that Deku’s been able to take so many of his Quirks, but even so – something feels wrong. Something is off.

Four things happen at once.

Shota Aizawa blinks.

Katsuki launches himself towards Shigaraki.

Black tendrils shoot out of Shigaraki’s body, surrounding him like a giant arachnid, digging into the sand as he takes a step towards All Might.

But he doesn’t even have time to put his foot down before a supersonic force from who the fuck knows where whizzes by, making full contact with Shigaraki’s torso, blasting them both over the

ocean, leaving turbulent waves in their wake.

Unable to stop the inertia, Katsuki wraps his arms around himself, navigating himself to the ground where he rolls, quickly getting up and sprinting back towards the others.

“What the hell was that?!” Ashido asks in a high-pitched voice, feet shuffling backwards towards the shelter.

“That was – that was – was that *Shigaraki?*” Kirishima’s voice is trembling – Katsuki doesn’t think he’s ever heard the other’s voice tremble.

“Guys! Is this a prank? Is this part of the training camp? This isn’t funny anymore!” Utsushimi laughs nervously, eyes shooting from face to face.

“…He’s here.” Yagi whispers under his breath, barely loud enough for Aizawa and Katsuki to hear, and Katsuki knows he’s not talking about Shigaraki.

There’s only one person that can move like that. Even without seeing his face, Aizawa and Yagi have to know.

Izuku Midoriya is here. He’s alive. And he’s here to finish what they started four years ago.

Katsuki turns his head to the sky, to where the two bodies disappeared, feeling a gnawing sense of deja-vu.

Zero’s metallic arm reflects the sun as a fist connects with bone, sending Shigaraki flying; but Blackwhip drags the other’s body closer, another fist meeting face, punch after punch after punch, only the sound of shockwaves heard in the distance.

Shigaraki’s body flings backwards from the impact; he takes a second to re-orient his body in the air before doing something weird with his hands; and suddenly, the air is morphing behind Shigaraki – he sinks into the invisible trampoline, launching himself with a trajectory straight for Zero, where he lands a fist against the other’s face.

Zero goes hurtling towards the ocean – Katsuki nearly swallows his whole heart before the other corrects his trajectory, activates Float, and wipes the blood from his mouth. His eyes are wide as he blasts himself forward with Air Force. The way he’s moving make it obvious that Shigaraki just did something that has thrown off the other’s game.

Shigaraki uses the momentum, blasting himself forward with Air Cannon away from Zero and back onto the island. Back towards the twins.

Katsuki’s hands spark, aiming towards the ground, and he’s just about to launch himself when he feels a hand on his shoulders.

“He needs you on the ground. He prepared for this.” Aizawa stares up at the sky, following the tell-tale green lightning erupting in the atmosphere, touching the surface of the ocean as it approaches Shigaraki with amazing speed. Blackwhip wraps around the other’s body, launching him back into the sky, and a flash of green lightning follows.

Another boom in the sky, and both bodies shoot arrow-straight into the ocean. And then – its sudden, but Shigaraki, wild-eyes and glowing is crawling on the water – quickly, too quickly – towards the shore, using those black tendrils as walking tools as his arms and legs swing underneath him unnaturally.

The flash of green lightning tackles it from the side.

The sound of explosions. Floating in the air, splash of water, and Shigaraki is back, bleeding but crawling desperately towards them.

Covered with Spear-like Bones, his own Blackwhip and Float keeping him above water, Zero looks bad. Worse for wear. Exhausted. He zooms past Katsuki, this wild, inhuman look in his eyes like he doesn't see anything past this fight, like the world around them doesn't exist.

He's faltering quicker than Katsuki could have anticipated. With each desperate tackle, with each fall into the water, with each ascension into the air with Float only to be shot down by the Air-Cannon Quirk that Shigaraki's overusing, Zero is starting to look tired.

Katsuki can hear his teeth crack under the grimace.

"YOU'RE LOSING, ONE FOR ALL!" Shigaraki yells into the sky as Zero approaches him once more, body noticeably slower. "YOU SHOULDN'T HAVE GOTTEN RID OF SO MANY OF THEM! THAT WAS YOUR ADVANTAGE, AND YOU'RE GOING TO LOSE! YOUR LAST MEMORY WILL BE THIS FAILURE!"

A kick to the abdomen sends Shigaraki flying towards the water, and he flicks something, body, bouncing in the opposite direction against air.

"YOU'RE GETTING ON MY NERVES! MAYBE YOU NEED A LITTLE DISTRACTION, HUH? DON'T THINK I FORGOT ABOUT LAST TIME! STUPID OF YOU TO KEEP YOUR WEAKNESS RIGHT NEXT TO YA!"

Katsuki raises his eyebrows.

… Deku's weakness?

What the hell -

Shigaraki licks his lips, black tendrils bursting out of his body, traveling at unprecedented speeds, slicing through the air and coming straight for him.

"STOP!"

Zero's voice sounds wrecked, panicked –

"SHIGARAKI, STOP! PLEASE!" He screams again, and he sees the other's body get flung somewhere in the distance, but the tendrils don't stop moving, and Katsuki launches himself into the air, but they approach, and they're closer, and he can't dodge, its like they remember his blood and are honed in on him, and shit, Shigaraki's too far for Aizawa's Quirk to work, and Katsuki lands back on the ground, because if he's about to be skewered he should do it from ground-level – he has a chance of surviving this, and -

He looks back up to Zero – a part of him, something crazy and vulnerable, wanting it to be the last thing he sees, when -

It happens in slow motion. Katsuki's gun emerges from Zero's waistband. He cocks it instantly, putting the barrel in his mouth. His finger on the trigger.

Katsuki feels the whole world give under his feet.

That's his gun.

How?

He checks on it every day. He makes sure it's secure. He – he. He hasn't seen it since that time he brought it for the confrontation with Zero in the café bathroom. He just simply… forgot.

This was the one thing that Izuku Midoriya actually wanted Katsuki to forget.

In that one moment, everything is crystal clear.

The way he felt then. The way he feels now. The way he felt when those eyes were on him. The way he felt when those eyes weren't on him. The way it felt to touch and the way it felt to put a name to the touch.

This is the worst moment in his life to have realized this and the only one that could have possibly made sense.

"IZUKU, STOP!"

His voice is thunderous, louder than any noise around them, and in a flash of green, Zero turns his head towards Katsuki. Distracted just long enough.

Katsuki doesn't even think about using this moment to escape from Shigaraki's attack.

Katsuki wraps one hand in a circle, pushing his palm against it. The shoddy prosthetic arm has the hydraulics connected to finger flexion along the elbow and outer forearm – he doesn't have to be that specific to hit it – and the Armor Piercing Shot slides straight through the top cylinder collecting the strands of microfiber supplying the thumb, index and pointer finger. The metal falls down to the ocean, the fingers holding the gun suddenly absolutely limp and useless.

Izuku Midoriya floats in the sky, mouth propped open.

The black tendrils hit Katsuki's skin, and he's so relieved he barely feels the pain.

The tendrils rescind, and Shigaraki's on the shell-shocked Zero so fast he doesn't have time to process it, launching both of their bodies straight into the ocean.

"BAKUGOU!"

"OH MY GOD! BAKUGOU!"

Katsuki collapses onto the ground. He looks down, vision blurry as something pink, yellow and red approach him. His breathing feels… wet, somehow. He looks down – his left thigh is gushing blood, pierced right through the middle, while his right breastbone sports its own hole.

"Well. Fuck." Katsuki laughs out, instant pain on his right with each inhale. He must have collapsed a lung. Well. That's not fucking great.

Katsuki smiles, watching the water before him.

There are legends about something called a green flash – right when the sun meets the ocean, it appears to glow green; just for a second. Some people say that flash represents the souls of the dead moving on from the corporeal world, while some legends say that the green flash is a representation

of an alternate world. And right now, Katsuki can see a green sun rapidly approaching from the horizon, the sharp wind knocking his former classmates back as hands hand on him, oddly gentle despite the power that surrounds them.

“No no no no no no no no no – “ frantic words pour out of Zero’s mouth as his organic hand tries to keep pressure over the gushing wound in his thigh, while the useless metallic tries to stop the air escaping from the gap in his chest. He looks frantic, hands covered in Katsuki’s blood.

“The h’ell are ya doing? Go fight Shigaraki, ya damn nerd. I’ll be fine!” Katsuki laughs, then promptly coughs, spraying himself with blood.

“Hey – wait – are you – Midoriya?” Kirishima asks breathlessly somewhere in the background.

“STAY BACK. DON’T TOUCH HIM. I’m going to fix this. I’m going to fix this. Stay with me, please please *please – “*

Katsuki can feel his consciousness fading. The world blurring before him. He expects his life to pass before his eyes, but it doesn’t. He can hear the waves. He can feel Izuku’s hand against his cheek. He can feel –

He *can’t* feel. Wait.

The pain is gone. Katsuki opens his eyes sharply, sitting up, staring down at his leg. The blood is stopping. He can see, in real time, muscle fibers repairing themselves in the gash.

Katsuki’s eyes open wide and he stares up at Izuku, breathing hard, tears in his eyes.

“… What the fuck. Did you just give me Regenerate?”

Izuku doesn’t look at him.

“What the fuck, Izuku! If Shigaraki takes it from me, that’s the end!”

Those eyes shoot back to Katsuki, irritation obvious on his face.

“If you just let me kill myself, you wouldn’t have been hit!”

“I couldn’t just stand there and watch you die!” Katsuki shoots back.

He’d rather the world end. He’s rather have Shigaraki murder every single person on this island, this country, this universe. He’d rather give it all up than see the person in front of him die.

“Please hide him. It might take a couple of hours for him to fully heal. I’ll try – I’ll try to keep Shigaraki at bay. If you keep him near the twins, he won’t Decay the island. I – “

Something bursts out of the water, and in a flash of green, just like that, he’s gone again.

“Come on, Bakugou. Lets get you – “

“I’m not moving off this fucking beach. All of you should get in the shelter.”

He watches as Izuku’s body hits the water. He bursts out, Black Whip wrapping around Shigaraki. He’s thrown off again.

And again.

And again.

He's not fighting the same way. He's on the defensive, and he's losing.

Fuck.

He stands on wobbly feet. The sensation of a foreign Quirk in his body feels slimy, like a million worms have deposited themselves under his skin, but he doesn't have time to worry about that.

"Bakugou, what are you – "

Katsuki aims his hands at the sand, and with poor precision, launches himself into the sky as Shigaraki flings Izuku for the fifth time; he grabs on to his arm best he can and throws him back onto the island.

"HOLD HIM DOWN!" Katsuki orders, and a very confused Kirishima and Ashido comply, Kirishima sitting on Izuku's legs while Ashido binds the one remaining hand.

"Why did you fly with your injuries?! You're going to re-open them!"

"Are you seriously going to worry about me right now? The twins! You need the fucking twins!"

Yagi approaches, nodding his head slowly, even though Izuku refuses to make eye contact with the other man, keeping his head turned away.

Katsuki knows he's right. If the behemoth underneath them can't even fight off Kirishima and Ashido, he doesn't have much time left.

"Electron-positron annihilation. You inverse your portion of the Quirk with their Quirk, and use it against Shigaraki. It will cancel both out. You can still win. I know you. You've though about this."

Whatever fight left in Izuku's body leeches away instantly. He goes limp in the sand, eyes closing.

"I can't take their Quirk away," he whispers.

"Isn't that what you came here to do? Isn't this the whole fucking *point* of this?!" Katsuki spits, relying on the safety of his anger to shield him from the entire fuck-show that his emotions currently are.

"… I can't. I can't. I can't anymore. I can't go through with it," Izuku shakes his head, closing his eyes tight, though he can't hide the tears embarrassingly leaking out of the corners of his eyes.

"Why." Katsui's voice is croaking, and he doesn't know why.

When Izuku opens his eyes again, the blacks of his eyes are surrounded by a glowing, forest green.

"Because you called me Izuku. Because Izuku would never do this."

"Are you…" Katsuki's hands drop to his side weakly. He wants to scream, rip his hair out, punch the other in the face.

"Sir, excuse us. Shouldn't that…" Aoto starts.

"Be our decision?"

“When the hell did they get out of the bunker?” Katsuki asks accusingly. Who the fuck should have been guarding it?

Katsuki is, unfortunately, ignored.

“We want to help. We know about – about him. About All of One.”

“And if we can somehow help stop it, then of course we’d take that chance.”

“What kind of heroes would we be if we didn’t give everything to help?”

“Please, Mr. Vigilante.”

Izuku lip trembles, and he hesitates before shaking his waterlogged hair.

“I can’t take away your Quirk. You’re about to become pro-Heroes. I can’t take away that dream –“

Aoto and Otoa look at each other and smile. Their smile is crooked, just like Izuku’s.

“Who says you need a Quirk to be a Hero?” Aoto and Otoa say in synchrony.

Ashido and Kirishima let go of his arm and legs. Izuku Midoriya – a man who altered his body, his mind, his morals, his entire goddamn life for this Quirk – sits up and stares at the two boys like they’re absolutely alien to him.

“WHERE ARE YA, HAH, ONE FOR ALL? PLAYING GAMES WITH ME? DID YOU BRING REGENERATE BACK – I KNOW YOU DID! I CAN FEEL IT! THAT’S SO KIND, I’VE MISSED IT OH-SO-MUCH - ”

“Make a decision, Midoriya,” Aizawa urges, and all eyes are on Izuku.

The ocean starts to bubble, the light steam from before now boiling, waves dissipating from the path Shigaraki is making underwater, eyes glowing red, white hair waving like wild snakes, hissing as he walks slowly towards the island.

The twins reach their hands out, faces stoic. Izuku looks around, fixing his eyes to Katsuki for a beat too long to be accidental, before reaching out his shaky biological hand.

Light erupts from the point their fingertips brush. The two boys instantly collapse to their knees, eyes closed as the white light ascends Izuku’s body, into his hand, throughout his chest, pouring out of his eyes. The light shifts, then, into a cacophony of colors, turning from red to green to purple to yellow, dancing the whites of Izuku Midoriya’s eyes - Katsuki puts an arm in front of his face, squinting against the brightness.

The glowing Izuku starts to Float, clouds becoming thick around him as his celestial body exchanges lightning with the atmosphere.

“Let’s get out of here!” Kirishima throws Aoto over his shoulder as Ashido grabs Otoa, Aizawa and Yagi ushering them into their own hidden bunker.

Shigaraki makes it out of the water, eyes set on the last of the people entering the bunker, fingers encroaching on the ground when Blackwhip – now not so black, laced with white lightning, grabs him violently off the surface, bringing the other hundreds of feet into the air.

“Its gone? You took it – Wait. Wait! Hey, hey, hold on – don’t do anything stupid, kid! You’ll be Quirkless too! You’ll – “ Shigaraki tries to move his shoulders, grin falling slightly as dark tendrils sink themselves into Izuku’s flesh.

The other doesn’t even flinch.

“You don’t have to have a Quirk to be a hero!”

Katsuki can hardly hear the words over the roar of the winds around him.

“Bakugou – let’s go! Come on!” Utsushimi pulls on his hand, tearful golden eyes trying to catch his attempt, but Katsuki is staring at the supernova imploding in front of his eyes, retinas burning as he finds some kind of meaning in all of this.

“Go.” He says softly, simply, meeting her terrified eyes and nodding. Her face morphs into one of sad understanding, and she squeezes his shoulder before running to the shelter.

The world is pure, radiant white. Katsuki’s mind is beautifully, absolutely clear.

This is it.

This is the end.

And they’re going to meet it together.

“Goodbye – “ The words are soft, but Katsuki can hear them as if they were spoken directly to him, like Izuku is standing right next to him.

“ONE!”

Power surges through Blackwhip, the white light emanating from the other transferring over to Shigaraki; the latter starts to scream, trying to writhe out of the Blackwhip’s grip, but hundreds of feet above the ocean, arms braced, he can do nothing as the light finds its way past his teeth, making its way out his mouth, his fingers, his toes.

A dense center forms around the two of them; connected by Blackwhip and the black tendrils, a ball of light encompassing them both completely. The pressure builds, the ball of light seeming to spin, wind picking up around them. Powerful trunks of trees start to crack around Katsuki under the pressure of the wind, tilting violently towards the ground. Katsuki braces himself, using his hands to half-heartedly protect himself from the forming cyclone.

When the ball of white light starts to expand, Katsuki starts to think about the end.

About how he meant it when he offered to run away with Zero in that bunker. About the first time he met Zero and knew – knew – that there was something special about him. Like he’s always know that Quirkless, useless Izuku Midoriya was special. About how, even now, he’d happily give his life for the other.

About the slime monster – about the only light in his periphery a gangly pair of limbs and a green that he can’t stop seeing, even in his dreams.

About one of his first memories – that small hand reaching out to him by the creek. This feels the same – the hot white waves of light rattling the world feel like his hand, and he’ll take it this time.

He should have all along.

Because…this whole time, Izuku Midoriya has been Katsuki's hero.

Katsuki throws his arms open as the first wave of power hits the island, as trees level to the ground, as sand disappears to the ocean floor, as the mountain crumbles to nothing before him.

But he doesn't feel the impact. Katsuki's light-blinded eyes can only process a flash of bright red, a sharp force against the back of his skull and then –

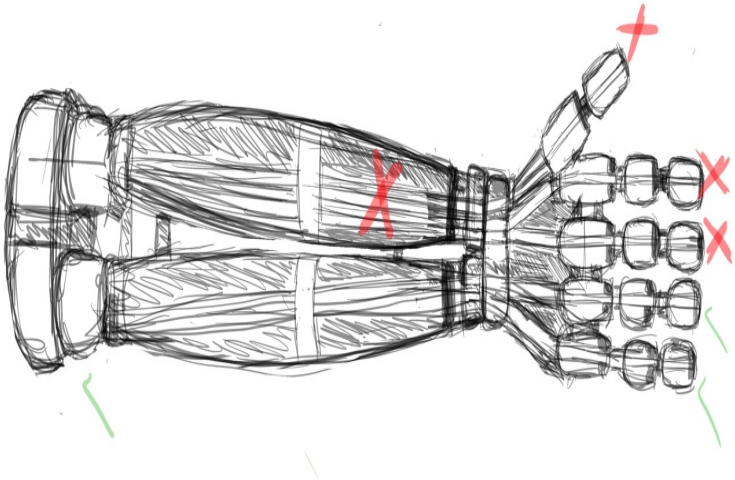
Nothing.

Chapter End Notes

Izuku, picking up the gun after Katsuki had a mental breakdown in a coffee shop bathroom:



Not that anybody cares, but an awful sketch of Izuku's artificial arm – I made the 'tendons' controlling thumb, index and middle vs ring, pinky in the nerve distribution, so Katsuki's shot only hit the main fingers used for firing said gun, with hopes of sparing his arm to continue the fight.



(aldfjalsdfja writing fight scenes is SO HARD OH MY GOD. I'm SORRY IF THIS SUCKS. I've had the gun scene in my head since the very inaugural part of this story for the DRAMA but damn leading up to it? Impossible to write. How do you make 'and then he punched him. and then he punched him back. And then, there were more punches' interesting?!??!)

(not to be a major nerd but I 100% meant the final scene to look sort of like the metaphase part of cell division; for everyone who is also a biology loser, I'm sorry and thank you for your service)

(AND for those of you worried that this might be the end, considering we just faced the major villain – DON'T WORRY. The REAL big bad is Katsuki's and Izuku's fucking trauma. Let's call the next arc "Well, time to deal with the utter bullshit from the last 12 chapters….")

Chapter 14

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Katsuki's choking.

He can feel the thick sludge slither down his throat, wrap around his windpipe, force itself into his nose and eyes and mouth, and he can't breathe and he can't see and he can't even scream - he's dying, oh god he's fucking *dying* –

He flexes his hands, clenches his stomach and tries to break free, biting, gnashing against the object propping his mouth open, using his shoulders and hips to roll, to thrust, to get any leverage at all, any advantage, he has to fight this, he can't die like this, not again, no no no no - but the sludge just grows thicker, stronger, binds his wrists, slithers over his stomach, pressing down on that old scar and fuck, that pain -

He gags against the sudden flood of iron in his mouth, mental flash of *green green green* making his chest feel like someone's torn his ribcage open, and he thrashes against the bindings, *Stay back stay back stay back -*

"SOMEBODY HOLD HIM DOWN!"

"KATSUKI! KATSUKI! YOU'RE IN THE HOSPITAL!"

"PUSH HALOPERIDOL 5MG! HE'S GOING TO BREAK THROUGH THE RESTRAINTS – "

"NO! No - please, just, just – get that tube out of him, he'll calm down, he – stop sedating him, please, I can't do this again, stop letting him wake up like this – please – "

A woman's voice. Familiar and yet completely alien, because he's never heard it sound like *that.*

He doesn't know how he can still feel guilty when he's dying, but he does. His mother has never sounded to goddamn desperate, so terrified, and he wants to placate her, he wants to tell her for both the first and last time – *I'm sorry I'm dying. I'm sorry I failed. I'm sorry that you've wasted these twenty years of your life, thinking you raised a hero but knowing you raised a coward. I'm sorry I wasn't a better son. I'm sorry I'm so weak -*

His hands, soaked with nitroglycerin and sparking, are covered by something soft and he feels a small weight next to him, a voice murmuring gently in his ears, and his eyes burn in an effort not to show her his weakness. He can't stand to listen to her sound like this. Not like she did back then.

Not like he's cradled in her lap, wrapped in a blanket after a bath in his All Might onesie, rocked back and forth as her voice rings out so softly above him, chin resting on his head, warm and safe and –

Katsuki. Katsuki. Katsuki. I'm here. It's going to be okay. I'm here.

He feels his body melt into the touch.

If this is a lie, if he's being tricked, if this is how he dies, then it doesn't seem so bad.

The background noise that Katsuki could hardly comprehend, a flurry of high pitched mechanical sounds and cacophony of voices come into some semblance of clarity. Rhythmic beeping in time with the pounding in his head. Voices, some quiet, some in his forefront. One in particular, another womans, is right next to his other ear.

"… Okay, Mr. Bakugou. Ready to get this tube out?"

Katsuki just nods, because what the hell else is he supposed to do?

"Great!" The voice sounds pleasantly surprised, and Katsuki can feel his irritation spike in time with the beeping in the background.

People move around him, just shadows behind his closed eyelids. He tries to crack them open, but the light is blinding, so he elects to keep them shut, listening to the instructions of the fucker with the power over the object gagging him.

Touch your chin to your chest. Give us a thumbs up. Give us a cough.

When Katsuki accomplishes said tasks, he literally hears someone clap like he's some goddamn sideshow clown performing tricks.

"Excellent! Alright, let's get ready. Mr. Bakugou, on the count of three, we are going to start pulling – give us a good cough, okay?"

Katsuki grunts around the thing in his mouth.

"Ready? 1-2-3!"

Katsuki coughs violently, sputum and spittle flying from his mouth as the garish plastic device is removed from his throat. He spits onto the towel in front of him, slowly pealing his eyelids open as to adjust to the light.

"Can you say something for us?" That tube-removing fucker asks, pushing their annoying smiling face directly into his line of sight.

He swivels his head around, barely processing the half-dozen other silhouettes around his bed staring at him expectantly.

"Fuck each and every single one of you," Katsuki rasps out, and he sneers as several people in the room 'whoop' lightly and clap. Katsuki feels the tight grip against his hands lighten as his mother sits back, lips quirking up in the most pathetic attempt at a smile Katsuki's ever seen.

"Oh thank god, he's back – "

"Katsuki – Katsuki – "

"It looks like he's alright for now. We'll give you some space." Tube-fucker says somewhere in the background, and most of the audience to this goddamn sideshow leave the room. Except the two people that Katsuki can hardly look at, chest flooding with shame at being seen in this pathetic state.

Needing his mommy to hold his hands to calm him down. What a fucking joke.

"I need to get the fuck out of bed," Katsuki grunts. He fights through the nausea and the vertigo and swings his legs around to the side of the bed. He tries to stand up, unsurprised when his butt hits the

side of the bed almost instantly as his left leg gives out on him.

He ignores his parents who both lurch towards him and glares down at his thigh. Right. Last he remembers, he was hemorrhaging out that same thigh after Shigaraki made Shishkabob 2.0 out of him. The scar on his legs matches the one he has on his left shoulder and stomach, starburst and discolored.

It looks old. Well healed.

"…How long have I been out." Katsuki asks, barely hearing his own voice over the sudden painful throbbing in his chest and the screeching of that goddamn monitor. Irritation spikes and he grabs at the leads still on his chest, ripping them straight off, before turning to parents.

"Katsuki. Lay back down, son. You've been through a lot." His father walks towards him, both hands up like he's approaching some kind of feral creature, glasses fogged up too much for Katsuki to be able to discern his exact expression.

His tone makes Katsuki want to do the exact opposite, which is what he does.

"How the fuck am I alive?" Katsuki asks louder, sounding angrier to himself than he intended as he uses his bed to brace himself in another attempt to stand, thigh shaking with the effort. This time, with the help of the IV pole, he can keep himself upright.

Huh. Everything seems to be… present, at least. Two legs, two arms, his head and his dick. The big 6 are all still intact.

Katsuki snakes a hand under the hospital shirt he's wearing, feeling up to the second rib space.

He remembers his lung collapsing. He remembers gurgling on blood. He remembers the sensation of drowning.

But all he feels is a scar. The same as the others.

"Katsuki – son, please – "

If he's alive –

Does that mean?

Deku? The twins? Kirishima and Ashido and Utsushimi? All the kids? … Shigaraki?

Whatever that power was that Deku released from using Inverse on Shigaraki leveled trees and crumbled mountains. Katsuki *saw* it. He made *sure* to see it. His body, *no* body, would be able to withstand that degree of power. And Regenerate *should* have disappeared with the electron-positron annihilation…right?

Katsuki grabs one of the IVs in his wrist and yanks it out. He watches the blood squirt out of the hole where the plastic catheter just was. And watches it. And watches it.

He definitely doesn't have Regenerate anymore.

So the question still stands.

How the *fuck* is he still alive?

“Goddamn it, what the *fuck* did you father say, huh? Lay your stupid ass back down and stop pulling shit out!”

Katsuki’s blood runs cold as his mother raises her voice at him. Gone is that begging softness, but that familiar rage is laced with something else that Katsuki can’t quite put his finger on. He turns to face her, but his sneer falls right off his face as he watches fresh tears trickle down her porcelain face.

What the hell is that all about?

He feels the rage in his heart simmer down to just a fine boil as he watches his usual stoic mother fight desperately to keep her composure.

“You stupid. Selfish. Dumb. Asshole –“ Mitsuki walks towards him, standing between him and the door and bangs a weak fist against Katsuki’s chest, hiding her face as her body becomes wracked with sobs.

“I haven’t heard from you in nearly a *year,* and the first call I get is to identify your *body* – you stupid, stupid – “ she’s weeping now, and Katsuki stares at her, eyes wide. Someone clearly abducted his mother and replaced her with this… thing.

She didn’t cry when the Sludge monster attacked him. Not when he was kidnapped. Not when Shigaraki nearly killed him the first time.

So what the fuck gives now?

“…What happened, Mom?” Katsuki puts his hands on her shoulders, shaking her slightly to make her raise her head and meet his eyes. Eye to eye, Katsuki can see just how dramatic the change has been – her cheekbones are protruding, her eyes look dull and drained, and her perfect complexion has taken on a grey-ish sheen. Katsuki swallows down his concern, glancing over to his father.

The man’s never looked so thin. He stands there dumbly in the middle of the room, in his dirty-ass polo, untucked from his dirty-ass pants. The man is wearing mismatched shoes, for fuck’s sake.

“Dad. What happened.”

Masaru Bakugou’s head shoots up, like he did not expect to be addressed, and withers under Katsuki’s glare. It doesn’t take long to break him – it never does – before his father is talking a mile a minute.

“… After that explosion in Minami-Ioto Island… we heard that four were still missing, and that the heroes were trying to dig through the wreckage, but we didn’t know that you were – When they found you – “ Masaru Bakugou’s voice chokes off.

“Y-you lost so much blood. You were under the rubble for over 24 hours – god, if it wasn’t for – “ Mitsuki starts.

“… The others?” Katsuki interrupts, swallowing against the trepidation. “Did they find the others? Is everyone – are they all – “ Katsuki can’t say the word.

Mitsuki steps back, nodding slightly. “Yes. Everyone survived. You’re the last to wake up.”

“Deku too?” Katsuki whispers, unable to phonate clearly with how tight his throat suddenly feels. The silence is too long and panic starts to build as Katsuki breathes faster, faster, no, *no* –

“…Y-yes. Izuku is… he’s alive.” Masaru’s voice sounds strained, but Katsuki ignores it.

He’s alive .That’s the only thing that matters.

“Does Inko know?” he asks. His mother and father exchange a look that Katsuki doesn’t understand before Mitsuki speaks again.

“…Yes. She knows.”

His mother doesn’t elaborate, and Katsuki opens his mind to press further, but Mitsuki throws her body at him, voice high pitched in his ear.

“Oh, god. Katsuki, I’m - I thought we lost you.”

She has her arms around him, squeezing until Katsuki feels his ribs start to bend with the pressure, but he breathes through it, placing a hand on her shoulder in a half-hearted attempt to return this unusual show of affection.

“… Well, I’m not lost, am I? So stop your fuckin’ crying, old lady.”

“You’re a little bastard.” Mitsuki actually laughs as she pulls back, slapping him hard on his ‘good’ shoulder before wiping her hands against her eyes, surprisingly not smearing any mascara. It appears, for the first time in Katsuki’s twenty years of life, she’s not wearing any makeup.

Silence extends as Katsuki stands there, holding on to his IV pole and playing staring chicken with his frankly malnourished and somewhat smelly parents. It’s getting old extremely fast.

“Look, I’m clearly alive and shit. See?” Katsuki fans with his hands to his entire body, banged up as it is. “You two need a shower. And a meal. And to leave this goddamn room.”

“But we – “

“What if –“

“What the hell can I get up to in here? Seriously. Fuck off so I can get some rest,” Katsuki lies as he swings his legs back into bed, closing his eyes.

It takes a solid ten minutes, if the mental counting Katsuki was doing to make sure he doesn’t fall asleep is accurate, before he hears a sign and quiet murmuring from the other two, and at long last, the door to his hospital room closes.

Sweet, sweet solitude.

Katsuki’s eyes shoot open and he stares at the ceiling.

He needs to get out of here immediately.

He grabs on his IV pole, standing himself back up, testing the balance of his left leg. He starts towards the door when it opens once again, his homeroom teacher hobbling inside.

They stand in front of each other in complete silence for what feels like forever.

Katsuki clears his throat. “… Hey.”

Katsuki doesn’t expect the other man to dart forward, awkward on his prosthetic leg, and actually wrap his arms around Katsuki. Whole ass hug, complete with Katsuki’s unexpecting head nuzzled

within the other's armpit for a solid half a second. Aizawa pulls back, not meeting Katsuki's eyes, a scoff and shoulder shrug the only explanation for whatever the fuck *that* was.

Two hugs in one day? Way over Katsuki's yearly quota.

"You two are never gonna stop giving me gray hairs – " Aizawa murmurs under his breath before he clears his throat, straightening his shoulders.

"You're awake."

"No shit. Can you tell me what *actually* happened without crying every two words like my folks? Everyone okay?"

Aizawa's expression steels somewhat, jaw setting, eye narrowing. Katsuki can feel that he's hiding something before he even opens his mouth.

"Depends on what you consider to be 'okay.'"

Katsuki huffs out an irritated breath. "You fuckin' serious right now? Really?"

"… If you are asking whether everyone's alive, yes. You, Kirishima, Midoriya and Shigaraki were the last four to be found and are all still hospitalized here. The others are home and unharmed."

Katsuki furrows his eyebrows. Kirishima? He was in the shelter with the others. There's no reason for him to have been hurt. Must have been something he sustained during the search effort. He'll give him hell for that later.

Izuku and Shigaraki? It doesn't make sense that they're alive, but with the degree of augmentation both their bodies went through to carry the two halves of One, it's not too much of a leap of faith to assume they could somehow withstand that atomic-level blast.

That leaves Katsuki – the one person who has no reason to have survived.

"… How the hell am I alive?" Katsuki asks again, eyebrows furrowed, now more frustrated.

" Good question. Come with me."

"..What?"

"Better you see rather than I tell you."

Aizawa leaves the room briefly, and Katsuki can hear hushed whispers behind the door before he waves Katsuki over. Katsuki frowns, holding on to the IV pole as he ambles forward in his shitty threadbare hospital pajamas and hospital slippers.

After he gets a feel for his weaker body, Katsuki finds walking, breathing, and existing is not much harder than usual. It must have not been *that* long since he's been out.

Aizawa doesn't say anything as the two of them walk slowly through the hallway, nurses and doctors in scrubs paying them no attention as they rush past. Katsuki glances out the window to the mid-day Tokyo skyline before them.

The sun is shining. Schoolchildren are no longer wearing their jackets. Budding flowers are starting their first shy bloom. Shades of green splatter the previously grey world in front of them. Winter is

barely holding on, but even it knows that it's time has ended.

Life moves forward.

Aizawa buzzes through another portion of the hospital with double-paned doors. He dons a mask, putting one on Katsuki before he has a chance to protest, and walks forward.

The two of them stop in front of a glass room in the middle of a closed unit.

"What the f – " Katsuki starts.

"Is this okay, Mr. Kirishima?" Katsuki's eyes shoot to the spot the voice is coming from. Through the glass doors of the room, Katsuki sees a sight that nearly makes him upchuck the nothing in his system – a scrubbed nurse, gently patting down the most grotesque back he's ever seen.

Broad, puckered, discolored, each scar looking like it's on the verge of ripping open with even the tiniest of movements. Katsuki winces as he watches the nurse scrub over a particularly pink and raw patch of skin over the lower spine.

It takes too long for Katsuki to peel away his eyes from that deformed back to the red head of hair that dons the unfortunate owners' head.

Realization hits Katsuki like a goddamn freight train and he stumbles back, leaning against the nurses' station counter, refusing to process what the hell he's seeing in front of him.

"He jumped in front of you during that first wave. Then the mountain collapsed, and if he wasn't shielding you, you would have been crushed to death." Aizawa says it without sympathy, factually, like that isn't the worst fucking thing Katsuki's heard in his entire life.

"Let's let it air out for now, okay? Feel free to walk around the unit! I'll come back to re-do your bandages before you go to sleep!"

Katsuki watches that face – yes, its Kirishima, of course it is, but Katsuki doesn't want to believe it – turn to his nurse, grinning that shark-toothed grin like he doesn't have a care in the world.

"Thank you so much, Yui-chan!" Kirishima exclaims, and the nurse flushes before she bows deeply and nearly runs out of the room.

Katsuki prays Kirishima does not notice him.

"Bakugou! Holy shit!"

Fuck.

Kirishima practically jogs out of his room, looking all the world like he wants to tackle Katsuki before he stops, arms still outstretched.

"…Uh. I'd hug you, but, you know. Infection risk." Kirishima makes two thumbs up and points them to his patchwork back, like Katsuki's supposed to know what the fuck that means.

"The fuck did you do…?" Katsuki wants to push the other, punch him in the face for good measure, at least *yell* at him, but his voice comes out breathy and bewildered, and Kirishima's smile turns to something much more soft as he brushes a hand through his shorter hair.

“I, uh, know that things haven’t been great between us, but you’re still my best friend, dude. I couldn’t – I had to – My feet just kind of…“

Kirishima clears his throat, looking somewhere behind Katsuki.

“Moved on their own.” He finishes lamely.

Not knowing how to sort through the slurry of emotions in his chest, Katsuki glares at his former homeroom teacher instead.

“What, you let him run out there like some suicidal idiot? What kind of teacher are you?”

“You think I could stop him?” Aizawa clips back, tapping his prosthetic leg against the floor as a reminder of the last time him and Katsuki happened to share a battlefield.

“Its not like you didn’t do anything, Prof! Dude, seriously, this is the coolest part – you have to show him!” Kirishima ignores the tension between the two, bouncing on his heels as he stares excitedly at Aizawa.

The former sighs. Then, with one hand, lifts his eyepatch. Katsuki stares at the empty socket before he processes that his hands are, involuntarily, sparking.

“What.” Katsuki says, ignoring the concerned glances from the medical staff as his fingers light up with unintentional fireworks.

“Old dog. New tricks.” Aizawa doesn’t explain, and puts down his eyepatch, the sparks on Katsuki’s hands extinguishing just as unintentionally as they started.

“No way I would have lived through that first wave of power if Prof didn’t make my quirk, like, insanely powerful. Left eye – turns off Quirks. Right not-eye – turns on Quirks.” Kirishima covers each eye for emphasis, his scarred shoulders folding awkwardly with each movement.

“Since when?” Katsuki’s fingers still tingle with the sensation of evaporating nitroglycerin, and he clenches and unclenches his fist to try to get rid of that feeling.

“Since a week ago.” Aizawa shrugs, ending the conversation before it even began.

“Why?”

Katsuki doesn’t understand. He just *doesn’t.* Its *him.* No one was supposed to care. He’s pushed the two people in front of him away for years, and here they stand.

Having risked everything for his stupid, meaningless life.

“…Unfortunately, putting my students in danger doesn’t actually – how did you phrase it? – make my dick hard.”

Kirishima lets out a surprised guffaw.

“Dude. Mean.” Kirishima half-scolds Katsuki, before smiling softer. “It’s good to have you back, man.”

Katsuki scoffs to fight off the flush threatening to darken his cheeks.

“Whatever. You visit Deku yet?”

Kirishima’s face flattens instantly.

“That’s… that’s not funny, even for you, man.” Kirishima says, voice low, eyes downcast.

“He doesn’t know,” Aizawa explains, and Kirishima’s eyes widen before he gives Katsuki a weird look – somewhere between guilt and pity – and takes a step back.

“Know *what?*” His voice raises, and several nurses look at him, one standing slowly from their seat with an intentioned look on their face.

“…Midoriya’s been arrested.” Aizawa finally says, and Katsuki 100% should not be in a Burn Intensive Care Unit right now, because he’s about to fucking *combust.*

“He *WHAT?!*”

“I’m going to have to ask the two of you to leave – “ the nurse starts before Katsuki is turning his IV pole around, trying his damnest to stomp out on his pathetic toothpick legs in his pathetic loose-fitting hospital pajamas.

He refuses to even look in Kirishima’s direction as he walks through the automatic doors and as far into the hallway as he physically can, before he feels too exhausted on continue. He sits down on a shitty hospital bench, chest heaving. Each one of his muscles feels hollowed out, strained and painful, his head fuzzy, his throat absolutely parched.

When was the last time he drank any water?

Aizawa joins him not long after.

“Bakugou, its – “

“How could they arrest him? He fucking saved the *world!* Did you tell them what happened? If he’s arrested, *I* should be arrested! I – “ Katsuki swallows his next words.

He’s done a lot of illegal shit. He’s conspired with Zero knowing fully well what he was doing was against the law. He doesn’t even know how many counts there should be against him. But here he is, alive and walking free while Deku – Deku -

“Save it for the trial.” Aizawa grunts back, folding his arms, leaning back against the wall.

“…The trial.” Katsuki repeats, raising his head. He meets Aizawa’s eye.

Aizawa nods. “I might as well tell you, because you’ll see this as soon as you turn on the TV. This is being highly publicized. The Hero Commission is going to try to make an example out of Midoriya. The government is putting all their weight behind putting him away for the rest of his life.”

Katsuki’s heart drops into the pit of his stomach. The image of Inko Midoriya, her already dead eyes, seeing news of her son, alive but arrested and on trial as a criminal –

He needs to talk to her. He needs to – he needs to.

He needs to see him.

Aizawa seems to sense Katsuki's distress, because he stands back up, extending a hand out to him.

"We should get you back to your parents, kid."

Katsuki does not take his hand. Instead, sweat-soaked hands slip down his IV pole several times before he's able to get a good enough grip to force his weakened body up. He meets Aizawa's eyes, each ounce of malice he's stored away for a rainy day directed at his former homeroom teacher.

"I have to see him." Katsuki doesn't ask a question or make a request. Its factual and final, and he can tell Aizawa knows that, because his shoulders droop in defeat before he can try to protest.

"Yeah… I know. You have to wait until the night shift, but I already talked to his overnight guard. Be patient."

Aizawa and Katsuki make their way back to Katsuki's hospital room. Katsuki can hear the voices past the door – his parents are already waiting for him, and for some reason that makes him want to stand out here, with Aizawa, for as long as physically possible.

"…Thanks, old man. For saving my life, or whatever."

"You forget that people care about you, little asshat. You're… a good kid." Aizawa pauses, then puts a hand into Katsuki's likely horribly greasy hair, ruffling it like he's some kind of child, not a six foot something nearly twenty-one-year-old pro Hero.

"What-the-fuck ever. Get Deku out of prison, fuckin' one eyed geezer." Katsuki scoffs, pretending that the words don't stab him like a steak into his fragile heart. He didn't know how much he needed to hear that. Particularly from Aizawa.

"… We'll be in touch regarding that. Behave tonight. The guard is taking a big risk letting you see him."

Aizawa leaves with those cryptic words, and Katsuki walks back into his hospital room, only to be accosted by his parents.

They make small talk between the three of them, ignoring the giant imprisoned green-haired elephant in the room. It doesn't take long to actually fatigue Katsuki out, and his eyes start to drift closed as his mother relays something about his apartment.

"Oh! Before I forget. This was found on the island. Figured you'd want it."

Mitsuki Bakugou digs in her purse, pulling out Katsuki's unscathed phone.

With that, Mitsuki and Masaru leave the room.

Katsuki stares at the rectangular object in his hand.

The thought of talking to anyone, the thought of telling people that he's okay when he's anything but, the thought of facing the shambles of a life that he's left behind when he went to that island…

He's not sure he has it in him today. Not after everything.

He powers the phone up anyway, willing for his eyes to ignore the slew of messages, voicemails, emails that show up on his phone. Instead, he swipes to the right and finds an old familiar friend.

‘Target disconnected.’

For the first time since Katsuki placed that tracker on the other, there is no green light for him to look at. No green light to assure him of the other’s survival.

No vague signs, no clues, no theories.

No guesswork about where he might be, who he might be, what he might be planning. It’s all over, Shigaraki’s been captured, and Izuku Midoriya is alive, somewhere in this hospital.

Katsuki won’t believe it until he sees it.

He dozes off briefly, making sure to set his alarm to right around shift change.

When he wakes up, the sun is mostly set, illuminating his hospital room in a gentle orange light. Katsuki surprises himself when he finds himself thinking that it’s pretty.

Katsuki sits up in his bed and listens for any indication that someone might be coming into the room. Satisfied, Katsuki grabs on to his IV pole and stands up.

He’s got a hand on the doorknob when it opens towards him.

“Oh.”

Mismatched eyes widen, surprised, as they meet red.

This is the first time they’ve made eye contact in who knows how long and Katsuki’s previous gentle gratefulness for staying alive another day freezes over like the literal hell Katsuki’s just found himself in.

“What the fuck are you doing here.” Katsuki spits, taking a step backwards, feeling the hairs on the back of his neck stand up at the sudden chill in the room.

“… I heard that you were awake, so I decided to stop by after my shift. I didn’t come here just to see you, if that’s what you’re implying.” Shouto Todoroki’s calm voice makes Katsuki somehow more furious. He clenches his jaw, flaring out his nostrils.

“Then *why. Are. You. Here.*”

“… I’m on security detail. The police commissioned my father’s agency to guard the prisoners prior to the trial.”

Katsuki scoffs, half-laugh bitterly escaping from his lips.

“The prisoners. What, you don’t know who they are?”

Shouto’s face changes into something complex, nearly pained, before he evens his expression.

“… I was not told who it was prior to coming here, no. But its better us than anyone else. Not everyone out there is on Midoriya’s side.”

Katsuki’s hands start to drip nitroglycerin at the sound his name, and he clenches his hand so hard his fingernails dig into his fleshy palm, making every effort to not combust the asshole standing in front of him.

“Keep that name out of your mouth. Fucker.” Katsuki tries to walk past Shouto, utterly uninterested in extending this reunion any longer than it needs to be.

“You were right all along. I’m grateful you found him. That he’s safe and alive, even under these circumstances.” Shouto pauses, looking somewhere behind Katsuki, eyebrows furrowed. He laces his fingers, leaning forward, too close for Katsuki’s comfort.

“Don’t fucking pretend to care about him now.” Katsuki nearly spits in the other’s face. The betrayal still feels fresh – he doesn’t know if it will ever truly fade. He trusted him. He shared Deku’s note with him. The hours, months, years they spent looking – and in the end, he was no better than the rest of them.

Shouto remains quiet for too long, the room filled with nothing but the silent hum of the machines and the ticking of the clock somewhere in the corner. The hospital is starting to quiet, day shift switching to night, and he can vaguely hear nurses and doctors discussing their evening plans, voices jovial, as they walk past his room.

“… I never stopped caring about him.” Shouto finally says, sighing out loud. “The problem was that I started caring about *you.*”

Katsuki raises his eyebrows.

“…I…” Shouto pauses, eyes roaming up and down Katsuki’s body, like he’s got something else to say. It makes Katsuki feel dirty, and he crosses his arm over his chest, leering at the other.

“I’m grateful you’re safe too. I hope him being back brings you some peace.”

Katsuki says nothing as Shouto bows slightly, so formal it makes Katsuki’s skin crawl, before he turns around. Katsuki waits until his footsteps disappear from his earshot before he exhales, chest suddenly aflame.

For that bastard to show his face – to spew that kind of bullshit at him?

How the fuck dare he?

Katsuki pushes the feeling down as far as he can and proceeds with what he has to do.

He follows the instructions Aizawa texted him. He takes the elevator to the basement, walking down the poorly lit hallway until he reaches a door labeled B-4. There’s a single buzz panel, then a secondary door, a bored looking security guard sitting between two rooms in a glass office. Katsuki swallows. With his IV pole and hospital clothes, its very obvious he has no business down here.

The man pays him no mind, slowly turning the pages of whatever book he’s reading. The man seems to *intentionally* be paying him no mind. Aizawa must have threatened him, or paid him off, or something. Doesn’t matter now. Katsuki moves forward. He presses the button labeled B4, and the door latch clicks open.

Just like that, Katsuki pushes open the metallic door to find himself in a large, square room made of concrete. A window takes up a majority of the space, past which lies what looks like a relatively normal appearing hospital room. A single chair sits outside the door to said hospital room, currently occupied by an incredibly familiar figure.

“…Ponytail?”

Momo Yaoyorozu closes her book, standing up primly and placing it in her seat. She bows to Katsuki, smiling at him with a politeness that would put most diplomatics in the country to shame.

“It’s good to see you, Bakugou. I’m so glad you’ve recovered from your injuries.”

“…I’m…. Shit.”

Katsuki swears he had a response for her, but his mind goes completely blank as his eyes drift to behind Yaoyorozu and to the figure that just moved on the hospital bed.

Katsuki’s legs start to shake, and with an astounding quickness, Yaoyorozu manifests a chair and places it under Katsuki’s weak knees.

Izuku Midoriya is laying on the bed, wearing the same hospital pajamas he is, the sleeve of the right arm completely limp.

He looks like Zero – objectively – but Katsuki can recognize him as Deku, like one of those crappy optical illusions, where he can finally see *both* patterns in the same image, rather than the singular one.

It seems so obvious. Even from here, he can see the powder of freckles across his nose. Dark roots are growing in under his bleached blonde hair. His body still looks much too large for the crappy twin-sized hospital bed, the springs of the mattress looking like they’re about to collapse under him, and yet he looks... *smaller* than he last remembers.

This is probably the least physically fucked up he’s ever seen Izuku Midoriya in the hospital setting and there’s something tragically hilarious about that. Katsuki stifles a delirious laugh with a cough against his fist.

“…He’s changed so much,” Yaoyorozu adds, as if verbally continuing Katsuki’s train of thought. She doesn’t mean it as a compliment, Katsuki can hear it in the breathy way she speaks, like she’s trying to comfort him.

“…Not as much as you think,” Katsuki responds, almost defensively, before he clamps his mouth shut.

He sees Yaoyorozu furrow her brows, digesting what those words imply. Her mouth props open, on the verge of saying something.

Katsuki needs to change the subject. And fast.

“Can he see us?”

Her mouth clamps shut, and she purses her lips.

“…No. It’s a one-way window. It allows for the doctors and nurses to always keep an eye on him.”

“Hear us?”

Yaoyorozu’s eyes dart to a speaker system by the door. She clears her throat, eyes flashing back to the corner of the room.

“Individuals are able to communicate with the patient using the speaker on the wall. There’s a button that needs to be pressed that allows for two way communication. He can’t activate it from his side.”

“Seems fucked,” Katsuki comments casually. Yaoyorozu coughs, trying to hide the smile tugging on the corners of her lips.

“…Well. I must. Take a tea break for a few minutes. I trust you will… behave.”

The closes the door behind her quietly, and suddenly, they’re alone.

Katsuki’s heart has never jumped into his throat so quickly.

Izuku Midoriya is right there. Right in front of him. Alive and in the flesh. The real him.

No memory Quirk. No disguises. No lies.

The real Izuku Midoriya. The same person he’s been looking for for four years.

Katsuki just watches. Just watches the other stare at the ceiling, blinking slowly. Watches as he chews the corner of his lips, mouthing something to no one.

How many one-sided conversations has the nerd had in the past four years? How many times was his own voice the only one to keep his company as he fell asleep? How different was his life outside this prison?

A weird sense of elation passes through Katsuki – like he’s watching a beautiful animal in the zoo, one that can’t run away from him, hide from him, one that has nowhere else to go. Captivity looks good on him. He could probably spend hours here, just watching him.

But Katsuki doesn’t. The minutes are few and precious, and he can’t just waste his time sitting here – he has to.

He has to.

He doesn’t know what he has to do.

He eyes the button and speaker on the wall next to the door. He’s not entirely sure he can get his voice to work, but he wants – he *needs* – to at least see the other closer.

He has no idea what to say. But he hobbles over to the speaker anyway, shaking fingers pressing at the button. He can hear static erupt in Deku’s prison cell, and the other looks around, first wearing an expression of surprise before his mouth turns into a grimace.

“I’m not speaking to anyone without my lawyer,” Izuku Midoriya clips, and it’s so ridiculous that Katsuki can’t help but laugh out loud.

He can see it in real time. Deku eyebrows furrow in confusion, and then he’s bouncing out of bed, nearly tripping over his sheets as he rushes towards the window, eyes wide as his hands touch the glass.

“Kacchan?”

Katsuki sort of wishes Yaoyorozu made a few more chairs, because he didn’t expect his entire body to turn to stone and make it’s best attempt at shattering at the sound of his childhood nickname.

How long has it been? Four full years?

It sounds like him. It sounds like Zero, too, but it also sounds like *Deku* – whiny, high pitched, needy, nerdy Deku. Pressed up against the window, those ridiculously large green eyes shine against their sunken backdrop. Despite everything, they're so still so goddamn bright.

Katsuki's voice dies in his throat.

He reaches a hand out, fingertips tracing against Izuku's handprint on the glass.

"… Kacchan…?" The downturn of the other's lips, the slight wobble, the pathetic way his voice cracks and Katsuki's chest feels like it's going to combust, too full of an emotion he doesn't have a name for.

"It's me, nerd."

He feels his entire face flare bright red at the giant smile that eclipses the other's face instantly. He's grateful that this is a one way mirror. There's something freeing about letting his body shake, letting his cheeks flush, letting himself trace the outline of the other with his fingertips, express his humiliating truth without the other ever knowing.

"Are you alright? I heard that you were awake, but – how's your leg? Your chest? Are you breathing okay?"

"Fucker, are you *seriously* gonna worry about me when you're literally in prison?" Katsuki's voice is harsher than he intended, relying on safe frustration to bat away the slew of feelings on the verge of knocking him over. The smile falls off the other's face, and Katsuki can't help but outline his features with his eyes.

"…I'm always going to worry about you." Katsuki watches the other's mouth form a smile, the forced uptick of his lips highlighting his dimples. "…I'm sorry you got hurt because of me. I wish you hadn't stopped me –"

"Don't fucking finish that sentence. Are you kidding me right now, Deku? Do you have a single coherent thought in that shitty head of yours? What about your mother? All Might? Your friends?"

What about me?

His shoulders droop and he swallows, slowly, intently.

"They would have been fine. I've been dead to everyone for years, anyway." His voice is flat, final, serious. He sounds exactly like Zero, and it makes Katsuki sick to his stomach.

"Not to everyone." Katsuki levels a harsh look at him, even though the other cannot see. "Not to *me."*

"Kacchan, I never expected you to – "

"What, *give a shit about you?* Last time I *saw you,* I nearly gave my fucking *life for you*, and you disappear for *four goddamn years* and what, now you're going stand there and spew this garbage at me like none of that shit even mattered? Like *this* –" Katsuki's voice chokes up and, furious, he looks away from the other. What the fuck. What the fuck. What the ever-loving fuck.

The silence sits heavy between them, green eyes staring at the nothing in front of him.

His voice sounds so soft, so confused, when he speaks again.

“…How long have you known? That it was me?”

“… Since the bunker.” Katsuki tells the truth, because he knows Deku can’t see him, because he can’t see the way his cheeks pinken, or his legs shake, or that he’s keeping his sweaty palm flush with Deku’s despite the inches of window separating them. He takes his other hand, outlining the other’s parted lips.

Katsuki hasn’t forgotten the feel of them against his. Hasn’t forgotten the feel of the other’s fingertips against his skin. Hasn’t forgotten what it was like to fall asleep next to him.

He doesn’t think he’ll ever forget what it felt like to have Deku without having him.

The blush that flares to life on his face is pretty, and Katsuki uses his hand to outline the pinkness of his cheeks, trace along the freckles dotting his nose.

“…But we. You let me. I - ” He stammers through the words. “Why did you let me do those things to you?”

Katsuki stops.

That’s both an absolutely impossible question to answer and the simplest thing in the world.

Why? Because Katsuki wanted to.

But why Katsuki wanted to? Admitting that he was attracted to Zero means he’s attracted to Deku. Admitting that he intrinsically trusted Zero means that he intrinsically trusted Deku. Admitting that he felt safe with Zero means that he feels safe with Deku.

What makes it okay when it’s a stranger and not Deku? Their history, their childhood, their rivalry? All good answers, all answers that make sense, all things that Katsuki can lean on, except he know that that’s not really what it is.

It’s like… you may adore the ocean, so you go to aquariums, watch documentaries, spend time on the water to feel close to the object of your fascination, but if presented with the opportunity to become a deep sea explorer, you may not take it.

Like if you adore the stars and outer space, so you buy a telescope and you visit a planetarium and you keep your eyes on the sky, but if given the opportunity to become an astronaut, to transverse that final frontier, you may not take it.

The imitation is safe. Reachable. Predictable.

The real thing is unknown. Complicated. Terrifying.

And Katsuki’s looked death in the eyes, saw pure evil consume the world, has seen more blood and gore and anguish than anyone his age should have, and yet? He’s never been afraid.

Now?

He’s too close to transversing the unknown. And that? That scares the ever-loving crap out of him.

So he lies.

“To distract you. I put a tracker on you that night. In your prosthetic arm.”

The half-truth makes Deku's face blanch completely, whatever inkling of hope wiped out with just those few words. It's a gift Katsuki has. A part of him is grateful it hasn't faded over time.

"To distract me." He repeats, words coming out monotone. He raises his eyes, devoid of emotion, mouth moving like he can't believe what he's saying. "…You let me rape you to distract me."

Its Katsuki's turn to be completely stunned.

"…What the fuck, Deku. You didn't… *rape* me. I – It was – "

"Would you have?" Deku interrupts, voice louder, harsher, betrayal painted clearly on his paled face. "…Would you have done what you did if you knew it was me?"

"No."

The word is out of Katsuki's mouth before he can take it back.

Because it's the truth.

Katsuki watches the other's face transform. Its eerie, the way he's learned to control his emotions. Deku used to be so *reactive* – from furious one minute to tearful the next, he expressed everything so passionately, so openly.

But that isn't a useful quality to a fugitive, or a vigilante, or a spy. So those round, hurt eyes, that wobbling lip, the shake of the other's shoulders smooth out mechanically, like repainting over a work of art with stark white paint.

"You should go." Deku's voice is cold as he takes a step back from the window.

It's only a single step, but it feels like a rift. He can feel the other pulling away, falling outside his reach, and sudden panic spikes in Katsuki's psyche.

"Deku – "

"No. You couldn't – you couldn't even grant me the dignity of letting me die. I have to live with this. With what I did to you. With every choice I made. I always knew you hated me, but this is – "

"Deku, shut the fuck up." Katsuki's finger arch against the window, nearly slippery with new nitroglycerin.

Can he blow up this window? Can he get the other out of here? Can they escape and run away together?

"Please leave me alone."

"Deku – " Katsuki chokes out. "Don't do this."

The other ignores him completely. Katsuki keeps the speaker button pressed, staring desperately at the other.

"Izuku – "

Deku walks away from the window, back to his own bed, and fiddles with the remote attached to the railing.

Katsuki has no idea what he might be doing until a bright red light ignites over the one-way window, flashing repeatedly. Katsuki furrows his eyes at it, refusing to move – it takes Creati slamming the door open, chest heaving, eyes panicked to finally break Katsuki out of his trance.

“You have to go. He’s calling the medical team. No one can see you – “

Katsuki turns back to the window, pressing the speaker button, all sense of composure flushed down the toilet.

“IZUKU! ARE YOU FUCKING – ARE YOU KIDDING? YOU – “

“Please, Bakugou,” Yaoyorozu says, her eyes dating towards the door. Katsuki scoffs, pushing down the ache. He grabs on to his IV pole, casting one last look the other, who is now back in bed with his back to the window, and walks out the door.

He walks slowly, each step a minefield down the hallway as several nurses and doctors rush towards the same room he’ll probably never set foot in again.

Chapter End Notes

Katsuki, genius mastermind, definitely seeing this outcome coming (not):



WOW okay a lot happened in this chapter.

(it gets worse before it gets better, but it DOES get better!!! Happy endings only folks!)

I'm super psyched about the Trial Arc. We're going to hear a lot about the past four years of Izuku's life and explain some of the fun Quirk fuckery I've been throwing at you for the last few chapters. This will also have a lot about Katsuki rebuilding his life now that his search is over, which is definitely not a metaphor for depression and getting better lol

Happy Holidays and Merry Crisis. The last six months have been some of the most challenging of my life - without this silly little story and these silly little memes and you, the person who decided to take a chance on this frankly very weird piece of writing - I think I would be so lost.

Thank you for being here, and for reading, and I'm so so grateful to you guys for everything. I love you all.

Chapter 15

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Katsuki glances over his shoulder. The shadows seem to keep moving on their own, closing in on him, whispering something – but that's impossible. He knows it is. He redirects his gaze to the splintered door in front of him. He lifts his fist, knocking, hearing the thing creak under the minimum force he's exerting. Dust that has settled into the ancient wood floats up to Katsuki's nostrils, making him hack a cough that shoots straight to the scar on his chest. He rubs against the puckered tissue, the extra pressure easing the burning sensation crawling over his skin.

His cough echoes around the empty halls, and Katsuki looks around again, goosebumps forming on his skin for all the wrong reasons. This place is dark as hell, eerily quiet, and fucking impossible to find – the apartment complex seems to be located in the back lot of some kind of industrial office building, only accessible through the office building's garage and a janky-ass gate that's falling off its hinges.

It looks exactly like the type of place one might go to get their organs harvested or, if he's lucky, murdered.

Katsuki knocks again, huffing with irritation. He doesn't have time for this. He raises his cane, rapping it against the door. He hears something shift within the wood, like a crack, and Katsuki has no qualms about breaking this piece of shit door in two, so he raises his cane once more when it finally swings open, Aizawa's scruffy irritated face peeking through the small gap.

"Were you followed?"

Katsuki glances around incredulously. It would literally be impossible to follow him here. No one ends up in this shit-stain complex accidentally. He's fairly certain no one else even *lives* here, much less loiters in this sorry excuse for a meth den.

"You serious?"

"Answer the question."

"Fuckin' *no.* You gonna let me in or what?"

Aizawa sighs like he's not the person who invited Katsuki over in the first place.

"What are you doing in this fucking pig-sty in the middle of the day? Don't you have child soldiers to indoctrinate?" Katsuki says casually as he makes his way past the door. He watches Aizawa lock the first lock, deadbolt the door, and fasten the little chain, for good measure. Then, he places a chair in front of the door, right underneath the handle. Katsuki finds his grip tightening against his cane.

No one knows where Himiko Toga is, right? She hasn't been captured? Maybe she found him, and this is her revenge for being part of getting her boss arrested. Katsuki's about to be bled dry.

He finds himself oddly calm with that thought in his head. His hands don't so much as sweat.

"First of all, I live here now."

Katsuki looks around the tiny studio apartment once again, scrunching his nose. The entirety of the place is made up of the smallest, saddest goddamn kitchen he's ever seen, literally a tatami mat with a yellow sleeping bag on it, and a desk with a laptop on it, and a white curtain that Katsuki can only assume separates the toilet from the rest of the room. The light bulb above the living room is burning out, and it flickers intermittently.

"…Second of all, I was placed on forced leave from U.A. Along with Toshinori."

Katsuki almost doesn't process the words, continuing his silent judgement of the apartment before he nearly drops his cane.

"You were *what?*"

Aizawa shrugs. "The blame for having the children on the island has fallen on the two of us, and parents called for termination of our employment. Pending the results of the trial, this leave might very well become permanent."

Katsuki taps his cane against the wooden floor, stomach twisting into knots.

"…Where is Al – Yagi, anyway? I haven't seen tits or tail of him since the island."

Maybe something childish in Katsuki wanted his former idol and mentor to visit him at least once in the hospital, just so Katsuki can tell him to fuck off, but the man never made an appearance.

"…That's part of what we're here to talk about. Sit."

Katsuki looks around the entirely barren apartment before finally sitting on the only non-floor surface – namely, the computer chair.

"The three of us, along with Kirishima, Ashido, Utsushimi, and likely some of the students will be expected to testify at the trial. If it's found out we're meeting beforehand, any testimony we might present may be completely disregarded with the excuse that we have been… 'colluding.'"

Katsuki nods, because colluding is exactly what they're doing.

"Toshinori still has friends in the police department. Midoriya has been transferred to Tarturus and will be held there until the trial in two weeks. That gives us two weeks to gather as much information as possible to lessen his sentence."

Katsuki doesn't meet the other's eye.

The obvious is left unspoken.

Deku's going to be convicted. After all, he committed the crimes he's being accused of.

Five years ago, he might have escaped with a slap to the wrist, all in the name of doing what must be done for 'the greater good.'

It's what happened after the Stain incident. After Kamino Ward. After Daika City. After Jaku.

A forgiveness reliant on the populace's trust of a young hero's judgement, of understanding what extraordinary circumstances surrounded their fights.

When All for One and One for All disappeared, any sense of collective forgiveness seemed to go with them.

Speaking of.

"…So where *is* the old fuck?" Katsuki changes the subject.

Aizawa lifts his wrist extraordinarily close to his face, glaring at the clock face like the thing owes him money.

"…He's supposed to have called around…."

The computer sitting in front of Katsuki instantly lights up with a green background, a crappy animation of a telephone vibrating back and forth, compounded with an annoying high-pitched ringing sound. Katsuki connects the dots without instruction and clicks on the large green button overlying the image.

A full-screen version of Toshinori Yagi's gaunt face fills the entirety of the screen and Katsuki does his best not to recoil away from the image. It gives the illusion of being inches away from the other man, his protuberant cheekbones and hollowed eyes overwhelmingly obvious in this position. He looks even more skeletal with the desk lamp angled slightly away from him, casting harsh shadows against his bony features, revealing the standard-appearing hotel bed behind him.

"How's the search going?" Aizawa dives right into the conversation, not clarifying a single fucking thing for Katsuki.

"Not great, I'm afraid. Young Midoriya is quite the… escape artist. It turns out that the time he spent at the safe-house we arranged for him was… limited. Outside this, I'm having difficulty finding where and when he traveled."

"…That's what I was afraid of." Aizawa shakes his head. "The kid's been in disguise for four years without being tagged. We probably won't be able to pick up on his trail. You should come back to Japan. We can start to approach this from a different angle. If we can get the two hero-lay judges on the case that have worked with Midoriya in the past, we can – "

"Wait. You need to know what Deku's been doing the past four years?" Katsuki interrupts.

"…Yes…" Yagi breaks the silence, narrowing his eyes on the screen.

"You're in fucking luck," Katsuki nearly laughs at the absurdity of the situation. All that fucking research, all those sleepless nights… that fucking *wall* might not have been for nothing after all.

"Listen. I've got… I've got a bunch of shit that I've been researching…uh, independently… the past few years. You'd be fucked to find a better account of where this dipshit's been over the past four years. Cities. Names. Correlation with the Leagues movements. I've got it all. I can digitize this shit and sent it to you in a few hours."

Aizawa rubs his stubble, the wrinkle in his forehead giving away the fact he's thinking about something before he even opens his mouth.

"If it's that complete, maybe we can just hand it over to the defense attorney – "

"…Except most of this shit was obtained illegally and won't hold up in a court of law." Katsuki interrupts before Aizawa gets too far. His former homeroom teacher narrows his eye at him, crossing

his arms, making Katsuki feel vaguely like he's about to get scolded. He continues anyway, because he's a fucking adult and Aizawa doesn't still make him feel like a grade-schooler, *dammit.*

"It should at least give you a place to start. I'm pretty sure I've got at least rough descriptions of his disguises for the first two years. After that – "

After that, Deku became Zero.

And Zero was the perfect disguise. To everyone that Deku didn't want remembering him, he was absolutely invisible. Non-existent.

"…After that?" Yagi goads on, eyes weirdly wide, something deep within that darkness sparkling with an emotion Katsuki can't stand to look at. He glances down at his thighs, fiddling with his fingers. He hadn't told them.

"… After that, I met him." Katsuki finishes.

The silence between the three of them is palpable. Katsuki glances up, just to make sure the line didn't disconnect, but the only sound between the three is the sound of Aizawa's laptop hissing out hot air.

"You met him?" Aizawa asks. "Why are you just telling us this now? So your theory about him coming to the island wasn't just a theory?" His voice raises slightly, but not with anger – there's a panic, a concern in there that makes Katsuki's hair stand on end.

"I'm not telling you two shit. Remember? I needed you two to be in on the plan so I could change the training camp and keep those asshole kids safe, but it's the same reason that we didn't tell Dumb Blonde, Raccoon Eyes or Shitty Hair why we did what we did. The court is likely to use some truth-telling Quirk that will implicate all of you if I tell you more. With what you know now, your only crime will have been trusting me and my batshit theories, which – "

Katsuki sucks on his teeth. Trusting him *should* be a crime. Izuku Midoriya would be offender #1.

" – which last I checked, isn't punishable by law. So relax."

"Are you intending to implicate yourself, then?" Yagi's voice sounds distant, thoughtful, those same dark eyes filled with that disgusting pity that makes Katsuki want to yak up his lunch.

"I'm not 'implicating' shit. I'm guilty."

He doesn't mean just regarding the case, and the silence between the three of them tells Katsuki his former teachers understand.

"I'm going to… write you something that describes the Quirk he's been using for the past two years to disguise himself. There has to be a way to… retrieve the memories that he's made others forget. Better we find it before the prosecution does."

Katsuki swallows against the sudden dryness in his mouth. Deku made him forget about the gun. What else did he make him forget? What has he said to the other? What has the other said to him?

"You're a lifesaver, Young Bakugou."

Katsuki can't stand the look of awe and gratefulness on Yagi's face, so he rolls his eyes.

“You need help out there, old man? I can buy a ticket in – “

“…Hold on.” Aizawa squeezes Kasuki’s shoulder, chin jutting to where his cane rests against the wall, tapping his own prosthetic against the floor.

“We’re only going to slow him down. We need to ensure everything is ready here.”

Yagi nods in response, and Katsuki huffs out in agreement. All Might still has pull in America – his influence hasn’t faded yet and he’s got the best chance of obtaining new information. Hell, he’s probably got the most motivation too, considering he’s at least partially (completely) responsible for the nerd being in this mess.

“…Any word on your end, Shota? Regarding Shigaraki.”

Aizawa glances at Katsuki before starting.

“From what I’ve heard, he’s still completely catatonic. He’s behaving similarly to…” Katsuki can feel the sharp inhale of his teacher behind him, the slight bend in the chair as his teacher grips the back more forcefully. “…To Kurogiri. There are brain waves, but they’re very… scattered. They do believe he’s still in there, but progress has been slow. I don’t believe he’ll be ready to testify prior to the trial.”

Yagi nods thoughtfully.

“Right. Then it’s up to us.”

It isn’t, and Katsuki knows it. The world doesn’t work like that. A scrappy team of heroes isn’t going to save the vigilante with a heart of gold. There are systems – there have *always* been systems – to ensure that the house always wins. His entire fucking life has been nothing but a zero-sum game – no winners, no losers, a struggle towards exactly nothing. In the end, the sum total of everything is zero.

“…I’ll get the stuff to you by the time you wake up. Don’t fuck up.” Katsuki tells the screen before he clicks on the red button next to the screen. Aizawa narrows his eyes, but Katsuki doesn’t need to know if they wanted to continue their conversation. As far as he’s concerned, everything that needed to be said has been said.

Katsuki stares at his hands. He knows that he should stand, should leave, should proceed to his apartment and accomplish the promised task, but something is keeping him in this chair. Some weight, crushing his shoulders, keeping him anchored in this shitty apartment.

“… Four years of tracking him, huh?”

Aizawa gives Katsuki a quizzical look, and Katsuki uses all his concentration not to blush at the implication.

“...So the fuck what,” Katsuki defends against the non-accusation, making Aizawa narrow his one good eye in, like he can see right through Katsuki’s façade.

“It’s not your fault he disappeared, you know. You don’t need to keep trying to… kill yourself to prove – “

“That’s not what the fuck it is!” Katsuki stands up suddenly, the chair rolling away from him across the floor. Aizawa steps back, arms outstretched as Katsuki finds himself slightly off-balance, his left thigh shaking at the sudden exertion. He grasps for his cane, leaning against it, refusing to meet the other’s eye.

"…Then what is it? Why have I watched you try to die for him twice now? Why have you spent the last four years of your life looking for him?"

Katsuki stares back at the other. It's an absurd question, and one he doesn't really have an answer for. He rakes his exhausted mind for something that sounds plausible and would get the other off his back.

"Atonement. I'm partially the reason he's this fucking reckless. I was an absolute shithead to him and it gave him a complex or some shit. If I caused it, then I fix it, yeah?" Katsuki crosses his arms, waiting for the other to dispute him. Aizawa, instead, remains silent, lips pursed.

"And how many times of almost dying does it take to 'atone?'"

Katsuki opens his mouth, and Aizawa cuts him off instantly.

"Let me reword that. How many people are going to suffer in the crossfires of your atonement?"

The image of Zero, gun barrel in his own mouth in an effort to prevent Katsuki from getting impaled flashes in the forefront of his mind, and whatever comeback he has disappears from his tongue.

He hurts him, and he can't stop hurting him. No matter the significance he has in the other's life, no matter whether a childhood friend or an enemy or a rival or a lover, Katsuki always hurts Izuku. Each of his actions, even those that seem well intentioned, only end up hurting him *more* – that cursed power, his disappearance, him being imprisoned.

The look on his face when Katsuki told him he wouldn't have touched him if he knew Zero was Deku. The way his expression turned distant, cold. Even then, even when he had the opportunity to be honest, even when he should have said absolutely anything else, he chose to hurt him. Hurting Deku is as easy, as intrinsic, as natural as breathing.

Maybe it's time he starts asking himself *why.*

"… Stop asking weird philosophical bullshit and get to work. Fuck you." Katsuki points his cane at his former teacher and, without much more preamble, limps out the door. He slams it shut, like the petulant child that he is, ignoring the way the dust from the ceiling above falls in response.

Where the hell does he get off?

Katsuki makes it to his apartment much later than he intends. His brain is rattling with his former teacher's words, and he needed the walk to think through it; but now that he's standing in front of his former study, half-destroyed and unlocked, he wonders whether that was truly enough time.

He simply can't get past the mental roadblock of 'how many times does sacrificing his life equal to atonement?'

The best answer Katsuki has is 'as many as it takes to save him.' But it's an insane answer, one that admits that not only has he tried to die for Izuku Midoriya twice now, but he'd do it again. He's do it a hundred more times. He'd do it until he was successful. There's no reality in which he'll do anything smaller than give his everything to ensure Deku is safe.

Even if Deku doesn't want him to. Even if Deku has decided that he's going to die. Even if no one else understands why. Katsuki's always, always understood the greater good.

And Deku *is* the greater good. Even if he can't see it anymore.

Katsuki half-drags his leg up the ladder to his roof, lifting the box out of the storage closet and hauling the thing back into his study.

The wall to his left is entirely empty, paint unnaturally white where papers covered the otherwise grimy surface. Four years of his life, a part of himself, rests in a tiny pile in his hands.

He sits down on his chair, spreading the papers out like playing cards on the empty table. He pulls his laptop out of the box, blowing on it lightly to get rid of the imaginary dust settled there.

It's only been a few weeks, but it feels like a lifetime.

Katsuki opens his computer, quickly creating a folder to store each photograph.

He takes out his phone, and, one by one, he takes a picture of each document in the stack.

The maps. The articles. His own letter – it makes his skin crawl, thinking of anyone's eyes on the words that Deku had written for him – but what was theirs is no longer theirs. Katsuki's sentimentality won't stand in the way of somehow getting Deku's sentence shortened.

After over an hour of work, Katsuki is left with just a few remnants in his previous pile. Katsuki has been averting his eyes from them – the photographs do nothing but intensify the ache within his scars, make his chest constrict, make his mind wonder that useless question – *what if what if what if?*

The *what if's* have changed, morphed, become something much more tender, much more daring, so far outside anything he's thought of before that he doesn't know how to process it. It should disgust him, surprise him, at least *scare* him – but altering his fantasies to include touch, to include the other's lips against his, to feel his fingertips through his hair, to feel his *hands* on his hips – has been absolutely effortless, natural, like the next step on a staircase he's been ascending his whole goddamn life.

Katsuki doesn't know what the fuck to do with that realization.

He pauses on the picture. Smiling wide, freckles and dimples alight on his cherubic face, holding an ice-cream cone just off to the side. The upquirk of his too-full lips, the sunrays through the curls of his hair, those long eyelashes framing too-green eyes. He's sitting on the grass, everything green and alive in front of him. It's an intimate picture – it looks like it was just the two of them, and Deku looks like he was caught off guard, his cheeks just a tint of pink suggestive of either a sunburn or a blush or both.

The first time he saw the picture, he had jacked Todoroki's phone as the other slept next to him. He used his fingertip to unlock the device, knowing exactly what he was looking for, still finding himself absolutely astonished with the sheer *quantity* of pictures the fucker had of Deku.

And how many of those pictures, Deku was smiling right back at him with that fucking unabashed, easy smile.

Katsuki grinds his teeth down, hands forming into fists as he sets the picture down gingerly, corrosive sweat a recipe to dissolve the photo paper.

Deku didn't smile at him like that. There was always something… hidden, something distant, something dark behind the way he smiled at him. He still did – like he was obligated to, like he had to placate Katsuki with it – but it wasn't the same way he did at the others.

He fucking hated it.

He can't imagine that Deku will ever smile like that again. Not after everything. Not after what Katsuki did to him.

You let me rape you to distract me?

It was such a ridiculous statement Katsuki didn't fucking know how to respond. He's the one that kissed him the first time. That coerced him into the blow job, into having sex, into *everything.* He pushed when Deku didn't *want* him. He kept pushing, even though he *knew* the other didn't want him.

The way he covered his eyes? The way he shook? The way he kept saying *no?*

If anyone's truly at fault here, if anyone forced someone into something they didn't want, it was definitely Katsuki.

There's no forgiveness for this shit. And atonement?

Atonement can only get you so far.

Atonement is logical. Its reachable. Its attainable. But the thing that makes Katsuki want to give everything for Izuku Midoriya – give everything *to* Izuku Midoriya – is something much less tangible. Something absurd. Something that Katsuki doesn't deserve to feel towards the other.

He lost his right to feel this way the very first time he put his hands on him with the intention of harm.

Maybe that's why it felt so good to be with Zero. Because he allowed himself to feel, to want, to dream of the exact thing he doesn't deserve to have with Deku.

Izuku Midoriya doesn't deserve the burden of Katsuki's feelings. He doesn't deserve being held down by him. He doesn't deserve to be part of this endless cycle of sacrificing themselves for one another; Katsuki because of his absolute devotion, and Deku because of his… fuck if Katsuki knows. Intrinsic heroism? Dedication to his childhood friend? Belief that history holds more weight than reality?

They're two for two at this point, aren't they?

Maybe it's time to quit while they're ahead.

… All I've ever done is make your life worse. But after this, I promise. I promise I'll be gone. You'll never see me again.

Zero told Katsuki that on the mountain, and Katsuki took that choice away from him. But it's what Deku wanted – and Katsuki is starting to understand why.

"This is the last thing," he promises the young-eyed photo. "This trial is the last thing. Then you'll never have to see me again. I'm going to let you go."

The picture just smiles back.

When he's eventually done – when the final swishing sound emits from his computer, indicating that the email has been successfully sent, Katsuki comes back to himself to hear some off clanking coming from the kitchen.

He sniffs, sharp spice hitting all his senses all at once.

He opens the door of his study, shuffling out in confusion. What kind of villain cooks mapo tofu –

He observes the back of someone dainty, with his same fucking haircut, humming something over the flying pan. The warmth of the kitchen spreads throughout the empty apartment, making its way into Katsuki's bones, tickling his nose.

The television is on in the background, and any sense of comfort Katsuki felt dissipates as his spine straightens, every hair rising on the back of his neck with the sound of one name.

Izuku Midoriya.

Katsuki approaches the half-island, taking a seat in one of the swivel chairs, resting his elbows against the counter as he watches his mother cook absently, ears trained to the sound of the television in his living room.

"You didn't have any groceries in this shithole." Mitsuki says without looking at him, flipping something on the stove.

Katsuki grunts in response.

"Who the fuck told you you can come here?"

"I have your spare," Mitsuki reminds him, too calmly. "And I let you try to figure your own shit out for the past year. We tried to give you space. But you nearly fucking died, so let me take care of you." Mitsuki pauses, letting the words settle between them, before she adds, "Bastard."

Katsuki scoffs, shaking his head, but says nothing else. His ears train on the television behind him. He hasn't turned the thing on for this exact reason since he's left the hospital – but if he's not the one that turned it on, it must be okay for him to listen – right?

"Izuku Midoriya, former U.A. student, made headlines four years ago when it was revealed that he was the successor to All Might's power. The twenty year old recently re-appeared in Japan as a vigilante – multiple countries with counts leveled against him, including Vigilante Behavior, Aggravated Assault, Impersonating a Hero, Identity Theft, Embezzlement, Unlawful Quirk Usage, Coercion, and most recently, Attempted Murder of forty U.A. third year and several former classmates and teachers, notably All Might himself. I have Tsutsutaka Agoyamato here from the Hero Commission. Mr. Agoyamato, what are your thoughts regarding these developments?"

"Thank you for having me. Well, it seems quite clear that Izuku Midoriya is a natural result of the flawed hero system that we have fought so hard to replace. Just like Hero Killer Stain, Izuku Midoriya has chosen to push forward his ideology no matter the laws that are in place or what consequences he may face. It's likely the reason he left Japan in the wake of our change – a perfect demonstration why many young heroes left the country. A level of selfishness, self-absorption and arrogance that leads former heroes to believe they are above the law, and that their status should be above all people, leading to god-like or celebrity status. In fact, Izuku Midoriya – "

Katsuki doesn't remember when he stepped in front of the television, or exactly when he put the remote in his hands, but all he knows is he's standing in front of the blank screen with his thumb on the Power button.

"Why are you watching this shit," Katsuki says, because he feels like he has to say something.

He knows the reason she's watching it. It's the same reason the rest of Japan is watching.

They just want to see somebody go down for what happened four years ago. They don't even care who it is.

"… He was such a sweet kid." Mitsuki has to open her fucking mouth, of course she does, laced with that fake pity that makes Katsuki want to combust his entire fucking apartment. It's the same goddamn tone she used at the dinner table when she lamented about *poor Inko and her little Quirkless Izuku.* She might as well have said *I'm glad it's not happening to me,* because that's what it's always come down to.

"Don't tell me you're buying into the Commission's shit. You fucking *know* Deku. He's not some criminal."

"…People change, brat. He's been gone for four years. He might be a completely different person than the person you knew."

He is and he isn't.

Katsuki's stomach, previously growling at the delicious scent wafting through his apartment, now seems to be contracting in on itself, making bile creep up Katsuki's throat.

"… You speak to Inko?"

Mitsuki pauses with her hands on the pan, shoulders going stiff, before resuming her movements. She takes the pan off the stove, opening the rice cooker, keeping her face in proximity with the steam for longer than she probably needs to. She takes the rice paddle, dishing out a generous helping for Katsuki, drenching it in tofu, spices and peppers. She places the plate in front of him, not making one for herself as she leans against Katsuki's counters.

"It's disrespectful to call your elder by their first name." Mitsuki's words sound like a warning, turbulent and nearly accusatory.

"*She* told me to call her that."

Mitsuki's eyes flash a lighter red, and her mouth twitches downward, almost enough to give away her obvious displeasure.

"I know. I'm saying she *shouldn't* have. She's a goddamn mess, Katsuki. What the hell am I supposed to say? She won't talk to me. She's just… locking herself in her apartment and crying all day."

"Shouldn't she be happy? Her son is alive." Katsuki finds his words coming out flat.

Mitsuki shoves the food across the counter closer to Katsuki, brandishing chopsticks from his kitchen drawer. She stares at him expectantly until Katsuki, against every instinct in his body, because his stomach is rebelling, flipping and flying like its going for a goddamn Gold Medal, picks them up and shovels a bite into his mouth.

Mitsuki's expression softens and she leans back against the counter, crossing her arms.

"It's not that she's unhappy, Katsuki. It's just… it can't be easy to lose someone twice."

Katsuki can't taste a goddamn thing.

Lose him twice?

She never lost him in the first place. She just got impatient, just like everybody else. What, they were supposed to believe Mr. Compress when he, in the middle of getting his ass handed to him, assured them of Deku's death? Anyone with half a brain had to know he was lying – and yet, everyone latched on to it. Believed it.

They held a funeral for him, for fuck's sake.

People are so much more scared of uncertainty than death.

But why the hell is she mourning *now?!* It's him. He's back. He's Deku – a different one, a burned and bruised one – but he's still *him.* And he needs his mother, now more than ever.

Katsuki takes out his phone, mindlessly shoving another bite into his mouth. He's avoided the minefield that is his texts and notifications this long, but its time to face… whatever the fuck this is.

Surprisingly, it didn't take very long to find [I.]

Sunday:

[I] 10:34am – *I heard some U.A. students were involved in the explosion – have you heard anything? Any of your friends?*

[I] 10:40am – *Katsuki, please message me back*

[I] 11:30am – *please text me back. No one knows where you are*

[I] 17:00pm – they still can't find you. Please. Come home.

[I] 17:55pm – I can't go through this again.

[I] 2143pm – be okay. I'm thinking of you.

Monday:

[I] 11:04am – *four people have been found – are you one of them? Tell me you're one of them*

[I] 1333pm – *this has to be a joke*

[I] 1355 – tell me this is a joke. That boy isn't

[I] 1400 – its not him

Tuesday:

[I] 0603 – it is him. But he won't look me in the eyes

[I] 0615 – he asks about you. I don't know what to say

[I] 1212 – wake up, Katsuki. Please.

Friday:

[I] 0722 – I came to see you. You looked so peaceful.

[I] 0755 – please wake up.

[I] 0803 – wake up

Sunday:

[I] 1655 – I told him you woke up today. It's the first time I've seen him smile.

[I] 1703 – for a second he looked like my Izuku

Tuesday:

[I] 1300 – the police are tapping into my phones. They aren't letting me see him anymore. Please. Katsuki. I don't know what to do

Katsuki bites the insides of his cheeks. He scrolls back to their previous texts – short exchanges on agreeing to meet, but never this. She's fucking losing it.

But she's also spoken to Deku. Multiple times, it sounds like. He tries to push back the discomfort and texts her back.

Me 1858pm - I'm fine. Just recovering at home. Need to talk about Deku. When are you home?

[I] 1859pm – always home. Would love to see you. Have been so worried about you.

Disgusting. Katsuki glances up to his mother, ensuring she hasn't been looking at his texts. She's busied herself with cleaning, the sound of running water surely drowning out the panicked huffs he's breathing out. She's the absolute last fucking person he wants to see. Even sending this text back feels dirty.

He almost doesn't notice as his mother turns away from him, her nails digging into his counter, voice forced.

"…You okay, brat?"

Katsuki stares at the back of her head.

"Fuckin' peachy. Why wouldn't I be doing great? Because I'm fucking crippled and who knows when I can go back to work? Or because idiot Shitty Face is permanently disfigured because of me? Or because idiot Deku is in Tartarus and it's my fault? Take your pick."

His mother spins around, eyes furious. It's not entirely the reaction he expected. With Inko, every time he started with his sob stories, she responded with tearful eyes and a tender hand over his. Mitsuki is not that kind of person – he knows it, always has, and didn't tell her shit for that exact reason – but he still hops up in his chair as she slams a hand against the counter, dishes rattling with the force.

"Why do you do that? Why do you make it so hard to talk to you?"

Katsuki raises his eyebrows.

"I don't fucking know. Look in the mirror." Katsuki responds easily.

His mother's mouth clamps shut, and she breathes out harshly through her nose before turning right back around, fiddling with something in the kitchen.

"…I know I'm not…" Mitsuki sighs, rubbing the bridge of her nose. "The most affectionate mother in the world. And maybe you didn't have a good example of how to treat people that care about you. But you're gonna eventually have to find a way to love people without hurting them. Or you're going to end up alone."

Katsuki says nothing in return. He knows his mother is waiting for him to respond, to lash out, or hiss at her like some kind of feral cat. But he doesn't.

She said it like it's some kind of warning. But Katsuki hopes it's a promise.

Mitsuki sighs, voice softer. "I love you so much, Katsuki. You're stubborn and proud but you don't need to shoulder the weight of the world by yourself. Me and your father are here for you, whether you want us to be or not. Because that's what it means to love someone. I hope eventually you'll understand that."

Katsuki doesn't move. His mother gathers her things, landing a kiss on his cheek as he remains stationary, not even moving his eyes when the door closes behind her.

That's what it means to love someone.

I'm not leaving you. I don't fuckin' care what you say. You're not doing this alone. I'm going to be here.

Katsuki's throat goes dry as he remembers his own words, crystal clear in the forefront of his mind.

"What the fuck." Katsuki rasps out, exhaling shakily. He wraps his arms around his head, laying them down on the counter, whole body shaking at the realization.

Why are you following me, Kacchan?!

"Even then? You're fucking kidding me." Katsuki laughs at the marble, hot tears forcing their way out of his eyes.

Stop trying to win this on your own.

He can feel himself getting overheated, his hands starting to sweat, and all he wants to do is pull his hair out, punch something, explode something, fucking *fly* because he doesn't need to feel this way. He can't allow himself to feel this way.

Do you – do you think that's what love feels like?

Zero's shaking words. The warmth of his body next to Katsuki's. This incredulous question – so young and innocent. Warm lips, hurried intake of air, like every motion might be their last. Katsuki wraps his arms around his head tighter, trying to muffle the chest-aching sob.

The joke is on his mom. He knows it better than anyone, knows it like the parasite it is, and wants to rip it out of his body, cut it away or drown it or strangle it, but no matter what it does, it just keeps growing, keeps taking more of him, and there's only so much left to give, his heart, his mind, his sanity. He's being swallowed alive.

Why would she say that he has to learn how to stop hurting the people that he loves, when love *is* hurt?

With no one else to watch him, to judge him, Katsuki lets himself exhaust himself with crying until he's a snotty, disgusting mess. He sniffles, wiping his face with a paper towel.

Even this reminds him of shitty Deku.

What the fuck has his life become?

He lays in bed, a ghost of a solid body next to him. He looks up at him, and his eyes are so green that he almost believes that this isn't a dream. Katsuki laughs to himself, turning over in his bed, feeling the loss of pressure with the slight wakefulness.

He must be truly fucked in the head, if that lie is the only non-nightmare he sees when he closes his eyes.

Light comes, and the nightmare continues. He musses his hair, grabs his cane, and hobbles to the train station.

He doesn't listen to the television on the train, constantly on rerun with the latest news, flashing pictures of Zero – of Deku, lip busted, face bruised, hair bleached but eyes too devastatingly green – on the screen. He can't listen to the whispers. Can't listen to the name *Midoriya* leaving stranger's mouths. Each time he hears it, it snaps his heartstrings, making his chest vibrate.

He hates this neighborhood more and more each time he steps foot in it. He hates the sidewalks, hates the flowers, hates the stray cats, hates the front of the shoddy apartment complex Inko lives in, hates how much his leg hurts when he slowly climbs up those stairs, hates how sick he feels outside her door – he shouldn't be here, he shouldn't be here, he should –

"Katsuki!" Inko throws the door open, eyes brighter than he expected. She's smiling widely, teeth stained with a bright red. Her hair is dull but done up in that shitty half-ponytail. Her clothes fit well.

Her cheeks look more rounded but her eyes look just as grey and tired.

She hovers over Katsuki, body too close as he maneuvers around the genkan, placing his light jacket on the coat rack. He keeps his cane tightly held between his fingers, not trusting himself to let go of it, although he can certainly walk around a room without needing it's assistance. Something about having something solid in his hands, something that he can use as a weapon, brings him an odd sense of comfort. Which would make sense, if he was in the vicinity of an enemy. But instead, he's in the Midoriya household, whole body on edge like he's about to get into a fight.

"Please. Sit. I've made tea," Inko starts, directing Katsuki to the same couch he's sat in before. It looks… cleaner, somehow, the dull violet couch sporting some new looking decorative pillows. The floor looks freshly waxed, table set with placemats, even the fan on the ceiling looks like it's been dusted. The place spells pleasant.

Like pine.

Inko comes back not long after, holding two cups of tea. She's holding two plates with what looks like… green cake of some sort, placing it in front of Katsuki with a certain flourish.

"Its matcha cheesecake. I hope you like it. I've made it myself – oh, the forks!"

Inko rushes back off into the kitchen, leaving Katsuki alone with his tea and the jiggly green cake in front of him. Something about the clean apartment, about the fresh made food, about Inko wearing makeup makes all the hairs on the back of his neck stand on end. His mother told him she was locked in here. Crying.

She doesn't look like she's crying.

The couch gives, and Katsuki looks up at Inko unintentionally. She meets his eyes, smiling again.

Katsuki glances to the shrine, still burning incense, the middle school picture of Izuku Midoriya still there. He wants to throttle Inko for still having it up. Katsuki breathes through the simmering rage, picking up his teacup, ignoring the rattling sound of the cup as his hands shake and the hot liquid splashes against his lips.

"How are you healing?" Inko asks, taking a sip of her own tea. She places a fork into her own cheesecake, eating it readily.

"…Fine. It's getting better. I'm doing physical therapy and shit. Hopefully will be out in the field again in no time."

"Mm…" Inko hums, smile turning gentle. "Izuku told me you got hurt trying to protect him."

Just the mention of that name makes Katsuki's skin heat up. He ducks his head, hoping the brightness of his ears isn't instantly obvious to Inko.

"…You've been able to talk to him." Katsuki can hear the jealousy in his own voice, biting and vile, but Inko doesn't seem to notice.

"A bit. I… messaged you regarding… why I haven't been able to see him recently. But he's been writing. He's been telling me about some of the things he's seen. He seems so excited! I'm glad – " Inko's face drops, words becoming more forced. "I'm glad he was able to travel the world. See some beautiful things. Now that he's – "

“What’s he like?” Katsuki asks, for no reason at all. Is he cold and cool-headed like Zero? Is he bright and rambley like Deku?

Inko’s fingers blanch slightly as she grips on to the teacup.

“…Different. He’s different. But I still see… parts of him, in there. Its, um.” Inko looks at Katsuki, really looks at him, and Katsuki tries hard not to drop his teacup.

“You ever…miss someone when they’re sitting right in front of you?”

Something warm covers Katsuki’s hand, and he realizes with some sense of vague disgust that she’s touching him.

“Yeah.” Katsuki responds, jerking his hand out from her grip, having to set his cup down so he doesn’t stop it. He ignores the twitch of disappointment in her wrinkled face.

“Don’t get me wrong. It’s nice that he’s… still with us. It’s wonderful to see him. Even if it’s like this. I think of that little boy that played All Might and think about where it all went wrong.”

Katsuki knows where it all went wrong.

“He’s Quirkless again.” Katsuki reminds himself and her, and she nods.

“…Yes. He said that. He’s… worried you won’t want to be his friend anymore.”

Katsuki is surprised at the laugh that comes out of him. So is Inko, apparently, because she recoils, somehow ending up on the other end of the couch (putting some distance between them. There’s relief there, somewhere between the loneliness and disgust.)

His friend. As if Katsuki was ever even fucking capable of being something as banal to Izuku Midoriya as a *friend.*

He’s pretty sure he can never be his friend again.

Inko’s voice changes, then.

She almost sounds like him. Electric, threatening, otherworldly. It nearly makes Katsuki stomach looking at her.

“… I wonder, sometimes. Who he would become if he never met you.”

The clock ticks.

The incense burns.

The cane Katsuki holds taps against the floor.

“Yeah. Me too.”

Katsuki leaves the cheesecake on the table. Inko doesn’t stop him as he stands, or even as he shuts the door behind him.

Older than twenty in every way but chronological, Katsuki stands in the alley, waiting to be swallowed by the darkness, knowing fully well that a Quirkless boy with too good a heart and eyes that put galaxies to shame can’t come to save him this time.

Chapter End Notes

Kacchan, Realizing Things (TM) Every Fucking Chapter:



Flashback to Katsuki and Shouto, Being Absolutely Normal About Their 'Relationship:'



Extra one for the ladies (retroactive to chapter 3, because unfortunately I wasn't that funny yet lmao) you just KNOW Kacchan gives that good sloppy toppy



...i dont know how this happened but my playlist for this fic has slowly become EDM/trance with depressing lyrics. what vibe am i even going for anymore. why have I chosen violence.

Whoa - happy 100k words (yikes) 10k hits and fucking 2022, I guess? I have enjoyed becoming progressively more insane over the past two years hand in hand with you beautiful himbos, bimbos and theybos. Stick around, I have a lot more mental illness to squeeze out of this bad boy (both this fic and my soggy brain)

But seriously HAPPY NEW YEAR I'M KISSING EACH AND EVERY SINGLE ONE OF YOU AT MIDNIGHT

Chapter 16

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

'Izuku Midoriya vs. Hero Commission of Japan trial is set to start in two days. Mr. Midoriya has been moved out from Tartarus to a secure holding cell prior to the trial. The police have not issued a statement whether a confession has been secured while the prisoner was in holding; however – "

"Oh wow! He's very handsome." Hikari Shiryoku comments between sucks of black tapioca balls through the comically large straw stabbed into her fruity drink, hand on her chin, eyes looking dreamy. The lull in their awkward conversation has somehow lead to the girls turning their attention to the television. He can't seem to fucking avoid it any place he goes. Every screen, every radio, every smartphone is playing the same goddamn news on repeat. Even on the patio of this coffee shop, a place where they (strategically) should have been free of screens, the beautiful spring day lead to windows and doors remaining open to welcome in the breeze and to let out the utter fucking garbage being pumped out of their televisions.

"Hm?" Senko glances up from her phone, following the gaze of her sister through the cracked open doors of the near-empty bar next door, face lighting up instantly. "Oh! Oh look, that's pro hero Fusion, isn't it? I heard they used to be classmates – "

Katsuki gnashes his teeth, unable to resist glancing up at the television at the comment. It's a scene of Deku, walking out of Tartarus, surrounded by media, microphones shoved in his face, the clamoring sound of people yelling over one another to get closer poorly filtered out of the audio. His eyes are downturned, long eyelashes hiding his eyes from the cameras. His prosthetic is still missing, the right arm of his orange prison uniform loose, but the left held in front of him in a tight fist. His hair has grown out slightly – dark roots more prominent below the eye-sore bottle blonde.

He's flanked by Yaoyorozu and Todoroki, both faces frustrated and furrowed, clearly mouthing for the crowd to keep away, using their bodies to shield the taller and larger prisoner from the all-out media attack. The cameras pan to citizens stationed outside the Tartarus fences signs sporting short and to-the-point messages like 'Murderer' and 'Death Penalty' and 'Die Vigilante.'

Todoroki keeps a hand on the Deku's left shoulder, fingers splayed gingerly along his shoulderblade. Katsuki feels bile climb up his throat as he watches Todoroki not discretely move his thumb along the other's deltoid.

Katsuki closes his eyes tight and clenches his jaw. He focuses on his breathing, everything buzzing in the background, all voices just a steady stream of nothing until Aizawa's comes through, loud and clear.

"… So you don't recall ever meeting him." Aizawa keeps his one eye narrowed on the teenagers, taking a sip of his *own* milk tea. Even in casual dress, Aizawa looks ominous, and the brightly colored tapioca drink is making him stand even more.

The one who is thirsty for Deku laughs slightly. "Oh, no, I think we'd remember meeting someone like him!"

"… And he doesn't remind you at all of the guy that kidnapped you." Katsuki snaps at them, harsh tone making both girls freeze. They glance at one another, wide eyed, before they swallow and tilt

their heads.

"…We didn't hear his voice or see him…. Wait, do you guys think it was him?"

Aizawa turns to Katsuki expectantly, and Katsuki just shrugs. Not having his own drink to distract from the conversation, he picks at his nails.

He doesn't *think,* he *knows* it was him. He's the *only* one that knows it was him, apparently. But not only do they barely remember the kidnapping incident, Hikari shows no signs at all of remembering – either physically or mentally - owning Regenerate. Even so, Katsuki feels a weird tingle in his skin at their proximity – like something magnetic in his bloodstream is drawn towards the twin. He'd brush it off, except it's the way he's been able to tell the two apart – and has been right approximately 100% of the time.

Its fucking unnerving. Katsuki rubs the spot where the goosebumps won't seem to go away, glaring at the ground.

"Right. Well, thank you for your time." Aizawa stands from his seat across from the girls, nudging his head at Katsuki. Katsuki stands up out of the metallic chair, which scrapes loudly against concrete with his urgency, and bows shallowly to the two girls, ignoring the way the two start to giggle as him and his homeroom teacher make it out the gate and back out onto the road.

"Well. That was a bust." Aizawa states unhelpfully, and Katsuki groans in response.

"None of them seem to know *shit.* There's no way they're actually going to be helpful."

"On the other hand, they also won't be able to testify against Midoriya either, so this could be a blessing in disguise."

Katsuki frowns. Unable to provide the data regarding the twins to Deku's attorney – considering they were illegally obtained from the Tokyo Police Department server – Katsuki had the bright idea to *talk* to them and see if they remember anything. But of course they don't, because the fucker had a *forgetting* Quirk, so each pair of targeted twins has so far done nothing but look at him blankly and give him *nothing.*

Which is fine and all, for the three pairs that held Deku's placeholder quirks.

Less fine for Aoto and Otoa, who woke up after their school trip Quirkless with no memory of what happened to them.

"This is fucking pointless. We're running out of time." Katsuki knows he doesn't need to tell Aizawa that, but he chooses to anyway. He has to say something, because he's going to vibrate out of his fucking *skin.* It's like the last four years all over again – but this time, his incompetence is going to get Deku, the very alive Deku, imprisoned or killed. So Katsuki's nails are bitten down to the skin, nail beds bleeding, mouth a constant tingle from accidentally ingesting too much nitroglycerin.

All the statements from their former teachers, classmates, the kids that Deku rescued, every sob story they're going to try to pull out account for who Deku *was* – but the past four years remain an empty black hole that the Hero Commission will surely fill with fake horror stories of recklessness, selfishness and vigilantism.

It would be a lot easier to find some kind of truth if anyone that interacted with the fucker remembered anything about him. And Katsuki's the only person can provide an alibi for, what?

Maybe three nights? And also provide a very clear implication in a minimum of two crimes?

He did this on purpose, Katsuki's brain supplies as an explanation, and just because its true doesn't mean he wants to fucking hear it.

Of course Izuku Midoriya is the most insufferable criminal on the goddamn planet.

Katsuki doesn't question himself twice as he follows Aizawa to the mans' awful apartment. The mere thought of going to his place, of being alone with nothing to do and just wait for Deku to get torn apart on live television for the entire world to see makes his skin crawl. He has to keep busy. He has to do *something.* Even if its cooking his former homeroom teacher a simple meal as the man paces his apartment, on phone call after phone call. Whatever strings the man has, he's been pulling them, and Katsuki absolutely doesn't feel a sliver of gratitude or admiration or any of those cheesy-ass feelings as he listens in the background.

They eat their meal in relative silence, both watching the clock until it hits 8pm – around 6am for Toshinori Yagi, who has been in New York for the last several days.

Katsuki, now walking cane-free, lets his teacher take the seat in front of the laptop, leaning himself against the creaking chair as the call comes through on schedule.

Yagi's eyes are a bit bloodshot, but he's wearing a wide smile, and Katsuki tampers down any sense of hope that he has blossoming in his heart.

"Tell us you found something," Katsuki orders the static image on the screen.

Aizawa grunts in agreement, casting Katsuki a glare. Yagi rubs his thin arm, glancing away from the screen, smile faltering slightly before coming right back. A habit of his Symbol of Peace days, Katsuki is sure, because there's nothing to be smiling about nowadays. Katsuki wishes he found the gesture irritating, but he doesn't. Just like when he was four, he finds himself comforted by that expression.

"The three survivors from the fire in Brooklyn listed in the article are… unfortunately no longer survivors." Yagi starts, eyebrows knitting together. "I've interviewed several additional individuals from the building and the woman who posted the photo you sent. They do corroborate your findings, but nothing additional, I'm afraid."

Katsuki feels his lips settling into the frown.

"So we've got nothing." Katsuki summarizes, but Yagi shakes his head, smile re-forming on his face.

"Now I didn't say that, Young Bakugou. I was able to use the description of the Quirk you sent me to follow a lead. Apparently, it fits the same Quirk description of a certain villain that was high on the FBI's Most Wanted List approximately two years ago. This is, of course, classified information, but it appears that he was captured in an unusual way. He was left in front of the FBI office, tied up and Quirkless."

Katsuki feels his chest concave. So it wasn't one of All for One's Quirk's. Deku took it from someone.

"…What did he do?" Katsuki finds himself asking, not sure if he's referring to the villain or to Deku himself.

“He was a serial rapist turned murderer. Targeted young sex workers in New York. Had been active since he was a teenager – since none of his victims remembered him or remembered being attacked, people would wake up to find themselves assaulted. He went uncaught for a long time, as no one believed that these individuals were hurt – just that they may have drank too much or did too many drugs and were responsible. But when people started going missing, the case was taken more seriously.”

Katsuki raises his eyebrows. Yeah. That’s a perfect Quirk for a goddamn villain. No one can catch you if no one remembers you. The fucker deserved to die, rather than just get his Quirk stolen.

“The vigilante you described in New York – there were several reported sightings of them prior to the arrest of this individual. Then, they completely went off the grid. It seems very likely that Young Midoriya took this Quirk and used it as his primary method of disguise. After that, unfortunately I have not been able to track down any information on him.”

“… So how was this fucker arrested, if all of his victims didn’t remember who he was?” Katsuki crosses his arms. Sure, a random guy being dropped off Quirkless in front of the FBI building is great for showmanship, but not exactly an ‘innocent until proven guilty’ kind of process.

“Here is the part I’m sure you’ll be happy to hear about – while there does not appear to be a way to ‘reverse’ the Quirk, there *is* a way to make the individual access those repressed memories. The agent who interviewed the victims happened to have such a Quirk.”

“Can we stop beating around the fucking bush? Is this ‘agent’ going to help us or not?” Katsuki huffs out, his own heart beating a million miles a minute.

His own desire to know what he doesn’t remember has nothing to do with this. It doesn’t.

“Oh yes, he agreed to be a part of the investigation and testify in the trial, if need be. You should be very proud, Shota. He’s become quite a formidable young hero.”

Katsuki glances down at Aizawa’s hands, suddenly gripping against his desk so hard his knuckles turn white.

“This is ridiculous. Who the fuck is it?”

“Shinso Hitoshi. Your former classmate.” Aizawa says without looking at him, and Katsuki feels his world go white.

“…The same fucker who took Deku’s spot in the Hero Course after he disappeared.”

He doesn’t know why he says it out loud. Everyone on the call is very much aware of Shinso, of his ability, of his mentorship with Aizawa, and of course the eventual integration of the fucker into class 2A.

Outside his dry personality and creepy-ass Quirk, Katsuki couldn’t stomach him for that simple reason – *that he wasn’t Deku, but he was sitting in his chair, writing on his table, filling a void that should never have been made in the first place* – and avoided him like the plague. Not that it mattered. After two years, just like half of the rest of the class, the troll-doll looking motherfucker went to work overseas. The details of his assignment would probably land on the top of Katsuki’s ‘I don’t give a fuck’ list, until now.

“I believe he’s flying out tonight. He should be landing tomorrow afternoon. He relayed that he’ll be letting you know as soon as everything is confirmed.” Yagi looks proud of himself, and Katsuki can’t fucking blame him.

This is big. If they can access the memories of the people that ‘Zero’ interacted with, this whole thing could start to make some semblance of sense.

“When the hell are *you* flying out, then?”

“…I am not.”

“What.” Katsuki and Aizawa speak simultaneously. Yagi has the gal to look sheepish before his eyes focus back on the screen.

“I’m… on to something incredibly important. I’ll need to… travel to several more places to confirm my theory. To Amsterdam, Moscow, Reykjavic and Bangkok.”

“… There’s two days until the trial. This really a good time to be going on a fucking world tour?” Katsuki bites out at Yagi.

“I don’t want to say anything regarding this yet, but I’m confident that this might… make all the difference in this trial. Young Midoriya is…” The soft smile that Yagi sports as he says his name makes Katsuki feel like he swallowed a big ball of yarn.

“He’s a remarkable young man. I never even consider that one could – well. I won’t make assumptions until I have more information. Please trust me on this.”

What else can they do?

They have to wait for Shinso. They have to trust that Yagi finds the answer he’s looking for. As soon as Shinso is here, Katsuki needs to gather the twins – at least the three pairs that were given Quirks and Aoto and Otao. They’re on a time crunch – two days until the trial, less than a day by the time the bleary-eyed fucker gets here, but it should give them something. It has to

“FBI. Impressive.” Aizawa smirks to himself, and Katsuki rolls his eyes.

“What, he doesn’t tell you shit?”

“…Underground heroes are not to report on their assignments. I’ve heard through the grapevine that several of our former students are now employed by them. I’m sure you remember Hagakure and Monoma. I believe Mirio is also a part of the task force. I do wonder if any of them have held some contact with Midoriya as the vigilante…”

Katsuki furrows his eyebrows. He hasn’t been following the careers of most of his former classmates, but even he has to admit that he hasn’t seen any of their names in the media in several years now. Being deep underground is a good reason for that. And who would know more about someone who doesn’t want to be seen or heard than those three?

“I’ll… try to get in touch with them. I’ll need you to talk to the rest of the twins. We’ll need to interview them prior to recommending their involvement in the trial.”

“Right.”

“They’ll be announcing the nine judges tomorrow.” Aizawa narrows his eyes somewhere behind Katsuki. “Many of the active heroes in Japan know of or have worked with Midoriya. Although its only two of the nine, we might have an advantage.”

“Hm.” Katsuki grunts out.

“…I’ll have to ask you to take charge of Shinso when he arrives.”

Katsuki nods before he turns sharply to his former teacher. “Wait, haah? “

“I still have things to take care of prior to the trial. Besides – I live *here.* You have two bedrooms.”

“What? Fuck that! He’s staying at a hotel!”

“Which is an excellent place to be ambushed or to give away our plan to the Hero Commission.”

“Goddamnit.”

Katsuki grumbles to himself on the train, averting his eyes from that same clip, playing over and over again on every goddamn screen like the universe is doing it just to torture Katsuki specifically.

‘Now, it seems fairly unusual that two former classmates of Izuku Midoriya are in charge of guarding him throughout the process. Are there any concerns regarding Fusion and Creati being tasked with responsibility for this criminal?’

‘There’s been significant speculation regarding the decision to make these young heroes in charge of guarding Izuku Midoriya. His relationship with Fusion specifically seems to go back to early high school – sources report that they were close friends prior to Izuku Midoriya’s disappearance four years ago.’

Katsuki gnashes his teeth, eyes firmly set on wall in front of him as the others on the subway turn towards the television. The sounds are familiar – the cheering of the crowds, the flashes of greens and blues and reds, the sonic boom and subsequent crashing sound of thousands of pounds of concrete disintegrating. He doesn’t need videos of something he watched happen in real time, but the context of it is nauseating all the same.

‘An incredibly show of power!’ The TV personality truly seems awed at the performance before clearing his throat, switching back to his serious demeanor. *‘All this said, Creati and Fusion are the shining stars of Endeavor Agency, which remains the contracted agency with the Tokyo Police Department because of their service to the community and their ability to uphold the Hero Commission’s laws and regulations. Considering that their former classmate has made a mockery of the laws these two wholeheartedly uphold, I have no doubt they will take their task very seriously and will not let emotion get in the way of duty.’*

Katsuki rolls his eyes, shoving headphones in his ears, turning up the music so loud it physically hurts.

He checks in with the hospital staff and makes his way to the Burn Ward, receiving a harsh glare from the same charge nurse that kicked him out just a few days earlier.

But even as he slides the door open to Kirishima’s room, he’s assaulted with the same news, the same clip, the arrest photos of an exhausted, miserable looking Izuku Midoriya, holding up his prisoner number with his single hand.

“Why are you watching this crap?”

“Bakubro!” Kirishima grins as he turns to him, waving the other forward. Katsuki grunts in response, making himself comfortable in the chair next to the other’s bed. He rubs his thigh, pain flaring.

“Where’s your cane?” Kirishima asks, eyes shooting between Katsuki’s hand on his own thigh and his eyes.

“I don’t need that shit anymore.” Katsuki grumbles back. He’s maybe a little slower, and long distances are painful, but the sooner he can get away from the handicap, the sooner he can get back to work. This inactivity is making him feel insane. Not being able to blow something or someone up is making him feel like he’s about to crawl out of his own skin.

“I’ve never really been on this side of a trial before,” Kirishima admits, rubbing at the puckering scarring on his shoulder. “’M kinda nervous. Silver linings though, right?” Kirishima’s eyes brighten as he pats Katsuki’s knee.

“Midoriya’s alive, and you’re talking to me again!”

Katsuki feels the blush flare harshly on his cheeks and he glances away.

“What the hell you going on about?”

“Dude.” Kirishima’s face gets serious, and he removes his hand. “I’ve barely seen you since Midoriya disappeared. No matter what I did, I felt like… you didn’t care about me anymore. Like you didn’t care about any of us. And I blamed myself, ya know? That I couldn’t get through to you. Everyone expected me to be able to. I feel like everyone thought I failed you. But I learned that you can’t always save people – sometimes they have to save themselves. Metaphorically, obviously. I still saved you literally.” Kirishima grins, flexing his disgustingly scarred back, and Katsuki huff out a little laugh against his permission.

“…You sound like you’ve been to fucking therapy.”

“…Wait, you *haven’t?* Its mandatory for all active duty Heroes in the ‘States. I thought it was stupid at first but I guess I’ve been carrying some heavy stuff around the past few years! With the USJ and the training camp and your kidnapping and Camino Ward and Eri and the war and Midnight and Midoriya going missing and you shutting down on all of us, my head was seriously screwed up!”

Katsuki stares at the other, tongue tied. Laid out like that, like a little paper chain of disasters, each more fucked up that the last, it seems almost trivial. One trauma after another, folding in to make one seriously fucked up human being.

It’s not like he wasn’t offered therapy. After being kidnapped, he was. After Deku disappeared a fucking counselor came to their school every day with open office hours for ‘grief counseling.’ More so when he was announced as ‘dead.’ But Katsuki had never set a single fucking foot in that room.

“Maybe after this is all over,” Katsuki finally concedes. The way his words brighten Kirishima’s face makes Katsuki nearly feel bad about lying to him. *Not like he’ll be here to know either way,* Katsuki tells himself.

The door slides open, making Katsuki and Kirishima both turn their heads.

“Oh! Mr. Bakugou, you’re here as well! Excellent.” The nurse’s dry voice makes Katsuki bristle slightly. He scoots back in his chair as she approaches, giving her ample room to work.

“I actually brought something for you leaving the hospital! Since it’s a high infection risk for your wounds, we designed this jacket – “ the nurse proudly hands over a see-through, plastic-wrap appearing abomination.

“Please! Put it on!” she squeals, bouncing on her heels. Katsuki and Kirishima exchange a look before Kirishima reaches out to it tentatively, grimacing at the plastic crinkling. With some effort, the see-through jacket sticks to his tender skin like someone rolled him up in saran wrap.

“It’s perfect! You can wear your regular clothes over this and it should protect the wound! Good luck!” she smiles again and bows, making her way out of the room.

Katsuki places a hand over his mouth.

“I feel like leftovers,” Kirishima bemoans, and Katsuki can’t help himself. He actually laughs, enough that the wound in his stomach starts to ache, and then he keeps laughing as his former classmate joins.

Katsuki’s phone vibrates and, against his better judgement, he wrangles it out of his pocket.

[Unknown Number] 1522 – Aizawa-sensei gave me your number.

[Unknown Number] 1523 – Sounds like you’re going to be my host over these next few days.

[Unknown Number] 1524 – I’m arriving in Japan at the International Gate around 1400 tomorrow

[Unknown Number] 1525 – Kurasu coffee will help me be productive and cooperative

[Unknown Number] 1526 – as a hint

“This fucker has the *nerve – “* Katsuki grips his phone hard, thumbs digging into the glass screen. If he could strangle someone through text –

“Who is it?” Kirishima asks, leaning forward, trying to get a glimpse at Katsuki’s phone.

“Troll-Hair.” Katsuki twists his wrist in exasperation as Kirishima gives him a quizzical look. “Shinso. I’m fucking babysitting him, apparently. He’s gonna be part of the trial.”

“No way!” Kirishima grins his shark-toothed grin. “This trial is going to be like a mini-class reunion!”

Katsuki gives him a glare. It’s such a ridiculous thing to say, and yet, somewhat true. It’s probably going to be the first time so many of their classmates are in one room in fuck knows how long. Certainly not Katsuki.

[Me] 1530 – Go fuck yourself.

[Me] 1531 – I’ll pick you up tomorrow

Well, now he has to go to the supermarket. Fuck this, honestly. Katsuki hasn't been a host to anyone or anything in four goddamn years, and the thought of this dude sleeping in his apartment gives Katsuki the heebie-jeebies.

"…Right. I need to go do some shit. … See you at the trial?"

"It's a date!" Kirishima grins. He takes his eyes off Katsuki, trying to peal the plastic wrap off his torso unsuccessfully with his hands as Katsuki exits.

So here he is. Like some goddamn fool, standing at the greeting gate of International Arrivals. There's groups of people with signs, flowers, balloons. Bright eyed kids hopping up and down, lovelorn adults glancing around anxiously at each and every body pouring out from the escalator, and Katsuki, secretly hoping the person he's supposed to greet got lost and isn't going to show up at all.

Katsuki nearly misses him. In all fairness, he's probably never seen the fucker out of his U.A. uniform or his hero costume, and with his characteristic troll-doll purple hair hidden under a black beanie and in a casual black bomber jacket and black jeans, he looks like any other fucking college student. But those dark circles under his eyes are like fucking high-beams (or the opposite of?) and Katsuki approaches him, choosing to stand directly in front of him rather than reach out a hand, or call to him, or do anything that a normal person might.

"Troll-Hair." Katsuki bites out, crossing his arms, eyes narrowing in on his.

"Temper-Tantrum," Shinso responds just as easily, keeping his hands planted firmly in his pockets.

When two grown men standing in front of each other, glaring into each other's eyes from less than one foot away starts to border on homoerotic, Katsuki breaks the staring contest and grabs the other's rolley bag and starts to walk in the direction of the exit.

"Such a gentleman." Shinshou quips, because of course he does, and Katsuki imagines strangling the guy with his own white scarf instead of doing it in the physical realm. He walks ahead of the other, making sure he's taking faster steps every time the other's longer stride tries to catch up to him. When they finally get to his parking space, Katsuki throws the trunk open to the rental car with so much force the vehicle creaks, as if deciding whether to break off the hinges just to make Katsuki's day just a little bit worse. It doesn't break, so Katsuki tosses the bag inside the trunk and sits in the front seat, hands on the steering wheel.

"You know how to drive? Hot." Shinso says as he sits in the passenger seat, poking and prodding at the rental like he's never seen a fucking car before.

"Can you shut the fuck up?" Katsuki grits out before he sighs, pulling out of his spot and focusing in on the road. "We're gonna be going all over the fucking city today, and I'm not sitting around on the train making nice with you. This is a fucking job, got it? I'm not gonna be your pal."

Shinso snorts out a laugh, which isn't exactly the response Katsuki was expecting.

"I have no intentions of being your *pal.* I'm here for Midoriya and as a favor to All Might. I'm technically not supposed to be here at *all*."

Katsuki glances at the other as he stares out the window. His eyes don't give away anything at the sight of Tokyo. Same tired glare, same hunched demeanor.

"What's that supposed to mean?"

“I’m FBI. Off the grid. I technically don’t exist. My boss finds out I’m here, I’m definitely fired.”

FBI. Right. Because Shinso was the one that interviewed the victims of the original owner of the forgetting Quirk.

“… All M- Yagi said that you’ve encountered the forgetting Quirk before.”

“I have.” Shinso voice grows darker, more serious. “Midoriya taking the Quirk from that monster was a god-send. He’s a hero. He doesn’t belong in Tartarus. I’ll lose my job any day to prove that.”

Katsuki doesn’t say anything after that.

Shinso walks into Katsuki’s apartment like he owns the place, tossing his bag on the floor.

“Where’s your shower?” he asks, and Katsuki grimaces.

“You fuckin’ kidding me?”

“I just spent 14 hours on an airplane. Unless you want my body odor to be the ‘insult’ that breaks my Quirk’s effect, I’d give me 30 minutes.”

With great annoyance, Katsuki directs the other to his own bedroom, throwing him a fresh towel and busying himself in the kitchen, trying not to think of this stranger using his shit.

“Something smells amazing.” Hair down and still wet, in a simple sweatshirt and jeans, Shinso is nearly handsome, and Katsuki wants to punch himself in the face at that thought. Instead, he grabs a mug, pours the coffee out of his French press and thrusts it towards the other. He crosses his arms, tapping his foot impatiently against the kitchen tile as the bleary-eyed fucker smells the brew before taking a slow, slow, agonizingly slow sip of the coffee.

“Ah. Tastes like home. You’d really make a great house-husband, Bakugou.” Shinso smirks at Katsuki’s offended expression, leaning against the wall, continuing to sip and close his eyes in appreciation.

“Can you – goddamn it. How does it work? The forgetting Quirk?”

Shinso slurps just long enough to make Katsuki think quite seriously about murdering the man before he decides to answer.

“It’s called Forget-Me-Not. Its active at all times; it cannot be turned off. It’s a powerful Quirk that allows one to control the world’s perceptions of the owner; every time you interact with someone and regret it or don’t want the other to remember, the memory simply becomes disconnected from their cognition. If, however, you want someone to remember something, it becomes a stronger memory, with many axons connecting to it. The previous user described moments where his subconscious made his parents remember when he played well with other kids, but forget when he hit others or got in trouble. Thus, he grew up with a reputation for being kind, intelligent and exemplary. It’s one of the reasons he was so difficult to capture.”

Katsuki’s gut twists.

He remembers him. He can’t stop remembering him.

So it wasn’t the absence of shame that lead to him remembering his encounters with Zero? Zero actually *wanted* him to remember all of them? He wanted those memories so cemented in Katsuki’s

head that he can't sleep at night without feeling the other's lips against his skin?

There's something hopelessly cruel in that.

"…But he got careless. Started to want glory for his crimes. The women started to remember his face. And then, the bodies started piling up. I'm sure the police force came in contact with him many times, but – but in the end, it was Midoriya that brought him to justice."

"Did you know it was him?"

Shinshou shrugs. "I thought it was Shigaraki at first. But it didn't fit his M.O. So the only other person with a power even remotely similar was… well."

"Yeah." Katsuki swallows. "So. How do you get them to remember?"

"I use my Quirk on them. When they're in the blank space my Mind Control induces, they're able to access repressed or hidden memories. Then, it's up to the person's subconsciousness to determine they want to integrate that memory into their living consciousness. Most of the women I interviewed chose to repress those memories."

The choice to forget. What an interesting concept. If Deku was here, he'd nerd out about all the amazing possibilities that Quirk could hold in the hands of a hero – helping individuals with PTSD, comforting traumatized children, infiltrate villain groups from the inside. But instead, this talent ended up inside a psychopath who used it to hurt as many people as possible.

"You ready to go yet?"

Shinso sets down his empty cup, rolling his shoulders.

"I'll need another cup of coffee."

Katsuki rolls his eyes. "You're in luck, then."

Granny Honoka's coffee shop is oddly quiet. The bell chimes pleasantly as the two enter the warm atmosphere, earning a quick glance from the two patrons scattered amongst the chairs. Katsuki finds his eyes drifting to that corner of the couch, half expecting the giant to be reading his English book there, sipping on his tea.

"Welcome to Honoka's Café, what can I get started for – oh." The twin's eyes widen in recognition as Katsuki lifts his head, hidden under the hood of a sweatshirt. Katsuki glances down – Aoto on the nametag – before meeting the other's eyes.

"Your brother here?"

Aoto audibly swallows before nodding.

"Anywhere we can talk privately?"

Aoto looks around the shop, the two customers seemingly entranced by whatever the hell they're doing. He nods again, and waves them over, directing all three of them to ascend up the creaky stairs. He knocks on the door across the hall from Granny's craft room.

“WHAT?” comes the other teenager’s harsh bark.

“Come on, Otoa, we have guests.”

“I TOLD you I don’t wanna see any – “ Otoa throws open the door, large headphones falling off his ears as his jaw drops. He stares at Katsuki for a beat too long, cheeks pinkening. He steps outside the room, closing the door behind him instantly, but not before Katsuki catches the definitely not officially sanctioned giant Dynamight poster above his bed.

“You – uh. Hi. Hello. What are you – who is – “

“We can talk in my room,” Aoto states, leading them next door. Aoto’s room is very sterile, bed well-made, not a single poster in his room. Aoto sits on the bed, Otoa joining him, Shinso making himself comfortable on the computer chair. Katsuki chooses to lean against the wall, crossing his arms.

“You two aren’t in school?” Katsuki asks, and Otoa seems tongue tied, so Aoto answers for the both of them.

“We’re taking a leave of absence since becoming Quirkless. They don’t exactly know what to do with us. We were just a few months off from graduation, too – “ Aoto laughs bitterly and Katsuki frowns.

“What about Eri-chan?” Shinso asks them, and all three heads swivel to them. Katsuki nearly forgot Shinso and Eri had a close relationship, considering the latter lived with Aizawa before she entered U.A. herself this past year.

“We tried… but she can’t. Its – it’s like it never existed in the first place.” Aoto stares at his hands and sighs. “The hardest part is we can’t – can’t talk to each other anymore. In our heads, I mean. It’s like we’ve been conjoined all our lives, and now we’ve been forcibly cut apart. It feels weird.”

“The *worst* part is not knowing how this happened!” Otoa snaps back at Aoto, and the twin clamps his mouth shut, shoulders drooping.

“What if I told you you can remember?”

Aoto and Otoa gape at Shinso like he’s some kind of angel, both terrifying and awe-inspiring.

“How?”

“Can you?”

“Is that even – “

Shinso lifts a hand as if to stop them. “I can access the memory. But it’s up to your own subconscious whether it wants to integrate the memory into your conscious mind. We can record it, though, in case your brains decide to leave it forgotten.”

“If we can remember – “

“If we can understand why this happened –“

The twins speak simultaneously, and Katsuki watches as the two smile each other for the first time since he’s been in this room.

“Bakugou, if you please – “ Shinso hands Katsuki his phone, open to the video function.

“I will ask you a question and access your subconscious. You have to allow me in. Is that okay?”

“Yes.”

The greens of the twin’s eyes dissipate into pale white, both shoulders drooping, hunching over in their beds. Katsuki barely remembers to press the ‘Record’ button as Shinso starts.

“How did you lose your Quirk?”

Aoto and Otoa speak simultaneously, word for word completely in sync, and its fucking weird as hell.

“The blonde-haired guy with the metal arm asked us whether he could take it to defeat the monster. We said yes. You don’t need a Quirk to be a hero.”

“Have you met this man before the island?” Shinso asks, and Katsuki feels his own heart race in his ears.

“Yes.” Otoa says, and Aoto follows. “He came to the coffee shop every day. He always ordered green tea and read a book in English. He never said much and seemed very polite.”

“Have you ever seen him talk to anyone in the coffee shop?”

“Yes. Mr. Bakugou started to spend time with him. They would argue sometimes. One time, they locked themselves in the bathroom for a really long time – “

“Ooookay, enough.” Katsuki’s cheeks pinken as he approaches the two boys, flicking their foreheads one by one. The greens of their eyes return, and they both look up at Katsuki, confusion painted on their faces.

“Well?” Katsuki gripes, discreetly erasing the end of the video.

“Huh? When are we gonna start?” Aoto asks, and Katsuki sighs. He shoves the phone to the two boys, and they watch the video, eyebrows shooting up.

“Oh shit.”

“We met the vigilante?!”

“And we agreed to give him our Quirk?!”

“…Whoa. We’re kind of awesome.”

“You don’t need a Quirk to be a hero? That’s a banger line.”

“Ok, we’re done here.” Katsuki sighs.

So. It works. Otoa and Aoto didn’t give them anything useful, except the fact that they consented to give their Quirk to the other.

Shinso sports the most shit-eating grin Katsuki’s ever seen as the two of them get into the front seat of the rental.

“You failed to mention that *you* had interacted with him when he still had Forget-Me-Not. Out of everyone, he wanted you to remember him, huh?”

“So what?” Katsuki spits back, feeling the heat climb up his neck.

“Makes sense. Who else would it be?” Shinso sighs, staring out the window, sounding nearly wistful.

“What the hell is that supposed mean?”

“Nothing at all,” Shinso finishes. “Where we going next?”

“Kanagawa.”

Katsuki and Shinso loiter outside the high school as the final bell rings. The twins notice them before he notices the twins, and Hikari and Senko are waving goodbye to their friends, rushing over to Katsuki and Shinso like the four of them long lost friends.

“Thank you for the milk tea the other day, Mr. Dynamight!”

“None of our friends believe that you took us out for drinks!”

“But then we remind them that you rescued us from being kidnapped!”

The twins continue to chatter, and Katsuki rubs the bridge of his nose, feeling rather than seeing the smug aura of Shinso’s irritating grin next to him.

“Look, I gotta ask you some questions about that again.”

“Again?” Hikari and Senko exchange a glance, and Shinso leans forward.

“With my help. I’ve got a special power that helps people access memories. What do you two think?”

Hikari’s eyebrows shoot up, but Senko looks uncomfortable.

“I’m not sure I… want to remember the kidnapping. What if something happened to us before we woke up in that warehouse?”

“Then we’ll deal with it together!” Hikari insists. Her sister nods tentatively.

“Anywhere we can talk?”

The four of them walk to the empty track field, clambering up the metallic bleachers.

Shinso explains the way his quirk works, and Katsuki tries to swallow down his trepidation.

“You two ready?”

“Yes.”

Their dark eyes go blank.

“Do you know who kidnapped you?”

“The vigilante on the news. Izuku Midoriya.” The twins respond instantly, and Shinso glances over to Katsuki as if searching for surprise in the other’s face. Katsuki keeps himself carefully neutral.

“How do you know?”

“He asked us. He said there was a villain targeting twins and the others he asked refused. We agreed.”

“…Why?” It’s not a structured question, not the careful interrogating one that Shinso has asked other times. This one is sincerely confused.

“Because if we can do something to help protect others, why wouldn’t we? Eighteen pairs of twins had been knocked out and their blood stolen. We didn’t know what the villain was going to do with that blood, but the vigilante seemed to know and wanted to make whatever was happening stop. We just wanted to help.”

“…Do you remember who took your blood?”

“The person looked like our friend. But there was something wrong with her eyes. They were vertical and yellow, like a snake. And then, when we woke up, we were alone.”

A chill ascends up Katsuki’s spine. He should have known.

“Ask them about Regenerate.” Katsuki whispers, and Shinso glances to him.

“What do you know about Regenerate?”

“The vigilante gave it to me. He asked me if I would hold it, and I said I would. He said he might take it back. I felt it when he did. It was shortly before that explosion. I hope it helped him win.” Hikari smiles brightly, and Katsuki feels his skin prickle again.

“Why did you trust him?” Shinso asks.

“He just… seemed like an honest person.”

“You have to believe in people sometimes. Even if it’s scary,” the hypnotized Senko adds, and Katsuki shakes his head. Even their subconscious selves are full of righteous bullshit. The naivety of childhood. No wonder Deku was able to recruit them.

“You have more questions?” Shinso turns to Katsuki, and Katsuki shakes his head. He taps both girls on their legs, and they shake their heads, eyes turning back to normal.

“…Huh.”

“Do you… remember that?” Senko asks her sister.

“Like a dream. Its fuzzy, but – we met him. Izuku Midoriya. The vigilante on TV.”

“We helped him.”

“Does that make us criminals?”

Both girls give a panicked look to Katsuki, who simply shakes his head.

“Fuck no. You two little shits are heroes.” He ruffles their hair, the bob-headed girls staring up at him as Katsuki directs Shinso down the bleachers, leaving the flabbergasted girls to sit there and stew on their new memories.

“Huh.”

“What?”

“He was storing Quirks in twins?”

Katsuki sighs.

“It’s complicated. So twins actually share the same Quirk – “

It doesn’t get less insane every time Katsuki tries to explain it, but Shinso listens anyway without interruption, which is a blessing of its own.

By the time Katsuki pulls up to his apartment, its evening and both of them are carrying a thousand pounds of exhaustion on their shoulders. Shinso had even stopped making comments, keeping his gaze fixed out the window, watching the streetlights pass him by, head bobbing every few minutes as his eyes drift closed. Katsuki’s body is in the same place, but his mind is racing. Zero used the twins – but with their consent and understanding. He asked for help and received it.

There was nothing particularly special about the three pairs of twins in Nakano, or Kanagawa, or even the Shiryoku twins in Kanagawa. Each pair of twins was able to house the Quirks; but it’s those three that agreed to do it.

Katsuki’s phone vibrates and he takes it out mindlessly, tossing a water to Shinso, who has already made himself at home on Katsuki’s couch, eyes closed. Despite that, he still catches the water bottle without so much as cracking open an eye.

[Aizawa] 1956 – They’re about to announce the judges. Turn on your TV

[Aizawa] 1957 – Also, call me after. We need to talk about some things. I also need to hear how things went with you and Shinso today.

“Turn on the TV,” Katsuki orders the other, and Shinso complies without complaint.

‘…The case of the century, Izuku Midoriya vs Hero Commission of Japan, is set to start at 9am tomorrow. As always, this case is open to civilians, with about 50 seats present in the judge’s chamber available first-come, first-serve. There are already crowds lining up outside to have an opportunity to watch history unfold…’

‘Yes, and the entire trial will be televised so no citizens are deprived of watching justice in action. That said – breaking news is in. The nine judges have been announced. As in all hero-related trials, two of the six civilian judges will be replaced with pro-heroes. The final judge’s panel with contain four civilians, two pro-heroes, two certified judges of the general courts and one Hero Commission appointed judge specializing in Hero Law.’

‘Majority rules in the final verdict, having to include at least one court-appointed judge.’

Katsuki’s butt hits the couch and he stares at the screen. He doesn’t know why he’s holding his breath. It doesn’t matter. They live in a country with 99.7% conviction rate. The hero-judges being in the same category as lay-judges means that even if they vehemently vote to protect Deku, their votes can easily be overturned.

Photos start to flash across the screen. A headshot, full name, occupation and age. They stay on the screen for 30 seconds as the announcer reads the information aloud, and then the next goes on. Four

non-descript faces flash across the screen. Two serious looking judges. Katsuki could spit on the smug look on the commission-appointed judge in their headshot. And finally, the pro-hero judges -

A familiar face, dark skin, white hair and bunny ears covers the screen.

“Pro Hero Mirko, Usagiyama Rumi… “

The next picture has Katsuki nearly spitting out his water at the screen.

“Pro Hero Chargebolt, Kaminari Denki.”

“Fuckin’ Doofus?! Is one of the judges? Oh my god. Deku’s so fucked.” Katsuki yells at the TV, Shinso just chuckling behind him, using his hand to cover his ridiculous smile.

“The fuck you laughing for? What the hell?”

“He’s smarter than you give him credit for,” Shinso says in his stupid cryptic way, and Katsuki sits right back down, crossing his arms.

‘Any commentary regarding the panel?’

‘Yes, of course. As everyone is familiar, majority rules under each section of judges. All Judges are a part of the indictment process and must agree on the sentence. I am concerned that one of Izuku Midoriya’s former classmates – a twenty year old rookie – has been placed on the judge panel. However, we must trust in the process.’

“Trust in the process my entire ass.” Katsuki turns the TV off with a flourish, melting into the couch. It could be worse, he supposes. Kaminari is certainly a Deku sympathizer; but that’s not what he’s worried about. These sneaky fucking commission judges have ways of getting into people’s heads, and if anyone’s gonna get tricked to voting against his own friend, it would definitely be Electric Dumbass.

“…Well. We should get ready for bed. Early morning.” Shinso says, like he sleeps at night.

For the first time, Katsuki becomes acutely aware of how close they’re sitting next to each other on his couch. Both their heads are leaned back against the head cushions, and Katsuki turns his head towards the other, surprised to find those tired purple eyes already fixed on him.

“… Hey.” Katsuki swallows the knot in his throat. He doesn’t know why his heart starts racing even thinking about asking for this, but it’s been on his mind all day, and it might just drive him insane if he doesn’t *know.* It doesn’t fucking help that Shinso used that mint-shampoo, the fucker, and he smells so much like Deku it makes Katsuki’s head spin.

“Hm?”

“Can you use it on me?”

Shinso’s eyes widen slightly.

“My Mind Control?”

“Yeah.” Katsuki feels choked up, and Shinso gives him a curious look.

“… You think there’s things he didn’t want you to remember?”

“Yeah. I know there are.” Katsuki shudders at the insistent image of Zero shoving the barrel of his gun into his mouth.

“There are some things we’re better off not remembering.”

Katsuki bristles. This cryptic-ass mother*fucker*.

“What the hell does that mean?”

Shinso pauses, eyes becoming less focused, like he’s somewhere else entirely.

“… Some of the people I’ve met would have been better off if they didn’t remember. The things I made them re-live –“ Shinso’s mouth fixes in a frown, eyes glistening with an emotion Katsuki doesn’t fully understand.

“And if Midoriya didn’t want you to remember… Those memories might truly be terrible. Don’t you think we should trust him?”

Sure they should. Katsuki *does* trust him. Would trust him with his life. And has, many times.

But this is different.

And it’s not Shinso’s choice to make.

“I have to know.” Katsuki assures him, and Shinso sighs, glancing away.

“People have a higher chance of integrating the subconscious into the conscious when they’re sleeping. If you truly want to remember rather than just be told what happens like we did with the others, I’d recommend me awakening these memories while you’re asleep. Gives the brain time to process and connect events.”

“Like a dream?”

“…Yeah. A lucid one.” Shinso looks distant. “Where you remember and feel it all.”

Katsuki swallows. “Fine.”

“Is that what you want?”

“Yes.”

Katsuki’s brain goes still. His body weakens. And then there’s nothing but static. Somewhere, in the background, he can comprehend someone’s voice, high and warbling, like spoken through water.

“Go to sleep and remember everything that Izuku Midoriya wanted you to forget.”

Katsuki wakes up in his bed in a cold sweat. He’s naked for some fucking reason, and the room reeks of sex and humidity. He has no idea what time it is, but the place is pitch black – even the dull blue light from the television that usually filters through the bottom of his door are gone.

He feels around the sheets – Zero was just here. How did he fall asleep with a stranger in his bed? He must be more tired than he thought. He leans back, closing his eyes again. Zero probably dipped, as he often does. Last night was good, though. He can't explain why his body seems to respond so much to the other. Zero's awkward and clearly inexperienced, but something about the way he acts all shy makes Katsuki's blood boil in all the best ways. Genuine attraction seems to make sex better. Who would have thought.

Katsuki searches his bed, finding his underwear tossed under his pillow. He pulls it on, turning in his bed and closing his eyes. He's just about to doze off again, sore and exhausted and satisfied, when he hears something.

The slight creak, one that Katsuki can't be completely sure he's heard, still puts Katsuki's brain on overdrive. His senses sharpen suddenly – even in the pitch darkness, he can suddenly see, every sensation on his skin heightened, aware of the exact position of his body in this space, hearing astute. He puts his feet down on the floor, tiptoeing through his apartment, using fingertips again walls and furniture to guide him. He's sweating potent nitroglycerin – a subconscious decision to put whoever is in his apartment out quickly.

The sounds have stopped. Katsuki takes a quick look around. There's streetlights outside his living room window. Its dark outside, but not pitch black; a hint of the rising sun somewhere deep below the horizon. Even so, his apartment itself is eerily lightless. He doesn't notice it normally, but the absence of it is jarring – no time from the microwave or the oven, no tiny glowing light on his refrigerator telling him he needs to replace his filter, no annoying flickering of his WiFi router. He must have lost electricity. Katsuki touches the light switch as he exits his bedroom, but hesitates – the sound of flipping the little plastic switch is likely enough to tip off whoever is currently in his apartment that he's on to them. So he doesn't.

The study door is open.

He doesn't need to see it to know it.

Katsuki approaches it, quiet and agile. He knows where every creaky floorboard is, knows every corner of his furniture, knows every rug like his life depends on it, because it does.

Katsuki pauses at the entrance to the study.

He doesn't know why he's not panicking. Why he's not rushing the other, why he's not tackling him onto the floor, why he's not beating the shit out of him. He doesn't know. He just stands there, silently, and watches the other man.

He recognizes the silhouette instantly. There's no one else it could be. It's Zero. He's holding a tiny flashlight between his teeth, directed towards the wall, illuminating his chin and upper chest in a pale blue light. He's still shirtless, wearing nothing but boxers.

Katsuki's body tells him to pounce. The fucker's got broken ribs and this shitty dysfunctional arm, he's mostly naked and clearly can't hear him. He'd be easy to take down. But curiosity gets the better of him. Katsuki can't help himself. The way Zero is behaving doesn't… really fit with the image of a manipulative theif. Instead, Katsuki feels like he's intruding on some private moment, something he's not meant to see – which makes no goddamn sense, because this is his study, his wall, his *secret*.

The man who is supposedly targeting Shigaraki is not looking at the wall featuring Shigaraki. Instead, he's standing in front of the wall dedicated to finding Deku. He stands in front of it, statue still, heavy breathing the only sound in the room. Katsuki holds his breath as he watches the other lift his organic

hand towards a picture of Deku – his flight-or-fight reflexes beg him to dart forward, but something else in his mind tells him to keep watching – and trace his fingertips gently, oh so gently, against the photograph.

Against Deku's face. When the fingertips finally find Deku's right arm – covered with a compression sleeve, as it often was back then, his scarred hand holding on to his ice cream cone, Katsuki hears it. The sharp intake of air, the shake of the other's shoulders, and something that distinctly sounds like a sob.

Katsuki's brain is on overdrive instantly.

Why? Why is he reacting to seeing pictures of Deku like this? Did he know him? Have they met? Has he encountered him on his search for Shigaraki? Why is this giant trembling like a leaf in front of pictures of a teenage boy who has been presumed dead for over two years?

Katsuki has to know.

"Did you know him?"

Zero instantly drops the flashlight from his mouth, the thing clattering to the ground. It spins, turning towards Zero. The shadows illuminate his shocked face – the red-rimmed eyes, the tell-tale track of tears. Even the hand that's covering his mouth, poorly trying to prevent him from making any noise, is shaking.

"K – Kat – I'm – I can – I can explain – " Zero says breathlessly, not sounding at all like his usual aloof, mysterious self. He sounds like a terrified kid, like he was just caught stealing money out of his mom's purse.

"I'm fucking sure you can't. Talk, because I'm this close to beating the shit out of you and putting you outside so your blood freezes you to the sidewalk." Katsuki's voice comes out cool, confident, collected, not giving away the sheer degree of panic escalating through his psyche.

"You break into my study," Katsuki says, voice raising, taking a step forward. "You take out my electricity," that one's just a guess, but the way Zero's eyes widen ever-so-slightly is enough of an answer for Katsuki. "You steal my research. Haah?"

"Katsuki – "

"Don't fucking 'Katsuki!' me! What the fuck, Zero?"

"I – I didn't – I was looking for things about Shigaraki. I didn't know – "

"You didn't think to fucking ask me? I helped you, I lied to the proes for you, and you think I wouldn't share my fucking research with you?"

"…I don't know. I don't know! I'm just – " He hangs his head down, sighing. Katsuki, for some reason, doesn't lurch forward and pummel him where he stands. "I've been lying and hiding and stealing for such a long time – this is the first time – urgh. I'm sorry."

Katsuki's heart lurches forward at the word. Sorry.

"How am I supposed to trust you if you can't trust me?" Katsuki asks, and it's a weird thing to say to a complete stranger that just broke into his most precious and most protected part of his life, but he says it anyway.

“I *do* trust you. But you shouldn’t trust *me.* I’m not – I *told* you I’m lying to you. Why do you – “

“So that was your plan. You wanted to steal from me and then cut me off.”

“I can’t! I can’t, Katsuki! This partnership doesn’t work for me! I – its making me so – I don’t – “ Zero turns towards the Deku wall, pointing to it like it makes any sense. “I hate lying to you. I hate it.”

“So don’t lie to me.”

“I *can’t – “*

“Don’t lie to me and tell me why you were looking at him like that. Do you know him? Have you met him?”

The little flashlight on the ground flickers, making Zero’s terrified expression even more frightened appearing.

The flashlight suddenly flickers off, leaving both bodies entrenched in pure darkness. Only deep breathing breaks up the silence between them.

“Yes. I know him.” Zero’s voice comes out strangled, barely a whisper, and Katsuki’s has to hold everything in him together in an effort not to collapse to his knees.

“…What. What? Where is he, Zero? How do you – where –“ Katsuki lurches to where the other is, placing his hands on his shoulders, shaking the other softly. Zero shakes under his hold, chest heaving.

“…Why are you looking for him?” The incredulous sound of Zero’s voice makes Katsuki’s head spin.

“The fuck you mean ‘why?’ He’s missing. I’m going to find him.”

“…How do you know he’s not dead?”

“I just *know.* I can’t fucking explain it! Everyone always wants me to explain it – and it’s not fucking guilt, it’s not pity, its not some psychological bullshit! I just know. How the fuck do you know you still have your kidneys, or your lungs, or your fucking liver? You can’t see them, so how do you know, huh? That’s how stupid that question is.”

Katsuki takes a breath.

“If he was gone, I’d *know*. Besides, I told him. If he dies, I’ll kill him. He’s not going anywhere unless I’m there with him – blaze of glory and all that shit. He doesn’t die unless I die too or I’m doing the killin’. That’s final. This disappearing, off-screen death isn’t suitable for a main character like him.”

“…What is he to you?”

It’s a weird question. It’s a question that Katsuki has never been asked. It’s a question he doesn’t know how to answer. And why the fuck Zero sounds so breathless, he also doesn’t know. But in the darkness, for some reason, Katsuki feels himself answer.

Katsuki’s hands slide down his shoulders, and he finds himself pulling closer, closer to the other man’s body heat, the chill from the outside world closing in on him.

"…He's a shitty nerd." Katsuki whispers, closing his eyes as he leans an ear against the other's chest. Zero's heart is beating so quickly, loud and rapid, pulsing against his ear. He swears that heart is trying to say something to him, trying to speak in some kind of Morse code.

"He's a self-righteous, pompous little asshole."

He can feel Zero's own arms slide down his back, the sound against his ear and each touch a symphony to a song he doesn't understand.

"He never takes himself into account. He's reckless and selfless. He'd risk his life at any given opportunity – because he never understood how special he is."

The heaving chest Katsuki rests his head on stops suddenly, taking a few seconds to shudder through a wet breath.

"But he *is* special. I hated that about him. How he brightened every room he walked into. How he kept working and fighting despite everything in the world working against him. I hated his shitty notes and his shitty delusional hero worship and his shitty good grades and his shitty eyes that always looked right through me. I hated how he tried to save my life when I did nothing but make him – " Katsuki finds tears forming in his own eyes, and he doesn't know why. His fingers dig into the other's skin, and he can feel his body pressed tighter into his, bare chest against bare chest, hands wrapped around him like his body will anchor Zero to this world.

"I hated that he understood me better than I understood myself. I hated that he saw me, every part of me, and still wanted to be a part of my life. I hated that he made me want to be better. I hated that he inspired me. I hated that he changed my goddamn life, and I let him. Because I knew he was going to leave me. I *knew.* From the very first fucking moment we met; I just knew if I let myself get close to him, I'm going to regret it. I knew, and I still – "

Katsuki takes a deep breath as the words pour from his mouth, a dam that he didn't even know he was holding back opening into Zero's arms.

"… he was the best fucking part of my life, and I didn't even know it. S-so I'm going to find him. And make him answer for all the shit he did to me. Make him answer for making me depend on him, trust him, worry about him, and then *leaving* me."

Katsuki leans back, glancing up from the other's chest, feeling disheveled. Tears are running down his face without his permission, his whole body is shaking, and Zero is still holding him too closely. Too softly.

"So if you know where that motherfucker is, you tell me."

Zero hesitates, exhaling shaking breaths, an occasional whimper escaping trembling lips before he's composed enough to answer.

"I haven't seen him in two years. We… crossed paths in New York."

"Oh." Katsuki stomach sinks.

"He, um, mentioned you," Zero adds hastily, and his hands pull Katsuki even closer. "He… um. He said he missed you. At least… he was probably talking about you. He said he missed a…" Zero takes in a deep breath, pauses for too long, and then his voice whispers out the sweetest goddamn thing Katsuki's heard in his entire life. "…Kacchan."

The elation that passes through Katsuki is unlike anything he's ever felt before. It feels like a hit of stimulant to the brain, immediate release of dopamine - *he hasn't heard it in so long, so long, that god awful shitty nickname, Deku was thinking of him, he was thinking of him* – and Katsuki grabs the other's face in his hands and pushes their lips together.

It's all salt and puffy lips and he wraps his arms around the other's neck, pressing them closer together, closer and closer until he can feel their hearts racing in sync, bodies fitting together seamlessly. His lips are so goddamn soft, trembling and urgent, each brush of swollen lip against his a jolt to the warm pool in his stomach. It doesn't take long for Katsuki to swipe his tongue against the other's lip, to taste the salt and saliva collecting there, to taste the hot air of desperation as the other takes it as permission, as he slots their mouths together and runs his tongue against Katsuki's, each brush of muscle pure, delirious ecstasy.

Zero's arms find themselves beneath Katsuki's thighs, and Katsuki complies happily, wrapping his legs around Zero's large torso, feeling himself press up against the door in his study as they exchange body heat, Zero instinctively rolling his lips, his growing cock pushing impatiently up against Katsuki's. Katsuki refuses to break their lips apart, though, refuses to breathe or to think, because something in him is *alive,* pulsing and ecstatic and alive, and Deku thinks about him, misses him and the way Zero said his name, it nearly sounds like –

Katsuki's lightheaded, but he can vaguely comprehend that the two of them are moving through space, that somehow he's not tripping all over Katsuki's furniture, and he's being lowered onto the bed, Zero climbing after him. In the early light, he can nearly see the other's eyes – bloodshot and red-rimmed and hungry, and he leans down again to consume Katsuki whole, his mouth, his lips, his hands, his body all a dream Katsuki doesn't ever want to wake up from.

He must be delirious from the lack of oxygen when he makes the request. "Say it again," Katsuki whispers, voice hoarse like he's been chewing gravel, and the whole-body shudder of the man above him, the slight exhale, the sensation of his lips against his ear, *fuck* -

"Kacchan…" Zero whispers against his ear, and his entire body erupts with goosebumps. Zero kisses along his ear, mouth sucking wet, needy bruises into his neck, his organic hand trailing up and down his body like he's a blind man reading braille, like he's trying to understand something, like Katsuki's body holds the answer to some ancient mystery. Katsuki takes his hands to the other's hips, hurriedly pulling down his underwear, stoking at his engorged length, salivating at the groan the other lets out from his spot worshiping Katsuki's clavicle.

The desire to have this – to have him, to be filled with him, to be one with him, to destroy every inch of space that dares separate their bodies – is overwhelming, and Katsuki digs around blindly for a condom, ripping it open and rolling it over Zero's cock. He arches his back as the larger man moves on to his nipple, teeth grazing the bud, taking the opportunity to take off his own underwear. Unprompted, Zero's hand finds his cock, fingertips gingerly grazing it before taking him into a likely too-tight grip, pumping him. His own sweat is lubricating, but it's just on the side of dry and rough that it makes Katsuki oversensitive, wanting, desperate.

He grabs the lube from the bedside table, inelegantly squirting it along his length so that it gets all over Zero's fingers, hoping that the other man understands his not-so-subtle hint. He seems to, as he pumps a few more times before two fingers probe against his asshole. Still loose from just a few hours before, but raw and sensitive, he whines as the other introduces one finger, impatiently escalating to two, then three, arching them each time to tease his engorged prostate, and shit, he's going to cum on his fingers –

Zero finally pulls out, leaning back, positioning himself at Katsuki's entrance. He hesitates, hand still slowly pumping Katsuki's cock, before whatever battle he was having in his head is over, and he pushes forward. Katsuki grips his back, digging his nails in, biting into his lip from the stretch and the hypersensitivity, each nerve screaming out in pleasure, body wound up tight from being on the brink of orgasm. When he's fully sheathed, when he's bending over Katsuki, leaning away from his right side, clearly in pain but overwhelmed with something entirely different, Katsuki decides he's gone completely insane.

"… Call me that again."

"Oh god, Kacchan – " Zero crashes their lips together, rolling his hips, making Katsuki moan directly into his mouth. He keeps Katsuki pinned under him, so close its nearly suffocating, but he can't find it within himself to care. Each roll of the hips, each poorly suppressed gasp, the shaking of his bed, their sweat inmixing, and Katsuki's brain is empty all except a single thought.

He sounds just like him.

Lips against his, tongue entwined with his, slick chests sliding against one another, Zero's stomach rutting against Katsuki's cock, and it's so goddamn good, and he *sounds like him* -

"Shit – " Katsuki digs his nails into the other's back, so hard he feels the other wince as be cums over both their stomachs. Zero follows almost instantly, collapsing onto Katsuki's body like he's not nearly 300 pounds of pure muscle. He nuzzles his sweaty forehead into the crook of Katsuki's neck, and Katsuki laughs.

"You sound just like him. Isn't that fucked up?" Katsuki laughs, panting as he comes off the high of his own orgasm.

Zero stiffens instantly, moving off Katsuki as he pulls out. He doesn't say anything, just pulls his condom off and disappears. Katsuki's eyes are falling closed, so beautifully exhausted he can hardly process Zero cleaning off his stomach.

He talks again, almost like it's in a dream, his hushed voice sounding wrecked in all the worst ways. "I'm such an idiot. I don't know why I keep doing this. You remembering me is enough. It has to be enough. God, I can't – "

Katsuki's asleep by the time the other climbs out his window.

When Katsuki wakes up from the dream, he's hard as hell, flooded with shame and pretty sure Shinso might have had a point when he said some things are better off not remembered.

A shower, phone call, and digging his only suit out from the back of his closet later, Katsuki and Shinso meet the others outside the courtroom. Aizawa, with his hair tied back, seeming to be in that same press ensemble he wore when he was apologizing on national television for Katsuki's kidnapping, waves them over. He hands each one of them a lanyard with a piece of paper insite it.

"Reserved seats. Considering we're testifying." Aizawa grunts out. Katsuki glances to the giant line of civilians, some with sighs, standing outside the courthouse. Eijirou Kirishima shrugs his shoulders, his seran-wrap protective coat crinkling loudly with the motion until his poorly fitting suit jacket.

Katsuki, Shinshou, Kirishima, Ashido, Utsushimi and Aizawa all find their way to the front of the courtroom.

It's stuffy, with only fifty or so chairs in front of the fenced off area. The middle is empty, save for a small podium with a microphone. On either side are the prosecutor desks and the defense attorney desks. Across from the ‘audience,’ are the two levels of desks with four seats in the front, five seats in the back.

Soon enough, the civilians waiting outside start to silently filter into the room until every single seat around them is full and the chamber is filled with muttering.

When all the civilians are sat, the nine judges walk in through the door on the opposite side of the room, sitting down in turn. The first four are the civilians, with Kaminari and Miriko on the rightmost side on the upper row. When Kaminari looks up, his face brightens and he waves in Katsuki’s and Kirishima's direction. Miriko, sitting right next to him, swats his arm down. Katsuki doesn’t notice the faltered smile and half-raise of Kirishima’s arm in response to Kaminari’s greeting.

Several lawyers in tailored suits come in to the left side of the room, placing stacks of documents on their desk.

And finally, the accused.

He also comes in through the side door. The defense attorney comes first, then Yaoyorozu, then Deku, then Todoroki behind him. They look straight ahead while Deku keeps his eyes fixed to the ground. They cleaned him up for this trial – his growing out locks are shaved down to a buzzcut, now just his green roots showing. He no longer wears the uneven stubble that he’s been sporting in every media appearance. He’s cleanly shaved and showered and wearing a well-pressed suit.

There’s something nearly hilarious about this. Never in Katsuki’s life did he think he would be here, sitting as a witness to a trial indicting Izuku Midoriya. Considering their childhood, he was supposed to be the one arrested, and cherubic sweetheart Izuku was supposed to be the one in the stands. But here they are – the world is unfair, Izuku Midoriya has been arrested, and Katsuki is here.

He can’t take his eyes off him.

“Okay. It is time to begin the trial of Izuku Midoriya vs. Hero Commission of Japan. Everyone present?”

Rhetorical question, of course, but Kaminari nods anyway.

Katsuki feels his entire body try to burst into flame as Izuku’s nervous eyes dart towards him and lock. His ears flare with heat at the memory from the previous night; his requests, their intimacy, the context of his honeyed words prior to his breakdown in the bathroom. He doesn’t know how convey it – how to tell him everything without saying a word, so he keeps his eyes on Izuku’s. And, for some reason, Izuku doesn’t look away.

“Alright. Let’s start with the opening statements.”

Chapter End Notes

Izuku, literally so fucking stupid, still convinced Katsuki doesn't like him after he literally told him he's the best part of his life and had mind-blowing sex with him as he was calling him by his childhood nickname:



Me, for some goddamn reason:



A fun extra, because every time I write for this story I feel insane:



Okay get ready because my only knowledge of Japanese law is the one Wikipedia article and playing Phoenix Wright. I fused the court system to be a little Japanese, a little American, and all poorly researched because nobody pays me to write my horny little stories so apologies if you're expecting some kind of anthropological evaluation of the Japanese justice system lmao

Also am fully obsessed with Shinsou's and Katsuki's dynamic, I think they would be hilarious interacting. Hori GIVE THE PEOPLE WHAT THEY WANT

anyway... that flashback scene. I've been frothing at the mouth to write the scene where Zero discovers Katsuki's Deku wall. God they are so in love i'm losing my MIND end tweet

Chapter 17

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“Everybody’s got one, right?”

Katsuki rests his foot on the chair in front of him. His back is perched against the window, one arm on his desk holding his chopsticks, stabbing absently into his bento like his lunch is the world’s least exciting crane game. He rests his face against his fist, the picture of utter indifference, a king on his throne self-feeding himself grapes as the idiots around him fill his space with useless chatter.

The classroom is half-empty. Only half, because Katsuki hates the outside chill and decided to eat lunch inside today. That means that instead of going outdoors, half of the nameless, faceless background characters that call themselves his classmates flocked towards him, hurriedly claiming each empty desk surrounding him as if being closer to his radius will grant them some kind of special prize. Goddamn vultures, circling him, desperate for whatever choice scraps Katsuki is willing to spare them.

Social standing, money, popularity landed the background character a closer seat to Katsuki, and as they became progressively less ‘high ranking’ - whatever the fuck that means in *middle school* - the farther they would sit from Katsuki.

Meaning the person eating lunch alone, completely outside Katsuki’s personal asteroid belt of nothings is…. Well.

The person that’s always just a little too close and a little too far. Always just out of reach.

Nothing to be said about that.

“Bakugou, do *you* have a best friend?”

Katsuki snaps out of his stupor, still mid-way through chewing his *tonkatsu.* He nearly ends up biting his tongue in surprise, the instant desire to explode the fucker who deemed himself worthy enough to talk to him is quelled by the dozen of expecting eyes suddenly on him.

Watching him.

Waiting.

It’s an impulse. A reflex. Something as ingrained into his neural network as kicking out when the pediatrician hits his knee with that little hammer.

Katsuki’s head turns to look at the boy in the back of the classroom, sitting alone. He looks so desperately pathetic, black *garukan* falling off his bony body as he rips at his convenience-store bun with twitchy fingers, bleary eyes focusing on the task like ripping it just right might fix his entire useless life. He pops the tiny piece of bread between his lips, chewing for too long, before he glances up, accidentally meeting Katsuki’s eyes.

Deer in the headlights, dull greens widen at their unexpected contact, but Deku doesn’t look away, and Katsuki can’t bring himself to either.

Does Katsuki have a best friend? Does Katsuki feel closer to one person more than anyone else? Is there a person that knows him better than he knows himself? Is there a person he can have whole conversations with without saying a single word?

Is there someone he can't turn away from, no matter how long he's tried to all his life?

"Hah, why are you looking at Midoriya?"

Reality pulls back at the nape of Katsuki's neck, sitting him firmly back in the real world. The real world where people like Katsuki and Izuku can be nothing but enemies.

It's just the way the world works.

The predators hunt. The prey die. The scavengers gnaw on the remains.

"Because maybe you should be asking *him* that dumbass question. Well, *Deeeku?* Do you have a best friend?"

Deku flinches at the nickname. Laughter rings out as gleeful eyes land on the outcast. With one swift movement of Katsuki's legs, he's standing up, weaving through the throng of extras before he's right in front of Deku's desk. He slams a hand down next to the half-eaten bun, earning himself a poorly suppressed yelp.

"Come on, don't be shy! Well, Deku? You have *any* friends?"

He shrinks in on himself, eyes focused onto his desk as he tightens his lips, head down so his curls cover his face. The vultures descend, their own quips about *weirdo* and *why is he always*

mumbling? He's creepy and, ultimately, *I hear Quirkless people are actually all…*

Katsuki grins to himself, relief somewhere in the back of his mind. With focus drawn towards Izuku Midoriya, no one notices that Katsuki didn't answer the question.

Deku's so damn good at being a punching bag. The scapegoat. The fucking doormat.

Eight years later, it's like nothing at all has changed. He's still sitting behind some desk, trying to make himself small, though much less successful with his massive height and musculature. He's still Quirkless, still self-isolated, still the picture of *other* in everyone's eyes.

Despite all this time, he's still the person people want to despise, to blame, to point their fingers and shirk any of their responsibilities.

And, once again, Katsuki's put him in this position.

How the fuck is any of this my fault?! I didn't tell him to disappear for four years and get his stupid ass arrested! Katsuki argues with himself, knowing blaming anyone other than All for One is completely illogical, but the guilt blossoms under his skin anyway, each accusatory thorn digging further and further into his flesh until the pain forces him to look away.

He doesn't know why it feels like it's his fault. He just can't shake it; it's like he should be sitting opposite of Izuku Midoriya in this courtroom. Maybe a jury of their peers can finally answer the question oscillating between the two of them since age four: who fucked up the other worse?

Because at this point, Katsuki's losing score.

Katsuki shifts in his seat, grabbing the bottom of his chair as he twists his back, loud cracking of his spine the perfect cover to get a glimpse of whoever else might be packed into the overheating courtroom. He recognizes Shoji and Jirou sitting on the opposite side of the court, Uraraka and Iida standing upright in the back in full uniform, and, of course, Inko Midoriya. Half-hidden in the back, seated next to some asshole holding a *Death Penalty!* sign, she soaks through tissue after tissue, tears free flowing despite her soundlessness. His heart lurches at the sight and he turns right the fuck around lest the woman meet his eyes.

I told her I'd bring him back! So I brought him back! Why the fuck should I feel bad? Katsuki argues with himself, though the voice in the back of his brain answers the question. *But not like this. She didn't want him back like this. He didn't want to come back like this.*

God, why is it so goddamn hot in here? His own hands are starting to slip slightly, his underarms damp already. The room is packed to the brim, body standing along every inch of empty wall. Hot air mingles with body odor and the hum of cameras, ready to televise the worst moment of his life for the world to see.

If he's sweltering, he can't even imagine how Deku must be feeling in that shitty suit.

Katsuki glances back over to him, eyes drifting to the hand that's stayed glued to his left shoulder since the second the two sat down. He can't quite tell from here, but he's got the distinct impression Todoroki is doing it not just as as a friendly gesture but to literally keep him cool under pressure.

Katsuki scoffs.

This fucker, after *everything,* gets the goddamn privilege to put his hands on Deku, to 'comfort' him, to be the voice in his ear when Katsuki can't even get near him?

Ain't that the way it always goes.

Katsuki's only ever been someone's first choice when there wasn't anyone to compare him to.

Big fish, small pond. Of course a goldfish might gaze upon salmon and think they're amazing – but dump both in the ocean, and the word takes on a whole new definition.

Enter Shoto Todoroki.

Todoroki's so cool! Todoroki's so amazing! Todoroki's so funny! Goddamn it he could drop-kick that half-and-half asshole into the goddamn sun and –

Katsuki exhales slowly, counting backwards from ten in his head. Some part of Katsuki wanted to forget that they were *close.* Much closer than Katsuki and Deku around the time he disappeared. Sure, they could work together without trying to kill each other, and they occasionally spoke multi-word sentences to one another, but it was nothing compared to Izuku's relationship with Shouto fucking Todoroki.

They spent time together. They trained together, studied together, ate out at restaurants together, watched movies together. They were always just… together. He wasn't really aware of it until he opened up Todoroki's phone and had to face the fact that half of the fucker's camera roll was filled up with Deku's ugly mug.

How many times had Katsuki willingly spent time with Deku outside training? How many pictures exist of just the two of them together?

Katsuki and Todoroki were not the same. That was obvious from the very beginning.

If Katsuki was the sun and Izuku the earth, then Todoroki was the moon. While Deku orbited Katsuki, Todoroki always orbited Deku. Didn't matter that he wasn't as bright, wasn't all-encompassing, didn't demand attention like Katsuki did. At least he was *close.*

They were close. He made it clear from the moment Izuku disappeared, to the moment where he 'resurfaced,' ornamental urn and all.

Conveniently not long after Mr. Compress – *Atsuhiro Sako, Katsuki knows his name, of course he does, but if he thought of him as anything other than the villain that kidnapped him, killed people, hurt Deku, he's not sure he could live with himself, not after what he did, not after his skin boiled and he screamed and his eye melted in his socket, no no no no no* – died from his injuries at the local villain hospital, a Norwegian 'branch' of the 'World Hero Commission' identified some ashes, that, when sequenced, seemed to match one Izuku Midoriya's genetic structure 1:1.

Not like they still had a League member to ask questions about, you know, where and when and why Tomura Shigaraki and Izuku Midoriya apparently traded blows, and why there was no big battle, and why cities weren't decimated, and why no one knew or heard anything about it. So.

So the ashes were flown back to Japan. Izuku Midoriya was announced to have died a *'hero's death,'* whatever the fuck that means.

Then, there was a funeral.

They held it at U.A.

Katsuki did not go.

He stayed in his room. He worked out, scoured websites for any hints of Deku's activity, did his homework. He didn't flinch as he heard the wails of his classmates. He didn't think about Deku, pale and cold, lowered into the ground. He didn't think of him, scared and alone, disintegrating at Shigaraki's hand. He didn't think about Deku. He doesn't think about the fact that when Mr. Compress jeered those words at him, Katsuki, for the first time in his life, lost control of his Quirk and melted the skin right off the man's bones. He doesn't think about the smell, the scream, the horror in his eyes. Katsuki doesn't think about his own hands, dripping with blood no matter how many times he washes them and washes them and washes them.

He doesn't think at all.

He's surprised it doesn't happen sooner – a few hours after the funeral is over, someone's knocking on his door. Not normal knocking. More like pounding. Putting a little rage into it; as some indignant idiot that actually believes Deku is dead would.

Katsuki ignores it. But the pounding gets louder, more insistent, and with a flare of irritation he stands from his desk and throws the door open.

He fully expected to come face to face with Class Prez or Aizawa or even Yagi, but the last person he expected to see was Todoroki.

Todoroki pounds on his door approximately never. That was never their relationship.

He was still dressed in all black, hair limp, eyes puffy. Despite his even expression, Katsuki could feel the burning rage from his left side. Its radiating out, barely suppressed behind whatever composure

Todoroki is pretending to have. The heat prickles his skin and makes his mouth dry.

“You should have been there,” Todoroki spits at him, and Katsuki just rolls his eyes, slamming the door in Todoroki’s face. Or at least he tries – Todoroki places a foot as a door jamb and forces himself inside.

“Get the fuck – “

“He admired you. He defended you. He supported you. He was so overjoyed to have you be his friend again. He always spoke of you with such high regard. Despite the way you treated him, he always held you above *everyone* else! You meant everything to him, and you couldn’t even – “ with each impassioned word, Todoroki crowded closer and closer to Katsuki, backing him up against his own bed, tears glistening in mismatched eyes. Todoroki’s self-control was slipping rapidly, nostrils flaring, fists shaking.

He’s never seen the guy so much as wobble a lip. The guy watched his dad nearly die on live TV but this – this is the most emotional he’s ever seen the guy, which instantly pisses Katsuki off for no reason at all.

“Fuck you. If you want a fucking fight, lets fight – “ Katsuki stabs a finger at the other’s chest, forcing him out of his space.

“But I’m not going to sit around and listen to everyone scream and cry for a person who isn’t *dead.*”

Todoroki had the gall to look surprised.

“But – Mr. Compress. And the ashes. His DNA – “

“That’s real fuckin’ convenient, don’t ya think? No big fight, no struggle, not a single fingertip found in the vicinity. You think that’s the way Deku is going down? Just a random pile of ashes on the other side of the world? They don’t know where he is any better than we do, and the Hero Commission ‘finding’ those ashes just proves it!”

It’s a working theory, at least. Why else would a League member, after not being seen or heard from in nearly 6 months, suddenly reappear near U.A and start taunting them with Deku’s name? Maybe he was hoping that Katsuki had a slip of his tongue, that Deku’s been in contact, that – that.

Katsuki can smell the burning flesh in the room, all around him, and he breathes out quickly, forcing the tainted air out of his lungs. Why can’t he stop thinking about it? Why can’t he stop seeing it? Why won’t the fuckers bubbling skin and horrified eyes leave his head? He was taunting Katsuki. He was *asking* to be hurt. He was -

“…You truly don’t think he’s dead?”

Katsuki startles, forced out of his spiraling thoughts at Todoroki’s too-earnest question. The other sits on his bed, uninvited, shoulders drooping. He looks so goddamn miserable, and Katsuki hates him for it.

Katsuki burns and burns and burns and Todoroki’s entire goddamn life has been scorched by parallel flames.

For the first time, Katsuki gets the impression that Todoroki might actually understand how he feels. He might be the only person that understands.

“I *know* he isn’t.” The words come out much softer than Katsuki intends. “You’re supposed to be the nerd’s friend. You really have so little faith in him? You know that stubborn asshole - he’s still out there, fighting the whole fucking world on his own like the fucked up bastard he is.”

Katsuki is surprised to hear Todoroki huff out a laugh. He hurriedly wipes his eyes with the back of his sleeve.

“… Despite everything, Bakugou, you actually cheered me up. Thanks.”

Katsuki’s ears flare red and he ducks his head, unable to meet Todoroki’s eyes.

“I didn’t do it for you.”

Todoroki doesn’t leave. They sit next to one another on Katsuki’s bed, intimate in their mutual misery. There’s something comforting in it. There’s something nice about not having to suffer alone.

“I want to believe he’s still out there. I want to believe he’s still alive. Maybe its childish of me – “

Todoroki finally stands, sighing, before soundlessly walking towards Katsuki’s door.

“Wait!” Katsuki doesn’t know what compels him to stop the other. The fact that he’s never seen the usually emotionless guy cry before? Because he’s the only one that had the balls to confront him when he knows the rest of the class is just as furious for him not coming to the funeral? Because besides himself, Todoroki knew what Deku was capable of, and has to understand that sneaky fucker wouldn’t give up without a fight?

It doesn’t matter why now. Katsuki still called out, and Todoroki still stopped.

“I’m gonna keep looking. If you wanted, I mean, you’d probably just get in my way, but if you wanted – “ Katsuki shrugs, averting his eyes again, unable to finish the sentence.

Todoroki smiles at him, hand on the door.

“Yes, I’ll keep searching for him with you, Bakugou. If anyone will find him, I know it’s going to be you.”

Every day after class. Computer searches, digging through his notes, interviews, scouting locations. Every single day, which turned into weeks, which turned into months. When they got too pent up, they fought. And when that wasn’t enough to quell their mutual anger and frustration… Well.

They fucked like they fought, rough and furious and holding nothing back. Until they didn’t. Until Todoroki started to change.

Until a few weeks before graduation, when he was met with his entire class in the common room, Todoroki at their side.

“We’re here ‘cause we’re worried about you, man. It’s been two years – “ Kirishima says something, but Katsuki isn’t listening. Isn’t listening to the other dozen voices and their shitty fucking ‘concerns.’ Because Todoroki – Todoroki, who was supposed to understand, who believed Katsuki, who Katsuki trusted – is standing right next to them.

You need to stop searching. Its driving you crazy. He’s gone. Let him go. Just let him go.

The same person who turned his back to Katsuki, who told him to forget about finding Deku is now standing there, without an ounce of shame, putting his hands on Deku like he's got any *right.*

He hates this. He hates seeing them next to each other. He hates the fact that it makes his stomach twist, because they're sitting in a goddamn *courtroom,* where Deku's the *defendant,* and Todoroki is his *prison guard.* Its ludicrous to have these stupid, vapid, high-school emotions.

But he has them anyway.

The thought that he preferred when no one else knew Deku was alive, when it was just him and Zero, still sticks around his mind, and Katsuki takes what might be too long to sweep that loitering thought away.

"Prosecution representing the Hero Commission of Japan. Your opening statement, please."

The words ground Katsuki back into reality and his eyes shoot to the Commission-appointed lawyer, an unassuming man likely in his 30s in a sharp suit and short haircut. He doesn't *look* like anything special – just other middle-aged cardboard cutout in a suit. Could be a million people walking down the street at any time of day in Tokyo. It's really his movements that set him apart –he fixes his tie as he walks to stand in front of the judge's podium, pacing the room with deliberate steps. An actor in a play, enthralling his audience with his stage work.

What was his name? Haiyu-san?

He crosses his arms behind his back as he stands in front of the judges, voice ringing out loudly, projecting for the entire audience to hear. Katsuki watches his fingers twitch as if in rhythm with his words.

"Four years ago, one of the most devastating disasters the world has ever seen unfolded in our great nation. A group of villains called the Paranormal Liberation Front destroyed Jaku City, killing thousands, while simultaneously using our grief to stage a country-wide mass prison outbreak. Violent criminals raged the streets with only destruction and revenge on their minds. Society seized to exist. Children were forced into hiding, the streets burned, and most of us didn't know if we'd live to see another day. In these moments, the heroes that we loved and looked up to gave up in droves, leaving us to fend for ourselves. Vigilantism became the norm then – it's all we could do to protect our friends, our families – to fight when no one else fought for us."

The silence in the courtroom is stifling. Katsuki blinks a few times. The lawyer sounds like he's trying to defend *Deku's* actions.

"…Everyone in this room lost someone they loved to the prison riots – be it in the crossfires of villains or the vigilantes themselves. In reality, those that took up arms did not have training, reacted violently to friend and foe alike. Thousands of deaths that could have been prevented escalated as Quirk use at the discretion of the user ran rampant."

"In the end, vigilantism lead to the exact world the Paranormal Liberation Front wanted. Those with strong Quirks exerted their influence, forming gangs and using coercion or threats of violence to obtain resources while others starved. The powerful thrived and those of us – particularly the Quirkless," he turns to Deku, like he's got any right, waving his arm toward him. He's both people in his example. That's probably the point.

"Each perceived threat was always met with fatal force. It is this lawless world that the Hero Commission inherited; to fix the mistakes of 'heroes' who no longer protected the innocent when it

became difficult, while ensuring those without adequate training and supervision did not use their power to enact whatever 'justice' best benefits them."

"Izuku Midoriya is the perfect example of selfish, dangerous actions that lead to disaster. With not so much as a high school education, this young man ran around the world, inflicting his personal justice no matter the context, country, or environment he was a part of. Because of his powerful Quirk, he did as he pleased. I don't mean to say that he was doing it out of cruelty – " The lawyers eyebrows shoot up, donning a mask that's supposed to be pure sympathy, but looks fake as shit to Katsuki's eye. He looks like one of their shitty middle school teachers – the ones that would pat Deku on the shoulder after someone pushed him down or stole his lunch or knocked books out of his hands. That insincere, forced smile that was supposed to be sympathetic but was very clearly pitying.

Katsuki can see right through it. Deku can too. At least he would, if he would lift his goddamn eyes from that desk.

" – But that his misguided actions have led to irreversible harm. Izuku Midoriya was aware of the movements of Tomura Shigaraki and his team for years, and without informing authorities, he pursued this villain on his own. His final act as a vigilante would have been to sacrifice the lives of forty budding hero students; leaving multiple heroes permanently injured and these children – our children, the future of this country - to bear the scars of his actions."

Where were those honeyed words when Katsuki and his classmates were cleaning up their mess aboveground? Where were the impassioned speeches about saving Japan's youth?

Guess people like Katsuki are only worth protecting when it serves an agenda.

"Izuku Midoriya is the perfect example of what the mindset of the old ways leads to. This young man has used violence, bribery, lies and manipulation of civilians to accomplish his objective and none could stand in his way. Izuku Midoriya, in his hope to become a hero, has ultimately become the new All for One, controlling the Japanese populace with his own ideals. Today is a grand day – because finally, we can put the wielders of these Quirks away and live freely without fear of destruction on a single person's whim."

The Hero Commission lawyer – Haiyu - turns to the audience, bowing deeply, before walking back to his desk, the only sound in the room the scraping of his chair on tile.

The courtroom, as if lifting a muffling curtain, ascends in volume from complete silence to poorly suppressed whispers to full-voiced proclamations within seconds. The civilian judges follow.

Only Mirko and Chargebolt remain quiet, jaws tight at the ringing agreement across the court. Mirko is at least feigning composure, but Kaminari is shaking all over, poorly hiding his clenched fists digging grooves into his own thighs. His mouth is twitching, like he's desperate to say something, but judge participation is not allowed until both opening statements are complete; even that idiot has to know it.

Katsuki feels a bump against his shoulder and turns sharply towards Kirishima. The other is giving him a tense, toothless smile, chin tilting towards his hands.

"…Bakugou, you're smoking."

Katsuki turns back down to his own hands, gripping hard against the bottom of the plastic chair. The plastic is melting under his grasp, sticking hotly to his fingers, letting off a horrific stench. Despite the obviousness of this, Aizawa to his left says nothing. His eyes are fixed on the prosecutor, eyes

glowing a slight red. *He's seeing if this persuasion is a part of his Quirk,* Katsuki thinks, but it's stupid, because it isn't.

They both know that.

"Quiet, everyone. The defense's opening statement."

Aizawa and Yagi pulled every string in the goddamn law-enforcement sweater to get this guy on Deku's case. No one wanted to touch the case with a ten thousand foot pole, from what Katsuki heard. Going up against the Hero Commission means career suicide. Even if they agreed with Deku's actions, even if they were trusted friends and long-term colleagues, everyone has a family to feed. Their own interests to protect.

Everyone has to keep living in the world after the trial. Why go down with some kid who everyone had already forgotten?

Which makes the person who stands up and walks to the front all the more surprising. The man is *young,* perhaps not much older than Katsuki and Izuku themselves. Compared to the Commission lawyer, this guy looks like he's playing a children's dress-up game. Long, unkempt brown hair, fashion-forward tight fitting grey suit and pinstriped tie are all ridiculous enough, but the not-subtle nudging of his hair when he moves his head shows two small, symmetrical black horns growing out from his forehead.

"…Oh. Wow, Akuma-kun is actually Midoriya's lawyer? I thought he might be an understudy…" Shinsou furrows his eyebrows, earning a not-so-subtle elbow from Aizawa. Katsuki, however, leans over his former teacher.

"Who the fuck is 'Akuma-kun?' You know this asshole?"

"Of course I know him. He was a General Studies student; a third year when we were first years. He must have *just* graduated Law School."

"He graduated a year early," Aizawa adds through gritted teeth, not looking away from the young man standing in front of the judges.

His voice is oddly delicate when he speaks, the candor so soothing that Katsuki visually sees the jury's shoulders drop as soon as the other starts to speak.

"Jaku, Deika, Hosu. The prison riots. One disaster after another. We barely had time to bury our dead before the next wave of fatalities. We did not have time to grieve our friends and loved ones, we did not have time to rebuild, we did not have time to process the trauma of living in a world where, at any second, we might die. We had to grow apathetic, numb – because to fully process each tragedy would be to be immobilized by pain. We had to keep living. And to live, we had to latch on to something, anything – in this case, blame. We turned our backs on the heroes, and the heroes turned their backs on us."

"The heroes, unable to fulfill their vow to save others, hung up their uniforms. And us, in our great grief, forgot that these people are humans – that they are too suffering loss, that they're the ones digging bodies out of the rubble, that they're the ones whose hands are covered in blood. We turned against one another. All of this is true. But its childish to lay the blame on the civilians, or the heroes, or even the villains. The instigator of these crimes is All for One and his protégé, Tomura Shigaraki – we all knew this. And we blamed the heroes for not stopping him."

“Yet, imagine these very human heroes – just as human as you and me – tackling that God-like monster. We forget the degree of power All for One, and in turn, Tomura Shigaraki held. We forget the leveled cities, generational homes nothing but rubble, parks and museums and schools decimated to become wasteland. We forget that we were not even able to identify the remains of our loved ones due to the complete annihilation his Decay caused. The suffering, the fear, the praying your loved ones weren’t in the subsequent pile of ash – this was not a power that any pro hero could face. They have tried. And they have failed. Or have you forgotten? Mino City? Carkoon City? Venarro City? Hando City? Mos City? Horis City?”

Katsuki can hear Ashido inhale somewhere to his left. Kirishima subtly reaches out, grasping her hand in his. Yaoyorozu doesn’t get such gentleness – eyes averted, she tries to maintain professionalism as her shoulders shake. In another universe, Deku would reach out his hand to comfort her; but his right sleeve lays limp and motionless in his lap. It isn’t fair. This Akuma guy is using a battle many of them were in, having to describe it in detail, because not a single citizen in here knows what its like to be the one covered in blood and sweat and mud, watching your heroes and mentors fall all around you, feeling powerless in the face of the absolute.

Aizawa’s eye and leg, Mirko’s arm, Katsuki’s stomach – pieces of them still litter that battlefield. All that, reduced to pretty words to sway the hearts of citizens who could never understand what they went through. What Deku went through.

“… Cloud City, Carida City, Calamari City, Synara City, Hao City, Ciro City, Shido City…”

They all suffered enough. Katsuki has no idea why it hits him now. Kirishima, Ashido, fuck, even Kaminari, Yaoyorozu, Uraraka, Iida - they were all *there.* They all had people they couldn’t save.

“Anoto City, Cheno City, Oata City, Asaluda City, Nabato City, Kawa City, Kohera City. Thousands of people died with a single mindless attack. The heroes could do nothing to fight back.”

The room is silent.

“…Now imagine if you had the power to stop it.”

Katsuki raises his head, eyes turning towards Deku.

“Izuku Midoriya was sixteen years old when he learned he possessed the only power that could stand up against this God-like force. It’s a heavy responsibility to place on the shoulders of a child. He watched the world fall around him, and had two choices presented to him.”

Akuma turns out his palms, turning towards the rest of the courtroom. He raises one.

“Keep doing more of the same. More cities destroyed, more heroes dead, more fear, more chaos. Or.”

He raises his left palm, turning back towards the judge box.

“He could try to save us. Four years ago, Izuku Midoriya disappeared. Four years ago, Japan entered an era of peace. We allowed a sixteen year old boy to fight for his life while we lived in sweet ignorance. But the truth is, we would all be six feet under if it wasn’t for this young man – the greatest hero the world has ever known, sitting in this courtroom, prosecuted as if he’s no different than a villain.”

Akuma turns towards Izuku and walks towards him, the heels of his shoes resounding through the courtroom. He leans against the table, as if speaking directly to Deku himself, voice softening.

“Izuku Midoriya is a young man has been thrust in extraordinary circumstances, and to save as many as he could, was forced to take extraordinary actions. In Jaku City, he rushed from perceived safety to an empty zone so those that could still be saved were saved. Knowing he was the target of Tomura Shigaraki, Izuku Midoriya chose to flee. Imagine knowing that you were a target of a killer, and that as long as you stayed away from people, he would chase you. As long as you remained alive, he would not give up. It’s a nightmare for us all – but for sixteen year old Izuku Midoriya, it was his reality. Yes, he broke the law with his actions. But when following the law kills thousands, hundreds of thousands, what is one person left to do? He sits here, in front of the whole country of people he’s saved with his head low, ready to take whatever judgement you are ready to throw on him, but I know the truth. I hope you will grow to understand it as well. Izuku Midoriya is a hero – a man who surrendered his youth, his joy, his entire life, so we can sit here today and watch him be destroyed by the very commission his sacrifice allows to exist.”

Maybe this devil-horned asshole isn’t so bad. Katsuki watches Akuma walk back towards his seat next to Deku, not missing the look in the other’s eyes. This isn’t just professional. The small smile, the tender expression – he actually believes in Izuku. Maybe even admires him.

This isn’t an objective case. It was never going to be. To talk about heroics is to make things personal. The definition of hero and villain have oscillated so sharply in the last few years; each set of eyes might perceive the man in front of them as something different despite the same actions. The scales are constantly tipping and all they can do is hope they tip in the direction of hero. Just this once.

“Hero Judge #2.”

The first to raise their sign is Kaminari, face determined. Katsuki feels trepidation rise along his spine. Kaminari shouldn’t be the first one to start the questioning – he shouldn’t be the first one doing anything, at all, in general.

“What exactly happened in the battle at Jaku City?”

Ah. Outside himself, Deku, Todoroki, Endeavor, Gran Torino, Eraser Head, Rock Lock, Manual, Ryukyu and later Iida and Nejire, that part of the Paranormal Liberation War remained up for speculation. It’s likely that not a single citizen in here knows that Deku’s come face to face with Tomura Shigaraki before – multiple times in fact – with Endeavor’s full support, and still barely made it out alive.

“I will be able to provide that information.”

“… Sustained. To the witness stand, Professor. As witness testimonies are not objective, we utilize a truth-serum during testimony. Do you consent to the use of the Book of Truth?”

The odd mustachioed… referee? Katsuki supposes, he’s not sure of the man’s actual job, but he seems to be directing the actions of the court rather than actively participating, points to the thin book laying on top of the witness stand. It’s a double edged sword, Katsuki figures. Of course they’re using a Quirk to evoke the ‘truth’ from witnesses; which can inadvertently cause people to share what they did not want to share. However, if you refused, the testimony would likely not be trusted by the judges.

Aizawa looks down at the book for 0.5 seconds flat before placing his hand on the cover.

“I consent.”

The mustachioed man nods. “Proceed.”

Aizawa starts like he's in the middle of a sentence.

"We were given a hint by Kurogiri regarding the location of Dr.Garuki, the brains of All for One's operations and creator of the Nomu. Myself and many other pro heroes established different teams to simultaneously take out Garuki and the Nomus while addressing the Liberation Army stronghold. Our teams consisted of a Hospital Raid Team, the Villa Raid Team, the Backup Team and the Evacuation team. Despite the support of two dozen top ranked pro heroes and the entire Tokyo Police department, the Hospital Raid resulted in the escape of Tomura Shigaraki and several Near High-End Nomus. At the release of Shigaraki, Gigantomachia awakened in the Villa. Shigaraki was undergoing physical modifications to… fuse himself with All for One, and we were not able to successfully stop it. Shigaraki had grown incredibly powerful – we held multiple new Quirks and his Decay could destroy even things he did not touch. Jaku City started to fall."

The book appears to flow a light blue and get slightly thicker with Aizawa's words.

"Shigaraki's consciousness was fused with All for One, whose purpose was to find and destroy One for All. Izuku Midoriya heard this during his rescue operations and, being in the middle of the city and fearing he would attract Shigaraki and cause more destruction, ran to an unpopulated part of the mountains. I believe his classmates, Bakugou Katsuki and Todoroki Shouto accompanied him. Myself, Endeavor, Rock Lock, Manual and Ryokyu attempted to help with the battle. I tried to cancel out his Quirks to give the others a fighting chance. We did not succeed. Shigaraki was nearly fatally injured but survived secondary to his new Regeneration quirk, and thus retreated. All present on the battlefield suffered severe injuries and we were all transferred to Central Hospital."

Katsuki's whole body aches. He can feel eyes on him; everyone still knows who he is, but now he might as well be sitting naked in this courtroom, every one of his traumas exposed for the world's judgement.

"… It became clear that Shigaraki was pursuing Midoriya and exclusively Midoriya. Before he was able to recover, the decision was made to secure Midoriya in a safehouse until we were able to come up with a strategy to defeat All for One and Shigaraki, as well as allow the heroes injured in Jaku to heal. All Might had connections with Stars and Stripe, the #1 in America. It seemed to be the safest place for him; we secured documents for him, and on my last communication with him, he had landed safely in Los Angeles, California."

"And then what?" Kaminari asks, words straight out of Katsuki brain.

Aizawa pauses.

"… Two weeks after, Izuku Midoriya went off the radar. We were not aware of his movements afterwards."

One of the appointed judges raises his placard. Mustache-man nods at him.

"Aizawa-san, why was the decision made to send Midoriya to America? It seems irresponsible to potentially send the individual with the only Quirk that could potentially defeat All for One to a different country. Why not a safe house in Japan?"

Aizawa glances at Izuku, placing his hand on the book in front of him once more.

"Three-fold. One, most of the top-ranking proes had been injured in the Liberation War. We were at a severe disadvantage and couldn't adequately protect Midoriya. Second, Los Angeles is located in proximity to a large desert, which would allow to even the playing field between Shigaraki and Star

and Stripe and avoid civilian fatalities, should he attack. Third, Midoriya, who had… interacted with One for All on the battlefield, seemed to be under the impression that placing One for All and All for One at a distance would weaken both, which may garner us an advantage if Shigaraki was to attack again. These are odd questions to ask, considering moving Midoriya was Commission approved."

Aizawa lifts his hand from the Book of Truth and turns to the commission lawyer, as if silently saying *Your turn.*

He shrugs his shoulders, non-plussed.

"But of course. So you agree that Izuku Midoriya's actions were supported by the Commission and Pro-Heroes until he decided to act on his own without license or pro hero support, indicating the start of his vigilantism approximately four years ago?"

Aizawa clamps his mouth shut, glaring at the other.

Akuma stands up.

"So, Aizawa-san, you are stating that Tomura Shigaraki was able to locate Izuku Midoriya in a battlefield with thousands of others, and in order to protect both Midoriya and the Japanese population, he dropped out of school and was sent to live in a foreign country. Is that correct?"

Katsuki frowns. Where is he going with that?

"…that is correct."

"And is it correct that Tomura Shigaraki, once he recovered, was likely to pursue Izuku Midoriya no matter where he was in the world?"

"… that is correct."

"You've painted Izuku Midoriya as a promising young hero. Tell me, Aizawa-san, how was he as a student?"

Aizawa glances at Izuku.

"He was top of the class. Attentive and hard working. Brave. Excellent team player. But very reckless and borderline self-destructive."

"In the six months you were his teacher, had Izuku Midoriya ever done something that demonstrates him placing importance on saving other's lives above his own?"

Katsuki grinds his teeth. Ain't that the question. Every time the fucker goes into battle, it's like he's *trying* to die.

"Yes. Even during Jaku City, he and Katsuki Bakugou directly placed themselves into Shigaraki's firing range to prevent my death."

He says it simply, flatly, but Katsuki feels his own heart lurch.

"What you're saying is that Izuku Midoriya is the type of person that would sacrifice his own safety to protect others, is that correct?"

"…Yes."

“So it would stand that two weeks may have been an adequate amount of time for Tomura Shigaraki to recover. Midoriya, living in a city that contains nearly 4 million people, knowing that he’s a target, would attempt to protect those around him by leaving his safehouse and attempting to move on to less populated areas. After all, he’s done that twice before.”

The commission lawyer stands, furrowing his eyebrows.

“A fair deduction, Akuma-san, but your line of questioning detracts from the point. Midoriya’s vigilante activity started after his disappearance. The reasoning for said disappearance is not important. It would be one thing to tout that Izuku Midoriya, in his endless selflessness, simply ran to less populated areas to prevent Shigaraki finding him and causing additional destruction. However, that was not the case.”

Katsuki grinds his teeth. This fucker has something up his sleeve.

“If you all can please turn your attention to the screen to my left.”

Heads turn to the projector, which has magically lit up.

“You see, lone vigilante activity significantly increased in the United States in an East-ward trajectory up until two years ago. While vigilantes are much more accepted in the United States and protected under law, this does not apply to individuals who are not citizens. Thus Izuku Midoriya avoided capture and litigation, but very clearly continued to practice Hero work and frequently traveled within heavily populated cities, making your claim that he simply disappeared to avoid large casualties a moot point.”

The pictures flash in front of Katsuki’s eyes as the lawyer clicks through, self-satisfied smile on his face.

Some of them he’s seen. Some he hasn’t.

It's clearly chronological, pictures traveling past his eyes like one of those shitty flip books.

His body is clearly changing through each photograph. Bigger, bulkier, always masked, disguises different every time, but to Katsuki’s trained eye, very clearly Izuku Midoriya. Blackwhip is obvious in the first two, then Float, then Smokescreen, then *others.*

“Midoriya, are you the individual in these pictures?”

It’s the first time Deku’s addressed directly, and he lifts his eyes to the screen, jaw tight.

“Yes.” He answers simply, then looks back down.

A civilian judge raises a placard.

“…That doesn’t make sense. There’s like… 10 different Quirks displayed there.”

“Right. It’s an open secret in the Hero Community, but why don’t you finally tell the civilians exactly how One for All works? Of course I’d ask All Might, but it doesn’t appear he’s here with us today.” The lawyer sounds so damn fucking smug, grinning widely, staring straight at Deku like he’s got him, hook line and sinker.

And Deku will have to place his hand on that Book of Truth.

Panic rushes through Katsuki. It's not a good idea to bring Deku up to the stand right now. He's going to get his own ass thrown in jail for life, knowing him.

Well… there is *one* person who knows the Quirk just as well as All Might and Deku.

"I can explain it."

Katsuki is surprised at his own voice, or the fact that he stands up and approaches the stand like he isn't literally shaking in his shoes. Aizawa stares at him critically, as if trying to communicate something Katsuki doesn't understand. Well. Too late to second-guess himself now.

Katsuki can feel everyone's eyes on him, but the only pair he cares about are on the defendant side.

He looks, not expecting the other to look back. But there they are, his eyes, wide with surprise, mouth just slightly agape. Katsuki's heart skips a beat, heat rising up the back of his neck. Carefully, gingerly, he keeps his eyes locked with Izuku's as his hand descends on the Book of Truth.

He doesn't feel anything different. Maybe a vague tingling sensation on his palm and the distinct impression that his hand is very, *very* dry, like the book is sucking the nitroglycerin out of him.

"…Isn't that Dynamight?"

"…Why is he on the podium? Why would he know how that guy's Quirk works?"

"I heard they were classmates…"

Katsuki tries to shut out all the voices, focusing on the lawyers and judges in front of him. He waits for a question – not getting one, he decides to talk anyway.

"I knew Dek – Izuku Midoriya since we were children. We grew up in the same neighborhood. I found out about One for All, and because I knew about it, All Might told me how it works. Since its gone now, it's not worth keeping a secret anymore anyway," Katsuki finds the words slipping and rapidly clamps his mouth shut, cringing internally.

One sentence out of his mouth and he's already reminded Deku he's Quirkless again. Holy shit. What the fuck is wrong with him.

"One for All and All for One are stockpile Quirks. Dek – Izuku's quirk had eight different predecessors, so he had access to their Quirks."

"… But there are at least 10 Quirks displayed in these photos."

"Is he the same as One for All?"

"How did we let this kid run free? He's incredibly dangerous!"

Katsuki closes his eyes, working hard to keep his voice even.

"Right, as he got stronger, he was able to pull Quirks from All for One. Think of it like a pool of water with drains on opposite sides. The one that has the larger gait or keeps it open for longer will drain more of the water. As Deku got stronger, he got more of the 'water.'"

"That implies they drew from the same pool." The civilian judge narrows their eyes at Katsuki. Katsuki just nods in response.

“They did. All for One and One for All is the same Quirk, just in two different bodies. Three temporarily, I guess, when Potato-fuck was controlling Shigaraki out of Tartarus – “

Murmurs erupt, interrupting Katsuki’s train of thought.

“What?!”

“How?!”

“That’s impossible!”

Katsuki rolls his eyes. Everyone is acting like this is the end of the goddamn world, but Katsuki’s had months since *that* existential crisis, so now it’s just annoying. In a world with weird-ass superpowers you would think people would suspend their disbelief every now and again.

“Not impossible. It’s been in front of your dumb faces for hundreds of years. Most identical twins share the same Quirk.”

“…Izuku Midoriya and Tomura Shigaraki are twins?!”

“Wait, twins? Why does that sound familiar…”

“There were a bunch of twins being kidnapped not too long ago, right?”

“Wait, weren’t there twins that you were on the case to rescue?”

They’re all talking over one another, but its Miriko who raises her placard and waits patiently.

“Hero Judge #1.” Mustache-guy calls on her. She crosses her arms, voice flat.

“And why couldn’t he just kill Midoriya?”

Akuma raises his eyebrows and stands next to the witness stand.

“I can address this question. Bakugou-san, would you say in the battle in Jaku City, Shigaraki was using force with intent to kill Izuku Midoriya?”

Katsuki feels all the hairs on the back of his neck stand up as Akuma talks to him in that weirdly sweet, melodic voice. There’s something not *right* about this guy – but he’s fighting for Deku, so he has to trust him.

“I would say yes,” Katsuki says easily, fighting the impulse to lift his shirt and show the grotesque wounds he sustained so that these idiots saw exactly what kind of *force* they were talking about here.

“And the battle on Minami-Ioto island. Was Tomura Shigaraki exerting a force with intent to kill Midoriya then?”

Katsuki grinds his teeth. This guy is asking very simple, closed-off, yes-or-no questions rather than the open ended bullshit the other lawyer has been touting. Katsuki glances down to the Book of Truth where his hand rests and furrows his eyebrows. This is intentional.

He’s trying to limit them implicating themselves by asking extremely specific questions. Katsuki feels the tight knot in his stomach loosen slightly. This fucker might actually know what he’s doing.

“No.” Katsuki answers.

“Ah. So it appears that Tomura Shigaraki discovered something about One for All and All for One in these last four years. Haiyu-san, if I may borrow the projector for a moment.”

The Commission lawyer narrows his eyes but hands over the clicker device. The blurry shots of Deku’s vigilante work are replaced with gore.

The civilians gasp. Some of the judges cover their eyes. Katsuki doesn’t even flinch.

Why would he? He’s the one that found them.

“Between Izuku Midoriya’s disappearance and now, there have been several unusual cases of murders involving twins. The autopsy report of these two girls – “ The bloodied corpses of the two young girls laying side by side, Toga Himiko’s masterpiece, flashes to an official looking document in a different language. “ – Demonstrates that the two had been tortured and likely experimented on prior to their murder.”

He clicks again, showing the article of the burn victims with their identities and grotesque, charred bodies.

“Two pairs of twins here, charred by what witnesses reported was a blue flame. One pair identical, one pair fraternal. Their autopsy reports also demonstrate evidence of torture – starvation, puncture injuries and loss of limb prior to their murders.”

“Where are you going with this – “

“You see,” Akuma continues, “It appears that Tomura Shigaraki made his own discovery regarding twins during the four years Izuku Midoriya was missing. Which, of course, brings us to the Twin Sequencing Case. Bakugou-san, if you don’t mind leaving the stand, I would like to call Jirou Kyoka as a witness.”

Katsuki meets the other’s eyes. It seems innocent enough, but its almost like Akuma *knows* that as soon as Katsuki speaks on the twins case, he’ll implicate himself.

Katsuki walks back to his seat and watches a confused Jirou stand and take his place.

“Earphone Jack, you, as part of The Lurkers team, worked on the Twins Sequencing Case, is that correct?”

“…Yes,” she answers, tilting her head.

“Would you please explain the case to the audience?”

“Uh… sure. Over the course of a few months, we had discovered three pop-up underground laboratories that were processing samples of twins. We were never able to track how the blood samples were obtained, and all of the twins didn’t remember what happened, reporting episodes of lost time they couldn’t account for. From what we could tell, their genetic codes were being sequenced, and specifically identical twins were being targeted. Shortly after, one of the pairs of twins that were identified in the lab were kidnapped by an unknown assailant.”

“Interesting. So it stands to reason that, seeing we have seen members of the League pursue and kill twins, it’s possible that Tomura Shigaraki was behind these samples, and thus the kidnapping.”

“…I suppose that could be true.” Jirou shrugs her shoulders. “There apparently was a perpetrator found at the kidnapping for the Shiryoku twins, but they weren’t apprehended. It seems fully possible

that it was Shigaraki or one of the members of the League. I was not present at that case. But Tentacole and Dynamight were both there, if that helps."

Katsuki feels all the blood drain out of his face. If they ask him to testify right now… this is all going to be over.

"Ah, excellent. Thank you, Earphone Jack. Tentacole, if you would please come up to the witness stand." Akuma smiles innocently. Jirou glances around, confusion clear on her face before she leaves the witness stand and Shoji replaces her.

"Mezo Shoji, hero name Tentacole, you are currently employed under Gang Orca, is that correct?"

Shoji isn't paying attention, multiple limbs attempting to cover the thickening book.

"Can you describe that happened on the Shiryoku twins rescue mission?"

Finally figuring out how all three of his hands on the left side can rest on the book, he starts to speak.

"Of course. We were able to identify their location rapidly. I was on the reconnaissance and lookout team and the direct rescue team consistent of Gang Orca, Man O' War and Dynamight. They used smoke as a distractor while they rescued the twins. They were unharmed. There was a perpetrator, but…" Katsuki feels his blood go cold as Shoji's eyes meet his. "…They appeared to have escaped. No arrests were made."

The Commission lawyer stands, approaching Shoji.

"Tentacole, did you *see* the assailant themselves?" Haiyu asks. Shoji shakes his head.

Then, he hesitates, looking conflicted for just a brief second, before he speaks again.

"I did not see them. But I did hear… Dynamight speaking with the kidnapper. Like they knew each other. I… I believe he might have let him go."

A spotlight might as well have just appeared out of the sky and shined straight at Katsuki. All eyes are on him – even Kirishima looks confused, nearly hurt, begging for an answer with his eyes.

Katsuki feels his tongue shrivel up in the back of his throat.

"Interesting. Very interesting. Thus, it stands to reason that the kidnapping wasn't perpetrated by the League, as I'm sure pro-hero Dynamight wouldn't have let them go. I think we are all aware of his… feelings regarding members of the League."

Nausea crests in Katsuki's stomach. The walls seem to be closing in on him, all around him, and he can't fucking breathe, he needs to throw up, he needs to leave, he needs to go –

"Now, I wonder who Dynamight might want to protect from getting arrested. Tentacole, if you don't mind opening the Book of Truth. You will find Bakugou-san's testimony, word for word. Can you please read what he said when he started to explain the way One for All works?"

Shoji hesitates, casting an apologetic eye in Katsuki's direction before he starts to read.

"*I knew Dek – Izuku Midoriya since we were children. We grew up in the same neighborhood…*"

“Interesting. Katsuki Bakugou and Izuku Midoriya have known each other their whole lives. They were classmates. And, coincidentally, Katsuki Bakugou was on Minami-Ioto island. He was involved in the twins case. This is how deep the cancer runs, dear judges. Of course Izuku Midoriya escaped arrest until now, because he had supporters. Pro-Heroes, who allowed this individual to kidnap children. Katsuki Bakugou, if you would please come back up to the stand.”

Katsuki feels numb. His body moves, but he doesn’t comprehend how, because he can’t think. He can’t breathe. He mechanically places a hand on the Book of Truth, feeling like he just came to the firing range and every judge is ready to put a bullet between his eyes.

“Katsuki Bakugou – is the person who kidnapped the Shiryoku twins Izuku Midoriya?”

Katsuki says nothing.

“It’s a simple question. Yes or no.”

The person who kidnapped the kids was Zero. He wasn’t Izuku Midoriya. They’re not the same. He can just say no and it wouldn’t be a lie. He begs his tongue to work, but it doesn’t.

“Dynamight, I will repeat. Is the person who kidnapped the Shiryoku twins the defendant?”

Fuck. He reworded the question, and Katsuki can’t stop his mouth from opening.

“Yes.”

The courtroom might as well have spontaneously exploded – that would probably lead to less chaos than what is unfolding in front of him now. Wide eyes, dropped jaws, people yelling, something being thrown at Deku –

Todoroki doesn’t hesitate – he erects a wall of ice in front of Izuku, teeth clenched, eyes furious. Katsuki can’t move his body. He can’t turn his eyes towards Deku. He can’t.

“I would like to request a recess to allow for us to call the Shiryoku twins to the witness stand.” The self-satisfied commission lawyer states. The mustached man nods.

“Accepted. We will allow for a 30 minute recess.”

People flood out of the courtroom, voices loud, until Katsuki’s the only one still standing at the stand, crushed with utter defeat.

Except.

Except they’re bringing them up to the stand. And the girls, and Shinsou, and the fact that they consented; yes, it’s going to be okay!

He has to tell Deku. He has to – he has to see him. He has to talk to him. He has to.

“Bakugou – “ he can hear Aizawa somewhere in the background, but Katsuki feels his legs move on their own to where the defendant’s team disappeared in the back of the room. He surely shouldn’t be here. He knows he shouldn’t. This could land him in even hotter shit, but he can’t stand the idea of Deku despising him, of thinking he’d betray him, he needs to tell him -

Katsuki spots Todoroki standing outside of a door and heads straight in that direction. He’s the only one in the narrow, empty hallway; the closer Katsuki gets, the more he can tell that Todoroki’s

standing outside of a single-person bathroom. Likely waiting for Deku, like the loyal fucking guard-dog he is.

Katsuki ignores him completely, going for the door, but Todoroki grabs him hard by the shoulder, shoving him backwards.

“You shouldn’t be here.”

Seems that he might mean more than just literally outside this bathroom.

“Let me talk to him.” Katsuki grits out through clenched teeth.

“He doesn’t want to talk to you.” Todoroki says coolly.

“He needs to hear this from *me!”* Katsuki insists, pushing forward, but Todoroki puffs out his chest, eyes turning significantly less sympathetic with each passing second.

“He doesn’t need to hear anything from you. You just destroyed his chance to –“

Katsuki feels his anger boil over, his hands dripping with potent nitroglycerin. Todoroki doesn’t know *anything,* this goddamn fucking bastard -

Katsuki is going to kill him.

“Fuck *you!* How dare you try to be his *protector* NOW when you stopped looking for him then, huh? Who the fuck do you think you are?!”

Todoroki pushes harder against Katsuki’s shoulder, mouth fixed in a snarl, the mask of feigned politeness crashing to the ground.

“When are you going to let that go?! He was gone! You were killing yourself looking for him! We had spent that whole year together, and I just - I was worried about you! I *cared* for you! I might have even lo – “

Katsuki cuts him off before he dares to say the horrible words on the tip of his tongue.

“You’re confusing me with someone else, asshole, because we just *fucked.* That’s IT. You were fucking stress relief to me and nothing else! Don’t pretend it was more than it was, because you didn’t mean *SHIT* to me!”

They’re inches apart, screaming at one another, testosterone and rage and the thick scent of nitroglycerin hiding the fact that the bathroom door opened and a third has joined them in this empty courtroom hallway.

“…Wait. What?” A tiny hurt voice rasps out, and Katsuki turns his head towards it, his heart nearly stopping at the sight.

A shocked looking green-eyed, green-haired Izuku Midoriya standing in front of the, small droplets in his hair and face, like he just rinsed out his eyes in the bathroom stands just a foot away from them.

Katsuki had so much to say, and suddenly, he can’t find a single word to offer.

The one who breaks the silence is Izuku.

"…It was him?" Izuku whispers out, staring straight at Katsuki, voice weak and defeated.

"*He* was the one you were with?" His voice raises as he steps forward, the familiar turbulent force making Katsuki's brain stutter. "He *loved* you?"

Desperate green eyes search Katsuki's face, chest heaving, breaths labored and heavy. Tears are rapidly accumulating in his eyes and he shakes his head, staring up at the ceiling as if attempting to prevent the droplets from spilling over.

"The *second* I was out of the way you got in bed with my best friend, huh?"

"Deku, it wasn't like tha – "

"Midoriya, why are you – " Todoroki reaches a hand out, but Deku slaps it away.

"Don't TOUCH me!" He snaps at Todoroki, redirecting furious eyes back at Katsuki. Under them he feels like small, a tiny rabbit faced with a wolf baring his teeth. He opens his mouth, but nothing comes out. He doesn't know what to do. He doesn't know what to *do*.

And the funny thing? The thing that's running around his stupid little brain right now isn't the trial, isn't the fact that he's probably going to lose his license, isn't the fact that he's probably about to get his ass beat – it's what Deku called Todoroki.

His best friend. *Todoroki* is his best friend.

It was true in middle school, and its true now. No matter how pathetic it is - Izuku Midoriya is Katsuki Bakugou's best friend.

But like many other things in their relationship – everything, really, at this point - even that isn't reciprocated.

He can't even imagine what is going on in Deku's head right now. But he also doesn't know why the fuck he feels so guilty, either.

Maybe because Todoroki was Deku's. Deku cared for him. Maybe he even loved him. Maybe hearing that Todoroki felt anything at all for Katsuki breaks his heart. Maybe he feels like he stole him – like he stole his youth, his life, fuck, even his Quirk – from him.

"If it was a stranger, or Kirishima, I would understand – but we were all in work study together, we were all *friends* – but I was just in the way, wasn't I? You always just wanted me out of the way! What a joke."

"Izuku, that's not – " Katsuki tries, some desperate part of his brain using his first name, like it's going to make a difference, but it does nothing but make the other turn around and start walking away, right back towards the courtroom.

Todoroki just glares at him wordlessly before running after the other. Katsuki watches him try to place a hand on his shoulder, but Deku shrugs violently away, increasing his pace.

Katsuki just watches him walk away, the crushing weight of loneliness, of this too-familiar hurt rendering him immobile.

He's walking away again. How many times is this? How many times is Deku going to walk away from him? How many more times does Katsuki have to desperately run after him? When it does

nothing but hurt them both?

Maybe he should stop chasing him.

Maybe… He needs to let him go.

He needs to let him go.

Chapter End Notes

Katsuki, literally unable to stay away from Deku:



Akuma, Deku's lawyer, who is definitely not just Goro Akechi with horns drawn on. Noooooo. Original character design is my passion.



The people that picked up on Shoji side-eyeing Katsuki during the twin rescue were SPOT ON

Also, me? Put in a love triangle to put MORE jealousy and hurt in Katsuki's and Izuku's relationship? I would NEVER 👀

For those of you still reading - literally I'm just so FLOORED. Despite the fact that I'm really awful at responding to comments because i'm so fucking embarrassing and don't want to just keysmash all over your inboxes (funny enough i actually have a hard time expressing...uhhhhhh myself with words) I read them over and over and over and over again and CRY because, like, shit, you're giving this a chance and taking time out of your day to say nice words to a weirdo on the internet who, frankly, shouldn't be putting her entire heart and soul and pussy into a anime-boy fanfiction, but here we fucking are lmao ANYWAY. ANYWAY.

I LOVE YOU SO MUCH. see you next month.

Chapter 18

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Katsuki lingers outside the courthouse, leaning against the wall, staring off at nothing. He refuses to be the first back in the room, to duck and hide and take cover. So he stands out here in the open where each disgusted civilian, each shocked hero can see him and hurl whatever insult they need to help themselves sleep at night. It doesn't matter. Katsuki's hands don't so much as sweat as a furious looking civilian spits at his feet before entering the courtroom.

This utter platitude, this *indifference* is foreign. Uncomfortable. His body, his mind, his heart weren't built to be this empty – he has, from the start of his life, been bursting at the seams. With rage, with pride, with the will to fight, with passion, obsession, fuck, even devastation. But now he feels nothing at all.

It almost makes him miss the all-encompassing despair.

He stands a little straighter as a taxi stops in front of the building, letting out two twin girls from the back, a taller, older looking woman emerging from the front seat. She looks to be the mirror image of the twins, matching jet black bob haircut and all – leaving the impression that maybe her daughters might have been intentionally styled to be mini-versions of her and not the other way around. She waves the girls over to her with a harsh formality and points towards the building.

It doesn't take long for them to notice him.

"Oh! Mr. Dynamight! Hello!"

Before Katsuki could respond, the older woman in front of them picks up her pace. He doesn't budge as she enters his personal space and doesn't move as, in slow motion, she picks up her finely manicured hand and, without an ounce of hesitation *SMACK!*s it across his cheek.

Katsuki barely feels it – the tiny sting on his face incomparable to the persistent layer of pain constantly plaguing his body. He fights a weird instinct to react, to flinch, to voice something – a way to placate the woman, show her that she accomplished what she wanted to, *reward* her in a way. There's no satisfaction in trying to hurt someone and having no effect. No relief of that persistent itch for violence, for release if they don't so much as flinch.

Katsuki knows that better than anyone.

So he stays stoic, not so much twitching a muscle, meeting the woman's dark eyes as he feels his face reddening from the contact.

It's not what she expected – he can see in the miniscule narrowing of her pupils.

"How COULD you? You're supposed to be a hero! You're supposed to *protect* them!"

"MOM! STOP – what the hell?!" One of the twins – Hikari, Katsuki recognizes from the persistent tingling in his skin at the girl's proximity - furiously grabs her mother's hand, squeezing it tight. "We explained what happened! He *asked* us –"

“That *thing,*” she nearly spits the word, and for the first time in the last 30 minutes, Katsuki feels a spark of rage in his chest. “Should not be asking *minors* to help him commit felonies! And you just let him go?! How could you?!”

She redirects her fiery gaze back to Katsuki.

“I trust him,” he responds simply.

“That’s not enough!” she yells, shaking her head. She grabs her daughters’ hands, the two mouthing ‘sorry’ as they enter the courtroom.

Katsuki tastes the words on his tongue.

“…Then what is?” he wonders aloud.

Trust isn’t some intangible, involuntary, subjective thing like love or friendship. Trust is earned. Its built. Its separate from *emotion* for Katsuki. It’s the highest honor he can bestow on someone.

What kept him coming back, what let him free in that warehouse, what let the man sleep in his bed, what spared him an ultimately death when he broke into Katsuki’s study – it was that trust. And even though it might be foolish – the trust remains.

He has to trust Zero. He has to trust Deku. He has to trust that this was all for something – that there was a meaning, a purpose to all this pain. He has to. He doesn’t know any other way to live.

He re-enters the building, eyes fixed to his seat towards the front of the courtroom. He barely makes it a step in before a soft hand is gripping for his nitroglycerin-soaked one. Katsuki recoils – *no one touches his hands, they’re dangerous, murderer*, *murderer, MURDERER* – glancing upwards to meet tear-filled baby-browns. It takes him a second to process those eyes connected to pink cheeks hollowed out by age connected to the bob she’s let grow out to past her shoulders. *She’s older*, Katsuki realizes with some semblance of surprise. He’s not entirely sure he’s recognize her without her hero costume on, which leaves an oddly bitter taste in his mouth.

“Bakugou, why did you keep this from us? If you knew he was alive – we could have helped you – we could have – “

She squeezes his palm harder, trying to say something with the touch that she’s not saying with her mouth. Even though she’s speaking in a near whisper, Katsuki can’t ignore the way the civilians turn towards them, leaning in to catch a whiff of their conversation. It’s just what they’re hoping for – confirmation that the heroes are only looking out for their own, that they would have let the kidnapper vigilante run free if only given Katsuki’s same opportunity.

Katsuki averts his eyes. There’s good answers to this. He wanted to protect Deku’s identity. He knows how flighty he is – if more people knew or wanted to be involved, he might have abandoned the whole mission. He didn’t want to involve more people in case shit went south and caused more casualties.

But it's more than that. The dirty, sludge-filled part of Katsuki’s heart didn’t want anyone else to have him. He spent too long watching Pink Cheeks smile and touch Deku during high school, spent too long seeing the way he looked at her, the way she made him smile. Deku’s even confirmed that he avoided her specifically – her, Iida and Todoroki, at least – to ensure his desire to be remembered didn’t out his disguise. At least on a mental level, Deku had already placed those three in higher importance than Katsuki.

But this – Zero - is something he had over them.

"…If he was the kidnapper of the Shiryoku twins… the person you called the distress signal on – " Katsuki's pulse skyrockets as he twists his head to see a significantly less sympathetic Iida behind Uraraka

"…No." Uraraka lets go of his hand instantly, taking a step back.

"…Bakugou, did you call that distress signal to *hurt* Deku? Did we… oh my god, did we hurt him?" Uraraka turns to Iida, asking for him to dispute her question, but he simply closes his eyes and shakes his head. When he opens them again, he's looking at Katsuki no differently than he looked at Zero that night on the roof.

A monster.

"Everyone, please be seated. We're ready to get court back in session."

Katsuki maintains his eye contact with Iida, flashing back to Uraraka to give them their wordless answer.

He doesn't care if they hate him. He could scream excuses – *he lied to me, he fucked me, he left me, he deserves to be hurt, why can't you understand?!* – but he doesn't. It doesn't matter to him what they think. It's not like he's under any impression that he was in the right. It was a shitty, cruel thing to do. But so was pretty much everything that Zero had done since Katsuki first set his sights on him. Which leaves them exactly nowhere – par for the course.

Katsuki takes even steps, scooting over a Kirishima that won't make eye contact with him to a Aizawa who is giving him a tight glare. Only Shinso, on the other side of his former teacher, offers something half-encouraging with a half shrug, like silently saying *Mondays, amirite?* It shouldn't comfort Katsuki, but in a weird way, it does.

The twins stand with their backs to Katsuki, side by side in the booth, one hand each on the book in front of them. They remain quiet, spines straight, chins held high.

The bastard commission lawyer – Haiyu-san - saunters up to them, that fake sympathetic smile marring his average face.

"Hikari and Senko Shiryoku, thank you two for coming on such short notice. I cannot diminish the absolute crucial role you two play in this case." Haiyu turns to the audience. "Through no fault of their own, these *children* - How old are you two?" He stops, turning towards the girls, condescending tone blatant.

"Fifteen," the two girls don't hesitate, eyes sharpening on the smooth-talking lawyer.

"These *children* were involved in Izuku Midoriya's reckless plot. Is it correct to say that you were involved in the Twin Sequencing Case as two of the victims, and later on were kidnapped by an… *unknown*… assailant." Haiyu-san emphasizes the word unknown with a flick of the corners of his lips, deepening his voice like he's setting up a shitty joke. Katsuki feels his jaw click.

"That is correct." Senko answers, glancing at her sister.

"How very terrifying and unfortunate. Can you tell us what happened at the moment you had your blood collected?"

"…It's all a bit of a blur. Our friend… at least, a girl we thought was our friend, lured us in an alley after school. Something was wrong with her eyes – they looked like a snake's eyes and she wasn't acting like herself. Then she did something that made us both pass out. We woke up shortly after. We didn't find any scars or other damage anywhere… we didn't even know something had really happened until the police showed up telling us they found our blood samples along with a bunch of other people's… We haven't heard much more since then." Hikari shrugs.

"And was this before or after the defendant kidnapped you?"

"It was before…" Senko starts, but Hikari cuts her off.

"He didn't *kidnap* us. He asked us if he can have our help as bait to lure out the person who was doing the experiments on the twins. We agreed because we wanted to *help – "*

There's a pause as the audience starts to murmur in the background. That asshole Haiyu has the gall to act surprised, shoulders tensing before he rolls them back.

"This is a different statement than you gave the police. In this report," the man walks to his desk, pulling out a stack of papers that Katsuki isn't so sure have actual words on them but act as a prop for the judges, smacking them with one hand. Just for the sake of showmanship he grabs a pair of gold-rimmed glasses and places them low on the bridge of his nose, pretending to read the document in front of him. "…You noted that you had no memory of the kidnapping or of the person that committed it."

Everyone waits for the inevitable question.

"…Did you lie when you testified to the police?" Haiyu's voice is sharp, accusatory, and Katsuki sees the girls' mother twitch in the bench behind them.

"No." They answer simultaneously, easily, the truth-infused book beneath their hands glowing a soft blue.

"…So you two are openly testifying to aiding a vigilante, willingly, in his crimes?" Haiyu's tone switches from fake-sincere to predatory, and their mother jumps to her feet.

"Judges! What he's accusing the girls of is ridiculous – they're fifteen! They're minors! They didn't know what they were agreeing to – "

"Neither did he!" Senko and Hikari's voices sound shrill, quieting the entire courtroom as they turn towards Deku. They speak again as if directly to him, and he keeps his eyes trained on them, wide and glossy.

"He was just a year older than us! The Commission approved of him uprooting and sacrificing his own life – the entire hero society said it was okay for kids our age to risk everything to capture this villain just a few years ago – why is it wrong for us to do it? We could *help* – no one else could or would, so we stepped up! That's what a hero would do!"

"How are we different? How was our choice okay but his a crime?" Senko cries out.

No one responds. Katsuki takes a deep breath, something warm in his gut bordering on pride threatening to crawl out of him in the form of a smile. The air lightens around Katsuki – Kirishima taps him lightly on the thigh, eyebrows raised in apology. Katsuki just juts his chin down – a silent understanding.

“Commission Judge #1.”

Katsuki raises his eyes to the commission judge, his bespectacled ugly-ass face shining with sweat under the fluorescent lights, his little green-colored #1 placard raised for the whole room to see.

He clears the phlegm out of his throat before he speaks. “And exactly how can both of those statements be true? That you didn’t lie when you made the initial statement and that you’re not lying now?”

The twins turn to one another, mouths tight. Katsuki glances at Shinso who seems to have made the same realization.

“…Fuck.” He murmurs out, before pulling back his shoulders, allowing his back to crack. Then, he stands, wordless, as the rest of the court turns their eyes towards him.

“…And who exactly are you?” The commission judge asks, eyes full of vitriol. On the other hand, next to Deku, Akuma seems to be absolutely overjoyed, eyes glowing a mischievous red – like this is exactly what he wanted. Like this was exactly the outcome he had expected.

“…Shinso Hitoshi. I’m the reason they remembered what happened. I’d like to ask permission to come to the stand.”

The mustachioed referee waits for any protest – with the courtroom silent, he nods.

“Come forward.”

The girls both nod towards Shinso as he approaches them. The two sit next to their mother, but not too close, ardently avoiding her evil eye as they meld into each other, true united front.

Akuma stands up immediately as Shinso approaches at the podium, smile playing on his lips.

“Shinso Hitoshi. Hero Name: Minderaser. Former General Studies student, transferred into the Hero Course during his second year into class A as a replacement for Izuku Midoriya. Is that correct?”

“…I wouldn’t say replacement.” Shinsho murmurs, rubbing the back of his neck sheepishly.

“…Ah! Of course. Full disclosure, before anyone in the Commission tries to hurriedly find a way to derail this testimony by trying to connect us outside this courtroom, Shinsho-kun and myself were both in U.A.’s General Studies course. I was a third year when he was a first year. We had not interacted before this moment. Is that correct?”

He’s lying. Katsuki can feel it in his very bones, from Akuma’s sleek smile to the evenness on Shinso’s face.

Shinso’s hand is on the book.

“No.”

The book glows blue. Everyone continues – but Katsuki, along with Jirou and Shoji – can tell the subtle difference.

He didn’t use *his* voice.

Katsuki processes it in parallel to Deku, whose own eyes give away the realization. The Book of Truth must work on voice – and with such a short, quiet answer, particularly with that specific question (he could be imitating the voice of any one of his other male classmates when he was a first year in general studies, and no one would be wiser) – no one questions it.

Which leaves Katsuki with two questions. 1.) Why risk asking something like that in the beginning, with the full knowledge that there are people with hearing-based Quirks in this room? And 2.) How/Why had the two 'interacted' that such a lie is necessary in court?

Akuma continues like nothing happened. "Can you explain the way your Quirk works, Shinso-kun?"

"…My Quirk is Mind Control. I am able to control people if they respond to a question I ask. They are awoken from the control with some physical stimulus."

No mention of the Persona Chords. But also not technically a lie.

"…And what kinds of things can you control individuals to do?" Akuma asks, playful lilt in his voice, utterly inappropriate for the situation.

"…I can make people perform simple tasks. Its more… complex than that. I essentially can control different parts of the brain when I am using my Quirk. Including the memory cortex."

Akuma half-closes his eyes, humming out in interest. Katsuki glances around, confused why no one else seems to feel the very… unusual aura coming off the two. It sounds like they're on a freakin' coffee date rather than the middle of a courtroom.

"And why would addressing the memory cortex be important for the Shiryoku twins?"

"…Because they were affected by a memory-based Quirk. They do not remember the interactions with Midoriya-kun, but the events still happened; the memories are simply suppressed. Pruned and poorly connected. I am able to bring them to the forefront."

"…And that is what you did." Akuma says, matter-of-factly.

Shinso nods. "That's what I did."

Katsuki feels his heart jump into his throat. Against his better judgement, he turns his eyes to Deku, who is already staring right back at him. He purses his lips – still clearly furious, jaw tight, but eyes undergoing a slurry of emotions.

He shakes his head slightly, pleading, asking the question he must already know the answer to – *did he? Did you?* - and Katsuki's returns the plea with a stab to the gut in the shape of a nod.

I remember. I remember everything. Bastard. Liar. Asshole. Fucking die.

He watches his single hand grip hard against the table, exhaling sharply from his mouth, enough to earn him a panicked look from Todoroki who rapidly follows Deku's eyes to Katsuki in the stands. Todoroki's fingers twitch over Deku's shoulder – whether to comfort the other or himself, Katsuki doesn't know – but a sick satisfaction twists in his gut that Todoroki can offer him neither as the hand retreats behind his back.

Hit after hit after hit. Katsuki fucked his best friend, Deku made him forget that blubbering heart-bearing confession when he begged the other fucker to call him Kacchan and the other complied and got his rocks off like the sadistic bastard he is. It's like they're beating the shit out of one another in

real time, and no one else can see it. Katsuki wishes he had something to show for it, at least. A bruise. A busted lip. Anything at all except the unstoppable gushing from the wound in his heart that won't fucking *stop*.

He's hemorrhaging in this courtroom in real time and all these bastards are none the wiser.

"Ignoring the fact that you used your Quirk on civilians outside your jurisdiction, why, outside your country of licensure…" Haiyu starts, voice low. Aizawa flinches, but Shinso gives nothing away in his expression. "…What exactly is this 'memory' Quirk and how are you aware of it?"

"Excuse me, Arbiter, but I believe this is a leading question and paints Shinso-kun in a negative light. If I may remind the rest of the court of the Hero Commission's own Order 54 – citizens may use their Quirk in the event that not using it will cause another irreparable harm. You would never ask for an individual with a healing Quirk not to use their Quirk on someone who got hurt. The same applies here."

"So you agree, Akuma-kun. Causing individuals not to remember their own lives or actions can be a cause of irreparable harm?" Haiyu smiles politely.

Katsuki can see Deku flinch, doubling over. Another hit. This one straight to the sternum. He hopes it fucking hurts. He hopes it never stops hurting.

"Order in the court. Akuma-san's objection sustained. One question at a time. We are not here to prosecute Shinso Hitoshi."

"Right. A job for the American branch of the World Hero Commission – which will certainly be hearing about your participation in this trial, Shinso-san."

Shinso's face doesn't move. He just keeps staring at the two judges with bored eyes. Kaminari appears to be panicking enough for everyone in the room, head dashing back and forth between Shinso, then Aizawa, then Deku, legs bouncing obviously under the table.

"Now, per my colleagues' request, let me re-phrase the question. How were you aware of the Quirk Izuku Midoriya used to alter people's memories?"

Shinso pauses. "I've… encountered it before."

"So you've encountered Midoriya during his vigilante spree."

"…Incorrect. I encountered it when it belonged to the previous owner."

"…Wait, the previous owner?"

"Does this mean…?"

"That's impossible!"

The whispers get louder with each passing second and Haiyu, that asshole, lets it get nearly rowdy before he speaks again, voice boisterous.

"Ah! So you're reporting that Izuku Midoriya stole this Quirk from someone."

"I don't believe there's a law against that, Haiyu-san." Akuma starts, but Shinso cuts him off.

“Just like you said. Order 54 – citizens may use their Quirk in the event that not using it will cause another irreperable harm. The previous owner of Forget-Me-Not was a rapist and a murderer that avoided capture by the police due to his Quirk for years. Midoriya taking it from him saved many people. I was on the case. I saw what that monster did. I made people *remember* what he did to them.”

The first blip of emotion crosses Shinso’s impassive face, and Katsuki’s stomach churns.

“But of course. And how many other violent criminals walk the streets with Quirks that wouldn’t serve Izuku Midoriya quite so well? Why is he allowed to decide who gets to keep their Quirk – a very facet of their being – and who has to lose theirs? A person with that kind of thought process must think himself a God.”

“There is some truth in that statement – Haiyu-san, was it?”

The boisterous voice coming from the back of the room, accompanied by the loud opening of the door, commands attention – leading all heads to turn to the blinding light now showering the courtroom. The sun must be on its way to setting, perfectly level with the open door, washing out the silhouettes of the individuals entering the room.

Even so… Katsuki’s eyes widen – he could recognize that voice anywhere.

“Obtaining additional Quirks, particularly from violent villains, didn’t serve Young Midoriya well because there was always the chance that Young Shigaraki would be able to take the Quirk and use it against him or others. Everything he added to the pool always had the chance of being redirected to his enemy. So he did just the opposite.”

The doors swing closed behind the group, and there he stands in all his glory. Skeletal, apparently still in procession of that god-awful yellow pinstripe suit yet carrying such a strong aura around him that the room collectively holds their breaths at the sight of him. Behind the widely smiling All Might follow people – about a dozen of them, different ages, races, genders, forms.

The only one Katsuki really recognizes is that crazy cat-lady – *Ragdoll,* Katsuki’s brain supplies.

Before he’s able to fully process what’s happening, Akuma is standing up, making a T-shape with his hand.

“I would like to request a five-minute recess to discuss the case with the new arrival!”

“…Agreed.” Arbitrer can’t seem to take his eyes off All Might. Despite him being both the Symbol of Peace and the Symbol of Lost Peace in the past four years, anyone alive during All Might’s reign still can’t help but be star-struck at the sight of him. A God that decides to walk among humans doesn’t become less of a God.

Katsuki nearly scrambles out of his seat, making a beeline straight for All Might, Akuma getting to him before the former reaches his teacher.

“Come with me,” Akuma states, grabbing All Might’s sleeve. Katsuki follows behind, but Akuma stops him with his hand pressed against his chest, voice darkening. “Not you.” In this proximity, Katsuki can see the nails on Akuma’s hand are unusually long and sharp, and the way they’re poised on his chest looks like they’re ready to pierce his tender skin and claw at his heart at any second.

“I’m part of this!” Katsuki hisses back, making a motion to swap the impromptu-weapon away from him.

“I *know.* I’m trying to make sure you don’t go down with Midoriya, you idiot! It’s the only thing he asked of me, so stop being a jackass and let me do my fucking job!”

Katsuki stands back, stunned, as that sugar-sweet voice becomes a nearly demonic growl, eyes glowing a threatening red.

Somewhere between being furious, Katsuki still finds something disgustingly warm spread in his stomach. That fucking idiot. He glances to Izuku, still sitting at that desk, mouth tight as Todoroki tries to say something to him.

He’s still thinking of Katsuki and his safety, even now.

Even when they’re trading blows.

Even when they’re at each other’s throats.

Even when they’re trying to destroy each other, they’re still trying to save each other.

All beautiful things eventually ruin you, and Deku? He’s the most goddamn breathtaking thing Katsuki’s ever seen.

Katsuki keeps his eyes on Deku as he makes his way back to his seat. He wants so desperately for him to look up, to meet his eyes, he needs it as much as he needs a knife to the throat, a bullet to the gut, he needs it to heal him and break him and hurt him. He needs their special brand of tender violence, needs to be filled to the brim with it. It’s the only thing that makes sense right now.

“Bakugou?” Kirishima nudges him. Katsuki shakes his head, finally breaking the one-sided staring contest, looking back to his friend. “Hey, what do you think he meant with saying he ‘did just the opposite?’ Who are all these people, man? This is freaky.”

Katsuki examines each unfamiliar face; some are speaking in languages he doesn’t recognize, most looking at Deku with an odd sense of reverence, until he lands on the cat-looking woman in the front of the room.

What was her name? Ragdoll? Wasn’t her Quirk… stolen? By One for All?

But you don’t know exactly when or where.

I used to. I always used to know where he was. But that couldn’t last forever.

“Five minute recess is over. Court is back in session,” Arbitrer states, and the few that moved during the short break obediently find their way to their seats. All Might’s presence magically clears a front bench, a dozen citizens standing in the back of the room so the thin man can comfortably sit, laying his cane on his lap, directing whoever else can find a seat to join him. Many remain standing, yet not a single face appeared uncomfortable – more set eyebrows, tight fists, determined expressions – all facing Deku with a type of reverence Katsuki would normally only reserve for All Might.

Katsuki watches All Might’s face, hoping his expression betrays whatever the old man has planned. Last he checked, neither his or AIzawa’s phones went off. There was no warning when or where the fucker might show – but he’s got a talent for making an entrance, and bringing all these people with him? He’s got something under his sleeve – something *good* if that persistent sparkle in his sunken eyes says anything.

“I would like to call Tomoro Shiretoko to the stand, please.” Akuma’s soft voice rings out. The cat-woman – Ragdoll – stands up from her spot next to Toshinori Yagi, smoothing her dress before approaching the stand. She places a hand on the book, glancing briefly at Deku before re-focusing on Akuma.

“Tomoko Shiretoko, Hero Name: Ragdoll. You are part of the Wild, Wild Pussycats and were active in the hero community until a bit over four years ago. Is that correct?”

She nods. “That’s right.”

Akuma turns to the entire courtroom, making his voice morose for the audience. “And why exactly did you stop active hero work at that time?”

Her head droops slightly. “…At the Training Camp Incident… when the League attacked the class 1A and B students…” she pauses, voice tight.

Katsuki feels his own chest constrict, ghostly fingers encroaching around his neck at the mere mention. The smell of smoke, blue fire, screaming, *Stay back,* its still so fresh, so vibrant in his memory that Katsuki can hardly believe the timeline. Over four years ago? Maybe to them. To him, it keeps fucking happening – night after night after goddamn night.

Stay back. Stay back. Stay back.

Deku.

“My teammates and I were trying to protect the children. Myself and… Bakugou Katsuki…. Were taken by the League.” Katsuki feels eyes dart to him, accusatory, as if asking him why the fuck he keeps coming up in this story.

He’d love to have an answer. He grips at the underside of his chair, working hard not to melt the plastic under his fingers. Kirishima offers him what should be a comforting shoulder bump and sad smile. *Therapy,* his eyes seem to say. Katsuki grunts in response.

“Around that time, I believe All for One took… my Quirk, Search, away from me.”

And then he gave it to Tomura Shigaraki.

And then Tomura Shigaraki found them, among the thousands fleeing in Daika City.

And then, Katsuki got turned into a human shishkabob by the bastard.

And then, Deku, knowing full fucking well that Shigaraki knew where he was at all times, ran away.

And then…

Four years passed.

For no logical reason at all, absolute vitriol floods Katsuki’s senses. He’s never hated this stupid cat-bitch more. He’s never hated someone for having a Quirk that put Deku in danger. Never hated someone more for not being able to stop All for One. She was supposed to protect them. She was

supposed to help. Instead, she put everyone in danger. She put Deku in danger. Her Quirk took him away. *She* took him away.

Katsuki exhales sharply. Blaming her is foolish. He knows he just wants someone to blame. Fuck, none of this would even be an issue if Deku didn't accidentally give away their location by sharing a Quirk with All for One. Which wouldn't be an issue if All Might didn't give Deku that cursed Quirk in the first place. Which wouldn't be an issue if Deku didn't try to save Katsuki's life. Which wouldn't be an issue if Katsuki wasn't such a fucking pathetic, weak bastard that the Quirkless kid he used to bully decided to jump in to try to save him from a D Tier villain –

Katsuki bites into his cheek hard, trying to stop the spiraling thoughts. Not the time or the place for another pity party – not when he's got a whole-ass pity parade to plan for.

"But… um. I woke up a few weeks ago, *mew,* and…" The whole room instantly quiets as the woman looks down on her hands, flexing the fingertips as if confirming they're real.

"…And it was *back.*"

The judges explode into action, two of the civilians standing, eyes wide, Mirko's jaw dropped, Kaminari grinning like a mad-man, and each court-appointed judge exchanging extremely confused glances as they yell out their questions with no semblance of organization.

"How is that possible?"

"What are you implying?"

"Isn't that just because Shigaraki was captured?"

"Please, everyone. If I may continue," Akuma says in his sugary voice, somehow evoking a hush across the courtroom.

"Lucky for us, we have a very direct way to find the answer to all of your questions. To find out how you got your Quirk back, if you will." Akuma smiles and Ragdoll nods, swallowing audibly.

Shinso gets up from his seat without prompting. He stands next to Akuma in front of the woman.

"Would you like to remember how you got you Quirk back?" Shinso asks, and Ragdoll grins at him.

"Definitely!"

Her body slumps over, eyes dull, completely motionless.

"Remember how you got your quirk back and tell it to everyone in this room," Shinso orders. Almost immediately, her monotone voice rings out.

"He came to me. The tall boy with the metallic arm. He thanked me… and then he touched my forehead and I felt it *back.*"

"… Was it the man in the defendant's chair? Izuku Midoriya?"

Ragdoll smiles. "He had a different haircut and contacts in, but yes. It was him. He didn't tell me his name, but I knew. The Quirk knows him. I remember him. I could never forget that boy."

Shinso lightly taps her on the hand and Ragdoll jerks awake, looking around, blinking several times before her eyes settle back on Izuku, staring down at that table.

“Midoriya. …I was so happy. Thank you.”

The dozen or so others around All Might all stand, and the room is a cacophony of voice, of light, of smells. Bubbles, a small ray of light, an elegant tune, several more Quirks joyfully displayed in front of Deku as they all voice their joy, tears in their eyes, all in separate languages but their message crystal clear.

Only All Might remains seated, but he looks like he’s on a verge of crying himself, face wide and proud.

He was giving them back.

He spent the past few years traveling the world, giving people their Quirks *back.*

A sense of awe overcomes Katsuki.

This is why. This must have been why Shigaraki seemed to go down so easy, why the Electron-Positron Annihilation didn’t destroy the whole planet, why the few Quirks that he couldn’t ‘give away’ to the previous owners he ‘stored’ in the twins. He truly weakened them both as much as possible while trying to undo the damage that All for One did.

“My goodness! Izuku Midoriya isn’t only a hero – he’s a modern-day Robin Hood! He took from the villain – the thief who stole people’s Quirks, their livelihoods, their joy – and returned it.”

“…That’s. Unbelievable. He… returned them?”

“Even though it could have made him weaker?”

Katsuki can’t help but stare at Deku, the latter’s cheeks pinkening at the praise as he keeps his eyes directed to the desk, not so much as showing a smile.

This is who he is, isn’t he?

An invisible person.

Refusing to be acknowledged. Undoing generations worth of oppression, of fear, of thievery and strife. A good man who tried to return to others what he knew he’d never get to have himself.

Izuku Midoriya loves Quirks, and he made his life mission to return those that have been taken, even if it left him with nothing. *Knowing* it would leave him with nothing.

“His victory was not in that he grew stronger, had more powerful Quirks. His victory lay in that he intentionally weakened himself. His strength was within his weakness. Shigaraki did not know how to fight, how to live with nothing. Izuku Midoriya did.” Akuma turns to Izuku.

“Those that compare you to All for One could not be more wrong. You are – you always have been – the embodiment of the name of your Quirk. One for All. You gave everything to others, expecting nothing in return. I’d like to thank you as well.”

The mood in the room shifts – almost visibly. The citizens holding up signs asking for Deku’s execution lower them slowly, seemingly embarrassed. Anyone putting themselves in the shoes of a

person whose Quirk was stolen – the very real horror story that parents told their children at night – could understand the joy the individuals who, years after having a part of themselves taken away – had it returned by a stranger in the night.

Whispers sound cautiously hopeful, almost *excited.* It's far from over – but Katsuki can see the turn of the tide with just the reactions of the civilians in the room. Everything is being shown of live television in all of Japan.

The wave of hope is spreading, and that stupid green-haired moron is Groud Zero of it all.

"… Very well. Thank you for your testimonies. It is now five o'clock. Court will re-start the session tomorrow at 9am. Please prepare the rest of your material. Judges, you will be escorted to your court-appointed barracks."

Katsuki's head swivels around. He glances up at the clock on the wall, unable to believe that eight hours have already passed. No one else appears quite as surprised – Kirishima, Ashido, Utsushimi, Aizawa and Shinso get up around him. He can't help it – he finds Inko in the crowd. She meets his eyes instantly, like she was waiting for him to look over, and tilts her head in a half-smile. She turns away, making her way towards the door, not lingering behind to take a final look at her son.

He doesn't know how she can look away. He keeps himself seated, waving the rest of his companions forward until he's the last in the front rows, left alone, a beacon signal for Deku's attention. The latter stands up, Todoroki giving him ample room to turn without them touching.

And, just like Katsuki hoped and feared, Deku raises his head towards him. Looks him straight in the eye and doesn't turn away, even as he's directed towards the back exit by his bodyguards.

With raised eyebrows and he most disgustingly sincere eyes Katsuki's ever seen, Izuku Midoriya takes his hand and places it on his chest. His cracked lips curve into a sad smile dripping with unspoken words. And Katsuki, for a reason he doesn't understand, mimics the movement back.

A hand, his right, over his own heart. He feels it pulsing under his fingertips – *alive, alive, so tragically fucking alive* – and for a second he wants to believe its his. The heart in the chest he's placed his ear on in the darkness of the night, the heart within that trembling ribcage, the heart that he can feel in the lips of the other each time they kiss. For a second, they don't feel so far away.

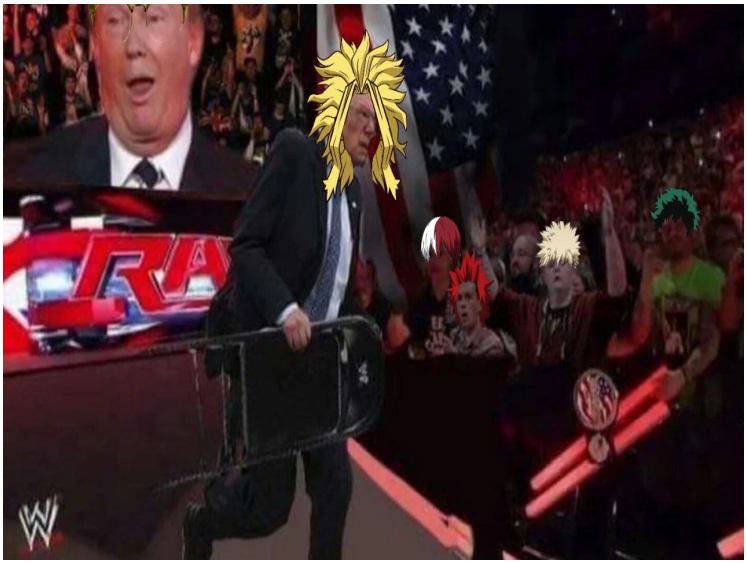
For a second, it feels like they've never been apart at all.

Chapter End Notes

Haiyu, a fucking asshole:



Us: Oh shit the commission lawyer has the upper hand, Deku's fucked and...wait. What was that? ITS ALL MIGHT WITH A STEEL CHAIR!



Izuku, as soon as he figured out that he doesn't have to keep the Quirks he steals:



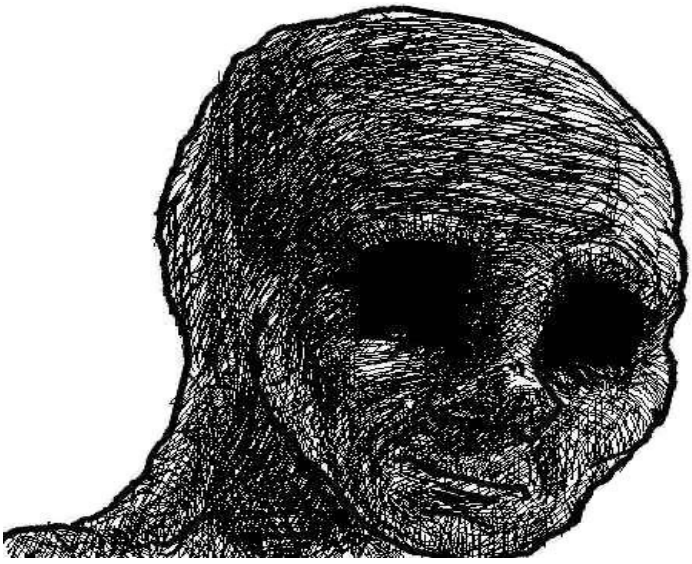
WHO GUESSED OUR BOY WAS TRAVELING THE WORLD IN ORDER TO RETURN THE STOLEN QUIRKS?!

I originally wanted this to be the big reveal at the very END of the Trial Arc, but it felt much more natural here - to soften the blow against Izuku and allow his final statement, the final battle and Katsuki's, Kirishima's, Ashido's and Utsushimi's statements to have the most impact. That said, Chap 19 will be the last chapter of the Trial Arc (and it's already half-way done, so expect it sometime this week!!!) We're on track to have probably 23-25 chapters total. Anna, you might ask. How are you gonna save this train-wreck?! Great question lol can't wait to find out with you.

Chapter 19

Chapter Notes

Me Publishing Chap 18, 3K words into Chap 19: haha nice! i'm halfway done with the next chapter
Me Today, Publishing 17K words of the most depressing shit I have ever written:



I don't usually say this about my own writing, but if you're not in a good mental headspace, I would avoid this for a bit.

(But if you love pain and suffering come on in babey!)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

‘In a fascinating turn of events, Toshinori Yagi - better known as All Might – joined the proceedings today, completely flipping the trial on its head!’

‘That man certainly knows how to make an entrance!’

‘That he does! And with him came about a dozen individuals, each of which claims that they had their Quirk, previously stolen by All for One, returned to them by the accused – Midoriya Izuku. Many outlets are claiming that this testimony may be the turning point of this trial. We have Soda Kichiro, professor of Hero Law with Tokyo University and Yano Michi, representative of the National Diet involved in the re-structuring policies governing Professional Heroes in Japan here with us to discuss these results.’

‘Thank you for the introduction, Takemoto-san. What people appear to be losing sight of is that Izuku Midoriya’s case thus far has been built on elevating his character. But the trial is not about whether he’s a ‘nice person’ or whether he used his Quirk in the ‘best possible way.’ The trial is about Izuku Midoriya using his Quirk to carry out his version of justice. What is the purpose of laws and government, ones which were established to protect the populace, if one powerful individual is able to bypass them? This takes away the agency of the Japanese citizen and should not be condoned.’

‘I apologize for my interruption, Yano-san, but I must disagree with you. Izuku Midoriya’s actions exactly uphold the very laws you have designed, because their explicit intention was to get rid of the only true threat to said laws. In addition, the Shiryoku twins and all of those with their returned Quirks reported that they gave consent prior to assisting Izuku Midoriya. Rather than controlling individuals with his power, he was assisting them.’

‘But that points out the factor that not a single one of these individuals remembered giving consent. Which only proves that they were under the effect of a Quirk during these moments – a Quirk that no longer exists. And even if it wasn’t a Quirk effect – is a consent forgotten true consent? I’d argue that it is not. This is manipulation at its finest. They may have consented to assisting him, but not to having their minds and perception of the world around them altered. Its likely no coincidence that these ‘lost memories’ work in Midoriya’s favor.’

‘Of course – because he recognized himself as a theoretical danger to civilians. In my opinion, utilizing a memory Quirk is quite genius, as it prevented individuals he came in contact with from threat of interrogation by the League of Villains while also continuing to do as much good as possible for said individuals. The results speak for themselves! Hundreds of returned Quirks, the children on the island unharmed, and Shigaraki behind bars. Within these last four years, we have no idea how many lives this young man might have saved!’

‘Or how many lives he might have ended!’

“This is so fucking stupid,” Katsuki comments. His hand rests on the remote, thumb directly over the Power button. It would take the tiniest flicker of muscle. But he doesn’t move. There’s something surreal hearing TV personalities discussing Deku’s morality – especially because his own head is so fucked up on how to feel about, well. Deku’s morality. A part of him hopes that these debates will help him form his own conclusion – but all they’re doing right now creating a big-ass migraine and a goddamn stomach ulcer.

“No matter what shit Deku does, the Commission is always going to have the same argument of why he should be behind bars. I don’t see why him returning Quirks is such a big fuckin’ deal.”

“Think about it. Quirks are just as intrinsic to people as their organs. Our entire society, economy, educational system, law system – the whole planet – works on Quirks. Suddenly becoming Quirkless is every person’s worst nightmare. So imagine meeting this beautiful, nameless, faceless *angel* – a man traveling the world, granting Quirks onto the Quirkless, generously giving away that which he will never have himself. Expecting nothing in return. Throw in a robe and some flowing locks and you’ve got yourself a brand new *messiah.* People eat that shit up.”

“Sure. Deku’s the second fuckin’ coming.” Katsuki grunts, glaring at Shinso - who has made himself *very* much at home, sprawled out on Katsuki’s couch like a spoiled cat.

“Get him alone in a room with me and Midoriya’s gonna have a third com – “

Katsuki grabs one of the pillows on the couch, slamming it against Shinso’s torso a little harder than is (probably) warranted, but the purple-haired bastard just starts laughing, not even pretending to defend himself against the onslaught.

‘…Well, now that’s an interesting point. Considering the utter destruction on Minami-Ioto Island, how were all the students left unharmed? It leaves me to think that Izuku Midoriya had assistance.’

‘Indeed! Everyone seems to have forgotten that Katsuki Bakugou – the young man’s former classmate and childhood friend – admitted to letting the accused go when he was apprehended during the

Shiryoku twin kidnapping. My bet is that this goes much deeper into the hero underbelly of Japan – and it all starts with Bakugou Katsuki.'

'Yes! Here is what we know about the illusive Great Explosion Murder God: Dynamight!'

'Hah! That's not his actual name!'

'No, see, it's in the Professional Hero Registrar! I promise!'

Katsuki drops the pillow and stares, slack jawed, at the TV. There he fuckin' is, scowl and all, plastered across the biggest civilian news network in Japan. With these dumb-ass anchors making fun of his frankly badass name, no less.

"You kiddin' me? Isn't the whole point of the Commission's new laws to avoid pro-heroes getting famous?" Katsuki groans, banging his head on the back of the couch.

"You secretly love I – " Shinso jokes, but doesn't have the chance to finish his sentence as his phone starts to ring. Katsuki and him instantly quiet, staring at the device. With exaggerated trepidation, he flips it around to see the screen.

"Shit – it's just Sensei. Sit closer to me, we can Facetime."

"Fuck you, I'm not sitting anywhe-"

"Hey Aizawa-sensei! Oh, Yagi-sensei is with you as well?" Shinso starts, voice and face all feigned politeness. Katsuki fake-gags before he rounds around the couch, looking over Shinso's shoulder. True to his word, Aizawa and Yagi are side by side, only half of each of their respective faces visible. Katsuki can see in real time as Aizawa's scowl turns into a small smirk.

"I see you two are getting along – " he starts.

"Who is getting along with who?! You fuckin' drop this guy on me to babysit like some kind of stray – I have shit going on!" Katsuki raises his voice, wagging his finger at the screen, ignoring the way Shinso is mimicking his words and movements for the camera simultaneously.

"We were just calling to thank Young Shinso for assisting with Ragdoll's testimony today! I truly think it made all the difference. We could not be more grateful."

Even in the dim lighting, Katsuki can see Shinso's cheeks tint pink as he glances away from the phone, mumbling something bashful under his breath.

"…You really had to keep us on the edge of our seats, huh old man?"

Yagi rubs the back of his head, flinching slightly.

"I do apologize, Young Bakugou, for keeping you in the dark. I wasn't sure anyone would come with me to the trial – it was asking a lot from strangers, particularly when they had no memory of the event occurring. It was certainly a risk. I didn't count on my… reputation… still holding such weight."

Katsuki scoffs. Ever the humble type.

"…How did you figure it out? That De - Izuku – was doing all this?"

“The data you sent me – the cities that you believed he had visited… The second I arrived in each… it’s difficult to describe. Like each city was holding a holiday of sorts. Everyone seemed so happy. And there were these whispers, rumors of some kind of Spirit, or God, or Angel that was returning Quirks to individuals. There were shrines, festivals, statues created for them. There was so much… hope. It was a sight to behold.” Yagi’s dark eyes fill slightly with tears and Katsuki can’t help but rolls his eyes, crossing his arms in response.

“You think people.. deifying… Deku isn’t gonna bite him in the ass?”

“Harder to justify throwing someone people consider a ‘saint’ in jail.” Aizawa’s jaw clenches, like he’s on the brink of saying something else, but his shoulders soon droop as he exhales slowly, tone laced with disappointment. “He’ll either be released and be a hero, or remain imprisoned and be a martyr. Either way, the Hero System as we know it isn’t going to be the same.”

“A lot of the outcome will depend on you, Young Bakugou.” Yagi tacks on to the end, staring at the phone screen expectantly, like Katsuki’s supposed to *feel* the eye contact through the shitty smartphone camera.

“On *me?* How?”

“Remember that day in the bunker,” Yagi starts, and Katsuki can very much feel blood rush to his face against his will. *Wrong bunker wrong bunker wrong bunker.*

“Someone needs to make it all makes sense – the inner workings of the Quirk and why Young Midoriya’s actions were necessary on Minami-Ioto Island. I believe you’re the only one who could truly make people understand.”

“I don’t…” Katsuki shakes his head. Most of his life he’s been told to talk *less,* actually. That he’s infinitely more likeable with his mouth shut. So being asked to… *talk*… on national television makes Katsuki’s insides twist in on themselves.

“…You can be surprisingly persuasive.” Aizawa explains. Shinso snorts as his answer, although Katsuki can’t find it in him to dispute Aizawa. After all… considering the events of the last few weeks, he may be right.

“Fuckin’ fine. I’ll think of something.”

Without waiting for a response, turning off the television or saying goodbye, Katsuki walks to his bedroom, shutting the door behind him loudly so no question is left whether his exit was temporary or final. He listens for a second, unable to hear continued conversation. He definitely doesn’t hear lingering footsteps outside his own bedroom.

So it’s safe.

He opens his bedside table, reaching underneath to remove the false bottom. He stares at the empty space that previously held his gun, pushing down the complex slurry of emotion that threaten to ascend up his throat. Instead, he turns his eyes to the new addition. A single notebook, water logged and thick with writing. Campos, Notebook #13.

He sits down on top of his covers, holding the notebook by just his fingertips, some visceral part of him not wanting to touch the thing without gloves on, not wanting to corrode the pages further. The instinct to flip through it, to read a few of the entries, still tickles at the back of Katsuki’s mind, but he ignores it. Instead, he takes an empty back page, turns the notebook around, and starts to work.

He wakes with a start, thick scent of coffee permeating his entire apartment.

“Hey, Bakugou – get up! We’re gonna be late!” Shinso yells through the door. Katsuki sits up in bed, stark still. He slept in his clothes, not even brushing his teeth, several scratched out pieces of notebook paper littering the floor and joining him on his sheets. He eyes the singular piece of paper that seems to have suffered the least of his frustration and folds it up.

“Yo, you hear me?”

“Fuck off! I’m getting changed,” Katsuki yells back. As fast as he can manage - but definitely not fast enough to give Shinso the *satisfaction,* that asshole! - Katsuki changes into fresh clothes and quickly brushes his teeth. He meets Shinso by the door, the other fully dressed and holding out an extra thermos of coffee.

Katsuki grumbles a barely audible *thanks* as he puts his shoes on, snatching the thermos out of the other’s hands.

By the time they make it to the courthouse, their former classmates – namely, Utsushimi, Ashido and Kirishima are all loitering outside the building. Katsuki and Shinso approach their tightly knit circle.

“…What’s going on?” Shinso asks, and the three of them raise their heads in silent acknowledgement.

“Glad you guys are here. Let’s go in,” Kirishima directs, sending Katsuki a panicked glance. He tilts his head to the fences around the entrance of the courtroom. On either side of the fences are crowds of people – protesters, just like yesterday – but something’s different. Katsuki can only truly appreciate the change as he walks between them.

“IZUKU MIDORIYA IS NOT A GOD! HE DOES NOT GET TO MAKE DECISIONS FOR THE CITIZENS OF JAPAN!”

The people to Katsuki’s left are no different than the crowds yesterdays, if not slightly louder. ‘Vigilante’ and ‘Murderer’ and ‘Death Penalty’ signs wave from the sidelines.

“IZUKU MIDORIYA IS OUR SAVIOR! HE’S SALVATION! HE GAVE QUIRKS ONTO THE QUIRKLESS! HE SAVED THE UNSAVEABLE! IZUKU MIDORI – “

The people on Katsuki’s right side, instead of posters, hold up flowers, candles, lighters, their signs predominantly made up of what looks like… television screenshots of Izuku in court, halos drawn around his head.

“Has everyone lost their fucking minds?” Katsuki murmurs under his breath.

“It’s him!”

“Its Katsuki Bakugou!”

“Traitor!”

“Hero!”

“Fuck this,” Katsuki groans as he speed-walks inside the building, too aware of the hundreds of eyes suddenly locked on him. That sensation – having hundreds of eyes burning into his skull – doesn’t dissipate as he takes his seat towards the front of the court.

When the civilian seats are filled, the Arbiter - the man with the mustache who seems to be running the whole thing - opens the door in the back to allow the judges to enter.

The last to come in are the prosecution and, of course, the defendant.

Katsuki's eyes dart to Izuku against his will – like he's got some kind of sixth sense to alert him of the exact moment even a centimeter of him is within visible range. He's in a suit again, crimson tie wrapped around his neck too well to have been done himself. His high cheekbones and sunken eyes start out even more today than yesterday, movements sluggish compared to the two top-shape pro heroes flanking him on either side. As if sensing Katsuki's gaze, Todoroki's eyes leave Izuku's back for just long enough to lock with Katsuki's, then dart back to Izuku, neutral mask slipping to one of careful curiosity.

The Arbiter walks back to the front of the room. He raises his hand for all to see – with a soft blue glow, pages manifest from thin air, wrapping themselves elegantly in a blue cover, landing within his palm. He waits until the book fully manifests before opening it to the final page, his mustache moving comically as he starts to speak.

"The case of Midoriya vs. Hero Commission of Japan, Day Two is now in session. Yesterday's court concluded on the testimony of one Tomoro Shiretoko, Hero Name: Ragdoll." He drags a fat finger along the pages of the book, as if a single person in the courtroom had forgotten. "With the assistance of Shinso Hitoshi, Hero Name: Minderaser, Tomoro-san was able to recollect that the accused, Midoriya Izuku, returned her Quirk. We will start with follow-up questions."

Kaminari throws up his placard so quick you'd think the idiot thought he was on a gameshow.

The Arbiter glances at him. His shoulders visibly droop as he sighs, sounding exhausted already.

"Hero Judge #2. Your question."

He doesn't need to, but Kaminari stands anyway, turning his whole body towards Izuku.

"So that's the reason you left? Without telling us anything? We thought you *died*. We buried you, man."

Kaminari has never looked so serious, eyes a glossy red, voice shaking with its delivery. Despite that, his spine is straight, chin angled, jaw set tight - the very picture of a hero refusing to back down from an invisible fight.

Maybe the feel-good story about 'returning Quirks' might be enough for the citizens of Japan – but for the people who lost him?

For his classmates who mourned him?

For his mother, who wept herself into delirium?

From the moment he left those shitty letters under their room doors to the day they buried his ashes on U.A grounds to the second he was televised across the whole country with bleached blonde hair and handcuffs – they've all been wondering the same damn thing.

Why?

Why did you go?

Why didn't you trust us? Weren't we a team? Why did you take on the world on your own?

The room remains quiet.

Izuku glances to his lawyer, and Akuma gives him a short nod before he turns back to the Arbiter.

"…Permission for Izuku Midoriya to come to the podium."

All heads turn to the defense expectantly. An energy materializes in the air – one of vague excitement, like the previous day was simply an appetizer to build up an appetite for the main event.

Todoroki kneels down, disappearing below the table by Izuku's feet. The sight of Todoroki on his knees in front of Izuku makes his hands sweat, his heart race, each muscle in his hand spasm involuntarily, like his fingers are ready to find their way around Todoroki's lily-white throat. *Get up. Get up, bastard. Don't look at him like that. Don't you dare look at him like…* Katsuki shakes his head out of his rage-filled fugue at the sound of chains dropping on the floor.

Oh. Right. He's cuffed to the table.

Even so, he doesn't miss the way Todoroki looks up at Izuku from below, that blatant display of awe obvious behind that fake impassive expression the bastard always wears. He hates it. He hates it. He can feel it all the way across the room – how does no one else see it? How can no one feel the enormity of Todoroki's desperate desire? It fills the room with its thickness and Katsuki coughs into his fist, pretending it's not choking him up.

Todoroki stands back up, and Katsuki can breathe again.

Izuku gets up, taking unhurried steps towards the podium. He keeps his eyes on the ground to Katsuki's distaste, not so much as looking at him as he turns into the podium, Yaoyorozu and Todoroki taking their positions on either side of him.

Although his back is to Katsuki, Katsuki can read Izuku's mood in the tensing of his muscles, in the way his wrist weakly lifts to just over the Book of Truth, the way his crooked fingers shake before just the fingertips land on the cover, tentatively, as if touching a wild animal you're not so sure won't bite you. His whole body exhales as his hand rests upon the surface in some tentative acceptance.

"…Four years ago." He starts, and goosebumps ascend Katsuki's arms at the sound of his voice. It sounds different than when he last spoke to Katsuki – much more assured, deeper, *older*, and he doesn't know what to do with that realization.

"During the battle in Daika City, Tomura Shigaraki attempted to take One for All from me. But for some reason, he couldn't. Instead, we ended up going to what I assume was… *inside?*... the Quirk? I've seen it before, but I've always been alone. Except this time, Shigaraki and All for One were there *too.* If he could see into my head and I could see into his, I started to think we were… *connected* somehow. Like those stories about twins being able to communicate just through their thoughts or see each other's dreams. And then I wondered how All for One was able to pass his powers onto Shigaraki, when it was supposedly the first user of One for All that held the power to pass on Quirks? There's only two ways it could have worked: if All for One somehow found another Quirk that would allow for the passage of Quirks *or* if this connection somehow allowed for the flow of Quirks between two parties. It's just like Kacch-"

Deku catches himself before he says it, but Katsuki's cheeks pinken anyway.

“Its just like Bakugou-san said yesterday. It would make sense if Shigaraki and I drew from the same ‘power source.’ Plus, when you think about it, All Might and All for One still being able to use the Quirk after passing it on kind of reminds you of, like, a battery, right? Even if you disconnect the power source from the battery, it can still use the power it’s stored up – but I don’t need to store it, because I have a constant flow from that power source. Does… any of what I’m saying make sense?”

Katsuki snickers to himself. His answer is evident in the dozens of blank faces staring back at Deku. There’s something so natural about the nerd ranting, words quickening to be barely comprehensible as he gets more worked up, no one understanding a goddamn thing he’s going on about. Hell, if he still had a hand, he’d probably rub it against that bottom lip, furrowing his stupid eyebrows as he wrote some chicken-scratch nonsense into one of those notebooks of his.

Izuku clears his throat.

“Anyway. After recovery in the hospital, I was transferred to Star and Stripe’s agency in the United States for protection. And I appreciated them. I really did. They were good to me. I just…”

He sighs, shoulder drooping. In this moment, he seems very far away.

“I realized that as long as I’m alive, Shigaraki will always chase me. That somehow he *needs* me. And he kept getting stronger, and so many heroes already died trying to subdue him – to protect me. I didn’t… I didn’t want anybody else getting hurt for my sake. So… I left.”

“If that power needs both of you, why didn’t we just kill Shigaraki? Or you, for that matter?”

Mirko doesn’t wait for someone to acknowledge her placard, just lets the natural lull in Deku’s statement open to her question. It’s a harsh thing to ask – and yet, she’s right. They have to know. *He* has to know. Why had Deku asked him to kill him? Why had he tried to end his life when Shigaraki was attacking him? Why not just… stop it all before it started?

Izuku actually laughs, somewhat bitter, like he’s surprised at the question.

“…I tried to kill myself, very shortly after leaving Star and Stripe’s care.” He chuckles, but there’s not an iota of humor behind the sound.

“I just… wasn’t very successful. When I tried to jump off a building, Float, the power from one of the One for All predecessors activated.” Like reading off a grocery list, completely stone faced, he continues, spreading out each finger from his functional hand to count. “When I tried to overdose on narcotics, I found out One for All makes me metabolize drugs so quickly they don’t even affect me. When I tried to hang myself, I found out my neck was too strong to snap! Hah. When I tried to drown myself, I found out I acquired an Underwater Breathing Quirk. It was one of the first times I realized that I had, without intention, been slowly siphoning off Quirks from All for One. I mean, nothing seemed to work. Even when… I tried to slit my throat… I discovered that I had taken Regenerate. Or maybe me trying to do those things caused the Quirk to come to me? Like One was trying to preserve itself, trying to prevent either one of us from dying so it could continue to exist…?” Izuku pauses, voice ending in wonderment, like the fuck actually holds some degree of *admiration* for the amorphous ‘Quirk’ that ruined his life.

The people in the audience murmur calmly, nodding to one another, like that’s a fucking normal statement to hear.

Except… except Katsuki knows, for a fact, that Deku acquired Regenerate recently.

He saw it activate that night in the bunker.

Had… had he tried to die even after they…

Nausea crests in Katsuki's throat and he bends over, the sudden urge to vomit overwhelming. He can't stand up, can't make a scene, his heart beating so quickly he can hear nothing but the constant *woosh* of it in his ears. Vaguely, he realizes that there's a hand on his back, that there's a voice whispering softly to him, but he refuses to respond because he needs to use every goddamn molecule of sanity left in his body to not freak the fuck out.

He said they were some of the best weeks of his life.

He said he was happy.

"…I didn't even really want to die – I just. I just felt like my continued existence on this planet put the people I love in danger. It felt like the best solution. I did what I could to keep y – them – safe, but there would never be true peace as long as I walked the earth. As long as there was still a connection to Shigaraki that allowed him to use his power. So I tried and I tried and I tried – but they didn't let me. The previous owners, I mean."

Confused faces stare back at Izuku, and he chuckles, like he didn't just explain to all of Japan that he tried to kill himself – what, five times? *Six,* Katsuki's brain addends, *counting the island.*

"The nature of each of these acquired Quirks is that they're attached to… the will? The soul? I'm not sure what it is, really… of the previous owner. And they… talked to me, sometimes. Sometimes, they were even able to… control my actions. They told me that there's no guarantee ending my life would even work. Even before Shigaraki acquired All for One, he was still nearly unstoppable with just Decay. So even if I somehow got rid of All for One and One for All, I didn't have a way to guarantee Shigaraki could be stopped… I don't know. I wish they could speak to you. They made a lot more sense inside my head." Izuku laughs again. There's something hysterical in that laugh – a cadence that can only be achieved by spending four years talking to people inside your own head.

How else is he supposed to sound? *There's voices in my head that told me to do things? The voices in my head control my body sometimes?* Of course everyone in the room is going to look at him like he's out of his mind. Izuku seems to realize this, because he continues, voice more assured.

"The longer I spent alone, the more I could… feel them. Talk to them. The remnants…vestiges of the previous owners of the Quirks. I heard about their lives. Their stories. Those that were still living…. I tried to seek them out. They gave me the idea to start returning them. So, what information I could garner from these snippets of their memory, I used. And then… I traveled. Researched. Looked for people."

Izuku smiles softly.

"Some people were happy to see me. Some weren't. It was okay. I did this without being fully aware that Shigaraki started figuring out the same things I already knew, about our connection, about how he was weakening. So… that's why I believe he started seeking out twins. Trying to find a way to sever our connection while still keeping his Quirk. At that same time, I was trying to find a way to get rid of it – the power source – all together. I got the idea in Switzerland, actually. There's a supercollider that creates new particles when they accelerate electrons and positrons very quickly. They cancel each other out. It was only a theory – but what if I found a Quirk that would allow me to… put an opposing *charge* on my half of One, so I could cancel us both out? If it really does work like electricity, then it's the only real way to destroy it."

“Wait, wait, wait. Hold up. How does it work like electricity?”

Kaminari sincerely appears curious, sitting forward in his seat, eyes wide in wonderment. Some people never change – make the subject about him, and suddenly he’s all wide eyed and bushy tailed.

Katsuki raises his eyebrows. Actually, this might be perfect. Who better to demonstrate this on than the walking Spark-plug himself?

Aizawa and Yagi both glance to him, voicing their silent approval, and Katsuki takes a deep breath, tapping the piece of paper folded up in his pocket, before standing up and walking towards the center of the room with what he hopes looks like confidence and bravado and not the very real spine-numbing fucking fear of having the whole world, Deku included, watching him.

“Okay, Doltbrain, listen up.” Katsuki starts. He chews at the inside of his cheek – this isn’t necessarily how he was thinking of doing this, but…

“Get down here. I gotta show these people somethin’,” Katsuki orders.

Kaminari looks to his left and right, confused, before pointing a finger to himself to Katsuki’s endless exasperation. Katsuki nods at him sharply and Kaminari stands up, tripping all over himself as he makes it down the stairs and out of the judges box to stand next to Katsuki in the center of the room.

The Arbiter, Akuma and Haiyu all say nothing, which is enough of a sign for Katsuki to continue.

“Creati!” Katsuki barks, and Yaoyorozu stands up slightly straighter from her spot next to Izuku, eyes wide.

“Can you make me a roll of copper wire, four standard light bulbs, thin graphite like you’d find in a pencil… Fucking wire cutters and a marker.”

“…Bakugou,” she starts.

Katsuki clenches his jaw. “*Please.*”

It takes less than a few seconds as the items materialize out of her body. Katsuki grabs them all, making brief eye contact with an incredulous Izuku, before going back to the center of the room.

Katsuki gets to work cutting the wire when the Arbiter finally speaks up.

“Bakugou-san, what is the purpose of this?”

“I’m explaining the way this shit works, because I can see all your eyes fuckin’ glazed over when Deku here was talking about his shitty quirk. Kaminari – Chargebolt – here is going to represent One, or the summation of power that is contained in One for All and All for One.”

“What! Dude, I don’t wanna be All for One!”

Katsuki snaps. “Shut it! I’m making a fucking – you know what? Stop interrupting. Anyway - Doltbrain here is the energy source – the ‘Quirk.’ He’s got the potential to release a ton of energy, but he’s not using it on anything right now. Yeah? Okay.” Katsuki lifts one of the lightbulbs to show to the whole court.

“Alright. This bulb is fuckin’ Deku.”

Katsuki grabs the black sharpie, taking the cap off with his teeth and draws freckles on the light bulb, marker squeaking against glass.

“If this big-ass nerd’s theory is true, then most people’s Quirks work like this.” Katsuki wraps one strand of wire around the light bulb in one direction and hands Kaminari the other end. The light bulb does not light up. Then, Katsuki wraps another wire around the light bulb base. The moment the second wire touches Kaminari’s others hand, the light bulb lights up.

“If the Quirk itself is a power source, and the movement of it through its connection with the body allows for us to ‘harvest’ the power. The flow increases and increases, particularly when we train our Quirks – but there’s only so much the human body can handle.” Katsuki turns to Kaminari. “Increase your voltage by 10 volts every second.”

Kaminari nods. The light bulb glows brighter and brighter and brighter until – ultimately, the glass cracks and explodes. Katsuki glances back to the rest of the court, just in time to watch Izuku flinch.

Katsuki grabs another bulb from the ground, drawing freckles on it. Then he takes a second bulb, drawing a beauty mark on the bottom and angry eyebrows on the top.

“Right. Now, look at this system with two bulbs.”

Katsuki wraps wire around both light bulbs, connecting them to each other, then the wires that connect them to Kaminari.

“Give it the same amount of energy as before. Enough that burst the first bulb,” Katsuki orders, and Kaminari follows. Both light bulbs light up, quite a bit dimmer than the previous display.

“Okay. Now keep increasing your power output; same as before.”

And Kaminari does increase it, up and up and up until both light bulbs are equally bright.

“The solution of having a powerful Quirk, evolutionarily probably, was to have an additional connection – another body – that allows an even split of that power so too much doesn’t ‘overwhelm’ the one system. A way to biologically share the burden. Particularly if one part of the pair is weaker, or able to handle less of the Quirk for some reason. Think of Deku’s shitty, puny body as this piece of graphite - ”

Katsuki lifts the piece of graphite for the room to see like some goddamn show magician.

“Your body not being optimized leads to resistance to flow – and power always goes down the path of least resistance. Pause, Kaminari.”

Kaminari stops the flow of electricity while Katsuki uses the wire cutters to snap the connection from Kaminari to the Deku-bulb. He then wraps each end of the wire to the ends of the graphite.

“Again,” Katsuki signals, and this time, the Deku-bulb is much dimmer than the Shigi-bulb.

“So with training…” Katsuki continues, signaling for Kaminari to stop. He breaks the graphite in half and hooks it up again. The Deku-bulb becomes slightly brighter.

“With getting rid of everything that restricts you. Optimizing your mind and your body…” Katsuki breaks the graphite again. With the final attachment, the Deku-bulb glows nearly as brightly as the Shigi-bulb. Katsuki glances around the room. Utsushimi is nodding, pursing her lips. If he’s making sense to the lowest denominator in the room, he’s probably getting through to at least 50% of Japan.

Hopefully.

“It’s not really a perfect metaphor…There’s a ton of fuckin’ factors that can be changed. Like, what if the wire was made from different material? What if it was larger, or smaller, or longer? Those changes can make small differences in the power traveling to each bulb – but at the end of the day, the way to make a real difference is to alter the power source *itself.* That’s what this fuckin’ genius asshole did. Hah!” Katsuki grins, glancing at Izuku. He can’t decipher the exact emotion going on in those green eyes - they’re sparkling, not unlike they did when the little nerd watched him during their U.A. exercises, like he’s itching to write down every little detail into a notebook. Katsuki would be lying if he said it didn’t make him preen, just a little.

“Creati, make me a car battery, a AA and a AAA battery.”

Katsuki waves Kaminari away, then uses each of the batteries to make his point. Less glow with the car battery, even less with the AA, and barely any light with the AAA.

“…But what about the twins?” one of the civilian judges asks, and Katsuki can’t help but grin.

“Capacitors. Places to siphon off energy, only activated when necessary. They store the Quirks Deku – or Shigaraki – didn’t want the other to get a hold off, so they can tap into them whenever they wanted. Hence why it had to be twins. The Quirks flow between them through that twin connection.”

Realization, much like the lightbulbs Katsuki’s hands, flashes in Katsuki’s brain.

“…Which is why killing himself would have been fucking stupid.” Katsuki grabs the Deku-bulb and smashes it on the floor, then places it back within the circuit. Although the Deku-bulb is non-functional, the Shigi-bulb still glows as soon as the connection is completed.

“Think about it. Those weird fuckin’ ghosts or Vestiges or whatever you call them aren’t *alive,* right? But they still somehow have a link to that power. The body might die, but something else… the soul, the will, I don’t fucking know… perseveres. This connection doesn’t end in death.”

Izuku stares at Katsuki. “…So stop.” Katsuki whispers, eyes fixed on Izuku, and it’s like every other body in that courtroom disappears. He swallows past the lump in his throat.

“Stop saying you should have died. Stop torturing yourself. Stop blaming yourself. You did the right fuckin’ thing. Your job was to keep burning. That’s it.”

Izuku ducks his head, eyes shutting tight. The shake of his shoulders, as miniscule as it is, gives away the slurry of emotions he’s trying to hide. Katsuki glances away, too aware of the odd look Todoroki – nay, the whole goddamn courtroom - is giving him.

Feeling entirely awkward standing in the center of the room, Katsuki starts to pick up all the props in front of him, tossing them in the trash before taking his seat.

“Thank you for that detailed explanation, Bakugou-san.” Akumo says, almost sounding fucking *sincere* for once, before walking to Izuku.

“Please. Go on. How did you find the way to… ‘get rid’ of this power source?”

Izuku takes a few stabilizing breaths. Despite that, his voice still shakes slightly when he speaks.

“I found them probably just before he started to suspect them too. It’s like… they were born *for* this purpose. Like… they existed as a way for the universe to balance itself out. Born in the same city.

Twins, just like him. U.A students, just like me. As soon as I found out, I went to them. I tried to protect them. If I knew Shigaraki, he was going to eventually find them, too."

Izuku shook his head.

"I thought he might be in Japan… I tried to lure him out before he found the Honoka twins… but I was not successful. I only found out how close he was when…" he pauses, audibly swallowing, "When I came across police records regarding the Twin Sequencing Case. All 18 pairs. Including the Honoka twins. That's when I knew I had to make my move."

Katsuki keeps his face neutral. Ah, yes. *Came across,* like that illegally obtained information was in the bottom of a cereal box and not in Katsuki's study, which the other broke into after fucking him senseless. Sure.

"They were going on this training camp, and I knew that if he was going to attack at all, it would be then. It was his best chance of either getting rid of them or using them. So I knew I had to be there. To protect them. To fight for them."

"Excellent. Thank you for your time, Midoriya-san. Lucky for us, several pro-heroes were also present on the scene and can explain the events of Minami-Ioto island."

Katsuki raises his eyebrows. So Deku's job was to provide the setting, the backstory, establish the mood – but now they're back to the case itself. Back to the evidence. Back to indicting the same guy that just tearfully recounted four years of what sounds like utter hell.

"If I may call Utsushimi-san to the podium."

Utsushimi glances around, as if she expects someone else with her same name to come forward, but seeing all eyes on her, she gives Mina a squeeze of the hand and stands. She saunters to the podium, placing a hand on the book.

"Utsushimi Camie, Hero Name: Illus-o-Camie. You were present on Minami-Ioto Island as one of the hero-supervisors to the Training Camp for class 3A and 3B?"

Utsushimi flutters her eyelashes before smiling widely.

"Like, yeah! Every year Ei and Min-min come back to Japan to talk to U.A. kids and recruit them to their agencies in the U.S! I decided to come with them this year for this super fun camp!"

"Akumo-san, if I may," Haiyu stands up as Deku's lawyer backs away. The opposing lawyer walks forward confidently, like he's just sunk his teeth into something absolutely delicious.

"…You attended Shiketsu High School, correct?"

"Uh, yeah!" Utsushimi uses her free hand to twirl her hair, seemingly annoyed at the overly obvious question.

"Tell me, Utsushimi-san. How much of your graduating class ended up leaving Japan to do hero-work?"

Katsuki feels the hairs on the back of his neck stand up. Shit. He knows where this guy is going with this – and having Utsushimi up on the stand, that simpleton, is going to make them sound like utter shit. This isn't good.

“Hmm. Um, probably about half?”

“Interesting. And why exactly is that, you think?”

“Boo, you know why! You took away public ranking, being able to be in commercials or movies, having your own products, then made it so we had to work under police officers rather than with them, controlling our uniforms and how much we were paid – it fucking sucks! Especially for people with Quirks like mine!”

Katsuki flinches.

“You heard her. Many of our Japan-trained heroes moved to different countries because it wasn’t… what… *glamorous* enough for you anymore?”

Utsushimi’s mouth clamps shut. “That’s not…”

“So you’re saying that the commission accomplished exactly what the purpose was – to ensure that Japanese citizens are protected by real heroes – those that don’t just go into the profession for riches or fame, but to actually help people.”

“I never said – “ Utsushimi starts, but Haiyu cuts her off, wagging his shitty finger in front of her to shush her as if scolding a small child.

“Quite interesting that U.A. actually promotes this behavior and allows you and your… colleagues…” his eyes flash over to Ashido and Kirishima, both of them stiffening under his accusatory glance, “To teach our youth.”

“You took all the fun out of it!” Utsushimi exclaims, and Katsuki has to physically restrain himself from facepalming.

“Fun. Young lady, saving lives, rescuing people, fighting for your country isn’t supposed to be *fun.* You witnessed what happened when we trusted the country to heroes who did this for *fun.*”

So you indoctrinated a bunch of children to do your dirty work for you, Katsuki thinks, gritting his teeth. The people who saw the change left as soon as they fucking could. And then, just like good little obedient soldiers, more and more students stayed in Japan, accepting the new work environment as law. Independent thought was stolen from them. Autonomy was stolen from them. All in the guise of ‘saving.’ It makes Katsuki sick.

He looks to Kirishima who doesn’t bother hiding the sour look on his face. He can’t blame him for leaving. He can’t blame any of them for leaving. If it wasn’t for… Katsuki shakes his head. In a different world, he’d be right on the other’s heels. But his desires to be #1, to save the world, to be the strongest hero all disappeared along with Deku.

“These kids should have the chance to see how other parts of the world do things! It’s totally uncool that the Commission is trying to pretend there’s only one right way to be a hero!” Utsushimi shoots back, and Katsuki is almost impressed at the chain of coherent words out of her lip-glossed mouth.

“I think we’re getting derailed from the point, Haiyu-san,” Akuma adds, walking back over, sounding for all the world like the might snap Haiyu’s neck at any moment, dark aura emanating off him in droves.

“Please, Utsushimi-san. Tell us what happened on the island.”

"…Well, it was supposed to be a scavenger hunt! The team that got the most flags would then all complete with one another to win an internship at one of our agencies! It was gonna be super fun! But, um. Then the day we were supposed to go, Bakugou showed up, and he looked pretty shitty – "

Katsuki feels his thigh twitch in an effort to stand up and bitch her out, but Kirishima places a hand on his shoulder, pushing him right back down into his seat.

"And he was all like," Camie, in that moment, transforms into a gangly, thin looking version of himself with dark circles under her eyes and a snarl on her face, "I'm gonna be here too! And we're gonna play nuclear fallout! And every time there's a flare, you hide or you die!"

Utsushimi transforms back into herself with a puff of smoke. "He was totes scary! But Baku was cool before the war, and Ei and Mina seemed to trust him, so I was like – whatevs! Let's do this! So he, like, sent us in four different directions, and every time a flare went off – I had a little buzzing phone for when I was supposed to release my flare – all the kids were supposed to hide and we were supposed to find them! Everyone we found, we sent back to Eraserhead and All Might!"

She pauses, persistent smile faltering.

"…And everything was going great, but then I heard two flares. I did what Baku said – I hid – but Min-min found me and dragged me to the tip of the island where All Might and Eraserhead were! But that's also where that…. Urgh." Utsushimi visibly shudders as she closes her eyes. "That *thing* showed up!"

"…Ashido Mina came to find you?" Akuma asks, eyeing Mina curiously.

"Um, yeah! She was such a badass! She was melting through trees with her acid like WHUA!"

"Right. Unless you have anything else to add, Utsushimi-san, may I call Ashido Mina to the stand?"

"Sure thing!"

Utsushimi stands down as Ashido obediently nears the podium. Ashido and Utsushimi briefly meet hands as they walk past one another, and Katsuki narrows his eyes at the exchange.

"…Ashido Mina, Hero Name: Pinkie. You were also one of the heroes on Minami-Ioto Island. Our reports say that you and Illus-o-Camie work in the same agency in Los Angeles."

Mina's pink hands meets the blue book.

"Yeah. We've both been working there for the past year."

"When she mentioned there were two flares, she reports that she hid, but you came to find her."

Ashido sucks on her lip. "Yeah, Bakugou told us to hide if there were two flares. That it meant there was danger. He's not generally a dramatic guy, so I knew it was probably really serious. And I didn't want Camie to get hurt. So I went to find her."

"And you brought her back to Yagi-san and Aizawa-san? Two nearly-Quirkless former pros?" Haiyu interjects.

Mina narrows her eyes.

"…Yes. They had their own shelter and the boat."

Akuma can hardly contain his smile. “Tell us more about this boat.”

Ashido shrugs. “I don’t know. It would show up a couple times a day and cart the kids that were caught during the game off. Probably to the mainland. I thought it might still be there and I could get her off the island.”

Haiyu interrupts once more, tone accusatory.

“So you placed priority on your co-worker rather than the children you were supposed to be protecting?”

Ashido glares at the Commission lawyer.

“… That’s not fair. I trust Ei and Baku with my life, so I knew they’d take good care of the kids. But Camie doesn’t have an offensive Quirk. If there was something that scared even Baku, then I couldn’t risk it. I had to protect her.” The tone in Mina’s voice sounds familiar, a similar melody to a song Katsuki swears he knows. The desire to protect without consideration of your own well-being. Hm.

“…We made it back to the beach, and that’s when I saw Kiri in front of the ocean. The waves stopped, and there was like this underwater walk-way that was red and bubbling. And it was super scary. We grabbed all the kids we could and hid in the shelter. Baku arrived shortly after.”

“…And the person that emerged from the water was Shigaraki.”

Mina flinches, clearly uncomfortable. “Um, yeah. I can’t tell you guys much more. We spent most of the time in the shelter protecting the kids. Ei, Baku and the teachers stayed outside when um… Shigaraki attacked.”

“Excellent. Thank you for your testimony. Kirishima Eijirou, if you would please…” Akuma calls, rapid sequence, not allowing Haiyu to throw in another stupid-ass question.

Kirishima startles, like he didn’t expect this natural progression, giving Katsuki what he assumes is a reassuring look before he stands up. He crinkles slightly, reminding him of the plastic wrap around his body to insulate his burns, and Katsuki feels his mouth dry, guilt sucking the desire to laugh right out of him.

“Kirishima Eijirou, Hero Name: Red Riot. You fired two flares. What made you do that?”

“…Bakugou said that if we saw anything weird, we should fire two flares. So when I saw the ocean do that… Uh. I don’t know. I had this impending sense of doom… So I trusted my gut. Better to shoot and be wrong than to… you know.” Kirishima shrugs.

“Bakugou showed up shortly after. As soon as Shigaraki was out of the water, Bakugou launched at him and got him up in the air. He blasted him into the sand, and that’s when he started going for the twins… I guess that’s when,” Kirishima’s eyes dart to Izuku. “That’s when Midoriya showed up. He must have. Um. I don’t really… *Remember?* The details? Next thing I knew - Shigaraki attacked Bakugou with those black… tendril things. I tried to get to him, but they were too fast. Bakugou then… called out Midoriya’s name and shot an AP Shot into the sky right before he got… stabbed.” Kirishima says the words like they physically pain him, weak words through gritted teeth.

“I don’t know. I don’t really understand what happened next. Bakugou suddenly started healing. There was something about taking the twin’s Quirk…” Kirishima stares down at the podium, shaking

his head slightly. “I don’t think I really *recognized* him as Midoriya until he was floating above the island, surrounded by light…But by then, I couldn’t…” Kirishima hesitates.

“We all went into the shelter after that.”

Haiyu stands up.

“…There were four bodies found on the island after the destruction, buried underneath the mountain. Yourself, Bakugou, Midoriya and Shigaraki. Is that correct?”

“Yes,” Kirishima answers.

“Yet you said that you went to the shelter.”

“I did, but then I realized that Bakugou didn’t come back with us, so I… tried to shield him from the blast.”

“…And you were severely injured. You suffered third and fourth degree burns all over your body.”

Kirishima gnashes his teeth. “…What point are you trying to make?”

Haiyu smacks his stupid lips. “Red Riot… You too left Japan after graduation, is that correct?”

“…Yes. I work out of Las Vegas now.”

“…And are your reasons for leaving Japan and working in the United States similar to Utsushimi-san’s?”

All traces of friendliness disappear off Kirishima’s face. The way he speaks gives Katsuki the impression that he’s been waiting to say these words for a long, long time.

“I was sixteen when I watched my teacher die in front of my eyes. It was *our* class that was digging dead bodies out of buildings, it was *our* mentors and heroes that were disappearing, it was *my* friend whose ashes were flown in from the other side of the world! We buried Midoriya! Of course I couldn’t stay in Japan! You know what it’s like to live with those ghosts?! Every street corner reminded me of the little girl I pulled from under the building whose face was so crushed no one would identify her. Every time I saw an All Might poster, I thought about Midoriya and how much he loved heroes and how happy he always was! Every time I went back to campus, back to the classroom, I thought about Midnight and how it felt to hold her limp hand! Of course I couldn’t stay! I don’t know how a single person could!”

“You used us as convenient tools – because we were kids, because we would still do anything for Japan even when Japan wouldn’t do anything for us – until you broke us! You broke us! I’d leave again! I can’t even think about coming back! Fuck you!”

Pride swells in Katsuki’s chest and he feels his lips form into a smile, canines showing. This guy has balls of steel, standing in front of all of Japan - the first one ever who has the gall to say what they’re all thinking.

“If your point here was to make me say that I regret or blame Bakugou or Midoriya for what happened, I don’t! That’s the point! I’m a hero – I’d sacrifice myself for my friends, no matter what. I made a choice, and I’d make that choice over and over again if it means that I could help them! That’s what you’re missing in your new regime! Making everyone comply to the same system takes out the

independence! The passion! The sense of responsibility! That's why I left – because I never wanted what happened to us to happen anywhere else!"

This perspective likely has never been revealed to the citizens – while they cowered underground, it truly was hero *students*, not the pros who were already too shorthanded or injured to clean up the mess aboveground – that performed search and rescue, that apprehended the escaped convicts, that risked their lives for them every day.

Kaminari is staring at Kirishima with wide, open eyes, tears running down his cheeks although, for once, he doesn't make a sound. An uncomfortable looking Mirko rubs her left shoulder, prosthetic glinting softly in the light. Aizawa taps his prosthetic leg against the linoleum floor. Katsuki feels his scars start to ache.

They're still here.

They are all still here.

Haiyu's mouth turns down into a grimace.

"Leave it for your own agency, young man. You're no longer a Japanese citizen, and thus have no say in the way our government is run. All I hear from these three 'heroes,'" And Haiyu does finger quotes, all the same, making Katsuki feel like he could choke a bitch, "…Is that the instrumentor behind what happened on Minami-Ioto Island is Bakugou Katsuki. So, if we're done here… I'd like to call him to the stand."

Katsuki stands up, feeling the tension in the room escalate. It's like walking down that final hallway to the execution chamber. Kirishima squeezes his shoulder as they pass one another – a small but welcome comfort. Katsuki takes a deep breath.

After this moment, Katsuki might be right there in Tartarus next to Deku. He might be exiled from his country. He might lose the very little he still has.

For some reason, it makes him smile. He stands on the podium, feeling the eyes of the world on him, and places a hand against the Book of Truth.

"Bakugou Katsuki. Hero name: Dynamight." Haiyu starts, and Katsuki sneers at him. There's a petty part of him that wants to correct him, '*Explosion Murder God Dynamight, actually'* but it doesn't feel like the right time or place.

"Present, I fuckin' guess," Katsuki clips back, earning a small laugh from the people behind him. He glances to Izuku, who is hiding a small smile behind his hand. It fills Katsuki with adrenaline, like taking a shot of espresso, and he straightens up, jutting his chin out at the commission lawyer as if in challenge.

"There's been an overwhelming amount of evidence that seems to point to you helping Izuku Midoriya in his vigilante spree, including the events on the island. Is that correct?"

Katsuki shrugs. "Yeah, I was helping him. He didn't know I was helping him, though, if you think we fuckin' worked together. Deku and I didn't have a fuckin' scrap of communication prior to the island. I just kinda… figured out where and when he was gonna be on my own."

Haiyu frowns. "Yesterday you reported that Midoriya was the individual who kidnapped the Shiryoku twins. If you hadn't 'communicated' beforehand, how do you explain the conversation TentaCole

heard you having with the accused?"

Katsuki exhales dramatically, rolling his eyes. "…I didn't fuckin' *know* that was Deku at the time. It was his… disguised persona or whatever. He went by a different name."

"…What name?"

Katsuki feels his heart catch in his throat. He doesn't want to say it. He doesn't want anyone else to know it. He doesn't want – "Zero."

Izuku ducks his head further, the only sign he had some kind of reaction to hearing that name.

"So you're saying that you worked with a vigilante even *prior* to knowing that he was Izuku Midoriya," Haiyu's sounds so damn smug that Katsuki wants to rub his nose in it. Just a little.

"Yeah. He was hunting Shigaraki, and considering the rest of the Japanese government has been touting that Shigaraki and the rest of the League has been dead for years, I took my fucking chance. He was the only person who believed me. And look how that turned out."

More murmurs. Katsuki smirks to himself.

"So, the connection between Zero and Midoriya. How exactly did you 'figure it out?'"

Katsuki wants to say some smartass shit – about the inadequate police force, or how gullible everyone on the planet is with those fake-ass 'ashes' that were brought to U.A. – but instead he grimaces and speaks through tight teeth. "I was conducting an independent investigation into Izuku Midoriya's disappearance."

"That has been a closed case for several years now." Haiyu adds unhelpfully.

Katsuki refuses to meet Deku's eyes. "Yeah."

"And I assume you found evidence."

"Sure." Katsuki shrugs. "You showed it yesterday, just in case you forgot. Not that hard."

Except it was. It took the better part of four years of non-stop searching, accessing classified information, to gather even a fraction of what these commission bastards were keeping behind closed doors. Katsuki bites his tongue. "I figured out the way the Quirk worked, and after that, it seemed kind of simple. Deku was able to use Quirks that didn't belong to him, and he was the only person other than Shigaraki I knew who could use multiple Quirks. So."

"Can we make the assumption that the way Midoriya-san got 'information' regarding the Twin Sequencing Case is through you?"

"Yeah. It was through me. He stole that shit from me, but yeah."

The book glows blue. Not a lie. In some ways, Katsuki can't help but be a little grateful that Deku was such a fucking asshole.

"…Kirishima-san noted that you fired an attack on someone on the island that wasn't Shigaraki. Was it Midoriya-san?"

"…Yes."

“And why exactly did you fire on your accomplice?”

“He’s not my… because the idiot was trying to kill himself, that’s why!” Katsuki spits.

“And why didn’t you want him to kill himself?”

Katsuki pauses. “Were you not fuckin’ paying attention? I did a whole goddamn show and tell – if he died and it didn’t work, the rest of us wouldn’t have stood a chance against Shigaraki!”

The book glows red. It burns the bottom of Katsuki’s palm and he pulls it off, wincing and shaking to allow the air to cool his tender skin. For a man who has calluses all along his hands, thick from years using explosions, this heat felt like something else entirely – not superficial, but like it dug straight into his nerve endings.

The Arbiter nears him, examining the book before casting him an odd look.

“The truth, please.”

Katsuki grimaces.

They could have probably defeated Shigaraki on their own. And he’s known that Zero dying was probably the safest and most likely to succeed strategy to defeat Shigaraki. But the other answer – the one he realized just as the idiot put the gun to his head – sticks in Katsuki’s throat, too heavy to be spit out and televised for all of Japan to see.

“Fuckin’ fine. I didn’t want him to die. That answer enough for you?”

The book glows blue.

“He was losing,” Katsuki continues, unprompted. “So Aoto and Otoa agreed to let him take their Quirk. He did exactly that – he fuckin’ inverted his half of One and redirected it on Shigaraki. I should have died in the blast – I was injured and didn’t think I was gonna survive anyways – but stupid shit-for-hair over there –“ Katsuki points his thumb behind himself to Kirishima, “Decided to try to sacrifice himself for a dead man. So here we fucking are. Shigaraki’s in prison, the person who saved all your shitty lives is sitting here waiting *to* go to prison, and I’m still fucking alive.”

There’s a silence throughout the room.

It extends.

After a full on minute, Katsuki starts to fidget.

He glances from Akuma to Haiyu, then to the judges. The judges themselves seem to be conversing between one another, no longer paying attention to him.

The Arbiter speaks next.

“…Does this testimony satisfy the Judges and our lawyers?”

“I’ve heard enough,” Haiyu states, crossing his arms. He glances to Aizawa and Yagi – as if calculating whether having those two testify will help or hurt his case – before shaking his head.

“Me as well.” Akuma nods. “If I may request a 30 minute recess to prepare closing statements.”

The very second everyone was dismissed, Katsuki's on his feet, making his way out of the courtroom. He slams the doors open, heaving huge lungfulls of air. He raises his arms, allowing for the slight breeze to cool off the sweat that's making stains on his pits. Even his hair feels like its soaked through.

This is insane. He has to wait for 30 minutes with his thumb up his own ass while nine people – one of which is *Kaminari* – decides Deku's fate?! Katsuki could claw his eyes out. Inactivity was never his strong suit – so no matter how fucking insane it might look to everybody else, he takes off running down the street. Just a few blocks. Just to give him something else to focus on. Just to get those tearful green eyes out of his head.

He ducks past pedestrians, jumps over curbs, keeps moving and moving and moving, letting his muscles burn, letting his damaged thigh spasm with each landing on unsteady feet, each flash of pain rendering his mind blissfully clear.

When the thirty minutes are finally up, he slows his pace, stopping in front of Aizawa, who too seems to be enjoying a little bit of fresh air. The man is rubbing his thigh, seemingly unaware of Katsuki's arrival.

Katsuki leans back, face pointed to the sky as he catches his breath.

"That was some show you put on in there," Aizawa says, and it takes a second for Katsuki to process that Aizawa is speaking to *him.*

He jerks his head, *tch*ing in response. "You fuckin' told me to find a way to explain it, so I did! Shut up about it already."

The comment rolls right off Aizawa's back. "You should consider teaching."

Katsuki clamps his mouth shut, squinting his eyes to make sure that this is really Aizawa and not just Utsushimi in disguise, before he barks out a laugh.

"Yeah, great idea, let's optimize the U.A. traumatization pipeline. Why wait three years when you can get them in one? Thanks but no thanks."

"I'm serious," Aizawa's one eye examines Katsuki closely. "You explain things in ways that other people can actually understand. You're an independent thinker who can interpret information in his own way without following the status quo. You're exactly what this generation of students needs."

Katsuki's sneer falls of his face. He shakes his head, this time serious. "I've still got a few good years in me. If I ever sink that low, though, I'll give ya a call."

Aizawa actually smiles at that. "Please do."

The sound of a gavel alerts the two of them that court is about to come back into session.

Exchanging a tense glance, the two make their way back inside the building.

Once everyone's sat and the doors are closed, both lawyers stand up.

Akuma starts first.

"In the past two days, you have heard a story about a young man who discovered something phenomenal and terrifying about his Quirk at the age of sixteen. He left to protect Japan, attempted to

undo the evil that the creator of his Quirk had instilled upon the world, and returned to our country to end this centuries-long reign of terror. Izuku Midoriya's actions were not government sanctioned – and yet, if they were, wouldn't Shigaraki still be running free? Wouldn't more be dead? Wouldn't people remain Quirkless in their corners of this planet? He did this in the effort to sustain the least loss and do the most good, having no other options. Even the individuals present in this room were never meant to be directly involved in his plans – but just like myself, these people believed in his message and trusted him to guide them to victory. Think about the results – about what kind of future Japan can now look forward to – because of the efforts of this one person. He saved us and our future – we have a solemn duty to save him and his future too – not just as a hero, but as a human being. Thank you."

Akuma bows deeply to the judges, then to the stands, then to the cameras. He walks away deliberately slowly, taking his seat next to Izuku. They exchange stilted smiles.

Haiyu stands up, gait still confident, still theatrical, still wide. Something about his walk irks Katsuki, but he bites his tongue, watching the oppositions closing statement carefully.

"Midoriya Izuku has been accused of vigilante activity. Everything discussed in this courtroom confirmed exactly that. He acted independently, without a license or supervision, in multiple countries all over the world. He never took responsibility for his actions. Implying that this young man shouldn't face consequences to his actions is saying that a certain amount of 'good' morality excuses you from following the law. But, as I may remind you all, through our democratic process, through careful curation and through decades of observation, the law stands. If a certain amount of 'good' excuses individuals from being accountable for their crimes, then why did Endeavor and Hawks serve time? Weren't their crimes also 'moral' under some guise? In the end, morality, goodness and kindness do not supersede the fact that for society to function, each person must comply to a certain ideal. If we let Izuku Midoriya go – who is next? Should Stain have never been arrested? Is intention truly more important than the crime? Is killing someone quickly so it doesn't cause suffering not still murder? No matter his intentions, no matter what he made of the situation, his actions are still those of a vigilante, and thus are still illegal. Izuku Midoriya is guilty – every person in the country knows this. If his actions here are excused – I challenge you to ask yourself what is next. And if you would feel safe going to sleep at night in that kind of world."

Without a thanks, Haiyu walks away, his shoes tapping the only sound in the courtroom.

The Arbiter nods. "The judges will now go and deliberate the sentence."

The door in the back opens as if on queue, and in single file, the judges disappear it. It shuts hard after them, resounding throughout the room like its infinitely heavier than the outward appearances would imply, leaving the entire court in uncomfortable silence.

In a few minutes, people start to mill around the room, getting into groups, starting conversations. No one so much as dares step outside the court itself.

Katsuki stays between his friends, absolutely fucking refusing to move, because it might bring him into spitting distance of Iida, Uraraka or Inko, who have made their own small circle, the two heroes comforting the still-crying mother.

He fucking hates that she's still crying. If he could stand to look at her, he'd grab her by her shoulders and shake the ever-loving shit out of her, scream in her face, beg her to open her goddamn eyes, *your son is alive! He's a hero! Stop crying! Stop fucking crying! Do something!*

It's like she represents all the worst parts of Deku. Like her entire personality is that meek, tearful, self-pitying shtick that benefits exactly no one and hurts everyone around them. Her son spent four years running around the globe in disguise, solving life's great mysteries, becoming some kind of deity that returns people's Quirks, fucking changing the very foundation of their hero society – and what exactly has Inko done, other than cry for him?

…Although. Katsuki can't even pretend he's that much better.

He's spurred from his thoughts by the mustachioed man poking his head out the door, standing with his arms behind his back, loudly clearing his throat. Katsuki's the first in the room at full attention – the rest follow briskly after, until the entire room seems to be collectively holding their breaths.

"The Jury has reached a verdict." The Arbiter announces. He keeps the door open as the nine judges file back out. Katsuki watches Kaminari's face carefully; for some reason, he's chosen this exact moment to be fuckin' unreadable. Kaminari's brows are furrowed, mouth a straight line, but there's no tears in his eyes, so it can't be *that* bad.

Right?

The judge in the upper right corner of the booth, the Commission-appointed court judge, unfolds a piece of paper. He stares down at it, grimacing at the words, before he starts to speak.

"Izuku Midoriya – despite your clear acts of vigilantism and illegal activity defying the Japanese justice system, this court has agreed that your actions have done more good than harm. In addition, your failures are the failures of the broken old hero system that encouraged this behavior and…" he pauses, grinding his teeth, "The still-developing current system that punishes all individuals equally without allowing for nuance. Thus, with majority rule of 2/3 court appointed judges and 5/6 civilian judges, your final verdict is…"

Katsuki's breath quickens.

"Six months in Tartarus and five years parole."

Akuma stands up, clapping his hand on Izuku's shoulder gleefully, fist pumping to the rest of the courtroom. More than half of the people in the room follow, throwing their fists in the air, hugging one another, cheers resounding.

Katsuki stands static. He doesn't know how to react – he can't cheer, or yelp, or scream. He's not happy… but he's also not upset. It's the best possible outcome that they could have anticipated.

A part of him even feels this weird… elation at the verdict. Six months in prison, five years parole. Izuku Midoriya isn't fucking going *anywhere.* He's got nowhere to run. His face and name is plastered over every channel in the world. He's Quirkless. He's crippled. He couldn't get away, even if he fucking wanted to.

This fucking majestic bird has been captured, placed in a cage, its wings clipped. Now all they have to do is wait for him to sing.

"Now to address those assisting him. Katsuki Bakugou."

Katsuki's head shoots up. What? He glances around, furrowing his eyebrows as the courtroom quiets, just as confused as he is.

“While you were not the defendant in this case, we have agreed that you do not need to proceed to your own trial, as the ruling per current laws would not change. Three month hero license suspension for knowingly assisting a vigilante.”

“…What?” he starts, but the bastard commission judge isn’t fucking done, it seems, continuing to talk in that acrid patronizing voice of his.

“Toshinori Yagi and Shota Aizawa,” the judge continues. “You did not testify in this trial, but the jury believes that you were also heavily involved with making Midoriya’s plan come to fruition. As we do not have enough evidence to determine your sentence, you will each be assigned separate court dates.”

Katsuki looks to his teachers, both pale and stony-faced. Was that Haiyu’s play? Avoid their testimony here so he could maximize the degree of punishment the commission can inflict on the adults openly disobeying them?

“Kirishima Eijirou, Utsushimi Camie, Shinso Hitoshi and Ashido Mina, your actions have been reported to your responsive agencies in the United States, and you will be prosecuted to the full extent of the law in your home country.”

The four of them, who at least moments before seemed in higher spirits, all sit up straight, color draining from their face, most of all Shinso who has never looked as tired as he does in this moment.

“For all minors who willingly assisted Midoriya Izuku, including Shiryoku Hikari, Shiryoku Senko, Honoka Aoto and Honoka Otoa, one hundred hours of community service.”

“Thank you for your participation. You are all dismissed,” the Arbiter says as soon as the commission judge stops speaking, not allowing Katsuki to fly over there and strangle him on the spot.

The people around them start to get up, slowly shuffling their way out of the courtroom. Like it’s a normal day. Like all their lives didn’t just change.

“Bakugou, you coming…?” Kirishima asks gently as Katsuki stays glued to his seat, the weight of the world on his shoulders keeping him stationary, though no one else seems to see the planet shaped mass pressing on his spine.

“Yeah. Give me a minute.” Katsuki says. He waits until the room in entirely empty. Every breath he takes echoes, but no one is around to kick him out. There’s a weird emptiness in all of this. He doesn’t feel satisfied. There is still something that he needs to do, but for the fuck of him he doesn’t know what. He’s still trapped, but he can’t figure out how to get out of this fucking cage. What is it? What’s still holding him down?

“……Gou?”

Katsuki glances up, for the first time aware that someone is standing in front of him.

Not just someone. Todoroki.

Katsuki glowers.

“What the hell do *you* want, jackass?”

Todoroki simply sighs, taking the seat next to Katsuki. He spreads his knees, leaning his elbows against them. Katsuki can feel the chill from his left side radiating out, and he tries to will the ends of

his hair not to stand up in response. Todoroki doesn't seem to notice Katsuki's discomfort, staring straight ahead. He chews on this words for a second before, monotone as ever, he starts to speak.

"Bakugou… I don't really know how to say any of this. My heart and my mind – its split in two and – "

Katsuki chokes on the involuntary laugh. He ducks his head down, pounding slightly on his chest. Todoroki looks up at him, stunned, before his eyes soften.

"That isn't funny."

Katsuki catches his breath. "Wrong. It's really fucking funny."

Todoroki smiles in exasperation, shaking his head.

"It seems to be in my nature to be drawn to things from different spectrums of a single thing. But I don't think I ever put together that may apply to you and Midoriya as well. Being around each of you – it's like I'm flipping a coin and forgetting there's an opposite side. I can try to ignore it, just focus on heads or tails – but one does not exist without the other."

"…What the *actual* fu – "

"What I'm trying to say is that I can never claim to understand your relationship with Midoriya. But I respect that it's not something that can be severed. It's not something I can just… end by sheer force of will. I understand that now. So… Come with me."

Todoroki simply stands, and Katsuki trails behind him obediently. His heart starts to beat a fraction faster.

They walk down the hallway and stop outside a nondescript room. Yaoyorozu stands outside of it, at full attention, although the face she's making don't remind Katsuki of a soldier – rather, a scolded child. She glances to Todoroki as the two of them approach, before giving a tearful nod to Katsuki.

Todoroki nudges his chin towards the door. "This may be the last time you see him in six months. Make it count."

Katsuki's hands shake and nearly slip off the doorknob as he puts his hands on it. He swallows the fear down, quietly opening the door, closing it softly behind him. He leans against the back, taking in what is in front of him.

Katsuki's heart sticks in the middle of his throat as he watches Deku hopelessly try to fumble with the tie stuck to his throat, one hand not enough to get through the well-tied knot. His face is flat, impassive, staring off somewhere distant but his hand is jerky, anxious, looking like at any second it might stop fussing with the knot and just pull on the tie until his airway is cut off. Katsuki can't find the words – they're so close right now, in touching distance, three steps away. Somehow, every time the thing that kept them apart – his own anger, continents, prison – dissolves, Katsuki finds himself immobilized by the possibility of proximity.

Deku sighs out loud, only now showing any acknowledgement of another body being in the room. Irritation quirks up his brow. He keeps his eyes fixed to the wall, shoulders square, voice now lower.

"I asked for a *minute* alone. Can you please just – " Deku finally twists his neck to face him, and the second he meets eyes with Katsuki, his entire body freezes.

“What are you –“ When his voice comes out again, Deku sounds breathy, his eyes large. Even so, that puffed up chest and deep voice are replaced with a squeaky imitation, devolved into the Deku he used to be – a power of Katsuki’s that doesn’t seem to weaken with time. That expression makes Katsuki’s tongue feel like its stuck to the roof of his mouth. Everything hurts. Each breath feels like its burning through his nostrils and blowing up his chest, like its making an effort to come out that hole in his lung and deflate him like the giant bag of hot air he really is.

“I’m sorry.” Katsuki says, finally. His eyes don’t leave Deku’s – don’t miss the slight arching of the eyebrows, the glaring shock in the whites of his eyes.

“What do you – “

“Let me speak.” Katsuki clips back, and just like he did when he was three, Deku’s jaw snaps shut. Seeing him do that – that old habit, that reflex, that rotten fear – makes it easier to walk forward, to make his stiff legs move towards the other despite the near oppressive wall between them – like they’re both north poles of opposite magnets, and no matter how much Katsuki wants to close the distance, there’s some invincible entity that won’t allow them to get close enough.

Some spark of bravery – or insanity, or desire, or something else entirely – makes Katsuki reach out, wrap his fingers around the other’s tie. He watches Deku’s Adam’s apple bob in a prolonged dry swallow. Speaking feels easier when he doesn’t have to look up into the other’s eyes; here, hands busy on the too tight knot, able to convince himself for just a second that the other looming above him isn’t *defenseless, quirkless, tiny, quivering, pathetic, unbelievably tragic, beautiful, heartbreaking Deku* – Katsuki speaks.

“I’ve thought about it every single goddamn day for these last four years – how things might have been different if I said sorry before. I couldn’t fucking do it – I couldn’t face you, I couldn’t say the words; you scared the shit out of me and I never stopped to ask myself *why* until you were gone and then it was *all* I could ask myself. Why. Why did you make me feel like I was lesser even though you had nothing? Why did you make me so angry? Why did I keep pushing you away? Why did you leave without telling me? *Why?*” Katsuki feels his voice crack on the last ‘why’ and he pauses, steeling himself. He’s stalling with his hands, fingers having loosened the knot around Izuku’s neck, but each word makes it feel like he’s fastening it around his own.

The boy in front of him is four years old, hopeful and bright eyed. The boy in front of him is twelve years old, gaunt and quiet, always sitting in the back of the room. The boy in front of him is fifteen, smiling at him across the living room during a group dinner, laughing with his friends, an owner of a cursed Quirk that took everything from him. The boy in front of him is twenty, nameless and faceless, looking at him like he’s still got something left for him to give.

Katsuki pulls on one end of the knot, the whole thing unraveling, soft silk falling on his hands. He watches it, unsure of what to do, until a warm hand rests over his fist, pulling it down to rest against his own side. Katsuki glances upwards. So close to the other, his cheeks still dotted with freckles like wildflowers in a field, those eyes – *life, springtime, a sapling growing from the concrete, defying odds, its him, it’s always been him, a reminder that the blaze has purpose; to warm. To grow.*

“Because you’re the only person that could make me stay. And I couldn’t.”

Izuku looks so sincere, eyes hard, determined, words absolute like he’s thought about them for days, weeks, years, and Katsuki’s heart does a somersault in his chest.

“…What do you mean?”

Izuku closes his eyes, furrowing his brows tightly, like it brings him physical pain to speak before he opens his mouth again.

"Kacchan – *Katsuki* – from the very beginning, I was absolutely mesmerized by you. I don't… I don't think it was a normal way for one little boy to feel about another. You were like a god to me – an unattainable, unreachable ideal, the blueprint of what a true hero should be. All my life I tried desperately to be acknowledged by you – because, in some twisted way, it would make me feel like I was *someone.*"

Katsuki feels his fist, so gently held in the other's hand, fall limply to his own side. A sense of discomfort creeps up in his stomach. Explosion Murder God Dynamight. Who would have thought that someone might take it literally.

Izuku scoffs instead, glancing to the side like he's embarrassed. "So I did what any devout believer does. I studied you, I imitated you, I prayed to you. I wrote sermons for you, I preached about you, I offered you sacrifices –" *A flash of panicked eyes clawing at slime, broken limbs on burned flesh, teeth cracking against blood-soaked tendrils–* "I tried so hard to be one of the *chosen* – but I never was. I never *could* be. But I believed in you so much – if you told me to stay – If you told me anything at all… I would. I…" Izuku shakes his head again, laughing slightly.

Katsuki doesn't think it's very funny.

"…it was mostly after I left that I realized what a horrible thing that is to do to someone. I made you into an abstract concept – an amalgamation of my dreams and aspirations – and did all those things without a single thought of how you'd feel about them. How you'd feel about someone following you, mimicking you, praising you, watching you – its… creepy."

Katsuki flinches. A familiar word. *Creepy. Freak. Quirkless.*

"…And then." Izuku sighs. "And then you looked at me like I never thought you'd look at me. But I know you weren't looking at *me* – you were looking at Zero. And I knew it was wrong. I *knew.* But some part of me, some horrible, selfish, narcissistic part of me – wanted to pretend. Just for a little bit. That I could be the kind of person you could want."

Katsuki's stomach drops.

"…It's not an excuse. I just… thought I'd die. I thought you'd never find out. I thought – what is another person in a sea of faces? I invented lovers for you so I could would get lost within them, fabricated stories in my own head about your desires, your morality, your body – I told myself all these lies so I wouldn't have to be the villain. But I was. And I am. What I did was unforgivable."

"Fine. So you're not some kind of saint, and I'm not some kind of god. We're just two people who have done shitty things."

Izuku's eyes, surprised, revert back to Katsuki's. He tilts his head as in in question, and Katsuki shrugs his shoulders in a non-answer. It's clearly not enough for the other, so he continues to dig his own grave. He's already three feet deep – why not another three more?

"You know what I liked about Zero?"

Izuku physically recoils at the sound of that name from Katsuki's mouth.

"… He wasn't scared of anything. He didn't let anything hold him back. He knew what he wanted and he took it. There's an honesty in that. Despite the fact that he was lying to me, I felt that everything about him was out in the open – genuine. That he wasn't holding anything back from me. I don't – I *never* felt that way with you. I always felt like you were hiding something from me. I always felt like you were lying to me."

Katsuki steps forward, suddenly spurred on by a bravery he didn't know he had. Despite the fact that Izuku's a head taller than him, he puffs out his chest, sneers up into his face.

"Last fucking chance, Deku. Tell me the truth for once." The *please* stays unspoken.

Dazed eyes look past Katsuki. "The truth," Deku mouths, before a determined pair of eyes meet Katsuki's. There's a resolve in there, so astute and thunderous that Katsuki can swear he sees flashes of lightning behind those irises. He brings his hand up to Katsuki's cheek, tracing ever-so-gently against his cheekbones before cupping his face like he's holding something so damn precious. Katsuki grits his teeth, eyes begging to flutter shut so he can focus on just *this,* take in every caress, ever sensation, to remember his hands, his hands, *his hand*…

By the time Katsuki realizes what's happening, its already too late.

The scent of cedar, hot puffs of shallow air, the heat between them escalating until it threatens to become an inferno, consuming them both – before their lips, feather-light, finally meet.

And it's the salve on their burns, it's the rains on the forest fire, it's the taste of a cherry popsicle on a raw throat. Its sweetness and comfort and home and *everything, everything Katsuki could ever want.*

Izuku doesn't melt into it, not like Katsuki, the brush of his chapped lips tentative, terrified, like at any moment Katsuki might push him away, might knock him down and laugh in his face. And Katsuki wants to, just a little. Wants to push him away, wants to see those big round eyes stare up at him, wants this person – grand, world-changing, saint-like hero Deku – to transform back into *his* Deku, pathetic and trembling and blubbery and under Katsuki's control. Katsuki tortures him just a little – doesn't kiss back, lets Izuku start to pull away, lets that moment of panic really plant itself into his brain before Katsuki wraps his arms around his neck, pulling the taller boy down to meet him as he opens his mouth and invites the other in.

It's all electricity; nerves tingle on the tips of his lips as they move against one another, soft and sweet and warm, each slick slide of flesh against flesh feeling like the first time he used his Quirk – tiny fireworks, flittering in and out of existence, tingling his skin, leaving feverish, painful spots relieved by cooling air until they coalesce and grow, more heat, more power, bigger and bigger until it lights up the sky – and he darts out his tongue, runs it along Izuku's plush bottom lip, tasting his desire and swallowing down that needy gasp, those shuddering breaths, the years of unspoken *everything* explained by something so, so embarrassingly simple.

So this is it. So this is Izuku's truth. The thing that's been hiding in those shadows, under those lidded glances, in those shy smiles. All these years, Katsuki always sensed something secret, something just under the surface.

Who fuckin' guessed it's that the nerd wanted to kiss him.

He should laugh. He should tease the other boy. He should do anything at all, but the air between them is humid and heavy, and the sensation of Izuku's hand cradling his jaw is heaven, and those irritating lips, pushing and pulling, nipping and biting, are drawing forth emotions that feel too large,

too overwhelming for his body to handle. He might just drown here, in Izuku's body heat, in Izuku's eyes, in Izuku's lips. He might just drown in him – and that's okay.

The words start to materialize in his head as their lips meet again, and again, and again, as the slide of tender flesh and soft tongue relieve each inch of tension within Katsuki's body, making him delirious and boneless and floating on fucking air. He doesn't want to speak, doesn't want to interrupt, doesn't want their first kiss – their last kiss - to die because of something as insignificant as words, so he kisses with reckless abandon, kisses like he doesn't have a heart to protect.

But there *are* words. Katsuki knows there are words, words he needs to say, and more than anything, words Izuku needs to *hear*.

But what the hell is he supposed to say? That for the first time in his goddamn life he felt a sliver or something magical in his gut, and he thinks it might have been love, but what does it say about him to love someone who doesn't exist, to love a lie, to love something fabricated just to be forgotten? What does it say that the only person Katsuki's let touch his skin in years was a man who is less of a man and more of an idea? What does it say about him when the dream (the beautiful, horrible, awful fucking dream) turned into reality, when the wooden marionette that Katsuki used as a vessel to project all his desires turned out to be a real man, one with blood and bones and sinew, and instead of turning away, instead of dissipating, the desire kept growing, spilling over, spilling out, filling basins and rivers and oceans – desire, bottomless, surging to fill every gap, every nook, every crevasse that once left Katsuki so empty?

How does Katsuki explain that the first time in his life he considered he might be in love is when hands he's dreamt off for nearly twenty years (Now just the one. Half is gone, because it has to be, because to be complete is to give Katsuki more than he deserves) wrapped themselves around his throat, making him wonder if love might be a bit like dying, might be a bit like that last fucking breath when nothing in the goddamn world can feel more cathartic - that last strawberry, the last sip of water, the last bullet in the chamber - and they bled and fought and fucked and destroyed each other and nothing has ever felt to pure and perfect and devastating and absolutely holy - if that's not love, then what the hell is?

He hates him. He hates him he hates him and he loves him. Maybe he's always felt like he deserved this - the most perfect torture, making him love the only person he can never stop hating, making the darkness love the light, making the land love the sea, making stars love the vacuum of space, because how is love supposed to exist between two bodies when the existence of one is the natural absence of the other? - and its fucking funny, haha funny, a joke at a funeral funny, ashes spread on U.A grounds funny - and he wants to tear his hair out because holy fucking shit. He's in love.

It's really that simple.

"I love you."

Izuku pulls back from the kiss, lips still swollen, eyes still hooded, cheeks a strawberry pink and it takes a second for him to emerge from that kiss-induced blissful fugue, a second until Katsuki can see the other process his words in real time. Bliss turns to confusion, then to horror. He steps back slightly, eyebrows arched, shaking his head like he can't believe, *had* to have misheard, what Katsuki just said.

"What?"

"Yeah." Katsuki laughs wetly. "I fucking love you. I've thought about you every day for the last four years. And every day before that, too. I'll probably fucking think about you every single day for the

rest of my miserable life. I didn't want to believe that's what this is – this fucking feeling like someone's carving a hole in my chest with an icepick – and I can come up with every excuse in the book, but here's what I know. Four years ago, I nearly watched you die – and for the first time in my life, I understand what it was like to lose all sense of logic, to forget about *duty* or *winning* or *heroism*. All I could think about was you. And it didn't matter what happened to me. What happened to the rest of the world."

Katsuki scoffs, glancing up at the ceiling, begging for the freshly formed tears threatening to spill from his eyeline to stay right where they are.

"That scared the shit out of me. You know that? I felt like I couldn't control myself. I couldn't stop. I couldn't stop looking for you. I couldn't stop missing you. I couldn't stop *needing* you. And the first fucking person after you disappeared who made me feel anything at all – who made me *want* anything at all – turned out to be you? It was so goddamn obvious - it all fucking fit together, like one of those shitty puzzles, you know? I didn't fucking *get* what that feeling was when I was sixteen, but now I know. I get it. And, shit, Deku – " Katsuki pauses, meeting those glossy, confused greens, "I don't fucking want this. I don't want to love you, but I do."

"…I." Jaw dropped, lips swollen and slick, Izuku Midoriya is speechless.

Katsuki could make a joke about finally finding the sequence of words that shut that annoying boy up, but his chest is shaking and he's trembling and his eyes and his face and lips are salty and he's fucking crying like saying these words finally broke whatever dam he built up within himself over the past 20 years, like this was the final straw that broke the camel's back, the last thread of rope holding him above ground, the last chain around his neck.

Yes.

Free. Free. Free. This love, this secret, this shame had trapped him, but now he's free.

"Yeah. Yeah, that's right. I love you and I'm walking away from you and I never want to see you again. Okay? I never want to see you again."

The first tear, a shooting star, tumbles down the backdrop of freckles on his face.

Katsuki makes a wish.

They tumble freely, one after the other, big, fat, and blubbery. Deku's always been a skilled crier. He's perfected the art of it. That wobble of the lip, the pinching of his chin, the full body sob like he's putting his entire fucking soul into the next slew of tears. He's so fucking pretty Katsuki can't look straight at him.

Because that's the dirty reality of it all. He loves Izuku, but he hates him too. He's awful to him, awful *for* him, and Deku's no better – a reflection of the same fractured mirror, just polished a little bit better. They break each other and bruise each other and beat each other then dip their inflicted scars in gold and call it art.

But he's done - he's done existing only to hurt.

He's done living this half a life.

A quick two knocks alerts them that the police are on their way to take Izuku into custody, and Katsuki steps away, slower than he should, slower than the urgency of the situation should force him

to. Katsuki's looks into his eyes once more – searching for something within them, some kind of answer, but he gets nothing but the constant tumble of stars down those dark eyelashes.

Without a response, Katsuki turns around, placing a hand on the door handle.

"Kacchan." Izuku says, no, begs, *pleads*, and Katsuki doesn't turn back, because in this moment he knows exactly what Izuku must have felt when he made the choice to leave four years ago.

If he turns around, if he acknowledges him, he'll never be able to leave. Izuku is the only person that can make him stay, and he can't. He can't.

"I love you too."

Katsuki can hear, no, *feel* the horrible sob that wracks Izuku's body right after he says it as if it's happening to his own body and he should say something, anything, give him a final word, some kind of platitude, some kind of promise, *anything.*

But ending it with this ellipses, with this lack of completeness, feels right.

Something bitter on the lips, so the lingering desire to taste sweetness never fades.

Katsuki turns the handle, closing the door gently behind him. He holds himself together – anything to prevent himself from collapsing onto his knees, from grabbing onto this dirty concrete floor, from weeping into Todoroki's pant leg until every ounce of this pain finally seeps out of him. Instead, he flexes his muscles, paints his face into a mask of indifference, and spares Todoroki a single look, the only thanks he can offer without losing himself, before he walks away.

Robotically, he steps outside the courtroom doors.

It's a warm spring day. Greenery is budding in each crevasse of the world, flowers threatening their bloom along every treetop, rays of sunshine dance along the busy streets. Even the breeze is gentle, playful.

Katsuki is free. The world is bright.

He's going to be okay.

As soon as he can will himself to move.

He feels her before he sees her – that small, oppressive force that he's been drawn to and disgusted by for years. He doesn't look to her – just knows that eventually, after clearing her throat in that way she always does, she'll speak.

"…What am I supposed to do now?" Inko Midoriya whispers out to the street. No more fretting, no more restless nights, no more 'what if's.' Her son is back, but despite that, she's still alone. They both are.

"I don't know." Katsuki responds honestly.

"Find something else to live for, I guess."

Katsuki's not quite sure which one of them he's talking to, lost in his own thoughts. Inko doesn't speak again, and when Katsuki finally looks to his left, he sees that Mirko has replaced her.

She's standing next to him, arms crossed and entirely still, unusually quiet for such a boisterous woman.

"Wha'da'ya want?" he finally breaks the silence.

She makes no motion to acknowledge him.

"… So you're suspended for three months," she starts, like Katsuki doesn't fucking remember.

"Yeah," he responds.

"… here. If you're still looking for a job then, you know where to find me. I liked the balls you showed in there. You're a smart kid and you can get your hands dirty to get shit done. I need someone like that in Hiroshima. Give it some thought."

Katsuki frowns as he watches her walk away, the card in his hand already dampening with his sweat.

"…Whoa, what did Mirko want?" Kirishima bounds in out of nowhere, mouth a sharp grin as he taps Katsuki on the shoulder.

"She wants me to work for her. She's insane." Katsuki pushes off the wall and starts to walk, hands in his pockets to hide the shake of his fingers.

"You gonna take her up on it?" Kirishima wonders, and Katsuki shrugs.

"Hiroshima in ten hours away."

Kirishima seems to think for a moment, before winking at Katsuki like he's got something all figured out.

"Hey, what ever happened to that person you were seeing? The one you were… uh." Kirishima rubs the back of his head, but Katsuki knows exactly what he's referring to. The day they stopped by the apartment. The day he nearly broke Utsushimi's hand.

"Didn't work out." Katsuki says flatly. Kirishima nods in response, staying quiet for a solid five seconds.

"Well, dude, you've got three months until you can work again and sounds like you've got nothin' holding you down here! How about you take a vacation? You haven't come to visit me even once yet!"

Katsuki's about to refuse – the word is on the tip of his mouth – when he remembers.

He remembers the night in the tent, laying side by side with Zero, listening to the fucker talk about his time in the United States. About what it was like to look at the stars in the middle of the desert, what it felt like to stand in a field of wheat taller than your head, what it felt like to be in the middle of a large city and have no one look at you twice. What it felt like to be a part of something grander that yourself.

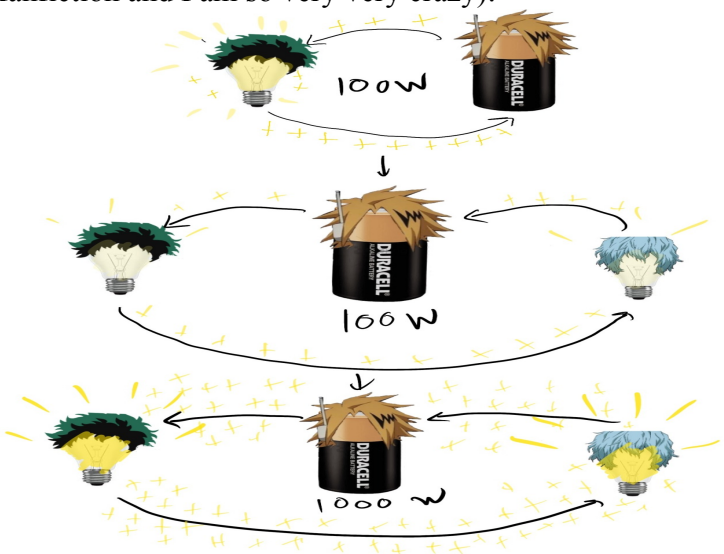
He thinks about the places he's gone, the world he's seen, the people's he's become. Then he thinks of himself – same apartment, same town, same life, paralyzed by fear. But now Deku's here – now he's got no choice but to be stationary. And Katsuki can finally – finally. Be set free.

"Yeah, fine," Katsuki relents, grimacing at the blinding smile his friend gives him in response.

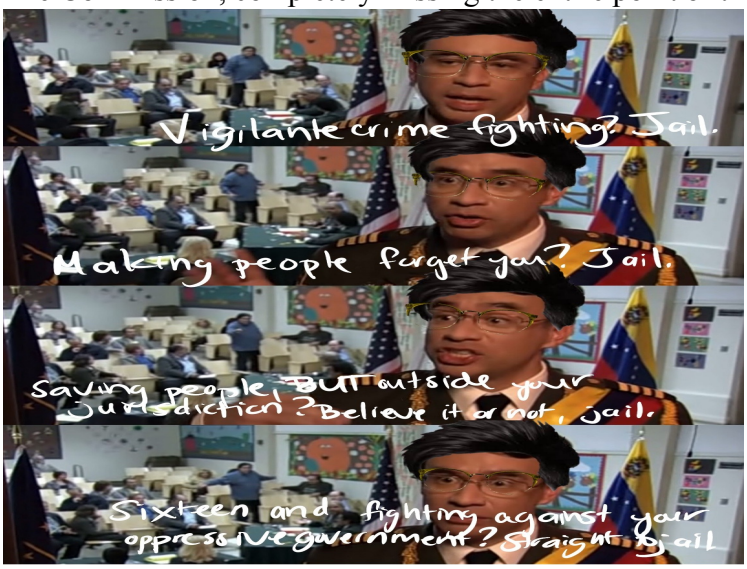
“When are we leaving?”

Chapter End Notes

A Visual of Katsuki's Brilliant Lesson (also if you understand how electricity actually works I totally know that this metaphor actually doesn't 100% work but suspend your disbelief this is fanfiction and I am so very very crazy):



The Commission, completely missing the entire point of the trial:



Katsuki, irreparably changed, having everyone and their mothers (literally) come up to chat with him:



Haha. Haha. I'm very normal about this chapter. Its fine. Everything's fine. The Author Is Normal About The Concept Of Letting Go Of The Person You Love And Trying To Live Life Without Them, Feeling The Emptiness Slowly Get Smaller But Never Really Being Whole Again

Next up: Healing Arc, AKA Katsuki's Hot Girl Summer. And I promise promise PROMISE its DKBK endgame. Happy and healthy and in love even.

On another note, I'd love feedback regarding the confession scene, particularly from people who have read other things I've written. I always feel like my confession scenes are lackluster and kinda disappointing, so I tried to go a little more prose-y in this one but not sure if it worked or just made it less comprehensible? Yikes. YIKES.

Anyways I think I need therapy after writing this lmao.

Chapter 20

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The desert air is torridly dry, making his nostrils burn and throat itch with every breath. All the air conditioning in the world can't camouflage the sheer, unforgiving heat; Katsuki's shirt sticks to his chest, his joggers are chafing his thighs, and every time somebody brushes past him he can *feel* their sweat evaporating off his own skin.

He spent the first however many minutes barking at each fucker who dared intrude into his personal space, but the constant flow of people just made it an exercise in futility. So now he lets his rage simmer just under the surface, repurposed as a hydraulic system to keep himself upright.

He leans farther into the glass counter, fingers wrapped firmly around his drink like any moment someone might pry it out of his grip.

The counter itself is glass, backlit with LEDs, under which plays a high definition hologram of koi swimming in a pond. Despite the fingerprints and spilled beer marring the screen, its unexpectedly lifelike.

Katsuki's eyes track the orange one, adorned with black spots that look suspiciously like his hero mask, as it swims down the bar. He disappears eventually – only to magically reappear on the other side. He swims, disappears, and reappears again.

Does he know this isn't real? That he's just an imitation of the real thing, a charade of beauty for ungrateful eyes? Does he know that no matter how hard he swims, he'll never get anywhere? That there isn't a *where* to get to? That it's all a fuckin' lie?

Shit. Katsuki drags the drink closer to his face, opening his lips just wide enough to capture the straw between his teeth.

He didn't really expect his thoughts to be this fucking morose. This entire goddamn city is structured – no, specifically *designed* – to be the perfect distraction. Too bright and too loud to allow for these kinds of thoughts to slither inside.

He's stumbling through this circus with funeral clothes on, trying to convince himself that it's a fuckin' party, damn it!

The alcohol was supposed to help.

It, decidedly, is not helping.

"Come on, ladies, it's my boy's 21st birthday!"

A large hand claps on Katsuki's shoulder; he's too out of it to stop himself from bucking under the weight.

"Oh my gosh!!! Happy birthday!!! Next round's on us! Wanna do some shots?"

Excited squeals erupt around Katsuki and he leans further into the table, refusing to acknowledge the voices screeching near his ear. The world tips as his chair is spun around, and Katsuki's eyes refocus

on three pairs of tits – two of which belong to a duo of scantily clad women that he's never seen before, one of which belong to a guy who hasn't learned what a fuckin' shirt is in the six years Katsuki's known him.

"Not even close," Katsuki grunts to Kirishima as he grabs onto the bar and swivels himself back to the koi and his near-empty drink.

Kirishima has been nothing but the ever-faithful Golden Retriever, fetching things and presenting them to Katsuki as an offering. *Will this make you happy? Is this what you want?*

Katsuki knows *exactly* what he wants. He knows *exactly* who he wants to talk to, who he wants to see, where he wants to be, and *that* is making him absolutely fucking desolate. All the tits and booze in the world can't fix that.

But you can't blame a man for trying.

There's probably shots. Probably. Katsuki's downs whatever people put into his hands, because who the fuck cares, because he's never drank in his life since *what if I'm shitfaced and the League attacks and that's when Deku reappears, Deku Deku Deku* and the neon lights are starting to blur in front of him, and there's noise, just noise, and none of it makes any goddamn sense, and he's just so fucking tired.

Next thing he knows, one of them is dragging him up by his elbow, and he's leaving this bar, and the koi keeps swimming in their virtual little pond, and nothing matters. Nothing matters.

One day, you might be standing on death's door, the world crumbling around you, and the next you're in a shitty bar watching holographic koi.

One day, you're telling the boy you love that you love him and you say it in a way that means *no, not in a good way, I meant it as a wound that will always fester, I meant it as a killing blow* and you hear him crying and you don't turn around. You don't look back.

You can never look back.

Because you have to live, you have to survive, and to look back, to love him like you love him is to *die.*

"The show's about to start!" Katsuki barely processes the eardrum-piercing shriek in his ear.

The show? Katsuki blinks a few times, raising his head and rotating his neck. He's in a completely different setting than he was approximately 8 seconds ago. Him, Kirishima and the two girls from the bar are all sat around a table stacked with drinks, front and center in front of a stage obscured by red curtains.

Katsuki reaches forward and grabs whatever the fuck is in front of him. He brings It to his lips – water, he figures. He chugs it down just to have something to do.

He doesn't remove his eyes from the glass as the lights dim and an announcer speaking in too-fast, sultry English says something that Katsuki can't understand. If the crowd's reaction is anything to go by, Katsuki's going to want to end his miserable existence exactly two minutes into this. He sets a mental clock.

One twenty.

With great trepidation, as the music starts, Katsuki's eyes blearily move up to the stage.

About ten men, all dressed in suits and ties, are standing shoulder to shoulder.

One hundred.

The lights dim around them, one light appearing overhead for each man on stage. A heavy bass beat vibrates Katsuki's glass. Heads dropped, one by one they look up dramatically. Each one is finely chiseled, similar height and build, handsome in that photo-copied way that's both unthreatening and universally appealing.

One by one, in sync to the music and the flashing lights above them they rip they pants clean off their bodies, tossing them into the screaming audience as they reveal their true outfits – G-string, bowtie, and literally nothing else.

Sixty.

Katsuki's eyebrows shoot to the top of his head, a surprised laugh bubbling straight out of his stomach.

Kirishima turns to him the second that laugh makes its way past Katsuki's lips, unable to hide his own smile as the two girls accompanying them giggle and grip onto each other, screaming along with the rest of the audience at each particularly creative twist of hips.

Forty.

Twenty.

Zero, and Katsuki forgets that he's supposed to hate this.

The tunes are all English but familiar enough for Katsuki to bop his head along to, whole body relaxing into the rhythm as dudes three times as buff as himself shake their muscular asses for his viewing pleasure.

They're all really talented. The costume changes, the choreography, the tasteful bulge. He stares at one man's thighs as they wrap around a stripper pole, holding himself up with nothing but the clench of those muscles, abdominals flexing with each rotation.

Those legs. Crush-your-head and suffocate-you kinda thighs. Katsuki feels all the saliva in the back of his throat dry up, as unprompted memories of *other* legs, *other* thighs invade his mind.

"Now, ladies and gentlemen…. THE HEROES OF THE WORLD!"

Katsuki watches, stunned, as men wearing G-string versions of hero costumes, adorned with horrible wigs and the ugliest fucking makeup he's ever seen strut confidently onto the stage.

Star and Stripe, Salaam, fucking *All Might?* Katsuki sounds foreign to his own ears – he's sure its his mouth that's moving, he's sure that sound is coming from his windpipe – but its so unfamiliar, this *laughter.* The one that won't stop tearing through his body, making all his muscles convulse uncontrollably, tears gather in the corners of his eyes as his lungs forget how to breathe – particularly when looking at that fuckin' All-Might look alike, giant painted smile and all.

He keeps one hand on his abdomen, the old injury flaring at the flexion of his stomach – and the ridiculousness of that, the injury he got *for* All Might's successor, the one that looks exactly *like* All

Might's career ending wound, makes the whole situation that much more fuckin' hilarious.

Katsuki knew his entire life was a goddamn joke, but he's relieved to find that at least it's a funny one.

Their entire life is a joke. They share the same one, don't they?

"Deku, you seeing this sh – "

Katsuki turns, fully expecting Izuku to be there. Losing his entire fucking mind. Muttering up a storm. Ready to ask the guy for an autograph or some shit. He wouldn't even be horny about it – would probably ask the dude for workout tips. Izuku is –

Katsuki looks around the table, smile faltering.

Izuku is not here.

Izuku Midoriya is in Tartarus.

Where he'll spend his 21st birthday. Hated and vilified by the very people that he saved.

Alone.

This suddenly isn't so fun anymore.

"AYYY! ALL MIGHT! We've got a birthday boy here!!!" One of the girls from before yells, waving a fifty dollar bill in the air.

It, unfortunately, captures Stripper-Might's attention.

"Can we treat him to a special dance?" One of the girls asks, pushing her arms together so her tits look particularly large. Stripper-Might smiles his award-winning smile and guides her hand into his G-string, flaunting the crisp fifty gleaming against his meaty thigh for the rest of the audience. The bill *slides,* like the entire fucker is covered in oil, and then turns his fake baby-blues onto Katsuki.

Katsuki sees it happening in slow motion.

The horrible wig.

The off-white smile that doesn't reach his eyes.

Fuck, the cheesy star the dude's got painted on his chest.

His whole body breaks out in a cold sweat, each hair standing on end. The room doesn't smell like sweat anymore – no, everything is smoke, plumes of putrid smoke blinding him, choking him, trying to crawl into his mouth and he can't *breathe.* And it's All Might, All Might standing in front of him, and he's smiling but his teeth are stained with blood *and is it his own? Is it his own?*, and its *gone,* One for All is *gone,* and Katsuki ended him, ended All Might just like he ended Deku just like he ended One for All.

His fault.

His fault his fault *his fault.*

Katsuki doesn't know when he got up, when he started running – he vaguely hears the chair clatter behind him, the doors slamming open, the surprised gasps from the rest of the audience, but his hands are numb and he doesn't know where he's going or what he's doing, all he fucking knows is that the smoke is choking him choking him choking him and he can't fucking *breathe.*

Katsuki stumbles out in the street, shoulder-checking whoever he can in the dense crowd, all protests and drunken annoyance unheard to Katsuki's frazzled ears. Its too much. Too many people, too many hands, too many bodies, too many voices – its too much *too much* and Katsuki knows he shouldn't, but his hands are dripping and his heart is crawling out of his throat and all he wants is *out.*

He launches himself in the sky, one carefully timed explosion after another. He hears the same people pushing him and throwing expletives just seconds before now pointing, laughing, clapping – like his display is some kind of show – and fuck if it isn't.

Hundreds of feet above ground, wind cooling his caustic sweat, the noise dissipates, and the spring in his chest coiled impossibly tight finally releases, allowing for the free flow of air.

When his brain clears up he identifies his target – a skyscraper just a few feet below - and sends another small explosion behind him to propel himself towards the roof.

He stands at the edge, letting the cool air evaporate the sweat collecting on his forehead.

He doesn't know where he is. He doesn't know where the strip club was relative to the bar relative to Kirishima's apartment relative to Japan itself. The lights blur as Katsuki tries to search the landscape for something recognizable, but it's all the *same,* and these blinking neon lights hurt his eyes, and he's so fucking *tired.* He's just so, so goddamn tired.

Katsuki exhales. He sits down on the edge, letting his legs dangle over. Placing his arms behind his head, he lays back. The world is bleary and spinning and he's nauseated. It's too much, and still not enough. It's too much, but he's still empty.

He swears he closed his eyes for just a second, but when he opens them again, there's a red blur sitting next to him. There's a six pack of what looks like beer between them, one slot already sitting empty as Kirishima reaches for another. Katsuki can't read his expression – he looks very, very far away. Shoulders drooped, legs hanging over the edge, he looks much older than twenty-one.

Katsuki's drunk brain doesn't let him swallow down the guilt.

Kirishima didn't sign up to deal with his fucking temper tantrums. He was just trying to show Katsuki a good time, and all he's done is fucking mope and complain like a goddamn asshole.

He props himself up on his elbows to alert the other that he's awake.

After a brief silent moment, Kirishima just sighs.

"…Sorry, dude. We thought it would be fun." Kirishima admits, swinging his feet over the edge of the building.

Katsuki props himself up the rest of the way.

"It *was* fun." His voice is scratchy, and he clears his throat before he speaks again. "It's not your fucking fault I freaked out. I'm just…"

On top of this building, up above the world, its unexpectedly silent. All the chaos and lights below them now seem so far away, like they're occurring on a different planet. Its colder up here too, but the alcohol is warming Katsuki from the inside, seeping through his veins, making his mouth all slack and stupid.

"My head's still fucked. And everywhere I go, I just keep thinking how much he'd like this. No matter what I do, I can't get him out of my head. This blows."

How is he doing?

Is he okay?

Is he eating?

Is he sleeping?

Does he still have nightmares?

Does he still think about Katsuki?

"…That person you were dating?"

Katsuki grimaces. He's never dated someone in his life, and he definitely never dated Deku. It's never even crossed his mind. What the fuck would that even look like? When they're not violently beating the shit out of one another or fucking like each of them is about to die (*mostly because they were*,) all they did is miscommunicate and try to one up each other in the endless competition of who can ruin the other's life more.

"…We were never…" Katsuki swallows down the nausea, the pleasant dizziness making the bottom of the building look very friendly.

Deku said that at some point he tried to do this, right? Walk straight off a building. He can imagine him like he's standing right next to him. Can imagine those tentative steps to the top of the roof. That terrified but determined look on his face – a look that Katsuki is intimately familiar with. The slight tremor in his hand, the one he thinks no one can see when he's frightened.

He wonders what went through the nerd's head as he took that step over the edge.

He wonders whether he was relieved or disappointed when he didn't fall.

They were never… whatever Kirishima is implying. They never can be.

Katsuki feels himself choke up for no reason in particular.

"Man. I didn't realize you guys were so serious."

Katsuki says nothing, letting his eyes drift. Outside the small haven of bright lights and crowded streets, Katsuki sees an expanse of nothing. Something in the back of his psyche pulls him towards that darkness, but he reigns that feeling in.

"…I kinda had something like that too. A while ago. It does get better, eventually."

Katsuki furrows his eyebrows, turning his head towards Kirishima as the words connect in his sluggish brain. The other is staring at his own hands, laying uselessly in his lap. His lips are upturned

in a sad smile, eyes somewhere distant, wistful. It's the saddest Katsuki's ever seen Kirishima, and it makes something uncomfortable bubble up in his stomach.

"…You did?"

Kirishima glances up as if he didn't expect Katsuki to respond. He meets his eyes, then, as if on second thought, nods slightly.

"…Yeah. We were together for two years. Back in high school."

In high school? The high school that Katsuki went to? Shit, him and Kirishima shared a *wall.*

"Fuck, really? Who was it? An upperclassman or some shit?"

Kirishima scratches the back of his head, looking sheepish.

"Uh. No. It was Kaminari."

Katsuki snorts a laugh, feeling the mix of liquor shoot from his stomach and burn straight into his sinuses. He never even *considered.* Kaminari was such a creep around women sometimes, plus he's stupid as shit, plus –

"Dude, come on, don't laugh. He's an amazing guy." Kirishima defends, small smile playing on his lips like he's stuck in some kind of bittersweet memory.

"I had no idea." Katsuki says, honestly. Kirishima just shrugs.

"Yeah, you had a lot of your own shit going on that year. It felt like I lost my best friend, and Kaminari and I grew closer, and… well, it doesn't matter now. It was my fault we broke up anyway."

Katsuki says nothing, waiting for Kirishima to continue. The other gazes out at the city before him, eyes shining with something more than the glare of rhythmic lights.

"…He wanted to stay. I wanted to leave. And I could have stayed in Japan for him. But I didn't."

"…Shit, I'm sorry."

Kirishima shakes his head.

"Don't be. We're friends. I mean… not in the same way. Never in the same way. But we're okay."

Katsuki leans over to the six-pack, grabbing a beer. It feels nice in his hands – cool and heavy. He places the bottle against his forehead. His head is already starting to throb – foreshadowing of the morning to come, one that Katsuki is more than happy to keep postponing. He twists open the cap, grimacing at the bitter taste only a little as he downs the bottle like he's trying to set the record for 'most brain damage one can do to themselves in one night.'

In his opinion, he's winning.

Kirishima fidgets with the wrapper of the beer, rolling the pieces of paper into small balls between his too-big fingers, voice resigned.

"Maybe a part of the reason I left was because I didn't want to get hurt. He couldn't leave me or hurt me if I was the one that left, ya know? Sometimes it's easier to be the one who leaves. I still don't

know if it was the right choice, even after all this time. I still miss him a lot. But I know he's okay – that he's still happy, and that he's my friend."

Katsuki hates how much Kirishima's words make sense.

"You still love him," Katsuki concludes, because it's the most obvious thing in the world.

"Yeah. I do."

They stay quiet for a while. Katsuki can't imagine. Can't imagine being someone's friend, being *okay* with them, after that kind of love. How do you keep living? How can you ever look at them again and not drown in that pain?

"…How did you… deal with it?" Katsuki asks, sincerely curious.

"Not well, for a while." Kirishima laughs bitterly. "I blocked his number. I… I did some stupid stuff. Slept around. Drank too much. Threw myself into some dangerous situations. All of it just made me more miserable. Made me miss him more."

Katsuki doesn't try to hide the way his jaw drops. He would have never expected this from him. He's Kirishima. Honor and integrity are his first, middle *and* last names. *Kaminari* fucked him up that bad? *Kaminari* rejected him? *HIM?*

"…But it got better. I went to therapy. I made friends out here. I started finding the fun in hero work again. I worked on myself, ya know? Eventually I un-blocked his number. We started chatting again. He came out here to visit. It still hurt a lot. Seeing him hurt a lot. Knowing he was dating again nearly took me out for a week." Kirishima chuckles once more, this time nearly soundlessly. "It's stupid. I should be happy for him."

"…Huh." Katsuki replies. "…Do you still." Katsuki swallows. "Do you still think about him?"

Kirishima sets his beer down, tilting his head in confusion.

"Of course I do…" silence extends between them. "It's okay, you know. To think about them."

Katsuki's eyes avert to watch the busy streets below them.

Is it?

Is any of this okay?

"It's easy to be bitter and distract yourself and pretend they never existed. But they did, and they do, and they mattered to you. It's not a crime to remember them. It's not a crime to remember how they made you feel. The times with them, both good and bad, played a part into making you into who you are now, right? Why fight that? If you lean into the blade, the cut will hurt much less. You get sliced either way."

It's exactly that. Katsuki has been running head-first into that blade, over and over and over again, and his skin is flayed and gutted and he knows it's killing him, he *knows,* but he just can't just *stop*. If said knife wasn't forcibly taken from him, Katsuki would probably let it slice him up until there was nothing left.

"… You don't get it." Katsuki finally says, shaking his head.

"…What don't I get?"

Katsuki breathes in deeply, letting these words, the same ones rolling around his head ever since he got on that plane and felt the taught string between him and Deku stretch to near-breaking, crawl out of his slack mouth.

"I've never felt that way before. I never *let* myself feel like that before. Never that high. And never that fucking low. And when it was gone… It was like… like suddenly seeing the world in color and only then realizing you've seen everything in black and white your entire goddamn life. And the absence of that thing is so fucking *stark.* Like I never knew I wanted it, and then it was gone, and I can't ever fucking have it back. And I feel so fucking *empty* without it. Tasting even a little bit of what it could be… I don't know how I can live without it. Without him."

Kirishima doesn't so much as twitch, his eyes fixed on Katsuki.

"…But it was the right thing to do. We were going to destroy each other. We *want* to destroy each other. He makes me feel crazy. Like I want to crawl into his skin. More than that. Like I want both our bodies to be dumped into a grave together. That I want our rot and decay and flesh to wither away, to intermix, for the worms that decompose us to take equal bites of each. I want the flowers, the grass, the trees that grow from our corpses to be equal parts him, equal parts me. And even that isn't close enough. I don't want just to be *near* him. I want to *be* him. I want to wake up and see the world through his eyes. To feel his pain. To taste and fuck and hurt in every way he does. I want *him.*"

"…Bakugou."

Kirishima seems to have sobered a thousand times over, eyebrows furrowed in something akin to concern, his too-honest eyes having a difficult time hiding the discomfort underneath. Katsuki grinds his teeth down before twisting the cap off his second beer bottle and tipping his head back, letting the taste of alcohol dilute his shame.

"Don't look at me like that. I *know.* I fucking know how it sounds! I'm fucking *saying it.* I hate him for doing this to me."

"…Do you?"

Katsuki glares at Kirishima, wiping the dribble of beer off his chin with the back of his hand. Did he not hear him?

"…Because it sounds like you hate the way he makes you feel. Sounds like you hate *yourself* because he makes you feel out of control."

Katsuki's tongue suddenly feels much too large for the back of his mouth. He wants to bridge the distance between them, pick up Kirishima by those stupid lapels of his vest and throw him over the side of the building just for implying… whatever the fuck he's implying.

But he can't find it in him to argue.

It's always been like that. Katsuki has never been able to control himself around Deku.

…But when that lack of control manifested as anger, at least it was a little easier to stomach.

Without thinking, he lets himself flop backwards, barely protecting his head as it meets concrete. He can see Kirishima out of the corner of his eyes, panicked and moving towards him, only pausing as he sees Katsuki rub the bridge of his nose with a hand, completely unharmed.

"…Fuck." Katsuki comments casually.

Kirishima just snorts, following Katsuki in laying down on the grimy roof.

"You wanna head home?" Kirishima asks, and Katsuki scoffs.

Home.

"And where exactly the fuck is that?"

Because it's not here. It's not in Tokyo. It's not in Musutafu.

He can't go home.

He was never really there.

And that's the last thing Katsuki remembers.

Waking up is less of 'awakening' as it is 'getting water-boarded by the sun.' Each drop of sunlight is making Katsuki gag and lurch, and he's about to empty every inch of his half-stomach onto Kirishima's god-awful velvet couch as he painfully pries his own eyes open. His mouth tastes like shit, his skin is sticky and crusty with fuck-knows-what, and his head is splitting down the middle like he's a coconut being thrown off a building at mach-speed.

"How the fuck did we get back?" Katsuki's voice sounds like someone put it through the blender, and he tries to clear his throat, instantly gagging at the taste of one thousand different types of alcohol hitting his taste buds.

The permeating scent of eggs and coffee doesn't help. At all.

"You passed out. I carried you. It was very heroic of me. Just sayin'." Kirishima teases, walking towards Katsuki, bringing the *smells* closer to his tattered senses.

"I hate you." Katsuki growls, still taking the plate of eggs and showing them into his face, because he'd rather throw up eggs than acid and regret, which is what the bottom of his stomach tastes like right now.

"No you dooonnnt!" Kirishima sing-songs, making Katsuki's head pound.

"You told me all about your feeeelllinnngs! Katsuki's in looooooveeee."

Katsuki feels his face go red hot.

He doesn't exactly remember all of the previous night – there's vague memories of All Might in a G-string, which will surely haunt him until the day he dies - but if he told Kirishima that he is actually, truly, ridiculously fucked up about (…in love *with)* Deku, he will never live it down. Ever.

"Kirishima, I swear to god – "

Kirishima raises his hands in his defense.

"Don't worry, dude. Your sappy feelings are safe with me."

“I don’t have any – “

“Eat up, man! We need to head out soon if we’re going to get to our campsite by the time the sun sets!”

Katsuki groans.

Kirishima owns one of those shitty gas-guzzling SUVs, painted a bright red. He blasts music loud and the air conditioner louder. He finds himself settling into a peaceful quiet, only slightly irritated at Kirishima’s off-beat banging on his steering wheel and awful falsetto in too-fast English to vaguely recognizable American pop-music on the radio.

Katsuki watches this city disappear, the desert appearing dramatically in front of him, taking over the entire landscape in its vastness.

Katsuki’s grown up in the city. He’s ridden crowded trains, walked sidewalks where he couldn’t so much as spread his arms, waited in lines for restaurants, sat in traffic the few times he’s rented a car. His favorite moments were when his father and him would go on hikes outside the city or spend the whole weekend up in the mountains camping.

It’s like the noisier his environment, the noisier his own brain would be. And the only time he could untangle his own thoughts would be out in nature.

The desert opens itself up, sand turning to sun-beat ground to red and gold-streaked mountains. Greenery - a different kind that Katsuki was used to but greenery none the less – livens up the view with wide-spread roots and leaves praying up to the ever-present sun.

Kirishima parks in a lot with few other cars, throwing Katsuki’s satchel at him as he dons a wide-brim hat and slathers himself with sun screen with practiced ease.

They start to walk, shortly passing by a large sign introducing them to ‘Red Rock Canyon National Park.’

Katsuki scoffs. Watching his red-haired, built-like-a-rock friend in his stupid cargo shorts and muscle tank, scar-tissue peaking past his shoulders like fucked up angel wings scurry between rust-tinted mountains feels… right, somehow.

“Anyways, like half my job is rounding up drunk tourists and getting them to their hotels so they don’t get arrested. It’s like everyone in Vegas thinks they’re the lead character of their own movie. It’s hilarious.”

The smile is obvious in Kirishima’s words, and Katsuki’s stomach twists.

“Too bad I got your ass suspended.”

“You got my ass on *sabbatical.”* Kirishima corrects. “And stop beating yourself up over that, man! Higher ups at the agency loved that stuff. ‘All press is good press’, or whatever. Don’t worry about it.”

In a way, Katsuki is grateful. He might have ripped each strand of his hair out one by one if he was left sitting in Kirishima’s apartment day-in and day-out while the fucker worked. There’s something nice about them both being suspended, as selfish as that is. It makes it feel like they’re on a no-obligations free-for-all post-high school trip that Katsuki never got to go on.

It's not that he felt left out. He didn't *want* to go.

He just didn't know it would be the last time he saw many of his former classmates for fuck knows how long, including Kirishima.

But that's all in the past.

By the time they get to their campsite at the top of a flat-looking mountain – a *mesa*, apparently, like Katsuki cares – the sun is making its way down over the horizon. Kirishima and Katsuki get to setting up their tents soundlessly.

Kirishima wanders off in the evening light, gathering up rocks, stacking his own firewood and scrunching up old newspapers over the top. Katsuki gives the fire pit a slight spark and blows on it gently, kindling the flame. As the desert cools, the controlled flames flicker to life. Katsuki and Kirishima exchange an excited glance, letting themselves settle with the fire between them.

Kirishima makes the American experience real authentic with a nice assortment of pig's asses – *hot dogs*, whatever – roasted over the open flame, and Katsuki enjoys watching the not-meat brown under the open fire.

They're full and comfortable when Katsuki decides to break the silence.

"…. How are you okay with me?"

"…What do you mean, man?" Kirishima responds, tilting his head.

"I was a dick to you for years. And you still fucking saved my life, and are hanging out with me now like nothing's changed. How are you cool with me? I'd fucking hate me."

Kirishima's lips quirk into a gentle smile.

"Why would I hate you? It was *Midoriya*. You've never been… logical when it came to him."

Kirishima's eyes flash to Katsuki's, voice deep with a certain understanding that makes Katsuki's cheeks pinken.

"I knew you had to figure things out yourself. And that I'd be there once you did. I'm not mad at you for hurting. I'm not even mad at you for pushing us away. I knew you'd come back. I always believed in you, dude."

"And you call me sappy…" Katsuki mumbles under his breath, using the stick he's been holding to poke at the fire in front of him, trying to convince himself that the heat and embers are the reason his eyes are burning.

"You're gonna be okay, you know."

Its gentler than it should be, sincere enough to throw Katsuki off balance. Katsuki swallows, looking up at his friend. Illuminated by the flickering flames, Kirishima's red eyes look distant, gentle, so much more knowledgeable and mature than Katsuki remembers. He's lived a whole life out here – grew into the man he always wanted to be.

He doesn't want to say he admires the guy – half of his life is completely nonsensical to Katsuki – but he's *him,* he did what was right for him, and he still finds it in him to be forgiving and kind. It reminds

him of someone else, too, and Katsuki can't help but laugh at himself for being so fucking predictable.

"Oh, crap! We should go. You ready?"

"…What the hell you talking about?!"

"Here." Kirishima hands digs through his tent, taking out a flashlight and handing it to Katsuki. Katsuki tests it out; flipping the switch makes the thing emit a very faint blue light. Not enough to see four inches in front of them, much less multiple feet in the desert in the middle of the fucking night.

"Shithead, your flashlight's broken."

"Oh, no, dude. That's the scorpion light. We're going to wear head flashlights!" Kirishima points it out by snapping on a headband, nearly blinking Katsuki when he flicks on the light.

"…Did you just fucking say *scorpion light?* Kirishima!"

Kirishima ignores him, walking forward like he knows exactly where the fuck he's going, forcing Katsuki to half-jog after him. The night is pitch black and silent in a way that makes the slightest scuttle deafening. Katsuki shudders; he has no idea if those noises are just the footsteps of a tiny desert mouse or the big-ass tarantulas that hunt them. And, maybe that's not for him to know. Afterall, Katsuki's just a guest here.

It's a moonless night, so outside the stupid flashlight pinned to both their foreheads, he can't see a goddamn thing. Even so, without those alleys, without those familiar streets, Katsuki feels his guard dropping. There's no villain waiting for him here. There's no memories threatening to burst forward. There's no flashbacks because there's nothing to flash back to. This is all novel, completely outside his known reality. He inhales and tastes dust on his tongue; there's a rightness to that, too.

The climb makes his legs ache is a familiar, pleasant way. He keeps his mind focused on each subsequent step. Every few seconds, he'd shine the scorpion light around him, just to make sure there's no surprises waiting for either one of them along their trek.

"We're here." Kirishima finally says, and plops down on a particularly flat rock. Katsuki sits down next to him.

Katsuki stares ahead. Its dark as shit, there's nothing around them, and he doesn't really…

His head tilts to just above him and his heart stutters.

The stars overlap, one after another, so plentiful and bright that he swears if he reaches up he could touch one. Comb his fingers through their heat, find the brightest and hold it between his index and thumb, scrutinize it as it burns down to his rotten core. Place it between his lips, let it roll around his tongue, swallow it so it swallows him.

"Look man, it's starting!" Kirishima points excitedly to the sky as the first trail of white shooting across the sky.

One after another after another they fall, thousands of light-years away, blazing hotter than his insignificant life can ever hope to. One after another they fall, older than time itself, existing because they *are* existence, because only something as silly as the human mind can look at millions and billions of years of condensed gas and think *shit. This is greater than me. From where I came, I will return. Dust to dust to dust to dust.*

Who is he to think his own fall is so grand when stars around them are collapsing one by one and even they can't make a single dent in this night sky?

Maybe it's okay to burn and burn and burn, okay to grow so hot that the small world around you can no longer contain your calidity, maybe it's okay to implode. To use the same untamable fire and turn it inside.

Maybe it's okay to become more as you become less. Maybe the only way to keep going is to end.

The lights burns his retinas. His heart aches, it aches and breaks and bleeds and yet, its so full because he never thought that he would be able to touch something like this. Never thought his fingertips could grace this *feeling* without being laced through scarred fingers of another.

It's funny. Being both insignificant and grateful for it.

Is this what he saw? Blood pouring down his temples, alone in this arid desert, away from all those that know his name, did he look up at these same stars, did he let their magnificence comfort him in what he thought might be the end of his very short life?

"… Though my soul may set it darkness, it will rise with perfect light. I have loved the stars too fondly to be fearful of the night," Katsuki whispers slowly, tasting each word on his tongue.

Somehow, under this sky, he *understands* him.

He doesn't want to. He doesn't want to understand – he wants the hate, the bitterness, the hurt to fester forever. It's his last line of defense.

He had tirelessly built up his fortress against Deku's onslaught age four onward, and the fucker did everything in his power to chip away at it. Year by year.

Even when he's not here, he's somehow still bulldozing past every wall Katsuki has put up.

"…Dude, what?" Kirishima laughs slightly and shakes his head. "You reciting poetry? That's manly as hell, bro."

"Shut the fuck up." Katsuki responds, less malice in his voice than he intends.

And he does.

As they head back to the campsite, Katsuki catches himself smiling, a profound peace settling like a warm blanket over his body.

On the hard desert ground, in the vacuum of silence, the nightmares don't come.

Katsuki sleeps through the night.

It's odd. He's been avoiding *this,* coming here, seeing his old friend, for over a year now. But when the prospect of leaving suddenly comes up, he's already homesick. For the desert, for Kirishima, for being another empty face in a crowd of people too drunk or high to give a damn about him. There's something relieving – cathartic, even – in that.

Kirishima sheds a manly tear as he waves him off in the airport. Katsuki shakes his head, trying to hide his exasperated smile, nothing but the duffel bag on his back that seems to have doubled in size since landing in the States.

He doesn't think. Not really. He keeps his eyes fixed to the window, seeing the expanse of desert, miles of nothingness save for single roads, slowly form into cities and mountains and life.

The humidity is the first thing that hits him, hair fluffing up in the heat; entirely different than the dry air in Las Vegas. He looks around, eyes instantly drawn to the bright pink hair standing out in the crowd, trailing up in embarrassment to the giant sign the two girls are holding with his *hero name* drawn in huge English bubble letters, colored black and orange and red with drawn-on flames on top, like a fucking kindergartener drew it.

"BA-KU-GO!!!" is the last thing Katsuki hears before he's picked up by surprisingly strong pink arms and spun around, in full sight of the entire arrival gate of Los Angeles International Airport. He tries to push her off, hands already slippery with sweat as Ashido giggles, keeping her hands on his shoulders to keep him upright as she puts him back on the ground.

"Oh my gosh you look so *good* with a tan! And you've put on some weight! Did Ei spoil you?!" Utsushimi squeezes his cheeks with manicured fingers, face lit up in utter joy as she spews what definitely sounds like a couple of back-handed compliments. Katsuki feels himself blush as he swats her away.

The listens to the girls chat over one another, words like 'observatory' and 'hike' and 'beach' excitedly drifting between the two of them, seemingly debating where the best places to take Katsuki are.

"You joking?" Katsuki says as the two finally stop walking in the massive, packed parking lot in front of what has to be a scaled-up version of a doll's toy car.

"What, you have a problem with good taste?" Ashido grins, spinning the keys around a finger before finally unlocking the atrocity.

"You *know* he does!" Utsushimi jokes back, flashing her tongue before jumping over the door of the convertible to claim shotgun.

The bright pink convertible zooms out of the parking lot with a roar, cutting off minivans with nothing but a wild cackle from the pink-haired driver.

He can't deny the way his back melts into the white leather seat as the sea air rushes through his hair and the blazing sun beats down on his skin.

Los Angeles is a monster of a city. Spread out yet dense, the tiny stucco houses and cactus-adorned front lawns juxtapose with giant skyscrapers and streets lined with tents, palm trees along the highways too dense with traffic. Katsuki takes it all in, only a little scared for his life with Ashido's frankly erratic driving skills.

They stop in front of an unassuming little house-turned-apartment-complex, front gate hidden from view with several bushes of roses and climbing vines. They walk Katsuki to the second story, opening up the door and tossing all their stuff on the kitchen table.

"Okay, get cleaned up and change, we're going to the beach!" Ashido says as she disappears into the back of the apartment with Utsushimi.

Katsuki takes the second of silence to walk around the small living space. He had his assumptions – with Ashido saving Utsushimi, their discreet brush of the hands, the fact that they work in the same agency – and this place confirms it. There's photos of the two of them all over the place – some framed, some just thumb-tacked onto the wall, some hanging off the fairy-lights that line their walls. Utsushimi and Ashido eating ice cream, making peace-signs for the camera on the beach, kissing inside a planetarium.

It makes something weird, something he's unfamiliar with, flare in his chest.

Ashido is the first to exit the shared room, putting a black baseball cap over her wild hair, joining Katsuki in appreciating her apartment with a grin on her lips.

"…So. This. How did *this* happen?" Katsuki jerks his head towards, well, the everything in their shared space.

Ashido threads her fingers together, eyes sparkling with a profound gentleness.

"It was really lonely out here when I first moved. My English wasn't great and I didn't know anybody here. Kiri was just four hours away by car, but he was busy too. I heard Camie moved out here and was working at another agency in Los Angeles, so I kind of reached out to her to see if she wanted to hang out. It's not like we were friends or anything. I was so homesick, I just wanted to talk to someone without trying so hard to be somebody else."

Katsuki doesn't miss the affectionate, dreamy look that comes over Ashido's face as she reminisces.

"We grabbed coffee. She was… so funny. I hadn't laughed that much is years. Being with her felt like being home. It was just like… an instant connection. Like I've known her my whole life. I never felt more like me than when I was with her."

Ashido giggles. "It was so cheesy. We were at a movie, and she bumped hands with me, and we intertwined our fingers, and I never felt so giddy and happy and flustered. I felt like I was a little kid. Our first kiss was like that too. And everything after that – it's just magical. She's magical. Loving her has been the best thing that's ever happened to me."

Katsuki wants to smile at his friend, but something rotten surfaces on the back of his throat.

Love being something other than pain? Love making you feel *good?* Love making you *happy?*

Maybe that's love. Real love. Maybe what he felt… what he feels… for Deku is something else entirely. They skipped all the sweet courting and fluttery feelings and joy and went straight into trying to destroy each other. He doesn't even know how to do that. To hold hands. To kiss someone without a preamble to sex. To… just talk to someone. To want to build a future with someone.

Because that's what this is. This tiny apartment is them merging their lives into one.

"Let's go, baby!" Utsushimi yells, jumping out of their shared bedroom in a white bikini.

Ashido raises her eyebrows several times, like she's bragging about her girl, before swiping Utsushimi into her arms, dipping the other and kissing her square on the lips.

Katsuki's stomach twists.

Holy shit.Is he jealous of this?

Does he want this?

Small apartment, sun-tanned skin, freckles on display, grins and pink cheeks and laughter?

“She’s the cutest, isn’t she?”

“Gross,” Katsuki lies as he disappears into the guest bedroom, quick to change into his own swim trunks, trying to push this weird feeling aside.

The beach is crowded and a spectacle all of its own. There’s models posing with products in front of silver screens, there’s children building sandcastles, there’s dogs off leash running into the water.

The last time he was at the beach was on the island – when he shared that tent with Zero, back pressed into the sand as they traded kisses and empty words on what could have been their last night on earth. The memory makes his chest ache, and he clears his throat, unaware of Ashido watching him.

“You ever surf?” Ashido asks, clapping Katsuki on his back, and Katsuki raises his eyebrows.

“No. The fuck?”

“You’re about to!” Ashido grins, dragging the three of them to a roped-off rental place on the beach.

He follows Ashido and Utsushimi into the waves, the two expertly getting themselves out onto the water. Utsushimi winks at Katsuki as she catches the first wave, feet steady on the board.

“Bet ya can’t go as far as me!” Utsushimi teases, and Katsuki grins wildly at her.

“You’re on!”

It takes him a bit to get his sea legs, but he’s Katsuki fucking Bakugou and he catches on real quick, schooling Utsushimi in an hour flat.

They go for hours, and by the time Ashido insists they go back to shore, the sun is starting to set.

“Oh! Let’s go to this taco truck! You trust me to get ya something?” Ashido asks, wiggling her eyebrows mysteriously. Katsuki’s so sunburned, sore and satisfied that he doesn’t even put up a fight, just shrugs his shoulders.

The three of them walk on the pier, Katsuki relishing in the sheer *spice* of this unusual food. Its fucking delicious and he finds himself devouring it faster than he’s eaten anything in fuck knows how long.

They join the developing crowd at the end of the pier, all watching the sun slowly set over the ocean, turning the sky into a cacophony of purples and pinks.

“This is so perfect! But it would be even more perfect if we had ice cream…”” Utsushimi pouts, rolling her lower lip out and turning to her girlfriend.

“Leave it to me, baby! I’ll be right back!” Ashido jogs off the pier, leaving Katsuki alone with Utsushimi.

Katsuki doesn’t say anything – just keeps his eyes fixed on the ocean.

“…Are you alright?”

Katsuki turns to Utsushimi, surprised.

"…What?"

"You're smiling but you look sad."

Katsuki shrugs.

"I don't know. I thought going places and doing cool shit would make me feel better, but it really hasn't."

"Yeah. I expected to be a different person when I came here too. Like leaving would somehow make my problems different. But a destination's no replacement for a purpose. You're still you, no matter where you go."

The words are so intelligent coming out of Utsushimi's mouth Katsuki has to do a double take.

She's smiling at him softly.

"Love doesn't fix it either, you know? A place, a person, money, power, career, none of it fixes you. Only you fix you."

Katsuki swallows.

He knows this. He's always known this. He knows this because no matter how many times he washes his hands, he can't wash the blood off. He knows this because no matter what he does, the scent of smoke, even his own smoke, makes him want to crawl out of his skin.

You can take off your gloves but you still have your hands, you take off your boots but you still have your feet, you scrub off the grime on your skin but what is left underneath is still you.

You still did the things that you did, still felt the things that you felt. You can try to take off the superficial layer to hide the evidence but the crime has already been committed.

"Shit. What were you running from, then?" Katsuki asks. He never considered that there might be something more complex to Utsushimi's personality. Even at the trial, she talked about the *fun* of heroics, seemingly ignorant and airheaded. But here, her eyes are deep and dark and her jaw clenches.

She's in pain, and it weirdly makes Katsuki like her.

"Himiko Toga. She stole my face. Took my life. I couldn't feel safe being in the same country as her; no matter what the commission said, I never believed she was gone. Sometimes I think I'm still her, that I'm not me at all. That I'll wake up one morning and Mina will be hurt because I'm a fool. I'm terrified that her loving me will kill her. I'm terrified of connecting to anyone at all. But I have to keep living. We all have to keep living, somehow."

Katsuki nods more to himself than her.

They do have to keep living. They all bear their own scars. They all made their mistakes. But it doesn't mean he has to be miserable for the rest of his life. He can find joy, purpose just like these two, just like Kirishima. He owes himself that much.

He feels something start to click inside him as he lives with the happy couple. Instead of being a third wheel, he feels like he's gotten a front-row seat to something good and pure, something that he never

thought he could want.

Making breakfast together. Watching stupid movies on the couch. Kissing each other good morning and good night.

They're in sync with each other in a way that's nearly elegant – not just when they fight, but also as they find their way past each other in the kitchen, walking in the living room, hell, even sharing a bathroom. It's like they understand each other's thoughts without having to speak.

But they do speak.

Constantly.

They are always talking. About mundane things, serious things, about movies and books and food and the traffic. They're always talking to each other, and it used to irritate Katsuki, but now he can't help but think it's fucking *weird.*

He can't imagine having that much to say to someone. He can't imagine wanting to share every thought and emotion he has with another person.

One night, after Utsushimi dozes off on Ashido's shoulder as they all watch a movie on the three-seater couch, Katsuki decides to ask.

"Why do you talk so much? To each other."

Ashido's eyes open widely and she tilts her head, pursing her lips in confusion. Katsuki clears his throat, lowering his voice slightly as not to wake the other girl.

"Just. Don't you get tired of constantly saying shit to each other? Don't you ever want to keep some things to yourself?"

"What? No way. We tell each other everything. I don't want to keep anything from her. Ever." Ashido insists.

Katsuki shakes his head. She's not getting it.

Or maybe *he* isn't.

The only love he's known is filled with secrets, lies, whispered truths the other is never meant to hear in the cover of darkness.

"…Why?"

Ashido smiles sweetly, turning her gaze to her girlfriend. She tucks a strand of blonde hair behind her ear, fingers lingering on the other's girl's sleeping face.

"Why would I? I want to share everything with her. My body and heart and soul. Thoughts, too. There's nothing that's mine that isn't hers too, you know? That's the only way we know how to be."

Is that what was missing? What prevented them from being… closer? Is that the pain, the constant ache, the missing piece? Katsuki knows he wanted the truth, he wanted honestly, he wanted *more.* But honestly means pain, means hurt, can mean rejection. He refused, for so many years, to acknowledge how important Deku was to him. Because he deserved – in his heart of hearts – to be rejected. To mean nothing to the boy that had, against all odds, began to mean everything to him.

And it's the most mundane fucking thing in the world. To realize something so profound on his former classmate's couch, an ocean away from anything and everything he's ever known.

This, too, has to end. Katsuki has to come home – to face his life. He doesn't get teary-eyed when he waves to the two girls as he makes his way through the airport. His bag is so stuffed, he actually has to check it. He can't help but smile at the *Pinky!* Sticker that Ashido so elegantly slapped on his luggage.

Katsuki walks through his front door and knows that everything is different now.

The air smells different. The apartment feels freezing. He feels like a guest in his own goddamn home, like a visitor to the country he's grown up in. Everything feels too wrong, too far away, too foreign.

He never felt so far behind his old friends, his classmates. They seem so far ahead of him. But in order to change, in order to grow, he has to move on, too.

He drops his bag, walking straight towards his closed where he remembers hanging up his suit jacket. He digs into the pocket, taking out the untouched business card. Swallowing down whatever trepidation he feels, he dials the number and waits.

"Yeah, hag, I fuckin' know, don't – " Katsuki takes his phone away from his ear, placing it on his chest, "Hey, don't fucking ding the wall, morons!" Katsuki glares at the people taking his furniture out of the apartment before putting the phone back to his ear. His mother has not stopped talking the entire time, somewhere between ranting and crying in his ear.

"Why move so far away? Are you trying to run away from me? Me and your father – "

Katsuki sighs loudly into the line, rubbing the bridge of his nose. He's getting a headache.

He doesn't run away. This isn't running.

But he can't sleep here anymore. He can't walk past that empty room that once held his very life, plastered against the walls. He can't sleep in that bed anymore – not where the spinning fan is still marred by Deku's bloody cape, where the pillows still hold the memory of Deku's head laying against them. He can't be in this city – can't walk around these corners, can't stand the scent of coffee, can't set foot in Granny Honoka's café without feeling himself falling apart. He can't be in Tokyo, knowing that at any moment, he can request visitation to Tartarus, and he'd get it – he knows he would.

He can't think about his words. Can't take them back. He told him he never wants to see him again. And it was a lie, but it was the truth, too. Just like the fact that he hates Izuku Midoriya. Just like the fact that he loves him.

And maybe Kirishima was right. Deku had left him – how many times was it now? Over and over and over again. And like a fool, Katsuki let his heart break with each departure.

He has to be the one that leaves this time. He can't be the one that waits anymore. He can't be this stagnant, anchored person waiting for something that's never going to come.

No one else can save him.

He has to save himself.

Chapter End Notes

Katsuki's Hot Girl Summer Expectations:



Katsuki's Hot Girl Summer Reality:



California Gurls Feat. The Saddest Sack You've Ever Known:



When I write Izuku's and Katsuki's obsessive unhealthy all-encompassing ruin-your-life love, I'm rotating Crush by Richard Siken like a rotisserie chicken in my brain. This quote in particular from Litany Where Certain Things Are Crossed Out:

We were inside the train car when I started to cry. You were crying too,
smiling and crying in a way that made me
even more hysterical. You said I could have anything I wanted, but I
just couldn't say it out loud.
Actually, you said *Love, for you,*
is larger than the usual romantic love. It's like a religion. It's
terrifying. No one
will ever want to sleep with you.

lmao i'm so sorry i've been gone a whole month y'all don't know how badly i want to write this but stupid soul-crushing medical career is getting in my way
(next chapter is their reunion. oh jesus. oh boy. which also means this story is almost over. i dont know what i'm going to do without zero sum lmao.)
((i was sticking a needle into a man's back to drain the fluid around his lungs, as one does, and he was reciting poetry, as one does, and i asked him if he still wrote, and he told me that he used to write all the time to help him figure something out. and once he figured it out, he didn't write again. and that scared me. i hope i never figure it out, whatever it is.))

Chapter 21

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Katsuki pulls his phone out of his utility belt, the button still open from his last or last last or last last last mindless grapple through his pockets. He must have checked the damn thing a million times today. He lifts it to the sky as if that would change anything. He's had perfect reception this whole time and he fucking knows.

No new notifications.

The black screen reflects back his own disgruntled face as if to taunt him.

"…What's up with you today, Dynamight? Where's your head at, kid?"

Katsuki furrows his eyebrows, turning to his boss. She's sitting right next to him, balancing the bento between her knees, nearly empty save for a bunny-shaped rice ball. She absently stabs her chopsticks into it and Katsuki, for some inexplicable up reason, flinches.

He blinks a few times at the woman, like the action would forcefully merge his flighty spirit with his physical body. It does the job, for the most part.

The sky is a pleasant blue, spreading its' arms wide in a cloudless sky. Just outside the bustling city center, Katsuki can see acres of forest, swaths of maple leaves a tapestry of reds and orange. Thousands of ginkgo trees attract tourists and lovers to parks to take photos and enjoy leisurely strolls. Katsuki has always, in his own way, been fond of the fall.

The leaves are the most magnificent, the most beloved, before their inevitable decay. *Not unlike him*, he figures. Something is crumbling inside and he's stapling the falling leaves back onto the branches poking between his ribs like the petulant child he is, refusing to accept that certain things don't last. They were never meant to.

Where is his head?

The same fucking place his heart is, he guesses.

"Hmm…" Mirko hums, smacking her lips loudly. "Midoriya is getting out of Tartarus today, isn't he?"

"HAH?"

Katsuki jerks so hard his own bento box falls to the ground next to him, mostly uneaten much to the loitering pigeons' pleasure. Katsuki forcefully shuts his jaw, fighting off the blush with a sputtering, "Why would I give a shit! What the fuck!"

Mirko snort-laughs. She's got the most obnoxious fucking laugh in the entire world and knows it, directing the full force of that ear-shattering sound in Katsuki's direction.

"Fuck you." Katsuki pulls the neck of his winter uniform up, poorly hiding his reddened ears.

"You gonna visit him?" she asks casually, like that's something people just ask.

Katsuki physically recoils.

“What the hell? No! I haven’t seen him in six months, and I’m keeping it that way.”

The mirth fades out of Mirko’s eyes and she sits up straighter, suddenly serious. She leans into Katsuki’s space, face painted with concern.

“…You mean you never visited him? Not even once?”

“ Again – why would I?” Katsuki bites back, feeling the familiar scratching of something feverish and uncomfortable under his skin. He leans away from the other, averting his eyes from her similarly colored ones.

There’s a lot about her that reminds him of his mother. Maybe that’s why every time she looks him straight in the eye and uses that calm voice she uses during rescues, he can’t help but hang his head in shame like he’s a little kid getting scolded.

“Kid… you torched your whole goddamn hero career on national TV for him. Some might think you care.”

“Well *some* might be wrong,” Katsuki snaps back. “I did what I had to do, and now it’s over, and he gets to live his life and I get to live mine. Got it?”

It comes out more emotional than Katsuki intended, voice louder and crackling and he reels himself in, taking a deep breath of the cool autumn air before banging his head slightly on the concrete wall he’s got his back to

He doesn’t want to be having this conversation.

He doesn’t want her to be right.

He digs his phone out of his pocket on instinct and sighs.

Four hours. It’s been four hours since he’s been released.

And nothing. No text. No phone call. *Nothing.*

He’s disgusted with himself.

He thought he’s done absolutely everything to eradicate this feeling – to banish it from his body. He thought he pulled it up by the roots – but the thorns remain. Insistent. Digging into his skin, his muscles, his goddamn chest. Refusing to let him forget what once grew there. What he’s thrown away. That despite his best efforts, that stupid, ugly little thing perseveres.

Hope.

And what the hell is he even hoping for? His life isn’t a shoujo manga. Katsuki isn’t the protagonist, Deku isn’t a mysterious yet tender-hearted love interest, and besides all that, it’s not even cherry blossom season.

He knows that if Deku was to text him, he’d block the number. If he was to send a letter, Katsuki would rip it to shreds. It doesn’t change what he’d do – what he’s committed to doing – but there’s something… dirty and selfish in him that wants Deku to think of him. Think of him first. Try to find him as soon as he could.

He still wants Deku to love him.

And he knows its selfish. He knows. If he really loved Izuku, if he was committed to what he told him that day in court, he's be *happy* that Izuku doesn't care about him anymore. It's an opportunity for both of them to live their own lives, unencumbered by the other.

A part of Katsuki hopes that's true for Deku. A larger, more hidden part that Katsuki keeps trying to squash down, hopes and prays that Izuku is plagued with the same dreams, the same fantasies that Katsuki is.

The fantasy that he'll call out of the blue. (He doesn't.)

The fantasy that he'll show up outside his apartment. (He doesn't.)

The fantasy that he'll be standing in front of his workplace, holding roses in the rain. (He definitely, certainly doesn't.)

Days turn into weeks turn into months.

Izuku Midoriya is free, and he hasn't come for Katsuki.

And that's fine. Its good, even.

He lives his life with hope in the background, like a song you can't get out of your head. Every time you think it's gone, every time you think there's a little reprieve, that tune starts up again. And you fucking hate that you know every single word. You fucking hate that you can't help but sing along.

The leaves fall, as they do, and Katsuki lives, as he does.

He rides the train as he always did, his weekend bag held closely in his lap. Everything is a dull around him – just like winter always is, clouds thick overhead, frost hanging in the air. Just early enough to avoid the cleansing blanket of snow, just late enough to lose the pleasant warmth and ample colors of autumn foliage. This time of year, the chill always gets under his clothes – no matter how much he bundles up, he still feels cold, his sweat glands burning with the effort to maintain a constant flow of nitroglycerin.

The music and lights are audible from a distance as Katsuki approaches his childhood home. As a teenager, he'd often leave the house as soon as the yearly party started – he couldn't stand the stuffy adults all staring at him, all asking about his Quirk, all looking at him like an object rather than a person – and jog to the park. Alone and freezing, he'd sit on the swings, staring at the wood pellets underneath his feet. The silent melancholy of it all was nice, in its own way. Like the flame of his own rage was somehow tempered by the grey emptiness around him.

No one ever came looking for him. No one ever asked where he was.

Katsuki can handle himself, his mother would say.

He's strong. He's got an amazing Quirk. Why *should* anyone worry about him?

(Well. There was always *one* person. But he doesn't worry about him anymore. He doesn't even think about him anymore.)

Despite all this time, despite everything he's been through, as he approaches his childhood home he doesn't feel a whole lot different than that sniveling boy, wiping away tears so no one ever thinks of

him of anything other than brave, anything other than *amazing, Kacchan!*

He swallows down his own discomfort, cracking open the door.

The noise is instant - clattering of platters, the sound of glasses hitting one another, voices shouting over other voices. It's so crowded and loud that no one notices the front door opening or Katsuki's entrance. He takes his shoes off, adjusting his bag over his shoulder. In the genkan, looking up at the wooden floors, at the lights adorning the walls, at the blurring faces, Katsuki can't help but feel… alien. Like he's intruding into something that he doesn't belong in.

In socked feet, he tentatively makes his way upstairs. He feels eyes on him, people parting in silence, hush falling among them as he makes his way past. He ducks his head slightly, the attention making him squeamish. He's nearly to the stairwell when a hand grabs his, spinning him around.

Mitsuki Bakugou hasn't aged at all in Katsuki's memory, all smooth skin, finely groomed hair, mascara and lipstick that never seemed to smear. She's wearing a well-fitted red sweater, something clearly off her own fashion line, fingernails painted a bloody red. Katsuki watches them as they dig into the flesh of his wrist.

"You're not even going to say hello to your mother on her own birthday?"

Katsuki bares his teeth, jerking his hand out of her grip. Her breath smells like wine and her cheeks are pink even behind the blush.

He knows from experience to keep his voice low. Unemotional.

"I was just putting my shit upstairs. Here. Happy birthday." He swings his bag around, digging out a gold-wrapped palm-sized box. His mother's eyes lighten as she takes the box gingerly into her palms.

"Fine, fine." She waves him off. "Go drop your stuff off, then come find me. I need to introduce you to some people."

Katsuki feels his lip twitch, the desire to tell her off as natural as breathing. He doesn't know what he expected. That she'd be happy to see him? That she'd thank him for coming for the first time in at least five years, of his own volition? That the distance between them has somehow made her into a different, more tender, more kind person?

Katsuki walks upstairs. Everyone seems to have forgotten that he was there – just as well. He makes his way to his former childhood bedroom, turning on the lights.

He doesn't know why his chest aches.

Maybe a part of him expected it to never change. For his childhood to stay in a stasis bubble – for his parents to be more sentimental, for his same bed and same desk and same posters.

Everyone moves on. *(Except him, he guesses.)* His family is no exemption. All that's left of his childhood bedroom are holes in the wall from where his All Might posters once hung. The bed, the desk, even the colors he colors he chose for the walls are all gone. Painted over and wiped clean, like they were never there in the first place.

Like *he* was never here in the first place.

He doesn't seek out the guest bedroom. He drops his bag on the small couch that his mother must have set up to entertain her clients and looks around. The half-dressed mannequins look ominous,

nearly threatening, his mother's sketch-desk ornately neat. At some point, she kept sketches everywhere – on the kitchen table, in the bathroom, stuffed under the couch cushions. She was passionate, obsessive, attentive – he loved those moments when she'd draw. Like under her demeanor, within her designs, he saw a different person. A person he could admire.

He squares his shoulders, takes another look around and makes his way back downstairs. His face remains placid as the watches the heads move amongst themselves, the noise crescendo and decrescendo, and he's nearly sick of it already when he spots something that he can't have possibly just seen.

A head of green hair.

Everything speeds up and slows down all at once. Katsuki's heart races and he runs down the stairs, attempting to make his way past the throng of guests to where he just saw what he can't have seen.

There's no reason for him to be here. He's – he's just hallucinating. Wishful thinking? Fear incarnate? Somewhere in between? Fuck if he knows.

The only reason he agreed to go to this was because he was certain – *absolutely* certain – that this is the one place he wouldn't bump into the other.

"Katsuki!" His body is still walking forward as he feels his mother's hand on his, and she's pulling him, hard, before she finally squeezes his face with her hand. It forces him to turn to her, to glare in her direction. The look she's giving him stops him from saying anything at all.

She's a stoic woman – one that always insists that expression of emotion will yield wrinkles. Yet, the harsh line of her mouth, the narrowing of her eyes, the intensity of her grip scream something at Katsuki. She grabs at him, fingernails digging into the soft skin of his wrist enough to hurt, and turns him in the opposite direction of where that head of green disappeared.

"Ah, Hakimura-san! Have you met my son?"

She keeps her hands on him; but Katsuki's a hero and his mother is not, and he can tell in her paranoid glances, the way her body tenses with each call of her name, the fact that she's holding on to him like she's afraid of losing him in the crowd… well.

There's something she doesn't want him to know.

"Katsuki?"

Oh.

Nausea crests as the woman's voice causes shudders to go all the way up his spine.

His mother's hand tightens against his wrist.

"Your mother said you wouldn't be coming," Inko starts, smiling widely at him. He turns slowly to look down at the woman, every instinct in him screaming for him to *run. Run. Run.* The sight of that ghostly, too-wide smile of hers, lips painted with bright red lipstick, those poor imitation of green eyes staring up at him with a kind of displaced wonderment. She waits, staring up at him, and even Mitsuki Bakugou, eyes darting between the two of them, says nothing.

"…It was a surprise." Katsuki finally answers, short and to the point.

“It’s so lovely to see you again, Katsuki,” she says his first name again, so sweetly, so intimately, and Katsuki feels all the food in his stomach churn. Inko Midoriya moves, not an ounce of shame as she grips his hands between her own, shaking Katsuki out of his own mother’s grasp so she could hold his hands close to her. She keeps looking at him, keeps staring up at him with those expectant eyes, asking Katsuki a silent question that Katsuki isn’t privy to.

Her hands are objectively normal fucking hands - warm, dry and soft - but Katsuki’s never felt something so horrific in his life. Like someone just placed a rotten fucking corpse into his palms.

The tension between them oscillates back and forth – Inko doesn’t move, and Katsuki’s paralyzed by the woman’s proximity. Her cheeks are slightly more plump than last time he saw her, and her dull green eyes hold just a fraction more light; like the sun peeking through a shaded window, like something is cracking open underneath.

It’s enough like *him* that Katsuki forgets himself. Just for a second.

“…Yeah,” Katsuki responds, finally, but he can’t bring himself to jerk his hands away. It makes him sick, but at the same time, something primordial in him wants this. Wants to be touched. Wants to be looked at.

“Hey, mom, I think I’m go – “

He’s not paying attention, looking over his shoulder like he’s searching the house for something as he places his hand on his mother’s shoulder. When he finally turns his head towards the people Inko Midoriya is talking to, Katsuki watches Izuku Midoriya’s face twist into one of unbridled panic.

Most of the baby-fat has disappeared off his face, leaving a sharp jaw and prominent cheekbones that speak less of age and more of fatigue, although his freckles are still numerous and bright, bringing youth onto the haggard landscape. Even his body has thinned down – the grey sweater he wears hangs off his shoulders, still large but nowhere near as Herculean as they had been just nine months prior – the right sleeve still hanging limp.

But it’s not that that draws Katsuki’s focus. It’s his eyes – although wide and fearful, they’re so bright and green, eyelashes distractingly long, and his hair – his *hair.* Green hair is just long enough to curl over the boy’s forehead, wild and untamed and so *Deku* that Katsuki feels all the air rush straight out of his lungs, only to be replaced by a feeling, a familiar feeling that is too big for his body. Too grand to reside in him without tearing him apart.

He never realized how badly he wanted to run his fingers through those messy curls until they were gone. And now he’s just standing there, no shackles, no secret identity, nowhere to be. Standing there, in front of Katsuki, looking at him like he’s a fucking ghost.

Maybe he is.

Katsuki can’t imagine his expression is any better.

He doesn’t even realize that Inko’s hands are still on him until he sees the other’s panicked gaze dart towards their joint fingers.

Like the touch burns (and it *does,* it corrodes, its destroying something deep inside Katsuki and he doesn’t know *what)* Katsuki jerks his hands away, pulling them close to his own torso, eyes darting back to Izuku’s in some kind of desperate explanation.

He didn't think he'd feel like this. His chest feels like its concaving, he can't breathe, and his face feels like its on fire. Even though there's dozens of other party guests, even though there's alcohol and food and laughter, Katsuki is sinking into quicksand, and no one even knows he's dying – much less willing to save him.

(There's only one person who could. Only one person who ever could.)

He sees it happen within seconds – that expert change in expression. The brights of his eyes dull to impassive greys, and he just… looks past him. Like he can't see him. Like he doesn't even exist.

Katsuki doesn't remember how to breathe as Izuku Midoriya slides past him.

As always, once Izuku makes his appearance (*in Katsuki's life, in Katsuki's dreams, everywhere that Katsuki is*) the absence of him is overwhelming. Its more palpable, that loss, than anything else Katsuki's felt since he got here.

He's not following him. He's just making sure that… the weirdo doesn't do anything… weird. Yeah. That's it.

He doesn't know what the other is doing. Izuku puts on that stupid, irritating determined face, squares his shoulders, and starts *talking* to people. And he can tell the others recognize him. They flock to him, eyes hungry, invasive.

Katsuki sips on his drink, listening to his mother say something to him in the background. Is what why he was invited? As a conversation starter? Who wouldn't want to gossip about the vigilante that spent the last six months in prison? He's certain this particular choice will make his mother's party the talking point for her potential buyers for months to come.

Something in chest sinks at that thought – the thought that Izuku, who is trying to return to a semblance of a normal life – is being paraded about like a prized dog or a real fancy vase.

It's pathetic, how hard he's trying to look normal. To look happy. He quirks his lips, anxious fingers digging into the threads of his grey sweater, towering over everyone in the goddamn room, hunching his shoulders to look small. Nothing about the way he looks today gives away the truth that lies underneath. He's trying to look like a regular, unthreatening fucking *kid.* Not the boy who transversed the world on a suicidal mission, not the boy who lost his arm, not the one who nearly gave his life to save someone, *anyone,* so no one has to be as lost as he was ever again. Not the boy who spent the last six months in prison.

Katsuki watches him become more and more rigid, his responses shorter, his jaw clenched tighter as time passes. Something giddy surfaces in Katsuki stomach as he hears Izuku raise his voice, promptly clamping his mouth shut and making some shitty excuse before darting out from the crowd formed around him.

He's losing his temper. Katsuki's always been oddly fond of that moment – when polite Izuku disappears, the last thread snaps, and the monster underneath surfaces.

When he doesn't come back, Katsuki seems to be the only one that notices.

Instant panic shoots through him and he rushes to the genkan. No, there they are – the most butt-ugly fucking red shoes he's ever seen.

His fingers itch as he stares at them. *He can't leave if he can't find them,* Katsuki's mind supplies wildly, and he shakes his head. Kirishima's words ring in his head and he grimaces at how right the other was. *He makes you feel like you can't control yourself.*

Like all logic flies out the window when it comes to him.

The porch. The kitchen. The living room. The bathroom. He knows he shouldn't. He should be trying to keep away. He shouldn't care at all. But something in him, something desperate wants to reach out, to see him, to talk to him. There's still so much unspoken, still so much of his heart that Izuku owns without Katsuki's permission.

He wants it back – but how exactly can he take back something Izuku doesn't know he owns?

Katsuki tries to be discrete, taking a second to politely talk to his parents' friends that inadvertently stop him, put their hands on him, ask him shallow questions that make him want to claw his eyes out, before he's finally able to sneak away upstairs.

His ears pique at the sounds of… something. Almost like the wind, a sharp, gust-like sound coming from his former childhood bedroom. Katsuki approaches it. The door is slightly ajar – the same place where that noise is coming from. He leans against the wall, listening for it once more.

Its rhythmic, strident – *a person,* Katsuki realizes. Hopes, at least. There's not an ounce of light coming from under the door, so whoever it is is sitting, laying, doing *whatever* they might be doing in absolute darkness.

Katsuki opens the door in just the right way –he's an expert at opening his childhood bedroom door in the most quiet way possible – and steps inside.

The air suddenly grows humid. Katsuki stops himself from breathing, body going absolutely still. There's another person in the room, and he doesn't need light to know exactly who the fuck it is. Katsuki would recognize the silhouette of his shoulders in the goddamn vacuum of space.

Izuku is trembling. His shoulders are heaving up and down, his singular hand over his face, nails digging through his curls and scratching into his scalp, feet digging into the carpet like if he didn't anchor himself to this couch, he would simply float away. The sheer panic radiating off the other, the poorly suppressed heavy breathing, the large body shaking like a goddamn leaf – its familiar enough that Katsuki could put a name to it.

He hasn't noticed he's in the room. A guy who has evaded the world for four years, one who probably has the sharpest senses on this planet and an even sharper sense paranoia, hasn't noticed someone else has entered the room. Katsuki clenches his teeth. *He's not okay.*

He's not really in control of his body as he walks towards him. It's against all logic as his hand reaches out – he doesn't think as he lightly, ever so lightly, taps the other on the shoulder.

Only to break him out of this. Only to stop him from panicking. Only to – only to.

He doesn't have an excuse. They're toxic to one another, rotten and awful. They've both sworn to stay away from the other; and yet?

Like any addiction, it's so much easier not to give in when it's not right in front of you – hiding from the world, trying hard not to break down.

Katsuki doesn't see it coming. He's fast and unreasonably strong even when Quirkless. Katsuki's not sure when his entire body was dragged across the room, not sure when a large forearm pressed against his neck obstructing his windpipe just on the wrong side of *too much*, not sure when he brought his surprised eyes up to meet a pair of rabid electric-greens, red-rimmed with tears. The panic behind those eyes feels akin to a wild animal trying to get unstuck from a hunter's trap; even though you're trying to help it, its scratches and bites and draws blood from pure instinct.

"DON'T TOUCH ME!"

Thousands of miles away to feet away to inches, Katsuki tasting the other's breath on his own tongue, and the sight of him demanding and violent makes something stupid bubble up in Katsuki's chest, something ecstatic – hell, his fucking heart even skips a beat. He doesn't avert his eyes. He can't help but relish the fury which turns into realization which rapidly turns into poorly controlled horror.

"Ka – " he watches the other choke on his name, eyes darting back and forth between his own, mouth slightly agape as he stumbles back, barely catching himself. It's a familiar scene – that first day they fought in the gym with him as Zero, the horror after Katsuki put his mouth on him – it's a bittersweet nostalgia, but Katsuki still licks his lips, tasting the memory of the other's raw desire in his mouth.

Adrenaline surges, and he walks forward slightly, massaging his neck, certainly bruised from where the other's elbow dug in.

"What the fuck was that, Deku?" Katsuki asks, too aware of the way the other flinches at the sound of the name.

"I… I didn't know it was you," his voice mumbles out, suddenly much smaller than the roar from before. He looks at the floor, drooping his shoulders, and this movement, this making himself small makes Katsuki want to strangle him.

"Who the fuck *else* would it be?"

He says nothing. Katsuki clenches his fists, taking a step forward, barely able to control his own ragged breathing.

He's ignoring him. He's backing down from the fight.

Katsuki refuses to accept that.

"Didn't I say I never wanted to see your fucking face again? What the hell are you doing in my parents' house? In my fucking room, huh?"

Katsuki walks forward and Izuku stumbles back, keeping the distance between them until his knees hit the back of the same couch he was previously sitting on. Izuku falls backwards, wide eyes finding themselves locked back with Katsuki's as his butt hits the cushion. The light from the street streaks across his face, illuminating his iris – pupils pinpoint, bright and celestial green, flecks of gold sparkling with the arrival of fresh tears.

Those eyes pin Katsuki in place. Katsuki swallows, trying to control his own breathing as he watches the other's lips open in aborted words, eyebrows rising in feigned innocence. It makes Katsuki sick.

He leans forward and grips the other by the front of his sweater, feeling his own knees hit the soft cushions of the couch. Any further, and he'd be straddling the other.

" I wasn't – "

“Shut up! Shut up – “ Katsuki interrupts, nearing Izuku even further, until their faces are inches apart, until no matter where Izuku looks he wouldn’t be able to look away from Katsuki – as it always should be.

“Don’t fucking lie to me! Don’t fucking look me in the eye and lie to me again, fuckin’ Deku – “

“You – she begged me to, and I – I didn’t think you’d be back from Hiroshima, I – “

Katsuki lets go of the other’s sweater, taking a step back. His own mouth falls open.

“You… knew where I was?”

There was a logical part of Katsuki that knew that Izuku knew. He had to have. It wasn’t exactly a secret. A quick online search, asking any of their former classmates, hell, a conversation with any of the people just down the stairs, including his own parents – who seem to be okay enough with the criminal and his mother to invite them to his mother’s birthday party – would reveal that information.

And yet. It confirms the very thing that’s been pressing into Katsuki’s temples all along. Izuku knew where he was.

He simply made the choice not to come to him.

“I promised you you’d never see me again. I didn’t want to accidentally… do this.”

Katsuki has no reason to be upset about this. He has no reason to feel like his heart is concaving. He shouldn’t feel like his knees might collapse below him. This is what he wanted.

He didn’t want Izuku chasing after him anymore. He didn’t want to chase after Izuku anymore.

(Katsuki asks Izuku not to lie to him, but he keeps lying to himself, doesn’t he? Because that’s not what he wants. That’s not what he wants at all, and he hates himself for it.)

“…I’m sorry. You seem upset. I’ll just head home – “

Katsuki clenches his fists, scoffing at the words.

He’s so fucking predictable.

“Sure. Run away like you always do, you goddamn coward.”

Katsuki can see the innocent, apologetic look fall straight off Izuku’s face, and the other stands again, irritation obvious on his brow. He uses his superior height to stare down at Katsuki, fist clenched as if waiting for a fight.

Finally. Yeah, Katsuki may have hit below the belt, hit him where it hurts, but at least this he’s familiar with. This is an arena where they can trade blows. They’ve been doing it like this their entire lives.

“You said you never wanted to see me again! I’m just doing what you want!” Izuku spits, accusatory. He shakes his head, eyes shutting tightly. His fist it clenched so it physically trembles. He looks like he wants to clock Katsuki in the face.

A part of Katsuki kinda wishes he would.

“You don’t know SHIT about what I want!” Katsuki snaps back.

“YOU NEVER TOLD ME!” Izuku shouts, honest-to-god shouts, and the two exchange a panicked glance as they both snap their mouths shut, nary a breath between them as they listen for anyone ascending the stairs. Unheard, Izuku turns his head back to Katsuki, nostrils flaring.

“You’ve never told me anything! You just left me guessing! What, was I supposed to act like you ‘didn’t mean it,’ like I’ve always done when you said something to hurt me? Nine months, Kacchan. Not a word from you. You blocked my number. You moved to a city ten hours away. You left me *behind!* What was I supposed to think?!”

Katsuki laughs bitterly before snarling back.

“Left *you* behind? Are you fucking kidding me? You don’t get to say that to me. Not to *me.* I looked for you for *four fucking years.* You didn’t even try!”

“OF COURSE I TRIED!”

Katsuki’s eyes open slightly as Izuku approaches him, tears in his eyes, shaking his head, lips trembling. His eyes dart to them – when emotions get out of control, when they get this heated, he can’t help but want to dash forward, to smash his lips against Izuku’s, to work out this aggression and hurt without words, to ignore this shit for just a little longer until it grows too grand to control and finally eats him alive.

“You live in Naka Ward, close to Shimura Hospital. You work with Mirko. You’ve made some friends. You’ve even been on a couple of dates. You seemed *happy,* Kacchan! And that’s all I want! I just want you to be happy!”

“BULL-SHIT, YOU ASSHOLE!” Katsuki nearly yells, grabbing the other by his shoulders.

“STOP ACTING SO GODDAMN INNOCENT! YOU AVOID ME BY COMING TO MY PARENTS HOME?! YOU WERE FUCKING HOPING TO RUN INTO ME!”

“SO WHAT IF I WAS!”

Izuku looks surprised at the words, and he lifts his head, furrowing his brow. He seems to have just noticed how close to one another they are, only just noticed how hard he’s gripping the front of his shirt. He laughs then – a wild and delirious sound - like he can’t believe the words that are coming out of his mouth.

“…Of course I wanted to see you. I’ve wanted so badly to see you. I waited for you every single day. I was so alone, Kacchan. I was so, so alone. I didn’t even have them anymore – “ he points to his head, index finger and thumb, and Katsuki feels sudden nausea hit him as the memory of the other holding his gun to his head flashes in front of his eyes.

“And I kept hoping, dreaming that you would show up, that you would take it back, but you *didn’t!* I felt like I was going crazy and you’re the only person that ever made any of it make sense! Of course I wanted to be close to you! I still do, even though you asked me to stay out of your life! *”*

Katsuki tilts his head, and finally, finally, instead of screaming back, he just shrugs his shoulders.

There’s so much he can’t take back. There’s years he can’t dissolve in acid, no matter how much he’s tried. He can’t take back his fists against his jaw, he can’t take back the venom he spit at him to hurt him, he can’t take back the four years of agony, of missing him so much his chest split open, and he

can't take back the past nine months. Walking away was supposed to solve everything. Walking away from Izuku, severing their broken connection, was supposed to make things better.

But it hasn't. It hasn't. He's trapped himself in a new cage of his own volition, still lying to himself, still forcing his desires, his dreams, his needs into a path that he's supposed to want, supposed to be happy with. He's changed the brand of gun, but there's still a bullet in the chamber, and he's still playing Russian roulette with his heart every fucking day he so much as thinks about the nerd.

"Fine. I take it back."

Izuku raises his head. "…What?"

"I take it back. All of the shit. Saying I didn't want to see you again. Saying that I hate you."

He's walked these two paths, two simple fucking paths, his entire goddamn life. Playing hop-scotch between the two, never able to decide which one is right. Which one fits. To love Izuku Midoriya, or to hate him. He walked them both – and neither took him to the destination he wanted. Neither took him to the Izuku standing in front of him. Neither gave him the answer that he was looking for.

Those green eyes widen a fraction, lips falling open.

"…And I take back saying that I love you."

He watches Izuku deflate. He opens his mouth again, slightly, then shakes his head as if not understanding. His lip wobbles – just a tiny bit, just perceptible to someone with an astute eye like Katsuki – before he bites into it deep, touch of blood marring that same lip from his own abuse.

Katsuki presses on.

"I don't. How could I? I don't know anything about you. Maybe I loved Deku at some point. That stupid pig-headed bastard dug his way into my heart like a fucking parasite, and I *still* love him for all his flaws. He's a horrible, fucked up, annoying little nerd, but fuck yeah, I'd die for him another million times. But you…? You aren't Deku anymore, are you?"

He bites harder into his lip, looking up at the ceiling, but Katsuki is privy to the tears he's trying to hide – doing a poor job, too, as they spill over his lash line, making those dark lashes clump together. Katsuki fights the urge to spread them with her fingertips. To wipe those tears with his own tongue.

"And maybe I was falling in love with Zero. Because he didn't take my shit, and because he fucked even better than he fought, and he had this insane fucking moral ideal that normal fucking people don't; and he stuck with it, no matter what sacrifices it required. That reminded me of a certain someone who has been on the receiving end of my fist more times than once. I'd get on my knees for that fucker any day. But you're not Zero either, are you?"

Izuku's eyes fall from the ceiling, allowing those tears to tumble free of his lashes, down those pinkened cheeks, into his mouth propped open by his teeth. He's both and he's neither.

Whatever is standing in front of him is 30% something he knows, something he can put his hands on, and 70% fuckin' mystery.

Case in point, the fucker starts to chortle. Big, fat wet laughs capitalized by sobs. Katsuki watches him, mesmerized by what is certainly a mental breakdown, until the other calms down enough to sigh out loud.

"…Thank you, Kacchan."

Katsuki steps back. Yeah. He actually lost his entire fucking mind. Okay.

"What the fuck is wrong with you?" There's no bite to his words. His fingers itch to touch him. To ruffle his curls. To feel his lips as they arch up in a delirious smile. He makes a fist instead.

He sighs again, satisfied, like he just ate an amazing meal.

"…Everyone else just expected me to hop right back into my life from when I was sixteen as soon as I was released. Everyone expected me to be the same. I can see how disappointed they are that I'm not. You don't know anything about the four years I was away. You don't know anything about my time in Tartarus. You told me that you loved me, and I didn't believe you, because there is no *me.* And still… No one, no one ever admitted that I'm different now. Except for you."

He smiles that wet smile that has Katsuki's heart melting, and it's weird – this exchange should be leaving them both upset and angry, and yet some kind of tension between them dissolves with Izuku's tears. Katsuki feels like he can exhale, too.

It clicks into place. He didn't fully understand why he related to Kirishima, why he mourned his love for Deku when the other had told him he loved him back. But maybe that's the whole point. That Katsuki was mourning his lost love for Deku – a person who no longer exists. He mourns something that never was, and never could be.

But the person that's in front of him – Deku and Zero and so much more. Katsuki feels his lips upquirk involuntarily. This man… this man can ruin his life. Katsuki kind of wants to let him.

"KATSUKI!"

Katsuki feels all the hairs on the back of his neck stand up, something about being in his childhood bedroom and hearing his mother's shrill voice from downstairs sending him back in time. He turns his head to Izuku, who just stares back with wide eyes.

"WHERE THE HELL ARE YA! WE'RE DOING THE CAKE!"

"The cake," Katsuki repeats back to Izuku. It's something he shouldn't miss; Izuku stares up at him like he understands. And yet, there's still that tension, there's still so much unspoken, and Katsuki doesn't know if Izuku feels it too – this desire to just… stay. To stay in the same space. To be together. Against all logic (*or with the very natural entropy of the universe*) to continue being together.

"… Shit. I – " Katsuki says, gesturing for the door, unexpectedly awkward.

Tears dry on Izuku's face as he sits up straighter. "When are you leaving?"

Right. Leaving.

Katsuki's chest tightens. "Tomorrow."

"Oh. You could. If you wanted to talk. Come by after the party. To my room. I mean. I – I wouldn't mind – I'll stay up – "

Katsuki watches the nerd stumble and stutter over his words, and it's a beautiful fucking thing. The person who defeated Shigaraki, who literally spent the last six months in jail, is stumbling over his

words like a fucking loser nerd virgin, and if that doesn't soften Katsuki's heart into fucking *goo,* well…

"You're getting flustered, nerd," Katsuki teases. He takes his thumb and forefinger, squeezing the other's cheek, relishing in that child-like blush that spreads across the bridge of his nose.

"Nothing like *that*! I just – I just like… spending time with you. I guess. I'm sorry."

"Stop being sorry. And keep the light on." Katsuki says, and with one last look, he makes his way downstairs.

He knows Izuku leaves. He doesn't notice it, not really – the shoes are gone, and Inko isn't there when the candles are blown out. But he's giddy and he's smiling and even his mother, her own grin plastered on her half-drunk face, can't help but comment on it.

The rest of the night passes in a mindless flash. Everyone is asleep before he opens up his childhood bedroom window, hops off the roof, and walks – maybe jogs, since there's no one around to see – to that familiar apartment complex.

This is the first time in nearly five years that he's seen the place without wanting to claw off his own face.

The winter air has never felt so fresh in his lungs. Every time he takes a breath, it spurs him on, quickening his pace until – until. He stands below the other's window.

True to promise, the Midoriya household has one single light on. Not wanting to alert the neighbors, he grabs onto the fire escape, climbing up as silently as he can. Heart in his throat, he knocks on the window.

A hand slides the window up, and a surprised looking Izuku is looking back at him. Like he never expected him to show up. He's soft, curls ruffled, in a nightshirt and pajama pants, and Katsuki has the distinct impression that in another universe, in a world where they didn't fuck everything up, this might be normal for them. Katsuki sneaking in through Izuku's window. Smiling at each other through the glass.

"…Hope you didn't lose too much sleep for me," Katsuki comments casually, not addressing how long both of them have actually waited. Hours. Days. Years. Decades, if you really think about it.

"…I don't really sleep well anymore." Izuku admits, sitting down on his bed. Katsuki doesn't hesitate, sitting next to him, leaving enough room so that a third person could sit between them.

"Me either."

They sit there in silence, marinating in some kind of mutual understanding. Katsuki doesn't really know what he's doing there. He doesn't know why Izuku offered for him to come here. There's nine months of unspoken words, years of pent up tension, and yet, right now? Katsuki feels normal. Comfortable, even.

Its Izuku who starts, leaning back until his shoulders hit the wall. His chin tilts to the ceiling, and Katsuki can't help but outline his jaw, the strong muscles of his neck with his eyes.

"I… after four years of living as someone else, after spending those six months in Tartarus, I have no idea who I am. I… often feel like I'm floating outside my body, like I don't fully feel or see what's happening around me. I lose my temper easier than I used to."

"…What happened in Tartarus?"

"I took a few beatings early on. Everyone knew I was All Might's prodigy and the reason Shigaraki was imprisoned. People had scores to settle. About a month in, I got put in solitary. The only people I interacted with were the guards, visitors, and Shigaraki. It was… oddly peaceful, actually."

"You're fucked in the head."

"Yeah, I know."

Katsuki picks at his own fingernails.

"Who visited you?" Katsuki asks, some sense of guilt niggling in the back of his head.

"…Oh, everyone. From our class, class B. Our teachers. Eri, Kota. My mom. Your parents. Even Mirko. A little after you guys started working together." Izuku smiles, as if lost in a pleasant memory. "Everyone except for you."

Izuku doesn't sound bitter. Katsuki almost kind of wishes he did.

He should expect better. He should deserve better.

"I didn't come to your funeral either, you know."

Izuku tilts his head, meeting Katsuki's eyes. He doesn't look surprised. Just… resigned.

Katsuki hates that fucking look.

"I didn't fucking believe it was you, but even if I did, I still wouldn't have gone. I was so fucking mad at you for disappearing – for dying."

"…You don't have to make excuses, Kacchan. I understand." Katsuki watches the other's Adam's apple bob in a prolonged swallow.

"…Were those your real ashes?"

Izuku smiles, moving his right stump up and down in his T-shirt. The cloth pulls back to show the puckered skin underneath.

"Yeah. My right arm. It was Kurogiri. He amputated it with his Warp-gate. I don't know where he warped it *to*. I think the plan was to get it to Toga so she could get enough of my blood and start to impersonate me, but seems like that's not what happened."

Katsuki blanches. That would have been something straight from one of his nightmares. Izuku's skin melting to reveal fangs. Someone with Izuku's face, stabbing a knife in his heart.

"… At that point, I had obtained a 'Denervation' Quirk that allowed me to sever all my nerves in the area, so it didn't hurt. But nerves grow back, and I had returned it to the person who previously had it. It was a doctor. Very useful Quirk to have for him. Wasted on me."

Its… nearly surgical. Katsuki noticed it somewhat when the original prosthetic was attached, but without it, he can see the cut as if made by a laser. It's not clean, just below the shoulder joint. It must have hurt like hell. The fucker must have nearly bled out. There's major vessels that run just under the bicep, a muscle embarrassingly amputated to less than 1/3 its length with the injury.

“The nerves grew back wonky – any prosthetic I’ve tried hurts. The one you broke was the only one I was able to tolerate for a bit, but something like that is too heavy for my body now.”

Katsuki watches Izuku as he laughs, rubbing at the nub where his arm used to be.

“Not that it matters. I don’t need the arm anymore anyways.”

“…Izuku.”

Izuku sighs wistfully, continuing as if he didn’t hear Katsuki.

“I didn’t plan this far ahead, you know? I figured I’d always end up losing One for All, but I didn’t think I’d be alive to see it. I have no idea what I’m doing. Everything I’ve done to this point was to be a hero. Now what do I do? Who am I?”

“…Izuku.”

Izuku finally turns to Katsuki, casting him this sad smile, and Katsuki can’t help but reach out, placed a hand on the other’s shoulder. He flinches, and it makes something painful lurch in Katsuki’s chest.

“You were someone before One for All. And you’re someone after, too. Your Quirk doesn’t fucking define you. *You* taught me that.”

Katsuki feels his face flush as the sad smile on Izuku’s face transforms into something shy, sweet, radiant.

“You’re an amazing person, Kacchan. You never stop surprising me.”

Katsuki’s hand is still on Izuku’s shoulder; experimentally, he runs his hands past his shoulder, fingertips grazing over the top of Izuku’s clavicle. Izuku whimpers, shutting his eyes tight, and Katsuki takes his hand away. Irritation flares. He can’t help but imagine all the times Todoroki kept his hand on him in court – all the times Izuku didn’t seem to mind even remotely that constant touch.

“…Is it just me? That you don’t like touching you.”

Izuku’s eyes open widely and his jaw drops before he’s able to reel himself in, shaking his head slightly.

“It’s not because it’s you. I don’t – I can’t really. Uh.” Izuku clears his throat, looking towards the ceiling, his face undergoing a slew of different expressions before he finally sighs.

“No one has put their hands on me without hurting me for nearly five years. I guess I just… developed an aversion to being touched. Its… uh. Really hard for other people to get used to. Especially mom.”

“Yeah, right. So, what, Half-n-Half is the exception? That fucker can’t ever keep his hands off you. Bet he hopped on your dick the second you were out of jail.”

He bites his tongue as the words come out – he sounds so goddamn bitter and jealous. He doesn’t even really know why he said it.

So Izuku denies it?

So Izuku confirms it?

“It’s not like that with him, Kacchan. It never was. It never was with *anyone.”*

Izuku shakes his head again, looking up at the ceiling, chewing a new hole in his lip.

The background hum of the heater in Izuku’s room is the loudest goddamn thing in the world.

Katsuki feels all the blood drain from his face and pool in his toes as Izuku’s words crystalize in his brain.

“Izuku…” Katsuki starts again, surprised at the sliver of panic he lets into his voice.

Izuku doesn’t look at him. He bites a strip of loose skin on his lip hard, a droplet of blood escaping out from underneath the abused flesh. Katsuki watches Izuku lick it off.

“… Izuku. Are you… you have to be kidding me.”

Katsuki suddenly doesn’t want to be here.

“I was the first.” Katsuki says, and it isn’t a question.

Izuku doesn’t respond.

“…The only?”

Izuku eyes narrowing in on the ceiling.

Katsuki can feel himself growing more frantic by the second.

“…The blowjob?”

Nothing. All he gets is an involuntary twitch of fingers.

“Shit, Izuku. The *kiss*?”

When Izuku looks at him again, the smile he’s sporting is so goddamn sad Katsuki wants to punch it straight off his face.

“…Sorry.”

“…What the fuck. Izuku. Why did you… Why did you let me *do* that to you? Do you even – are you even – “

Katsuki’s mouth doesn’t know how to make the appropriate words.

“…I didn’t. I mean. I didn’t really… ever… of course I always *loved* you, but before you kissed me, I didn’t really…. Know? Understand? Anyway, you don’t have to worry. I didn’t do anything with your ex-boyfriend. I can still barely look at him.” Izuku scoffs then, smile turning into a frown as he looks towards the window even they both know damn well it’s too dark to see anything except their own reflections.

Katsuki’s heart jumps into his throat. Fuck. He *really* doesn’t want to talk about this. Fuck Mina for putting this stupid fucking idea in his head.

We share everything. Heart, body and soul. Everything that’s mine is hers.

Fuck everything – and fuck the fact that he actually wants to try for this fucker.

"…He wasn't my boyfriend. I don't even fucking know why I kept fucking him. I hated him."

"…No you didn't."

Katsuki sighs.

"No. I didn't."

"I'm going to regret asking this – but how did that even start?" Izuku looks sincerely curious, and Katsuki's stomach flips.

"Uh. He was helping me look for you. We were doing research. He was… acting weird. He started talking about the war. The fight with Shigaraki."

Izuku flinches.

"…After I took the hit. He started talking about you, and it was pissing me the fuck off. How you went fucking crazy. How you bit through those fucking tendrils that skewered me like they were nothing. And he kept talking about you, and talking about you, and he was pissing me off, and he was in my face, and I wanted to beat the shit out of him, and then he kissed me." Katsuki shrugs. "He was just getting all hot and bothered talking about you, I fucking guess."

Katsuki doesn't state the obvious – that he, too, must have gotten 'hot and bothered' during that conversation. His dick got hard. He kissed Todoroki back. He didn't try to analyze the whole situation then, but saying it out loud brings the whole fucking fiasco into perspective.

"…I barely remember that. I just knew I wanted to kill him. I might have, if I was strong enough then. Hell of a hero, huh?" Izuku laughs then, lightly and in such a self-deprecating manner that Katsuki can't help himself. He has to say something even worse, to make this idiot feel better.

"… I killed Mr. Compress. Atsuhiro Sako. It was a regular fight, and he got in my fucking face, and he told me you were dead. It was before your ashes were found. He said Shigaraki killed you. He said he saw you die, that you died begging for your life like a bitch. And I fucking lost it."

Katsuki lifts his hand to his face.

"I never, ever lost control of my quirk. But the explosion I launched at him was like fucking 10 Howitzers, straight to his face. I watched his skin melt of his goddamn skull. He died from his injuries a few days later."

"Good. Fuck him."

Katsuki's eyebrows shoot to the top of his head as his head swivels to Izuku.

The other is wearing a dark expression, jaw clenched. The storm that brews in those eyes is tantalizing, and Katsuki's heart speeds up, ricocheting wildly in his chest.

"He took you away from me. I wish it had been me that killed him."

His voice is dark, final, and Katsuki can't look away from him.

He's falling in love.

He can't believe he can just keep falling more and more in love with this fucker. Every and any version of this fucker.

The air between them changes, suddenly charged with something untouchable. Katsuki's drunk off of it – this honesty, this rawness, this sincerity. Years and years of ducking around being vulnerable around each other, years of endless bullshit and misunderstandings, years of pretending to be something they're not – it's all crumbling down. Here they are, two broken people. All the good and the bad, flowing out in the open, intermixing.

Izuku is honest with him for the first time in his life, and Katsuki's already addicted to this feeling. He can feel the heat ascend his chest, collect under his sweater in his neck. This feverish, warm feeling inches forward, and Katsuki wants to chase it.

Izuku feels it too. He can tell. He's looking at him like Katsuki belongs to him, like he'd bite the hand of anyone that would dare to look in his direction, and things are escalating rapidly.

This confessional is mighty holy when the flames of hell are licking at Katsuki's feet. But he loves the warmth. He can't help but want to jump in.

"I slept in your bed after you left. Pretty much every fucking day. Until your mom brought it here. And then I came over sometimes and slept in it here."

"…Oh?" Izuku raises his eyebrows, half-lidded eyes.

"…This bed?" Izuku asks, petting the covers with his hand. His pupils dilate slightly as he looks back at Katsuki.

"Yeah." Katsuki croaks out. "Jerked off in here, too."

Katsuki bites the inside of his cheek to prevent himself from smiling at the sharp inhale of air Izuku takes in.

"*Why?*"

"Smelled like you. Was going crazy. I wanted to do something, and I didn't know what. I think I wanted *you*. I think I still fucking do."

Katsuki finds himself getting a little closer to the other in bed. Izuku slides down, like this is a practiced dance, until his head rests against the pillow, curls fanning out like a forest underneath. Katsuki's body feels like it's on fire. He encases the other between his arms, keeping just far away enough so they don't touch.

In the past four years, he's come to dread this bed. He's come to dread the nights he spent in it, to dread Inko climbing in with him, to know that its empty of the one person he wanted to still be here.

And for Izuku to be laying in it, to be looking at him with those glazed over eyes, after all this time – shit. This head doesn't feel like it belongs to his body. He feels like he might wake up from another wet dream at any second, alone in Hiroshima like some goddamn lovestruck fool.

He feels it too. He has to feel it too.

He rolls his hips slightly, feeling the other's full length against his thighs.

He pulls back, raising his eyebrows. The other has the audacity to blush.

“This turning you on, nerd?” Katsuki teases, and the other rolls his eyes in mock exasperation.

“Weird. I seem to remember you closing your eyes and refusing to look at me every time we had sex.” Katsuki mentions it casually. He didn’t realize that still bothered him. And now, encased by Katsuki’s arms, in his own childhood bedroom, Izuku has to answer him. He has nowhere to go.

“…You’ll make fun of me.” He mumbles. All fake shy, as always, because his hand lifts from the bed, making its way under Katsuki’s shirt. His fingertips graze the puckered scar on his back and he shudders at the light touch, feeling goosebumps erupt along his spine. Like a goddamn virgin.

Katsuki ducks down until he’s less than an inch away from the other. The way the other’s breathing is shallow, rapid.

“You like it when I make fun of you.” Katsuki states.

Izuku doesn’t argue.

“… I thought I’d cum too fast if I looked at you.”

“Ha!” Katsuki *does* laugh, laughing even harder when Izuku narrows his eyes on him, and even *harder* when this prison-hardened nerd actually pouts.

“Kacchan! I wanted you to feel good, and – and – no one had ever touched my dick and it being you, I mean, your mouth, *Jesus* -”

“You liked my mouth, huh?” Katsuki smirks at the other, and Izuku rolls his eyes again.

Forcefully, he pushes Katsuki’s back down with his one hand so their pelvises are flush. Katsuki rolls his hips again, so Izuku doesn’t miss how hard he is, too.

In case the (not so) little nerd didn’t get the memo.

He doesn’t get it. He has been on dates. But no one has really done it for him, no one has turned him on in this way. And now he’s hard as a goddamn diamond from just *talking* about having sex with Zero.

“I liked all of you. I… I wanted to touch you so much. Kiss you everywhere. Find out all your sweet spots. Discover every way you could moan. I wanted so much more than whatever that was between you and Zero. It’s stupid, isn’t it? Being jealous of my own alter-ego?”

“Stop talking like you’ll never get a chance, fucker. You giving up already? Like I’m not literally on top of you, in your bed, with my dick hard?”

“I want that more than anything, but… how? You’re leaving tomorrow.”

Katsuki leans in further.

“Then *chase me*, you coward.”

A flash of lightning green, and those chewed-to-hell lips are on Katsuki, and all his muscles give out under him as is body melts into the other, bulk on bulk, tension snapping as he licks at the blood in Izuku’s mouth.

And, *oh.*

The world is in color again.

He can see the light explode behind his eyes as he skirts the other's tongue with his own. His spit is minty and his tongue is sweet and the world is fucking right again, and the other holds him so close to his body as if he's afraid Katsuki might disappear, and Katsuki's afraid he might disappear too, so he kisses back with everything he has, he bites into his lips, he caresses his tongue, he doesn't stop as the other breaks to breathe, kissing open lips, kissing tear-stained cheeks, kissing each and every fucking freckle. Kissing until whatever fucking line between them that he's built no longer exists.

He's crazy. Katsuki knows that he must be crazy. He walked away from this for a reason. He's not sure if returning – if re-opening that door so readily – is bravery or stupidity. Either way, this is his choice.

His choice is Izuku.

His choice was *always* going to be Izuku.

Izuku makes Katsuki feel like he can't control himself – and this time, Katsuki chooses to relinquish that control.

Walk straight into the fire.

It's the only way he knows how to live.

The sweet little sounds coming out of Izuku's mouth are driving him wild, and he grinds his hips into the other, feeling Izuku's cock jump at the movement.

"Kacchan?"

"Yeah?"

"I want to suck your dick."

Katsuki blinks, breathing heavily, lust-drunk mind taking a solid five seconds to process that statement.

Unexpected.

But definitely, definitely not unwanted.

"Fuck. Yeah. Yeah. Okay."

They flip around wordlessly, Katsuki's head on the pillow as Izuku slides down his body, feeling every plane of him on the way; his pecs, his stomach, his thighs, a needy desperate hand touching everywhere like it needs to make up for the lacking second.

He's still wearing his jeans and sweater, and its fucking sweltering in this room, and he wants to take all his clothes on, he wants to burn the barriers between them, he wants it to just be them, sweat and skin and heat. But it's too much, too fast, and he hasn't even gotten his own head on straight, so he tries to stay as calm as he can as he unbuttons his jeans, pulling the fabric down just past his ass.

He will never admit to the whimper that involuntarily leaves his mouth at the feel of Izuku's hand over his still-clothed dick.

Somewhat overwhelmed, Katsuki looks up at the ceiling – at those same shitty glow-in-the-dark stars. How many times has he looked up at this same ceiling? How many days had he spent in this bed, miserable and broken and alone? How many days had he wished, prayed, hoped that the person on his knees slowly stroking his aching cock would come back so he could beat the shit out of him?

Maybe he can work out some of that aggression by making the nerd choke on his cock. He feels it twitch in his underwear at the thought.

He keeps his eyes on that head of green hair, brain a pleasant, mushy buzz. Those electric eyes briefly glance up to him before he's pulling his underwear down, revealing his engorged cock in all its shameless, aroused glory.

He half-wonders if Izuku locked his bedroom door. He half-wonders if his mother might be listening. He kind of hopes she is. She's been so thirsty for his cock for fuck-knows how long, and he hopes she's choking back tears as he face-fucks her precious son. His. Izuku is fucking *his*.

Katsuki watches, mesmerized, as that wet tongue pops out of kiss-slicked lips and teasingly, so fucking teasingly, licks along the head of his dick, dipping slightly into the tip, lapping up his pre-cum. He grabs on to the bedsheets, anything to stop himself from grabbing the other's curls and ramming the boy in front of him down on his member. Izuku pulls up, just far enough to make eye contact, just enough that he can see the thick line of precum still connecting Izuku's tongue to his dick.

He looks fucking dangerous. Ravenous.

He kind of understands what Izuku was getting at. He feels like he might just blow his load over the other's face with how heated that look is. Now, *that's* a thought.

"Keep your eyes on me," Izuku says, and he knows exactly what the fuck he's doing. He knows what those words mean.

As if Katsuki could look anywhere else.

Izuku encompasses him in that wet heat, taking him as far down as he can, and Katsuki moans, not bothering to be quiet, as his cock hits the back of Izuku's throat. His tongue caresses the underside of his dick, and slowly, deliberately, Izuku bobs back up, tongue swirling around the tender head. He pulls back, thick lips lavishing him with adoring kisses, tongue desperate for a taste of his cum and he slides down once more, just as aggressive, just as deeply, and Katsuki keens at the feel of that sensitive flesh in the back of the other's throat. He's gotten better. Katsuki doesn't have the mental capacity to wonder why that is.

Katsuki's ascended into the astral plane, observing the hottest shit he's ever seen third person as his soul threatens to leave his body through his cock when the demon that is Izuku Midoriya grabs his hand (that's depositing so much nitroglycerin into Izuku's bedsheets that it very well might be a fire hazard) and puts it on the top of his own head.

"…You want this, don't you?" Izuku asks. His voice is so gritty because of Katsuki's cock that a weird sense of pride and fresh gush of arousal floods his belly. He has the vague idea that Izuku isn't just talking about putting his hands on his hair, or this blowjob, but something more nebulous than that.

He does. Whatever the fuck it is, if it involves Izuku, yeah. Katsuki wants it. He can't stop wanting it, and he's tired of pretending that he doesn't.

“You can hurt me. I like it when you hurt me.” Izuku reassures, as if reading Katsuki’s mind. Katsuki watches his spit-slicked cock bounce at those words.

“I like it when you hurt me too.”

Katsuki grabs the others curls hard, pulling them between his fingers, heart threatening to beat straight out of his ribcage as he pumps his hips forward, *hard,* hitting the back of the other’s throat instantly, not letting the other up with the harsh grip he had on his head. The tiny, choked off sound the other releases nearly makes him cum on the spot.

“Fuck, you look so good like this, Deku.” The nickname slips out, but Izuku doesn’t seem to mind it – if anything, he seems to respond with more fervor, hollowing his cheeks out. Katsuki watches the other’s hand disappear somewhere below him and he can feel from the hitching of the other’s breath that he’s touching himself.

Shit. No. He gets to ask for this. He deserves to ask for this.

"Stop, don’t cum. I want to watch you jerk off. Over my chest.”

Like it pains him, he removes his hand from his own pants, slamming it on his bed as he grips the covers. Katsuki bites his lip, trying to talk himself down. He didn’t fucking know an obedient Izuku would make him feel like this, but shit. He’s discovering a bunch of new stuff about himself lately.

His beautiful fucking eyes leak tears, there’s spit all over his perfect cheeks, dripping down his jaw, and his curls feel like silk between his fingers. Maybe feeling this profound affection isn’t necessarily normal when face fucking someone, but he takes pity on the nerd – pulling his head up so Izuku has to look at him as he cums in his mouth, closing his own eyes and moaning at the release.

The other doesn’t even wait – he swallows and scurries up to mount Katsuki, eyes dilated, dangerous. Thick with expectation.

He can feel how hard his cock is, how hot it feels despite the fabric between them, how badly he wants that cock in his mouth, in his ass, anywhere and everywhere Izuku fucking wants because he’s his. His, his, his. Always.

Izuku pulls down his pants and Katsuki, in concert, hurriedly tears off his own sweater. Izuku stops, staring at the scars on his body, tentatively outlining them with his fingers. Then, he takes out that massive cock that makes Katsuki’s throat dry up and strokes it, fast and inpatient.

It takes less than a minute. A perfect fucking minute that Katsuki’s going to remember for the rest of his life. The way his face, still covered in spit, scrunches up like the pleasure he’s feeling is bordering on pain. How pretty that fucking aroused blush looks like on his freckled cheeks. How good Izuku looks with his hair standing all over the place.

He doubles over, barely making a sound as he shoots his seed across Katsuki’s chest. He looks so hot like that, holding his big cock in his hands, staring down at Katsuki. He doesn’t think he’ll ever get tired of seeing him like this.

He doesn’t budge from his spot on Katsuki’s hips. They just breathe heavily, chests heaving as they look into one another’s eyes. Without words, it all makes sense. *I’d do anything for you. I want you. You, and only you. For the rest of my life. No matter what that means. Even if it hurts. Even if I bleed. Even if this all ends in fucking tragedy. Its you. You. Always been you.*

Eventually, the other moves. He wipes the cum off Katsuki's chest with his own T-shirt and lays down next to him. Katsuki's wouldn't say its cuddling – not really – just lying next to one another like they did in that tent, understanding flowing easily between them despite the lack of words.

It's odd. In the past, Zero always snuck away. Always said some cryptic shit to make Katsuki feel like human garbage. Always made things worse. But now, Katsuki is going to be the one that leaves. And it's weird, because his body doesn't want to. He wants to stay right here, safe with Izuku, under these shitty glowing stars. He wants to watch the way they reflect in his eyes. He wants to fall asleep next to him, wake up to his nightmares with him, meet the morning with him, sex-hair and bad breath and crusty eyes. All of that gross shit, Katsuki wants.

But, today, he's the one that leaves.

Katsuki gets up eventually, urged on by the dawning light of an unkind sun. He opens Izuku's window, letting the winter air chill them both to the bone.

He looks back, swallowing down his emotions lest he say something stupid. He clears his throat before finally settling on his parting words.

"…You know where to find me. Apparently. Fucking stalker nerd."

He hears Izuku laugh, just slightly and he gives him the two finger salute before he jumps out his bedroom window.

Katsuki can't hide the grin on his lips, and if he skips halfway home, that's his business.

Chapter End Notes

Izuku and Katsuki, Very Normal at the party:



Katsuki, being very smart, immediately taking the opportunity to be alone with Izuku:



Izuku, Stupid Bitch, Being Jealous of HIS OWN ALTERNATE PERSONA:



This chapter was originally going to have Izuku come to Katsuki. Find him in Hiroshima, wait at his door. But then I thought - Izuku can just leave. It would be cruel for him to just introduce himself into a new life that Katsuki's built for himself, especially when Katsuki would always be scared of him leaving. Their reconciliation - or at least the beginnings of it - had to be on Katsuki's turf. Katsuki has to be the one that leaves. Katsuki has to be the one that makes the choice to come back. AND he gets a little head. As a treat.

Also it felt like the perfect moment for Katsuki to make peace (sort of?) with his relationship with Inko, with Izuku's bedroom which had nothing but bad memories for him until now. To make peace with his life in Tokyo - and the life he chose. To invite Izuku inside this new life.

(i hope it didn't feel too disingenuous? yikes i know i made katsuki like... deal with leaving Izuku for the last two chapters so him jumping in bed with him IMMEDIATELY after seeing him again might be a little whiplash-ey. But also he'd 100% do that.)

Chapter 22

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"We're being followed," Mirko states, like Katsuki doesn't fucking know. Katsuki just *'tchs'* in response, jumping into action, because fuck if Mirko finds him before Katsuki does.

He blasts his way into where he last saw the hem of a green overcoat disappear. He's unexpectedly fast and Katsuki, against all logic, feels kind of proud when he isn't easily able to catch up to him. He walks back to his boss, face a careful picture of frustration despite the self-satisfied giddiness hidden underneath.

"You find 'em?"

"Eh. Some kinda fanboy. Was trying to get your autograph. I chased him off."

Mirko's shoulders actually droop as she rolls out her bottom lip, making big eyes at Katsuki. Despite the fact that the woman is way over six feet, towering over Katsuki like some kind of ridiculous behemoth, she tries the innocent act with *him.* Him! Mount Lady is one thing, but Mirko? All bulging muscles and reputation for crushing your neck with her monster thighs? Pass times 1000.

"Probably a horny freak. I did ya a favor."

She pouts harder. "Not everyone that likes me is a horny freak!"

"Keep telling yourself that," he quips back, earning a laugh from his boss.

They continue onwards. He glances up at her, scrutinizing her even expression. He can't help but remember his last conversation with Izuku. He refuses to feel guilty about not coming to see him – and yet, the thought that the woman next to him, who barely knew the guy, made the two hour flight to go harass him in fuckin' prison makes Katsuki a little… curious.

"…So you went to see Deku, huh?"

Mirko's eyebrows shoot to the top of her head, her ears standing straight up. Even the hairs on top of said ears stand on end.

"Who told you that?" she screeches at him before evening her voice, making her face placid. Unlike his mother, she's shit at hiding her emotions. Shit, her *ears* are quivering, folded in half as if ashamed.

"Doesn't fuckin' matter, does it? So what's up, why you visit him? Was it before or after he got his ass beat and landed himself in solitary?"

Mirko looked somewhat embarrassed up until the end, then stands up straighter, tilting her head at him.

"Got his…? Kid, I don't know what you heard, but was thrown into solitary to protect the other prisoners."

Katsuki stops walking, forcing Mirko to do the same. She turns back to him, eyebrows furrowed, face painted with obvious confusion. As if Katsuki was supposed to know this information.

"…He's Quirkless. And crippled."

"Everyone there wears Quirk-suppressing collars. And your boy didn't fight with his arms back in the day, now, did he?"

Katsuki doesn't comment on the way the word 'your' makes his heart speed up. Or what the thought of Izuku fuckin' Midoriya, the sweetest boy he knows, knocking prisoners around so badly that he had to be put into solitary does to him. How fucking *hot* it is that the only hero in Tarturus was also the biggest goddamn threat?

"You might want to reconsider messing with him. That boy is dangerous." Mirko finishes, ears standing back up. Despite the seriousness of her words, her lips quirk into a knowing smile. He narrows his eyes in on her as he covers her mouth with her hand, laughing to herself like he's in on some private joke.

He doesn't see him for the rest of the day. Not for the rest of the patrol, not when he spends an extra 30 minutes at the gym, not when he stops by the grocery store. Not when he scrutinizes each bok choy for brown spots, or argues with the butcher regarding the freshness of the chicken, or as he meticulously checks each package of tofu for its expiration date. He might take a little longer than he normally does - just to torture him a little.

In reality, he might have gone to a convenience store today to grab some garbage to stuff into his body. He's tired, it's close to his new place, and he doesn't have the time or energy to cook every night. But this is a bit of a performance – an act. *Yes, my life is incredibly together. Yes, I'm normal, and happy, even! Yes, don't pay attention to the beer in my cart. It's a six pack, and it lasts for a while, and maybe I wouldn't mind sharing it with a certain stalker.*

He's grinning to himself as he puts away his groceries. Slowly, even for himself.

No knock. No doorbell. Nothing.

…The other's been on his heels all fucking day, and Katsuki knows for sure that he followed him home. So the fact that there's no one knocking at his door is straight up bewildering. What was the point of all that if not to…

Well.

He doesn't know the other to wimp out, to not follow through. But maybe he's got his own reasons. It's not like Katsuki's been waiting for him.

(Every day. For nearly a month. But who's counting.)

Katsuki tries to shake the tension out of his shoulders. Instead of overthinking, he gets his hand on a knife and gets to work. He grabs the stock pot and places it on the stove. He pours in the dashi, bringing it a soft boil. Bok choy, scallions, tofu, miso paste… He combines the ingredients in a simple mixture, stirring the soup, too aware of how hard he's listening for a knock on his front door.

The soup is done. He pours himself a bowl and walks to his living room, setting it on the coffee table. The warmth of the soup is pleasant in his stomach and he takes his time chewing through the tofu, sipping on the broth. Waiting.

He brings the bowl to the kitchen, having enough time to rinse it and start to pack away the rest of the soup when he finally hears it. He lazily lifts his eyes to the time on the microwave. It's been over an

hour since he's gotten home – he can't imagine what the other had been doing all this fucking time. Always keeping him waiting.

Katsuki wipes his hands against the kitchen towel, leisurely walking towards the door. He looks through the peep-hole, seeing none-other but a head of green hair and a fidgety hand, messing with the hem of his own shirt.

Katsuki opens the door to the boy standing outside. He scrutinizes him – the outfit is pretty much the same as what he saw earlier today in the alley, long green overcoat, sweater and jeans. That same stupid All Might red-white-and-yellow scarf wrapped around his neck.

The only new addition is the satchel draped over his shoulder, straining against its zipper.

Katsuki narrows his eyes at it.

"Hi." Izuku says finally, looking down at him as he takes his bottom lip between his teeth, and it's so fucking endearing Katsuki has to clench his fists to prevent himself from jumping him.

"Whatdaya want?" Katsuki crosses his arms and leans on one hip, not entirely sure what the hell he's supposed to do with his body. There's an odd tension between the two of them – an air of uncertainty – that keeps the other a firm three feet away. He's looking at him with those puppy-dog eyes, wide and green and hopeful. The thought of this big softie being so threatening in Tarturus – literally the most high-security for violent villains prison in the entire country – that he was put in solitary confinement makes Katsuki nearly crack a smile.

But he's got a role to play, so he keeps his face impassive, borderline uninterested, like the man in front of him didn't suck his dick in his own childhood bedroom less than a month prior. Like Katsuki didn't, very directly, ask the other to chase after him.

"… I found you?" Izuku says, keeping his lips fixed in a confused smile, and Katsuki only shrugs.

"You want a prize or something?"

Katsuki keeps himself barring the door. Keeps his arms crossed. There's something exhilarating in seeing the other's expression morph from one of excitement and hope to one of confusion. As Katsuki remains silent, the other's shoulders droop, the bag shifting behind him at the movement.

"…Are you going to invite me in?" His voice is slightly more terse, on edge. But if he's willing to give up that fucking easy, then this isn't going anywhere.

Katsuki remains rocklike, making his stand in front of this door.

There's a giant fucking wooden horse standing in front of his fortress, and Katsuki knows that his end is probably lying underneath that unassuming disguise – something sweet and innocent masking the danger within – but he opens the door anyway. This is his last stand. His last attempt to prevent the impending invasion.

"Why the fuck should I?" he finally asks, tilting his head at the other. It's a sincere question. And maybe, maybe Katsuki is asking himself that question too. Maybe he's been asking himself for the past month, since he's returned from Musutafu on the teetering edge of a breakdown, because he did something fucking *impulsive.* Something that he had been trying to convince himself would bring him nothing but misery if he dared to indulge.

But the world didn't implode. He didn't feel miserable. He didn't feel anything *bad,* really. That stubborn seed of hope has taken root, was rapidly growing through his ribcage, destroying all doubts like an invasive species. He doesn't know why this is. Maybe because with Izuku – not Zero, not Deku, but Izuku specifically – there's a chance to start over.

They've turned the universe inside out and now trying to put it back into place again. And everything's backwards, in the wrong order, at the wrong time; but Katsuki doesn't really mind. He's never been a sucker for doing things the 'right' way, whatever that right way might be.

"…It's cold outside?" Izuku starts.

It *is* cold outside. Each time he speaks, a small puff of air escapes his lips. His cheeks are deliciously red on top of his freckles, reminding him of a chocolate covered strawberry. The top of his nose and his tips of his ears are rosy, too, making him look so fucking young.

"Looks like you're dressed pretty warm." Katsuki doesn't close the door, chest oddly light. *Try again,* he tries to say with his eyes.

He watches Izuku chew at his lip, that disgusting habit that somehow makes Katsuki's stupid heart skip a beat before he raises those ridiculously green eyes back to Katsuki's.

"It's raining. If I don't dry off, I might catch a cold." He says with a straight face.

It was not raining. It hasn't rained in months. Izuku Midoriya is not soaking wet. Katsuki feels the corner of his jaw twitch against his permission.

"I'll get you a towel." Katsuki steps away.

His heart is beating so quickly he can hardly breathe, he can feel how hot his cheeks suddenly are, and his stomach is twisted in knots. He refuses to think about his actions, grabbing a clean towel from one of his drawers and walking back towards the door.

He doesn't think twice – he probably doesn't even think *once* – as he's throwing the towel over the other's head. Completely covered, Katsuki's chest too full, he rubs his hands over those curls in a drying motion. His fingers run gingerly to the back of his skull, breath caught in his throat, fingertips alive with electricity despite the barrier between them.

Katsuki isn't sure the direction where his blood is going when the other takes his hand from out of his pocket and places it on top of Katsuki's. So cold, making Katsuki's overheated fingers nearly steam.

"Thanks, Kacchan." Izuku takes the towel in his hands, revealing his own flushed face, hair fluffed up to triple its previous volume. Electricity makes it stick to the towel as he moves it to his neck and Katsuki has to bite his lip to prevent himself from laughing.

Katsuki remembers what the fuck he's doing, and, after what is likely two seconds too long of keeping his hand right under Izuku's, jerks it away before the humidity between them erupts into something even Katsuki can't walk away from.

"Whatever," he croaks out, taking a few deep breaths.

The door closes behind Izuku and the world starts to cave in on itself.

Katsuki looks up at those green eyes, those pink cheeks, that stupid hair. He looks at those pinkened lips, that strong jaw, the tiny hint of skin above his scarf.

“You – uh. You need to get out of those wet clothes. And take a shower. So you don’t… catch a cold.”

He can see the way the other’s Adams apple bobs with a prolonged swallow, the way his mouth opens slightly in a shuddering exhale.

“Y-yeah. I’m freezing.”

Katsuki reaches towards the frills of the All Might scarf. Gently, he pulls at the end; it unfurls from its spot around the other’s muscular neck. Katsuki drops it to the floor, watching the other carefully.

Izuku understands the assignment. He zips down the forest-green coat, keeping his eyes locked with Katsuki’s. He shrugs the thing off his shoulders to reveal the black sweater and jeans underneath.

He leans down, and Katsuki grabs the nape of his shirt, pulling it over his head as the other obediently lifts up his arm.

Katsuki steps back for a second, devouring Izuku with his eyes. Despite the fact that he’s objectively thinner than he was when he was Zero, who was bulky and broad, Izuku as himself is now all dense muscle, finely-toned and cut as if from marble. Katsuki swallows.

He takes a slightly shaky hand, placing it flat over the taught muscles of his stomach, skirting where his pants meet naked skin. He feels Izuku’s abdominals tense under his fingertips and Katsuki swallows down the butterflies as he trails his fingers up those muscles, along his ribs, up his pectorals, taking enough of a pause to rub a thumb against a hardened nipple.

He watches the other’s eyes roll in the back of his head as he shudders into his touch. He trails his hand down once more, resting, inquisitory, against his waistline.

When Izuku opens his eyes again, those unbelievable green irises are eclipsed by dark pupils.

Katsuki keeps their eyes locked as he unbuttons the other’s jeans, swiping the zipper down. He feigns a mistake as he lightly outlines the other’s half-hard bulge pressing against his boxers. Katsuki chews at his lip, tension escalating as he takes each belt loop on either side of his size and pulls them down.

He can feel the heat in his stomach churn, his own chest coiled tight with excitement. He keeps his eyes on the collection of fabric at the other’s feet. He hadn’t taken off his shoes. Those stupid red shoes. He’s standing there, in his living room, in Hiroshima, half-hard in his stupid boxers – just a plain red; wet spot in the front betraying the Izuku’s poorly hidden excitement – tense muscles of his thighs locked, jeans pooled around ugly-ass red shoes.

He has to fight the urge to get on his knees, to sink his teeth into those corded muscles in his legs, to taste that nervous sweat pooling in this inner thighs.

His eyes trail up his body, slowly, savoring it.

The other seems to know exactly what he’s thinking, toeing out of his shoes, kicking the denim away until he’s standing in his underwear in Katsuki’s living room.

They say nothing to each other.

The sudden sound of his tea kettle whistling breaks Katsuki out of his trance. He raises his eyebrows, the air around him suddenly very chilly. He tongues at the inside of his cheek – he doesn’t know when he started biting into it, or why the flesh tastes suspiciously like his own blood.

"…You should shower. Through that door." Katsuki points to his bedroom. He sees the shift in Izuku's eyes too – that entranced darkness replaced with something different. Something vulnerable. He shuffles away, still in his underwear, into Katsuki's bedroom.

Katsuki doesn't *not* watch the way his ass moves in those tight boxer-briefs.

On autopilot, Katsuki walks to his kitchen, taking the kettle off the stove. He leans against the counter, breathing deeply, trying to calm his mind.

The sound of the shower turning on makes every hair in his neck stand on end.

What the actual *fuck* is he doing?

Katsuki looks around, trying to come back into some semblance of reality. But it doesn't seem to be a dream – Izuku's clothes litter his floor, his duffel bag – the first thing he dropped, laying right in front of Katsuki's front door.

He walks towards it, unsure why he feels the inherent need to know what is inside. He leans down, unzipping the contents.

Nothing too surprising. Several changes of clothes. A toothbrush. A comb (something that Katsuki is sincerely surprised to find Izuku owning.) He digs along the bottom, feeling something against his fingertips. He pulls it out, his heart jumping into his throat.

He'd know the water-logged pages anywhere. Notebook number 13. As he takes it out of the bag, something falls out from within the pages.

Laminated and holographic, Katsuki brings the card closer his face, letting it shine in the dim lighting of his living room.

Summertime, popsicles, his own holler and Izuku's – no, Deku's – whoop of pleasure as they both opened their trading card packs, both somehow pulling out the super rare one in a million holographic All Might.

This is the most important fucking thing in Izuku's life.

Why did he –

Katsuki feels his butt hit the floor as realization crashes full force into his psyche. Numbly, he blinks at the bag, swallowing a few more times, feeling tears collect in his eyes. The shower is still running. The heater in his living room continues its persistent buzz. The wind picks up outside, knocking a branch of a tree against Katsuki's kitchen window.

Izuku's not just visiting.

He stands up. His feet move automatically – past his bedroom window, into the bathroom, past the steamed glass.

"Oh – uh, Ka – " Izuku notices he's there, shily covering up his junk with his hand, soap bubbles from his hair running into his eyes, and the former closes them tight.

Katsuki breathes in deep, and, fully clothed, steps under the stream.

Izuku's mouth stays propped open as he tries to wipe at his eyes, soap continuously pouring from his hair down his pretty face.

Katsuki's shirt and pants start to weigh down under the water. He stares at Izuku – skin pink with heat, steam surrounding him, his curls straightened out under the weight of water, betraying the sheer length of his hair. Katsuki swallows, taking his fingers and brushing the strands off his chin, off his forehead, brushes them back behind his ears and gently, ever so gently, massages his scalp, directing him under the stream to ensure that each soap sud is rinsed off.

Surprised, the other opens his eyes to watch Katsuki. Katsuki doesn't do anything in response – he automatically grabs the bottle of conditioner, pushing Izuku out from under the stream with one hand. As the other complies, Katsuki squirts some conditioner into his hand, and without being instructed Izuku leans his head down.

He works the conditioner within his locks gently, systematically, letting his fingers massage his scalp, the back of his neck, behind his ears. He can feel each breath become more haggard as tiny sounds escape the taller man in front of him. He's forgotten to keep covering his dick – he can see it start to harden again against his thigh.

Against every instinct, he ignores it. He ignores his own annoyingly wet clothes, sticking against his skin and weighting him down.

He grabs the sponge and douses it with body wash. He starts at the other's chest, under his arms, along the stump (not ignoring the mesmerizing way Izuku flinches at the touch,) around his stomach, his inner thighs, his outer thighs. Izuku is fully hard, pretty cock bobbing under soap suds, ruddy and leaking. Katsuki's not much better.

Katsuki grabs the other's waist, harder than he intends, and spins him around. His shoulders, the tense muscles of his back, the dimples right above his ass. Katsuki feels his mouth go dry as he lathers up the other's muscular ass, then just underneath, against his taint, fingers trailing just a little too far to touch his engorged shaft. He pulls back, running the loofah against the back of his thighs, against his calves before standing back up.

He drags the other, malleable under his hands, back under the stream.

The scent of mint is washed off. The shitty stuff he puts in his hair – that same woodsy hair gel he can't stand – is gone. Under the steam, the cleansing water, things are new. They're different. He's not the Deku he used to be. And Katsuki's not the person he used to be, either.

He reaches to his own back, peeling off the soaking shirt, then quickly skirting out of his pants and underwear.

Izuku doesn't turn around and Katsuki doesn't coax him to. He quickly washes his own hair, his own body, lathers up with the same sponge, the same body wash, the same shampoo. He pushes the other, gently, out of the steam, wrapping his sudsy arms around his midsection.

His dick rests, fully hard, against the dimples in the other's back, against the cleft of Izuku's ass, and his heart flutters in a way he can't explain. Katsuki reaches around the front, and – no surprise, but it's still so fucking pleasant when the other's cock is fully hard for him.

They don't look at each other; how could they? Katsuki takes the other's swollen dick into his hand, using the body wash to help him glide around the sensitive head, nearly crooning and the feel of the other buck away from his touch and straight into his dick with his slippery ass.

Katsuki resists the urge to rut against his smooth body, resists the desire to force him down, to split himself open on that massive cock, to kiss and bight and bleed and fuck until both of them have forgotten how to stand.

But he doesn't.

There doesn't have to be an urgency to this. There doesn't have to be a back-breaking violence to this. Izuku brought his whole life with him to this apartment. It seems like they have time.

Katsuki wants to be thank him, to be grateful, to bless whatever happened in Tokyo over the past month to finally let him pack his bags, for him to book that flight, for him to find him.

It's too big of a gesture – but anything smaller might not have been enough. Katsuki wanted it all. And 'it all' is standing in front of him, at the mercy of his hands, letting the person who has spent half his life hurting him so everything he can to heal.

To soothe these old wounds.

To show that he understands him.

He exhales softly against the other's shoulder, lips resting on the scarred tissue. He nips it with his teeth, earning a beautiful high pitched moan from the other. He rubs at his pretty cock, trying his goddamn best to keep it together, to let his arousal speak through lips against soft skin that smells like him. Hair that smells like him. In his home, in his shower, under his hands. *His his his.*

He rubs a thumb over his slit, moving slowly to the base, stroking back up, arching his wrist, letting the vibrations of the other's soft moans guide his way. Over and over, smooth on smooth skin, growing harder, balls tightening, large body trembling, sweet moans losing their sweetness and turning into sounds of pure lust. He can feel him about to cum before it happens, the cock pulsing in his hand as Izuku all but stops breathing, arching his back and stopping breathing all together.

Katsuki strokes him, slightly slower, coaxing each drop of cum out of his dick as the other rests his body against him, remembering to breathe in large, heaving lungfuls.

"Sit," Katsuki states, turning the sex-drunk Izuku around, pink in the face from the heat of the shower. Katsuki pushes him down and the other sits, large legs and knobby knees barely fitting in the tiny porcelain tub, looking up at Katsuki in his own naked glory. He doesn't seem to fully understand what is happening before his eyes focus in on the swollen head of Katsuki's swinging cock – his mouth opens slightly, filled to the brim with saliva, and he starts to lean forward, but Katsuki pushes him back.

He's his. His shampoo, his body wash, his shower. Katsuki wants to mark him – its primordial, instinctual, and somehow *right.*

He takes his weeping cock into his hand, watching the other watch each tantalizing slide of his wrist, desperate hungry eyes and half-open mouth. Katsuki jerks himself off as efficiently as he can, grabbing the other's curls and forcing him to look up as he tries not to buck under the force of his own orgasm, cum splattering perfectly on Izuku's pretty face.

Izuku closes an eye as one glob of cum drips over his eye, sticking in his eyelash as it drips onto his chin. He watches the other, sizing him up, but Izuku doesn't falter. He just sticks his tongue out, catching the drop caught on the tip of his upper lip.

Katsuki grabs the head of the shower, spraying it across the other's face. Wordlessly, Katsuki turns off the water, stepping out of the shower. He hands the towel to Izuku, the same one he'd given him in his feigned rain-soaked hair, grabbing another for himself.

The Izuku that steps out of the shower is a different one that climbed in. Skin kissed with warm water, hair clean, freckles on display, face without that stupid constipated terrified look – just satisfied, and happy, and comfortable. He wants to tuck him under his covers, wants to protect the other from the goddamn cruel world, wants Izuku to stay here and never, ever fucking leave ~~him.~~

"Kacc- "

"Don't talk. Go to sleep."

He looks conflicted.

"Where?"

"…You an idiot? There's a bed right there." Katsuki waves vaguely to his own.

He just stands there, starkly naked, staring at the bed like the thing might just eat him alive. But he can see the way goosebumps rise in his skin – it's still winter, he's still fresh out of the shower, and his flesh is no different than Katsuki's – seeking out warmth where it can get it.

Katsuki climbing under the covers, still naked himself. Katsuki exhales slightly, closing his eyes, tension tightening in his shoulders, hearing astute. A part of Katsuki expects the other to walk away. To go to the couch. Or worse yet; get dressed and walk out his front door.

But the mattress gives under the other's weight. Izuku makes his way under the covers, staying silent. Katsuki doesn't do anything, evening out his breathing, feigning sleep.

Izuku turns. His hand tentatively touches the skin along his spine. When Katsuki doesn't react, he scoots in closer, tiny movement of his legs, hips, torso until their warm skin is flush with one another. Katsuki's back fits perfectly against the other's torso, like each curvature of his chest was designed to fit with Katsuki's spine. Katsuki melts into the contact. They're so close he can feel Izuku's heart against his spinal cord, feels each beat through every nerve, pulsating in his arms, his legs, touching each part of him. Even the way his pelvis fits against the curve or Katsuki's ass, even the way his hairy calves naturally intertwine with his.

Katsuki's eyes are filling with tears and he can't explain why.

Izuku ducks his head into the space between Katsuki's head and shoulder, lips resting against the sensitive skin there. Goosebumps erupt up Katsuki's spine as he feels the other's warm, wet breaths against his shoulder.

Despite himself, he can feel blood filling out his dick. He shifts, putting pressure on it, forcing his ass back against Izuku's own hardening dick.

Izuku wraps his arm around Katsuki's waist, forcing the two of them closer together, closer still, closer if that was at all possible. The bedsheets melt into the background. It's all heat, all warmth, all *Izuku* and Katsuki feels a single tear leave his eye, tracking down his face and soaking into the pillow. He exhales, slowly, controlled, anything to prevent his chest from shaking.

"…Thank you," Izuku whispers against his skin. "Thank you for saving my life. I asked you to kill me, but you're always, always saving my life."

Katsuki swallows against the dryness in his throat.

He can tell himself he didn't mean to. He can tell himself that he didn't tell the same man melding into his skin in his bed that the day he told the other to jump off the roof, somewhere between choking on garbage and searing his own skin to try to *survive, dammit, survive*! He thought – just for the briefest blip of time – that he deserves this. To choke and weep and die just like he lived – the mercy of his own Quirk. To die as he lived – a spectacle. To die as he lived – alone.

He saved Izuku but Izuku saved him first.

They've traveled to the opposite end of the world, they inverted reality on its head, and the hand that once reached out – big eyes, the river, the flap of butterfly wings that changed the fabric of space fucking time itself – is gone, and Katsuki's reaching back, Katsuki is holding on to the fingertips of a ghost, and its realer than anything else, more real than this apartment, this bed. This is the only real thing.

Izuku takes his hand and threads his fingers through Katsuki's, and Katsuki lets him. He lets him.

Izuku's breathing evens out behind him, and Katsuki can sleep. He can finally, finally sleep.

Katsuki's alarm blares, phone vibrating on the bedside table.

When he opens his eyes again, his heart starts beating fast, panic instantaneous. He doesn't want to be awake – doesn't want to face the inevitable reality of Izuku not being in his bed, not being in his home, not being *here.*

But he is. He knows it from the weight against his back, from the light snores against his shoulder, from the arm still wrapped around him, crooked fingers still interlaced with his. The world is still dark outside – nothing but quiet and peace, not even an offending light to ruin this moment. Everything is in stasis. Everything is as it should be.

The cold outside these covers has never made Katsuki so cautious.

But, duty calls, and he gently takes Izuku's arm off his waist, scooting out from under the covers into his bedroom. He walks to the closet, quickly pulling on whatever clothes he can get his hands on with memory and feel alone. He looks back to the bed – to the shifting shape within the covers, and somehow, against all instinct, leaves the front door.

"Give me the name of your guy," Katsuki grunts out as him and Mirko start their morning patrol.

"Which guy? My wax guy?" Mirko winks as she does an effortless high kick, as if to demonstrate her ridiculously bald bikini-line.

"What the fuck! What is wrong with you!" Katsuki yells, face flaring red as his mentor laughs at him, clapping her hand on his back.

"Which guy, kid?"

"Your prosthetic guy."

She grins and shifts her shoulder, as if displaying today's prosthetic for Katsuki's enjoyment.

In reality, he's been eyeing them for the past few months. She exchanges them regularly, like it's a goddamn fucking game. Like choosing a weapon in a video game. She fucking showed up with a

chainsaw – a fully functional one at that – one day. Whoever was making these seemed pretty sucking sharp. Maybe sharp enough to solve Izuku's… problem.

"…Why?"

"Why you always gotta ask so many questions, huh? What are you – " My mom? Katsuki wants to finish, but he knows the woman would jump on that in every inappropriate manner that exists, so he bites his tongue.

She scrutinizes him for a minute before pulling her phone out of somewhere that Katsuki doesn't care to know.

"I'm sending you his number. Don't be a freak."

"Fuck you." Katsuki spits back, rolling his eyes.

"…And tell Midoriya I said hi."

Katsuki's eyebrows shoot to the top of his skull and he can't stop himself from choking on his own saliva, sputtering in fake protest and that horrible woman laughs her ass off, patting him 'comfortingly' on the back.

Katsuki hesitates outside his front door. His feet feel heavy, chest full of trepidation. Despite this, he still puts the key in, still opens the door, ready for whatever (or lack thereof) meets him on the other side.

There are noises from the kitchen, and Katsuki slowly walks in to see the other playing some video on his phone, trying and failing horribly to cut up a tomato with his singular arm.

"What the fuck are you doing?"

Izuku nearly hops up at the noise, cheeks flushing a startled pink.

"Er… cooking dinner?"

"Yeah? And you know how to cook?" Katsuki asks, dropping his bag on the ground. He approaches the other at the sink. He taps the other as a warning, and when Izuku doesn't flinch away from him, he proceeds to wrap his arms all the way around his hard torso, resting his head against his shoulder blade. It's odd – he's not an affectionate person. He doesn't particularly like to be touched. And he knows Izuku doesn't either. But the sight of the other standing there in his kitchen pulls on every goddamn heartstring Katsuki has. Izuku's playing him like a fucking fiddle and he doesn't even know it.

"I – um. I can learn!" He waves distractedly at his phone, recipe video paused on an image of some white dude in an overpriced kitchen slicing through some tomatoes.

"I have to pay you back somehow – not that I'm – well – I'm going to get a job, and all that, I just don't… have any skills? So…" The way he says it is so fucking cute Katsuki can't help himself – he snorts into the other's shoulder blade, fingers digging into the hem of his pants, biting his lip to prevent from laughing as he bucks back at the feel of Katsuki touching his cock.

"Kacchan! I'm holding a knife!"

"You can't do shit – "

And just like that, the fucker uses his calves to turn them around, thigh pressing against his torso as the knife brandishes against his throat. Izuku stands over him, eyes electric, smirk playing at the corner of his lips. Katsuki just stares up at him, tongue tied.

Even though it nudges the knife closer to his throat, he leans forward, feeling the cold metal as he meets Izuku's lips.

They pull back slightly, Izuku's eyes pleasantly hazy and very much surprised. Seeing him this close up is pretty nice. In a rapid movement, he grabs the other's wrist, twisting it, making the knife clatter to the floor. Izuku just swallows, slowly, not averting his eyes away from Katsuki's.

"…You play dirty," Izuku whispers, voice low, pupils blown. Katsuki shudders at his tone.

"I play to win."

A forceful arm gets Katsuki sitting on his counter and Izuku goes all in, lips on his, messy as they go from kissing softly to nibbling on his lips to scattered kisses along his chin, his jaw, in the crook of his neck. He feels himself arch back as desperate wet kisses, punctuated by soft bites rain on him. He wraps his arms around the other, pulling him in closer.

He feels a hand against his scar, the one on his calf that Zero inflicted with Spearlike-limbs. The memory of the bunker flashes starkly in his eyes, and he can't help but compare them. The pain, the fury, the dust and dirt and grime, to this warm kitchen, the lights, the way Izuku can't stop, *won't* stop looking at him. Its everything. Its more than he could ever imagine to deserve. Each scar – the one on his calf, the four starbursts like marks as a compass on his mangled body, the hallucinations, the nightmares, it's all for him. Because of him. And each one was worth it – to end up here.

"I'm sorry – I'm sorry I hurt you," Izuku whispers, frantic against his lips, and Katsuki doesn't know if he's referring to the physical scars, or the other ones. The secret ones, the ones that still give him nightmares, the ones he wears on his heart.

"I'm sorry it took me so long. I'm sorry – "

"Izuku, stop." Katsuki kisses him softly, letting the other man exhale in his mouth.

"I'm sorry too. I'm sorry I was such an asshole to you. I'm fuckin' sorry I walked away from you. I was still fucking bitter about what happened, but I'm not anymore, okay?"

"I – "

"Are you listening to me?" Katsuki takes Izuku's face between his hands, makes sure that the other is staring him straight in the eyes. They glimmer with unshed tears, staring at Katsuki like any next word he might say may change his whole life.

"I don't want to fucking do that anymore. I don't want to hurt each other over and over and over again and call it love. I can't promise I won't be an asshole anymore, or that I'm going to be as good to you as you deserve, but I'm going to fucking try. Okay? And I want you to hold me accountable. Don't walk away from me. Don't let me get away with shit. If we're doing this, you need to be in this. One hundred percent."

"Kacchan…" A single tear travels down that freckled cheek, and he grins at him. He honest-to-god grins.

"One hundred and ten percent? Plus ultra?"

“I cannot fucking *stand* you – “ Katsuki groans, catching his breath as Izuku bites particularly hard into the muscles on his neck. He jerks his hips, reveling at the feel of the other’s heavy hand against his thighs. Steadying him. Grounding him. Katsuki can’t help it. He’s grinning too. He’s grinning right back, because they’re sharing this goddamn madness.

Izuku grabs at the hem of his shirt, and wordlessly Katsuki raises his arms, enjoying the sight of Izuku devouring his chest with his eyes.

Izuku peels back, eyes wide, inquiring. They dart back and forth from Katsuki’s, red-rimmed and already tearful, asking a question he knows the other will never ask out loud.

“Kacchan. I’m so in love with you. I don’t think I’ll ever love anyone the way I love you.”

Katsuki’s chest aches at the confession, and he knows with the sincerity oozing from those honest eyes, he’s telling the truth.

“I’m going to make damn sure of that,” Katsuki smirks back, and, *oh.*

As if his words just unlocked something in the other, Izuku just darts forward, warm tongue against his nipples, biting and sucking hard enough that Katsuki’s head hits the cupboard he’s backed against. It’s too much, and it’s too good, and Katsuki digs his nails into the other’s shoulder blades, pleasantly surprised at the excited groan the other releases as his harsh treatment.

Izuku pulls back, cheeks flushed, looking pathetically at Katsuki, tent in his pants.

“…Um. I know it would be sexier if I could carry you, but…” Izuku lifts the nub on his right, earnestly embarrassed. Katsuki just rolls his eyes, hopping off the counter. He slides a finger into Izuku’s waistband and walks, wordlessly, into his bedroom.

“How do you want me?” Katsuki asks, flexing his muscles a bit as Izuku stares him down wolfishly. In the past few months, he’s started to put on weight; he can see that the other likes it, too.

“…Every way,” Izuku murmurs out loud, eyes opening wider at the words like he didn’t intend to say them.

“O – on your back? If you – if you want to – I mean – “

Katsuki flops down on his back, shucking out of his pants. For emphasis, he opens his bedside drawer, taking out the lube.

“We’ve done this already. No reason to freak out.”

“…It was different,” Izuku says so quietly that Katsuki has to strain to hear him. He’s not sure in which way. The same bodies are performing the act. Maybe the emotions behind it are different. Maybe the people, in some way, are different. Maybe the act itself means something different.

Katsuki’s never known sex to mean something – but in a way, it feels like an extension of letting Izuku into his home, kissing in the kitchen, sleeping in the same bed, eating meals together. This isn’t revenge, this isn’t self-harm, this isn’t violence, this isn’t domination.

This is…

Katsuki flushes at the thought, and, with the full intention of ignoring it for as long as he possibly can, he puts a pillow under his hips and tosses the bottle of lube to Izuku.

He catches it effortlessly, the dork. Katsuki half-imagined him fumbling with it, but he's smooth as ever – particularly when it comes to this.

"Are you… are you sure?"

Katsuki points to his dick, hard enough to stay floating just above his stomach.

"…I look unsure? What are you scared of, Izuku?"

Izuku walks forward, getting on his knees on the bed. He caresses Katsuki's inner thighs with a reverence that is nearly embarrassing, staring at his dick and balls like he's at a goddamn museum.

"…Everything, Katsuki. I'm scared of everything."

Katsuki shudders. The way the other's voice shakes, the vulnerability, the honesty in those words. In this bedroom, in the darkness, he's not lying anymore. He's not trying to be that brave Deku that always does his best, not Zero that has accepted that he's going to die and is fucking running to that finish line at top speed.

This person in front of him is afraid.

It makes something soft unfurl in Katsuki's gut. He does a small sit-up, catching the other's jaw in this palm. He presses a kiss, soft at first, but then deeper, thrusting his tongue into an unexpecting mouth, swallowing down the surprised moans emanating from his former rival. He pulls back, foreheads meeting.

"And me? You scared of me?"

"Katsuki," he whispers out, and Katsuki swallows hard, images of Zero flashing in front of his mind. That voice gritty like gravel. Like he's being dragged behind a moving vehicle and fuck if he doesn't want it to go on forever.

"I'm scared of *losing* you. I'm scared that this will end. I'm scared you'll hate me."

"I could never hate you, Deku."

The nickname slips and Izuku's eyes widen, mouth opening slightly. With a ferocity Katsuki doesn't expect, he smashes his lips against Katsuki's, forcing his head back onto the bed, back onto the pillow. He's rough, tongue thrusting into his mouth, Katsuki meeting it back for all its fervor, tasting him the way Izuku tastes him. closer and closer and closer still. His cock aches, stomach tense. He wants and wants and *wants* –

He doesn't remember hearing the bottle of lube open, but Izuku is caressing his hole with a single wet finger. Katsuki groans, biting into Izuku's lip as he slides his finger in.

"Fuck – Izuku – " Katsuki groans and the other gasps, just slightly, against his mouth as he rubs his hips, still dressed, against Katsuki's thigh. He pulls back, desperately, eyes wild and Katsuki knows exactly what he wants – he grabs his pants, pulling them down, revealing that hard, massive cock.

Katsuki can feel his hole twitch at the sight of it, his mouth flooding with saliva. He's so damn pretty its nearly criminal. Katsuki fights the urge to laugh at his own internal joke, considering that yeah, he *is* a criminal.

“It’s – I can’t believe you ever thought I would be disgusted by this. Jesus, Katsuki. Look at you. You’re so beautiful.” Izuku’s eyes trail up his body, nice and slow before landing on his eyes. There’s danger behind those long lashes, despite his chocolate words. Katsuki feels a second finger penetrate his rim and he moans, unabashed and loud, arching his neck back. Its more for show than anything else, but the way Izuku’s fingers stutter, the way he keeps chanting gentle, sweet affirmations against Katsuki’s skin – anywhere he can get his mouth, his chest, his stomach, just over the hilt of his cock, just between his thighs, just teasing enough to be sweet rather than infuriating.

Aware of the other’s inexperience, Katsuki lets himself get taken away by his excitement, trying to adjust his own comfort and arousal to Izuku’s mood. Except – except!

Lightning runs up Katsuki’s spine, exploding into fireworks behind his brain.

“Ah! What the fuck!” Katsuki gasps, doing a small sit-up to glare at the grinning Izuku sitting upright, watching his own fingers with an enthralled rapture.

“I’ve been doing research!”

“What kind of fucking *books* do they have in prison?! SHIT.” Katsuki wheezes as the idiot keeps pressing his crooked fingertips against his prostate, the sensitive tissue sending waves of pleasure through Katsuki’s abdomen, ultimately making his poor weeping cock harder, wetter, more desperate.

He’s been into this before, but – something is different this time. This is a factor of mutual pleasure. Not just hurting each other to get off. Not some kind of revenge. Nothing but the desire to make one another feel good. It makes Katsuki feel all fucking… soft on the inside, which unfortunately brings his impending orgasm even closer to completion.

“Deku, stupid shit, if you don’t fuck me I’m gonna – “ Katsuki bites his tongue, glaring at the other, too aroused and somehow simultaneously angry to react to that fine flush along the other’s cheeks.

“M-my balance, might, um – “

Katsuki raises his eyebrows. It certainly will be hard for the other to fuck him face to face without a second arm to at least keep him upright. It annoys him more than he can wrap his head around.

Instead, Katsuki throws his calves over the other’s muscular shoulders, arching his ass closer to him. He can’t say the words out loud, because it’s so fucking stupid he might throw up. *If you can’t balance, let me help. Depend on me. You can always depend on me.*

Katsuki flexes his hips and calves, lifting his hips to be in good fucking distance of that massive cock Izuku’s holding between his hands. He looks conflicted for exactly half a second before he’s lubing up that monster and nudging it against Katsuki’s hole.

Katsuki has not had sex for, what, about 10 months now? Izuku mentioned that he had been on dates, and yeah, he had. He was at least *trying.* To move on. To prove himself wrong and find someone else that kept his attention for longer than a solid five minutes. They didn’t. the dinners were fine, conversation was passable, and some people weren’t that bad looking.

But compared to this sight in front of him? Compared to this scarred god, angel-wide eyes and pink cheeks attached to the body of a warrior? He doesn’t think he’ll ever feel the way he feels when he looks at Izuku. No one can measure up. No one ever stood a chance.

“Slow, Izuku. You’re fuckin’ huge. I need a second to adjust,” Katsuki admits. Not that the sex with Zero was bad, necessarily, but what made it good for Katsuki was that he wanted it to hurt, he wanted it to be more unpleasant than pleasant, he wanted to feel like someone beat the shit out of him after. This is different in a way he can’t truly put his finger on. He doesn’t want tender – that’s not in him, it never has been – but he doesn’t want it to hurt, either. For either one of them.

Izuku nods shortly in return, breathing so fast and so hard Katsuki is temporarily worried the other might pass out.

Katsuki sees stars in front of his eyes the second that thick cockhead penetrates his rim.

He refuses to close his eyes, addicted to the way that cherubic face morphs with the minute thrusts. He looks like he’s in so much goddamn pain, advancing so obediently slowly. Beads of sweat are collecting on his forehead, soaking those pretty curls, making them cling to his face. He’s chewing through his lip, mumbling something under his breath, and Katsuki’s heart feels like it might just explode.

He surprises himself as the smell of smoke emanates from his covers. He lets go of them quickly, eyes darting back to Izuku’s, just as surprised as him.

Even if the fucking fire alarm was tripped, even if this entire goddamn room was filled with smoke, Katsuki wouldn’t stop this. They’ve been careening towards this inevitable connection their entire lives, even when he didn’t want to believe it. His skin, his breath, his hand, his legs, his cock, his desire, everything, *everything* is Katsuki’s. And all that is Katsuki’s is his, too. That’s how it was always supposed to be.

“Ah, um.” Katsuki comes back to reality. His brain is buzzing like he’s fucking broken a beehive in the damn thing, his legs are numb, and he’s inexplicably *full.* Izuku’s massive thighs are shaking against his with the effort of staying still, and his face is scrunched up into something so fucking ugly Katsuki wants to laugh. The (not so) little nerd looks like he’s about to cry, front teeth digging into his front lip.

He’s the most beautiful fucking thing he’s ever seen.

“Move, idiot,” Katsuki whispers. It’s enough to get the other to open his eyes widely, to remember where the hell he is, before he slides out.

And shit, what the *fuck.* He’s pretty sure that something coming out of his ass isn’t supposed to feel like *this,* like someone is rubbing against the tip of his dick with a ribbed dildo. It sincerely feels fucking amazing, and he doesn’t know if it’s just his brain trying to rewire itself, but shit if he doesn’t nearly cry at the sensation.

Izuku is much, much worse for wear. On the first thrust his one good elbow gives out, and he lands straight on Katsuki’s torso, shaking hands trying to gain traction on Katsuki’s bedsheets. He gets enough to anchor his pelvis in just the right way to keep his thrusts short and sweet, but close enough that Katsuki can reach the other with his mouth.

He wraps his arms around the other’s sweaty neck, licking behind his ear, up his neck, reveling in the salt against his tongue. He’s going crazy. He’s going crazy. Izuku tastes to goddamn good, the scent of his sweat, the taste of his spit, that cock claiming him. All the neurons in his brain are fried and all he knows, all he wants, all he feels is Izuku.

Everything, inside and outside, is green. Just green.

Izuku kisses frantically, against his ear, his jaw, and when their lips meet he moans hopelessly into his mouth, wantonly like he doesn't know what to do with himself, sweaty curls hitting Katsuki in the face.

"Ka- Kacchan, oh my god, oh my god – " he groans, bucking his hips, fucking into Katsuki too tantalizingly slowly, but the sweat between their stomachs trapping Katsuki's dick between the two is just on the right side on painful – enough pressure to make him feel like he's going insane, but not enough to end his misery.

Katsuki's wanted to do this for forever. So he takes his hand, wraps it within the other's curls, down to the very root, and *pulls*.

"AHH!" The high pitched moan that escapes the huge man on top of him makes Katsuki chortle, stomach flexing, body thrumming with power. He pulls again, and Izuku's head arches back revealing his beautiful neck. Katsuki latches on, sucking harshly, lapping up each salty bead of sweat, lips feeling that hummingbird pulse, feeling it transcend into himself.

He pulls back, leaving his body chilled with the winter air cooling their mutual sweat, eyes hooded and staring at his face as his pelvis starts to make more elegant, more calculated arcs.

There's something electric behind his eyes, and Katsuki feels the humidity pick up in the air again, like a storm is forming in this bedroom. Maybe it really *is* the Quirk. Remnants of One for All that Izuku is accessing, making his bed frame rattle, making his eyes glow that terrifying green.

He's losing his mind. The warmth in his abdomen is too full, overflowing, spreading into his fingertips, into his spine, into his toes. White light is everywhere, and the fact he hasn't blinded them both is fucking shocking.

"Shit, *please* –" he asks. It's not like him, but he doesn't have to ask for what, because Izuku's hand is on his cock, his torso and hips showing their perfect muscles as they rock repeatedly into Katsuki, hand stroking his cock like stroking the cheek of a lover, and weaker men have cum from less, so forgive Katsuki for nearly biting his tongue in half, shutting his eyes and arching his back halfway out the bed as his seed spills all over that scarred fist.

He's suddenly empty, and panic shoots through Katsuki's psyche, the post-orgasm high marred by that sudden feeling of *nothing* inside him until he watches, breathlessly, as Izuku pulls out and quickly jerks himself off all over Katsuki's stomach.

Then there's silence. The only sound is their ragged breaths, competing for which one can breathe faster. Izuku is trembling all over, like the exertion might have been too much, and a part of Katsuki sort of hopes the other collapses on top of him, weak and sad and Quirkless.

He doesn't. Instead, illuminated by the light from the living room like some living deity, he hovers over Katsuki with the sweat running down his pecks, sliding into the line of his abdominals and disappearing into his pubic hair may or may not make Katsuki want to do something gross. Like stick his entire face into that bush.

"You gonna get me some shit to clean up, or you gonna fucking stare?!" Katsuki puts a little bite into the statement to get Izuku out of his own head, not feeling mad at all. Some crazy part of his brain kind of wants to marinate in Izuku's and his own cum. Luckily, Izuku is a perfect gentleman, and he wipes his chest with a wad of toilet paper, sporting an apologetic cheesy smile the whole fucking time.

Katsuki's heart lunges against his ribcage and he clears his throat, fighting down the urge to hug the other, coax him into bed and fucking… *cuddle*...for the foreseeable future.

"I'm hungry as shit, nerd. Too late to cook. Let's order takeout."

Izuku's eyes open slightly wider and he scratches the side of his face. That poor, sad half-cut tomato, sitting on Katsuki's cutting board. It was a noble sacrifice, at least.

Katsuki pulls on boxers and nothing else, walking out to the living room, making a quick call to his favorite place before sitting down. He hears the shower running, smiling slightly. The second time Izuku's used this shower. The second time he'll be sleeping in his bed.

They're making a life together. Izuku is making his life here, and he fits right in, and Katsuki is going to do everything in his goddamn power to make him happy.

Izuku comes back out, wrapped in nothing but a bedsheet and sits down on the couch to dig into the meal. Katsuki turns on something, keeps going until he finds something he thinks Izuku will enjoy. An old All Might movie.

"…Do you think he regrets it?" Izuku asks after a prolonged silence, and Katsuki tilts his head towards Izuku.

"What, nerd?"

"…That he gave it to me.

"He's fucking proud of you. He doesn't regret a single fucking thing. Can't say I agree with him."

Somebody else could have carried that burden. Someone else could have disappeared for four years. Someone else could have suffered. It didn't have to be Izuku.

But even Katsuki knows that's not true.

It had to be him.

"…I think I finally understand how he felt when he lost it – when he gave it up, for us. I feel like my whole purpose has just been ripped out from under me. I don't know what to do."

Katsuki remembers Camie's words. That purpose can't be found in a person – and yet a part of him wants the other to find it in him. In this apartment, in this city, in this world. He wants him to be okay, but can't expect him to be. Not after everything.

He remembers how it felt to be standing outside that courtroom, the last four years of his life – and not much of a goddamn life it was, but it was his – when his very blood ran at the single purpose of 'Find Deku', but Deku was found, and he was home, and Katsuki's suddenly never felt so fucking lost. He remembers Inko, who hasn't existed outside the role of devastated mother for fuck knows how long that she wasn't sure who she was outside that. He remembers how stuck they have all become in prisons of their own volition. And Izuku's there, too.

Katsuki stands, walking to where he knows the other's left his duffel bag. He digs around until his fingers grip that final notebook; and he takes it out, making sure that he has everything else in his hand. He goes back to the couch, handing the thing back to Izuku, who looks up at him with wide eyes.

“This is who you are. This is who you were before the Quirk. Would you tell that shitty four year old that he doesn’t have any value as a person ‘cause he’s Quirkless? That he can’t be a hero, just because he’s Quirkless?”

Izuku’s mouth drops open as he takes the notebook, gingerly feeling it between his fingertips.

“I know you wouldn’t. You still value that part of yourself. You wouldn’t have brought this shit with you if you didn’t. You’re still that person. You can still be the person you wanted to be.”

Izuku laughs slightly, resting his chin in his hand. He glances to Katsuki, a smile so soft on his face that he feels his stomach invert on itself.

It's stuff like this that makes his heart feel like it’s going to break free of his ribcage. The physicality of it is easy. They always fucked like they fought, and turning one into the other was like walking on the other edge of a very thin tightrope. The talking, these looks, the sheer affection dripping off the other, looking at Katsuki like he’s so much more than he could ever be, *this* is the difficult part.

And every instinct in him wants to push it away, brush it off, protect himself; although, he knows it’s too late. It’s always been too late. He probably never had a chance, no matter how much he tried to trick himself.

“I never expected you to be the one giving me pep-talks about being Quirkless,” Izuku finally sighs out, and Katsuki just rolls his eyes.

“If you’re gonna moan about the unexpected, then look the fuck around.” Katsuki gestures at the – well, everything. At them both half-naked on his couch, in Hiroshima, having just fucked like they have a score to settle. And, maybe they do. Maybe they’ll be settling it for the foreseeable future.

Izuku leans back further into the couch, still smiling. He reaches his hand out. Katsuki pretends his cheeks don’t flush as he, despite how goddamn embarrassing it is, meets the other’s palm with his own. They sit there, staring straight ahead, just the sensation of their hands touching speaking volumes, playing a goddamn symphony in this tiny apartment.

“You’re… you’re the only person I feel like I can be myself around.”

“You’ve never been anything but yourself around me.”

When he was Deku. When he was Zero. And now, this beautiful, fucked up Frankenstein amalgamation of them plus so much more. Izuku. His Izuku. The truth.

“…That a good thing?” he asks, hopefully, casting those mesmerizing eyes in Katsuki’s direction. Katsuki just shakes his head.

“…Sometimes. Other times, you drive me crazy.”

“It’s not too bad, you know? To be crazy.”

Katsuki is apt to agree.

They climb into bed for the second time, naturally, filling like they were molded for one another. Deliriously, Katsuki thinks that he could get used to this.

“Where are we going?” Izuku is wiping the sleep from his eyes, shuddering as they walk along the sidewalk. Katsuki took his lunch break to grab him, laying on the couch hopelessly staring at the television, looking bored out of his mind. He hopes that the package arrives a little later – anything to keep the other busy, anything to keep him from leaving – anyway. Anyway.

“You’ll find out, nerd. Here’s the place.”

It’s an unassuming building with tinted windows, a regular office building in an industrial part of town. He rings the doorbell.

“…Who is it?”

“Bakugou. We talked on the phone,” Katsuki bites out, glancing at the time on his phone.

“R-right. I’ll buzz you in. Third floor.” The voice states. The door unlocks and Izuku and Katsuki exchange looks as they walk inside. The office building is fairly nice inside, clean carpets, good lighting, a couple of plants throughout the lobby. They press the elevator button – the third floor appears to be locked, but as they step inside, the elevator starts to move on its own.

The doors open to what appears to be a warehouse. A guy with big black curls, large goggles, adorned in some steampunk bullshit, fairly young looking, runs up to them, wiping motor-oil covered hands against a white lab-coat.

“Pleasure to meet you, Dynamight, Mirko speaks highly…of……you…….” The man’s voice trails off as he stares at Izuku, eyes comically wide behind his thick rimmed glasses. It takes him too long to pick up his jaw off the floor, panicked eyes oscillating between Katsuki, then Izuku, then Katsuki again.

“…Er. Oh. Oh my *god.* You aren’t. Are you? You’re – “

Izuku has the audacity to flush. He ducks his head, nodding slightly.

“This gonna be a problem?” Katsuki rasps out, finding himself involuntarily stepping in front of Izuku – ironic as it is, considering the other is taller and wider than him and, as he keeps demonstrating, able to take care of himself.

“Not at ALL! I’m a HUGE fan! Well, er, not a fan, necessarily, that would be weird, Heroes aren’t celebrities – “

Izuku raises his head, eyebrows furrowed at the word Hero, and Katsuki can’t help but feel some sliver of elation at the slight glimmer in his eyes.

“I just – what happened to you was terrible! I can’t believe they put you in Tartarus! Oh, I just have to ask – how was it?! Do they torture people? Can you hear the screams of villains all night?! My parents always told me horror stories about that place, to keep me from doing stupid stuff, haha, but – but man! You’re unbelievable! I love your work! You’re super cool!”

“Fine, fine, fanboy, jerk off to him later. We’re here to see if you can make a prosthetic for him.”

Izuku and this new guy turn their heads towards Katsuki – the former carrying a look of confusion, the latter pure elation.

“It would be an honor! Oh my god – prosthetic for Hero Deku – I’m going to actually cry. Here! Here! Let me show you some prototypes!”

The guy grabs Izuku's hand, nearly hopping away. Izuku gives Katsuki a distressed glance as he gets pulled away. Katsuki smiles slightly, and although it takes more effort than he'd ever admit, he leaves Izuku and returns to work.

When Katsuki gets home, there's a package waiting by his front door. He furrows his brows at it. Izuku should have been able to hear someone knock on his door and bring it in… unless.

Katsuki's hands shake against his will as he unlocks the front door to an empty apartment.

He turns on the lights, silence crushing into his chest like a goddamn semi-truck. His steps are short, tentative, hair standing on end. His brain is screaming, screaming and screaming. He can't have. He didn't leave. He wouldn't have done that to him. He wouldn't –

Why not? Doesn't he always leave? You think you'd stop making the same mistake over and over again. You think you'd learn. Izuku Midoriya always leaves. That's who he is.

"Fuck you," Katsuki says to the hallucination, surprised at how loud his own voice sounds in his own apartment. He feels that tepid breath on the back of his neck; so rare in these past few months, of course its triggered by Izuku. A part of him can't help but feel bitter.

The person he needs and the person who hurts him are one and the same, and Katsuki can't do anything about it.

Except to fight these demons. Except to grow. To move on. To know that the ghost is a liar, because it's Izuku. Because he – he's not…. He wouldn't. Not anymore.

He walks around, not sure how to stay still, until he reaches his bookshelf.

On it, notebook number 13. The All Might card. Kota's letter. All proudly displayed. The most important parts of Izuku's life.

His eyes burn.

He didn't go.

He showed him that he wasn't leaving. He traces his fingers against that laminated All Might card. He wants to bring his own out, too, one he's been hiding with all his other shit for years. He didn't really think of displaying anything here. No photos, no trophies, no treasured things. But Izuku having done it – making it his *home?*

Katsuki wipes at his eyes as the door unlocks behind him, a grinning Izuku holding rolls and rolls of paper under his armpits.

"Ah, Kacchan! I'm so sorry I got home so late! We got really carried away at Nishida-san's lab! He went to Shiketsu, apparently, and was a year behind us in school? He's got some really cool ideas! We've been sketching up some prototypes together! I'm going to do some research and – "

Home.

Katsuki walks straight up to him, grabbing the other's cold cheeks in his hands and pressing his lips to Izuku's. All the stammering disappears and his arms grow weak, the sound of bunch of parcels hitting the ground the only other thing in the apartment.

“Fuckin’ nerd,” Katsuki whispers with warm breath against the other’s nose, enjoying the way his breath hitches at the motion.

“You’re coming with me to the gym tomorrow. Before you hang out with your nerd buddy.” Katsuki states, and Izuku raises his eyebrows.

“What? How come?”

Katsuki glances back to the letter. To the All might trading card. To that waterlogged notebook. Hero Analysis for the Future. And the boy in front of him has so much more future left to live.

“You’ve got just over four years until your probation is over, right?” Katsuki grins at Izuku, and the other’s confused expression slowly morphs into one of cautious wonderment.

“Wait…You don’t… Kacchan, you can’t be…”

“Why not? Don’t tell me you’re giving up already, nerd.”

The smile that Izuku gives Katsuki is nearly blinding. That annoying determined look in his eyes, the way he stands a little straighter, the way he fucking *shines*. He’s never going to get tired of it.

“Never.”

Chapter End Notes

Izuku, After the Heavy Religious Imagery Rebirth Shower Scene, Horny Out of His Mind:



Mirko, Baldest Bitch in the World, after Katsuki Doesn't Ask Her for Her Waxer's Information



There's a couple of landmarks we passed last chapter that I forgot to mention!
1.) I've officially been writing for BNHA for over two years. Intersecting Lines came out 5/20/2020 but I started it 3/2020 so...wow.
2.) Zero Sum has, as of last chapter, officially surpassed the word count of Battle of the Bands, making it the LONGEST THING I'VE EVER WRITTEN. GIRL HELP
3.) Zero Sum also has the most subscribers out of all my stories! Whats up besties its me, in your emails, on purpose. But seriously, thank y'all. I realize this story isn't for everyone, but I'm grateful that there's a few of you who were willing to go on this journey with me and have stuck around for this long. Seriously, I love you guys so much. It means more than you know.

I realize this chapter could have been stretched out to two - but I'm not personally a huge 'slice of life' person, and get bored with stories after the conflict is resolved. Hopefully everything will be wrapped up in at least a semi-satisfying manner with chapter 23 - which, I regret to inform y'all, will be the last.

(This is... the first time in the past two years I'll be finishing a story without having already started on another project. If someone wants to beam me an idea that will make me insane for the foreseeable future, it will be highly appreciated lmao)

Chapter 23

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The scenery passes by in a blur as Katsuki stares out the window with an almost dogged intention. With enough concentration, the anxious voices from the kids on the bus fade into the background like television static.

He's listened to this same shit for weeks now, but now that the day has finally come, the tension in the air is palpable. They try to joke and tease and goad each other on but he damn well knows that they're all terrified.

He'd never admit this to anyone, but he's just as nervous as the kids. Maybe more so.

Despite the airs he's putting on for his class, he hasn't felt this frazzled in fuck knows how long. Each of his muscles is tensed to the point of discomfort, his chest is tight, and his stomach is making a valiant effort in digesting itself.

He couldn't even stomach his breakfast – despite the fact that he went through all the fuckin' effort to wake up extra early and make it.

They're his, and if he taught them anything at all, each and every one of them should pass. If they don't, that reflects badly on *him,* and fuck him if his first year as a homeroom teacher doesn't go down in U.A. history. 100% Pass Rate. Perfect victory or nothing at all.

Not that it would mean that they aren't good students or adequate heroes. *He* failed the provisional licensing exam – a fact he's mentioned half-a-dozen times to quell his students' imminent panic. But it's different now – they're living in a system that isn't quite so forgiving. Under the new commission laws, the provisional licensing exam is available for students only once they reach their 3rd year of high school. There's no supplemental courses. Their only other option is to try again in six months.

Not a big deal, he reassured them. Except he knows their mentalities, sees the fire in their eyes that make him feel like he's staring face-first at a mirror warped through a goddamn time machine. The idea of falling behind, the idea of being anything lesser than their classmates, the thought of any delay - no matter how small - in becoming a hero is absolutely unacceptable.

Failing the licensing exam broke something in Katsuki. It had to have been that moment, specifically, when sixteen years of bravado - his carefully structured arrogance to hide his insecurities - came tumbling down. And it wasn't just that *he* failed – no. It was that *that damned nerd* succeeded -

Katsuki breathes in deeply through his nose, exhaling through his mouth. He can't help but wring his hands, thumbs digging into the tender muscles along his palms. His thoughts always run back to *him*. They always had, but over the years he's learned to relax into that inevitable turbulent flow.

That's the embarrassing reality of it all. His head should be with his class, but its stuck exactly where it's been since he was three goddamn years old.

Katsuki brushes his hands against his pockets, struggling to swallow down the thick glob of saliva that seems to have made a permanent home in the back of his throat.

The bus jolts to a stop and the students, previously rattling on loud enough to induce headaches for every damn day of the oncoming week, hush in a nervous quiet.

Katsuki carefully masks his face, crossing his arms so the kids don't see his trembling fingers and palms wet with sweat, before standing up.

"Okay, little shits, listen up. I expect each and every one of you fuckers to pass. Don't embarrass me out there."

He signals for the driver to open the door and categorically glares at each and every single one of the students as they pass by him. They all beam at him unapologetically with their wide eyes and nervous smiles and some even playfully tap him on his shoulder.

He grits his teeth.

It didn't take very long for him to stop being scary to them – he's still not fucking sure if that's a good or bad thing.

He follows them out into the throng of people gathered outside the arena doors. It's a larger crowd than he remembers seeing last year – the usual groups of seniors from various hero schools around the country, but an increasing proportion of civilians as well.

It's still considered to be a somewhat of a controversial move among the seasoned heroes.

Understandably so.

The country went from the mindset of 'only the elite few, with the right education, pedigree, and Quirks can be heroes' to 'anyone can be a hero.'

Anyone can take the provisional licensing exam.

There's just two basic requirements. One – minimum age of 18 (or senior in an accredited Hero school.) And Two – No active warrants within the country of Japan.

Katsuki stands in the crowd, searching the crowd for anyone familiar, only vaguely aware of his kids chattering amongst themselves, sometimes saying non-sensical shit in Katsuki's direction to which he tries to grunt in response.

"Ah! Young Bakugou!"

Shit. Not today, Katsuki thinks as he turns to the pair of hollowed-out eyes, somehow having found Katsuki in the crowd before Katsuki found him. He gives his former homeroom teacher a tight smile that he hopes screams *Fuck off.* Yagi doesn't seem to notice his thousand-yard stare as he approaches him, waving his hand joyfully.

"Ah, Yagi-sensei! What are you doing here?!"

"Just here to cheer on my favorite class! Go get 'em, 3A!" Yagi raises his fist in the air, sleeves of his horrible giant yellow suit falling back nearly to the elbows. The kids don't seem to be bothered, all pumping their fists into the air in concert, cheering and high fiving their former professor as he, very intentionally, nears Katsuki.

3A is not his favorite class and they're not the reason that Yagi came all the way out here. Katsuki and Yagi both know it – but for the sake of the kids, Katsuki says nothing.

Katsuki doesn't know what to do with his hands. He keeps them crossed, then puts them in his pockets, then put them behind his back. He scowls, hoping that somehow his display of displeasure will force the other man to leave – but no such luck. Toshinori Yagi claps a large bony hand on each shoulder and actually pulls Katsuki towards him in an awkward (yet thankfully short) hug.

"How are you feeling, Young Bakugou?" Yagi asks, glint in his eyes a little too-knowing for Katsuki's taste. Katsuki shrugs his shoulders, shoving his hands back into his pockets.

"Fine! Just fuckin' peachy!" Katsuki's voice is louder than he intends it to be, earning a couple of curious looks from his students. He bares his teeth at them and they laugh. They *laugh!*

Seriously, they need their asses handed back to them on a platter when they get back to campus. These little shits are getting a little *too* comfortable, and -

"Hm," Yagi hums. He turns towards the crowd, scanning the heads briefly before turning back to Katsuki. "I haven't seen Young Midoriya yet. I assumed he'd be with you."

Katsuki feels his cheeks turn pink as he stares at the ground.

"Don't assume shit, then." Katsuki retorts. "… I'm here as a teacher today. That's it."

Except he knows the only pass or fail that matters doesn't belong to a single student in his class.

A bell chimes from the stadium entrance, thankfully ending the conversation. Katsuki, Yagi, and every other hopeful hero turns toward the noise.

"Hero candidates, please enter through the double doors to begin the written portion of the provisional hero licensing exam. You have two hours to complete your exam. Instructors, please enter through the side doors to make your way into the observation decks."

Katsuki exchanges a look with Yagi before turning back to his students.

"Give 'em hell," Katsuki states, completely serious, to the twenty pairs of anxious eyes fixed on him. It's the best pep talk they're going to get from him and they know it. Twenty students all nod back, faces fixed in determination as they blend with the crowd to enter the stadium.

"Let's grab our seats, shall we?" Yagi's voice returns Katsuki back to reality and he follows his former teacher up several sets of stairs, respectfully waiting as Yagi uses one hand to hold on to the railing, the second to use his cane as he ascends step by step. Katsuki's hands hover behind him, just out of sight. The second Yagi turns around, he hides them back in his pocket as if nothing ever happened.

Toshinori Yagi is aging. It's more and more obvious each time he sees him. His movements are more stiff, increasingly sluggish. His thick blonde hair is now peppered with a few greys – nearly indiscernible except the way they catch the sunlight. He's just past middle aged, but for a former hero, he's fucking geriatric. Retirement – not just from hero work, but from teaching too – has been a topic of conversation more and more frequently over the past few years.

No one was surprised when Katsuki took over his homeroom class.

It's just not the way he thought he'd carry on All Might's legacy.

Nothing's really turned out the way he thought it would.

Who is a hero when there are no more monsters? Who is a soldier when there's no more war? You can say that there will always be monsters, there will always be war, there is not a world without conflict and thus, there must always be those that face it. There will always be an altar upon which to lay his carcass, there will always be a cause just enough to deserve his life, there will always be a reason to die –

There was a time that Katsuki felt that his life had to be used as penance. For existing, for being born with this fire in his hands, for the acid on his tongue, for the lives he's trampled over to reach the top.

And there was a time that Katsuki wanted an excuse – any reason, any at all – to draw his final breath, and fuck did he want his sacrifice to at least do some good, because he was so so tired and his previous ideals just weren't enough anymore.

The goal was to die as a legend – a legend in a story he no longer believed in.

He never thought he'd end up here – and yet, every path in his life had always lead back to this spot. In the stands. Next to the man he's surpassed in each way that matters.

Because that's what he learned.

He learned what matters.

And it wasn't rankings, it wasn't praise, it wasn't pride.

It was something so, so simple. The same thing millions of men have fallen to before. Katsuki never thought he'd be one of them, but. Life is full of surprises like that.

Katsuki and Yagi eventually find their way to a section of mostly-empty stadium seats. Yagi takes the seat closest to the stairs and Katsuki takes the seat two over. Close enough that they can hear each other speak, distant enough that Yagi can't see Katsuki's trembling hands.

Katsuki props his feet against the back of the seat in front of him. He crosses his arms once more, watching the volunteers hand digital tablets to the examinees, each of them proceeding to sit down at what appears to be spaced out makeshift classroom desks (all of which suspiciously look to be made of grass.)

It's there that he spots him. That head of green hair, pen tucked behind his ear, carrying a giant yellow backpack stuffed so full the clasps barely close, he finds a spot in the very corner of the stadium and, focused and single minded, gets to work.

Katsuki feels something in his chest unfurl at the sight of him.

"This is quite a bit different from when you two first took this exam," Yagi comments.

"Don't remind me," Katsuki sinks further into his chair, keeping his eyes focused on Izuku.

He doesn't know how he's going to spent two hours staring at a green head of hair that he can barely see from the distance (not to mention he essentially blends into the grassy background) and *not* talk to Yagi, but here he is. There's not even anything or anyone else around to distract them. They're almost the only spectators in the stadium – most other instructors were likely smart enough to do other shit during the two hour written portion.

But Katsuki couldn't fathom of not being here, even for this.

Yagi hesitates, clearly mulling something over before he speaks again.

"…You must be nervous."

"What's there to be nervous about?" Katsuki snaps back, too quick and defensive, earning him raised eyebrows and a subtle cough.

Izuku, staying up all night, designs scattered over his desk, cheek smeared in pencil lead, drool collecting on the papers. The hours in the gym, sparring with one another, that grin on Izuku's face as sweat sticks his hair to his face, his shirt to his chest. The endless quizzing, the nervous rambling, the new notebooks piling up in his bedroom.

The way his eyes shone when he found out he could take this exam. The way he almost looked like his old self. Just brimming with that hopeless, naïve optimism. Just the barest hint of a spark that Katsuki couldn't help but stoke into a rip-roaring flame.

He's good at that, apparently.

"You shouldn't worry so much about Young Midoriya, Young Bakugou. He's certain to pass."

Katsuki leans forward, ruffling his own hair as he watches Izuku press something on the virtual screen in front of him. Face concentrated. Eyes serious. The glint of his prosthetic visible past his sleeve, reflecting the sun.

"… I'm not worried about him not passing."

The implication of those words hangs heavily between them.

Katsuki knows that isn't fair. This is Izuku's dream. He deserves a second chance to become the hero he always wanted to be. He wants him to be happy – and this would make him happy. Katsuki knows that. He *knows.*

But he likes their life the way it is. He likes Izuku always within his reach. He likes him *safe.* And now that he's started to make the transition of taking on less hero work and doing more teaching, he wanted… he doesn't know. A quiet life together. Lazily sharing orange slices with the window open, arms and legs entangled on the couch, nowhere to be and nothing to do. No new wounds that need stitching, broken bones that need setting, nightmares that need quelling.

Let the others fight the monsters – they've faced their battles and they deserve this hard-won peace.

But all that is nothing but a fantasy. That's not the life either one of them signed up for. That's not the life he expected when he chose Izuku, or when Izuku chose him.

Maybe he's getting sentimental in his old age.

You're twenty-six! His brain protests, although his back and joints would beg to differ.

"…With his criminal background, he may have some difficulty finding work," Yagi says, less with concern and more with the intention to comfort. Katsuki bristles at that.

"*Someone's* going to hire the nerd." Katsuki hesitates. While many of their former classmates are working outside the country, there's still plenty of agencies in Tokyo that employ their friends. One of them would surely put in a good word for Izuku.

Katsuki bites into his lip.

Maybe.

"…Todoroki and Uraraka still out of the country?" Katsuki knows the answer, but he still asks aloud.

Yagi nods his head slowly.

"Yes. But it does seem that they've narrowed in on a potential hideout for Dabi and Toga. I'm hopeful they'll be returning soon."

"Yeah, they told Izuku the same shit like six months ago."

"They've been successfully hiding for nearly ten years, Young Bakugou. These things don't happen overnight."

Katsuki sighs. There's a lot he can say about that – about how they shouldn't have lost sight of their purpose, how they shouldn't have just moved on, how they should have looked for Izuku and the League like Katsuki had – but.

But it took more than retrospective shame to change things for them.

It took Izuku coming back. And Katsuki hates it – how can a person who had been missing for four years make such a sudden impact on people's lives? But it's a rhetorical question, because he changed everything for Katsuki. To think that he's the only one that Izuku's existence had a stranglehold on is simply irresponsible.

Something about him coming back – something about him developing a relationship with Shigaraki in prison, about saving him, about forgiving him – seems to have struck a chord in the two. Like his own selflessness had reminded them that there are still people that they wanted to save.

It was their burden to bear and their burden to ignore. There's good and bad in that - about remembering what it was like to be sixteen again. Izuku brought them there – reminded them of that version of themselves. Reminded them of their immaturity and their naivete. But also reminded them of their dreams, their idealism, their belief in others.

Izuku, the pillar of forgiveness, was fast friends with Todoroki within weeks of his move to Hiroshima. His frustration and jealously was forgotten (or, at least, put aside) comically fast. Himself and Todoroki were still slowly working on building up that brittle bridge that they've both burned.

Katsuki doesn't necessarily want to – avoidance has worked well for him thus far – but it's important to Izuku, so he has to at least fucking *try.*

It's disgusting how much Izuku affects Katsuki. Katsuki finds his lips curling as he looks at the other, furiously pressing something onto the virtual screen. Even from here, he can see his lips moving, mouth chewing on the defenseless pen that he had behind his ear, furrowing his curls into further disarray as he rapidly reads through each question.

And, just as fast as he got in there, he shuts down his screen, looks around. Then he stands – the first in the entire stadium – and returns his computer to the volunteer.

"Wow – done already."

"…He's been a goddamn nerd his whole life. A test on hero law ain't exactly hard for him," Katsuki finds himself smiling. Especially considering Izuku has hands-on experience with hero laws. Specifically breaking them.

His eyes roam back over to his students. The other twenty people he's keeping an eye on are clearly not faring as well.

"…Are you going to go and try to find him? "

Katsuki's face flattens.

"No. I'd just make him more nervous. He's in the zone right now – he's gotta stay there."

As the two hours come to an end, the stadium screen comes to life with ID numbers of those that have passed. They're all anonymous, so Katsuki doesn't know which one is Izuku's and which ones belong to his students. The only way he'll know is if they pass back through those double doors onto the next portion of the exam.

He picks at his nails, too aware of Yagi staring at him expectantly, looking for all the world like he wants to say something.

The amount of people that walk back in through must be less than half. To his endless relief, he sees all twenty of his students walk together as a group through the doors.

The fact that there's also a tall hair of green hair, facing forward like he's too nervous to interact with a single other person, doesn't hurt either.

Other teachers start to trickle into the stadium. Katsuki doesn't recognize many of them. He was introduced to a few when he shadowed Yagi the year before, but fuck him if he remembers any of their names. He's probably the youngest instructor in the stadium. Most of his classmates – save for Yaoyorozu and Iida – are still doing hero work, although Katsuki had heard whispers of Aizawa planning to recruit Shinsou back to U.A. in the next coming year or two.

"Congratulations to those who have passed the written exam!" The announcer starts, and the kids whoop loudly. The adults in the audience – Izuku included – stare stone-faced ahead.

The announcer continues.

"Our first physical challenge today is Hide and Seek."

Katsuki rolls his eyes. "Fuckin' child's play. Seriously?"

The grass from the ground that previously made up the desks in the arena grows to enormous proportions, obscuring the sky, complex scaffolding of skyscrapers, bridges, caves separating all the test-takers in a maze of green. Katsuki stands out of reflex, trying to get a better look into the green city that spreads out below him.

The shitty nerd blends nearly seamlessly into the environment – Katsuki can't find him and he can feel his heart start to pound as his eyes frantically search the field.

"…If you are captured, you are 'out.' You do not move on to the next part of the test."

"An evasion test rather than a combat-based test. That's an interesting choice - " Yagi comments.

Interesting if you're a coward, Katsuki wants to say, but instead focuses his attention of scouting the field. He doesn't find Izuku, but does find several groups of his own students, banded together, looking around wildly.

"There are ten minutes on the clock. Your time starts – NOW."

The large clock over the stadium starts to count down, each second a rhythmic, repetitive beeping sound. At the same time, Katsuki notices multiple forms materializing out of the grass that makes up the makeshift city – humanoid monsters, hundreds, certainly more than there are participants, starting to move throughout the field. Their vine-like arms spread in front of them, touching the surfaces of the stadium.

The humanoids wander aimlessly – until a flash of light and rumble of the ground emanates from the other end of the city. The humanoids slowly start to amble in the general direction of the disturbance, fusing then emerging from grassy walls and obstacles.

"Ah, I see," Yagi talks more to himself than Katsuki, rubbing his chin thoughtfully.

Katsuki narrows his eyes. He can't see any of the kids. No signs of any of their Quirks either.

As if reading his mind, the screens in the center of the stadium come to life – multiple different angles, different parts of this makeshift city projected in high definition.

Yagi just continues talking, not seeming to give a shit if Katsuki is listening or not. "The 'Seekers' are made from the same material as the pseudo-city itself. While the 'Seekers' don't appear to have eyes or ears, I'm sure the sensation of an individual running or fighting alerts them of the participant's location. It focuses on the participant's using their best judgement – when is it best to run and hide, and when is it best to fight?"

Katsuki glowers. The cameras make that fact obvious – everyone in the audience catches on instantly but the examinees don't have that same privilege. Some are fighting wildly, recklessly, seemingly unaware that the harder they struggle, the more humanoids they destroy with flashy displays of their Quirks, the more humanoid creatures spawn and head in their direction. Some simply run.

Katsuki hears a high-pitched noise and looks up to the screen to see a young woman encased in the grass. Her body disappears into the field, vines pulling her underground. An ID number disappears from the board.

A familiar sound makes Katsuki turn his head. The explosion is loud enough to garner the attention of many of the humanoids – a blast and flash of light followed by black smoke, spreading circumferentially in the field.

Katsuki's heart speeds up. Izuku must have figured out the way this Quirk works – low visibility has no impact on them. So why –

The sound of metal and Katsuki can see the grappling hook from his artificial arm fly into the air from inside the smoke, latching onto an arch on a makeshift bridge. Izuku flies through the air, landing on top of the bridge. He grins wildly back at the smokescreen before he starts to run.

The antics earn him his own screen, front and center on top of the stadium. Katsuki's mouth drops open, just slightly, as he watches with rapt attention.

His yellow backpack has transformed into the variable suit of armor that it's been designed to be. The straps latch onto Izuku's back, the inner workings transforming into a jet-pack. The utility belt wrapped around his midsection carries the different attachments to his prosthetic, smoke bombs lining the lateral edges of his belt. Izuku's grappling-hook attachment comes off and he slaps the air-cannon one in succession.

When Katsuki glances back down to the field from which Izuku had just escaped, he sees two or three piles of grass – victims of the humanoid monsters.

It started off as just designing a new prosthetic – one that's comfortable enough for Izuku to wear full time, one that he can use to chop tomatoes in the kitchen, button his own clothes, something with adequate flexibility and dexterity. But Katsuki just *had* to put the idea into Izuku's head – and suddenly he couldn't think of anything else. It came as a surprise to him, really, that Izuku hadn't been trying to design assistive gear since he found out he was Quirkless. After all, many professional heroes have relatively useless Quirks and rely heavily on their assistive devices.

Why not Izuku?

And it was so simple. He had gotten comfortable with mid-air maneuverability, with capture weapons, with utilizing a smoke screen, with the recoil from powerful air blasts. His kicks might no longer be superpowered, but iron soles still pack a punch, and the strength of his legs would render most grown men weak. It only made sense to design equipment that capitalized on Izuku's previous Quirks.

Even now, completely Quirkless, Izuku seems to be the most agile, the most competent on the field.

He keeps to the high ground – and he's not the only one. While Izuku tries to avoid others, Katsuki can see some of the examinees setting up traps for their colleagues – whether it's making noise when anyone is near them, throwing those running with them down to the ground so their colleagues are captured before themselves, each tick of the countdown renders the examinees more ruthless, more desperate.

The last ten seconds are the loudest.

The timer runs out with a loud blare and Katsuki vaguely realized he hasn't paid any attention to his class from the second Izuku appeared on the large screen.

The grass structures dissolve back into a normal field – leaving just over half of those previously present standing. Katsuki's eyes search the remaining individuals on the field. His kids seem to have stuck together – and in a heart pounding few seconds, he realizes that all twenty are still standing.

"Tenacious bunch," Yagi comments with an air of approval in his voice.

Katsuki can only roll his eyes.

"No shit. I'm their teacher, aren't I?"

"…That you are," Yagi agrees.

"Congratulations to those still standing. Unfortunately, there was a second grading criteria on this test. Please turn your attention to the screen."

Another dozen or so IDs disappear, followed by furious outcries from below.

“Those who have been observed to sacrifice others intentionally to secure their own victory have been disqualified from moving forward. That degree of selfishness is not congruent with the hero society that Japan is hoping to build. You are dismissed.”

Heads hung, the two dozen individuals exit the stadium. Katsuki exhales slowly.

His class is still all there. All still in the fight. Thank fuck.

“Examinees, please prepare for the second and final challenge of the provisional licensing exam. All of those who pass will be able to obtain this license – as a reminder, this allows Quirk usage in the setting of an emergency even outside the direct supervision of a licensed hero. The next challenge will start in five minutes. Feel free to grab water or use the facilities during this time.”

Katsuki watches the back of Izuku’s head as he disappears to the washroom, something uncomfortable scratching at the back of his brain at the fact he’s our of Katsuki’s eyesight.

“…You know, I never thought you’d agree to this position. Aizawa, however, seemed quite sure that you’d say ‘yes.’”

“…What?” Katsuki turns back towards Yagi. The man looks distant, soft smile painting his skeletal face like he’s stuck in some kind of memory.

Aizawa, who was certainly sitting in the stands of the other site of the provisional licensing exam, where class 3B was taking the same test, isn’t a small reason as to why Katsuki wants all his students to pass.

So he can rub any failures in the other’s class in his former homeroom teacher’s face.

He never intended to say yes. The words that Aizawa spoke to him after the court case – about how he’d make a good teacher – stuck with him. In moments of boredom, he really thought about it. Turned the idea over in his head. Discussed it with Izuku – who, as always, was more thrilled about the idea than Katsuki ever could be.

You taught me half of what I know without ever intending to, Kacchan! Just think what you could accomplish if you actually tried teaching on purpose?

“I’m not here because of him,” Katsuki finally answers, knowing fully well that’s not what Yagi is implying. “Or you, for that matter,” Katsuki adds.

Yagi only nods knowingly in response.

It took time for Katsuki to be ready to return to Tokyo. There was an ease in the distance – an excuse to avoid aspects of his life he wasn’t ready to tackle. His family. Inko. Todoroki. All Might. His former friends and classmates.

A part of him knew that they were hiding from the world.

Despite all that he had faced, returning to his hometown continued to feel like an insurmountable challenge. Like the final hurdle in whatever journey he’s decided to travel.

Well, not *the* final hurdle. There’s something that Katsuki wants to – no, *needs* to – do. He rubs his hands against his pockets. Something that will probably never stop being terrifying to him.

"…Well. I couldn't think of a better person to take over my position. As always, you have my gratitude, Young Bakugou."

Katsuki feels the back of his neck heat up and he rubs against it, trying to dispel the uncomfortable warmth. Goddamn it – this guy is always so sappy. Always ready to talk about his feelings. He doesn't know what to do with him sometimes.

"Shoulda thought harder," Katsuki retorts. Yagi says nothing in response.

"This next challenge is called 'Rescue.'" The incorporeal announcer starts and the two of them quiet instantly.

The grassy field expands once more; ten thin towers erupt from various parts of the stadium, geometrically appearing to be equidistant from one another. On top of said towers the grass parts to reveal bright orange 'dummies,' plush dolls in the shape of a human. The rest of the field erupts into hundreds of grassy humanoids, the same as in the prior challenge. They amble about, surrounding the towers.

"Your objective is to 'rescue' the victims on top of the towers. This must be accomplished without engaging in combat."

Katsuki narrows his eyes. Wait a minute –

"And as you may have noticed, there are only ten 'victims' to rescue. All those that assemble teams and utilize each of your skills to perform the rescue will count as a 'rescuer.' Either only ten of you pass, or all one hundred can – but only if you work together."

No combat. Several different Quirks used in an attempt to rescue a bright orange dummy at altitude.

"…Are you fucking serious?!" Katsuki feels his hands spark inadvertently and he turns to Yagi, who seems to have reached the same conclusion.

"Ah, Young Yaoyorozu and Young Iida must have had a hand in designing this challenge!" Yagi laughs to himself while Katsuki stands, pacing among the seats, anything to let some of that anger out. What the *actual* fuck! Ever since the two joined the Hero Commission, they've been nothing but annoying little assholes about everything!

Here's a fucking replication of Kamino – one of the worst days of Katsuki's life – *to test your ability to be a hero!* The next time he sees either one of them, it's on *sight* -

"Your time starts *now!*"

Katsuki feels the rant die in the back of his throat. Izuku immediately approaches for his class. Of course he does, because he knows all of their Quirks, and because he's the goddamn king of shitty complex plans.

He sees Izuku huddle with nearly all twenty of them. They talk for longer than they should, dummies disappearing one by one off the podiums at the hands of makeshift teams or individuals that happen to be a little less considerate than Izuku himself.

They split into two teams, Izuku leading one, running to opposite ends of the stadium.

To preventing infighting, probably.

He doesn't know how the hell Izuku's going to pull this off – with ten Quirks, plus his own equipment – it seems like too many cooks in this tiny little kitchen. He can easily blast himself onto that tower and grab the dummy on his own – but of course he insists on helping a bunch of others pass. It's like he's building some kind of silly Quirk-based Rube Goldberg machine – but if anyone can do it, it's that nerd.

Within all that noise, they choose their target.

Three surround the perimeter. The kid with the mole claws starts to dig a trench into the grass, while the kid with the 'blanketing' Quirk uses his weirdly stretchy body to hide as much of the grass from sunlight. The third, the student with the weather changing Quirk, appears to make the weather cloudy and frigid in their small circle.

Katsuki watches the grass humanoids try to come across the trench – but their legs are rooted within the turf, and aren't able to cross. The same humanoids try to materialize from underneath the 'blanketing' Quirk kid; but whether it's the physical act of being smothered, or the sun-less, frigid environment, they aren't able to emerge.

Katsuki raises his eyebrows. Well shit. He figured out how the goddamn Quirk works, after, what? Ten minutes of observation?

The 'enemies' subdued, Katsuki turns his attention to the other eight left over.

He watches the kid with the 'Architect' Quirk draw a square then manifest it, the kid the 'Growing/Shrinking Inanimate Objects' Quirk enlarge the simple 3D square, the kid with the Gum 'Quirk' rub one of the square sides with the sticky pink substance, the kid with the 'Vector' Quirk making a vector on the Square in the general area of the dummy, the kid with the 'Super Strength' Quirk punch the block until it's 'adequately charged,' the 'Psychic' kid float Izuku up so that his shoes stick to the pink gum on top of the box and finally, the weird kid that can transform into inanimate objects becomes a 'parachute' and larches on to Izuku's back.

With a wave of Izuku's hand, he's spring boarded into the air, the box crashing into the tower as Izuku uses his grappling hook arm to ricochet himself to the top of the tower, grabbing on to the orange dummy before the parachute is activated – slowly floating Izuku down.

The whole thing probably took less than three minutes, but there's a moment – just before the timer runs out, just as Izuku wraps his arms around the orange dummy, Katsuki feels like he can see something in him crack. Something about the confident, focused demeanor break apart. He holds that dummy to his chest with an almost suffocating intensity, feet finally touching the ground as the timer rings out.

The kids cheer, surrounding and hugging Izuku – but Izuku keeps holding on to that orange dummy.

"…COMPLETE! The passing IDs are listed above. Congratulations to all. Please collect your Provisional Licenses on your way to the exit."

The line starts to form to obtain the badges, and Katsuki doesn't know what to do with himself, so he simply exists the stadium along with the rest of the spectators, Yagi in tow.

He loiters around outside, close to the bus. Yagi eventually leaves – citing an 'appointment,' promising that he'll call Izuku later to congratulate him.

Katsuki shrugs. He's got other things on his mind. A reminder of a part of his life that he had mostly forgotten about.

He never asked, not really. In Kamino, Izuku isn't the one who held out his hand. Of all the times he had previously, that wasn't one of them. Katsuki figured it was because of his speed – him and Iida made sense to be the base of Kirishima; but knowing Izuku, if they could minimize the quantity of people involved, maximize speed so there's less weight and greater chance of success, just him and Iida would have been enough.

So…why?

"Sensei! Sensei Bakugou!"

"…Wha?"

Katsuki is blindsided by twenty students careening towards him, eyes bright, all smiling, some of them crying. They circle him, yelling one over the other to the point where he can hardly understand what they're saying.

"We did it! We all passed!"

"Thank you so much Sensei!"

"Honestly I don't know if we would have been able to – "

"Where is Deku-san, by the way? I haven't had a chance to thank him – "

Katsuki's ears buzz at the sound of that nickname. Save for the rare times he lets it slip, no one has called Izuku that for quite some time.

Did he… introduce himself as that? To his students?

"Oh, there he is! Deku-san! Deku-san! Please come and meet our sensei! Deku – "

Katsuki turns in the direction his students are yelling, only to see a head of green hair move quicker towards the exit gate, head ducked.

"Let me go, you little assholes – " Katsuki breaks through the crowd, rapidly approaching an Izuku who looks like he's trying to sneak away without talking to him. Katsuki, concerned, grabs at his wrist, turning the other around.

He meets large, watery eyes, and his heart drops.

"…Oh. Kacchan. Um. Hey."

"Don't hey me. What's wrong?"

Izuku tries to pull back, eyes averted to the ground, refusing to meet his. "Nothing. I need to go – "

"…Izuku."

"I would have done anything. To have been the one – " Izuku starts, voice cut off with a tremor. He shakes his head, as if trying to shake those thoughts loose.

“I’m sorry. I’m being silly.” Izuku puts on a fake smile, one that sends panic signals straight up Katsuki’s spinal cord. Izuku continues, eyes skewered shut in fake joy.

“Look! This is all thanks to you!”

He brings the freshly laminated card to Katsuki’s face. The ID picture looks just as miserable as he looks in front of him – and yet. The hero name, in large, block letters, says everything.

D E K U

An overwhelming emotion wells up in the back of Katsuki’s throat, and he tries to speak, but no words come to him.

“…I should go. I’ll see you later – “ Izuku starts, maneuvering out of Katsuki’s grip. He stares after him, almost waiting too long, almost letting him go, almost letting him walk away – almost.

He grabs the other’s wrist, jerking him towards himself. Using Izuku’s surprise, he grips his face with both hands, looking him straight in the eyes, hoping that his expression shows everything he doesn’t know how to say, before he kisses him.

Gently, lingering, in full view of his students and the entire goddamn stadium.

When he pulls back, those starlight-eyes are glimmering with tears.

“Good job, Hero Deku.” Katsuki is surprised his voice doesn’t shake with the statement. Izuku doubles over in a laugh, poorly hiding the shed tears. He bites into his lip, rapidly wiping his face with his sleeve.

“You should go celebrate with your class, Kacchan. Seriously. I’ll see you tonight.”

Katsuki hates to see Izuku walk away like this – he’s clearly not okay, there’s something going on in that nerdy little head of his, and he wants to follow him, but – He turns around. There’s twenty seventeen and eighteen year olds standing outside the bus, all their jaws nearly on the floor (the Gumby fucker’s jaw *literally* on the floor.)

When he turns back to say something to Izuku, he’s already out the gate.

Katsuki rubs the back of his neck, approaching his students.

“…Whoa, do you *know* him!?”

“Sensei, what was that?!”

“OH MY GOD. OH MY GOD. I KNEW IT.”

“I’m going to cry. Oh no. Sensei likes men? I’ll never have a chance…”

“You never had a chance in the first place! Plus, have you seen Deku-san? You kidding?”

“SHUT UP. ALL OF YOU!” Katsuki raises his voice and all the kids instantly quiet down, standing at attention. He rubs the bridge of his nose, shaking his head slightly.

He'll probably have a lot of questions to answer. But now is not the time.

"Congratulations, all of you. You all worked hard and deserve this win. Obviously this was always going to be the expectation, but I'll give it to you just this once. Discuss what you want to eat tonight – it's on me. I'll send it to the dorms. Now get on the fucking bus."

Whatever discussion about Katsuki's love life was escalating stops, and the kids scramble onto the bus, excited voices calling out ideas for the most abhorrent, expensive meals that they can think of. His bank account will surely regret this decision – but. He can't help himself.

They really do deserve this.

Katsuki waves the kids off, finally putting in the order for an exorbitant amount of sushi that definitely chewed at least half-way into his monthly earnings (he might be a U.A. teacher, but he's still a goddamn teacher.) as well as a little something for himself and Izuku and heads home.

Katsuki unlocks the door, placing the bags of groceries on the kitchen counter. The place smells of springtime, light setting across the open windows. It's a fairly spacious two bedroom – one that he and Izuku picked out after nearly two months of arguing. Katsuki liked the large kitchen. Izuku liked the north-facing windows. They both liked the proximity to the train station and the gym. Katsuki didn't like that it was close to his old place, and that the floor plan was nearly identical. Nothing inherently wrong with that – until the dreams and memories came in flashes, indiscernible from reality – until Katsuki found himself waking up panting, grabbing onto Izuku, convinced that this is all still a hallucination. That he's alone. That he'll always, always be alone.

There's too much red-white-and yellow in the interior, Izuku's prized All Might collection 'discreetly' (if you could call it that) hidden in the living room. The blanket draped across the couch. The throw pillows. The kitchen towels. The 'abstract art.' It's fairly standardly decorated otherwise, the only stand out factor the giant drum-set next to the window.

The place is relatively sound proof. Another plus.

The nerdier shit Izuku's hidden away in his studio.

His studio. Katsuki could laugh. In every home Katsuki's had in his adult life, Izuku's had his own place. There's not a single place that Katsuki can go – not even within his own mind – that doesn't have a nook carved away specifically for Izuku.

He keeps the disaster that is his studio behind closed doors, at least. Sketches, sheets of aluminum, welded contraptions that make absolutely no sense. Some collaborative items have been sold to design companies – but most of the shit Izuku invents in there are for his own use. And, it goes without saying, for Katsuki's.

Katsuki unpacks his bags. The movements are automatic – he places the bottle of sake into the freezer, taking out the sushi from the same restaurant he got for the kids.

There's still a weird taste in the back of his mouth – the way they left that stadium, how upset Izuku seemed to be.

He hasn't been able to get out of his head. What got Izuku so shook-up? Kamino isn't a good memory for either one of them. Maybe just the reminder of that day put him in a weird headspace. But that was so many years ago. Everything is different now. He has to know that.

Katsuki will have to remind him if he forgot – like he's apt to do.

Katsuki makes sure everything is ready for this weekend's meal preparation. That has been one of the best parts of transitioning to teaching more than hero work. Every weekend together. Waking up together. Breakfast together. Running together.

This is how they won.

How they obtained something that All Might never did.

For all his self-sacrifice, for all the silent suffering, for all the loss of friends and family and loved ones, Yagi never had this. The implicit trust of another person. The ability to wake up next to the person he loves. The realization that there is more to life – so much more – than heroics. That, in a sense, the most heroic thing one can do is to live. To save yourself. To find that joy.

That's what Sir Nighteye wanted for All Might – but he never listened.

Katsuki puts the kettle on the stove, lost in thought.

He's later than he generally is.

Just as he thinks that, the front door opens, a somewhat flustered appearing Izuku stumbling through the front door.

"I'm home!" he calls out, taking his shoes and jacket off in the genkan, bounding up the stairs like a child on holiday. All traces of the previous odd mood seem to be gone – or, at least, adequately hidden. Katsuki decides to play along.

"I'm so sorry I'm late! I missed the previous train, and – Oh! What is all this?"

Izuku doesn't wait for a response, just sets his eyes on the black ornate boxes sitting on the dining room table.

"Sit," Katsuki orders, ignoring the question. He grabs two small glasses and the sake, placing it in the middle. The kettle hisses its readiness, and he grabs that too, pouring them each a cup of tea. While Izuku gets back into his own head, murmuring something under his breath, eyes wide, Katsuki places a pillow just under where he normally sits and watches him, expectedly.

Izuku scrambles to get down onto the pillow, looking across the table with big, grateful eyes as Katsuki pours him a shot of sake.

"This is so nice – gosh, we haven't had sushi in forever! You must be in such a good mood since all your students passed! How are they - "

"Mmm." Katsuki responds, cutting Izuku off. He opens the box, immediately grabbing for Izuku's favorite just to shut him up.

"Taste this fatty tuna." Katsuki holds out the nigiri in his chopsticks across the table and Izuku leans forward, taking the piece into his mouth. He blushes slightly as he chews, eyes wide with wonderment before he closes them, overjoyed.

"This is so good! Wow, this is so amazing, thank you so much Kacch – "

“Stop praising me, dammit. Just – “ Katsuki shuts his eyes tight, evening his voice. “How’s Shigaraki?”

“Oh!” Izuku leans forward, taking one of the cups of sake and bringing it to his mouth. He flinches at the bitter taste, just barely, before putting it back down.

“He’s doing really well! He wasn’t exactly super excited about me getting my provisional license. He’s still not a big fan of heroes.”

Izuku looks somewhere behind Katsuki, gentle smile on his lips. It’s odd for the other to speak to Shigaraki when Katsuki carries four symmetric scars on his body because of him. But, with time, they learned that Shigaraki has no memory of his life since undergoing the bodily modifications and becoming ‘one’ with All for One. In this reality, he’s still an irritable, whiny teenager who couldn’t wait to get his hands on Izuku the second the latter walked into his prison cell. Katsuki sort of wishes he saw the look on his face when he found out he could no longer use Decay.

Izuku has his theories about it. Many of them compounding on the idea that Decay was originally part of All for One. That it was not Shigaraki’s innate Quirk. That, from the very beginning, this child’s life was manipulated by the demon king. That he never had a choice in any of this. That All for One orchestrated his trauma, his abandonment, his very relationship with this hero society so that he could be used.

Shigaraki understood that all too quickly.

It’s not that Izuku forgave Shigaraki. He simply understood him. Felt responsible for him.

It was because of Izuku that Shigaraki was still alive – and this life was torture for him. To save someone didn’t always mean to ensure that their heart is still beating, that their lungs are still breathing. To save someone, sometimes, means to be there for them to deal with the repercussions of continuing to exist.

“He’s been doing a lot of writing. Bad, angsty poetry. And art. He’s very good at drawing hands.”

Katsuki levels Izuku with a look, who only laughs back, resting his elbow on the table. The lightbulb above them flickers slickly. Katsuki makes a mental note to change it in the morning.

“… How come you’re avoiding talking about it?”

Katsuki feels the alcohol warm his throat as he swallows it down. Izuku’s leaning over, using his organic arm to support him as the prosthetic holds the delicate glass between mechanical fingers.

“… I don’t know, Kacchan. It all feels really weird.” Izuku looks to the ceiling. “Kind of surreal. I don’t know if I was just fooling myself into believing I could do this…”

“What the hell are you talking about? You passed the goddamn exam. Same as everybody else.”

“…That’s not what I’m talking about.” Izuku’s mood, the whole smiley façade, slips. The circles under his eyes look much more prominent, a slurry of complex emotions behind those always-sparkling eyes.

“Talk to me,” Katsuki pushes, leaning forward, leveling the other with his eyes.

Izuku shakes his head.

“It’s stupid. It’s so stupid. We live together. We sleep together. For me to feel this way is just – just – “

“What way?”

“…I don’t know. It just reminds me so much of Kamino… I knew you wouldn’t have taken my hand then, so I didn’t even offer it as an option, because saving you was more important than… than wanting to be the person whose hand you would take. And it made me think of all the times you wouldn’t take my hand. And I guess… I’m still afraid that you still wouldn’t – wouldn’t take it.”

Izuku’s voice is shaking hard, eyes watery, and Katsuki furrows his eyebrows.

Katsuki’s not sure he understands what the hell that it means. Take his hand? When is Katsuki going to have the option to ‘take his hand’ and reject it?

Deflect. Deflect with a joke, because the weight of those words is suddenly too heavy.

“…You’re acting like you’re going to ask for my hand in marriage or some shit.”

The way Izuku blanches instantly sends alarm bells ringing throughout Katsuki’s psyche.

“…Deku.” Katsuki’s voice takes on a lower cadence, a warning, an imploration, anything to get the other man to respond. “Tell me you’re joking.”

He knows he isn’t.

He saw it. When he traveled to Los Angeles for Mina and Camie’s wedding, Izuku could only attend virtually. Through video, he still did the whole gambit – he dressed in a suit, complete with horrible tie that Katsuki wasn’t there to fix, held up his own glass of champagne at the toast, had his own seat at the table. And in a way, Katsuki was grateful that Izuku wasn’t there in person.

Katsuki thinks that if he saw that watery eyed, prison-hardened, prosthetic wearing, vigilante, angel-faced boy leaned into his shoulder, dancing with him under that multi-colored disco ball, watch the brides with those wistful eyes, hold his hand under the table and smile that stupid fucking shy smile in his direction, he wouldn’t be able to maintain his sanity.

How can there be something this large in life that can’t just be earned, can’t be hard fought, can’t be won? How can there be something that can change your entire life that depends on the whim of another person?

Lately, he’s been thinking. A lot. Too much free time, he figures. He thinks about the end. He thinks about how, the last time Izuku disappeared, the last time he nearly died, he went without knowing how Katsuki feels. He’s not so sure he knows how Katsuki feels *now.* They’ve lived together for five years. They eat meals together. They have an apartment together. They fuck regularly.

But does he *know?*

Obviously not. Obviously not, if he can still think that Katsuki wouldn’t – wouldn’t *take his hand.*

What would he do, if the new hero, Deku 2.0, ends up beneath a building? What if his last thoughts on this planet aren’t the assured knowledge that Katsuki loves him? What if he dies still wondering about his place in this world, his importance to those around him, what if he dies with the same regrets that Katsuki has in his heart?

Katsuki has learned to accept his regrets. Learned to live with them. Learned to live with every version of himself. But he'll never forgive himself if he lets the person sitting across from him, looking like he's on the verge of breaking down, live without knowing the truth.

He's kept this thing in his pocket for fuck knows how long. This isn't how he wanted to do it, but.

No fucking time like the present.

He digs it out, and on impulse tosses it towards the other.

"Catch."

Izuku fumbles, placing his palms together as the object bounces off his metallic hand, reflects the light of the singular bulb, then goes back into his organic hand.

"Kacchan, what is this?"

Katsuki says nothing.

Izuku opens his fist.

The ring is a simple malleable silver band. Nothing flashy. Made from flexible material. The fucker's got one hand, but at least his left remains. He'll never hold the right, never take the hand that once reached out to him, but there's a different way for him to reach back. A different way to take his hand. A different way to hold on and never, ever let go.

"…Kacchan?" his voice is three octaves higher, and it would be hilarious if all the blood in Katsuki's body wasn't currently pumping through his ears.

"…What. What is this?"

Well. Now or never, he figures.

He's made up his mind about this long ago. It solidified somewhere between the moment that Izuku showed up outside his door in Hiroshima, to the horrible meals that he'd think up while Katsuki was at work, to waking up with sweaty and sticky because Izuku's a goddamn cuddler (a new development; it took some time for him to touch again, so Katsuki couldn't complain.) to how bright he smiles every time he finds (and buys) an obscure All Might-themed piece of merchandise that he insists is discreet and cool but obviously isn't.

He's always been so angry at Izuku for leaving.

But he's never asked him to stay.

Katsuki walks towards the other, steps intentional, not taking his eyes off Izuku's face.

And, smoothly as he can with his old injuries aching the whole way down, he dips to one knee.

Izuku starts to bawl. Big, fat, ugly tears just *pouring* from a muscled up, six-foot-something provisional hero. Deku 2.0. The love of his fucking life.

Katsuki wouldn't have it any other way.

This is it. The final battle. The last stand. The thing he has been too much of a coward to conquer. The question he's been too afraid to ask.

" Izuku… You never made any goddamn sense to me, you know that? I'm still trying to understand you. I think it's so hard for me because I see the worst of myself in you. And I think you see the worst of yourself in me. And loving that is terrifying. It is for me, and I know it is for you. You show it – you might not know it, but you show it. You show it in the shit you hate about yourself – the nightmares and the scars and your shaking hands. I have them too. You know I have them too. The way you fear things you never used to fear. The way you hesitate when you never used to hesitate. I'm afraid, too. I know that's why you didn't tell me how you really felt. There's so much you still won't admit out loud. There's so much that I can't, either. But I'm trying. I'm trying. Please, just let me try."

Izuku says nothing, body in stasis, so Katsuki takes a deep breath, gathers all the bravado in his body, and continues.

"When you disappeared, I felt like I lost a part of me. And that feeling was too big for me, too much to understand or to express, and just like it began, it was over. You kept me guessing – always guessing, always wondering, always wishing for something I couldn't put a name to – but I'm putting a name to it now. You are – you always have been - my anchor. My point of stability. Before you, I always felt like I was free-falling, but you anchored me, you made these nebulous ideals something *solid,* something tangible, something I could put my hands on. You made me start to understand what dreams are worth dying for, what dreams are worth living for, and because of you and only because of you I was able to keep going. To make a home. To start to understand why I'm still here. All of that is because of you. Not because you saved me physically – and you did, you did, you're always saving me, and I'm always saving you, I fuckin' know, we'll always save each other because that's who we are, but it's more than that. Its more."

"You inspire me, each and every fucking day. You do. To see you *alive,* to see you fighting after having your life ripped away from you, to see you forgive, to see you smile, to see *you* makes me want to believe that there's hope in this goddamn broken world. The person you are makes me want to believe in the future. You're a fucking revelation, Izuku. You've made me find the meaning in every little goddamn thing – in shitty morning breath, in burned coffee, in ugly posters that you won't fucking stop buying. Every moment I live is saturated with beautiful moments of you."

"But it's not just that. I want the ugly too – to be the person they call when you inevitably end up in the hospital again. The person you come to when the nightmares don't stop, when the memories feel like they take on physical shape, like they can wrap themselves around your throat, when it's about to rain and your shoulders hurt, when I pretend that I don't need your help climbing ladders, when you pretend you don't need mine buttoning your shirt or tying your shoes. I want to be the person you experience your victories with. And your defeats. I want to be that for you – and I don't want you to have to guess anymore. I don't want to guess anymore. I don't want you to be afraid that I don't love you. I don't want to be afraid that you'll leave. This is just a shitty ring – it doesn't have to mean anything if you don't want it to – but this is my heart. Take it or leave it. I'll understand either way."

"But you need to know – you need to. That, with all of me, I love who you were, I love who you are, and I love who you're becoming."

"I want to spend the rest of my life with you. No matter how short, no matter how painful, no matter how fucking temporary all of this is. I want to experience it with you."

"Marry me."

It’s not a question.

Izuku drops to his knees.

He’s too much of a goddamn blubbering mess – tears, snot, sweat, you name it – Izuku is currently secreting it. Katsuki’s chest fills with enough affection to drown him alive.

Fuck, he loves him so much.

“Y-yes, p-please,” Izuku stutters. It seems to be all he can get out, because he’s bawling like a baby, and Katsuki pries the silver band out of his steadfast grip, briefly grateful that the fucker didn’t lose his left hand. This one belongs to him now.

Easily, he slips the ring on.

Like the motion releases each drop of exhaustion from them both, they collapse against each other, barely supporting themselves against the slippery wooden floor, against gravity, and their hands scramble to wrap around one another, chests heaving with tears and laughter. Deliriously, Katsuki wants to make a joke about Izuku accepting things from blonde men that inevitably change his life forever. Maybe later.

They’ll support each other, they’ll hold each other up, they’ll build this new life together. A life worth living for.

Who fucking cares if they deserve it. Against all odds, they got their second chance.

And this time, they’re gonna do it right.

Chapter End Notes

Goodbye, Zero Sum Game



Please feel free to skip this because I'm about to bare my soul in a fucking My Hero Academia fanfiction lmao:

I've been sad so long that it feels more like home than not. Eleven years since I've started to search for what 'recovery' means and what it's like to live and keep living with acceptance of never being that idealized version of yourself - the one that was never sick, the one that never tried to die, the one who doesn't have these scars on their body.

And man it never really stops and you never really forget but you grow and you learn and you forgive yourself. So to write Katsuki as self isolating, self destructive, finding comfort in places he knows are wrong, fearful of loving and being loved coming out on the other side having to restructure his goals but learning to be okay with it, of finding purpose when he thought he lost everything, of finding love and friendship when he believed he's burned every bridge there is to burn… and to write Izuku a mere shadow of the hero he dreamed of being, so used to hurting that he forgets how else to be, to live when he's been convinced for god knows how long that the people he loved have already forgotten about him, to have to deal with what life looks like after being convinced he wouldn't live past 20 only to have a second chance at being the person he wanted to be, only to finding a foothold in a world he never thought he'd belong in again, only to love and be loved by a person who can actually understand what it feels like to bleed and break and get back up over and over and over again… and them, finding understanding and hope in one another, weaving a new life together; not in spite of their shared hurt but because of it…

It all anchors on the belief that you can still be who you want to be. The belief that 'broken' people can get better. The belief, the ever present faith - because it has to be faith, because all tangible things are friable but not faith, not this - that you can be found. That you are not irredeemable. That there is a future worth fighting for.

This is the first time in many years that I've been okay enough to use my own experiences in my writing. To drag my vulnerabilities out for the vultures to peck at. When I say Zero Sum is my heart, I mean it in the rawest sense. Make of that what you will.

So thank you. Thank you for reading this. Thank you for your comments. Thank you for the people that stopped reading, those that pushed through, those that hated it or liked it or felt seen by it. Thank you for supporting me and inspiring me and giving me the time of day. Thank you for looking at this ugly beat up little heart of mine and thinking it was worth anything at all.

Thank you.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!